In my exile

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53019742.

Rating:	Explicit
Archive Warning:	Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)
Relationship:	Adora/Catra (She-Ra)
Characters:	Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)
Additional Tags:	Medusa AU, Inspired by Medusa (Ancient Greek Religion & Lore), Medusa/Blind Female Character (Ancient Greek Religion & Lore), Alternate Universe - Ancient Greek Religion & Lore Fusion, In which Adora goes THROUGH it, Mentions of PTSD, mentions of trauma, Chronic Illness, We are going with the Roman Origin of Medusa with a lot of changes, Absolutely NOT using the assault plot neither in the past present or future, The gods are gods and get offended easily, Alternate Universe - Soulmates, Love at First Sight, Physical Disability, Disabilities are beautiful, Catra is still a magicat, Falling In Love, Minor Character Death, Greek Tragedies, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, Blind Catra, this work is a femininomenon, Quote: This is a Love Story (Fleabag), Spicy tags next, Dry Humping, Mutual Masturbation, Cunnilingus, Vaginal Fingering, Strapping, Body Worship, Face-Sitting, Light Bondage, Edging, biting and scratching, end of spicy tags, Other Additional Tags to Be Added, Slow Burn, Love Confessions, Idiots in Love, Graphic descriptions of violence, Men get what they deserve, english is not my first language, Happy Ending
Language:	English
Series:	Part 1 of Serpents and Flowers
Stats:	Published: 2024-01-13 Completed: 2025-05-14 Words: 294,690 Chapters: 14/14

In my exile

by StarryNap

Summary

There is a monster crawling on the floor, her eyes no longer blue hidden under the dirt stained skin of her palms. She was a princess and now she is a demon. If you look at her face, she will turn you into stone.

And it was not her fault.

Princess Adora has always known she is to love someone, nurture her and adore her. But when greed falls into her home and the Gods turns their back to her, the wish of love dies alongside her. Until that very same wish finds her in hell and sets her free.

Or

The long awaited Medusa AU ft Medusa Adora and Blind Catra. A story about love, pain and loyalty; about learning to love what makes you who you are and let yourself be loved in return. Another Tragic Love story (with a happy ending) for my collection ♡

COMPLETE

Verse I

Chapter Summary

"This is the time the Gods that Adora loves, betray her"

Chapter Notes

sauntering my way to your screen We are the Muses, goddesses of the arts and proclaimers of heroes...

... except that there are not Greek heroes on this story! At least, not in the way we've been taught. What makes someone a heroe? Slaying the creature? Or saving them?

Welcome to the Medusa AU! Woohoo! After two years since I first talked about the plot, we are finally here with the very first chapter or this new adventure. At first, it was only going to be a quick angst and fluffy one shot but you know how characters are, sometimes they want to tell their own story so here we are!

Today, we'll take a glance to the past, the origin, and the start of love, so, if you are ready, I'll see you at the end!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse I

Poppies' Ichor

I need my golden crown of sorrow

My bloody sword to swing

My empty halls to echo with grand self-mythology

I am no mother, I am no bride, I'm king

– **King** , *Florence and the Machine*

She must be punished

It is not her fault

It does not matter

It is destiny



There is a monster hidden on the corners of the cave.

The walls are cold, the ceiling dripping with debris and freezing tear drops of water. The air smells like rotten fruit and decay, like old stone crumbling in darkness.

There is a monster curled up on the floor, knees pressed to the chest, arms around her face. There are poppy petals crushed under her feet, staining her skin in red.

There is no sun under here, no sunlight, no golden rays that bring warmth with their touch. There are no greens, no yellows or blues.

There is a monster racking her hands through her head, pulling and gasping and tearing apart, bleeding herself into the floor, ripping herself apart until she can't do it anymore. It does not matter, the monster remains in her, blood in her blood.

The walls are cold, the water cuts like swords. There are stones shaped as fake heroes crumbling into pieces all around, some of them falling, some of them rising as the gods' shadows that had once carried her and later had cursed her. They surround her, trapping her into a circle, inside this exile that has become a grave for those that seek glory with her blood.

There is a monster crawling on the floor, her eyes no longer blue hidden under the dirt stained skin of her palms. She was a princess and now she is a demon. If you look at her face, she will turn you into stone.

And it was not her fault.



For Adora, the world is dark. Dark in a way that aches.

It hasn't always been like this, but for that, we must return to the beginning.

First, everything was golden. Golden air, golden curtains, golden grass. Golden crib. Golden kingdom and sapphire eyes. She had been born in a world of rich wine and fresh figs on colorful mosaic plates. She had been born among silks and peacocks singing in the gardens; and evergreen crowns of laurels on even more golden strands of hair. She had been born in a world where richness and beauty were pride to be taken and where she, Adora, was the crown jewel of it all.

She is the only daughter of King Randor and Queen Marlena, and the twin sister of her brother, prince Adam. A princess, a wish, a prize.

Her family and the people of Eternia saw her be born and grow from a small thoughtful child to a smart young woman and they all loved her and praised her the same.

She is loved for the sharpness of her mind and for the kindness of her heart, but also sorrowfully and most of all, for the beauty of her face.

Princess Adora of the Great City of Grayskull is the most beautiful woman of Eternia

Adora's hair is golden. True gold, not like wheat but like pools of the sunlight spilled over her royal head, long and falling free in gentle waves over her hips.

Her skin is soft, cheekbones and collarbones dusted in pale freckles; moles scattered from her chin, all the way down her strong arms and elegant hands. Her lips are full and red, always curved in kind smiles, passionate words and sweet words.

And her eyes, her eyes are turquoises swimming in pools of light, goddess's ichor trapped in her irises, raw ambrosia for the famished.

She is smart, smarter and more cunning than any high ranking member of the First One's council and its politics, with their red and golden robes. She is passionate about her beliefs and her ideas, always looking for a greater good and for helping her people have a better life; always putting herself in the line for everybody else. She will stand tall and confident in the face of anyone, cocky and beautiful as a sun and defend what she believes is the right thing to do with everything she has. Yet, is always there to reach with a gentle hand to those in need of help or guidance.

And she loves the gods. During the most tender years of her life and later her young adulthood, she is grateful and she is devoted. She spends long hours on the temples, lighting incense and candles, dipping her fingers in sacred oils and placing fresh flowers on the feet of the golden statues, the poppies she so much adores brushing against her fingertips with the last linger of dew. She lives surrounded by the smell of myrrh and lit sandalwood, her feet bare over the cold marble of the well cared floors, her hair loose and her hands open and pleading, sacrificing the best of her banquets to the gods everlasting lightened fire, never asking for anything but a single secret wish and the safety of her people. Adora plays the part, because that is what she has been disciplined to believe and follow, because that is the way her life has been led and Adora accepted it. Because, after all, it is what the people she loves have taught her.

When she is not in the temples Adora spends her days walking through the evergreen gardens of her parents home, scrolls of written poetry and politics alway nestled between long fingers. The strands of her sunlight hair will be tangled with fallen leaves and the twinkling lilac jewels of her crown. The gold accentuates the rich purple of her tunic and robes, enveloping her in sweet swirls of fabric all the way down her, most of the time, bare feet. Now that she is older, no longer a child chasing frogs and crickets in the grass, Adora has taken a liking to sit down near the pomegranate trees and read in silence, most of the time unaware of the prying

eyes of the people that walk by, dragging their eyes up and down her figure in undesired want.

Adora dreads it, she doesn't want it. Since her coming of age, she has been subject of the highest honors by every single person not only from Eternia, but of the entirety of the Realm. At some point between her maturity and the loss of the last softness on her cheeks, hundreds to thousands of gifts have been placed at her feet in praise of her godly beauty. First Ones and hundreds of other habitants all the same, singing choruses to her hair and eyes and hands, thrown to their knees in front of her feet, loving her as a nymph, a muse, a goddess. As an object. And Adora can only smile small and tight to them and gracefully accept their presents, glancing every once in a while with an uncomfortable and tired look to her parents, fidgeting with the wish to escape, holding her breath as to not scream.

This is not the way she wishes to be loved. Not like a prize to be won or a statue too far to be touched. She wants to run away and hide between the walls of her home and the pages of her poetry, or in the foot of the altars she puts so much love into, begging the gods to not forsake her. But her parents are the kings, and she is a princess, so Adora can only hold her tongue and close her eyes and hope it’s over soon so she can go back to the warm refuge that are her lonely chambers.

This is how she spends her days. Accepting praises. Reading with her father, wrestling with her brother and practicing sparring with her mother. Sitting on the floor of the temples and sleeping at their flower adorned altars. Days are hard sometimes but they are good. They are happy. She has no right to complain; she is a princess, she is a golden treasure and she has everything.

It doesn't last. As many things in tales and myths, Adora is destined to tragedy one way or another and it catches her before she can even take a breath. The rumor of her beauty travels as quick as a fire on dry leaves and reaches even the most rotten souls, tempting them to drag their pride drenched bodies to her home.

The first time she sees him, he is white. White robes, white sandals, white hair, white hands drenched in blood she still can’t see. It clashes against the green of his sharp eyes and drives a shudder down Adora's spine that she can't differentiate between fear and disgust. He comes as a token of supposedly peace, an emperor of the foreign kingdom, who arrives in Eternia to form alliances with the kings and their people.

Adora looks at him from her place besides her parents, fidgeting with the hem of her red tunic. From the edge of her gaze she can see Adam on the other side of the throne chamber wriggling uncomfortably on his feet, throwing worried looks between the man and Adora with squinted eyes and a snarl in his lips. But before Adora can fully turn her attention to him, the white man steps in and presents himself with a husky voice full of heavy confidence.

"King Randor and Queen Marlena. Prince Adam," but he is not looking at them, he is looking at Adora, his eyes piercing directly on hers like swords. "Princess Adora "

That's how it starts.

Emperor Prime doesn't kneel to her feet or kiss her hand. He doesn't pray to her beauty or listen to her mind. But he speaks. He is charming, he is slick and sweet. He is clean and pure. He is corrupted. He pours sticky rotten words into her ears and the ears of her people, poisonous thoughts clouding them like a poison. He speaks about violence and anger and oh so called justice that frightens her. About the strength of fighters and the glory of wars, about the past of First Ones and the need of order. About violence and beauty as equals. His presence hovers over her like a falcon, covering her in tight heavy darkness until all of Adora's senses are overwhelmed by him and his voice, wrapping her and all that she wishes for her life in fear.

And for some dangerous months, he is allowed to. Everyone allows him too. The kings and the council are besotted by him, by his ideals and his passions. By his strangeness. He is different to anything they have ever known, exhilarating for a kingdom who has stayed inside the safety and warmth of the walls for too long, aching for the chase, for the hunt that had characterized the First Ones for so long. They allow him to wander in the bright walls of Greyskull Castle, to step foot on the libraries and the holy gardens, to turn an eye away from their temples, staining everything within his reach without them ever noticing it. They allow him to step close to Adora.

It is not a secret that the princess has no interest in the men-kind. After all, she has been seen and heard, talking softly to the ladies of the kingdom or the loyal guards of her palace in their golden armors. They all have seen her flustered and shy or confident and attentive, bright as she runs her eyes down the angle of an ankle that escapes the fabric of a dress, or the curve of a perspiring bicep during a mock battle, always looking for something, always marveled by their fierce beauty. For a long time, Adora wishing for the soft swell of a breast it's not a problem or a gossip inside her kingdom. It is not a cause of confusion or anger in this world and, after all, there are plenty of ladies of royal crib that will do excellent consort princesses with time as the Council whispers among themselves in agreement. It is not a motive to cause her pain, until Adora stops being a person and starts being a medium to join this foreign king. To a king that wants her.

That is the first time the First Ones, her own people, betray Adora.

Sometimes, for rotten and painful moments, Adora wishes. For a second, buried in the blankets of her bedroom and in the hopes of the people she loves and the responsibility that weighs over her head, she wants with all her heart that this would be different, that this person her people push her towards would be someone else. She wishes to be able to want this too. Because after all, who doesn't want to be loved strongly, unconditionally. She has read and heard all her life glorious tales of lovers and warriors, people who risk their lives and their souls for love. Stories of tragic lovers thrown themselves to the sea, of promises in the form of sea shell rings and shielding golden dragons in blue waterfalls. Stories of heroes slaying down cruel and soulless monsters and the infinite tenderness that follows inside the arms of their beloveds.

This, this putrid sweetness, this is not that wish and Adora can't. It is not who she will ever be, it is not who she is looking for.

She has always known that she is destined to love someone in particular. She has dreamt of her, since she was a little child and all the way until now, the fragment of a wish, the light of a dream that she can't quite remember in the morning. She knows the curve of her soles against the grass, she has met the creases of her collarbones and the warmth of her palm. She knows the bounce of her curls like spilled earth over moss. She knows exactly how many freckles there are on her face and the secret dimple on her smirk when she smiles. She knows the song of her laughter, the smell of her breath, the taste of her closed eyelids. Adora *knows* her, even if she can't remember what her eyes looked like, what all of her looked like. Like looking at a deity to the face and knowing she is the single most beautiful creature in the world yet not being able to put words into her mouth or brush paints in her body. A blurry cloud against a midday sun that accompanies Adora like her own kind of miracle.

“She is a gift from the gods. A merciful miracle,” Marlena says to her daughter the first time tiny little Adora wakes up with the dream of a tiny little hand cradled inside of hers.

Adora is still young, too young, and she doesn´t understand completely, but her mother´s words comfort her as she tucks her back into her silk soft bed.

“When the gods made us, we were one being, too beautiful and too wonderful, too dangerously close to the gods' divinity. So Zeus, in all his wisdom, turned us apart. In a way is a curse, Adora, and in a way it is also a blessing because we are to seek for the other half of our soul across our life and the world. Many never find each other again, not even in the Elysium. That is our payment for being mortals.” Marlena runs her fingers over her daughter ´s honeyed hair, her eyes silver and tender. “You are lucky, my daughter, so lucky. She exists because you live and you exist because she breathes. The gods must love you so much and they will guide you to her when it is time. Cherish her.”

“Yes mommy,” Adora whispers back, sleepy and only six and with her heart full.

And so, Adora falls in love with a dream, with the promise of a beautiful miracle. Adora knows that she is to love and nurture this person, even if she is not in her life yet. Adora knows she loves her, even if she might not exist at all. And in order to be able to be with her, Adora needs to survive, to make it out of this alive.

Adora remains quiet and she never supports Prime and his speeches of freedom, even if those very same speeches seem to please and manipulate her own people. She looks at him, teeth clenched and nails dug on her palms, as he walks around her gardens and her streets like a peacock followed by hordes of his followers and soldiers and, later, by her own people and she becomes afraid.

Because she knows what he is, almost as quickly as he steps foot into her life, she knows what he is. A dictator, a conqueror. A murderer. She knows what he wants of her city, of her parents, of *her* ; the power that the First Ones possess to rise war against other realms, the power to tumble everything down, the power to become the emperor of it all and never look back.

She speaks about it in hushed rushes of whispers with Adam, hidden both in the secrets spots that had once been they playground around the castle, tangling her fingers with her brother´s

so much alike one to the other, daring to speak the words and worries that tumble out of her mouth like shivers.

They are, after all, so much like the other and they love each other just as deeply. And Adam, just as stubborn and smart as his sister, stands with her.

They walk around the castle side by side, murmuring between themselves things only siblings and twins know about, his hand always resting over Adora´s back when the green eyes try to find her again. They go to meetings together; spar next to each other until their muscles are protesting with exhaustion; and later take dinner together, always twin chairs, always Adam´s sharp blue eyes keeping Prime´s away.

In the months when Prime latches himself with even sweeter smiles to the sweet ears of their parents, Adam is the only one that listens and the only one that stays by Adora´s side.

“I will never allow him to hurt you,” Adam says one day, sleeping over the makeshift cot on the floor of Adora´s chamber.

Adora has never felt like this before, scared of even sleeping alone in her own home, but Adam stays and it reassures her enough to fall asleep. Adora stares at her brother's face from her place on her canopy bed with sleepy eyes, eyelids heavy after so many sleepless nights.

“And our parents?” Adora whispers back, fighting the need of running her hand over her damp eyes. “They believe him, they praise him as everyone else. I love them, Adam, they are our parents. What am I going to do then?”

“It doesn't matter,” Adam cuts her off, gentle but just as firm. He has always been the braver one between both. “You are my sister and you are a fighter, Adora. You are braver than you think, you´ll survive this.”

The twins share a long stare, charged with unsaid fears and strong affirmations. This is how they have always communicated with each other, how they let the other know they are there, with long looks with the same blue eyes.

Adora loves her brother and Adam loves her.

Adora looks at her brother and eventually falls asleep and Adam stays.

That is, until Prime waltz outside of a meeting with the Queen and King and Adam is promptly sent to the other side of the kingdom to support the Harvest, because he is a prince and Adora is a princess and they are not children anymore; they have duties they were born to fulfill.

Adam away, playing the prince; Adora here, playing the trading coin.

As much as Adam fights to bring Adora with him, their parents won't listen, too kind or maybe too stupid, too besotted in the power of this fake King promises to look at the darkness pouring out of him. Unaware of the walls he builds around them and their daughter. Unaware that he is a monster until it is too late.

He drives her friends away when she is not looking and no matter what Adora tries they step back with apologetic eyes and quick glances to the man always lurking in her shadow.

When Adora is not there nor her parents to see what is being done, he snarls and snaps at people that try to come close to her to admire her beauty, jealousy starting to drip from his eyes in lava rivers, treating her as if she was already her belonging.

He starts to become volatile, dangerous, violent. Every night's banquet with his followers is just another wine drunk fist fight. Loud hubris screams, speeches of greatness and of want and lust.

It doesn't even matter how much time Adam tries to spend around his sister the remaining days he is in the place before having to leave, sheltering her from Prime's sickly green eyes.

The Kings grant him a blessing and he starts to look at Adora sharper, harsher, wanting. Like a hunter that has spent too much time playing with his food and now just wants to devour.

“I do not want this,” Adora says one night, unable to contain it anymore, closing her hands on fists as the maidens in her room swirl her into green robes and golden jewels.

She hates green, she hates gold, she hates her sun-like hair and she hates herself. Nor the smell or the candles or the sounds of the last day of the Harvest can even reassure her now, not like they had done once upon a time, when she was younger and she had not yet learnt she wasn´t free in the first place.

That the place she once called home was nothing else but a prison now. The tapestries in her room with the embroidery of past heroes and past monsters´deaths are nothing but threats now. The bracelets in her wrists are chains and the looks in her mother's eyes are poisoned stares that return her rageful gaze.

“It does not matter what you want, Adora. It never has,” Marlena walks towards her and tightens the knots of the golden ribbons that lace around Adora´s waist, robbing her of her breath.

There is not a single wrinkle that hasn't been done on purpose, not a single strand of hair out of place; Adora is perfect like a golden statue and it makes her sick. Her own mother´s hands over her skin make her sick.

“You think you ever had the right to choose? You think *I* ever had a right to choose? You are a First One, Adora. You are a princess, my daughter. You have obligations with your people, with this kingdom and with its future. *You* have been blessed by the gods, Aphrodite, Athena, our lady Artemis, by the godly ones themselves with beauty and wisdom. You are *adored,* Adora, and it makes you powerful, don´t you see? The people will follow you like they followed Helen, to war and to glory. Whoever that has you will be powerful and it will bring victory to the kingdoms he favors. You have never been destined to choose Adora unless it was the best for the kingdom. And now, your destiny, *our destiny,* it's finally here. *Y*ou are our medium for greatness, Adora.”

“That is not what you taught me,” Adora snaps, walking away from her mother for the first time in her entire life.

This is not the person Adora knew; the one that taught Adora about the First One´s mistakes, about justice and mending mistakes. About being humbled and about love.

This is not the woman that helped Adora lit the gods´altars and helped wish for a love that was honest and tender like a bloom.

This woman is harsher, colder; she is prouder and calculating. Cruel. If Adora looks too closely to her eyes, she thinks she might find green among the silver.

She is still Queen Marlena, and she is still Adora´s mother, but she is not herself anymore.

“That is what *he* told you. You and father have let him tangle himself in our home, in our beliefs, in your minds. Look at you,” Adora points at her mother and the maidens gasp. “You have never wanted glory, you´ve never wanted war. I don´t know who you are anymore. You ´re not worth calling yourself queen anymore.”

Marlena slaps her, so violent and strong that it echoes across the entire chamber. It makes the maidens' ears to deaften.

It makes Adora stumble back and tremble from head to toe. It makes Adora bleed. Adora´s mother made her bleed.

“I raised you wrong,” Marlena says, scowling.

Her palm burns from where her hand hit Adora, stained with the blood that drips from her sliced mouth. This is the first time she has hit her, it will be the last time she touches her but she doesn't know that yet.

“I let you chase after meaningless dreams and it made you selfish. You are not allowed to *want,* Adora, and you are not allowed to bargain. You will do this for the future of your people and you will be grateful for it.”

Marlena walks back towards the door, scowling at the shivering maidens that quickly make themselves disappear behind the frame. She doesn't even stop to check on Adora, doesn't even slow her steps or glance at her.

Adora is still standing in the middle of her room, eyes casted to the ground, hair tousled over her shoulder; she is breathing hard, chest heavy with the broken pieces of her own heart. There are blood drops smudging on her lips but Marlena's own heart doesn't even flinch at that.

“Clean yourself and join us at the Hall. Emperor Prime will have the honor to make the offering to the gods today and you'll be there to support him,” Marlena regards her daughter one last time and then snaps her eyes away, head held high. “Do not disappoint your father. Do not disappoint me”

Marlena steps under the frame of the door, holding the last word until Adora gives a shaky breath, holding herself to all the bravery that lives inside her heart.

She is shattered but she is not broken yet.

“You are not my mother anymore,” Adora whispers, low enough that is a doomed secret, high enough that echoes like a war horn on the childhood walls of her home.

She hears Marlena hold her breath and absently waits for her to do something, anything at all; turn around and slap Adora again or hold her inside her arms like she used to do.

Marlena does none and she leaves Adora alone in the room, with her golden laurel crown and her fingertips tinted on gold dust.

Adora runs.

Adora, who has never run away from battle; Adora who is smart and brave and stubborn, Adora the noble princess, the undefeated warrior, runs away. Because she is afraid.

She makes it past the halls cradled with tapestries, further away from the lit fires on their metal pedestals, across the empty gardens where flowers have gone rotten and dry, barely making it past the loyal guards that once had seen her with tenderness and mirth and now only give her judgmental charged looks.

She runs, tripping with the freezing cold floor and scraping her bare ankles and knees when she falls on the floor, standing again and running once more.

She doesn't go far and nobody follows her.

Maybe no one actually considers her capable of actually leaving. Why would she, when she has everything anyone could ever possibly wish for?Maybe they think she is a coward, maybe she actually is one.

Because, even though Adora runs, she doesn´t make it past the high stone walls around the palace, once built by the gods themselves to keep her city at peace; she doesn't climb the trees or throw herself to the deadly quiet oceans that like the shores of her home.

She can´t, because even between her rage and her fear, she loves these stones and these trees and these waves.

Because, after everything, she loves her mother and her father; she loves her brother. She loves her people. She is as devoted to them as she is to the temples, she owns them herself and she can't leave.

Adora stands up from where she had curled at the bottom of the steps that lead to the temple, rising colorful and magnificent in front of her, frighteningly white and cold.

The fires are not lit tonight, nor are the myrrh or the incense. Very few people come here anymore, not even the priestess and their maidens, not when they can follow the vivid light that is Prime and his teaching, not when he drips words like gold coins into their hungry

hands and spits lies of greatness into their ears; not when the promise of war and conquer of the rivals that once were their neighbors is almost granted.

Adora walks inside the quiet temple, barely even hearing the muted brush of her feet against the marble, following the paths that lead to the altars by sheer memory and desperation.

It is so quiet here, so silent, like a tomb made a long time ago, like something meant to be buried and hidden away. If Adora breathes, she thinks she might just disappear among it´s stillness; she wishes she could.

The flowers are dry and the golden plates are empty when Adora makes it to the center of the temple, not a single light illuminates the space around her.

She holds her breath, just a second, just enough for her lungs to scream and her heart to rage against her ears like a furious ocean. And when she can hold it back anymore Adora breaks into two and sobs, sinking into her knees with a quiet fall.

“Help me”Adora whispers, Adora cries, Adora begs; bowing until there is nowhere else to go, stretching her arms over the floor in front of her.

The marble floor is freezing cold where it touches the skin of cheek where she has rested it against the tiles. It makes her mouth go numb and her body to lock into a perpetual shiver.

“Help me, please”

The silence it's so overwhelming that folds her down and Adora sobs, digging her nails against the tiles.

She begs again but nothing comes, not a sweet breeze or a reassuring whisper or a devastating earthquake. Adora is here, curling on the cold floor and alone.

If she could scream, she would scream, high and high until it ripped her apart and the gardens and the castle as a whole. If she could throw herself from the cliff towards the ocean, she would, swirling on its mercifully lethal waves until there was nothing left of her.

But instead, Adora is here, begging for help that does not come.

Seconds turn into minutes that feel like unstoppable eons of time. Adora can´t hear anything else but the sound of her own ragged breath and the tears that spill from her narrowed eyes and into the ground.

She feels numb and she feels heavy, the too soft fabric of her green robes wrapping itself against her neck and her body, unable to move or run or cry anymore.

For a moment, Adora considers staying here on this spot at the feet of the altar like an offering all on its own. To open her throat and sacrifice her own blood over the cracks of the marble; to run the sacrificial dagger over her wrists and drink from the gods´ tears and lay her body to rot and decay before letting a single man lay a hand over her.

For a moment, Adora drags her heavy soul and her living corpse over the floor and lets herself fall against the steps of the statues like a martyr of its own, because maybe she cannot sacrifice herself in life for her people but she can do it in death. Maybe, if the gods are pleased, her death might chase the shadows and the poison of that man away.

Adora grinds her teeth, her crystal blue eyes shimmering with tears under the dark, one last act of bravery as she reaches for the black knife.

A hand shots forward from the darkness, wrapping Adora´s wrist between its fingers. It's an old hand and an even older touch, cold where it meets Adora´s pale skin yet surprisingly strong when it pulls her arm away from the altar.

Adora looks back, halfway startled that it might be a priestess or a guard, halfway hoping it is Death that has come to take her away. But it is none, if fact, the eyes that look back at her are almost frightening, mesmerizing in the way looking at the gods' faces mist feel like, except that this woman is neither goddess's nor mortal.

The old woman regards Adora in silence, quietly but firmly placing her arm back into the cold step, palm up as she studies the inside of Adora's hand with cautious eyes.

Her hair has gone silver and white, long ago aged out by the pass of time; her tunic is simple and practical, old also by the look of it with the beautiful pink color washed out long ago, so long it brushes the floor every time she moves; or maybe this woman is just tiny, with her knotted hands and her earlobes heavy with earrings.

There is a kind of kindness with which she carries herself in the spot next to Adora, tender but also firm, her back long ago bent by the weight of the ages and the memories.

Adora snaps her eyes towards hers, looking at her old face through the honey strands of her hair, silver eyes meeting the woman´s with a shivering gasp.

The woman's eyes are golden, pure gold, from the pupil to the sclera, so bright that they are painful to look at, like looking at the very sun with bare eyes.

“Don´t do that, Adora dearie,” the woman says, turning Adora´s wrist gently so she can rub tender circles over her palm. “It is not worthy. You are so needed and so loved, you have no idea how much.”

Adora chokes with her own breath, hiccuping against a dry sob. There are no more tears falling down her face, stuck to her eyelashes and fallen on the marble floor.

She digs her nails into the ground, holding the old woman's hand with eager desperation.

“You're a prophet,” Adora exhales. The steps of the altar dig painfully on her knees. “You are the Oracle, Apollo blessed you with vision of the future”

“Is it really a blessing hidden as a curse, dearie? Or a punishment cradled in power?”

The Oracle doesn´t let go of her hand, instead sitting on the steps next to Adora. She leans closer towards her, grasping a lock of golden hair between her own fingers and placing it

gently behind her ear.

“I was like you once, my dear, I was young and I was innocent too. I don't think I´ll ever understand why it happened, why it *will* happen.”

The meaning of the woman´s words crush Adora to the bone, even if she is not aware of the full weight of them yet. Instead, Adora snaps her hands away from the woman, anger making its way back into Adora´s skin and marrow.

“Is this really my fate?” Adora asks, furious, digging her nails into her own palms when she closes them into fists.

Ire and despair are eating her alive, indignation and pride keeping her in one piece still. It is not supposed to be like this, none of this.

Adora´s life is not supposed to go or even end like this, at the hands of people she loved or in the end of the blood drenched sword of greed drenched men.

She is supposed to be a warrior, a fighter; she is supposed to bring honor to her people and protect them, not being traded by them.

She is supposed to find love, to hold her inside her arms and nurture her. Adora´s fate wasn't supposed to be *this* .

The old woman, the Oracle, sighs heavily, tangling her fingers together over her lap. The hem of her tunic and her sandals are drenched in mud, as if she had walked all the way across the very woods to reach Adora here.

“Someone that loves you has given you a gift, my darling. Do you know what it is?” The Oracle´s voice lingers inside the temple, echoing through the columns and the small golden fire that burns in the myrrh above their heads. Adora doesn't even know when it started to burn.

“Beauty?” Adora scoffs, pulling from the silk strands of her hair until it hurts. “Wisdom? Power? I don't want any of it”

“None of those are gifts, darling, they are just circumstances and they do not matter in the end. None of them."

The Oracle shakes her head, her golden eyes looking far away, past the tree crowns and the moons circling the early night.

“No, no, you have been given something so much more important, much more powerful than any crown. You have been given hope. Sweet as a dove and sightless as faith. Hope on the form of a dream and a dream in the form of a miracle.”

Adora's breath hitches on her throat, her heart screaming inside her chest tugging from it's string cords as it claws and beg *home, take me home, set me free.*

“ What a wonderful thing it is to love until we ache, a privilege handed to so little, most of the time destined for tragedy. This is and will be the only devotion of your heart, my dear. It will be your greatest joy and your most tender sorrow, and in the end, you will need to let her go too”

Adora sobs, burying her face between her palms, tears dripping down the bridge of her nose.

Even after everything, the only thing capable of breaking her into pieces is the ghost of a love that she craves for; that she so desperately wishes to hold; the shattered pieces of a promise Adora made to her dreams when she was only a child.

The woman doesn't touch her and she doesn't reassure her, instead still looking far away from them, to something Adora cannot see but will have to face.

Adora grunts, grinding her teeth as she raises her head again, following the Oracle´s gaze. Her eyes are sore and red as the poppies drying on the altar, their powder staining the pristine green tunic in crimson.

“Tell me. Tell me what you see,” and the words feel like a sentence all of their own.

She still wants to hear it, all of it, she wants to hold herself to any kind of remembrance she can get, any breeze of long lost love she cannot reach. Any hope that, if Adora is to fail before even touching her, she might carry her inside her heart like a shield and an armor and never let anyone break her down.

“I see children seeking each other among light. I see pain and injustice. I see you betrayed, I see you grieving. I see darkness and rot and the death of hope."

"I see a woman like a sun and the blind loyalty of love. I see tenderness, I see punishment. I see a sword against snakes and blood in the ground. I see salvation but not from your hand”

The woman blinks and turns towards Adora, watching her with her gold filled and soul voided eyes and, for a second, Adora feels looked down by all the gods themselves.

“I see you and I can't see your face. I see you and you don´t know who you are anymore.”

Adora's breathing shivers, trembling from head to toe. Her shoulders are raised in goosebumps, her skin damp with cold sweat.

She wants to scream and break the earth and curse at the sky, she wants to run away, past the woods and the walls. She wants to stay here, on the halls that saw her be born and the family that raised her, with her scrolls of parchment and her white horse and her brother.

The Oracle is looking at her again, but her eyes are not glowing anymore, still liquid golden but apologetic, as if they held all the answers and the sorrows in the world.

“I am sorry” she says, wrapping her old hands with Adora's. “It won't be your fault”

The Oracle has seen many younglings, all of them beautiful and kind, all of them full of desire and want for something else. Some for hubris, others for glory, even for fame and

glorious death. And others, like this girl, heroes and legends that will live for thousands of years, in tales from mouth to ears and parchment pages.

But this girl is not a hero destined for glory, not in this life, in this life she was meant for love and now is doomed for tragedy.

“What should I do?” The girl with golden hair asks her, and it is not a myth asking a prophet for her fate but a young woman begging her to guide her because she is lost and afraid.

“Go home” the Oracle says back, because this she can do for her. “And fight back”

It comes down on the last night of the Fall Harvest.

There is a huge banquet, bigger than any other in the year. The Queen and King walk around the huge chamber with their golden tunics and laurel crowns, greeting people that gathered around the fire that burns warm in the center, orange and red flames dancing around the logs of wood.

There is music everywhere, lyres and flute rising songs of charming times and seductive glory. It won't take long for everyone here to be drunk after the first offering is done, a heavy sense of urgency hovering over everyone already.

Adam follows close behind his parents, back tonight from his unspoken exile on the countryside, throwing weary glances at the open corridors around them, his heart straining inside his chest with the clear absence of his sister.

“You'll come with me after the banquet, I don't care what mom or dad say. We can grab Swift Wind and go,” Adam had said to his sister before going to the hall, squeezing her hand reassuringly.

She was still in her chamber, standing without speaking next to the open window, her face thin and pale but her eyes firm, full of the same kind of fire Adam had always known since they were children.

She was quiet, frighteningly so. Adora is never quiet, but there was something boiling under her very skin, the need of rebellion or a different kind of war maybe.

“You'll like the countryside. Menagerie is quiet, it's hard work but I know you'll be happy with it. There are good people there.”

Adora didn't answer for a long time, eyes lost on the woods but with her hand tightly wrapped around her brother's fingers.

“Alright,” she said at the end, resting her temple against her brother's shoulder. “Alright”

Adora has been wandering the dark corridors of her home in silence, her gaze lost in the braces lit around her.

She has always loved the warmth fire brings, it reminds her of a happy childhood and joyful dances. It reminds her of golden dreams and the ring of a long lost laughter. There is a pull on

her chest every time she is near a fire. What may be a potential danger for her is a safe place to stand besides. The caress of a hidden lover.

There is a sudden hard noise and Adora snaps from her contemplation with a jolt, hands fisted in the fabric of her clothes, feeling the edge of the knife held to her leg with the tips of her fingers.

She is a princess but she is also foremost a warrior, a daughter of Eternia, a fighter. She knows who she is and she knows what she is worth and she knows how to defend herself. She will not go down without a fight.

“My darling”, comes the thick voice of Prime, slick as a snake when she steps out of the shadows and right in front of her.

He is standing next to the fire, in the center of the corridor, blocking the path almost completely. His green tunic is draped over his shoulder, falling down to his feet, and he wears a golden laurel crown atop of his head, so much like the one Adora's parents wear that it makes her want to barf.

His eyes are slightly covered by the shadows but Adora feels it’s burnt through the sheer cloth of darkness and into her very bones, studying her with poisonous gaze.

“Took you long enough” he whispers dangerously low, bringing goosebumps down her arms. He scowls at her clothes and hair, frowning deeply. She is not wearing the plethora of green tunics her mother had given her but a red one, blood-like and rich, and she is not wearing any gold, nor crown or bracelets or belts around her waist.

She is a stricken contrast to Prime's green and white, where he fakes purity, she screams war. Her hair is loose, void of the complicated loops and braids the maidens of the temples had tried to put her in, falling like tendrils of gold around her face, clean and wrinkled in unfiltered anger and disgust.

“I fail to see how that concerns you, Prime. This is my home, I can take as much time as I want,” answers Adora, unable to contain it, sharp and cutting.

It displeases him greatly. He snaps his mouth shut before stepping forward suddenly, almost pressing himself against Adora in the reduced space between them and the columns. Adora's breath hitches in her throat, adrenaline rushing through her veins freezing cold.

“Don't shake away from me, Adora" Prime snarls, opening and closing his hands at his sides, his sweet facade fallen.

He knows Adora knows what he is and he feels invincible in his position above her. He does not care about Adora's disgust anymore.

"Your *kingdom* loves me, praises me, just as much as they praise you. They wish for our union, for me to take you in marriage. They count on it and you know that, it is your duty. Our wedding will arrive sooner than you think. So behave, Adora." Prime raises his hand,

making a movement as if he were to either slap her or run his knuckles down her face. "Don't force me to break you”

She hates him, she hates him, she hates him. She wants him gone off her kingdom and her land and her life, but nobody has listened to her and she wants to scream, so she does.

She slaps his hand away and steps back, almost crashing against the lit fire when she walks away from him.

“Who do you think you are?” Adora commands, loud and without trembling. Tired, she is so tired and so angry, holding herself to the Oracle's words like a temple burning to pieces all around her. “Do you presume yourself of being the king already? I've heard what you say to your followers when my parents are not there; I know what your speeches of freedom truly hide. I'm sick of you, this is not your kingdom and I'm not your wife. Neither of us will ever belong to you so step back and never dare to speak to me like that again”

“I am an Emperor!” Prime exclaims between his teeth, red flashing on the pale of his eyes. “I am the owner of the greatest empire on the earth”

“And I am the future Queen of Eternia, and *you* are in *my* domain. And as long as there is breath in my lungs you will never, ever, get your hands on my kingdom.”

That makes it enough to cause Prime to snap. He rushes forward, trying to grab Adora by the upper arms with bruising brute force. This is the first time since the cursed day he arrived at her home where Adora has seen him break his facade of perfection, shattered in the edges by Adora's words.

“You are mine, Adora. Mine,” Prime growls, wrinkling the tunic around Adora's shoulder.

But Adora is faster than him and she is also angrier. She is tired of being treated as a threading object, she is tired of being silent to not upset the stupid people that make their council. She is tired of her parents not listening, of her brother's quiet frustration.

She is tired of dreaming at night of running her fingers through the hair of someone she is supposed to be looking for and instead being here, forced to look at this man's face one second longer.

So she does what she knows and pulls the knife out of its shed, swirling it expertly on her hands as she presses it tightly against Prime's throat. It's not hard enough to cut skin, but just enough to make the skin angry and spotted in patches of red. Enough to keep him away from her.

“I am no one and certainly not of you. My body is not your temple.” Adora snaps, breathing hard through her nose.

She pushes him away before Prime can even muster a word, turning on her elegant ankles and walking the opposite side of the corridor.

Now that there is distance between them, Adora can feel herself trembling from head to toe, skin covered in cold perspiration and chest heavy with the violent drumming of her heart, her knees shaking so hard they almost knock her to the ground by the sheer effort of keeping standing tall and above.

She is afraid, she is the most afraid she has been in her entire life but she doesn't doubt her steps and she doesn't look back, not even when she hears Prime moving behind her, yelling.

“What do you plan?” Prime exclaims, his voice echoing across the corridor. “Letting those whores fuck you until you feel less pathetic about yourself? Is that what this is?”

Adora feels herself flinching but she doesn't stop, balling her hands into fists, holding her own heart inside the light that lives inside her dreams.

“Adora” he yells, dangerous and commanding. Adora doesn't look back or stop or shrink in fear and it drives Prime mad.

“Adora!” Not even a single glance. Prime screams and throws the blazing torches into the ground, boiling red rocks and blue flames scattering across the floor.

“Adora!”

The corridor changes around Adora, from dark obsidian to bright marble all around her. There are more sounds now, loud laughs that shake the flames of candles, banters and music from lyres.

Adora throws her shoulders back and the simple wing earrings on her ears twinkle when they clank one against the other. There is no loud advice when she enters but the chamber immediately falls quiet when she steps foot on the full floor.

Every head turns to see her, drinking in the sight of her and her rich golden hair. Is not uncommon for Adora.

She gulps down the acid in her throat and walks forward, ignoring everyone´s gazes and marveled chattering until she reaches Adam, already making his way through the chamber to reach her.

“Are you alright?” Adam questions between his teeth, wrapping his arm around her back to try and keep her away from sight.

They are the same height yet Adora feels herself shrinking next to him, curling around his arm as she tries to pull out a polite expression in front of everyone else. The green and white drowns down every single patch of the rich chamber, tunics and crowns and jewelry and Horde flags on the walls.

Adora is the only one wearing red.

“We are leaving for Menagerie tonight,” Adora answers in an exhale, digging her fingers on Adam´s forearm.

Adam doesn't even flinch, looking at her with heavy eyes for a second before nodding, body and mind already completely alert.

“Alright. Do you want to go right now?”

“No, after the Offering,” Adora presses her mouth into a firm line, glancing at their parents already making their way towards the twins. “If I have to go, I'll do it with my head held high.”

Her parents are standing right in front of them now, unconsciously getting closer to their daughter and eyeing her tunics with recriminating eyes when the noise startles the attendants.

Their faces are sour when they look up from Adora´s face to the entrance of the hall and it’s obvious from miles away that their patience is just about to run low but it is already too late to fix it.

Adora, however, doesn’t see them, looking around with exhausted eyes to the place already waiting for the next drunken confrontation to break off. Instead, she sees Prime, completely sober and alert, an expression in his eyes that freezes Adora's blood.

“King and Queen Grayskull” Prime's voice rumbles in the chamber.

Every single one of the First Ones there turns to him, alert and already excited by the speech-like ring of his voice.

Adam clenches his teeth next to Adora, trading his fingers with hers into a firm hold at the same time her mother rests her palms over her shoulder, unconsciously pushing her forward. Prime's smile grows.

“I want to express my complacency on the work you have done to prove yourselves and your people worthy of the great Horde Empire's trust. You've truly exceeded all of my expectations about your kingdom”

Adora hears her parents take a sharp intake of breath and she can feel the vibrations of Adam ´s contained anger in the fibers of her own skin.

“I’m sure the joining of our kingdoms will be of great celebration and it will bring freedom and justice to the First Ones like there hasn’t been before. Together, we will bring down those that are beneath us; together we will make them obey and respect us as they should have done always. Together, we will bring glory and conquer, to all of Etheria”

The whispers of the people buzz and raise into loud cheers, people chattering among themselves about the Emperor's words, agreeing and nodding, already discussing which cities will they take over first, which friends and neighbors they will backstab for their own gain.

“And for that, it pleases me deeply to announce this to the rest of this kingdom, as the regal Regents and the honorable Council of this Court have already agreed with me that this union needs a stronger pillar than simple words and signatures in scrolls. That it needs something much more permanent.”

He turns now to face Adora's position directly and she stops on her track midway. The murmurs die down and so does her breathing.

"Princess Adora, the dowry I have given to your kingdom pales in comparison with you"

He stands next to the fire, huge in the middle of the chamber where the first offering to the gods awaits. He snatches a plate filled to the brim with ripe fruit and wine into his hands, hovering it over the flames that shimmer sudden blood red.

His posture is rigid and his expression sober, he knows what he is doing. Sudden fear drips down Adora's spine, freezing cold. Next to her, Adam holds his breath.

"I am sure of the honor you will feel now. The most beautiful woman in the world, joined to the greatest kingdom that will ever be. Joined to the Horde. Joined to me."

A copper goblet falls to the floor with a clank but everyone ignores it, the chamber charged with unspoken tension. Somehow, even the very sky seems to be awaiting.

Adora looks around her, at the faces of everyone standing around her but she finds no surprised gazes; instead, there is only unspoken eagerness, satisfaction and agreement.

Her skin is damp with cold sweat and her head spins, pulling together the words like sick puzzles, looking at her life the last months like a curse on a dusty scroll. She understands and everyone does too, why the molasses sweet words, why the possessive closeness and the jealousy.

She is a fairytale, a princess. She holds positions and most importantly, she holds power. The Oracle said it, her own mother said it. Prime has *bought* a place on his kingdom, on her kingdom, by wooing her parents, by preaching to her people; by possessing her, by forcing her to marry him. He is buying her.

This is the second time the First Ones betray Adora.

"Your beauty rivals any other. There is no other woman as beautiful in all of Etheria", Prime steps closer to the fire lifting his plate on the way. The truth slips down her throat like a disease.

"Emperor", she hears herself saying and is surprised by the calmness and steadiness in her voice, completely different from the turmoil she now feels.

She thinks in the loneliness in her heart, on her abandoned readings, on her voice silenced. She thinks of the gardens where she dipped her feet in mud; on the patches of golden fields where she raced with her horse.

She thinks of her parents, dead inside her heart even though they stand behind her; on her brother still holding her hand. She thinks of the Oracle's saddened golden eyes, of the cold temples with cold altars.

She thinks of dreams and knows she can't bring this poison with her, not to those dreams, never to *her*.

Adora knows she has to fight and she knows in the end she will die. From the brim of her blue eyes she sees Adam giving her worried looks of confusion, from the fire to Adora´s face. She thinks about all of it, gone forever from her grasp to a man that sees her as sacrificial meat.

"But let's be honest here among us, you rival even the most beautiful of the Gods, of the entire Olympus itself. Not even Aphrodite herself could compare to your beauty"

"Prime." As his dangerous pernicious words keep coming there is only one thought that is left in her mind, "That's enough"

"Why pray to selfish Gods that turn their gaze from us when the only goddess we need is standing right here. Next to me". Adora moves as fast as she can, letting go from Adam´s hand, but Prime is already tossing the offering to the fire, turning to her with mad victory in his eyes. "To your name, goddess"

There is a stunned silence in the palace. Adora looks at the burning food in the flames and she feels the dread of the offense on her very bones.

The air itself seems to cease to exist and the flames don't move at all. She looks at Prime with a vicious glance, eyes burning bright amber in her anger.

"Get out. I'm not going with you anywhere," Adora snaps, full of anger. She is golden among all of them and she is furious, there in front of everyone. "You are not worthy of calling yourself a king, or an emperor, or a *god*. You are just a man, you´re nothing. You are a monster."

People are talking again now, alarmed and angrily, staring down at Adora as if they didn't say to love her, as if they hadn't seen her grow up.

For Adora, who for the first time is standing for herself in front of them, it doesn't matter anymore.

"I have given *everything* to all of you, everything, my entire life," she says, looking from her people to her parents, eyes bright blue among the red in her skin. "But I won't give you this, not like this. You are not taking a single thing off me anymore. You're not hurting anybody through me."

Now she turns towards Prime, narrowing her eyes like swords.

"In the morning, you'll take your men, take your boats and get out of my Kingdom. This is an order, *Emperor* Prime."

Many things happen at the same time.

The Kings rush forward to pull Adora back and Adam steps between them, guarding his beloved sister´s back.

The Council and the rest of the people in the charmed clamor in anger, damning Adora and her words. Prime opens his mouth, maybe to curse her, maybe to hurt her.

The Oracle steps from behind the marble columns, looking at her face with golden eyes. Nobody gets to reach for her, not for anything, not in time. The fire crackles with a vicious screech and it dies down completely, drowning the chamber in darkness.

And then, Adora starts to scream.



... She must be punished ...

... It is not her fault ...

... It does not matter, she must pay in their name ...

... It's not her fault ...

... It isn't but she must suffer or their kind will never fear us again ...

... They must learn ...

... She doesn't deserve it ...

... What about the other one? Hasn´t she suffered enough too? ...

... Your love games with mortals are not of our concern ...

... What is a mortal to a god? ...

... What is a god to a lover? ...

... At least give her love, at least gift her of hope ...

... That love won't escape sorrow ...

... It is not her fault, it is not their fault ...

... But it is destiny ...

Adora is screaming.

She bends over herself and screams, howls, jowls until her jaw bone hurts and her lungs are burning, until her eyes are drowning in tears falling down her eyes and soaking her cheeks, until her body feels like it is breaking in two pouring ichor and venom and mortal blood into the floor.

People are moving around her, stepping back and away, shouting to each other to fire up the flames again, guards, *guards!*

But Adora can´t pay attention to them, can´t make sense of their rushing voices above the strength of the ocean that washes over her, all alone on this single spot of the palace that was once her home.

Among the darkness nobody can see it, but Adora runs her fingers over her face and she can feel her nails sharp, breaking the skin in shallow scratches that heal immediately, skin cold as the very stone of the floor where she is kneeling.

Her tears pool in her chin and fall on her bent knees and they burn, acid and sizzling. There is pain flaring inside her chest, inside her muscles and very bones.

There is something crawling in her head, slamming inside her temples, cracking her skull open and running down the shell of her ears and the back of her shoulders, cold as silver, sharp as ice, cutting as a sword.

It aches, it is killing her, desperation and fear making its way inside her soul, tearing her apart with desolation and the overwhelming feeling that she has been left alone. And she doesn´t understand why.

There is a single patch of the roof where the palace has been designed to remain open, an open circle where the light of the moon shines bright through to honor Artemis and that now falls trembling and dim with the new moon over Adora.

It is because of this light that she shouldn't be able to see but that now she does that Adora can blink down at her own hands, blurry sight misted by something else than tears, palms stained in her own blood when she runs them desperately against her head and thick strands of golden hair fall down, tangled in her fingers like decaying honey and rot.

She is changing, this much she knows, deforming and breaking apart and pulled back together like a doll made of clay that the celestials have decided to play with. They are tearing her apart, punishing her for something that isn't even her fault.

It won't be your fault. This is the will of the Gods.

This is the time the Gods that Adora loves, betray her.

Someone falls heavily on their knees next to her, their hands hovering above Adora among the darkness, unable to see and not knowing where to touch her.

Adora is hiding her face between her palms, panting heavily when she is unable to scream anymore, when her body has started to give up and the air inside her lungs is acidic. She can barely hear outside of the raging in her ears but she feels the warmth of sudden calm fire next to her, a lit torch of green and blue light followed by another and a single one more, dim still but enough to illuminate the space.

Adam leans closer to his sister, their knees knocking together as he slides over the marble floor, slippery and tinted in gold and crimson red, the sight seizing his throat.

He shivers from head to toe, raising his trembling hands again just so he can rest them over Adora´s wrist, grounding her down.

Under this light it is so hard to see, but so close Adam can hear the sizzling, low and menacing, the sound vibrating against his skin when he brushes what once was Adora´s hair. He holds his breath, tears stuck on his own eyelashes, biting back a painful yell when he makes off the figures sliding down Adora´s shoulders.

“Adora,” Adam whispers, voice breaking in the middle.

He is scared, terrified even, but not of Adora, never of her. She is his sister no matter what and Adam adores her with all his heart. No, Adam is scared *for* her, for the trembling of her body and her blood in the floor; for the people that surround them that make sense of the situation as every second goes by; for the whispers that linger in the chamber, for the confused stare on their ignorant parents that will sooner or later become disgust and rejection. For the flash of green still lingering in the now extinguished fire, weighing them with calculating gaze.

“Adora, it´s alright, let me see.”

Adora whimpers around her brother´s touch, shrinking into herself. Warm ichor and blood slips down Adam´s fingertips and wrists, his heart hammering inside his chest painfully.

He doesn't even know if Adora is fully aware of what has happened to her yet, he doesn't even know fully yet. It is not safe here, not anymore, and the urgency of getting his sister *out* is starting to make way inside his bones too.

“Let me see. It doesn't matter, Adora, it doesn't matter to me. I´m here and I love you so much. You are going to be alright.”

Among the blood and the ichor he can also feel Adora´s tears, falling down her hands and into Adam´s, cold to the touch. Adam pulls down from Adora´s wrists gently, cradling his sister´s face between his palms and rubbing gentle circles in her cheeks. Her tears are black stained, marking paths like water over rocks over her face, her eyes still vehemently casted to the ground.

The voices around them are getting closer, seeking to take a glance at the fallen princess with eyes full of morbid curiosity. Adam leans his forehead against Adora´s, whispering softly at her as he tries to drown the sounds behind her with reassurances.

“We are going to the countryside, remember?” Adam murmurs, pressing a swift kiss over his sister's forehead. The smooth surface of a slim body brushes against the bridge of his nose when he does so.

“We are seeing the lakes and the trees. We are going to eat figs until we are sick and then eat some more and we are going to stay together no matter what. I´m not letting you down,

alright? You are my sister and I love you, always will."

He can feel Adora´s faint and rapid breath against his own cheeks, hesitating as she listens to him beyond the noise and the pain inside her head. He presses one more kiss against her temple, cooing her face up with gentle hands, sighing when his sister´s eyes meet his.

He is the only person Adora loves that will ever see these eyes, nobody will get to know them again.

"It's alright, it's alright see? You are alright, Adora, I love you. I love-"

It happens very quickly. Painless. In a way, it is a mercy, a small gift from a benevolent yet selfish hand.

After all, not only Adora was loved between the celestials but her brother too. And when he goes, Thanatos themself extends their hand and touches the young man on the heart and carries him away, tearing their celestial eyes away as the warm body goes still as stone.

He will be carried over the five rivers without any of them really touching him, presented before Hades and reassured by Persephone and then he will walk into the Elysian Fields, as he never fought a war but this one, quiet and relentless, dying loving and protecting his sister until the very end and that is as honorable as any battle could ever dream to really be.

In another part of the world not too far from there, in the calm edge of a lonely Menagerie home, another kind of warm body jolts awake from the touch of Hypnos. Her dark hair falling over her face in loops, her breathing confused and scared by dreams too real and cruel to truly remember, her heart aching with the quiet tears that fall down her sightless eyes.

She is alone there but not really, guarded in silence and without knowing it by Eros, a god mournfully sitting at the frame of her window. Even among the tragedy, they are still watched over by someone.

In the palace, Artemis´ moonlight tries to shelter Adora but what it's done is done and there is no miracle for her tonight.

Adora´s breath hitches on her throat as she leans forward, running the tip of her raw fingers over the planes of her brother's face, forever casted in the marble surface of one last love word.

"Adam?" Adora calls for him, but he is not there anymore.

His golden hair has gone white, shimmering almost silver under the fire lights. His face has gone still, never moving again, the edge of a reassuring smile still lingering on his stone sculpted lips. His robes and tunics are hard to the touch and his hands, still halfway raised to cup Adora´s face in them, are cold. His eyes, silver rimmed and ocean blue depth, have gone blind, never again free from the tomb his own sister has placed over him.

"Adam?" Adora repeats, blinking dark tears off her cursed eyes, trying and failing to make sense of what has happened, to find an explanation, a reason strong enough for being

punished like this. She finds none. “Oh no. No, no, no, no.”

Adora´s eyes are not blue anymore, neither silver, nor liquid gold. There are faint lines on her face that will scar by the touch of her own hands.

Her hair has fallen down, pooling down in gold and red around her knees, and where the silk strand used to be now only linger the smooth scaled surface of snakes, blue as midnight skies and golden as gods´ judging eyes, white as the marble this cursed has turned her brother into.

They slither among themselves and fall heavily over her nape and back, staring with sightless eyes at the people looking in horror around them. They sizzle and shrink against their own cold bodies, scared of their own existence as they are also a part of Adora and they are innocent as she is too.

Either a gift or a punishment as Adora will never be looked at without sacrifice.

Adora sobs and curls herself around the cold and lifeless statue of what once was her brother ´s body, mourning him against his shoulder, keeping her head low and her eyes closed, fear overwhelming her.

Two guards approach her unexpectedly, seizing her by the arms and yanking her away from Adam's side with violent pull. And it is unfathomable to even think that these very same guards were once Adora´s friends and now they drag her away, slamming her against the floor so harsh her shoulder screams in pain.

She tries to, she really does, but the pain and the grief and the betrayal make her open her eyes just a slit, just enough to glance quickly at the guards hovering towards her with heavy hands before they still too, golden armors into gray stone, hairs of granite and faces of porous stone that crumble down almost as soon as they change into them.

Someone screams, followed by another and another, feet stomping on the ground as the court and the council rush their way own of the crowded chamber, yelling among each other, screaming and pointing fingers, not daring to look at her ever again even when, for years, they did nothing else but looking and never speaking.

Several guards are making their way inside the chamber, raising their swords and spears towards the curled up body of their once princess, who now covers her face with her hands and flinches when the edge of a sword brushes on her forearm.

“Don't look at her!” A voice raises in the crowd, commanding but not afraid.

Condescending even. Enjoying. A voice that knows that, one way or another, he has already won.

“Don't look! She is cursed! The gods have punished her.”

Adora grunts and crawls to her knees, searching among the level of the ground until she finds the familiar hems of her parents' tunics.

They are circling Adam´s stone and Adora won't dare to look up and search for their faces but she can hear her mother weeping against Adam´s marble shoulders.

“Mom? Dad? Please,” Adora calls for them, a young woman and now a monster but once the small child that played among her parents' legs as she chased for her brother. “Please”

“Go,” Randor says, low and very, very slow. A grunt, so gutural on his throat that it sounds like a growl, like a barely contained scream. “Go.”

“Dad-”

“I said go!” Randor turns around and Adora snaps her head to the ground, closing her eyes tightly. “Get out, Adora. Out!”

The guards aren't looking at her either, the chamber is still as the King´s shout echoes on the walls and so, Adora scrambles to her feet and does as she is told, as she did towards a cold temple seeking for help where she found none.

She raises, digs her nails on the columns and runs.

The walls are dark and quiet, the halls still and empty. There are shouts somewhere in the distance, yowls of orders and instructions of hunt that she can't quite place.

Smells are gathering around every corner or the palace, burnt logs of wood and metal in forges, swords pilled out of sheads that she can't see yet, all of these heroes that with time will gather around to hunt for her head already making a line on her fate.

Her feet are light over the slippery ground, carried across the paths by some kind of benevolent wind that brings her to the door of her chamber, where she trips and falls into, closing the door loudly behind her.

Adora tries to stand up again but this time her legs fail her and she stumbles painfully into the ground covered in tapestries, knocking fabrics and parchments to the ground.

She raises to her feet and falls again, weighed down by the mournful sound of sizzling following her everywhere. She crawls on her hands over the ground, ignoring the turmoil gathering below her open window or anywhere outside, just so she can reach the frame of the polished surface of the copper mirror that has fallen too with a loud crack.

She holds her breath and turns it around, staring at herself for a second too long before the scrambles back down, screaming at the top of her lungs.

Adora brings her hand to her head, wrapping her fingers over the body of the snakes and yanking her nails down them, pulling from their bodies with as much strength as she can, seeking to tear them out of her one way or another.

She can feel the strain of the self inflicted wounds over her own skin, flaring and painful, like a slash done over her own body even as she rejects this new part of herself with her entire being. She pulls and tears down and feels the way the snakes bite her on fingers in defense and fear but none of them come out.

She cannot think of what he has just seen, what she has just done to Adam, to her own brother who loved her. She doesn't want to understand why and she can't do anything else but to close her eyes and think of Adam´s marble expression and her own face against the mirror, scarred and changed and monstrous.

She has been stripped of herself without a chance to protest of defend herself. She doesn't know who is looking back through the surface.

A soft knock comes from the other side of the door, too hesitant and kind among the violence of what is happening.

“Adora,” It is Marlena, the voice of Adora´s mother making their way inside like tendrils.

She sounds quiet, hesitant even but soft, sweet as she speaks Adora´s name. Adora looks towards the door from between her fingers, cornering herself against the wall.

“Mom?”

“It's me, Adora, it's only me” Marlena tries to push the heavy door open but it won't give up that easily from her side, her voice mellow when she speaks to Adora again. “Let me in, sweetheart. Please”

Adora shakes her head even though she knows her mother cannot see her, balling her hands over her own chest. A snake brushes gently over her own cheekbone and she fights the urge to puke.

“I don't want to hurt you.”

There is a moment of silence there, a quiet second where Adora cannot hear anything else but the rush of fabric and a faint murmur that dies down as soon as it starts.

“Tie a rope over your face, sweetheart,” Marlena says again, her voice closer to the wood of the door. She sounds louder, the sweet tone melting on the edges of something harder.

“But mom-”

“Trust me, Adora,” Marlena cuts her, a sense of urgency washing over her. “It’s alright. You are my daughter.”

Adora flinches as Adam´s last words make their way too inside her mind, bending and mixing with her mother´s, the words of someone that loved her, of someone that was supposed to love her. And she believes her.

She trips as she searches for a loose piece of red fabric misplaced somewhere after she bursted inside the chamber, ripping it into pieces with eager hands.

She is trembling still, scared and confused out of her mind; she feels pain and sorrow and mourn and unbelievable loss but right now she needs her mother more than everything, so she ties the rope twice around her eyes until it hurts, until the already dark world becomes darker and she can't see past the merciful surface of the fabric.

Adora doesn't even know if this will help but Marlena is already pushing the door again, the click of something and the heavy weight of the wood against marble following the room when she steps inside.

“I´m coming in,” Marlena whispers, though her voice sounds still so far away Adora can almost feel the void that lives in it.

Adora waits for several seconds, kneeling in the middle of the room with her body and soul vulnerable and her eyes covered by fabrics, awaiting for her mother´s reassuring touch to cradle her in and help her where the gods have denied her mercy.

She waits and waits and she is so scared and distracted by the sizzling of the snakes suddenly snapping and swirling in her nape that she fails to listen to the silent rush of several steps inside the chamber, circling her until they are behind her.

She fails to feel the change of air until the acrid smell of sweat and heavy panting crashes against her nose and by then it is already too late.

A heavy weight falls over her head completely, enveloping her from the nape of her neck to her chin, covering a portion of the still young snakes on her head and her entire face with its cold surface.

It smells like metal, jarring and still hot and sizzling from where it had just been changed by forge fire from a theater mask to a prison. The iron mask devours her face whole and claps on the back of her head click and tighten into place so quickly that she barely has time to react to the several hands grabbing her by the shoulders and arms, shoving her down as she jolts and tries to struggle away from their touch, kicking at their hold with all her might.

“No. No. What is this? What is this?!”

Adora is screaming again but it sounds muffled, drowned out even for herself. Because the mask has been left without a mouth and the place where the eyes should see through has been covered by raw iron, imprisoning Adora inside her own curse without being able to say goodbye to the sunlight or take one last breath of clean air.

Her breathing speeds up, her heart beats so fast inside her chest it threatens to rip itself out of her chest.

She kicks and lashes, whispering when the hold of the people grabbing her digs sharply in her skin and she tries to snap their hands away only to be held down again with so much force her muscles protest in pain.

She struggles again and manages to set free one of her arms, running her trembling fingertips over the crude surface of the iron mask, feeling the depths and crevices of the metal against her skin, biting on whatever is left of her to be delicate.

She pinches at the melted metal and digs her nails into the iron straps that close over her ears and across the back of her head, pulling down without success. No matter how hard or violent or desperately she crawls and pulls the mask won't give away, it won't set her free.

She is no longer a princess, no longer the daughter of her parents or the sister of a now gone brother. She isn't even a person anymore.

Now she is just a creature the gods have turned their back to, no matter how devoted and loved she was once, they have abandoned her. And in return, her own people have abandoned her too.

“Take it off! Please! Please, take it off me! I swear I'm not going to hurt you, just take it off!”

Adora is openly sobbing now, choking with her own tears and the ichor still dribbling from the wounded snakes, salt and copper and iron smell making their way inside Adora's nose and mind and never leaving again.

“Mom, please. Please take it off!”

“I´m sorry, Adora. I´m so sorry,” It is her mother´s voice now, clear among the myriad of people that are speaking too, shouting orders to each other and breathing hard on Adora´s iron covered ears.

She sounds strained, like a heavy weight has been placed on her chest, yet she doesn´t sob or sound remorseful, standing somewhere in front of Adora´s kneeling body.

“You must understand, please, you must comply with this. The Gods are testing us, they are testing our resolution and our strength. Your brother, Adora, your father has not parted from your brother's side. Your brother is gone because of you.”

Adora flinches, pain washing over her worse than the iron mask and the snakes biting themselves over her skin. Marlena´s voice breaks down in the end and when she speaks next she doesn't even try to contain the venom inside of it.

“We´ve done so much for you, Adora, we have sacrificed so much for you already. This is the best we can do to protect our people.”

“No, that is not true!” Adora exclaims, fighting to stand up and failing completely by the hands holding her back and the mask asphyxiating her.

She drags her fingers over the neck of the mask, yanking it everywhere until she feels her own face raw and peeling underneath, scratched by poorly filled corners and sharp edges.

“This is not who we are, it's not who you are. You know this, mom. You know it wasn't my fault. Please, take it *off!”*

“Do not doubt, your Majesty,” there is a second voice now, right next to Adora´s mother. Sultry and sharp, Prim speaks every word with false sorrow dripping in satisfaction. “It is painful but sacrifices sometimes must be made to protect the rest of our people, of our nations.”

There is a ruffle of fabrics where Prime kneels down, grasping the iron cradled chin of the mask, yanking Adora´s head back painfully.

Somewhere inside Adora´s chest she feels about to be sacrificed too, like a goblet of wine or a horse or a legendary creature, about to be slashed down and beheaded to please a thousand gods or a single man.

“I am so, so sorry Adora, I truly am. You would have been adored under my sight but these are the gods wishes and we must obey them. Rest assured that I will look after what is left of your family and your city as they deserve.”

Adora´s eyes widen under the iron, shaking her head until she is dizzy. “No, no! Mom!”

“We´ll take you somewhere where you can never hurt anybody else. Then, if you still want to be free of what the gods have cursed you with, you can die by your own hand.”

Prime turns around, not sparing a single look more on Adora. The guards around her raise her up, struggling when she fights until she is exhausted to the bone and they drag her away, scraping her knees against the floor and catching the hem of her red tunic with the rocks scattered on the floor.

Adora calls and begs for her parents *Mom. Dad. Please. Take it off. Please!* but none of them answer, instead standing side by side around the kneeling figure of Adam´s statue, their own fate already falling over them cold and merciful, swirled by the Moiras fingers in green stained thread.

They never once dare to glance back.

This, *this* the last time her parents betray her. And then Adora becomes a monster.

The cave is damp and cold where Adora´s feet step over the slippery stones of the floor, dodging freezing water drops that fall from the erratic ceiling and puddles in the ground.

Nothing beautiful grows here, nothing colorful and sweet and warm, but Adora has spent enough years inside this nature-given prison to learn her way across the sharp formations of stone.

She has earned her place among these cold walls after tripping and falling in her knees a thousand more times, climbing the high columns of a once underground temple that now are nothing else but crumbles, seeking for sunlight until she fell from the end of a cavern into what later would become a refugee.

There are many stones here, rising high or falling down into pieces to the ground, surrounding the entrance of the cavern as their own kind of warnings, keeping those who want to take a glimpse inside far away and Adora here, quiet and completely alone.

There is a corner of the cavern where nor water or light ever reaches, hidden and buried among stone and shredded pieces of red fabric, where the torn pieces of iron and long ago

dried blood still remain, pried open by exhausted hands and nails and screams full of desperation.

That corner remains untouched, unvisited and silent.

Adora steps over a patch of blue moss, digging her fingers in the soft earth underneath with a small hum, the hem of her white tunic damp where she walked under the soft drizzle that slips inside.

The snakes that curl over her temples and forehead sizzle curiously over her skin and Adora tampers them down with the back of her palm, shushing them as she tucks them back inside the veil she wraps over her head.

She bends down and plucks out the broken end of an arrow that has found its way dug into the rock of the floor, sneaking under Adora´s sigh. She rubs her finger over the polished end, frowning at the colors wrapped over the thin wood, purple and pink and blue.

She doesn´t recognize this city but then again she has been here for over five years now, she doesn't even remember the last time someone raised a bow against her, *except that she does, she remembers them all.*

Who knows what cities have risen and fallen since she was thrown into this cave like Kronos to the Tartarus.

Adora carries the broken end with her for a few more steps and then tosses it aside against the walls, the gold tip falling carelessly among the other´s, swords and shields and broken bows gathered in dozens, their copper and gold and silver surfaces gone dusted and molded with the pass of the years, devoured by the rush of time against them.

Adora wraps her hand over the broken end of a column and pushes herself upwards, climbing easily into the soft patches that live there, barely even breaking a sweat.

There are no spaces for fire here, nor offerings or sacrificial pyres; she doesn't pray or ask for help anymore, doesn't cry. Adora is already a living sacrifice on itself anyway.

She is about to scrunch under the heavy fabrics hanging from the hole on the wall when she hears it, hears them. Shouts and exclamations, loud cheers and yelling getting closer and closer to the entrance of the cavern.

Adora stills, frozen in her place, waiting with her heart on her throat as she listens. She waits, begging that they are just an errand caravan walking by, lost on their path and that will be long gone in no time.

After all, the entrance is covered with thick trunks covered in sharp thorns, vines of rotten colors and sharp fallen rocks. Nobody would walk inside this place unless they know what they are looking for.

Adora´s heart hammers inside her ears as she listens to the voices closer and closer. She can't make out what they are saying but she can distinguish someone yelling, loud and harsh and

extremely angry, words getting lost among the noise as whatever they are traveling in stops right in front of the cavern.

Adora sighs, very slow and heavy, resting her forehead over the cold surface of the pillars with an exhausted and mournful exhale.

The yelling picks up again, clear struggle happening outside of the cavern. She hears a heavy thud and then something that sounds pretty much like a kick on someone's private parts because someone very clearly groans in pain and falls into the ground, followed by someone else cursing them in a very ancient greek curse.

It would be kind of funny actually, if it wasn't for the fact that the turmoil on the entrance of the cavern gives way to stumbling steps inside and a heavy, painful fall against the ground.

Adora shrinks in her small corner, not risking a glance away. She knows she needs to move, this is the worst place she could have seen herself cornered into, but she remains here, hidden partially by the column and the natural formations of the cavern´s wall.

The person inside the cavern groans, giving clear depth breaths for a few seconds before quieting completely again. Inside this silence, Adora can hear the frantic beating of their heart, rushing blood and quiet breath as the person stands up from wherever they have fallen into and then takes a step forward.

Adara waits for the chase, for the rush of adrenaline down the person's body as their mind catches on their body and they sprint forward, chasing the shadows as they search for Adora, for the monster that lives here.

Adora has seen many heroes waltz among this walls, alone and in groups and legions, all of them bringing new smart ways to try to evade her stone gaze, all of them trying to corner her and kill her and take with them her head as a trophy because, after all, who doesn't want to take the glory of bringing dead to Eternia´s most feared monster?

Adora has seen it all, has begged them to stop enough times; she has had to fight her way out. The scars in her body and the statues clustering the cavern are testimony enough of that.

The person is still walking inside the cavern, careful steps that seem almost hesitant and, not for the first time, Adora hears them stumble and almost fall, their heartbeat rising with each step.

The cave is dark but not nearly enough to be impossible to navigate into, and at least for the first meters between the entrance and where Adora is perched over, the path is mostly straight forward. But then again, maybe this is just another strategy to catch Adora off guard. Adora has always been an excellent strategist herself.

She slides off the column elegantly, standing behind the crumbled and thick backs of two of them that have long ago fallen into each other, leaving a perfect triangle for Adora to look through if she wanted.

Adora´s sight remains away though, staring at the pink quartz in the ceiling, Adora´s only source of color for many nights, when she laid here in the grounds with her face wounded and her hands raw, waiting for the Gods to take mercy or disgust on her and let her go.

The steps are closer now, just as hesitant as before but never slow, and Adora holds her breath, waiting for the challenge, the rail up or the insult, or even the sweet words trying to hypnotize her out of her spot and into the end of a sword.

Instead, she starts getting yelled at. Quite angrily, too.

"We'll then! Go on!" the person exclaims, loud and almost offended and Adora´s heart seizes in her chest, all of her thoughts jolting to a stop. "Get over with this already!"

Adora gulps around the knot on her throat, closing her eyes tightly before daring to open them again, turning away on her spot just so she can glance through the columns to the person now standing in the middle of the cavern.

Adora strains her eyes, looking through the thick shadows and then gasps, very low in her throat, a new kind of fear falling over her like it has never done before.

Because there, standing precariously in the loose stones of the cavern, is not a hero cradled in gold or a general seeking glory or a poor idiot looking for self satisfaction.

Instead, with her hands on her hips and her ears twitching nervously, there is a woman.

There have been many kinds of people walking inside this place and never leaving again. Men, women, both, neither and new, it doesn't matter it never did all of them were searching for the same thing.

But this person is different, completely different to all of them, clear to anyone that is seeing, mortal or god perched on their golden thrones.

She is not wearing gold or copper, she is not carrying swords or arrows, she is not cheering or alluring her. Instead, she is soft.

There is a certain kind of sharpness on her, a pride in the way she throws her shoulders back and her head tilts towards the ceiling when water drops fall over her cheeks, but everything else is soft for Adora to see, hidden on this secret spot between the columns like a longing lover gazing to a forbidden love.

She must be around Adora's age, elegant as a panther or a forest nymph standing in the middle of Adora's prison. She is wearing the color of grapes on her tunic, of a red so deep it almost looks purple, held in place by straps and belts of leather around her waist. They mirror the wraps on her wrists and her feet, dark colored and well worn after days or years of use.

She is a magicat, this much Adora can say, her dark tail and ears flickering nervously as she takes in the sounds around her; elegant hands with sharp dark nails that prick tiny holes on the fabric of her tunic.

Adora can´t make out her face among the shadows, but she can see her thick hair falling in heavy loops towards her hips and at either side of her temples, slightly in disarray after some kind of struggle Adora could only begin to understand.

She is prideful and tender at the same time, and Adora´s heart sizes painfully inside her heart suddenly, tethering her into something dangerous.

“I know you are here, just-” the woman calls again, strained between clenched teeth.

Her voice is full of some kind of soft pridefulness too, slightly high from where either exasperation or anxiety are eating their way on her chest, with a tender squeakiness in the edges that makes Adora immediately fond of it.

There is a kind of familiarity that lives inside this voice, in those shoulders and dark loops of hair. A familiar sense that overwhelms Adora from one second to the other and, for a moment, she thinks that maybe, *maybe* , a voice that for many years has only breathed inside Adora's dreams has taken an exhale into the real world.

A voice Adora adored and searched for before everything came crashing down around her. The fragment of a dream chasing her, looking for her, founding Adora even among the pits of Hell. *Maybe.*

But not even the Gods could be that cruel, could they?

The young woman stomps in the ground angrily as she runs her claws over the strands of her hair, letting Adora see the glimpse of a button nose scattered in freckles, pink blush dusted over the soft brown skin of her cheek.

A sight too close to her face, somehow too private and intimate; like looking at the naked ankle below the hem of her dress or the soft swell of her breast under the wrinkled fabric of her tunic, raising and falling with every warm breath.

Adora snaps her eyes away sharply, both scared by the danger of being caught lingering her lethal gaze over her, and embarrassed by the way the skin of her monstrous face tingles with sudden warmth.

“This is what I'm here for, isn't it? To die,” the woman's voice breaks and splinters in the middle, fear betraying her. It makes Adora´s own heart to mourn in phantom pain.

Adora has never wanted this, not ever. She just once has wanted to use this curse that has been placed over her against someone else, just one time, one opportunity that escaped her by being too trustful and too naive. Too young still.

But she has never wanted to hurt anybody else, not the warrior with their lion shield, nor the soldier with their sword. And especially not her, not this person carefully stepping down the rocks.

“Well, though luck you asshole, because I am not going to go down without a fight!” The woman exclaims again and this time, it does bring a small breathless laugh out of Adora,

nervous and slightly historical, catching the woman´s sharp attention. Her tail bristles with the sound, head tilting slightly towards the side as if she couldn't place where the sound was coming from. “So?!”

"Please leave," Adora says, resting the back of her head against the column, looking up again with eyes misted in sudden tears, gathering in the corners.

She misses the way the woman jumps in surprise by the sudden echo of her voice, her head framed in curls snapping towards the columns.

There is a moment of silence where the only sound inside the cavern is the breathing of the woman and the quiet sizzling of the snakes curling below Adora's veil, curious as they try to peak out of the fabric and take a quick sniff at the newcomer tiptoeing on the the floor.

For a moment Adora hopes she has frightened her, as much as the thought stabs into her own heart she hopes this person's bravery is not as strong as it seems.

Sadly and exhilarating all on its own, Adora is wrong.

"Who are you?" The woman asks again, her voice lower, much calmer, weighing her words as well as she weighs her steps.

She doesn't sound scared anymore, not as much, with anxiety still lingering in the edges but something firmer falling into her tone.

"Leave" Adora repeats, louder this time, pressing herself tighter against the column. "Please,” and it comes as a plea, "I don't want to hurt you"

The cave goes quiet again, the water falling from the ceiling loud among the stillness. It is so silent so suddenly that for a moment Adora thinks the young woman has actually left, with her careful steps and her wild dark hair and for that very same second Adora mourns her like a broken heart crawling through the ground.

It doesn't last long. A small bunch of rocks scatter suddenly across the floor of the cave as a pair of elegant feet trip with the crumbled pieces of a tall stone, making the young woman fall harshly against the ground.

"Ouch" the woman groans, catching herself on her hands and knees to try and cushion the fall.

Adora flinches at the sound, already knowing she has scratched her palms with the sharp splinters on errand rocks. She risks another glance, the end of an errand vine tickling on her forehead when she catches sight of her.

"Fuck,” the woman complains, feeling the edges of the stone she had just tripped into with her fingertips. "What the– what are these rocks?"

Adora looks at her running her palm over the long surface of the rocks, holding her breath when the woman starts to make sense of the smooth curve of an arm dressed in armor,

followed by the forever frozen palm of a hand and the long ago broken length of uneven and incomplete fingers.

She looks at her snatching her own hand away and towards her chest, heartbeat speeding up inside her chest.

“Oh. Oh gods”

Adora shrinks in shame, hiding her face against her own shoulder.

“You can leave” Adora insists, screwing her eyes shut. “I'm not going to hurt you, I promise.”

The woman hums as she considers Adora's words, still lingering around the fallen stones. She stands up from among the debris, shaking dust off her tunic.

She brushes the stone for support when she circles it, coming to sit on the smooth surface of one of them. She chuckles lightly, a sound like bells around the entire cavern that makes something long ago buried inside Adora by Adora's own hands to stir awake again.

“Well, thanks. That sounds great and all but the thing is that I can't,” even with everything happening right now and the edge etched on her voice, she still sounds way too calm, letting her face fall between her palms. “If I go, I have nowhere else to go. My village will definitely not want me back.”

“Why?”

Adora finds herself asking, pulled forward to this person by something she can't even begin to understand. The strands of a long ago dream drowned by the tragedy of pain making their way back around her heart again, something that had never died inside Adora to begin with.

“They have been suffering through tons of disasters for months now. And, for some reason, the wife of the governor convinced all of those idiots that it's my fault because the gods resent me or something. So they had the brilliant idea to, well, ditch me here with you as an offering to regain the gods' favor.”

Adora's blood runs cold, even the snakes curling and peacefully napping against her shoulders startling awake by the sudden fury running on her body.

She knows everything that there is to be about being sacrificed in order to please the gods, prideful and bloodthirsty. She has been forced to do horrible things in order to survive. And now, even after everything, she is yet again being used as some kind of godly punishment for someone innocent.

Rage pools in Adora's throat and spills out, a word like a sizzling snake breaking through her lips into a growl.

“Why would she ever do that?”

“Because she is a massive bitch, probably,” the woman answers easily, venom that mirror's Adora's own falling off her tongue, like she couldn't contain the words either.

Adora breaks into a breathless laughter and, after a few seconds, the woman giggles too, wet and drenched in unspoken sadness.

“I mean, all things considered it could have been worse, no offense,” the woman says with a shrug. Her back is slightly turned to Adora and there is a wild curl bouncing over the freckled skin of her shoulder. “They could have opened my throat over the pyres.”

It doesn't really help to calm down the burning fire in Adora's veins. She sinks her nails into her palms, feeling the way the sharp ends cut lines on the skin there pooling and falling down her fingers.

Even the snakes start snapping blindly at the marble column, shaken awake and angry at the sudden want to dig their fangs into something.

Adora doesn't notice how silent she has gone, lost inside her own thoughts, until the woman speaks up again, confused and slightly hesitant.

“Are you- are you still there?”

“You can go anywhere” Adora snaps, biting on her own tongue until she tastes copper and salt. Her words trip with each other with how fast she pronounces them, charged with all of the passion and fire she thought she had lost years ago. “You can go anywhere you want, you don't have to go back there. You don't have to stay here, it is not fair. And I won't be another one of them, stripping you of your right to choose or to be free. You can go.”

The woman's breathing is heavy suddenly, her feet falling over the ground with a soft thud when she stands up again.

“Who are you?” she asks again, this time firmer. Her voice is calm but there is an edge in it that wasn't there before, inquiring as Adora's breathing speeds up too.

“I'm nobody important.” Adora mutters, loud inside the silence of the cave.

The words must displease the woman deeply because she clicks her tongue, giving another step forward over the stones, this time in Adora's direction.

“I’m starting to find that hard to believe”

“Why?”

“You're kind.” The woman hesitates for a second on her walk, feeling the surface of the ground with her sole to avoid falling again. “Kind of dumb too”

Adora would have snorted on offense if fear weren't suddenly eating its way inside her bones.

“You don't even know me”

“I know you haven't hurt me.”

The woman sounds closer now but she stops suddenly, weighing her thoughts. Adora can't see her anymore, closing her eyes until sparks of light shimmer behind her closed eyelids.

“You don't know me either, how do you know I'm not trying to manipulate so you let your guard down?”

“Are you?”

“No.” And the woman's voice is soft then, the brush of her hair against her back the only tell that she has given another step forward. “I know what everyone says about you, about the… mystery of the creature living here. I know the tales about heroes coming in and never living.”

Another step, this time much closer. The snakes hiss in warning against Adora's ears and her head pounds with pain.

“Yet you are still hiding on that corner as if you were afraid of me.” She is right next to the column now, her hand hovering over the marble surface without reaching completely yet. “So who are you?”

There is a patch of light falling where Adora is, coming from the only place of the cave where Adora has found refuge. As the sun moves in the sky outside of the cavern it washes over both of them, golden among the dark blues and blacks of the cave’s walls.

Adora covers her face with her palms and curls over herself against the column, pulling absently of the thin veil in her head to try and keep the snakes, now completely aware and deadly curious, in place.

“Don't step closer,” she grunts, but instead of a growl it comes as a plea, broken in the edges by fear.

The snakes hiss dangerously loud now, feeling Adora's own anxiety, and Adora hopes *that* might be enough for the woman to stumble back and give up on her approach.

Except that it doesn't.

“Why not?” and she almost sounds haughty, railing up some deep part inside Adora.

Adora feels the woman's palms now, warm against the cold skin of Adora's wrists, softly trying to pull down from where Adora is covering her face.

The touch sends thunderbolts over Adora's skin and she knows the woman can feel them too because she gasps, her sweet breath brushing against Adora's cheekbone where her own fingers don't reach to hide.

She is too close, *too dangerously* close to the danger of dying, forever casted on the most precious marble, just another soulless statue torturing Adora.

“You are trembling,” the woman whisper's under her breath, seemingly much more concerned by Adora's own fear than by the danger of her mere existence so close to her body.

The woman is not trembling when she touches Adora; instead her long and elegant fingers are rubbing circles on the inside of Adora's wrists, gentle and reassuring. And Adora feels like she was here before, with someone gentle trying to comfort her, even when Adora is supposed to be the monster.

“Why are you covering your face?”

“I can't control it, I can't stop it, no matter how much I try to.” Adora tries to yank herself away from her touch but it falls quiet and without strength.

Instead, Adora lets the woman pull from her hands until they are hanging at either side of her body, defeated by a single tender touch. Adora's eyes are still vehemently closed though, pressing together so hard her head spins, lighthearted. The woman smells like sandalwood and lavender.

“You can't stay, you need to leave. Please, *please.”*

Adora can feel the way the woman stretches her hand, her fingertips brushing gently over Adora's closed eyelids, calloused skin caressing the fragile skin and fluttering eyelashes gently.

"Ah. I understand,” the woman whisper's under her breath, almost as if she was speaking to herself.

She exhales, running her fingers from Adora's eyelids to her temples and back.

“Open your eyes,” she coos her, voice falling into a silent plea, like a siren that has found her way inside Adora's hell either as a final punishment or an ultimate salvation.

Adora inhales sharply and shakes her head softly inside the woman's hold, still trying to step away but incapable to test herself away from her.

“You don't understand.”

“I do. Open your eyes.”

“You'll *die.”* Are monsters supposed to beg? To plead inside the hold of a warm woman?

How many others have wandered through these very same stones? How many others have come dragging swords and arrows, looking through the polished surfaces of shields to seek her head?

Why her now, then? Why her, with her hair that bounces against Adora's forearms, with her witty words and gentle steps?

Why has Adora, who has been abandoned by the gods and cursed to die, suddenly been given this?

Should she suddenly relish in the whisper of dreams long ago buried in order to protect them? Should she give voice to the thoughts rising inside her head that maybe, even after everything, the miracle that Adora's mother once spoke about has found her?

Beatriz to Dante. Orpheus to Eurydice. To feel like she knows her, in mortal ways, in prophetic ways, in celestial ways, in promised ways?

What if she doesn't? What if it was all really just a dream? Another godly promise broken?

What if she does? What will Adora's heart do then?

Is Adora supposed to want this? The temptation to let her sight roam and glance at this woman's mysterious face, even for just a second? To have appetite?

To want to rest her hands on this woman's waist and the curve of her shoulders. even though she has just felt her warmth close for the first time?

Is Adora supposed to open her eyes?

“Trust me. It's alright.”

It's alright, Adora. Adora can hear the words echoing inside her mind, this woman's, who smells like a forest, and her brother's and maybe even the echo of other voices, reassuring her to move forward. *It's alright.*

“Look at me”

Adora holds her breath and then exhales, shivering air that ruffles the loops on the woman's temples. Adora digs her nails against the column and prays to the golden and turquoise snakes to remain hidden and then she opens her eyes, face to face to this apparition in front of her.

She has the moon nestled in her eyes.

This is the first thing Adora sees. They are two full moons, shimmering under the merciful sunlight that falls over both of them, huge and beautiful as starried owl eyes.

Once, they were ringed by color, beautiful turquoise and amber, but now the precious silver has overtaken them completely, twin mirrors that focus on Adora without actually looking at her at all.

And she is stunning, absolutely completely beautiful.

Her eyes are candles in her face, fallen stars nestled at the sides of her button nose. Her skin is soft and rich dark, scattered in freckles like kisses over her sharp cheekbones and the bridge of her nose, down her temples framed in thick loops of dark hair.

Her face is tilted to the side, considering Adora's silence with a tiny smile etched on the corner of her red lips, the ever so slightly tip of a fang catching cheekily on the bottom lip and Adora's want nothing else but to run her thumb over the frail skin.

Something has gone numb inside Adora's head. Whatever voice that screams at her that this is wrong, that this is dangerous, that this beautiful woman in front of her will slowly turn into stone in her hands, has gone quiet, drowned by the fast beating of her heart inside her chest.

Adora raises her hand, hovering her trembling fingers above the woman's face before daring to move at all. The tip of Adora's fingers brush the curve of her cheekbone, a phantom feeling blooming inside her chest at the touch, caressing the skin under the woman's eyes that raises in goosebumps immediately at the touch, followed by a faint blush.

This is the first time someone turns her eyes at Adora's monstrous gaze and keeps breathing.

This is the first time Adora sees her face, surrounded by a halo of light.

This is the first time she meets her outside her dreams.

This is the first time Adora falls in love.

“Oh” Adora gasps, wet as tears start to drip down her cheeks, staining the beautiful blind woman's hands in ebony. “You can't…” a breath “Can you see me?”

“No,” she answers, full of knowing mirth, and the corner of her lips twitches in a sorrowful smile. “Can you?”

“Yes.” Adora sinks to her knees, tears falling unstoppable down her stone cold cheeks, unable to ever tear her gaze away from her ever again.

There she is, *there you are*, bright as a sun among Adora’s curse.

“You are so beautiful”

This is and will be the only devotion of your heart. It will be your greatest joy and your most tender sorrow, and in the end, you will need to let her go

---

Strike me down. You’ve won. I’ve lived my whole wretched life at your mercy, yours alone, and God knows I deserve to die at your hand. You are my only friend. I am undone without you.

– *Tamsyn Muir* , **Gideon the Ninth**

Chapter End Notes

Hope you liked it! I'm not sure when I'll be posting the next chapter but as always news, Q&A and art will be available on my social media (@aoiveaeart everywhere)

Comments, kudos and bookmarks are deeply appreciated. See you next time. Be good! (◠‿◠)♡

Verse II

Chapter Summary

> "For Catra, the world is bright. It has always been like this. But for that we must return to the past"

Chapter Notes

> I am back baby! Woohoo. Totally did not took me almost a year to write but I promise chapters will be coming sooner now!
>
> Today we take a look to Catra's story and from then on, we will focus finally on building Catra and Adora's relationship, which I'm very excited about!
>
> A few tiny notes before the chapter starts.
>
> I am getting political maybe with this story, and I'm definetly getting wildly feminist. Medusa it's, from the get go, a story about women and unfairness to women, and we seem to be living in a world where everything is fighting to remain treating us as objects. We are louder now, however, louder and stronger and we stand strong no matter what. So yes, this story is meant to be a love letter for woman and their strength and their live, as pretty much every single thing I write.
>
> Also, I've been doing lots of research to write Catra's character as she has a visual disability. For that my best guide has been this post https://www.tumblr.com/mimzy-writing-online/185122795699/writing-a-blind-or-visually-impaired-character which I highly recommend to read.
>
> Last but not least, warning for minor characters death
>
> Hope you enjoy this chapter and I'll see you downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse II

The River's Daughter

Darker times will come and go

Times you need to see her smile

And mothers' hands are warm and mild

I would rather feel this world through the skin of a child

– **Aurora** , *Through the eyes of a child*



For Catra, the world is bright. It has always been like this. But for that we must return to the past.

The first thing she remembers it's the sky. Blue. Wide. Filled with colors and filled with light. It is also the last view she remembers. Golden.

She remembers other things too. Berries, mostly, with their round seeds and deep color. Pomegranates and figs ripe in her fingers. She remembers holding them off the palms of her mother's hands and she remembers the copper shade of her pretty skin against hers, so much alike.

She remembers herself, a little bit, blurred on the copper mirror as if she was looking at her reflection on the moving waters of the river just outside. Dark hair like her mother´s, lighter behind her ears, almost red in certain places under the sun. Dark skin with patches of light and the shape of her own eyes, blues and ambers already mingling with the moon's light. But nothing else.

She remembers fabrics, cotton made. Olive green and purple and wine red. She remembers her mother's loom where she would spend long hours reaching the most beautiful tapestries; sitting next to the open window of their tiny home. Where Catra would spend so long sitting on the floor or in the grass next to her, looking at her through blurred eyes.

She remembers things yet she cannot remember her mother´s eyes. As much as she tries, she can´t; and maybe it is normal, a part of life as so many years have gone by since the last time Catra saw her face, but it is tragic and it is sad.

Catra remembers her, however, a little bit how she remembers the rivers, with their ever flowing currents and their cold water licking Catra´s feet. She remembers her as she remembers how the barks of the trees looked like or how many thorns a flower bush could have.

She remembers her in the little things that have nothing to do with sight. In the song of the bird that sang at the exact hour when her mother would wake her up to start the day. She remembers her in the smell of barley bread dipped in wine and in the heat of meat charring in the fire for the gods to thrive in.

Catra knows her from the quiet and thankful prayers to Demeter for another year filled with bursting crops and in the smell of pressed roses for Aphrodite to bathe in, filling their entire home. She thinks about her every single time she presses her feet on the spring floor and on the winters when Persephone says goodbye and the moss becomes cold.

As she remembers her in faith and in hope, she remembers her too in touch.

Her mother's hands were always callous from the field work, and her fingers always scratched from the loom. She used to run them over Catra´s cheeks and ears, caressing her scalp when she taught her to learn her own hair with sensation alone. She used to rest them over Catra´s small chest when she was sick; and she guided her with them across the steps of their home.

Catra remembers her hold as she taught Catra everything that there was to be told about their home, every single creak and place and corner, as tiny or as big as it was, painting a map inside Catra´s mind that later grew beyond their garden, and their forest and their village as a whole.

Her hands were there when Catra would miss a step and fall on her knees over the ground, not screaming at her or humiliating her but also not helping her completely, instead only guiding her up again. Because if there was another thing her mother taught her was that people are filled with goodness but sometimes also selfishness, and Catra would have to learn to fence for herself when the time came.

Catra remembers her in the touch of her hand as her mother laid in bed and the heat of her forehead as fever took over her until Tanatos came for her and took her away.

There are certain other things why Catra remembers her mother. In sound.

She recalls the shiver of her mothers voice the morning Catra woke up, five and scared as the world had become just a little more blurred in the edges, casting everything in light and making it look as if Catra was seeing the world from below the water.

Catra also remembers her mother´s voice as they sat with the village's physician and the touch of his fingers around her face. And the way he was dizzying, shape shivering like a flame on the breeze, barely even there for Catra to see. And for a moment Catra thought he looked like someone else entirely, golden and shimmering.

“How long?” Catra´s mother asked, wrapping her warm arms around her daughter's body where the latter had come to nuzzle into as if the embrace alone could heal her.

“Could be a couple of years, months. Weeks even, it's unknown,” the physician answered heavily and Catra remembers that he smelled like herbs and beeswax. “The only thing we can know for sure is that time will come where she will not be able to distinguish any shape at all. Light, maybe, but that's it. She will lose her sight completely.”

Catra was young but not as much as to not understand what was going to happen to her. She knew, after stumbling on her own feet even as a magicat; after getting wrong the path home through the forests one too many times; after looking up at her mother's face and not being able to recall how many freckles on her nose she had. She knew something was quite different in her and she didn´t mourn it until her mother did.

“Why her?” her mother cried, resting her cheek atop Catra´s young forehead. “Why C´yra?”

“It's the will of the gods, Io.”

“But she is just a child”

Catra blinked at the roof and for a second it didn´t look marble and adobe made but pink quartz, shimmering around the clouded spots of her eyes.

“Who knows, Io? Maybe there is a reason why she won´t be able to see past her young years. Maybe there is a reason.” The physician shifted on his chair, running his fingers over his golden hair, sun smelling. “Maybe it's a blessing, not a curse.”

Catra is nine when the world slowly drifts from shapes and colors into clouds, mist of the things she had come to know. She is ten when she can no longer see the tapestries woven by her mother´s hands; neither can she see the ways her fingers move through the threads, nor the figs or the rivers or the sky.

She is nine when Helios holding the sun becomes only golden light, slipping through her dark eyelashes and filling it all with white and shimmering colors that Catra can´t quite place. When the shapes she once knew become foreign to her, when the path becomes dangerous, when the world turns upside down.

It is foreign, in the beginning, this loss, but it is not sudden instead long ago expected. It happens slowly, it happens with pain, it aches every single day until it stops burning and the shapes and the people and the landscapes and Catra´s mother disappear beneath it.

It does not happen like something magical or amazing. Nothing wonderful comes in exchange from her sight. Sparkles don´t shine in the sky, her body does not become stronger or otherworldly. No god comes down to bless her.

It simply happens, like tragedies, like life. And the moment it arrives is still too early in her life, she is too young.

And she mourns it, quietly, secretly in the corners of the forest where she knows hidden spots lie. She cries endless hours there until her clouded eyes are sore and red and everything she can distinguish are golden and pink shapes. Even so young, she thinks that she will mourn it for the rest of her life, forever casted behind the mist of her own irises.

She does not understand yet, the reason painted as an excuse of future pain. But then again, she is still just nine and she is just learning the world.

She takes it head on.

She learns to make her way through the forest, over and back away through the path of the river so she can reach the village and her home again.

Her mother ties tapestry thread on the barks and branches and guides her a few times until she is sure Catra knows the way for herself and then she lets her go too, trusting for the gods to look after her daughter.

And Catra? Catra finds out she is not only capable, but she is also good at it. She becomes.

Even ten, even still a child, she follows the pretty sounds of the river she grew up learning, skipping over the slippery pebbles and the lilies that grow on the edge of the water and that doesn´t even try to pull her into the water by the ankles. She follows the knotted thread with her fingertips and carries the basket with figs on her hands, marching sure and without stumbling back towards the village where the market is.

She does not know this, but the gods love her, some of them, and some of them watch over her, following her still young steps with their breaths held. After all, they are immortal beings, and the deeps roots of love between mortals sometimes serves them as enough entertainment.

There is one day, the first week of Catra traveling alone, where the pebbles below her bare feet give up and she stumbles a little, barely holding herself up by the bushes around her. They catch her mid fall but also scratch her palms a little, making her wrinkle her nose in annoyance.

She is alone in the middle of the forest, her tunic wine colored even if she can´t see it anymore and her tail lashing nervously behind her with anxiety. Suddenly, another sound has come from behind her, the distinguishable echo of footsteps over the soft leaves and moss on the floor, approaching Catra carefully.

Where Catra´s sight has abandoned her, other senses have sharpened, alert all the time, by smell or touch or hearing or all of it together. After all, she is a magicat, and she hears the person walking towards her meters before it can reach her.

“Can I help you?” Ten years old Catra exclaims, sharp like a thorn, all of her curls held behind her head and her back straight.

The person stops on their tracks and hesitates, head tilting to the side, a sound Catra can hear by the way the fabric of the stranger's tunic brushes against the soft bells of their earrings.

“I was going to ask the same exact thing, youngling.”

It´s young, this person, but at the very same time it sounds wiser than any old person Catra has ever encountered before. There is a certain kind of command on their voice when they speak, but there is also softness, and an edge of mirth where they seem surprised by the proud tone of voice tumbling out of Catra´s young mouth.

Catra frowns, scowling a little as she finds the thread again and starts making her way next to the river again.

“I'm perfectly good on my own, thank you.” She says, snapping her teeth together. The person chuckles without mockery, making Catra´s ears twitch with curiosity.

“So I can see, little princess.”

That calls Catra´s attention but she doesn´t stop her march. instead giving a sharp flick of her tail towards them who renews their steps, following Catra closely behind.

“I am not a princess.” Catra grunts, following her own steps and the thread. “I´m just a weaver, and a farmer.”

“Yes, I guess you are right. You are not a princess quite yet.”

There is no malice in the person's voice and for a moment it makes Catra doubt, wanting to stop altogether and turn around to try and catch a better shape of the person now walking right next to her, between her and the river.

It should be frightening, the sudden appearance of an older person Catra does not know and that seems to have taken a liking for her, but it doesn´t feel wrong. It´s, in a way, like walking with a sibling, with a guardian, someone that smells a little bit like thunder and like the leather of arrows, walking next to Catra´s tiny and stubborn figure across the forests of Menagerie.

“Well, do you have a name, stranger?” Catra says finally after a few minutes of silence, still holding herself to her basket and to the red thread

“I don´t think my name is something you would like,” the stranger says, thoughtful. It almost seems to be mournful the way in which they say it, like something that holds a sad meaning for them even though it is just a name. Catra thinks about it as the stranger hums again, their tone cheering up again immediately. “My wife calls me love, though”

Catra blinks, her blind eyes snapping towards the side where the stranger is walking and then back in front of her. She frowns, her whole face falling into something blank, and she knows her mother would call her out for being rude but she cannot even begin to care right now.

“Well, she must love you quite a deal,” Catra dead pans, rolling her sightless eyes inside their sockets.

Instead of taking offense at the evident sarcasm, the stranger laughs, a loud snort that somehow sounds like bells and that scares the birds on the top of the trees and makes them fly away.

“Yes, she does. I'm really grateful and I´m really lucky for her,” the stranger says with an edge of tenderness that doesn´t go unnoticed by Catra´s young ears.

Catra shakes her shoulder, taking a sharp turn where she knows and hears the river parts into two paths, still following her path. And if she hadn´t lived here her whole life, and if her mother hadn´t taught her, or if she wasn´t *Catra* , she would probably have gotten lost. The stranger gives an approving hum next to her, still following close by as the path keeps going.

“And, have we met before?” Catra presses on, nibbling on her bottom lip.

The stranger hums again, shaking their head. There is quite a strange sound following him too, Catra hears. Like something heavy being dragged softly over the grass behind them. It's almost like the sound of a blanket, and also like the sound of a bird folding its wings, soft feathers against the earth.

“Not really,” they admit, clicking their tongue.

“Then why are you following me?” Catra snaps, exasperated.

The stranger snorts again, truly filled with mirth. It does not sound as if they were making fun of Catra but instead as if they were truly amused by her.

“My mother is awfully fond of you,” they start explaining, whistling under their breath. “I´m not supposed to interfere but I got curious, so I came to walk with you through the river so she would be sure you were safe”

That makes Catra's steps slow, even if just a little. If this stranger has a mother that worries then they cannot be that dangerous or weird. Though Catra has met a considerable bunch of nasty people even in her young years.

“Is she a friend of my mother?” Catra asks, still quite unimpressed by the whole thing. The stranger hums an affirmative tune.

“They are close. Your mother believes in love fiercely.” The stranger skips over the ground and steps softly over the moss, so softly that they almost make no sound at all. Somewhere inside Catra's head it occurs to her that it sounds like a flying bird skipping over the grass. “Other members of my family are also quite curious of you”

“Why?”

“I guess they realize stuff about you that you don´t know quite yet”

Catra shifts on her feet, trying to keep herself calm where her heart picks up. There is something in this stranger's voice, almost secretive, as if they knew something Catra didn't.

“Are they good?” Catra asks because she is still ten and she can't help but to ask.

“They are”

The path from Catra's home next to the river to the village it's not too long but just enough to take a bit of time to reach it. After all, the busy village with too much noise and movement was the last thing Catra's mother wanted for them.

Catra walks quietly in the company of the stranger, her tail still lashing nervously behind her and her ear twitching nervously but more quietly, carefully following the path. The stream of the river is still strong but Catra can start to hear the first echoes of the village nearby, merchant shouts and horses and the normal frenzy of the market.

“Tell me, little weaver, do you dream?” The stranger asks out of nowhere and somehow their voice sounds gentler and at the same time higher, as if the sun itself had made the notes sparkle with some kind of ethereal curiosity that Catra cannot understand yet.

Catra´s eyebrows twitch, confusion falling over her. “What do you mean?”

“When you close your eyes for the night, what do you see?” The stranger explains, skipping over the grass until their steps cannot be heard anymore. “Be honest, all friendship should start with trust”

“I didn´t say I wanted to be your friend,” Catra snaps back, clicking her tongue against her teeth, The complaint makes the stranger laugh again.

“I guess you didn´t”

They wait a beat, then another, but Catra cannot stop thinking in the words. She thinks she knows the meaning of the question or maybe she just supposes, but she knows the answer to it anyway. She has always known, just as well she knew her sight would change, just as well as she knew the light of the sun. In a young life where everything seemed to be ever changing, the one thing Catra has always known it's those dreams.

“I see gold,” Catra whispers, feeling the shape of the flower bushes next to her. She doesn´t see it, but the stranger smiles.

“That's interesting”

“But not gold like a coin,” Catra´s words stumble. Even like this, even from beneath the iridescent cloud in her irises, Catra can still see those images. They are seared inside her memories and embroidered there with golden thread. “More like the gold the sun was– is I guess. Gold like the threads of my mother.”

Golden like laughter, like warm smiles, like ankles beneath a tunic. Golden eyelashes and pretty blue like the glass she never got to know fully. Running in wheat fields and over sand so fine that it feels soft and cold at the very same time. Those are the dreams Catra has, the ones where she sits on white sand and hears running water and she walks hand in hand with a beautiful girl she cannot remember.

These dreams had been Catra´s only anchor through her entire life, something constant and never changing. They had guided Catra through the worst before she lost her sight completely, when the pain in her eyes and her temples was too much to bear and even asleep it would chase her. They had saved her, and when she could not see anything else but light, they became a star as bright as the sun and a sound as beautiful as a lyre, the lemongrass smell of the beautiful girl singing Catra to sleep.

She had never talked about this to anyone, nobody besides her mother and even Io didn´t know what else to say but to assure her that the dream existed because Catra loved, and she was loved in return.

“Before I used to see golden hair and… blue. It's all I remember..”

“Blue is beautiful”

“Blue is terrifying” Catra says, breath shivering. “Is both river and storm. Is both stone and sword. But it's such a beautiful blue.” Catra hesitates on her steps, unsure for a second if to

keep walking or just stay here and listen to the river forever. “It's not the things I see what matter though”

“Then what is?” The stranger asks and Catra knows they are trying to be gentle but there is just so much Catra is willing to give off her dreams with nothing in return.

“What do you dream about?” Catra asks the stranger, tilting her head to the side when they hold their breath, taken by surprise by Catra´s question. “Fair is fair”

Another chuckle, whoever this is, they seem to laugh too much, or maybe they are just getting a kick out of laughing at Catra´s impertinence. “True. Fair is fair, little princess. I am afraid that I do not dream”

“How so?”

“I don't sleep, not really,” They hum, suddenly deeply pensive. “But if I could dream, then I would dream of my wife and my child. They are my soul and my happiness”

It sounds sincere, deeply honest, and somehow it manages to ease Catra´s nerves.

“I dream of a girl that laughs.” Catra says finally, after a long sigh, all of her young devotion poured inside her words. “And she reads poetry next to orange trees and she smells like lemongrass.” Catra worries the inside of her cheek with her teeth, turning her head where she knows the stranger is. “That´s what I dream”

“That's perfect”

They are right in the limits of the woods and the start of the market now. The sound now is almost deafening, coming from every single side you turn your head to.

Merchants are screaming at the top of their lungs *Fabrics! Apples! Gold for the wrists of your wives!* And going in and around everywhere, tripping with themselves or with others and rushing on their feet as the morning rush starts to make it´s way on the village.

Catra grumbles a little under her breath, shifting on her soles as she feels the change from the grass to the stone ground of her village, cool beneath her toes. She knows all of these sounds by now, like the back of her hand, but that doesn´t mean the hustle is less overwhelming for her already sensitive ears.

“And here you are now. At the market,” the stranger exclaims with a little tug of victory on their voice, flourishing as a verbal curtsy for Catra to catch.

Catra rolls her moon-colored eyes, groaning deeply. “I´m blind, not deaf, you know?”

Another chuckle feels her ears and it makes the sound of the market to lower down, just enough that Catra can hear the stranger completely.

“Well I guess here is where I take my leave. I'm not fond of people looking at me.” The stranger explains, moving until Catra hears them right in front instead of next to her.

Catra shifts nervously in her feet, suddenly feeling unsure to be left. She is still just a child and she has no friends. “Will you be back tomorrow?”

The stranger seems to think about it for a long second, whistling softly under their breath before finally answering. “What are you selling tomorrow?”

“Pomegranates”

“Interesting. I think I will come then,” Catra feels a hand fall over the crown of her head, petting her curls twice before going away. “As it turns out, it seems I am also quite fond of you now”

Catra has no friends, except for those that have taken upon themselves to protect her.

“Be careful on the way back, C´yra”

One moment they are there and the next Catra knows they are gone, the sound of their bells like laughter left behind as the only proof of their existence. It is all too weird for Catra to wish to understand and it doesn't even occur to her that she didn't tell them her name in the first place.

“Crazy people”

Catra walks with the stranger to the village every single market day when her mother is not accompanying her. They walk in silence sometimes. They speak about figs and pomegranates and the sky sometimes. Sometimes, just sometimes, they speak about dreams.

Catra lives her whole life with these people, in this village, crossing the woods from the small home she and her mother share and back again. She knows nothing else and comes to learn it all just as she knows the crevices of her own hand, just as she knows the sounds of her forest and the smells that surround her.

The people of the town know her, deeply. After all, they have seen her be born and grow little by little. This little magicat girl who was always hung up from the skirt of her mother´s tunic when she went to the market to sell her tapestries to the royal heralds; and later who came to sell her own harvest too.

They have known her since she was a newborn baby and they respect her mother, even if the judgmental stares of the village follow them around when Io is not looking at them. Because after all, leaving the village to go live on her own with her child was something most of the village could not understand at the beginning.

Catra knows the village but the woods and the rivers are her home. She knows every single secret corner and soft patch of moss. She knows in what part of the river shore the fish swim in clusters in summer, their tails snapping against the water when Catra bribes them with bait. She knows the feeling of the earth when it´s the time of the harvest and the smell of the sky when the rains are soon.

Catra grows up knowing about hard work, her eyes never once stopping her from doing the exact same work her mother does. They plant seeds together and tend to the fields throughout the months where it grows. And once it is ready,they harvest together. The very first years, Io does not allow Catra to harvest on her own, teaching her the technique first and giving her the task to carry the crops back home. Once Catra is fifteen and older, Io hands her another sickle and together they cut the crops of their land and prepare them for the market.

Every once in a while, another lady would join them to help them harvest. Catra never knew her before her sight went away, but she always knew when she was near because she smelled like fresh apples and earth and she would always whistle under her breath to let Catra know she was near.

This woman, she was kind. She treated Io with kindness and Catra with gentleness and helped them on their harvest, blessing them under her breath as she worked.

Her hands were always worn out by the work on the field, Catra knew this from the times she would brush Catra´s locks and loop them anew. She spoke with a soft voice to Io and guided her through life when things were sometimes too much.

She was goodhearted but also strong willed and she taught Catra the things Io could not do by herself.

Politics, music and literature. She taught Catra how to.play the flute without needing anything else but her ears and her breath. She taught her how to write and read in different ways than others would do it, listening to Catra's poems and manuscripts as they harvested.

This woman would take hours off her day for it and would always hum approvingly, even when she corrected her. And she was proud, proud of Catra when she became a diplomat and a strategist all by herself. After all, this woman had always assured her just how smart, cunning and capable she was, and Catra grew up without being afraid of herself.

Sometimes, Catra would ask her mother who this woman was. Why would she do so much for them without asking nothing in return, almost becoming a part of their family too.

“Deo is a good woman,” Io would answer, guiding Catra´s hands through the threads of the loom. “She is older and she only wants to help us.”

Catra remained quiet, waving the tapestry with known movements, creating shapes and colors of the things she could remember. Sun and blue.

“Is she your mother?” Catra asked after a beat, her finger shivering over the threads. She could hear her mother taking a breath, controlled and quiet, as if she had been waiting for this to be asked one day.

“It's different, darling,” Io answered, caressing Catra´s cheekbones with the back of her knuckles. “But if it would be on her, I think Deo would like for you to think about her as a guide too.”

This is how Catra´s childhood goes. She lives between fields soft under her palms and the river's water up to her ankles and her dreams.

She drinks on them, loves them, holds them dearly to her heart. She lives on the times when she drifts into merciful sleep and her dreams welcome her gently, almost as a gift of someone who loves her.

They give her the sun, bright against her blind irises. They give her the softness of a lap over which she rests her head, surrounded by lemongrass smell. They give her the feeling of hands, young like hers too, running across the loops of her head and the roots of her hair. They give her music, the sound of a voice humming to her ears, lullying her even inside their dreams.

Catra has known her since she was six and a child and has held the dream of this girl close to her chest. Six and nine and twelve and fifteen until later, seventeen and still young, she knew she was in love. Hand in hand with prayer and hope.

Catra grows gently, so gently that she doesn't even realize all the things her mother protects her from.

Sometimes, very few times, Io´s sister would visit them at late hours of the night. She always comes perfume and wine smelling, the soft silk of her tunic brushing over the rough ground of the house. Catra cannot see the way her aunt snarls at the humble home but she can still hear the hostility in her voice when she fakes complimenting it.

“She is a bitch,” Catra spats in a mumble under her breath as her mother walks her back to her room.

“C´yra–”

“She is, mom. A manipulator, a, a shadow weaver,” Catra steps inside her room and marches on a straight line towards her bed, a hard square with fresh fabrics covering the sides to keep the bugs from slipping inside. “Every time she comes she makes you sad.”

Io hums, walking inside too. Catra has raised her legs, pressing her knees tight against her chest, her cheek resting over them. It´s a reassuring position, Io knows, one Catra always takes even since she was a child every time she feels too much at once.

“She is still my family,” Io murmurs, leaning to press a kind kiss over Catra´s forehead. “I must do this, even if every once in a while.”

It is not of poor knowledge for neither Io nor even her sister, that Catra has never liked the latter. Catra´s hostility towards her has never come quiet, either by murmuring some backhanded comment to her or by flatley antagonizing her. Which is also why Io asks her to sleep early for the day.

Once the night is much darker around them and the moon is well placed about them, Io prepares the dinner for her sister and makes her offerings properly before turning towards her sister, who is already looking at her with an indescribable expression in her green eyes..

“Why do you insist on living in this rat hole even after all these years?” Io´s sister says, loudly, even though Catra is supposed to be sleeping.

Catra, however, is not quite asleep yet. In fact, she is scrunched near the open entrance of the room, quiet as a bat and holding her breath so she can hear her aunt and her mother speaking in the other room, her breath very slow and her ears sharp.

“Not all of us have the dream of marrying a Magistrate like you have done, Lystra.” Io answers, still in a whisper. She says it kindly but there is an obvious edge in there, as if she were to roll her eyes any moment now. It tears a dry laugh out of Lystra´s chest, clicking her tongue against her sharp teeth. “I am happy here.”

“But you could be so much more,” a hand slamming against the table. Lystra´s voice is grave but sultry, filled with subtle manipulation. “You could have gold and fine clothing and connections. Not dirt and sweat and hard hands. Feel mine, sister, they are bathed with milk and honey and flowers, just as they wash the queen´s hands in Etheria.”

“I´m a weaver, sister. I have always been one. Hard hands are a part of it,” Io takes a small bite of her bread, dunking it on the pressed olives, and a long sip on the wine her sister had brought specifically for her. “You were one too, once.”

“And I hated every single second of that life. You *know* what I had to do to get out of this after our father died and left us with nothing.” The room falls in silence, thick tension falling over both of them. Lystra clears her throat, throwing her thick black hair behind her shoulder. “You don´t understand. My husband speaks of things, changes. He shares the stories right in front of me as I serve him his wine and cheese.”

“What kind of changes?”

“About Etheria and the Empire that is rising in the East.” Lystra shifts her weight on the chair, clicking her mouth. The sound makes Catra´s body recoil. “There are plans already in motion, even now. And when they happen we need to be on the right side to come on top.”

“I don´t stand on anybody's side, sister. I only stand with the gods and with my daughter.” Io says, her voice blank and unmoving as a mountain, making the silence falling between the both of them again. But this time her sister does not wait for Io to start talking again, her silver tongue already moving with venomous words.

“How old is your daughter?”

“Eighteen as of last autumn.” Io shifts on her chair, her voice dropping into a grave tone. Catra is halfway on the halfway back to her room but she is listening, her heart on her throat. “Lystra, be very careful about what you are going to say”

“She is old enough to marry.”

“Sister.”

“Please don´t tell me that you keep believing that the gods have some kind of holy prophecy for her.”

Io holds her breath, speaking through her teeth. “There is a reason why she is blind, why she has those dreams”

“She has those dreams because you have fed into her childhood fantasies,” Lystra sighs in frustration, the table creaking when she leans towards her half sister. This is all so different to her huge household and temples in the village, less marble and more moss and earth. “I know a few families that would take her, ladies whose daughters need a match. And if even then she cannot be controlled then there are plenty of men willing to have a wife who knows how to work. You have made her decent and you need to marry her now that she is young and desirable before her, *limitations,* weight more than her pretty face.”

“That's enough!” Io yells, slamming her hands over the table and standing up.

The outburst makes the entire food and drinks to dunk over the floor, the red wine slipping into the ground. It rips a startled gasp off her sister's throat and it scares Catra to death, who scrambles back to her room in a heartbeat. She had never heard or felt her mother so furious before, not for anything, so the sound of her voice so angry makes her blood rush cold and her body to move on its own.

“Io, by the gods. What has gotten into you?”

“Do not speak of the gods in my house, sister. You have never asked anything pure out of them,” Io barks, almost spitting in the ground. “Send for your horses and your chariot and leave. I want you out right now.”

Lystra slams her hands on the table too, standing in a rush of purple colored fabric. They are so different from each other, red and dark, poppies and mistletoe. Poison in the wine and sourdough. Like this it´s almost palpable the way in which they don´t share the same mother.

“You cannot just kick me out like that! Not after everything I have done for you!” Lystra screams at the tops of her lungs, grabbing a cup and slamming it against the wall until it breaks into dozens of splinters.

But the outburst does not scare Io, not anymore. She is no longer the little sister scared beneath the bed while Lystra screamed at her and tore her clothes apart out of jealousy. She is not the younger maid, standing on the side while her sister married the rich man that at the beginning had been promised to her. She is not the woman falling in love with a god near the river. She is a mother.

“I appreciate the gold you have handled me through the years so I could care for my child but as you said well, she is older now and she does not need your money anymore when she can get it herself. I will not make her an exchange coin just so I can become you.” Io slams her fist against the wood, clenching her teeth until they threaten to break. “I have paid for your philanthropy enough, She doesn´t need you and neither do I. So please, sister, do us both a favor and leave.”

“You will regret this,” Lystra snaps, taking her gold rimmed tunics and her long black hair and her shadows away.

“What I would regret is selling my daughter to you in exchange for the things you call richness.” Io spats on the frame of the door, staring at her sister under the light of the night sky. The river is tumultuous outside and the moon is new. “Leave, weaver.”

Catra makes herself a tight ball underneath her paper thin sheets and presses her eyelids crossed until her head pounds with pain. Until the horses of her aunt´s chariot gallop away.

Catra´s mother falls sick.

It happens slowly, progressively alongside the weeks to come, but once it's done it all happens quickly, so quick that it steals the breath out of their chests.

First it´s the sleepless nights. The long hours where Catra can hear her mother roaming the small house, incapable of falling asleep as she used to, her skin covered in cold sweat and her eyes sunken.

Then comes the weakness, the shivering hands dropping the baskets of crops into the floor and being unable to hold the threads of the loom before they tumble too into the floor. And Io guards it, in secrecy, keeping it away from Catra´s knowledge, but then again Catra has learnt the world in different ways and she can still hear her tired gasp and can still feel the trembling of her mother´s hand inside hers.

Finally, the fever takes over, and with it the madness, the insanity. Io does not recognize her daughter, her skin boiling hot and her eyes clouded in a different way than Catra´s.

She grabs herself to Catra´s hands but does not know who she is talking to, instead repeating over and over under her breath *C´yra, C´yra,* until the words are only sounds. And when she doesn´t call for Catra, she talks about gods and about prophecies and about serpents without eyes and Catra can´t do anything else but to press the damp cloth over her forehead and give her to drink the medical herbs the physician had given them.

“She is too far gone now, child,” the physician had said, still sun smelling, still not a day older even if Catra cannot know that.

Instead she digs her sharp nails inside her own palms and screams at him, curses him out of pain and out of grief because “Why her?” just as Io had asked once, “Why now? Why so quickly?”

“I'm afraid that I cannot answer that,” the physician says and he sounds almost mournful. “Only the Three Sisters can decide now”

Catra cleans her mother's face after they are left alone and leans her own cheeks over Io’s sore chest, hearing the slow best of her heart and the difficulty of her lungs when she breathes.

The dawn of the third day her mother sighs and starts running her fingers through Catra's hair, caressing her soft ears and the back of her neck gently. Catra is only nineteen by now and her mother is awake and aware once again, one more blessing of consciousness before it all fades away.

“Your dreams are important,” Io whispers and she is smiling. Catra knows she is because she knows the sound of her mother's voice when she smiles. “I want you to hold onto them with all your strength and live all of what this life can give you”

“I love you,” Catra whispers because there is nothing else she can or wants to say. “I love you very much, mom”

Catra's mother wakes up at dawn and she dies at midday, under the sun that waves her goodbye.

Catra walks outside, her bare soles meeting the cold winter earth. The crops are already harvested and the fields are bare, void and still as the coldest season passes them by. Catra stands between the river and her home and tilts her head backwards, towards the sky, blinking around the silver light that her eyes catch.

She gives a shuddering breath and then she breaks into pieces, crying so hard and heartbreaking that she thinks she might as well become a whipping spirit herself. She falls into the short grass and curls into herself and cries, just cries, digging her soft and young face against the tender floor and hoping it would swallow her whole.

All around her, even the air seems to change, mirroring her sorrow. The moss she lays in remains soft and fresh with life but everything else dries and dies down immediately. It paints the earth in browns and grays and even though Catra cannot see it she feels it in her fingertips. The cold air ruffling her hair, the sad earth beneath her sorrowful body, the silent scream of the fields at the loss of her mother. It wraps around Catra and the earth and the winter arrives completely.

It is night time when she hears the soft steps of the stranger crossing the fields of her home. After so many years walking to the market together, Catra has come used to the sound of their footsteps. Light, always. Quiet, always. Never a day older somehow.

“My mother is dead,” Catra says, quiet yet loud enough that it sounds like thunder among the silence. She is sitting at the border of the river, where the water damps the fabric of her dress and licks at the skin of her soles covered in mud.

Catra cannot see it, but she knows that the river is just a little more tumultuous tonight. She cannot see them, but she knows the stranger stops a few steps behind Catra and looks at the waters in silence.

“I know,” they say and their voice is still the same yet it sounds worn down. As if it was capable of mourning.

“Will you help me?” Catra asks after a whisper, curling over herself by the way her voice breaks into pieces.

The stranger does not hesitate though, looking at the back of Catra´s head as if she was still ten. “What do you need?”

“I cannot burn her myself.” Catra breaks, letting the tears fall down her face and into the river. “Please”

“Very well”

“And I need you to cut my hair”

“My mother will help.”

Catra prepares her mother. Deo comes too, with the smell of fields and her voice quiet, her tears endless and somehow they seem to make the blooms below their feet die in sorrow. She tries not to cry in front of Catra but Catra knows better, she always has, she can feel the wail of her sorrow in the very air. And with Deo also comes her daughter, pomegranate smelling. And then the mother of the stranger, seafoam daughter.

They help Catra wash her mother and anoint her with oils. And after that is done, they help her dress her and they stand to the side when Catra sits for hours braiding her mother´s hair in a way only she knows how to do. And when all of this is done, they take Catra aside and carry Io to the high bed, mourning her with their pretty voices.

The stranger´s mother stands behind Catra and Catra can hear her holding the handle of the knife between her fingers. Can feel her running the sharp blade right behind Catra´s nape and for one second Catra relishes on how easy it would be for her to run it against Catra´s neck, for Catra to die. Instead, the blade runs right below her ears and snaps off the thick strands one by one, loops of earth color pooling on the floor behind her.

She cuts Catra´s hair very short, curls bouncing against her temples and nape. The air is cold where it brushes against Catra´s newfound bare skin and it feels a different kind of lighter; the one that makes her dizzy instead of easy and that threatens to tumble her into the floor several times as she walks across the length of the rivers.

She does not light the fire nor place her mother's ashes on the grave. She stands on the side, between the river and the earth, barely held from crumbling down by Deo´s hands. Catra doesn´t even wail or scream anymore, too worn out, too devastated. The tears roll down her cheeks on their own, marking dark paths over her dark skin and falling into the ground.

This is a kind of devastation that Catra will never be able to undo from the strings of her heart. She will never be able to be stronger than these sad tears, will never allow herself to not think about this sorrow and not cry in her name. She will always remember her mother in sound and touch and memories; in the things that make Catra who she is, who she has become. And she will always cry for her and miss her in the depths of her heart.

The fire burns until the owls are cooing in the top of the trees and the moon is high in the night sky. Until the dreamworld weeps too and steals the sleep out of everyone in the village and within reach because after all this devastation reaches deeper than this world.

It's cold but Catra does not notice it, running her fingertips over the blank gravestone. Catra does not possess either the money or the family to build her mother a lavish monument so the stone is neither marble nor gold rimmed. She just has this, dug on rich earth.

It´s just stone, raw, polished on the surface and rough on the edges. But it's covered in blooms and moss, somehow already, as if the very earth wanted to mourn her too, to worship her too. The letters of her mother´s name are carved with finesse and precision, as if the finest of sculptors had taken a moment of their life to carve Io´s name on the stone. And somehow, this simple headstone feels holier and richer than any kind of royal temple could ever be.

Catra does not know how this came to be. She doesn´t know yet how she is going to survive this. She loved her mother more than anything in the world and now that she is gone she doesn´t know how to live in this world anymore. And for the first time since she was a child, she curses at her own eyes, who have kept her from looking at her mother's face one last time.

She doesn't speak to the strangers around her but she feels them, their presence, huge around her, moving like a breeze, mingling in her world for one single night until the dark sky gives away to the dawn again. A woman kneels behind Catra and ties a poppy- smelling scarf around her short hair, silently reassuring her.

“C´yra, do not weep, for your mother lays now on the Elysium and she will wait for you. For she is cared there by your father,” the woman says and her voice sounds like a thousand different and just one at the same time. Sweet like the voice of her mother, gentle like the voice that lives in her dreams.

Catra tilts her head to the side, blinking at the bright light that slips everywhere around her. Catra´s mother is gone, taken gently by Thanatos, carried to safety by Caronte on his boat to the eternal fields. She was too young when she was ripped off the world and Catra is too young now too, held to her life by the hope her dreams had gifted her of.

“My dream–” Catra starts, because for some reason she knows that the woman behind her already knows what she is about to ask. Because it is all that Catra has left.

“Go to the Oracle.” She answers, leaning away from Catra. In front of her, next to her, around her. “Little Princess, go to her.”

Catra is only nineteen when she travels beyond the fields of her home and the woods of her village.

Instead, she goes deeper into the forest, her soles bare to learn into the land, her tunic long and well tight around her waist, her mother's fabrics cradling her as she travels into the nothing.

She goes without letting anybody know because in reality she has nobody else, not even the people that call themselves part of her. She does so because after all she is a woman and she is alone in the world, so she is careful.

She goes against the stream of the river because that is what she is told by the stranger's mother. She learns the texture of the mud beneath her feet and eats the wild berries that grow in the edge. She learns the fruits of the orchards and smells the poisonous leaves when she walks around them. She feels the ants and the bug biting on her skin when she bathes on the lakes and blinks at the golden light of the sun and the silver shimmer of the night all around her.

She knots her mother´s himation tight around her shoulder and leans on its warm as she walks for days across the lonely woods, until the sounds of chariots and people leave and all she can hear with her fine ears are the natural murmurs of the forest, breathing alive alongside its creatures.

She stumbles a few times and her tail keeps her balanced when her feet fail her, trusting in herself and her body when the world around her is nothing but clouds and water. She goes on and on with nothing but her own voice to make her company and her short hair beneath the veil and ribbons tangled on her curls.

Catra reaches her destination at the dawn of the fifth day and she knows immediately she is in the right place because the air changes all around her.

The breeze, before warm and calming, stops immediately, stilling even the trees and branches that brush around Catra´s body, freezing them in time. The sounds die down,every single one and one by one, from the birds to the wolves to the snakes, hiding back into their burrows and turning away from the meadow Catra has just stepped into. Even the river, before strong and loud, seems to pale against the weight of this place, departing from Catra´s ears like submerged into its own waters.

Below Catra´s bare soles the mud gives away to moss and then to stone, cold and polished scattered by closed blooms. All around her there are tall stems of fields but they are different to the ones Catra knows, so sweet smelling that it seems almost rotten, making Catra hold her breath.

She does not know where she is, if still in the middle of the woods or stumbling in an abandoned temple or maybe even in the entrance of the underworld where Orpheus lost Eurydice, she does not know.

What she does know, however, is that she is suddenly locked in place. As if the stems and the blooms and the stone itself had tangled around her feet to keep her where she is, making her almost a statue of herself. She feels cold on her limbs and her bones and her very heart, seizing her throat and robbing her of her voice when she feels the need to scream.

She is not scared, she is not afraid to die. But she refuses all the same, the need to fight back against what keeps her in place being stronger than any kind of fear. She has lived through so much, endured so much and still came above it all, she refuses to die so suddenly.

But the cold meadow does not want to kill Catra, instead, it only keeps her in place as, in the middle of the unmovable silence, a new sound starts to echo. The sound of old footsteps approaching Catra.

They carry with them the feeling of warmth, a light candle held on the newcomer's hands, sandalwood smelling and almost scorching hot against Catra´s freezing cold skin.

“C´yra,” an old woman says, her voice worn out with time yet bright. “You have grown”

Catra tilts her head to the side, following the voice. She still holds herself to her tunics like a lifeline, breathing deeply several times before speaking.

"You are the Oracle." Catra says and she knows it is true the moment it stumbles off her mouth.

“I am,” the woman agrees and for a moment she seems to almost want to smile.

“You know my name,” Catra continues, proud that the way does not wave. “What is yours?”

The Oracle hums, low on her throat. She seems to really think about it, granting Catra the dignity of a proper answer.

“I had a name, before.” The Oracle says after a beat, loud in the middle of the silence. “But I ´m afraid that I cannot remember it”

“You don´t know who you are?”

“I know I was a grandmother,” the Oracle walks forward, stepping right in front of Catra. “I know my Mara was a great warrior. But you must understand C´yra, I know quite a lot of stuff and I have been alive for a long time, matters as my own name were never important for the gods´plans”

“It doesn´t seem fair.”

“Things hardly are, dear.”

Catra shifts on her feet, grimacing. Catra knows a great deal of unfairness and of pain. For a while, when she was younger, she did not think that there could be home for more of it, but now that she is older and she still smells like the bonfire that burnt her mother's ashes, she knows sometimes sorrow is inevitable.

“You´ve come to ask about your dreams,” the Oracles says and her voice sounds soft, gentle, yet almost apologetic, as if she was already preparing Catra for heartbreak.

“Yes”

“I´m afraid I cannot tell you where she is,” the Oracle whispers, catching a rebel short curl and tucking it back in place. Her fingertips feel old and warm and they make Catra shiver. “Nor can I tell you how to find her.”

Catra frowns deeply, snapping her head away from the gentle touch.

“So she is real,” Catra snaps but there is no real bite underneath her anger.

She won't admit it outloud, but she is desperate. There is a hunger inside of her, an itch, a kind of quiet desperation that has always been there and that has only become stronger as the years pass her by. What before was tamed, halfway fulfilled by her dreams only, has now become a need, close to breathing or to her heart pumping blood around her body.

She doesn't know why, she does not understand it, she is ignorant to the things that are already happening somewhere in a palace, to the looming tragedy quickly reaching white halls and golden hair, but she can feel it.

She can feel it deep within her chest, she can feel it in her fingertips and her nails. She can feel it in her throat and her lungs and her limbs. The need to run, run, to keep running until her legs burn and her hair becomes a mess; to not stop until she is breathless and in famine, until she can reach the place where her heart so desperately needs her.

She does not understand it but she knows somewhere in this world the flesh and bone of her dreams needs Catra more than ever. And Catra cannot reach her.

“You already know that, C´yra.” The Oracle steps back, her tunics brushing the ground when she turns around to look at the dim light slipping through the thick trees, even if Catra cannot see it. “She is real, she is alive, and she needs you”

“And still you won´t tell me where she is?” Catra snaps, finally moving from the prison the stone has made off her. She walks forwards, stretching her hand and grabbing the sleeve of the Oracle´s tunic. She means to be furious but she is just sad. “Why?”

“Because it's not time yet. What is to happen is not on any of you for now.” The Oracle smells like the meadow; something sweet, borderline rotten, like poppies pressed for too long under the sun. “She awaits for you. Where the sun touches the earth that's where you'll find her."

“What does that even mean?” Catra chuckles, something so close to a sob and so far away to an incredulous laugh that it sounds heartbreaking even to her own ears. She shakes her head, her short hair brushing on her temples, violently running her knuckles over her sore eyes to cast away the incoming tears.

The Oracle must feel something in Catra because she seems to take pity on her desperation, resting her old hand over Catra´s shoulder.

“You´ve just lost your mother and now you fear that you're going to lose her too,” she says as if she could read Catra from the inside out and for a moment Catra has to remind herself that she can. “Allow yourself to mourn for you will need to be strong.”

“So that's it?” Catra snaps her hand away, curling it into a fist until her nails cut open wounds on her palm. Her ears twitch nervously, anger filtering in every single of her bones and inside her heart. “That 's all? I am told to travel miles to find you, you know why I came and all I need to be is *strong?* Fuck you.”

It takes Catra by surprise, the amount of fury swirling inside her chest so suddenly. She wants to grab the Oracle by the shoulders and shake her until she spills the truth out of her mouth;

until she tells Catra exactly what the gods whisper in her ears; until she guides Catra in the right direction.

She wants so suddenly to tear this meadow apart and then herself, scream and scream and scream until she gets an answer of *where? why?* Catra´s mother is dead and all she has is herself and this dream breathing somewhere where Catra cannot touch her.

“It´s not fair,” Catra repeats because she can't help herself, anger melting into sorrow.

“I know, deary.” The Oracle takes a deep breath, holding her hand. “There is a gift, however, for you.”

It makes Catra´s ear twitch, her head raising with newfound attention even though her heart is still tearing itself into pieces. “What kind of gift?”

“What I see,” the Oracle places her wrinkled palm fully against Catra´s blind eyes, pressing on her lilac eyelids with firm pads. “I was once like you are, and I was given another kind of sight in return. I can give some of it to you, if you want it. A glimpse of what is to come.”

Catra´s throat clogs, her heart seizing inside of her chest. She knows that she has been granted something important right now, offered some seed of godly blessing that might help her or curse her for the rest of her life. She has never desired to become someone extraordinary, never possessed the kind of hubris princess and heroes had, yet she knows everything about the consequences of shunning away the gods´s gifts.

She would never want to see what is to come yet, at the same time, maybe this way she could be granted the chance to meet the woman beyond her dreams. Selfishness inside something selfish.

“Whatever you can give me of her, I want it,” Catra says, finally, feeling heavy as stone the second she words it.

“Very well then,” the Oracle whispers under her breath but Catra is already beyond words, white fire burning beyond her eyelids where the Oracle presses her fingers until darkness comes into nothing but light and her voice. “I hear you, stepping among rivers and lakes and stone paths made with cautious hands.”

Catra chokes, the air stolen from her lungs. Her ears start ringing violently and then go completely numb, deaf of every single sound except the ones paying inside her own head, mirrors of the visions inside the Oracle´s head.

“I hear lullabies, I hear tenderness, laughter mingled with honesty. And I hear pain.” Catra whimpers, curling her fingers around the Oracle´s thin wrists. “I hear screams born out of injustice. I smell the fire that comes with it.”

Catra can hear it too, so deeply inside her head that it seems born out of her very soul. Yells, screams, bodies dragged against the mud, hands wrapped around limbs until they bruise. She can feel the scorched fire against her neck and palms, sticking her sweaty hair against the

back of her head. She almost thinks that she can see more but she does not dare to see deeper inside herself.

“I feel a woman like moss, saddened, burdened. Her pain, I feel her ache, her longing. I feel years passing by, love in every strand of changed hair. I feel an exile that feels like paradise. I feel you love and be loved in return.”

Catra gasps, endless tears falling down her face in rivers. If she holds her breath enough, she thinks she can feel it too.

“I see you, even though you cannot see yourself. In the reflection of the river, in the marble stone, in impossible eyes. Waiting under the light. I see her in you even if you cannot rest your eyes in hers.” Catra gasps and all she can feel is infinity and gold and tears. “I see immeasurable love and with it you´ll carry immeasurable grief.”

Catra tumbles down on the floor, catching herself in her palms and her knees. She is trembling so hard that she cannot hear or feel anything else but the hammering of her heart inside her head and her chest.

The Oracle follows her to the ground too, holding Catra through it. After all Catra is still only nineteen, she is barely even an adult, trembling against the hold of the old woman's hands. Her hair is short and her tunics are dark, her mother´s tapestry wrapped around her shoulders like a second skin.

“I am sorry,” the Oracle says but Catra is already shaking her head, cleaning the tears running down her cheeks.

“I don´t want you to apologize,” she says because she has never needed nor wanted anybody ´s pity, not even now. “There is nothing to be sorry for”

“Even if you grieve?”

“It doesn´t matter.” Catra says and she knows it's true the second she says them. She knows too that she is meant to love. “I´ll wait, no matter how long, I´ll wait.”

“Then it will be worth it, little princess”

At night, in the middle of the quiet woods, Catra sits in front of a warm fire.. She rests her fingertips near the flames, far enough that she knows they will not hurt her and just close enough that it bites on her skin like a curious animal.

The cold has lifted from the meadow yet it seems that it has made a home inside catra´s bones, no matter how hard she tries to not tremble against the breeze. Her tunic is wrapped tight against her legs and body and the unknown lightness of her short hair is still strange for her, but she remains as still as possible, sitting among moss and stems and nothing else.

She grabs the last of the salted meat she has left and throws her where she knows the fire burns, immediately smelling the delicious smell of it being burnt and devoured into ashes by the gods that take the time to listen to her.

“I never ask anything of you,” Catra whispers, resting her chin over her bent knees. “I don't even know if you might deem me worthy to be listened to. And it's not fair”

Catra chuckles without real joy on it, running her hand across her face. Her head feels heavy with sleep and her limbs ache where she can barely hold herself awake.

“But my mother trusted you. So if I may, I just have one petition,” Catra tenses, gripping her tunic inside her fists. “Protect her, in any way you can. To whoever is listening, even when you cannot possibly protect her, shelter her.” Catra gasps, feeling herself torn apart. “Let her know she is loved”

She doesn´t know yet how loved she is, by fields and dreams that watch over her. Demeter, Morpheus.

She doesn´t understand yet that no matter how much love, gods are still gods, and gods sometimes like to play games.

She doesn´t know the wheels of destiny are already in movement, tugging from the red string that joins her to her other half.

Catra returns home and she loves the world. She does more than survive, she lives just as her mother taught her to. And she loves her life.

When the winter leaves and the Spring arrives again, Catra works her fields until her hands are raw and her soles are covered in soft earth. She plows and plants; she collects the rain and irrigates until the sprouts caress her fingertips and she knows that they are alive. Until they grow until they reach her waist and she braids them on the short strands of her hair.

She waves on her other´s loom. Catra collects the threads from the errand merchants and sits next to the window of her home, threading images she only sees inside her head, golden suns and skies; the blooms that grew in her window and the maps of constellations she memorized in her childhood.

When she saves enough gold, Catra buys a cart and a horse, who she grows incredibly fond of, and they help her to travel across the woods. It is easier for her, to carry the crops and fruits and vegetables and the rolled up tapestry and only make one trip instead of plenty across the day. It saves her already sore feet from blisters and splinters and she finds herself enjoying it, speaking to her horse as she caresses the sides of his neck and enjoying the sunlight in her skin.

Sometimes the stranger comes along, walking next to the cart and speaking about what kind of birds are flying them by, as if Catra didn´t recognize them all already by sound alone. Yet, as the days go by, she finds herself traveling more and more alone. Even Deo stops coming to the fields at some point, caressing Catra´s cheeks before going away.

Something is happening, already in motion, revolting the pantheon completely. And even if Catra could never understand it, she is somehow in the middle of it all.

In summer she meets another kind of stranger, less graceful and quiet, stumbling on his feet with everything as if he didn´t know how to use the damn things.

Catra halfway through the path towards the village when she hears him, stumbling on the short grass and falling against the earth, probably ungracefully. She hears him curse under his breath even before he hears the walk of the horse and the rolling of the cart´s wheels.

Catra´s ears twitch a little when he takes notice of her and he gasps, fumbling into his feet as fast as he can.

“Excuse me. Excuse me, my lady.” He sounds young, not much older than Catra herself. He also sounds quite winded, as if he had already been walking in circles around the forest for the good part of the last hours.

Catra stops her horse with a soft hush, brushing his thick hair to the side to calm him down as the newcomer approaches them. The last thing she wants right now is for her horse to kick him in the chest for approaching Catra too quickly,

This new stranger is… loud, that's the first thing Catra thinks about him. Everything about him is loud, from his feet where he stomps on the irregular floor, to the twinkling coins attached to his leather sandals and belt and even the rush of the heavy fabric of his chlamys. He is wildly enthusiastic, giveaway from the little whistle he does as he approaches. And he is rich.

Catra can recognize he is definitely wealthy for the clank of the golden coins and the weight of the fabric against the bushes, and for the way he refers to her for the first time. It's not some kind of hyper sense she has developed, even as a magicat, nor a godly power. It's habit, known, learnt from years of listening to the sounds of the village, learnt from hard work and adaptation to the world around her.

Catra tilts her head to the side, brushing an errant curl off her face. Her hair has grown in the months since her mother´s death. It brushes her chin now even if she keeps it wrapped around soft scarfs most of the time.

“You are lost,” Catra says, as a matter of fact, smirking when the stranger trips again and he yelps.

“I am quite lost, yes!” he says, breathless as he finally reaches Catra´s side. “Would you mind showing me the way to the village–? Oh, you are– oh”

He falls quiet in the middle of his sentence, taking a sharp breath.

He is staring, he is definitely staring, Catra can feel it even from where she is over the saddle of her horse. He is looking at Catra´s half opened eyes and she can hear the exact moment when he realizes she is blind by the way he stutters and tangles with his own tongue.

Catra has encountered a great deal of people in her young life, and she has experienced almost all the possible outcomes of someone realizing that her sight is different. From the most understanding to the most pitiful to even the rudest; she has dealt with it all.

“I– I– oh, shit”

For some reason, the way the young man in front of her trips with himself and doesn't even seem to know if to apologize or say anything else makes Catra smirk with amusement.

“I might be blind, but between you and me who was the one walking in circles again?” Catra says with a small cheer in her voice.

Any other disgustingly rich person would probably have exploded at Catra´s mocking words. Flipped over and screamed at her or insulted her for her nerve of speaking like that to someone above her position. The young man, however, seems to take a second to register Catra´s words and then he is snorting, choking on his own breath as he starts laughing.

“True. I am sorry, my lady, I was just caught off guard,” There are tiny coins also held in the young man´s hair, Catra can hear them when he runs his fingers through the strands.. “I apologize if I was rude”

“You weren´t.” Catra shakes her shoulders, resting her forearms over the neck of her horse. “Want me to guide you to the village then?”

“Yes please,” he says, sighing in relief at Catra´s offering.

“Do you have a horse?”

“I do!”

Catra waits for a second, then another, patiently waiting for the young lord´s brain to start working again.

“Well then?” She asks after a full minute goes by and he doesn´t seem to have moved at all. “The market won´t wait for us.”

“Oh! Shit, sure!”

Catra hums as she hears him rushing around the irregular terrain again, whistling to his own horse to get near. He talks to his horse kindly too, just like Catra does with hers, and by the easy gallope of the animal approaching Catra again she knows the animal is well taken care off, neighing pleasantly when they meet Catra´s own horse with a small huff.

“Alright then, follow close. And be careful where you guide your horse to step in, the earth can get softer near the river.”

Catra cooes at her horse to start walking again, following an easy going and pleasant march across the woods. The young man follows right next to Catra´s side, breathing easy now that he is not following his own steps across the woods.

“I apologize again if my reaction was rude,” he says after a few minutes, shifting nervously over his own saddle. He is close to Catra but he keeps himself respectfully aside. “It does not excuse me. It's just– I have met plenty of people before and not even half of them are as capable of their own lives as you seem to be.”

Catra chuckles, shaking her head softly. She is usually immediately annoyed by all men alike but the presence of this one is easy to handle, and he sounds as if he truly couldn´t contain his verbal vomit around Catra.

“I hardly think that riding a horse through the forest and carrying items to the market are great odysseys. But thank you, I guess.”

“Oh, I didn´t– I didn´t meant to sound condescendant–”

“Gods, breath, You are more nervous than a loose goat.” Catra chuckles, grinning broadly. “I understand what you are trying to say. You should try to learn a little more about people beyond your household, lord. You might be surprised about those of us that you might encounter outside your high halls. There are so many people out here. People with soul, with colors, with flavor; you might even find yourself being more similar to us than what you think. ”

The young man seems to have been left stunt, holding his breath as the coins of his clothes twinkle with the summer breeze.

“You are right,” he says, almost to himself. “That's very good advice.”

“Of course it is.”

Catra rolls her eyes a little, squinting at the bright daylight when it makes her temples ache. She can distinguish some forms of shadows and movement, especially in broad daylight. But even then the muscles of her eyelids have grown unused from keeping themselves open the whole time and she needs several minutes to rest them closed, especially if she already knows where to go.

“May I ask how did you know I'm from a high household?” He asks after a few moments of walking in easy going silence. Catra shrugs, tilting her head towards the place where she knows he is riding.

“You smell like oils,” she points out, wrinkling her nose at the strong orange smell coming from his skin and clothes. “Houses like yours tend to smell very similar to one another. I know the woman that sells the oils at the village. She has taught me a few things about oils and perfumes.”

“I hadn't noticed that before.” Catra listens as the young man gives a huge and loud sniff and she has to hold her own laughter when she realizes he must be sniffing himself. “Is it annoying?”

“Is not bad but only the high lords smell like that”

“Have you met plenty?”

“A few.” Catra points behind her, towards the cart. She always organizes the cart the same way, crops neatly tied together in the front, fruits and vegetables in the right, her bundled

tapestries to the left. With time she has forgotten how certain things look like, but organization and touch help her. “They buy my tapestries at the market.”

“Really?” He sounds obviously curious, the fabric of his clothes brushing close to Catra´s forearms when he leans to take a peek to the inside of the cart.

“You can look if you wish.” Catra grants him permission, waving her hand loosely towards the cart.

She hears the slow gallope of his horse coming to a soft stop. He grunts a little as he reaches for the side of the chart as the same time he tries not to fall off the horse and into his face again. He gives a small cheer at some point and Catra supposes he has managed to grasp one of the soft tapestries because holds his breath sharply.

“This is magnificent,” he murmurs, loud over the sound of the birds chirping happily above their heads. “Is this, is this your doing? You make the tapestries?”

“I do,” Catra follows the sound of his voice with ease, pulling from the laces of her tunic in a reassuring motion. “I might not be able to see as I did before, but I remember the motions and the placement of the threads. My mother taught me before she died.”

The man hums softly, his voice falling into an apologetic tune, honest before anything else.

“I am sorry for your loss,” he says, whistling at his horse to get back in motion. “She must have been an extraordinary woman”

“She was.” Catra whispers, unable to hold back the heartbreak inside her chest.

“Your works seem familiar to me,” he says after a moment, gently trying to ease the conversation, something Catra appreciates even though he does not know her even close enough to know the amount of sorrow inside of Catra.

“They might be. The people I sell them to are from the royal palace. They take them to Eternia.” She is barely speaking when she hears him choke with his own breath, a marveled expression stumbling off his mouth. Catra wiggles nervously, all of her senses suddenly in high alert. “Is something the matter?”

“You´re the weaver that makes the tapestries for the princess,” his voice is full of wonder, so painfully honest in his awe for Catra´s work that she is left stunned for a second.

“I– I didn´t know they were taken to her”

“They are,” he says, his voice suddenly wandering miles away from where they are riding in the woods. “I´ve seen them before”

Catra does not comment on the fact that the sentence might mean that the stranger either knows the Princess personally or might have been one of the multiple hands through which the tapestries passed through before reaching its final destination.

But whichever it is, Catra cannot help the sting of pride that rises inside of her at the knowledge that her work is appreciated in higher places. She is proud of the work she does, she is infinitely proud of the art her mother taught her. She is proud of being the waver of a village and creating art in the way she sees and feels things.

She feels the sun warming her cheeks and the texture of her horse's hair beneath her fingers and she is proud of herself.

“This place is beautiful.”

“It is,” Catra agrees, turning in the angle of the river where the sounds of the village start to become louder. “Even beyond what you can see, it's beautiful”

“I'm glad the Empire has not reached Menagerie yet,” he comments, his voice filled with some kind of layered anger and resentment that catches Catra by surprise. “The Horde and his Emperor seem determined to destroy everything beautiful in this kingdom.”

Catra chews the inside of her cheeks, frowning. She thinks her words well, guiding her horse and her newfound companion´s towards the limits of the woods and the entrance of the market. It has grown in the last ten years since the first time Catra came alone, buzzing with sounds and smells and people even at the early hours of the day.

“There will always be fucking imbeciles out there,” she spits, getting a surprised chuckle in return. “There will always exist people that will call themselves heroes to satisfy their hubris, no matter who they hurt or how much damage they do. They will always think they deserve everything for power or gold of godly divinity. That they can take whatever or whoever they want and no one will stop them.” Catra says, calling for his attention again. “I guess, at the end of the day, it's on us to stand up for what we believe, even if we are alone.”

Silence falls between them but it's not void anymore, filled by the sounds of the market now directly in front of them. Delicious smells and merchants' calls rise twice as high, making Catra´s ears twitch uncomfortably at the sides of her head, already overwhelming.

“Are you sure you're not from royal crib?” The young man asks, his voice in awe.

“I am not,” Catra answers, smiling again.

“Then how do you speak about life like this? With so much fire and wisdom?”

“Well, because I am a woman.”

Catra stops her horse and charts at the entrance of the market. From here, she knows that the young man will take no time on singing one of the guards placed around the square to take him to whichever rich house he is to stay over.

Catra clicks her tongue against her teeth and hums, pointing at the source of the sound with her head.

“This is the market. If you ever get lost again, follow the stream of the river, it will guide you where you need to go.” Catra hums, calming her horse with the back of her knuckles. “And

be careful what kind of strangers you ask for help next time. I could have mugged you at least twice."

"Of course. Thank you very much, my lady." The young man's horse gallops softly next to Catra's, his orange smell hitting her nose fully. "I'm Adam, by the way"

There is another moment of silence where neither of them speak and it does not take Catra much longer to understand what might be going on.

She smiles, an evil grin split her face from ear to ear, making even her tail to flick amused behind her.

"If you're holding your hand out so I can take it, you need to tell me"

"Oh shit"

"Because I'm blind"

"Bollocks, I'm sorry"

Catra's grin falls into a loud laugh, barely holding herself on her horse by practice alone. She had not laughed this honestly in months, not since her mother's death, and it feels good. To laugh again, it feels good.

"I´m C´yra," she finally manages between giggles.

Adam huffs, mildly annoyed and all kinds of amused too. "It´s good to know you, C´yra"

"Of course it is. If you excuse me now, your lordship, I have a long day of work to go. I trust you won't get lost on your way to the square."

"I'll do my best." Catra is already motioning her horse forward when Adam calls for her again. "Lady C´yra?"

"Yes?"

"I´d like to know more about the people outside my halls," he says, twinkling his coin belt a little and somewhere inside Catra's head she realizes he is doing it so she can know he is to her right. "Could you maybe help me sometime?"

"I guess I can try." Catra worries her lip between her front teeth, frowning. "But you'll have to see things my way"

"I´d like that"

"Sure. Whatever, then." Catra shrugs, wrinkling her nose at the progressively more alive market. "Goodbye, Adam."

"Goodbye, lady C'yra"

Adam watches her go with a smirk plastered on his mouth. Her cart is full and her black horse is calm as it gallops through known paths of the market, taking her where it needs to.

There is something in her that is familiar to Adam, something he cannot quite place. Maybe it is the way in which she holds herself, graceful and strong through life; maybe it is in the way she speaks so fiercely, as if she knew something about life that nobody else did.

Maybe it's the way her tapestries hang on the walls of his palace yet she lives on the rivers. Or in the way in which she smiles or the proud shake of her shoulder or the cheeky edge of her jokes.

She reminds Adam of his sister, that's it, still trapped in the high walls of Eternia. Somewhere inside of him tells him there is something important there, in the familiarity of these women.

“Your Highness!” A guard of the village has finally taken notice of the Prince and rushed next to him, out of breath, Adam glances at him sideways, still following C´yra as she makes her way through the market, whispering hello to the people she crosses by.

“Yes. Yes that´s me, I guess.” Adam sighs, pinching the bridge of his nose. His presence here is a known secret, but he has yet to know just how much of the truth behind it is known by the Lord of the village.

“The Magistrate and his wife await for you in their household,” The guard says, straightening his back once Adam turns towards him completely.

It was nice, to believe for a second that he was nos a prince anymore but somebody else, just someone else riding on the woods next to the river, meeting a stranger along the way. He sees the busy market and the limits of the woods, this patch of land of his kingdom that has not been tampered with fake light yet. And he thinks that, maybe, this village would be a wonderful place for his sister and him to live.

“Alright. Guide me there.”

Catra manages her life in the very same way she has always done.

Wake up before the light of the sun tickles on her eyelids, bathe, fix her short curls beneath her scarf. She tends to her fields and wrinkles her nose at the sun burning newfound freckles on her skin.

She feeds her horse and speaks to him the whole time she carries her crops and tapestries in the cart and travels across the woods. She no longer needs thread to know where she is going but she still ties bells on the branches of trees to accompany her way there, helping her place the things around her.

Some things, however, become different.

She starts crossing paths with a different kind of stranger to the one she had met years ago. Instead of fluttering feet and comfortable silence, Adam is loud; he trips with everything,

even his own sandals, and he talks until he either can´t breath or the market drowns down his stories.

He speaks about the birds and the bushes and the river, asking Catra questions about it all and drinking on her responses with new questions. He is like a little kid sometimes, Catra thinks more than once, being excited and amazed about everything and speaking about it to Catra right after. About the market´s foods and the boring meeting and just how dull the Magistrate and his wife are and Catra doesn´t even mention once that she is her aunt yet he seems to dislike the woman all the same.

He never treats Catra differently nor makes her feel as such. It does not come natural to him and more than once he catches himself pointing at stuff and referring them to Catra before correcting himself. And Catra finds herself actually laughing and making fun of him because of it instead of feeling annoyed or offended. It´s nice.

For Catra, who was always an only child, it is nice this newfound feeling. A mildly annoying stranger becoming an honest friend..

Catra teaches Adam about work, honest and happy. He never tells her which household he belongs to and Catra never asks, but she also never really finds it in herself to care. She knows he is a rich person immediately but instead of being uptight and rude, she also realizes that he is down to earth and kind.

He learns his way across the market and every single time he finds something new he rushes to her spot immediately after. He dips his legs inside the river until the water and the mud reach his waist and fishes there, learning the way the mud moves when the banks of fish are closer, things Catra has learnt with time too. He does not care about stained clothes of the coins of his sandals and belt to fall and get themselves lost.

After a while, he tags alone on Catra´s fields too, when she allows him to. He follows Catra´s cart on foot and describes to her the feathers of a robin nuzzling in her tunic.

He meets Catra´s patch of land, the place that was once her mother´s and now it's hers, with the blooming crops and the noisy river. He doesn´t even complain when Catra places a sickle on her hands and teaches him what is time to harvest and how.

He comes every day from dawn to mid morning and almost every evening after before rushing off to wherever lordship he takes his meals with. Catra learns the embroidery of his cape and the crevices of the coins in his earrings and Adam plows, plants and harvests too.

He drenches himself in sweat alongside Catra and whistles across the fields. He grows calluses on hands and feet and slips into the mud of the river and somehow the winds and the earth seem to be pleased that he is there, carrying things and helping Catra untangle the yarns of her tapestries, As if it was meant to be for them to arrive to Catra´s home.

“Are you completely blind?” Adam asks just once, sitting on the fine grass in front of Catra´s window.

“No,” Catra frowns, pulling from the threads of her loom carefully. “I can distinguish movement and some shadows. The change of light, the set and rise of the sun. I never saw things like you, not even as a child, so I learnt about the world in a different way.”

Adam hums, shifting next to Catra. He seems to have submerged himself so deeply in thought that he starts mumbling something unintelligible under his breath, trying to find his words to not be rude when he asks.

Catra huffs, swinging her yarn slightly to the side, where it connects soft but swift right on the back of his head.

“I don't need eyes to look at the stupid look in your face, tho.”

“Oh, very funny,” he mocks, shoving Catra´s arm playfully to the side. He falls into silence again but this time is shorter, considering his words one more time before asking. “Have you ever wanted to… you know, see?”

This time Catra does stop. She lowers the thread and remains still, blinking slowly at the light that comes dim inside the room from the fabrics hanging over the window.

“Of course I have.”

“Really?”

“Yes,” Catra sighs, pinching the side of her temples where the headache always starts. “I have learnt to live with what has happened to me, Adam, and I am content with my life, but that doesn't mean I don't wish for more sometimes. I am human, and I'm ambitious.”

“Aren't we all?” Adams shifts closer, dragging his stool closer to Catra's. He still smells like rich oils but there is a stain of grass somewhere in there too. “Is there anything you wish you could have seen?”

“Yes,” Catra runs her fingertips over the half woven tapestry. “My mother's face. My home, the river, the bloom of the apple tree and the dawn”

The shape of gentle hands and the dimple of a smile, Catra thinks but she does not say it. After all, her dreams are sacred, a gentle secret that she feels might fly away if she shares it from the confiments of her mind, even for a second.

“But this is my life, Adam. And I have learnt the world in ways others never will. I am not fixable because there is nothing wrong with me. So I'll be alright.”

Adam's mind is somewhere else too, still listening to Catra but not quite entirely present. He is closer to Catra's thoughts and dreams than any of them know, but only the gods peeking down on them know that.

“Are you sure you're just a mortal?” Adam asks after a moment, drumming his fingers over the wood of the loom, a noisy signal that he is leaning closer. “Because that thing you're weaving is breathtaking”

Catra chuckles, feeling the bumps and crevices of the woven threads, a small gentleness her mother taught her and now she does for herself. Being able to see her work even without her eyes.

“Do you know what it is?”

“Constellations,” Adam says immediately, proud of himself. “Don't ask me which ones, but someone I hold very dear is obsessed with them.”

“Very good,” Catra nods, taking the threads on her fingers and returning to her work in the shroud.

Spring passes them by and then summer, sticky warm and heavy air in the sky. Catra´s hair grows too, reaching from below her ears to her chin and the start of her neck, still carefully wrapped inside her veils and scarves.

She does not notice it fully but Adam grows too. His voice gets deeper and his hands much more calloused. His clothes loosen, from expensive fabrics and twinkling coins on his belt and hair to something simpler, cotton between Catra´s fingertips and leather sandals and belt.

He still smells like oils and he still laughs loud but Catra comes to be used to him. In the same way Deo is, and the stranger, and her mother, even if Catra does not have them like before.

For some reason, she has been given a friend.

“I'm a twin,” Adam says one evening, splayed over the grass of the fields with the sun washing completely over him.

Catra huffs, tilting her head to the side to follow the sound of Adam's voice. “Gods, are there two of you?”

“Yes.” Adam laughs but it falls flat after a second, his mind wandering somewhere else. “My sister is still in Eternia, with my parents.”

Catra knows a lot about hidden sorrow. Her mother never made her carry with the burdens and sadness that fell into her, not even in her bedrest, but Catra was always able to hear them in the tremble of her voice.

“You speak of her as if it made you sad.” She points out, catching the way Adam takes a sharp breath.

“I feel like I'm failing her,” he admits, his voice so heavy and so full of some underlying hatred that it takes Catra by surprise. “She is on her own there. And I can´t do anything for her.”

Catra hums, closing her eyes at the light. She hears the tranquility of the woods all around her; the smell of fresh grass and the chirp of birds fishing for food on the loud river. Things she knows from childhood and that have given her peace and protection her whole life.

“Then bring her here.”

It takes a beat, Catra´s words making sense inside Adam´s head. When he speaks next, he sounds almost vulnerable.

“What?”

“Bring her here, to Menagerie,” Catra repeats, shrugging.

As if it was the easiest thing in the world, to walk away from the place that harms you and find your real home far away. Maybe it is.

“And if they chase her?”

“Then just get lost in the woods,” Catra stretches her hand to the side, searching and finding one of the locks of Adam´s hair and pulling from it playfully. “And follow the river to get home.”

Catra loves him. In the way a sister loves a brother, fraternal. In the way Adam loves his sister, who he always speaks about but Catra does not know the name of. In the way he loves Catra back.

He is her best friend, he becomes it, he becomes deserving of Catra´s trust by pulse. He treats Catra as an equal and as someone worthy of respect and Catra starts holding him dear to her heart too.

There is something familiar in him too, something Catra cannot quite place yet she knows like she knows every single place of her land and the paths that guide her there. Like she knows the sounds of her dreams.

And it´s stranger, different but not unwelcome. As if Adam was a path himself guiding Catra where she is supposed to be. And Catra prays at night.

“I met someone,” Adam drops one evening, eating pretty loudly the bread dipped in olives that Catra had handed him. One of those weird nights where he has been able to escape the claws of the high lord of the village and his wife and has snuck here instead.

Catra´s eyebrows rise on her forehead, softly dipping her fingers inside her cup so she can feel the exact height where to serve her wine.

“Congratulations,” she says, sly and already falling into gentle teasing. “Who's the lucky winner?”

“Teela.” Catra hears Adam shifting on his own spot, “She is…”

“The fisherman's daughter, I've met her.” She has, a few times across the market from the moment Catra started to go to the village on her own. She smells like fresh cut grass and sea. “She is strong”

“She is”

“And a great singer”

“I´ve heard her”

“A skillful huntress”

“Yes.” And Adam says it around an exhale, like daydreaming.

“Hmm,” Catra smiles, resting her cheek against her palm. “Summer is coming to an end sooner or later.”

“What do you mean?”

“I mean, that if you'd like to ask for her hand, your moment is now.” Adam drops his plate into the floor, all the contents rolling loudly around them. It makes Adam curse loudly under his breath and Catra laughs out loud, enjoying his embarrassment more than she should. “Come on, don´t be shy.”

“I didn´t say– I didn´t mean–”

“I know what you meant, dumbass. I´m teasing you,” Catra interrupts him, pushing him softly with her foot. “You admire her and you love her, don´t you?”

“I– yes,” Adam sighs, giving in. “But I´ve just been here for a few months”

“So? Sometimes the Fates play with our red strings.” Catra lingers her own palm over her chest, pressing her fingers in the flesh there as if it were to split her heart open and pour the woman of her dreams in the middle of the room. “We could very well be taken by Thanatos tonight, or tomorrow or the next day. If you´ve found her, why wait more?”

Adam is quiet, breathing very slowly as he listens to Catra speak.

“She spoke highly of you too. Teela,” he says after a few minutes, his voice falling into something sweet. “She said you defended her when father was away at the sea and the wife of the Magistrate wanted her to marry a general. She said you took a slap on the face for her, that they could have very well executed you but you didn´t step back. She said you saved her.”

Catra bites into her lip nervously, shifting on her place. “Yeah, well, I have never quite cared for anything Lystra Spinner might want or say. It wasn't a big deal.”

Very carefully, Adam taps on the outside of her wrist with his finger, asking for silent permission. Catra turns her hand around immediately, allowing him to wrap his hand on hers and squeeze it softly.

“Thank you,” he says, and it's honest. “For standing for her, *with* her. Thank you.”

Lately, he smells more like grass and river water than oils.

He helps Catra with the last harvest of summer. They meet the night right before the full moon and collect the sweet and full crops, tying them tightly with thread strings, saving the seeds on their baskets and thanking the earth for another year of rich crop, honey and milk.

Catra is calmingly running the blade of her sickle across the firm stems when Adam's voice calls for her attention, suddenly very close to her.

“Catra”

Catra's ear flicks towards him, acknowledging him with a small tilt of the head. “Yeah, that´s my name”

This time though, Adam does not chuckle at the jab. Instead he takes several deep breaths, making Catra's fine skin stand on point.

“You´re– you're in the marriage age now, aren't you?”

Everything stops for Catra, her head suddenly coming to a complete stop. Tense silence falls between them in the middle of the wheat fields, the river's waters become violent suddenly.

Catra turns around without thinking twice, swinging her sickle towards the place where she knows Adam stands, somehow just close enough to brush the long strands of his hair without coming to open his throat at all.

“If this is what all of this has been about then–”

“Oh, no! No, no! Not to me!” Adam hurries to say, not getting closer but still in a rush, his words tumbling with each other. “Not to me, at all! Please let me explain. I swear!”

Catra grunts, grumbling under her breath without letting go from the sickle. “Explain then”

Adam exhales, quickly holding himself to the relief that Catra is not cutting his head yet.

“I want you to meet my sister”

Catra blinks, spots of light dancing beyond her irises. She falls into a frown immediately after, baring her teeth and snarling with confusion.

“Your twin”

“Yes!”

“Your sister”

“Don´t have any other”

“Your sister that lives in Etheria”

“That's the one!”

Catra exhales, letting her arm fall next to her hip. She takes a deep breath several times, controlling the sudden rapid beat of her heart. “Why?”

“Because you're a fucking brat,” Adam spats, giggling nervously. “And you're loyal and strong and loving. You hold your morals high and you're not afraid of speaking up.”

Warmth crawls over Catra's cheeks, her fingers finally relaxing from their deathgrip on the harvest knife. She hears Adam sigh in front of her. He clears his throat after a beat, shifting on his feet nervously, crushing the dry leaves below his sandals.

“There is something in you, something that reminds me of her. Rebellion, anger to live.” Adam whispers. “You're going to bonk heads with my sister and she is going to adore you to pieces,” he says as if it was a secret that made him deeply happy. “And I'm afraid she is quite easy to fall in love with.”

Catra holds her breath, her throat clogging suddenly. Her first instinct is to deny him, to curl inside herself and inside her home and close the door, to ask to be left alone.

But her heart slamming inside her heart is so much stronger than fear, screaming at her to allow herself to meet her home. Something inside of her is begging her to accept, to give the step forward, and from somewhere beyond her closed eyelids she can see spots of light, so bright that are like newborn suns inside her clouded eyes.

“Alright,” Catra exhales, pressing her palm firmly over her chest. “Alright.”

Adam hums, very gently placing his palm over her shoulder. Catra gives the step forward, allowing him to wrap his hands falling around her shoulders and squeezing reassuringly.

“I'm going to bring her with me, like you said.” He sounds happy, hopeful. As if he had somehow found the light too. “I´m to visit my parents this weekend for the Fall Harvest and after that I will bring her with me.”

“Alright”

“And I need you to promise me one thing.” It´s strange, Catra has never told Adam what she dreams; she has never spoken about it with anybody else, not since her mother, not since the Oracle. Yet Adam seems to already know. “I need you to love her as strongly as you possibly can. And allow her to love you too.”

He leaves the next evening.

He comes in the same horse as the first day and he doesn´t get lost this time. He finds his way across the trees and the red threads and follows the stream of the river until he reaches the bare fields of Catra´s land and her home, his clothes making a soft sound when he climbs down and approaches where Catra is already waiting.

Catra tilts her head to hear the sound of the calm river and the huff of the horse and Adam catches a single strand of her hair between his fingers, pulling from the curl that brushes her collarbones softly.

“Take this,” he whispers, clasping a twinkling trinket to the shoulder of her tunic.

Catra´s ears twitch with curiosity, running her fingers over the rise and crevices of the soft metal, feeling it's warm touch against her skin as she recognizes the carefully carved shape.

“Wings”

“It's the crest of my family,” Adam explains, “My sister and I grew up on our own our whole life, so I never knew friendship from someone else without some underlying greed behind it. But you don´t give a fuck about any of it.” Catra chuckles, wet with tears; Adam giggles too. “You´ve become my best friend, so if you ever need anything this will help you. Everyone will know that you´re one of us.”

“I don´t care for people to think I´m some noble lady,” Catra grunts under her breath but even for her it sounds shaky in the edges.

“I know,” Adam agrees, his voice heavy, “But the world can be very cruel if they think you ´re alone.”

Adam hugs her, full chest with his arms around Catra´s shoulders. He doesn´t even ask for permission this time, but Catra does not mind, not this once. She too wraps her arms around Adam's shoulder blades and nuzzles her nose against his pulse point, unable to hold a sniff.

“What are you thinking about?” Adam asks her under his breath, petting the rebellious curls of her nape. Lately he carries with him the scent of autumn sweat and wheat, no longer lingering to the soulless oils with which he arrived first.

“You smell awful,” Catra mutters and she grins. She can physically feel Adam´s grin against her temples in return.

“Finally”

She will never meet him ever again.

The night of the Harvest Festival, Catra tosses and turns in her sleep. She fights against unknown forces, choking her down and making her afraid, holding her like a prisoner inside the once safety of her own dreams.

Tonight, as she closes her eyes and walks inside her dreams there is no light to follow behind. Tonight, she meets real darkness, for the first time in her life. Heavy, merciless, terrifying darkness.

She rushes among thick fog that grasps at the fabric of her tunic and sandals, pulling from her hair and scratching at her skin when she crosses them.

Her bare soles are silent, not a single sound rising from her chase around darkness, nothing for her to hear and touch and it is all so overwhelmingly frightening that by the time the first scream comes Catra is already ripping the dream into pieces.

The sun is screaming, Catra´s light is screaming inside her dreams, oh so different to the lullabies she has come to know by heart. So full of indescribable terror that Catra gasps by the sheer weight of it. Her scalp is burning too, heated and aching like poured with poison.

“ *What's happening?”* Catra whispers inside her dreams and this is the first time she has truly spoken out loud, echoing in the dream world and in the real land. “ *What-?”*

“Take it off!” The sun screams and it sounds so far away it's close; so near that is far. *“Take it off, please!”*

“What's happening?!” Catra screams again, pulling off the curls of her hair, searching among her darkness. And she has never once cursed her eyes but now she does, keeping her away. *“Sweetheart”*

“C´yra,” someone is saying, wrapping invisible fingers over her eyes, holding her back. “ *Wake up”*

“What–?”

“This is the reason. You must not see this,” her father whispers, pulling her back from the dream. *“Wake up”*

“No.”

Catra fights. She fights the invisible touch holding her back, she pushes against the dreams, stretches her arms forward and searches for the light among the darkness but she is being torn apart, away. She fights the voice, the screams, the very dream, digging her nails on nothing and dissolving herself into fog.

No matter how hard she tries, she cannot reach her light again, pulling them apart by godly hands.

“Wake up”

In this part of the world, in the calm edge of her lonely Menagerie home, Catra´s warm body jolts awake from the touch of Morpheus. Her dark hair falls over her face in loops, her breathing confused and scared by dreams too real and cruel to truly remember, her heart aching with the quiet tears that fall down her sightless eyes.

She is alone here but not really, guarded in silence and without knowing it by Eros, a god mournfully sitting at the frame of her window. Held quietly in the strands of her mind by her father. The mournful walk of Demeter and her daughter walking on her fields.

Even among the tragedy, they are still watched over by someone, but it doesn't really matter anymore. What is done is done, and Catra will never be able to dream ever again.

She presses her palm against her fast chest, curls over herself and cries.

Catra cries for hours, days, so many that it feels as if she were made out of tears. As if she had been turned into something sad, something burdened, perpetually mourning the

unknown.

She cries until her head is pounding and her hair feels like it will fall against the earth. Until her eyes ache as if poisoned by ichor and everything in herself, inside of her, is confused and filled with tragedy. Until she has to force herself to sleep because every time she closes her eyes she finds nothing there. No light, no tenderness, no hope. Just darkness and silent, overwhelming void.

She cries and she prays. She tears the house upside down and dips her legs into the river´s mud. She throws herself to her knees and burns the land into fire and throws into it the food, the meat, the fig, the beautiful tapestries that she didn't get to finish and never will.

“What did you do?” she screams, digging her sharp nails against her scalp. “What did you do?!”

She cries and prays and screams until she grabs the knife and runs it herself against her hair and throws it into the blazing pile, giving them to her offering and begging to the pantheon to listen in return.

This time, however, who comes to see her is not godly but mortal and carries the same sorrow as her.

Catra is already outside when the cart stops in front of her home. She is sitting on the cold floor next to the extinguished fire, covered in ashes from her hair to her toes. She can feel it, sticking its touch and smell to the skin of her cheeks and her fingers.

And for a moment, as the newcomer jumps off the cart and into the floor, Catra is suddenly hopeful, overwhelmed with the hope that she had been heard after all. But as the footsteps approach her quickly she realizes they are foreign to her, lighter and new in her home.

“Who are you?” Catra asks, standing in precarious bare feet. The newcomer stops, holding their breath so painfully tight that it makes Catra´s chest ache.

“I– I am Teela,” she says in front of Catra. She smells a little bit like salt and fields, so much like Adam smelled like, that Catra´s head swings with recognition.

“Yes, I remember you”

“I´ve come–” Teela stops herself, choking on her words. She sounds winded beyond the exhaustion of the travel. She sounds desperate, broken, her voice raw and sore. Catra wonders if that's how she sounds too. “Adam never came back”

“I know”

“Did he tell you something or–?” Teela sounds hopeful, holding herself to the last strands of her hope. She smells like salt because she is crying.

“He was going to be back after the Harvest. He was going to come back with–” Catra chokes, unable to continue.

She cannot say it, she cannot put the thought into her tongue and her tongue into the world because then it would be real. And if it becomes real then she doesn´t know how she will survive.

“Adam asked for my hand,” Teela whispers, as if she would only tell Catra, as if there was nobody else but them now.

“I know,” Catra nods, gripping her tunic inside her fists. “I´m sorry”

“He is dead,” Teela spats, crude, doing what Catra is afraid to. Splitting both of their hearts open like a wound. “Both of them. They are gone.”

“You don´t–”

“I know. I feel it in my heart.” Teela is now right in front of Catra, placing her cold hand over Catra´s. their tears drop over their skins, full of ashes. “You know it too”

Autumn passed and Adam never came back. A month after that, the kingdom fell.

And then, there was war.

The war consumes it all faster than it ever took to build it. It runs across the entire kingdom like a sickness, like an uncontrollable fire, eating it all up until there is nothing else to devour.

The cities become strategist points and the villages become prey, casualties of battle, places where the warriors that once swore to keep the peace crash into to drink dry the wines and consume the bread of everyone else.

Markets cease to exist and the people that once were merchants, artists, musicians, bakers and weavers turn into blacksmiths, into armor makers and fabric sewers, dressing the soldiers with precious metals and heavy fabrics and cheering them goodbye when they part to slay the enemies that once were her neighbors.

Daughters are married away to warriors, exchanged for pocket money or for a chance to survive, it's the same. Some become priestesses, like Teela, retreating to empty temples in the forests where they are never found again by the hand of men. But those who do not possess the same luck leave the side of the parents and families and walk behind the caravans of bloodthirsty warriors.

The warm breeze turns freezing cold and the skies bleed into red, coated by unfair blood. The pires that once asked for mercy and for greed to the gods are destroyed, broken into pieces and replaced by other kinds of altars, ones that praise to a single man calling himself a savior, a god himself, an emperor. As if he and the gods were not the same, as if they didn't play with the soul game coins.

There is war in Olympus, there is war on the earth.

Etheria chokes itself in five years of war and because the gods can be as terrifying and unjust as men, so full of grudge and anger and jealousy, alongside the war also comes the cold and

the famine and with it the hunger and the hate.

The crops of Menagerie start to die. The earth blackens and the blooms dry out, curling over themselves empty and withered before there is even time to save them. Demeter curses the land; she digs her root fingers on the moss and against the bark of the trees and kills it all, fruit or crop the same, eternal winter arriving with her.

Helios burns the dry grass and the cattle dies, one by one, plagued, starved, sucked dry. They fall onto their sides and turn muscle to bone, vultures and villages sucking on the broken femur for a single taste of fat. Rotten, unfulfilling.

The river empties; its crystalline and clean waters run thick and acid like blood and when it poisons every single well and lake and the very clouds, it goes dry. When the villagers and the soldiers step into the bottom, they find nothing but rocks and dry roots, not even mud left for them to smear on their blistered skins.

In the kingdom, it is said that the plagues are a curse from the gods for abandoning them. In the battlefields scattered with blood and tapestries of war with pink and purple kingdoms, it is said it was brought by the war. In the corridors of the cities, it is murmured that it began with the princess, her blood and golden hairs spilled on the floors.

In Menagerie, the silver tongue of the governor's wife convinces the people that it´s Catra´s doing. And the same people that once saw her grow up, now starved with hunger, hunt her down.

Nobody had stepped foot in Catra´s land for five years. Not the stranger with his fluttering steps, nor his mother with her thousand voices. Not Deo, forbidden to stay close. Catra, however, knew they would come for her sooner or later.

After all, her land is alive, *alive.* The river is gone but in its place there is left a lake of clean waters where she bathes. The rain that falls over her head is warm and clean and she drinks out of it. The crops of her earth are fresh and her cattle are fat. She drinks milk and sips honey; she bites on meat and sinks her fangs on figs and pomegranates. She is fed, clothed and clean, untouched by the war.

She is more goddess than human, sprout of the gods, even if she does not know that. And if she does, she chooses not to speak about it ever again.

She knew they would come and yet she hoped, as the years went by and she remained here she hoped, held onto her prayers to deaf ears and blind eyes. Begging the light would return to her dreams. She hoped

They fall over her like wolves, at night. And as most times when something like this happens, she is in the place where she is supposed to be secure. At home.

They burst past her door and break the woods and tear the fabric of the windows. They spill the oil of the candles into the floor and the fire finally reaches inside her very home, rising hot as the very Tartarus on every single corner, erasing all of the tender places where she had been raised, where she had lived with her mother, forever.

Catra runs, she tries too. She screams at the top of her lungs when the men descend over her bed and try to hold her down and wrap her into rope. She yells, kicks and runs her claws over tender flesh until she feels blood on her palms and splashing on her face and she falls on the floor and crawls her way across ashes and dirt, coughing until her lungs are straining inside her ribcage and her palms are scrapped with wounds.

But at the end of the day, she is overpowered and the wolves tearing her land apart know it. She is autumn and spring but the war and its men are winter and scorching fire. Dreams are sweet until they are not and flowers rot apart and just like that her home and land burn and she is seized and taken away.

She still fights the whole way towards the village and for the first time since she was a child, she is afraid to cross the woods and she is afraid of not being able to see. She cannot see her home burning away but she can feel it. She cannot see the men holding her from throwing herself into the dead grass of the woods but she can feel their hands around her forearms and shoulders.

She cannot see the village that she has not stepped into in years, nor she can see the way the building are white and green and the temples are dark with past fires, but she can hear the loud murmur of the people when the cart where she is displays her to their eyes in the middle of the square.

Years ago, somewhere in another broken home, people refused to see. Tonight, all of them are staring, and it is all the same. Such is the importance of eyes; such is the importance of sightless sight. All the same.

Catra is taken inside somewhere huge, she can make out of it by the way the echo of the cart and the chattering of men is so loud all around her. It is dark too, she can barely make out the movement of shadows so she closes her eyes instead, letting her eyelids fall closed.

The cart stops with a jolt and then she is dragged again, way down until the floor where she is kneeling is not earth anymore but cold mosaic, biting mercilessly on the scrapped skin of her knees. Everything about this place is cold, it's what Catra realizes before anything else, cold and frail.

“Is this her?” A man asks in front of her, humming with displeasure.

Soft steps approach from behind Catra, familiar in a way she can´t quite place until a long hand wraps on the back of her hair and yanks her backwards, placing her sharp fingers right around Catra´s throat.

“It is. I told you it was true,” Lystra says, her sly words falling into Catra´s sensitive ears and making her twitch and shiver with repulsion. “Your men saw by themselves her land. It was green. It was witchcraft.”

The hold of her aunt's hand around her neck grows painfully and Catra wheezes, only able to hear as the first man steps even closer to them.

He smells a lot like expensive oils and wine, a clear tale that the weight of war has not weighed over him at all. And Catra doesn´t even need to be told who this is.

She knows immediately that the person now stopping in front of her is the Governor, once the Magistrate until he sold Menagerie to the war of the Emperor and became unbelievably rich in return. This is Hordak, her aunt Lystra´s husband, not a single trace of love in that marriage but filled with greed and hubris instead.

“My brother is still in need of a wife.” Hordak is saying, his rancid breath hitting on Catra´s cheeks. “After the fiasco of the Eternian princess he has barely managed to keep himself satisfied.”

His hand meets Catra´s face, gripping her chin in a steel hold. Catra snaps her head back and grunts, baring her teeth when Lystra pulls so hard from her hair that her eyes fill with tears and accidentally flutter open.

Hordak´s hand snaps away from her immediately, his loud steps hurried and clumsy as he rushes backwards over the floor.

“What's wrong with her eyes?”

“The gods took her sight when she was a child,” Lystra says, her voice falling dangerously.

Hordak grunts, his voice further away. “She is useless then”

Now is Lystra, wavers of shadows, the one that tenses, her hand tight around Catra´s body and her voice urgent, as if there was a certain kind of underlying desperation on her. “She can still bear children”

“My brother dismissed the most beautiful woman in the world like she was nothing,” Hordak spats with a vile chuckle, making Lystra´s body cringe. “He threw her to the monster and saw her flesh rot. What do you think he will do if I bring her a woman cursed by the gods? Do you think he will take it lightly? Don´t you think he will punish us instead?”

The huge chamber falls silent, only the sound of the burning oils accompanying them. Catra grinds her teeth so hard that she feels the chip dangerously under the pressure, digging her own sharp nails against her palm.

It would be easy, even tied up like she is right now. To turn her hand around and run her sharp nails over the tender skin of her wrists. To slice her skin open so neither men nor pyre will get to her flesh first. To hope the bear and the wolf and the rot get to her bones first to their ashes cannot be buried on top.

It would be easy but Catra is everything but a victim, and so much more than a human. She is a woman. And her womb and breast were made of holy clay, and she refuses to die here.

Catra throws her head back and laughs, loud, so loud it echoes like a war horn inside the huge space. Loud and unafraid.

“You are both so pathetic, aren't you?” She says, her shoulders shaking with laughter, her eyes wet with tears.“So stupid”

Lystra digs her sharp nails against Catra's cheeks, drawing spots of blood off the scratches.

“Watch your tongue”

“Or what? You'll open my throat on the pyres?” Catra taunts her, bets on her, defies her. “I´d rather die that let you put a hand on my legs or my throat. So do whatever the fuck you want but do it already, you imbeciles.”

Someone slaps her, so hard she tumbles unceremoniously in the mosaic of the floor by the strength of the hit.

Somewhere in her brain she partially understands that it must have been the governor's hand, as Lystra is still holding her with a death grip, but her body cannot comprehend it over the pain, resting her forehead on the cold floor and whimpering instead.

“Throw her to the beast.” Lystra says somewhere above Catra's body, her voice full of venom.

Hordak’s sandals shift over the floor, his breathing elaborated and breath rancid. “Keep talking”

“If she won´t serve for the bed, then let her serve the hunger of the people.” Lystra hums and Catra does not need eyes to know the amount of pleasure swirling inside her body. “They are desperate to blame their tragedy on someone they can break, so give her to their fury. They will judge her for what she represents and the mutiny for the hunger will end until the Emperor gets here.”

“Good, very good.” Hordak's sandals tap on the floor, his voice pleased, his laughter loud now. “Guards, drag her outside.”

“Do whatever you want with her as long as I never have to see her again”

Catra hears it all as if underneath the water, her ears ringing and her breath held inside her chest. She feels the guards seizing her from the forearms again and pulling her on her bare feet, already making their way towards the direction where the air is colder.

Catra snaps her head to the side, following the smell of wine where she knows Lystra stands.

“I´m still your family,” Catra says, placing an unknown curse over her. “You are still my aunt”

“And Io was my sister. The bastard half of my blood,” Lystra answers, tearing Catra's heart into pieces. “It did not keep me from poisoning her wine, did it?”

Catra screams until her throat rips itself in half. She fights and pulls and tries to throw herself in the floor and crawl her damn way back in the darkness and reach the shadows of the

woman that used to be her family and that had destroyed everything Catra held dear below her foot.

Catra is thrown into a different kind of anger by their hands. One that is mislead and unfair; one that has nobody else to blame to themselves and each other so they choose to throw it against the most different and isolated of them. As if somehow that would be enough to alleviate the guilt.

“Here you have who to blame!” The governor screams in the middle of the square, wrapping his hand around Catra's tangled curls, presenting her to the roaring crowd. “She has made deals with the old gods, exchanged the prosperity of your kingdom for a green land.”

The clamor of the crowd becomes unbearable, making Catra's head ring and throb painfully. She closes her eyes as tight as she can but maintains her head held up straight, facing whatever stands in front of her.

“So we will give her back to them fully. If the gods want blood then that's what they'll have. We will offer her a sacrifice to the beast, the monster that lingers on the cavern. The devourer of mortals, the slayer of men. It will feast on her and in exchange pride and greatness will return to our land!”

How terrifying it is, how easily the people that have seen you grow can turn against you.

Among the loud cheering, another voice raises from the crowd of people. Calm, well collected, peaceful among irrational anger. The village's physician speaks up and for some reason even the noise seems to lower down, quieting where he starts talking.

“Governor,” he says and he does not sound a day older than the moment he told Catra's mother that she would lose her sight. “Lady of the house,” and he sounds strong willed, dangerously serious, one last warning. “Think very well what you're going to do next”

Around Catra, someone steps near her and then far away; slow steps, low breathing. Catra cannot recognize everyone only by their voice or by the weight of their steps, but she knows this one, the Oracle's old wrinkled hands thumbing Catra's eyelids into an impossible caress.

See things as I do , she whispers in her old voice, Apollo blessed.

And among darkness, Catra makes sense of the shadows beyond any kind of image, and she knows. And she understands for the split of a second what is to be Cassandra, cursed, chased by future fire and despair.

She is ripped away from it by the hand of the governor wrapping around her face again, his breath hovering over her cheeks.

“Anything more to spit, witch?” Hordak grunts on her face, satisfaction painted inside his slick voice.

Catra blinks, feeling the heavy weight of tears giving away through her cheeks, washing across her face and clouding her sight, making her feel the village anew.

Grass, covered in red, rotting corpses. Blood rain. This is the way in which she sees things, whispered visions by ghosts and gods the same.

“You are all going to die,” Catra whispers, meeting everyone's eyes with her sightless ones. “Every single one of you”

The village goes frightfully quiet from one second to the other, the weight of her words falling over all of them. This is the first and only time the people have betrayed her, this will be the last. They don't know it yet but once Catra is gone so will be the last mercy of the gods.

The governor grasps her chin harshly, shaking her hard. “I will have you kill for your blasphemies”

Catra exhales, turning her full moon eyes straight into his, unnervingly sharp, unnervingly accurate. The sight of a goddess staring back at him from her xoous palace.

“It won't change anything”

Hordak lets go of her and steps back, tripping on his clothes and cursing loudly for it. He swears and spits in the ground near Catra's knee, shaking from fury so badly that it makes his black teeth crash against each other.

“Throw her to the beast!” He exclaims, his voice before victorious now afraid. He is suddenly terrified of her, as he has seen the ichor swirling in her irises. “Tie her tight and do not leave the entrance of the cavern until you are sure it has feasted on her flesh and sucked her bones dry!”

Things are moving around Catra again. For the split of a second, she wants to scream again, she wants to yell at them to *get the fuck away from me!* And, *do not put your hands on me ever again!* But this time she remains quiet, louder in her defiance with her body than with her words.

“It doesn't matter what you do to me,” she murmurs and she hopes it spreads over the village like a plague. “Even dying is under my control. I choose it over all of you.”

Someone hits her in the head so hard she gasps, hearing only the lighting breaking the sky, smelling only the smoke coming from her home.

The world goes completely dark and the next she knows is cavern and stone. Silence, the broken statues of faux heroes and a voice calling her home.

And maybe, just maybe, a prayer long ago asked for.

“You are beautiful,” the tender beast says, her tears fresh against Catra´s fingertips, her face pressed against her palms. She is soft, she is sad. Not a monster but a woman.

She smells like lemongrass, she is flesh instead of dream dust and, after so long, the golden light finally comes back inside Catra's eyes.

Flowers, I remember fields of flowers

Soft beneath my heels

Walking in the sun, I remember someone

Someone by my side, turned his face to mine

And then I turned away, into the shade

– *Flowers,* **Hadestown**

Chapter End Notes

Hope you enjoyed this chapter! Comments, bookmarks and kudos are deeply appreciated.

See you soon. Be good!

Verse III

Chapter Summary

" Do you know me? "

It would be so easy.

Chapter Notes

A woman that has lost all her faith and a daughter of the gods walk into a room...

Welcome! Thank you so much all fans and newcomers for being here. As I said before, chapter will be more or less more constant than before but they will also be a little short (about 10-12k per chapter I think) which is going to give me much more room to develop their slow burn better, to post more often, and to give myself a breath too. Hope the wait is worth it!

Today our girls are finally interacting in present time! And today officially starts the slow burn that is slowly driving me mad because I'm an impatient person >:] but it will be worth it

Also small note! Catra is granddaughter of Demeter and daughter of Morpheus (which is why the dreams are happening, it is a gift from her father so she would be close to Adora as they grew); for those that asked last time!

Without more to say, see you downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse III.

Wisteria

Honey, you're familiar like my mirror years ago

Idealism sits in prison, chivalry fell on its sword

Innocence died screaming, honey, ask me I should know

I slithered here from Eden just to sit outside your door

– Hozier, *From Eden*



“Do you think she is dead already?”

“I don't know. Just as I didn't know when you asked ten minutes ago”

Rustle

“It's been hours”

“I'm aware”

“Don’t you think there will be like… a change? The skies turn clear and the grass sprouts or some shit like that? Instead the sky looks fucking red and it´s fucking cold”

“I don't know”

Rustle, rustle.

“What if–?”

“Do you want to go inside and see yourself?”

“Of course not!”

“Then shut the fuck up!”

Two men are camping in the woods right outside the cavern. They talk loud and laugh louder, cooking greasy meat on an almost too muddy fireplace. Catra smells it from where she is tucked into, that known and delicious smell mingled with the stench of sweat and humidity from the men's bodies. It is almost enough to make her gag.

The men say something else and laugh again, their horses nervously neighing somewhere near the entrance. They are both standing guard on the outskirts of the cavern, making sure Catra is well dead before returning to Menagerie.

Catra leans against the thick wall of stone and moss and sighs, resting the back of her head over the cold rock. Her ears twitch nervously where she strained her hearing to make sure if the men were still there and her head is pounding painfully, aching where the light of the sun burnt too much against her fragile scleras.

Unlike the loud outside, the inside of the cavern is blissfully quiet, echoing only with dripping water from the stone ceilings and the whistle of warmth air coming from the entrance.

Here, the walls are covered in thick foliage and thorns, from the ceiling to the bottom of the cave, pinching softly on Catra's fingertips.

There is more that Catra can feel, making their way across the entire cavern. Strange forms with rough surfaces, wet yet crumbling a little if she rests her palms over them for too long.

They must be stalactites and stalagmites, Catra realizes after a second, covering everything in their texture. They are melted with other textures, also rough but softer and stronger, and if Catra were to rest her nose on the surface she would realize they are quartz and geode, precious stone that thrives on the humidity, the darkness, and the absence of any other living soul inside these natural confinements.

Catra cannot see them, but she feels them on the tips of her fingers and the soles of her feet, their rouge surface and the coldness in there too, making her shiver a little when she takes a step forward.

She knows there is moss beneath her feet and loose stone so she takes her steps carefully, slowly, taking her time to learn the way in which the cavern is constructed.

It is, as any other cavern Catra might have ever known before, stone and moss; freezing water and slippery floor. Only once she slips with a puddle of water and only once she curves under her breath when she steps into a sharp stone that threatens to break the skin of her soles. She wasn't even allowed the kindness of leather bands before being thrown here.

Cold water falls on the braids of her hair and her nose, making her shiver, but she keeps walking, making sure she knows where to go and where to step.

It is also cold. Really fucking cold and frightfully silent. The void makes Catra go a little bit mad.

She taps her fingers over the walls and the floor every once in a while, trying to locate the things around her by sound alone. Her ears are twitching like crazy at the sides of her head, catching every single sound and placing the way they bounce on the things around her.

It is all so wildly different compared to Menagerie, to the forest and the rivers and the earth with twigs and moss. Here she doesn´t know where to step and the sounds around her are different, deeper, making her confused several times before she finally finds her way around.

There is a strange corner on the side of the cavern, a place where Catra feels the air is colder than the rest and where the air smells just a little like burnt steel. Catra frowns and tip toes softly on the ground, making out the strange shape thrown on the floor, smooth and metal against the scratched skin of her soles.

Catra leans down, feeling the cold rock in front of her. There is something partially buried in there, among sharp pebbles and loose earth, with irregular angles and a sharp surface that pinches on her fingers when she grabs it from the sides, lifting the broken pieces of metal off their burial site. It's cold and definitely broken, twinkling with chains that crumble on her fingers in the sides.

Catra cannot make the shape of it, not completely, running her fingers carefully over the whole expanse of the metal. In a way it feels almost like a disk, something that you would find in the royal sports. Except that this one has dents on the surface, small pieces where the

metal has been forced and bent into unnatural ways. And other places are torn, broken like parchment, from one side to the other and open like flowers, almost as if someone had stabbed a sharp end on the material and pulled down until the same gave away and broke.

Catra has never known the weight of restraints or chains, but she knows them. She has known, too, the shape of theater masks; she heard them several times when the caravans were in her village. It does not take much for Catra to understand what this is, to give reason to it. To understand the deformed reality of what she is holding between her trembling hands.

She might not be able to see, but she knows the shape of covered metal eyes and the gagged mouth made of steel.She can feel the shape that was meant to close around the head, broken into pieces, sliced, as if it had been sliced by nails alone. She can feel the desperation guarded inside this metal and the rips on the surface of the mask until it finally gave away and broke into pieces, freeing its captive for the world.

A cruel testimony of a cruel moment in time, of unfair betrayal and the fear that came after being thrown in this place without a second thought.

Catra drops the broken mask back into the earth, stumbling back. Her breath tangles inside her lungs, making her want to gasp. She can feel her heartbeat inside her eardrums and the low of her throat choking her with something much different to horror and much more like sadness.

Catra stands back in unsure feet, tripping several times before she is finally able to steady in her feet. Her chest rises and falls several times with how quickly she breathes, unable to hold down a drowned sob when she presses her palm fully against her mouth and tilts over, hiding her face between her palms.

Here, the pass of time is unknown to Catra, the light of the sun hidden by the stone walls. All she can perceive when she opens her eyes again are still shadows surrounding her, and she knows she is alone as she has been for the last hours. Between broken metal and crumbling statues.

Catra starts making her way across the cave again, her shoulders trembling the deeper she goes into it and the further the temperature around her drops. She purposely tries to miss the statues scattered around the floor, holding her breath every single time their broken limbs catch on the torn fabric of her tunic.

They are dozens, several, so many of them that Catra feels lightheaded just by the thought of counting them at all. And they are everywhere.

Everywhere where she rests her fingers to balance herself, or where her feet brush against the ground, even where her tail and ears sometimes catch, among the earth and quartz, the statues are everywhere around her.

Frozen limbs, broken shapes. Some of them have long ago crumbled into pieces on the floor, their shapes no longer distinguishable for Catra´s fingers, nothing more but sharp stones against her feet. Other´s still raised, fresh almost, thick rock and rough surface, so different

from the polished surface of the abandoned columns also scattered around the cavern. As if these faux Greek heroes were not deserving of marble, not even in their graves.

Catra remembers the broken mask on the floor, metal and blood smelling, and she locks her jaw, closing her hands into angry fists; fighting to push down unfiltered rage.

She keeps walking across stone corpses, following the sound of her own breath until she finally reaches what she is seeking for, a trembling sigh of fresh breath hidden somewhere in the wall beyond.

Catra bites back an exhale, holding her breath until her chest aches and she is now right in front of the source of warmer air. Here, tiny specks of light dance in front of her clouded irises when she opens her eyes, almost as if pulling her forwards by some kind of divine touch.

She knows the person she is looking for went through this place, this almost tiny hole on the stone partially hidden by thick fabrics that Catra thumbs when she stretches her hand forwards, studying the entrance swiftly.

She knows because Catra felt her slip from her touch so suddenly that she barely had time to react, rushing to her feet and begging her to go one more time before throwing herself to the hands of warmth air and hidden entrances where she hoped Catra could not find her again.

And Catra, well, Catra knows a great deal about the world and about tragedy. Her skin still aches with the wounds her own village placed over her, her clothes still smell like the ashes of her burnt home. She, more than anyone else, has the right of being afraid of the unknown where she has been exiled into.

But she now also knows the feeling of a face pressed against her belly, forehead and temples resting against the warmth of her tunics, mouth and nose exhaling against her womb, making her tremble. She knows the touch of sharp hands wrapped around the divots of her waist, holding her close but never imprisoning her; just molding to her body as if the world were to crumble and succumb if the person kneeling at Catra´s feet were to let go of her for a single second.

Catra now knows what is to be touched reverently, even if for just a second. Someone beautiful cursed to pain finding solace on the brush of Catra´s skin against hers.

It took a second, just one for Catra to know that no matter what she wouldn´t want to be anywhere else but here, with stone powder on her feet and climbing the cold limits of a cave,

What she thought before was merely a hole in the wall turns out to be a whole corridor, narrow enough that Catra has to scrunch down to not bang her head against the quartz ceiling,

She grunts lightly and very slowly drops into her hands and knees, finding her way across the corridor. She tries to be careful, slippery stones bumping a little bit on her way, feeling the edges of them as she tries to find the end of the passage. She can feel warmth

progressively closer to her cheeks the further she makes it inside, as if Helios themself had lit a sun-like candle inside the very depths of the cavern.

In the end, it gets to get much faster than she can realize that she is already at the end of the path. The corridor falls into an abrupt end below her and Catra trips and feels herself fall, barely having a second to gasp sharply and brace herself before meeting the sharp rocks below the entrance.

Something breaks her fall, catching her inside a sure grip and holding Catra fully between strong arms.

Catra gasps again, wrapping herself fully around the person carrying her, her entire body shocked by the adrenaline of falling. She knows, somewhere inside her brain, that she must look ridiculous right now, holding herself for dear life to the neck of the person that has saved her, but she cannot even begin to care.

She can feel her feet dangling in the air from where she has been caught, an arm crossed below her knees and the other one around her back, holding her up and again from the floor as if she weighed nothing at all and the single display of strength makes Catra´s head swing, closing her eyelids tightly when golden light floods inside her eyes.

“What are you doing?” The woman with golden light asks next to Catra´s head, her breath just inches away from her mouth.

She smells like lemongrass, strongly, lemongrass and honey and a third scent that Catra cannot make off but that makes her mouth water immediately. Tears immediately bite in the corner of her eyes, barely held back by the speeding up of her heart, hammering against her ribs.

Catra feels suddenly as if she was still falling, sauntering from the sky to the sea with her arms stretched open. Icarus, after being let go from the safety of the wings, betrayed by the softens of the wax, reaching for the ground as the sun welcomes him with a kiss and pushes him away at the same time. That's how it feels.

“I'm following you,” Catra hears herself muttering, her hands slipping from the back of the woman´s head to her shoulders, broad against her palms, trying not to prick her with her nails. So close yet so painfully far away.

For the split of a second, she thinks she can feel the smooth surface of something brushing her fingertips before the woman snaps her head away sharply, grunting under her breath but still not letting go from Catra.

“You are going to break your neck,” the woman answers back, grumbling angrily.

And oh, *oh,* she is being lectured. Catra is actually being lectured by this woman. She can hear it in the heavy and clearly annoyed tone of her voice, huffing next to Catra´s ears and making them twitch.

All earth shattering tenderness that had suddenly sprouted inside Catra´s chest comes to an abrupt hold, still blooming but shaking from the inside out with irritation. Exasperation and frustration start to fight their way inside her throat, clawing on the back of her head with annoyance.

“I wouldn't if you'd talk to me instead of running away,” Catra bites back, snapping her arms away and crossing them over her chest instead. She kicks into the air, suddenly eager to be put back into the ground.

“I'm not running away,” the woman mumbles under her breath but Catra is already far beyond her shit, snapping her fangs together.

“You are!” Catra exclaims. She rests her palm over what she is almost sure is the woman's warm cheek and pushes her away, scowling deeply. “Put me down. You're annoying me”

Catra´s feet meet the ground almost immediately. She is placed very carefully back over the steady ground, and instead of more hard stone as she was expecting before she is welcomed by soft moss and grass right below her ankles and toes, tickling on her skin.

Catra bites back a sigh of relief and snaps her head towards the place where the lemongrass breath is coming from, ready to confront her again. But the woman snaps herself away from Catra´s reach, her feet raising soft sounds over the grass covered floor, dragging herself further and further away.

Catra misses her deeply in an instant.

“Why are you following me then?” The woman asks, her voice exasperated.

There are a few new sounds echoing inside this newfound warm place, coming from where Catra supposes the woman has gone to. Heavy fabric pushed back, the jingle of fine metal, things pushed to the sides and more fabric pushed against stone and then silence.

Catra opens and closes her hands next to her tunic, searching for the stone of the entrance next to her to lean into. The place where she has stepped into is flooded with light, bright and golden, aching slightly on the edges of Catra´s clouded vision. The air is clean and fresh and there is no more silence, the characteristic rush of running water nearby raising goosebumps over her skin.

“Do you usually call people beautiful and then leave immediately after? Or was that a one time thing?” Catra teases, resting flat against the cold stone wall. She tries to keep her voice as collected and teasing as possible but her heart is fighting a war inside her chest, pushing against her lungs and ribs with every single beat.

Somewhere away from her, Catra hears the woman take a sharp breath, followed by a low, almost sizzling sound that quiets down immediately after. The entire cavern seems to smell like her too, warm and sweet.

“I– I don´t–” the woman trips with her own words, breathing hard. She cuts herself short on her answer, her voice coming forcefully through clenched teeth. It's not funny, nothing about

this is funny, nor the faux teasing nor the tension, nor the sharp words. “There is nothing in here for you. You'd be better off leaving.”

The repetitive rejection slams against Catra´s chest like a spear, cold and heavy against her heart. Catra has spent a long time alone the last five years, recused inside her own patch of land until the people that once were her neighbors betrayed her.

She was not wanted by the rest of her family, she was betrayed by her people, and now, now she is pushed away by the same creature that was supposed to end her life. It all seems so much like a twisted joke, meant to drive her insane or tear her into pieces.

Because, incredibly, even now that Catra had chosen her own tomb as long as it was under her control, she was not wanted for it either. It's insane, it's crazy, but it hurts. The sun hurts, the light hurts, the distance hurts.

Catra hums, tilting her head to the side, away from the person hiding away from her as if Catra was the poisonous root suddenly sprouting on this lad.

She tries to push the pain of the rejection away, giving a careful step to the side. More moss and grass meets her along the way. Unlike the cave, cold and unsure, this place is steady and warm, something firm and constant almost everywhere where Catra steps.

It is still unknown though, completely unfamiliar to her who doesn´t know where she is going every time she gives a step forward. Unknown like stepping into a dream that she has not met in a long time and where she is not sure if she is going to remain steady or fall down. But she keeps walking.

She follows the wall and takes careful steps, blooms of unknown flowers sprouting around her soles, leaving a trail behind her step that brushes against her tail. Somewhere behind her, the woman holds her breath again, the sizzling and twinkling sound echoing once more before her voice follows.

“What are you doing?” The woman questions in the thread of a breath. She sounds unsure, unsure and almost scared of Catra.

Catra shrinks inside herself a little but doesn´t turn towards her, only acknowledging her with a swift flip of her ear,

“Feeling.” Catra´s fingertips run over the stone next to her until it starts feeling different, softer, covered by gentle leaves and patches of moss and softer stone. “Where are we?”

“Please–”

“Where are we?” Catra cuts her short, still not stopping in her steps.

She knows what the woman is going to say, what she is going to demand of Catra as she has been doing non-stop since Catra was thrown inside this place. Catra doesn´t want to hear it again.

The woman seems to struggle for a second with her words because it takes her several seconds to answer, and when she does her words sound stretched, almost forceful with the weight of honesty.

“An extension of the cave, I guess.” She murmurs, breathing so softly that, if Catra wasn't a magicat, she would not have heard her at all.

Catra nods, taking in the way the sound of their voices and the running water echoes loudly all around them. “It 's huge.”

“It is.” She has a sweet voice, sweet and charged with mistrust.

Catra wrinkles her nose and walks further until the stone and moss wall is finally over and she meets another kind of structure, so big that her entire palm does not reach the ends. It's colder at the touch but not as much as back in the cave, polished under her touch and somehow familiar to her among the unknown of this new place.

“These are columns,” Catra murmurs at the same time her soles leave the moss and step into a different ground. Polished too, obviously taken care of before time and nature took over and started to grow among the seams. Catra can feel the edges of the mosaic below her, tracing them with her soles and then with her fingers too when she leans down to press her palm over them. “Marble floor”

She is marveled, quietly and almost to herself. Out of all the things she expected to find deeper inside this previously seemingly empty cavern, a greek building was not among them. She can feel the traces of fine dust from where the marble and the mosaic have given up and now rise a little on the edges, brushing against her skin.

If she runs her palms over the tall columns, she can feel the small carvings tone over the marble, creating illustrations on the very foundations of the building. A few lights and shadows dance in front of her irises when she opens them and once the warmth coming from them is closer to her she realizes they are oil lamps, lightened up to cast the darkness away.

It is quite obvious that this place was once upon a time built with care and love, carefully planned through. Dug on the very stone of the cavern until the temple and this place were one and the same, covered by earth sprouts and the drops of water falling like fine drizzle over it.

“It´s a temple. Long ago abandoned.” The voice of the woman trails behind Catra and inside the building. “I don´t know for whom or for what. The opisthodomos got buried under the debris of the cave but the pronaos and part of the naos survived. The ceiling and columns are intact, they are limestone and marble and mud brick, but the stone has worn out with time.”

She speaks about it with great knowledge, not only about the things that Catra cannot see but also about the architecture of the temple, as if she knew far beyond what this lonely place could tell her itself. A bloom of curiosity tickles its way right in the middle of Catra´s chest.

“It was already here when I arrived.” The woman keeps saying, still tucked away in some corner of the rest of the cavern. “I think there was a collapse many years ago.”

Catra hums again, nodding her head with understanding. She doesn´t really know what to say beyond quiet acceptance, as if the existence of this place that with every beat seems to be more magical than before was something natural for her, something not expected but as easy to hold as breathing. In a way she feels like she doesn´t really *have* to say anything else.

She follows the mosaic floor until it ends again, very slowly feeling the beginning and the end of the steps of the temple, also dug on the earth. In here, the floor feels fresher, coated by dew and drizzle coming from the water falling strongly almost in front of her.

It also feels precarious and a dozen times more like mud than to steady earth so Catra remains where she is, stretching instead her arm in front of her. It takes her a second but her fingers meet the lukewarm water falling from a point much higher than her head; and her cheeks feel the rays of the midday sun shimmering right over, slipping past the rock and showering almost everything inside the cavern with golden light.

“Why is there a waterfall here?” This time, Catra can´t hold back her awe, dipping her entire hand into the water.

It´s not strong enough that hurts her skin. It feels like rain in a way, flowing and constant against her fingers and the earth below, soaking through the ends of Catra´s broken tunic and traveling somewhere across the cavern where Catra cannot see it.

“The ceiling gave up a long time ago.” The twinkling sound comes back, followed by soft fabric brushing against the floor. “I think we are close to a river so the water must have caused enough erosion for the stone to give up at some point. All the water that falls pools into a lake right in front of you and that water also runs somewhere else, beyond the cavern itself. I´ve never known where.”

The woman still sounds extremely weary but there is something else in her voice now, something careful. As if she was also stepping with precaution around Catra´s presence.

Catra takes her hand off the water and extends it towards the bare air instead, palm open like a flower. The warm light falls over her skin and her closed eyelids, warming her up from the inside out immediately.

“It's actually the sun. I thought–”

“Not all of the cavern is stone.” The jingle is closer now, still far away but nearer, her voice clearer for Catra to listen. “There are open spaces above you, on the stone; they act like domes. Rain and the sun come inside but they are too far away to reach”

She is taking her time describing things to her. Catra notices immediately and she doesn't know if it's a small mercy towards her or if it's burn out of pity but it twists something on the base of her belly, seizing its way tight against her throat.

The woman had said there was a lake in front of the waterfall, just a few steps to the side. Catra can already feel the damp earth, meddling around her toes and squishing softly under her weight.

It doesn't feel different to the limits of the river that used to exist in her homeland, before the greed of man and the devastation of war dried it whole.

She had missed this feeling, of soft earth and even softer moss and the water pooling in the ends of her clothes; the smell of petrichor and fresh water and the sound of droplets splashing gently when she gets a little too close to the edge of the water.

And Catra? Catra might not be able to see her, but she can *feel* this woman, lemongrass smelling and nervous with her sweet voice tangled on her vocal cords and absolutely exasperating Catra.

“Stop it,” Catra spats, frowning towards the place where the sounds are coming from. The twinkling stops suddenly, the woman's voice shivering a little with confusion.

“What?”

“You think too loud. I can feel you wanting to help me. Stop it.” Catra snaps back, throwing her shoulders back.

She is aware that she must appear like a complete mess, tousled hair knotted in places and torn pieces of her tunics and bruises on her skin. She is aware that, for this new stranger in Catra´s life, Catra must look like a lost spirit, blindly finding her way across the moss of the cavern. But if there is something Catra has always held high and intact is her dignity, no matter the way her skin tingles by this person hovering nervously around her.

“You are going to fall into the water,” the woman mutters but Catra just shrugs, dropping her hands back to her sides.

“So? Let me fall.”

Catra turns her head away again, letting her eyes fall closed. The ache on the sides of her head is slowly coming back to her, and now that the adrenaline has almost completely worn off her body, all of the pain she feels is coming to her in full force.

Her legs ache, deeply, worn out and exhausted after fighting her way across her home; all for nothing, always for nothing. The rest of her body is scattered in scratches and bumped bruises that Catra feels with her fingertips, covered with dried mud and dust and clotted blood in the edges.

She is mildly aware that her soles are covered in something too, already cracking uncomfortably against her skin. She tries not to pay too much mind into it but she knows it's her own blood, coming from where she sliced her skin into places trying to run.

Her tunic is a mess, torn apart on the shoulder where the fabric caught against something, the end of a spear of a sword, she is not sure. She really did not got to understand what was happening but she felt it, sharp against the skin of her shoulder blade and dragging down; once second it was cold, almost painless, and the next it was burning, making Catra gasp before the hit against the side of her head drowned everything into darkness.

Catra runs her fingers softly across the skin of her shoulder, feeling the ragged edges of the deep wound, pulsing violently when she grazes over them, no matter how softly. She bites back a yell and twists her body to the side a little, trying to grasp a better idea or just how bad it is.

Catra hears a sharp gasp behind her, the twinkling sound raising loudly before dying down with a painful grunt, a heavy breath almost held too tightly inside the chest. Only now it occurs to Catra that the wound is in full display underneath the light of the sound, a sharp contrast against her skin for the new stranger to see fully.

Catra keeps her eyelids shut until a spark of pain crosses her head, breathing very softly through her mouth.

“I'm bleeding, aren't I?” Catra asks, still not turning around. The woman, still somewhere in the cavern, gulps loudly, her voice unsure when she speaks.

“It's –”she cuts herself short, her feet raising a soft sound when she walks. “It's not bleeding anymore”

“Yeah, I'm guessing it's not pretty looking either way.” Catra tries to say the words lighthearted, almost as an unfunny joke but even for her, her own voice sounds unbearably sad, making her ears press against the sides of her head with shame.

Catra sighs and leans down, sitting on the soft earth below her with her knees pressed against her chest. Liske this she can feel now the very edge of the lake, its water covering Catra´s soles, soft waves cleaning the traces of blood from her skin.

It is colder than the waterfall but Catra welcomes it, the sensation washing away a little of the pain that now extends beyond her chest. She lets her open palm rest flat over the surface of the water, there in the middle where the sunlight still washes over her raw knuckles and the superficial tension promises to break free if she were to press a little deeper.

“I can't leave,” Catra whispers, resting her chin over her bent knees. “There are men outside the cave, making sure I´m actually dead. If I leave they are going to open my throat.”

The jingle moves a little to the side, still away from Catra but closer to the edge of the lake. The woman is breathing deeply, Catra can recognize the pattern, trying to calm herself. Catra has done it plenty of times on her own when the world was crumbling around her.

“Surely when they leave…”

“You don´t get it.” Catra chuckles, void of all kinds of mirth in it. She presses the heel of her palm against her eyelids and shakes her head, ignoring the way it makes her head swing.

The woman sighs, deeply, clicking her tongue softly against the base of her teeth. The fabric of her clothes shifts around her body and the earth when she moves and the breeze moves with her too, letting Catra know that she has lowered down on the floor too. Maybe sitting with her legs crossed, maybe even mirroring Catra´s posture, opposites on the other side of the lake speaking to each other in hushed voices.

“Explain it to me,” she whispers and she sounds soft again, tense but tender, like one of the bruises scattered on Catra´s skin. Too frail to ignore, too careful to touch.

“They– hate me,” Catra confesses after a beat, finally putting the words out in the world.

They are heavy. rotten taste and citric, like a fruit under the burning sun. Absently Catra wonders what would´ve her mother thought about this, just how angry and heartbroken she would have been to find out the people she trusted had forsaken her child like this. All of them.

“For them– for them I am just a conduit of tragedy, something to sacrifice to be able to cover their anger, to justify their pain, or to– display their power. I either die one way or another, or they will sell me to the Emperor to bear his breed.” A gasp, not from Catra´s mouth. “And what do you think I preferred?”

“I–”

“I am not a possession,” Catra gasps in a breath, rushing to push the words she has meant to say out of her mouth. “I am a woman. I feel, I think, and I can choose my own fate.”

The cavern, with all its golden light, seems to have submerged itself into a sepulchral silence. Even the sounds from the waterfall have been drowned, like a ringing in the ears instead of a natural fountain. All Catra can really hear is the faint splash of the lake´s water against her fingers and soles, and the faint breathing of other lungs besides hers.

Fear, it seems to murmur the silence; hatred and anger, woven on the very strands of the cavern´s darkness. A kind that is Catra´s but that is not only hers, melting together like the lake over the smooth pebbles on the edge.

“The guards might have dragged me here but it was the rest of my people who condemned me. Even if I were to leave, there is nowhere else for me to go and nothing else for me out there.” Catra whispers, half to herself, half to the air, all to this stranger with her silent voice and twinkling ankles.

Catra´s voice dies on her throat, sorrow overwhelming her. She wonders for a second what was of Deo, of the stranger of the woods, of Adam. She wonders if her mother is watching from the Elyseum or if she has fallen into a corner of the world untouched by the gods.

She wonders what was of her life, of herself, a woman punished by the war of others. She wonders what was of this newcomer stranger who is so familiar to her; whose touch around Catra´s waist left her skin on fire and bursted her heart with flower stems. She wonders why she is so silent right now, silent like an unmoving ray of light.

“Are you there–?”

“Alright”

Catra bites into her lip, so taken aback by the sound of her voice that it takes her tremendous effort not to fall into the water.

“Alright?”

“Alright.” Feet drag into the earth again, a body standing from its place near the wonder. And she sounds so unbelievably sad that for a second Catra cannot take it. “You can stand as long as you need.” An exhale. “Nothing will harm you here.”

The feet drag away, scattered around the depths of the cavern in echoes, like pebbles falling inside the lake. Catra exhales all the air she did not know she was holding and lets her head roll backwards, neck extended as long as it can to catch the light of the sun over her cheekbones.

It feels like drizzling or maybe that is just the fall of the waterfall, now singing back in all its splendor next to Catra´s ears. Birds are singing too, somewhere beyond Catra´s head, on the open ceilings of the cavern from which they saunter down and pick a little on catra´s curls before flying again.

Catra drops her hold on her knees and bends down, grasping the end of her tunic between her nails. She tears a long piece of the fabric and damps it inside the freshwater of the lake, very carefully bringing it to her back to run it across the open wounds.

It burns, she cannot help a hiss on displeasure the second she feels it, eating it´s way across her shoulders and her entire spine. The clotted blood and dirt had kept from her just how deep and aching it was but now that the clean water was washing it all again, it hurt so deeply her hand started trembling and she had to stop for several seconds, dropping part of the fabric back inside the water.

Soft steps approach her, this time much closer than before. They stop a couple of meters away from her, shifting their weight softly between one another.

“Gods,” Catra murmurs, wrinkling her nose when another stab of pain travels across her back and head. “I know you are there”

“I´m sorry,” the woman mutters, sniffling softly. “I don't want to startle you”

“You don´t.” Catra takes a deep breath, running the soaked fabric over the wound again. “It's bad, isn't it?”

“You need stitches.” The woman leaves something near Catra´s seat, dropping it softly above the floor. It sounds small and hollow, echoing softly with something slightly heavy in the interior. “Here, next to you”

Catra runs her hand over the grass, finding her way against the mouth of a small bowl. She takes it between her hands and brings it slowly towards her nose, taking one swift sniff at the contents in there.

Green chiretta, broadleaf plantain, cottonwood, marigolds, honeysuckle, salvia. The fresh and calming scents hitting the back of her throat immediately.

“Medical herbs.”

“They grow around the waterfall,” the woman explains, the pebbles of the lake rolling below her feet when she steps away.

Catra has an impulse out of sudden, born very deep without her chest. Of throwing herself sideways across the bed of the lake and wrap her palms around the woman's body, any part she could reach like this. Like she had just done when the latter had caught her on the entrance; just so Catra could feel her warm and solid body and know she is real.

But Catra stays where she is, holding the bowl with herbs like a lifeline, her closed eyes fixed in nothing in particular. “Thank you”

“I left some dry clothes next to you too.” The woman says, very slow, like she didn´t really know what was correct to say. And she feels conflicted, it is in her body and in the way her feet tap over and over over the moss, making the twinkling sizzle raise and quiet immediately after. “Your wound, I can–”

Her voice quiets, but Catra´s shivers with newfound energy, her tail switching softly over the ground.

“Would you?”

“I´ve stitched myself up plenty of times,” the woman explains, as if it was normal to be wounded so deeply so many times. “I don´t want to hurt you”

“I don´t think you could ever hurt me like they already did,” Catra says and she means it, she means every word.

The woman mutters something under her breath but Catra cannot catch what it is, instead hearing her clear her throat again and give slightly more rushed steps back.

“There are cushions on the floor to the left of you, three meters back.” The woman starts describing, accompanied by the soft sound of new trinkets moved around. “There is a small fire in the middle, be careful”

Catra nods, still holding herself to the bowl when she stands up. This time, it takes her a monumental effort to do it, her legs trembling so bad that they threaten to tumble her to the ground several times.

Something new, fresh and liquid tickles down the extension of her back, and just now it occurs to Catra just how wounded she really is, tousled and thrown around like a rag doll against chariots and floor and rocks.

Finding the cushions is a small mercy, soft next to her toes. Catra can feel the warmth of the fire too, not biting on her skin but close to her ankles, a warning for her to be careful as she lets herself fall against the pillows. It is more comfortable here than on the side of the lake and Catra appreciates it, humming softly when the fire starts warming up her aching bones.

The steps come back to her, louder than before. They are accompanied by the sizzle of before but also by another kind of jingle , higher and sweeter than a small bell, like a bracelet made of coins, held to the ankles of the woman to announce her presence.

The realization of it makes Catra´s ears burn, a low ringing crossing over them maybe from the headache or from the external warmth.

The cushions near Catra´s knees move a little, placed right behind Catra and where the latter supposes the woman kneels over, still away but just enough for her breath to brush very softly against her back.

“It's going to hurt,” she warns Catra, moving around her and towards the fire, the flames cracking a little when she places something over them and then quickly takes it away.

Catra takes a deep breath, as deeply as she can, bringing her knees against her chest and leaning her chin over them, holding to herself into a tight curl, her back completely bare for the woman to see.

“Go ahead.” It cannot hurt more than it already hurts, fresh droplets of blood running every once in a while across her back.

And not for the first time, Catra is wrong.

The needle grazes on the tender skin of the wound and Catra has barely time to hold her breath and bite down on her tongue before it stabs the aching wound, from one side and then from the other, making quick work of joining the gaping edges together.

It hurts so much Catra has to bite back a scream, the corner of her eyes dampening immediately with tears.

“Jeez,” Catra gasps between clenched teeth, barely holding back a curse when the needle and thread runs against her injured skin again.

“I´m sorry,” the woman whispers, her voice apologetic, almost sorrowful, but never slowing down or dragging things down because doing so would only hurt more and Catra knows that.

She is fast, extraordinary fast and careful. Her fingers and palms never touch Catra's skin, already slippery with blood and sweat, not a single time.

Instead all Catra can feel is the needle and the thread, from one side to the other, inside, outside and pull until it's over faster than when it was done in the first place, the needle away and the thread quickly sliced cut.

“I'm going to place herbs over the wound,” the woman announces, the bowl clanking when she takes it from Catra's side.

“Alright.” The herbs have been smushed into a thick paste, honeysuckle smelling which coolness brings immediate relief to Catra's pain. “Oh. That feels much better”

She tilts her head to the side a little and hums, barely noticing when the woman makes quick word of the dressing with clean stripes of fabric.

“You'll need to change the dressing daily”

“That's fine. I can do that myself.” Catra extends her wounded arms very carefully, feeling the ache even in her fingers but better.

“Good,” the woman moves away and to the side, her coins giving her away. “Can you extend your palms, please?”

Catra's eyebrows rise on her forehead but she complies, almost as a second nature. The moment she does so, another bowl is placed between her cupped hands, slightly lighter than the precious one and a dozens times more delicious smelling.

“What 's this?” Catra asks, her mouth watering immediately. She is starving.

“Meat, salted and cooked.” The womaneans away, the twinkling following her everywhere. “Magicats need meat, it's importat for you. Is– is that right?”

“That´s right” Catra nods, her gratitude and curiosity fighting on her voice. “You hunt here?”

“No,” the woman snaps and doesn't say more, a dozen unsaid things there.

Catra bites on the inside of her cheek, chewing on her tongue. “Have you made the offerings?”

“I don't do that anymore,” there is something in the woman's voice when she says that, something as heavy as Catra's before. Full of disappointment and resentment. “The gods have never listened to any of my pleads”

The coins in her ankles brush softly against each other, moving next to Catra.

“Inside the temple you will find a corner, furthest to the entrance and closest to the waterfall. You will feel fabrics and the bark of a tree and inside cushions and sheets,” she describes, sniffling again. “It's a bed, you can keep it”

Catra frowns, squirming over the pillows. “What about you?”

“I´ve been in this place for many years,” the woman murmurs, her voice suddenly miles away even if she is right next to Catra. “I'll be fine.”

“But–”

“Whenever you need to bathe, I'll go to the cave. You can sleep and rest all you want; there is food here for you, and clothes.” The woman exhales, giving up. “You can stay as long as you think it will help”

A cold has started to settle inside Catra´s chest, deep, the winter air tangling in her lungs and throat. It's uncomfortable, almost unbearable, forever holding itself to her bones and making

a home on the marrow.

The sun is right in front of her, her ankles chiming with bracelets of coins, and yet all of her warmth is kept far away from Catra´s touch. It makes her cold, shivering, and Catra who was born under the sun and who has loved the light of it tenderly inside her dreams, can barely manage the pain of it.

Maybe this *is* a punishment, after all. So close yet so far away.

“Please tell me your name,” Catra begs of her, pressing her palm against her chest. “I'm C’yra, daughter of Io,”

The woman exhales, takes a breath, falls quiet again. When she speaks, is guarded, pulling herself further and further away from her. “I'm just another monster”

“That's not true.” Catra snaps, shaking her head, her matted curls brushing over her bruised chin. “That's what people call you, but it's not true”

“It's true now”

Suddenly her clouded sight is a penitence. For the very first time, Catra curses at it because her body wants to live but her soul would gladly turn into stone just to gaze at this woman forever.

The sweet jingle starts to move, a told tale that the woman is moving away again from Catra ´s reach. The knot in Catra´s throat tightens and then snaps completely, betraying her own body.

Catra throws herself across the pillows, blindly stretching the woman's hand and finding her arm in the middle, wrapping her fingers swiftly around her wrist to try and make her stay.

“Wait,” Catra exhales, her knees dragging off the pillows and into the earth again.

The sizzling sound raises violently, filling the entire cavern with its hiss. The woman snaps her hand away from Catra´s touch immediately, so hard that Catra has to catch herself in her palms to avoid falling, scratching the already tender skin with loose stone.

“Don't touch me,” the woman snaps, the jingle of her ankles dragging several feet away from Catra. Her breath is elaborated, hovering over the place where she has stumbled into in her rush to tear herself away. After a few seconds she seems to take a deep breath, loud enough for Catra to hear it all. From the tremble of her heart to the violent beat of her heart. “Please”

Catra holds her breath too, pushing herself back into a more sitting position against the pillows. her heart is also hammering inside her ears, her entire skin crawling with a cold sweat that makes her itch.

“I won´t,” Catra murmurs, tilting her head away. “I'm sorry”

Silence falls again between them, heavier than before, much more tense, filled with a thousand things that pull Catra apart from every single thread of her soul.

“I know that you don't trust me,” Catra hears herself say, her mouth heavy like chewing molasses. “But I won't hurt you. I promise I won't”

The jingle hesitates for a second, sizzling and a hiss hidden by a strong breath. “You can't possibly promise that”

“I can,” Catra presses, trembling on the edges. A mortal woman begging a cursed creature to trust her. “And I know you won't hurt me either.”

A sigh and a step, backwards, away from her. “You can't know that either”

“But I do.” Catra rests her palm over her bandaged shoulder, her mouth turning with a grimace. “You accepted me here, dressed my wounds, gave me food and clothes. You could have killed me so many times already and yet you keep yourself away from me as if your presence next to me were to poison me.” Catra lets her hands fall against her lap,” So I know.”

The woman grunts, her breath catching on her throat. The coins on her skin are sad bells that before allowed Catra to know that she was close, and that now tells her that she is getting far away.

“You don't know anything about me.” she whispers, “And I don't want you to get close to me.”

Catra hears her leave. She hears her steps over the moss and grass and the bells of her feet, further and further away until they are drowned behind thick fabrics and then Catra knows that she is gone. Across the corridor that leads to the cave, maybe, or to another part of the cavern that Catra does not know about and that she cannot see either. She leaves quietly and Catra knows that she is alone the moment she does so.

Catra drops her face inside her palm and gives a shivering breath, unable to contain anymore the tears gathering on her eyes. She sobs, very soft and under her breath, hoping nobody can hear her and knowing nobody really will.

Even around the sun, even in a new kind of dream, she is alone again.

Above her head, on the open domes of the cavern, the skies thunder violently and the sunlight leaves, drowned by clouds. Rain starts pouring inside, splashing against the lake and the waterfall and extinguishing the small fire in front of her, cold settling completely inside.

Catra´s soles ache and beneath her closed eyelids she cannot distinguish the light.

Adora stumbles inside the damp cave, falling in her hands and knees several times.

The ends of her tunic catch with the sharp ends of the stones and statues scattered inside the gray space, tearing it apart when she drags herself up again.

It's an unpleasant feeling, being scratched on her palms and the rocks pulling from the straps of her sandals, but it is the last of her thoughts right now.

She pushes herself on her knees and sits over the cold floor, letting her head roll back. The pink quartz above her head seems to mock her, to make fun of her with their twinkling glimmer, so easy and calm against the dark.

As always, the cave is frightfully cold, freezing to the bone, perpetual winter here. When she exhales, a cloud of fog rises from her mouth, white against the darkness of the stone, perpetually mournful. It is matching almost to the storm and the chill coiling inside of her.

The statues around Adora seem to haunt her, as they always do. They hover with their somber bodies and frozen limbs next to her,over her, their shadows covering her in darkness as they have done from the moment they came into existence, from the moment the warm living bodies stepped for the first time in this place.

They have all died, they have all succumbed to the weight of Adora´s cursed eyes, to her horrifying face. Every single one of them no matter how inexperience or how mighty. They have all inflicted wounds on Adora´s skin when she tried to push them away and they have all turned to stone, either by her gaze lingering to the side or by their hands pulling back from her head and forcing her to meet them.

No matter how different, they were all the same. Every single one of them, one to the other, from heroes to assassins to her people to her family. The same.

Until her. Now she is here, C´yra. Even her name sounds like music.

There are freckles clustered on her cheeks and stardust powdered on her skin and she is beautiful, almost godly, over her cheekbones and the fall of her collarbones and the loop of her curls.

Her body is battered in bruises and cuts, shallow wounds and ragged lines that Adora had to sew like fabric; patches of red and purple scattered on her limbs like flowers. It makes Adora angry, it makes her rageful, filled with despair and with hatred. It makes something sticky and nasty to crawl its way inside her chest, underneath her skin, something not quite buried and never dead that festers Adora from the inside out.

To carry his breed, she had said, blood soaking on the ends of her tunic, and how dare he? To want to take something like this again? To feel himself worthy of it? How many others have suffered what Adora did, what this beautiful girl in the cavern went through? How many others will suffer again because of him?

Adora can see him in the center of her eyes still, even after so many years, He can see the green glimmer in his eye and the length of his boney fingers, wrapping themselves over freckles wrists. And she hates, all over again.

Adora snaps her head, narrowing her eyes until spots of light shimmer beneath her eyelids. Her mind swirling from dark thoughts into golden-like ones.

This beautiful girl has the moon in her eyes, rimmed with silver on her eyelids. She is blind. For some reason, she is blind.

She is blind, blind to Adora´s horror, to her curse, to her defiled beauty. to her terror. To the death nestled in her eyes. Adora can gaze at her not harm her, and she can tilt her sweet face towards Adora and still smile. Alive. She is the first to place her warm palm against Adora´s skin and still be flesh, still be contained stars.

Adora knows who she is, of course she does. How could she not? She is the half of Adora´s soul, the promised miracle of her childhood dreams, the one wish that she thought was also turned into stone.

Adora can hear her sobbing softly on the other side of the cavern, curled around the cushions and the rain that brings no comfort; in her torn tunic and blood stained soles. She has been sent to death and yet Adora is the one that has made her weep.

It brings shame to Adora's heart, it brings sorrow, the want to tear her scalp open and gouge out her eyes. But there is nothing that Adora can offer her anymore. She only has this, marble stone and abandoned cavern and golden snakes, curling sad and shameful underneath of the veil, casted away from the sunlight by Adora's contempt towards them.

There is nothing Adora can offer her, and nothing she could give Adora in return to fix Adora's pain. Instead, this beautiful woman is the most dangerous person inside this place right now. Most dangerous than all the warriors and killers, most dangerous than the very gods that betrayed her.

She already holds the strands of Adora's heart on her fingertips and she could so easily break them all into pieces. This woman, with her careful fingers and sharp grin, could do so much damage, cause Adora pain beyond imagination and immeasurable grief just by existing or by stopping breathing.

It doesn't seem fair. Deep inside Adora's heart, she wishes she could hate her.

“Why?” Adora asks, sore, citric in the edges, speaking for the first time again to the celestial beings to whom she has not spoken to in years. “Why her? Why now? Why are you doing this to me?”

She stares at the quartz and rock ceiling and, as always, all she receives in return is silence. Heavy and overwhelming silence. Faint drops of freezing cold water fall and splash on her face, running down her cheekbones and the end of her chin like lost tears.

Adora has not cried in such a long time. Days, weeks that turned into moths and then bleed into years. Her skin has been torn into pieces here; by sword or spear or arrow. Her face still bears the scars of the mask that almost drowned her to death, that she tore from her own flesh with teeth and nails.

“Have you not taken enough?” Adora presses, wrinkling the fabric of her tunic between her fingers, digging her nails on the skin of her knees and dragging down. The snakes hiss

uncomfortably around her temples and the base of her nape, coiling with pain when she raises red scratches in her skin. “Answer me!”

Her yell echoes across every single inch of the cavern, the strength of it making the fine dust of stone and status to crumble down quietly into the harsh floor. It rains over Adora´s face, dusting her clothes and staining her face in white, a mocking mirror of the sun make up she used to wear when she wasn't a beast.

“AHH!”

Adora screams, frustrated, slamming her fists against the rough earth. She hopes it breaks in the middle, that the entire cave splinters in half and crumbles down fully over her, but the rock remains as it has been for hundreds of years, unmovable like a mountain underneath Adora´s fingertips.

This time, when Adora screams, it is full of anger, of hatred, of grudge. She digs her nails against the loose stones and the granite and tears them apart herself until all of her nails splinter and break in half and beads blood starts to gather on the ends, staining her skin with red.

It aches and Adora gasps around the sharp pain but she keeps going, throwing the remains everywhere around her, kicking it away and cursing at it. She goes on and on, so loud in her rage that she is almost quiet, drowned out by the emptiness of the cave until the underside of her eyes is raw and red and there are new found scratches on her palms and cheeks.

But, just as the gods, the stone is silent, a quiet display of the prison Adora has been subdued into. It hurts Adora but it is by her own hand, and when she falls quiet and lets herself fall over the earth, the stone receives her again, shivering just a little under her murderous gaze.

The statues of the people she has murdered, assassins or not, stare back at her with their soulless and void eyes, judging her silently, for how does Adora dare to even wish to want, to be able to have?

After everything Adora has done to survive, nothing beautiful could ever be given to her in return for that. And Adora is not capable of creating anything beautiful either.

The snakes hiss softly over her forehead, escaping from the restraints of the veil, and Adora pushes them away, digging her sharp nails over their bodies until they lay still and quiet again. She doesn't care that their pain feels like an extension of hers, she doesn't care about the golden ichor dripping off them.

It is nighttime by the time Adora walks inside the cavern again.

She is careful when she gives the small jump from the hidden entrance to the evergreen floor, moving purposefully louder. The coin bracelets held to her ankles, right above her leather sandals, make a loud jingling sound every time she takes a step, announcing her arrival.

The cavern looks as it has been since Adora discovered it. Green grass spotted with patches of blue and pink moss; healthy fungus in the edges where humidity tends to gather and the

ceiling twinkling with tiny lights that she has never known if they are fireflies or trick of the eye from the stone.

Stone walls covered in quartz and long lines of green leaves that travel from the line of thick trees that have managed to find their way to grow inside this place. Three over the furthest wall of the cavern and two at either side of the entrance showered by both light and shadow the same. Their thick crowns create their own kind of temples and palaces in the air, right below the open domes and further away from what Adora has ever dared to go.

The floor is covered by soft fallen leaves and pebbles, making their own kind of paths towards the edge of the crystalline blue lake, mud surrounded and quiet under the moon's light. The waterfall is calm too, with its never ending flow that never floods this place but that keeps it breathing it alive.

Things are mostly as Adora remembers them, early on the day when she did not know how drastically her life was going to change again. The fire of the resting place is extinguished but the cushions are neatly placed, half to the side and half to the other, its humble fabric of red and copper a sharp contrast against the green of the rest.

The huge loom Adora had built with her own hands is still to the side, closer where she stands right now, untouched with the half finished piece of plain and long cerulean fabric that falls where Adora was weaving.

The abandoned temple is as it has always been, quiet and lonely, yet there is something different in it now. All the oil lamps and torches have been blown out, shut down by a quiet mouth and making the place drown itself in darkness.

Even from this corner of the cave, Adora can see something has changed in there. The previous marble columns are scattered with green leaves and sprouts of life, colorful flowers grown out of the nothing from the very base to the ceiling, where thick handfuls of lilac flowers hang heavy and in full bloom. The wisteria tree that makes the bed has sprouted, heavy with seed and bursting with life and color.

No flower ever grows here, not even once, yet tonight the whole cavern is scattered with them, tiny, huge, light as a feather and ponderous in purples and red and yellows. Every single path where C´yra has walked through is covered in blooms, following her steps in their own kind of trails.

Adora exhales, closing her eyes for a second. She hates, she wants to hate, to be who they have accused her to be, but she already finds herself following the sprouts, walking next to them without getting to crush them at all. The bracelets jingle but they make soft sounds, a kind meant to notify and not scare with its proximity.

Cushions and blankets have been left next to the cold pyre, carefully folded one over the other. They are Adora´s, the ones that were on the bed made of living branches and some others too. It is a quiet courtesy, a silent gratitude for hospitality meant for Adora to keep herself warm to sleep too.

Adora glances at them sideways and sighs deeply, turning her eyes towards the temple and walking again. It's not long until she finds herself right in front of the entrance, her feet shifting over the tilted steps.

What are you doing? Adora asks herself as she gives a step forward, into a space where once she slept and where now another sleeping body lays. *Turn back.*

Walk forward, another part of her seems to say, one buried deeper. The one that makes Adora stop in front of the tree bed and extend her hand towards the fine fabric hanging as a canopy around it, light as a feather on her fingers.

Adora parts it in the middle like parting the torrential rain with her fingers and looks inside, down towards the bed where a body rests.

She has changed from her torn clothes, C'yra, out of the fabric soaked in dirt and blood, and into one of the chemises Adora left for her, wheat colored and simple.

There are more clean bandages around her soles and palms, matching the one Adora had placed across her shoulder, barely holding back from trembling uncontrollably.

She is, however, still wrapped in one of the fabrics she had arrived with, a hemation of a red so deep that it almost looks like pressed grapes, waved in beautiful patterns of flowers and constellations. It is also cut open, sliced in places where the thread threatens to give away in any second, but she curls inside it like a lifeline, her nose buried among the fabric. And she is asleep.

Adora observes her in silence, counting the seconds under her breath, still expecting that her freckled dark skin will turn into stone any second. But it doesn't. Adora sighs and steps back, letting the fabric fall closed between them again.

She turns around and takes her leave but a hand stops her. Loose fingers around the hem of her tunic, barely holding her in, softly woven on the white tunic.

“Do you know me?” C´yra asks behind the canopy, hidden among the fabrics. A question, a silent plea.

Yes, Adora could say, so easily. *Below my closed eyes, beneath my eyelids, inside my dreams, like music,* she could say, like a promise.

Adora could give in, let the floodgates open and hope her heart doesn't break. Surrender. Love her. Hate her.

Right above the open domes of the cavern the November moon is red.

“No”

(...) There is an ocean so dark down below the waves

Where you watch while these dreams gently float away

And there is a silence so soft it's only memory

Like the way your voice always sounds when you sing to me

But I can't hear it now

Just tell me how to keep breathing while pretending I'm not drowning (...)

– I Can't Hear It Now, **Freya Ridings**

Chapter End Notes

Hope you enjoyed this chapter! Sorry for the final angst, it caught me right after I watched act 2 of arcane and I was bawling my eyes out :')

Comments, kudos, bookmarks and shares are deeply appreciated, see you soon! Be good

Verse IV

Chapter Summary

> "You are chaotic, like a newborn star inside this place. Your own very sun skipping over my stones. I'm just the void left when one dies"

Chapter Notes

> Hello! Welcome to a new chapter!
>
> Thank so you much everyone who has tagged alone on thi ride and all newcomers, I´m very grateful for all of you. And thank everybody that commented, I can´t always answer because of time managment but I read everything, so thank you <3
>
> Lets dive then a little further on these girls love story. The slow burn is burning I´m getting restless but I´ll have to endure it. See you downstairs :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse IV.

Stone Paths

For you were lonely

You were like me

Like some outside force had sent me

If I was easy to kill, you would have done it already

– Paris Paloma, *Hunter*

[Music x x x]

… There is plague on the earth. Pestilence. Rot …

Red skies, cold air, the death of the crop and the cattle and the dryness of the waters. And where there isn´t green life, there are insects and where they are, there is sickness, meant to make the world bend …

… Nothing beautiful grows anymore, nothing tender, the light ripped off and the colors with it, submerged in perennial darkness. The kind not even the green fire of torches is able to push away

There is war, on the skies. There is war on the earth, over five years now. The time passes by to the man and with it the battle and the greed. But the hunger, the hunger roots deep, and it settles with iron force against the world once the daughter of the gods is gone

Maybe this is why the gods punish the world or maybe it is a mere excuse, one of thousands, for the gods to play their games with living souls. Maybe it all comes from a heartbroken grandmother, or a sorrowful aunt, or because of protectors filled with rage …

Maybe it wasn´t meant to be, this destruction, but the threads of destiny choke their way even around the gods' throats. Or is it because the lovers weren´t meant to fight this war.

… There is plague and there is death, bodies fallen into the earth and the skies red … Men die, not all of them, sometimes not the one that deserves it, but they also must abide by the Fates in the end …

The gods don´t mingle in human affairs, they musn´t, but they do in the end. What is a cave, after all, if not godly clay?



Catra is used to nightmares. She is not used to night terrors.

She trashes in bed and closes her eyes until her head and her jaw ache, even asleep, and sleep fights with herself. She tangles herself with the sheet and her mother´s hemation and never remembers what she heard or felt during those dreams. She knows it's bad or maybe that is just what her heart feels, very deeply, the void staring back at her where she cannot possibly distinguish it.

What she knows is that she wakes up with a jolt and a half knotted scream nestled in her throat, soft light tickling on her closed eyelids where it slips through the fabrics hung from the bed. Her breath is always elaborated, choked on the back of her tongue, and her cheeks are always wet and clammy, testimony of nights of tears of sweat from the bad dreams.

However every time, when she wakes up, silence is not what meets her. She hears the rush of the waterfall somewhere next to the temple and the fall of the drops over the lake in the middle. Every once in a while, she thinks she hears birds singing, flying inside the cavern through the ceiling, chirping and making a home on the living branches scattered on the walls.

It reminds Catra a little bit of home, waking up in the middle of the night to the sounds of the wheat fields and the river just outside her window. Here though, the air smells a little bit like wisterias and a little bit to salt, swirling differently yet somehow all familiar inside her nose. It mingles and melts together with the scent of lemongrass.

Every time, Catra tries to recover her breath in silence; and every single time, she tries to ignore the soft jingling sound coming from somewhere on the corners of the cavern.

Catra closes her eyes tightly and clicks her tongue against her teeth, letting herself fall over the ripped edges of her mother´s hemation. She wraps herself on it as tight as she can and tries to ignore any sound coming from outside the temple.

When she falls asleep again, there is void all around her. Strange and unfamiliar void. And just before she falls asleep she can help herself but wonder if maybe something terribly bad is happening outside the stones of this place.



Catra spends exactly three days sleeping off her injuries and ignoring the world before she gets sick with herself and kicks herself up again. Her mother did not teach her to be self persevering and smart for her to be rotting over blankets and quietly eating meat and figs.

Catra carefully feels her way across the temple until she finds what once would have been the cella of the temple, feeling the rough edges of crumbled stone with her toes and fingertips and into the naos.

It is much colder back there, and the light gets immediately eaten by the privacy that the columns give, but is a much better place for Catra to undo the knots of her chemise and change into a cleaner one, quickly lacing it around her waist and shoulder before stepping back.

She has gotten so much better at walking around the temple´s limits in these three days. She can find the bed easily now without stepping into the wrong loose mosaic or banging her toes or her head against the tree branches that make the bed.

When she reaches the middle, she allows herself to fall over the blankets, undoing the errand braids around her temples to lace it all together into something much practical, over the back of her head, her nape and neck,

She knows the movements to it, repetitive and easy for her as everything else, a skill she learnt from early age and that now helps her to keep her curls from brushing against the back of her thighs every time she moves.

The stitched and freshly patched up wound on her shoulder blade aches deeply, pulling from her skin every single time she moves. So ache the deep scratches on her soles, padded by bandages, but she grids her teeth and bares them with a shrug.

Somewhere outside the temple, Catra can hear the soft movements of the woman, walking in and around the cavern. She wears the ankle bracelets ceremoniously, day or night; Catra knows this because she can hear the jingle of them even in her dreams and at first light in the morning, moving softly and easily around the place.

Catra hums, knotting the last stripe of fabric around a thick curl next to her temples. She searches then for the folded fabric next to her hip, her mother´s hemation,, running her thumb over the soft edges.

Her mother waved it for her when she was very young and her sight was in the last strands of its strength. Catra partially remembers the blurred shapes Io´s wove on it; the length of stems, and the teardrop fall of petals and the sharp ends of stars clustering the fabric in a whole universe made of touch alone, something Catra would get know the rest of her life and find comfort in it.

Now it is sliced in half and in ragged places, hanging by the strands where someone pulled from Catra when they were dragging her outside the house, and plainly cut open by the end of something sharp when Catra tried to run away before being taken here.

The cuts run right in the middle of several of the figures Io made, and the feeling of it makes Catra want to weep again, feeling deep in her chest as if they were cutting against the memory of her mother too.

Catra has long ago gotten tired of tears though, and she clenches her teeth as hard as possible before standing up with the hemation in her hands.

The buried steps of the temple are a little bit cold but the grass and moss surrounding it are warm, and there is a soft smell coming from everywhere around Catra. She tilts her head to the side and leans down, sitting over the steps peacefully, right between the temple and the rest of the cavern, filling the earth crumbling soft around her toes when she rests her still bandaged feet over it.

Catra follows the smell, leaning a little to the side until her nose crashes very softly against the soft petals of a poppy, making the pollen of the flower fly and stick itself directly against Catra´s nose. Catra tries to hold it together but she has always been a little more sensitive to pollen than any farmer or daughter of a farmer would, and she sneezes without being able to help it, rising like an echo across the whole place.

Somewhere in the middle of the cavern, a jingle and a soft sizzle follow the sound of Catra´s sneeze, letting know of her presence on the temple steps to Catra´s cavern–companion.

Catra sniffles, rubbing the back of her hand against her nose several times until the itch leaves. She waves away the cluster of poppies brushing the ends of her curls and returns her hands towards the hemation, softly pulling from the ends to learn the cut better.

“Do you have a needle and thread that I could use?” Catra asks into the cavern, knowing she will be heard.

Silence answers her back, as every single time that Catra has tried to start the bare minimum of a conversation and was met by nothing in return.

It makes Catra sick but she pushes through, waiting patiently on the steps. She could be met with nothing all over again, and frankly, Catra is not quite sure what she would do then; maybe scream.

But then she hears the soft jingle of the bracelets moving again, around some place and moving trinkets around. Then back again, finally starting to approach her after a few minutes.

Catra holds her breath, her eyelids still closed, face tilted towards the fabric still in her hands. Even like this golden light floods below her eyelashes, tickling on her skin and trying to cooe her into opening them again. Catra keeps them closed, hearing as the soft jingle stops a few feet in front of her and then leans down, something soft falling on the ground before the jingle walks away again.

Catra waits until the soft sound stops, far away from her again, and extends her hand down, brushing the edge of a thread roll placed over the moss right in front of her feet and sharp end of a needle carefully dug on the side of it.

“Thanks,” Catra murmurs, bringing it to her lap. Only silence and coin bracelets answer her back.

The thread is thick, spindle made by the way the fibers cross over each other and cotton made by the texture. It is also slightly rough, something nobody else would have noticed but that tells Catra that the thread has been carefully dyed. And it occurs to Catra that while she might not remember what colors used to look like or which ones were used by her mother's hands, the silent woman can see them and can know which one is missing from the torn threads.

Somehow, the seemingly gentleness of the gesture makes Catra´s ears drop, pressing on the sides of her head.

Catra grabs the end of the thread and patiently runs it inside the needle, feeling the ragged edges of the intricate patterns. She knows them by memory, from years and years of running her fingers over them when Io used to wear the hemation over her shoulders and later when Catra were to wrap it around her body to keep herself warm. She can follow the designs and embroider them closed.

Catra starts running the needle inside the fabric when her foot catches on something else placed on the floor and much more warmer to the touch than simply thread.

Catra grabs the clay bowl from the floor and brings it to her nose, breathing the warmth of the steaming stew inside. Creamy, heavily vegetable smelling and grease textured from shredded meat, hot on her fingertips where she holds the bowl in front of her face. Just the scent of it makes Catra´s mouth water.

She lowers the plate back down, resting it over her lap and the hemation with a sigh.

“Have you eaten too?” Catra asks, grabbing a spoonful of the stew. She searches for the warmth of one of the oil lamps resting over the steps of the temple and lets it fall against the trembling fire, silently murmuring a prayer.

The woman sighs, moving near to what Catra thinks is the lake, her feet and bracelets rising with them the sound of soft splashing and damp earth squished underneath her weight. Catra presses her lips closed tightly together and hums, not even trying to keep away the scowl off her face.

“Whatever, then,” Catra mutters, tilting the edge of the bowl against her lips and drinking from the rich stew, biting back a pleased trill when the hot liquid warms her throat and chest from the inside out.

Annoyance has started to sit heavily right against her ribs, mingled thick and rotten with the sting of the rejection of any kind of companionship and her own hubris. Tears dried on her cheeks and her mother´s hemation.

Catra has been alone for a long, long time and even in the years she wasn´t, she always felt the sharp edges of the void on the side of her heart. And after twenty five years, she has come used to it, to this.

If the dreams she so fiercely prayed for are to abandon her so brutally, so easily, she will have to grind her teeth and try to breathe anyway. Pain will overwhelm her but she will survive it, for now.

Outside the cavern the sky thunders again but no rain falls down again. Instead a single soft petal falls against her forearm, tremendously tender and frail, tickling her skin.. Catra frowns, searching for them with her fingers, but it comes undone the second she touches it, staining against her finger like powder.

When Catra brings her palm towards her nose, she thinks she can smell the scent of old fire, but gets drowned by the heavy smell of the stew and in the end she forgets it over the gentleness of the embroidery and the sound of the water.



It takes Catra exactly one week and three days to realize that she is not going to get an answer back.

“I swear this amount of food cannot be found inside this place. Are you giving me all your food or what is happening here?”

Silence

“Thank you for the clothes. Aren't you cold?”

Jingle. Silence

“Are you sleeping in the rocks or where on earth are you sleeping if I'm taking the only bed?”

Silence. Silence. Silence. Inamovible silence.

“Fine, don´t mind me then”

It also takes Catra one week to realize that she might actually be going insane, because she opens her mouth to talk and once she starts, she doesn't seem to be able to stop.

“How big is this place? There is a lot of light”

“Fifty steps from the temple to the waterfall and fifteen from the waterfall to the lake. And if that branch grows and throws me to the ground again I'm setting this place on fire”

“Rocks. Moss. Rock, grass. Moss. Flower! And more rocks”

“So your plan is to what? Vow silence for the rest of your life? I swear I´ve met Priestess with less determination because you take the fucking win.”

“One pebble, two pebbles, three pebbles”

“You snore”

“Fifty six pebbles, fifty seven pebbles. I´m going to pile them here.”

“There was a woman on my village who was a bitch, I hope she chokes on her wine”

“One hundred and five pebbles, I can keep going”

“This is a loom. Do you wave?”

“Hey! Where are my pebbles?”

“Did you know that I memorized the song of the Orpehus myth. I still remember it, maybe I should practice it now”

“Hello! Echo!”

“Sing O´muse the music of… Orpheus”

“I appreciate your bracelets but have you thought that you kind of sound like a walking sistrum?”

“Do you know why he turned around in the end?”

“And that one singing is a hummingbird, and that one a nightingale. Oh and that one an owl, who shouldn't be here because they are carnivores”

“Because to turn around is to love”

“Where is all this meat coming from?”

“I know a lot of songs and poems. My nana taught them to me. She was *not* a bitch like the other one but she was a little weird.”

“You snore like really loud”

“And then she waited for him. Twenty years. Twenty years waving that damn shroud, for a *man.* ”

“Are you digging on the earth? What are you doing?”

“I kind of want to blow something up”

“Echo!”

“Is that a mouse?!”

“Echo!”

“Nobody in their right mind would wait so long for someone. But I guess that's love or whatever.”

The morning of the eleventh day Catra is tired. Perhaps it is because she has had practically no sleep or because in the moments where she could slip into unconsciousness it was plagued by darkness, pounding in her head and the back of her eyelids like freezing water.

Perhaps it is because she has gotten exhausted, worn down after days and days of speaking to the breeze and having nothing but the echo to answer her back. Today her throat is sore, scratched and rough and it aches on the base of her throat and tongue, too heavy for her to even touch the plate of fruit still placed on the steps of the abandoned temple.

She is sitting by the edge of the lake right now, her knees pressed tightly against her chest, bare soles deeply dug inside the soft earth below the fresh water. It is a little bit colder today inside the cavern so Catra hugs herself, crossing her arms across her legs, and she can feel the tips of her hair soaking into the water too where she did not bother to hold it up.

Today Catra is in silence, her mind miles away from her little spot next to the underworld lake. She sits quietly over the pebbles and hears the woman´s loom moving around softly, the wrap beam from where the threads are held making a soft sound every single time the knots and quiet patterns are placed together.

It should be a calming sound, familiar, but for some reason today it just makes Catra mad, anger boiling in the back of her throat until it spills out of her mouth.

“So is this how this is going to go? Me sitting here and you hiding from me without speaking?”

The loom stills, silence falling heavy inside the cavern. Catra waits, again, not the first nor the tenth on these days, chewing on the inside of her cheek until her entire face is numb.

The water around her feet is a constant, as persistent as the ache of her injuries that are still taking their time to heal. The soft jingle of the coins is wavering, unreliable, Catra never knows when it is to move carefully around her and if Catra was cursed; or when it will remain silent like right now.

“Don´t ignore me, I just–” Catra cuts herself short, clicking her tongue against the back of her teeth, starting to feel more and more annoyed with herself instead. “Fuck”

The movement around the loom changes, the soft brush of the coins twinkling together when she moves her feet and the almost invisible sound of her chair giving away the change of her posture.

“I´m sorry"

This is the first time in eleven days that she has spoken to Catra. The sound of her voice is so sudden and so familiar at the same time that Catra jumps on her spot, her skin immediately rising in goosebumps.

And she sounds so…apologetic. As if treating Catra like an errand spirit inside this place truly, from the bottom of her heart, ached her. Like a weight she was placing on herself, self-sacrificing. Catra fucking hates it.

“Is apologizing the only thing you know how to do?” Catra barks, unable to hold her tongue.

The woman takes a sharp breath, the wood of her loom falling loudly against the soft earth when she lets go of it, hurt. It's nasty, it cuts, the way the words echo with misplaced grudge.

Catra shrinks into herself immediately, biting into her bottom lip until the skin gives away and it opens slightly, stinging across her entire mouth. She feels the shame of it the second the words cross her lips, covering from the head to the toes.

“Gods.” Catra whispers, letting her face fall against her knees. “I´m such a fucking asshole. I ´m sorry. I–”

Catra´s voice dies of her throat just as her words, tucking herself tighter inside her mother´s hemation and the bed of the lake. For a long moment, the chirping of errand birds finding their way inside the cavern and the waterfall are the only things between them.

Catra is not even waiting for an answer anymore when she hears the soft jingle of the coins changing from position, a gentle sigh coming off the woman's nose after several more minutes.

“I guess… I'm just afraid of you,” she says, heavy on her tongue when she pronounces the words, like admitting defeat.

Catra hears her clearly but she still doesn't raise her head from where she has hid it, her tail lashing nervously behind her and her ears tightly pressed at the sides of her head. She wants to understand but the noise behind her eyes is louder today, making her dizzy and angry and

terribly saddened today. Sorrowful for the weight that seems to burden the quiet woman somewhere meters away from her.

“Afraid?” Catra repeats, huffing. “I already told you, I'm not going to hurt you. I'm not going to open your throat in the middle of the night or guide those men outside down here. I would never do that.”

The woman remains silent even after Catra has gone quiet again, the cadence of her breathing and the sound of her bracelets as the only reassurance that she is actually really there. That Catra is not hallucinating about her presence in the cavern; that Catra is not actually alone in this place.

It brings no comfort for Catra anyway.

“Murdering me is not the only way you can hurt me, C´yra.”

Catra shivers from head to toe, thrown off the axis of her world the second she listens to this woman's voice molding itself around the syllables of her name. The affirmation makes her confused, afraid, scared of the silence and the distance, all the things Catra hates the most in the world.

“What is that supposed to mean?”

It´s sad, this interaction of them, this life they have built in the past days. A life where they are so much worse than strangers, so much burdened than exiled people. Catra tried so hard to distract herself for days and days in a row but not for a single second she failed to feel sharpness around her chest.

“Why do you want to know me?” The woman questions, softer. All about her sounds softer and so beyond reach.

It is like being inside the dream all over again but completely different, in a world where Catra cannot pass through the invisible barriers placed all around her. She had been let fall right next to an unapproachable soul, something Catra wants more than anything in the world but that seems to hate her in return.

“You smell like lemongrass,” Catra admits, finally, in a breath, because putting the truth on the open burns less than holding it in the base of her belly.

Catra thinks that she will understand, this woman. That she will understand the meaning of Catra's words no matter what she said that very first night.

But even if the woman does understand, she is like a mountain, like this cave, like the stone. Unbreakable and cold.

“I can't,” she says. “I´m sorry,” again.

Something inside Catra's chest grows bitter, acid to the touch. She gulps it down like reflux and tries to ignore the sadness and turn it into anger, into grudge instead.

She stands up in a rush, her feet slipping a little on the mud. She opens and closes her hands several times and bites down the panting in her chest, clicking her tongue against her teeth with a huff and a chuckle so void of any kind of joy that it is as dry as sand.

“Honestly, what did I expect?”

Catra turns sharply on her ankles, making her way across the mud and towards the temple, not even being careful to feel where she is going or how. And it eventually comes to bite her in the ass.

Her foot catches on the errand branch on the floor from before and she falls against the ground, hard, ripping a huff and a whimper out of Catra´s mouth.

Startled noise comes from behind her, things pushed away and hurried feet standing up but Catra can barely hear it above the ringing inside her ears, pain and humiliation burning inside her eardrums.

Her chin is throbbing and her knee screams in pain with the pull, traveling sharp and quick across her entire let and the arch of her feet.

Catra huffs, sputtering the grass she had eaten by falling and pushing herself into her palms. She can feel her ears twitching violently at the sides of her head, burning from the base to her scalp as she stands up in wobbly feet, trying to save the most of her dignity as she possibly can.

She can still hear the elaborate breathing of the woman several meters behind her but Catra pushes it away, biting into her tongue and walking the last of the distance towards the temple.

She ignores the fruit in the steps and the fire on the oil lamps and stumbles among the soft fabrics of the bed, burying herself and any other noise from the cavern inside them.

She thinks she hears a pained sigh outside, but Catra covers her ears with her palms and wishes for a second she had never be given dreams at all.



There is blood on the dead grass. The men taking guard outside of the cave are dead, their throats gaping open and their bodies left to rot, for the crows to feast on them and away from any kind of burial form.

Adora can see them from the spot where she is hiding into, behind thick stone and the sharp thorns of branches, squatted and covered by the shadows of the stone around her.

It doesn't matter anyway, there is nobody else here but her and the dead bodies, not an unnatural recurrence for Adora but shocking anyway. She is not used to blood that isn't hers, she is not used to violence that was not directed towards her body. Seeing these two people dead by a stranger's hands is unnatural and it manages to make Adora afraid.

Outside, in the world, the sky is virulent, red and purple and deeply dark. Clouds swirl above her head and condense tightly, menacing with the weight of lighting breaking them in half every once in a while and painting the world in purples and blue colors.

It's so violently different to the inside of the cavern, alive and green and covered in blooms, that Adora has to hold her breath, retreating back inside her prison that suddenly feels like the only safe spot left in the world. At least, for a monster like Adora is.

Adora grabs the handle of the wheat basket filled with meat and thread and turns into her ankles, leaving a frail trail of owl feathers behind her.

Adora walks among the ruins of the stones easily, purposely stepping on the crumbled debris until it digs painfully against the soft leather of her sandals, a perpetual reminder of the damage she has inflicted.

She presses the tip of her fingers against the newly formed blisters on her hands and feels the earth drug below her fingernails, cleaning the sweat and errand dirt from them against the wheat colored fabric of her chemise. They leave dark marks across the folds but Adora ignores them, swiftly jumping inside the corridor that leads towards the open cavern.

It's quiet today inside here, and it is unbelievably hot too. There is perspiration immediately gathering on the back of Adora´s neck the moment she jumps inside again, the fabric of her clothes sticking to her legs and waist below the leather belts that keep it in place.

Even the plants inside seem to be feeling the weather, their leaves and petals covered in dew just like they look like with the may´s rain. Slightly bent on the stem and exhaling oxygen where the heat and the falling water collide together into fog.

The cavern is silent too, from voice or song or any other sound. Adora walks carefully inside and roams her eyes inside before daring to give a step forward, the bracelets on her ankles jingling with each other with every single step.

She glances towards the temple, narrowing her eyes towards the fine fabrics of the canopy hanging from the branches but it is empty. the oil lamps blown off and the windchimes made of lake pebbles softly making a sound with the hot breeze. The seating circle with the cushions and the cold fire, the loom and even Adora´s improvised bed on a far corner of the stone wall are empty too.

Adora narrows her eyes, nervously biting into her cuticles as she looks precariously towards the waterfall. With the passing of the days, Adora has come to learn a little bit about C´yra´s usual routine, like the plate of figs she likes to have in the mornings and her sitting to embroider the edges of her broken hemation at midday. Like her praying at night on her makeshift altar inside the temple, for which Adora can see the twinkle of the lit candles from her spot on the other side of the cavern, or singing herself to sleep inside the canopy.

By now, Adora knows that she prefers to bathe at night, so Adora knows when to step out, every single day at the same line of the moon against the rock. Which, for Adora, who has always enjoyed to bathe under the waterfall at irrational hours of the dawn, is convenient and it allows her to be quiet as she moves around the cavern.

It doesn´t come as a surprise then to find the waterfall empty too, the water falling calm and constant over the earth. It does however dig a deep pit inside Adora´s belly, anxiety making its way sticky and nasty around the length of her bones.

Adora is aware of what she has been doing to both of them the past fourteen days since C´yra ´s arrival. Pushing each other further and further away until they couldn´t possibly be more distanced from each other. Be cold and uninterested and quiet even if inside of herself Adora was burning up from the inside out. Adora is aware of all of this, all the bridges she has been burning before they could even be properly talked about, and why.

It doesn´t mean that fear does not bloom inside her chest when Adora fails to find C´yra skipping her way around the green grass, panic seizing on her throat as if suddenly the gods had decided to punish her again for being ungrateful and had extended their hands through the open domes of the caverns and snatched C´yra´s warm body for themselves.

Adora rushes with her breath held across the cavern, uncaring if the sound of the coins at her feet make her abysmally loud. She has C´yra´s name already tangled in her vocal cords by the second she reaches the edge of the lake, barely avoiding the shallow lines in the earth that Adora had dug with her own nails, and looking inside the crystalline water.

C´yra is floating in the middle of the lake´s water, over her back with her arms extended to the sides and her hair displayed long and wet against the surface. Her toes barely peek outside the water and she is soaked from head to toe, peacefully floating with the soft flow of the lake and the leaves on the lotus that bloom around her fingertips and her ears.

Adora bites back a relieved sigh and finds herself locked in place, spell casted by the sight that is displayed so freely and trustworthy in front of her.

C´yra´s hair around her beautiful face makes her look otherworldly, specks of gold scattered among her freckles and the skin of her eyelids and lips like godly powdered brushes over her dark skin. Even soaked she looks tender, fresh like the blooms around her but also sharp, something smart and strong swirling in the way her cheek curls into a dimple and her fingers caress the water like a lover her body had not met in a long time.

The fabric of her chiton is soaked through too, marble white over the richness of her dark skin. It sticks to her ankles and the soft curves of her waist and belly, opening like butterfly wings around her forearms and colliding around the soft fall of her breasts.

If Adora looks just a little bit closer she would be able to distinguish the rose shade nestle in the chaste curves; she would see the cadence of her chest as it moves gently up and down with each breath, forming seiches on the water; and se would be able to lay her eyes on the secret freckles nestled on the fall of her collarbones, marking their own kind of constellations over her open body.

Adora snaps her head away sharply, frowning to herself, She digs her nails into her other hand´s cuticles until drops of blood gather in the edges and clicks her split tongue against the back of her sharp canines, cursing herself under her breath.

Adora is fucked, but that´s not new.

“I'm not dead,” C´yra says out of nowhere, her eyes still closed. “I just like to float”

Adora stumbles back a little, tripping with her sandals. She looks at every single side of the cavern except for the lake, rubbing her knuckles against her cheekbones hard to try and drown the warmth already crawling over them.

“Um”

“It's really hot in here,” C´yra keeps going, drumming her fingers over the tension of the water. There is a shade of deep red on her cheeks that Adora manages to catch when she glances quickly towards her, ripping her sight away immediately after.

“You–”

“I'm not running a fever, I´m not crazy and I´m not trying to drown myself,” C´yra cuts her

Her tone is still edging into something soft but much more guarded than the days before. The difference does not go unmissed for Adora.

“It's just hot,” C´yra says, the corners of her eyes wrinkling softly when she sighs. “And I'm tired”

Adora finds herself, unsurprisingly, unable to say anything at all. There are so many words swirling inside her chest, so many that she is desperate to say to her and that only manage to choke her when she bites them back.

Even the gods forsaken snakes embedded to her head sizzle uncomfortably, trying and failing to move inside the tight confinement of the scarf under which Adora had knotted them all together to keep them away from touching her skin.

She hates herself already, she does not need another constant reminder that no matter how much or how desperately she might want something she is not able to have it. That she will always be the monster of the tale that will be forsaken and betrayed all over again for the people she loves the most.

Adora already lived through that, she already had to learn and even then she barely managed to survive. Doing it again would murder her, it would break her irreparably. Adora cannot do that again.

Even with her hands filled with mud and dearth underneath her nails and blisters on the heels of her palms, Adora won´t give herself the luxury of falling in love. Those dreams were meant for somebody else, someone that Adora is not anymore.

Adora turns around from the lake and starts making her way back to the shallow cuts on the floor, flinching when the errand rocks find their way inside the straps of her sandals. It hurts a little but she has been through many kinds of pain already, a stone on her shoe will not make her fall to her knees.

She can hear, however, the soft sound of water splashing behind her, moving around and damping the earth at the edges. Adora tries to hold back from looking behind, she digs her

nails inside the soft flesh of her palms and narrows her eyes to a random point of the stone wall, but she is unable to resist the pull. Like a moth to a flame that she knows will consume her completely if she gets too close.

Moonlight eyes meet her when Adora turns her head back, already waiting for her. Half of Cy´ra´s face is inside the water, the crystalline liquid brushing against the side of her nose and her forehead when she tilts her head to the side to follow the direction of Adora´s steps. Her eyes are unfocused, searching among their sightless stares for the sound of Adora´s body, eager even in their silver blindness.

Even like this, even not looking at each other directly, Adora cannot help but to gasp softly under her breath. She is suddenly so taken aback by the way they are seeing her, holding her among clouds and sounds without even needing to look at her directly that her world feels like spinning completely from its axis.

Adora stumbles and tears her damned eyes away again, ignoring the earth so she can hurry towards the whole of her improvised bed instead. Perhaps it´s cowardly of her, perhaps she really is nothing more of a coward unable to move forward. Or perhaps she is too wounded to allow herself to step into the light again.

C´yra sighs, very low under her breath and returns her head towards the open dome of the cavern from which the golden light of the sun showers over her like a holy curtain. She closes her eyes again and hums, dipping her entire head and body below the water to chase away the ache of the light against her eyes.

Catra has wound up into singing lately. Which could very well be just a sign of boredom or another spiral of her going absolutely insane.

It starts as a hum, a soft murmur on the base of her throat when the night closes too tightly around her and she is unable to go back to sleep without wanting to scream. ream. The vibration of her vocal cords starts as an unconscious effort, following the notes of melodies Io used to sing to her when Catra was still very little and the nights were loud and unknown for her young ears.

Catra does so until the humming becomes lullabies, and from them full songs, echoing across the columns and the ceiling of the temple and stumbling their way down and into the universe of the cavern, notes and words mingling with the natural sounds of the earth and the running waters.

On most nights, they don´t manage to make Catra fall asleep again, but they do help to calm down her raising heart. Catra lays awake over the feathers of the bed with her eyes half closed and plays a game of putting a name to the shapeless shadows dancing around her, flashing errand colors over her irises before she grows annoyed and closes them completely.

It´s a thing she does, almost every single night of her days living inside this cavern. A familiar kind of game that she repeats to herself to avoid drawing herself crazy with the

forced solitude and the rejection. Sometimes it annoys her and sometimes it makes her bored but she clings to those nights like a line of salvation; to the words of her mother and the sound of her own voice, things that will never abandon her no matter what.

One night, however, Catra realizes she might not be the only one holding herself to those lullabies. One night she realizes she might not be the only one screaming inside her dreams at night.

It occurs, as most things since Catra was placed here, almost as an accident. It´s a night where Catra cannot fall asleep no matter how, not even to have nightmares. She lies upside down, draped between the floor and the bed with her arms around her head over the cold floor, biting into her lips until she feels them chip with irritation and has to forcibly stop herself.

Catra is quiet from the very beginning that night and she clicks her tongue against her teeth into a huff when she pushes herself up, levering herself in her palms and knees and pushing herself to stand.

The nights are hot here, they always are, but the moss and grass are colder when Catra steps over them, a small mercy from the water that runs across the entire length of the cavern, refreshing it all. Catra relies on this chill as she makes her way towards the edge of the lake, more careful now that she knows exactly where the roots grow and where the leaves of underwater lilies are more slippery.

She intends to dip her feet inside the water, sit over the damp soil and remain here until exhaustion reaches her finally or the start of the sounds of the dawn make their way inside, whichever comes first. Among the quiet and solitude of the sleeping cavern, soft sounds push their way inside Catra´s sensitive ears before anything else.

Catra freezes in her spot, her chin still leaning against her knee when another sound echoes towards her, a little higher than before; and then another, more desperate in the edges. At first, Catra thinks the woman is talking to herself in the middle of the night, but when realization reaches her it makes her heart shrink.

Catra knows this kind of sound well, shivering like the skin of her shoulders, something quiet in the middle of the night when you cannot push it back any longer. It's the sound of crying, low and inside restless dreams, sleep fighting your way across unconscious desperation and helplessness.

The woman of the cavern is crying on her dreams, fighting alone against whatever is that plagues her dreams and making her whimper sadly in the middle of the night.

There is an unspoken line inside the cavern that divides the both of them. A line that goes beyond the fireside, which is neutral space just as is the waterfall and the lake. It cuts them cleanly in half, separating Catra´s temple from the loom over the smooth rocks of the floor to the entire other side of the cavern where Catra knows the woman has made a lair to sleep.

That is where the sound comes from, among stones and fabrics and reaching Catra sitting next to the lake, a silent plea of help into a place that Catra is not sure how to reach. Beyond

her sight and beyond the unknown paths of a cavern she still has to learn, Catra doesn´t know how to cross the invisible line and she is not sure the woman would want her to, not even for the most fearful of dreams.

Catra tilts her head away from the sounds, biting into her cuticles nervously until she feels them sting and she has to force herself to lower them down. She doesn´t know what to do but she does not know that leaving this woman to fence for herself on the night is breaking her heart as if the dreams were digging their way inside her own chest.

Very slowly and under her breath, Catra starts humming again. It picks up and up until it becomes a full song, still whispered between her teeth but there and sincere, echoing alongside the sobs, not drowning them but accompanying them.

Catra knows she must be acting crazy and desperate and maybe even stupid, but she refuses to think anything about it at all. Not now. Right now, he doesn´t have to think, right now she just has to sing like Io used to do for her; sing and hope is enough.

The night keeps passing above the open domes, Catra can distinguish the change of light above her head but she remains here, in this small place next to the quiet waters, humming until it becomes a second nature for her. She doesn´t even realize when the sobs calm down and profound breathing replace them and she doesn´t get to see when eyes open from now quiet dreams and focus on her.

From that night on, Catra sits on the edge of the lake or the temple or her bed and sings out loud every night.



She is going to get herself killed, it's what Adora tells herself for the fifth time as she makes her way across the back of the cavern.

She is going to step over a loose stone and fall and rip her skull open because she has absolutely no regard for her own well being, so that is exactly why Adora has to follow C´yra down here like a shadow, just to avoid that she does something absolutely reckless and hurts herself.

A perfectly good excuse, right?

Adora saw her march from her spot next to the loose earth as C´yra´s bare soles were sure and almost angry as she stomped past the stream line between the waterfall and the edge of the lake, and completely towards the other side of the cavern. There where the three trees grow huge and endless and where their roots raise the earth in unknown paths filled with treacherous holes and trembling rocks and who knows what else. Adora has never dared to adventure more than what the end of the walls gave her.

Adora fell twice in her rush to try to stand up and follow C´yra at the same time, so quickly that she forgets to lace the coin bracelets around the ankles of her sandals and knot the beasts around her head into their usual restraints.

In a way, crossing the line of the waterfall feels like a huge deal, like breaking some kind of barrier that Adora has placed around herself years ago when she first stepped here and the trees were not a sign of hope but another layer of her cage.

Getting near this side of the cage filled with taller grass and shadow was never an option for Adora, not knowing all she would find below the green leaves was salt and stone and nothing else. In a way, it made her afraid, the knowledge of the unknown just beyond her reach, the fear of new things that could hurt her beyond the arrows and swords and her own nails.

It was logical, or so Adora thought, for anyone to be weary of that darker side of the cavern with unknown sounds and movements on the crowns of its trees. Yet here is this woman in front of Adora, skipping her way across a place she cannot even see but seemingly unafraid of stepping wrong or falling again.

In fact, C´yra looks almost happy around here, kicking the loose stones with the heel of her foot, and with her ears twitching as she follows the sounds of birds flying by her head before reaching the tallest side of the cavern where she cannot reach them but can still hear them.

The red fabric of her tunic is wrapped tightly around her body, crossing across her torso and knotted with belts around her waist. The long skirt of it is kept away from her feet safely, tucked into the hoops and rings hanging from her belts and avoiding for C´yra to accidentally step over the hem and trip as she climbs her way over a root as thick as her forearm and lands into the other side with a soft jump.

She has carefully styled all of her hair into fine braids, which she holds over her head with a maroon headscarf, adorning them with golden rings on the ends. She looks beautiful and also kind of flustered, huffing with her cheeks red as she bends down and shakes errand dirt off her knees.

“I can hear you following me,” C´yra says out loud, her back still turned away from Adora. Her tail moves lazily behind her. “You are not exactly quiet”

Adora cringes, rubbing her forearm with her hand. She can feel herself starting to grimace with the shame of being too clumsy, and the fucking snakes must feel it too because they circle Adora´s forehead and nape anxiously, Adora can hear the start of a hiss next to ears, curling tightly around her temples.

Adora digs her nails inside her palms to make them stop and tries to take several deep breaths, still staring like an idiot as C´yra tilts her head towards her with a scowl, her pretty eyebrows frowned already with the expectation of Adora´s persistent silence.

Adora bites into her split tongue until it hurts, forcing herself to give a step forward over the mushy moss below her soles. Her voice is still tangled on her vocal cords, sore after so long without using it, but she pushes it out too, tasting the words around the roof of her mouth.

“The cavern can be dangerous if–”

“If you can't see?” C´yra cuts her off, colder than the winter rains. “I'll manage, thanks”

Adora can´t help herself when she hisses with the sharp edge of C´yra´s voice, the rejection in it slapping her plainly on the face. She knows that she has made damage to whatever this is before it could even begin to take root; that she has dug it out of the earth and tried to the same off her heart with her bare hands, painting the distance between them with silences and steps at the other side of the cavern.

Adora made this between them, unsure and precarious like the broken stone.

But then again, Adora is weak and she is still human in some part of herself. And she knows C´yra sings at night.

The snakes sizzle and cling closer to Adora´s head but others start reaching forward, blindly seeking for C´yra´s presence among the game of light and shadows around them. They have no eyes but they can smell the sandalwood and lemongrass off C´yra´s skin and Adora has to grab them around her fingers and pull them harshly to keep them away.

Adora gulps, running her tongue over her dry lips to try to speak again. “But–”

“I want to know the rest of this place. I´m sick of walking in circles and I'm bored.” C´yra snaps, running her fingertips over the rough bark of a root that curls next to her elbow. C´yra clicks her tongue against the back of her teeth, angrily turning her head away and renewing her walk among the grass. “And anyway, you don't want to have anything to do with me, isn't it? I don´t know how any of this is your business”

Adora´s heart sinks inside her heart, her entire skin locking into a goosebump. There is an acid taste pooling on the back of her tongue, a little bit like venom and a little bit like the start of tears that never get to truly form.

“I–”

“So, if you excuse me again, I have places to be”

The ground below their feet is cushioned by the moss and the grass but every once in a few meters there are holes on the earth, made by the roots and the erosion of the past rains, hidden enough by the cover of leaves and shadows that you would barely notice them unless you were directly above them.

Adora thinks about it for a second, just one and then she stops thinking completely, following her instinct for the first time in years. She jumps the root too and gets as close to C´yra as she has gone since the first day when she stitched her shoulder back together. A copper skin that Adora can see through the folds of the red fabric where C´yra keeps her back turned to her, the edges of the past injury raised and lighter in places; a patch of almost rose white against a waterfall of sunlight that makes her back.

Adora follows C´yra and it almost feels familiar, like chasing something she knows well but she had almost forgotten inside these walls. In a way she thinks that's exactly what this is but she does not dare to put a mind into it.

“There is nowhere else to go,” Adora repeats, her eyes dancing between C´yra´s feet and the ground and back to her face.

“For *you* , you may say. For me, I have a long way to learn about this place. But why do you care?” C´yra´s chin is tilted forwards, her back straight and her feet sure but distracted, not paying attention where she is stepping or going for the rush of walking away and fast. “Besides, it is not like I was hoping to have a conversation with a self righteous, goody two shoes, emotionally unavailable assh–”

“Wait!”

Adora sees C´yra´s foot hover directly above a hole on the ground, waiting in darkness to swallow it whole and make her fall. Adora reaches for her as a second nature, something known to her like breathing, but in the end it is not her arm that brushes sharply between them, the nuzzle of a golden snake bonking C´yra directly in the middle of her forehead.

C´yra gasps, jolted away by the surprise. She gives a small jump to the side and freezes, still too close to the hole for Adora´s liking but not moving anymore. She freezes, her silver eyes opening wide and her mouth opening a slit.

Adora grabs the snake by the neck and yanks it back so hard her own scalp hurts, wrapping it around her fingers and wrist to keep her in place. The snake protests, opening its huge fauces and nibbling at her fingertips as it tries to set itself free and reach for C´yra again but Adora grunts, gasping as she shakes the head and throws herself back until her shoulder blades crash against the root.

C´yra blinks once, thrice, finally tilting her whole body towards the space where Adora was. Her elegant eyebrows are so high in her forehead that her expression looks almost comical, a mixture between shock and atonement that curls around her cheeks into a profound blush.

“Did–?” C´yra exhales, licking her lips nervously. “What was that?”

Adora curls around herself, holding the gods-forsaken snake against her chest. The damn thing sizzles softly on her palms, the white spot on its head shimmering a little as it pushes against the heel of Adora´s palm.

“I'm sorry,” Adora stutters after a second, kicking herself for the way her voice sounds so broken, desperate and shamed out of sudden.

C´yra shakes her head, her arms falling softly at her sides.

“No, I–” Her forehead twitches, confusion eating away any other emotion swirling around her factions. “Did you– did you just head bumped me?”

“It wasn't me,” Adora rushes to say, biting her tongue when she realizes what she is saying. “I mean, it was me but–”

Adora´s voice dies down, buried by how stupid she thinks she sounds. The shame eats its way around her throat like rot and choke her out of all of her words, the only sound lingering

in the still cavern being the soft sizzle of the snakes running their way across her hands and head.

C´yra lifts her eyebrow, pressing her pretty lips together as she thinks. Suddenly Adora really wishes that she will drop the matter completely, that C´yra will deem Adora insane or plainly annoying and turn around again and leave, even if it will only put more distance between them.

Anything, whatever needed just so C´yra does not realize the reality of Adora´s beastility, of her ugliness and the true weight of her curse. That she will not realize that Adora is not only cursed and a murderer but also how deformed she has been left to die here. That C´yra does not learn the kind of monster she has been left with.

Existing around her being able to hide just how horrible she has become has been a small blessing for Adora. But now, the first time that she has dared to step closer to her again, all of it feels so precarious again, so close to crumbling down into nothing that it makes Adora so scared and ashamed that she might actually throw up.

C´yra´s moonlight eyes are miles away from Adora´s thoughts though. Her smart though sightless eyes flash a little when she narrows them, tilting her head towards the place where she was just about to step into and the back towards the direction where she can spot Adora´s voice.

Very carefully, C´yra hovers her feet in front of her, her pretty toes and ankles dangling dangerously close just inches above the darkness of the hole. The hissing of the snakes picks up immediately, echoing loudly inside the space between them no matter how hard Adora yanks desperately from them.

C´yra drops her foot back into firm ground, letting her eyelids fall closed again and sighing deeply.

“What´s on the floor?” she asks, very calm. So much calmer than Adora, who is practically curling over the root and scared shitless, seems to understand.

“Uh, It's a small hole,” Adora answers automatically, still staring at C´yra´s face, filled with confusion and panic for her reaction. “You could break your ankle”

“Alright,” C´yra nods, shrugging.

She is not screaming, *why is she not screaming?* C´yra is not flinching away with disgust nor scowling with contempt not tilting her face towards Adora with absolute repudiation. In fact, all the contrary, she looks almost relieved as she nods, back into following the sounds around them as if nothing had happened at all.

“Alright, I´ll be more careful.” C´yra starts turning around again, resting her palm over the wall of the back of the cavern and following the tiny branches that grow there, safely away from the hole. “Thanks”

“I–”

“Not to *you,* ” C´yra adds, tilting her head just enough for Adora to catch the edge of her grin before she is moving away again.

Adora flusters from head to toe, closing her mouth so hard she accidentally bites herself, making her ears ring like temple bells. The snake hisses pleasantly though, curling over Adora´s forehead and sizzling happily as it nudges on her skin.



Things get a little more bearable after the incident with the ground. At least, as bearable as Catra can handle for now.

They are still not talking, not like normal people would do, but the woman stops walking around Catra on her tippy toes and even once, just once, Catra hears her sit at the other side of the fire and eat in silence the foot on the plates.

She still keeps herself away, as away as possible, but the air around them stops reeking like indifference and fear and starts feeling lighter, like the clouds once a lightning storm has passed and you are allowed to step outside and face the drizzle against your face.

Catra is aware that she could feel tense around her, that she is allowed to. That maybe even she *should,* to be more careful about her interactions and words. She is aware that she does not have the full truth yet but that she is close, and that truth could be frightening for some, disgusting for others even. But Catra has never done what anyone else has told her to do.

And the thing is that, instead of feeling more weary or suddenly afraid, Catra feels like she can breathe better. As if now she has the proof that the person existing inside this place alongside her is actually not a ghost but flesh and breath and bone. Someone who exists, who feels and who can feel both pride or shame. Someone who is deeply burdened and who makes Catra´s heart ache inside her ribcage.

Somehow, this new found knowledge that Catra has stumbled into by accident allows her to realize that maybe indifference is not the exact feeling brewing between them; that maybe Catra is not being pushed away for being insufficient or wrong or unwanted but all the contrary. Maybe dreams are not useless after all.

Catra still sings at night. And every once in a while, during the quiet days, she thinks she can catch an errand hiss followed by a rushed, almost panicked, shush under a breath. It makes Catra smile, secretly and still quiet, following the paths of the snake´s bodies she embroiders on her hemation with her fingertips.



Adora has lost C´yra.

Like, quite literally. She was next to the lake one second, Adora looked away for one moment and when she looked back she was gone. Completely.

She is not on the waterfall or the fireplace or the temple; she is not floating peacefully on the lake like she likes to do when it's too hot in here; and she definitely not on Adora´s side of the cavern, which only leaves by logic that she is somewhere around the trees, except that Adora cannot see her there either.

Slight panic starts to cover Adora´s chest as she drops the marble cane she has been polishing the last five days and jumps over the trail of smooth stones and past the stream of the quiet water, following the invisible paths C´yra had done just a few days back. It's midday and the sun lingers right above the domes, raising humidity that sticks to Adora´s shoulders and the back of her nape underneath the veil.

Adora steps carefully around newfound covered holes, filled with fresh earth, searching on every single corner and crevice and finding nothing in return. It does not help the sudden alarm settled inside Adora´s chest, fear and shame for that fear nestling around her throat and ribcage.

What if she left? This beautiful woman with light feet and sweet voice cursing roots under her breath and braiding her hair at the edge of the lake. What if she is actually gone, after all the silence Adora has made her go through these days? After telling her over and over again that she could leave?

Now that the silence comes from C´yra, Adora finds herself about to go insane, just by these simple minutes without the sound of her body in the cavern. Is madness, Adora hates every single second of it.

“C´yra?” Adora mutters, unable to speak louder than a whisper as she reaches for the very back of the cavern.

There she steps into the quiet space that lives right below the trees, in secret pockets between the humongous trunks and the stone wall covered by moss and fungus, stealing the breath off Adora´s lungs the second she lays eyes on it. These are places Adora didn´t even know existed until now, and that probably would have gone unnoticed and untouched if it wasn´t for C´yra wandering here and Adora following her behind.

Here it seems to exist another kind of world, completely secluded to the rest of the cavern. The grass is blue and purple in some places and from it other trees grow, fruit trees of the most diverse variety, scattered around each other in harmony, almost in a perfect circle.

They have made the perfect greenhouse here, made of bark and branch and leaf, painting the floors and the crows of their cups with heavy fruits that fall ripe against the grass or hang pretty against their branches. So much more than the ones Adora already knew existed in here.

The grass over which she steps over is scattered in figs and apricots and pears; pomegranate and persimmon and plumb. Adora walks among them and barely avoids stepping over a bush heavy with berries, a twig breaking below her sole when she catches sight of the small group of red and golden apples neatly placed against a patch of moss in front of her.

Adora blinks down at the fruits, still out of words when the branches above her head move softly, calling for her attention in the way it moves the shadows against the floor. Adora tilts her head backwards, biting back a surprised gasp when she finally finds her among the leaves.

C´yra is sitting in one of the thickest branches of the orchard, the blue skirt of her chiton tangled around her knees where she balances herself as she searches for the fruits hanging around her head. Her lap is heavy already with ripe apples and her frown slightly furrowed with concentration, silver eyes shimmering a little with the sunlight that manages to reach in here, covering her and the trees in golden light.

Her ears twitch when Adora´s weight makes the dry leaves below crack a little, regarding Adora´s presence with a swift flick of her tail before she stands up on sure feet and starts making her way even higher among the tree.

Adora panics a little, stepping right below the apple tree with her hands twitching at her sides.

“What are you doing?” Adora calls, obviously winded as she watches with her heart of her throat as C'yra grabs a branch and pulls herself up swiftly.

“Climbing!” C'yra calls back, undoing the knot of the hemation she has wrapped around her shoulder like a satchel and dangling it at her side. “Catch these!”

The warning is nice but Adora doesn´t really understand until the whole fabric and the fruits fall over her head, bouncing against her forehead and scattering all over the soft floor at her feet where the apples roll over each other and then away below the bushes.

“Ouch,” Adora mutters under her breath, rubbing the sore spot in the middle of her forehead.

She narrows her eyes as she looks at C'yra, easily stepping from one branch to the other, feeling the edges of the fruits with her fingertips and sniffing from their stems before pulling them free.

“Are you sure you're blind?” Adora grumbles, her jaw falling slack the exact second she realizes the words she just said. “I- I'm sorry- I–”

“I'm quite sure of it, thank you,” C’yra answers easily, waving Adora's panic away with a shrug.

Adora is still dwelling on how dumb she feels by the question when C’yra let's go of another apple, this time crashing directly against Adora's nose, successfully ripping her off the spiral of her thoughts.

“Ow! ”

“If you don´t catch them I can´t help you,” C'yra chirps, tilting her head and grinning. “Are *you* sure you're not blind?”

“I– ouch! Hey!” Adora kicks on the ground when another errand apple brushes her ear and then a second one crashes fully at the top of her head. Suddenly she is way more annoyed than worried, the sheer irritation making her cheeks bloom with a blush. “You are doing that on purpose!”

C’yra has gathered a bunch of apples on her hands while Adora complained, ignoring her completely as she holds them up and promptly lets them go unceremoniously towards the ground.

Adora catches three of them swiftly on her hands but the fourth one betrayers her, bouncing over her nose and making her drop the three apples two on the way when Adora tries to bat it away with her hand.

Adora grumbles, snapping her head up to complain loudly again. C'yra is already tilting her head towards her, wearing the most shit eating-fucking self sufficient grin ever seen, making even her silver eyes flash with divine mirth.

“I admit railing you up is quite entertaining, yes,” C’yra admits, shrugging with one shoulder.

Adora's jaw falls slack and then she laughs, *she laughs,* loud and honest actually *laughs* out loud with incredulity, shaking her head and looking at the apples and back at C'yra as if she couldn't believe her eyes. It echoes in the small space between them, the trees and the stone walls, sweet and from deep within the chest, a sign of happiness that Adora has not met in a long time.

She has not laughed in years, not a single time, even before the gods decided she was the one deserving to carry the blame, and not the people that had betrayed her or the man that had cursed her.

Adora has not laughed in so long that she didn´t even remember the sound of her own voice when it did, or the way it would feel on the middle of her chest, tugging from the cords of her heart like one would do to the strings of a lyre. It feels exhilarating and at the same time completely overwhelming, stealing the breath off Adora´s lungs the second she realizes what is happening.

Adora clears her throat, narrowing her eyes at nothing in particular before risking another swift look at C´yra still hanging from the tree branches.

C´yra´s lips are curled into a quiet smile, leaning the side of her head against the trunk of the tree. She considers Adora for a second, her ears twitching a few times against the side of her head as she thinks.

“Hmm,” C´yra hums, shifting her weight over the tree. “I'm coming down”

Adora watches her as she feels the edge of the tree and the curves of the branches and holds herself tight to it. Adora holds her breath, her hands twitching nervously around the surface of the apples as every single nerve in her body tingles with the preparation of catching her if she slips.

“Close your eyes.” C´yra calls before even moving. “I'm a lady and I don't want you looking below my skirts just yet”

“But”

“Close them”

Adora does, because for some reason she seems unable to deny C´yra of anything, which is definitely going to be a problem sooner or later.

Closing her eyes around sunlight feels nice, actually. Like the caress of a blanket that falls around her completely. She can hear the leaves and branches of the tree moving softly as C ´yra climbs down and the chirping of the birds somewhere above their heads, their song mingling with the far away waterfall. It also makes her realize that has never allowed herself to close her eyes just for the need to seek calm in the quiet until now.

She used to dig her nails until her irises until golden ichor was dribbling down her fingers and cheeks just to find them healing themselves right after. And then she used to tie rope around her face until even breathing was elaborated, but it only brought uncountable wounds from swords and arrows in return. And at night, when she goes to sleep, the nightmares are always there right below her eyelids.

There has never been comfort for Adora in closing her eyes, but today it feels lighter, softer. It makes her a little bit more tender and a lot more scared.

A soft finger appears out of nowhere and pokes Adora directly in the middle of the forehead, ripping her off spiraling dark thoughts. The sudden touch of another skin against hers makes Adora jump softly, drowned by a low chuckle right in front of her face.

“You really did close them, that's sweet.” C´yra mutters under her breath, smiling from ear to ear.

She takes her hand away immediately and she looks beautiful under the golden light next to Adora, red and golden and clay all around her.

Adora gasps, staring at her pretty face in awe and without knowing what to say before her mouth finally remembers how to function again.

“How– um, how do you know I did?”

“You wouldn't have let me almost poke you in the eyes if you had seen my finger coming towards you. Especially because I really didn´t know where your face was.” C´yra shrugs, undoing the knots that keep her skirt up and letting them brush back against the ground. “Or maybe you would have, which is also sweet. And kind of dumb”

Red blooms against Adora´s cheeks and she bites on the inner side of her mouth until it stings, shuffling on the floor covered with grass and fruits and flowers.

C´yra´s hair is very long, even inside the fine braids, brushing on the small of her waist and curling around her hips. It shimmers a little, as if she had been dipped in golden powder

instead of the Styx river.

“Your apples,” Adora whispers, brushing the fruits against C'yra’s forearms. C’yra shakes her head, shaking dust and pollen off her hemation.

“No thank you, they are for you,” she chirps, almost like a song, slipping on the grass past Adora's side.

Adora blinks confused, once, thrice, her eyes following C'yra's waist and the fall of her shoulders as she walks away. “But then why–?”

“I just wanted to check something,” C'yra turns around for a second, her long eyelashes casting golden shadows over her freckled scattered cheekbones. “Thank you for looking for me”

It feels like an inside joke and also like honest gratitude. And a secret third thing that makes Adora flush, her heart hammering violently against her ears. Something about Adora that Adora doesn't know but that C'yra seems to know deeply.

Adora looks at her walk carefully around the roots and then back towards the waterfall, following hesitant unknown steps and trying not to fall.

Then Adora looks down, towards the fruits in her hands. Round, ripe. Delicious red, so deep they look almost like wine; golden dusted under certain lights, the shape of fingertips on the root and stem.

Gazing upon them feels like a gift from love itself, something sweet on the tongue and completely dooming at the same time. Troy instrumental, woman blessed.

Adora rests her lips over them but doesn't bite.



Catra pulls from the last thread and cuts it clean off with the tip of her nail, leaving the soft roll behind her with a huff. The long hemation draped over her lap, the last thing Catra would ever have of her mother, sat finally mended completely, the swirls and soft designs over the fabric familiar against the pads of Catra´s fingers.

In a way it feels like a beginning all on itself, her fixing the tears and holes on the fabric with a new kind of thread, probably most different from the original ones that Io wove on her time, but that had managed to fix it anew all the same.

Catra sighs, thumbing the edges of the hemation, letting her eyes open just a slit, enough for golden light to pour below her eyelashes and eyelids. it tickles a little on her cheekbones, golden and silver pecks against her irises and scleras where the embroidery of the hemation should be. It makes her sad, for a long second or for a long life, it makes Catra sad that she is not allowed to see it.

She brings it towards her face instead, burying her nose and chin against the soft fabric, taking a deep breath out of it. If she closes her eyes very hard , she thinks she can still smell the lingering smell of apples and the sandalwood from her mother´s skin, the memory of her home surrounding her in the blanket she barely saved from being burnt.

Soft steps stop right behind her, the gentle jingle of the bracelets accompanying the equally quiet breath that comes with it. It hesitates a few steps away from her, lingering over her shoulder as Catra remains as still as possible as to not scare her away again.

“It's beautiful,” the woman whispers, awe clear in her voice but still contained, hesitant as she exists in Catra´s space.

But she has broken the invisible line, the tense piece of thread between their sides of the cavern that she drew between them and that Catra has been patiently waiting for her to cross. With her sandals knotted with coins and her sizzling echo around her head.

“Thank you,” Catra hums, letting her eyes fall close again. “My mother was a weaver. She taught me many things”

“Do you weave?” The woman asks, more bracelets jingling. They must be around her wrists too, adorning the skin there and that Catra can only hear.

“I do. I was well taught. It fed me through many nights.” Catra tilts her head a little to the side, aiming for a secretive grin and managing only a sorrowful smile. “I guess I never thought how much you could miss something once you have been ripped out of it.”

She hears the woman take a deep breath, holding the air inside her lungs and then letting it all free in the spac between both.

“Do you want to?” The woman asks after a second, echoing sweetly inside Catra´s sensitive ears.

It takes Catra more than a second to understand. She places the hemation back against her lap and turns to the place where she feels the woman standing, frowning in the process.

Catra doesn´t make it to ask her what she is talking about, though, because she hears the woman walk away and then immediately come again, dragging something with her in the process.

It´s a loom, Catra realizes as she stands up and extends her hand carefully in front of her, her fingers brushing the newly cut wood of the instrument. It smells good, fresh, like the branches of the trees that have fallen by the pass of time or the roots that grow near the foot of the lake. And it is huge, taller than Catra who is a little bit short herself and thick, with the starting lines of thread already held on the top and bottom of the wood.

Catra gasps, getting closer and feeling with her feet as it crashes softly against something that feels very much like knotted fibers of wheat. When Catra leans down to touch it she recognizes the round edge of a basket and the softness of the thread rolls inside, neatly placed in a single line for Catra to feel their textures and learn their order.

“Tell me the colors,” Catra urges, suddenly out of breath.

Her head is buzzing with the significance of what this means, this huge demonstration of kindness gifted to Catra after such a long time of hesitation. She wonders if it means something for the better or something that will only make her more lonely.

“From your left to right. Chloros, glaucos, kuanos, rhodos, phoinos.” The woman says carefully, giving several steps away.

Catra bites into her own tongue until it stings and focuses on the thread rolls, carrying the ones she wants and starting to knot their ends to the guides already placed in front of her.

She does not remember what colors used to look like, but she remembers their textures, their softness, the way they might or not scratch over the skin and how much tension and warmth they can keep in their threads.

And most of all, Catra remembers the motions, the way her fingers move around the ropes and the wood of the loom and they bride and braid together images she cannot see but that she can feel. The constellations, pieces of the universe that guided her through life before all she could see was light and all Catra could remember was the swirls of their magic thousands of hundreds of millions of miles beyond her, looking back at her and etching their starry reflection to her irises forever.

“Wow,” the woman whispers in wonder, stepping a little bit closer to Catra´s side.

Catra bites back a smile, shrugging a little without stopping her motions across the loom.

“I wasn't always blind,” Catra explains, resting her palm flat over the tense threads, “My mother always spoke of it as either a blessing or a natural occurrence of life. And I knew she was doing the best she could for me to navigate through it, but sometimes I just hated what it made me lost”

Catra exhales, knitting her eyebrows together with concentration.

“But I'm much older now, I´m not a child anymore. Losing my sight was nobody's fault and I ´ve come to understand that what happened to me also has given me something more, maybe much more important than I understood before.”

“What did it give you?” She sounds unsure, tethering on a fine line that Catra places in front of them with her words.

Catra tilts her head to the side, smiling softly, a kind of secrecy she holds inside of her and that she doesn't know if the woman understands just yet. She doesn't answer but she thinks she doesn´t need to either, in the way the woman's breath hitches in the edges and her coins shiver a little, her sounds all around Catra and her smell so close against that is fills Catra´s lung with lemongrass.

“Where is your mother now?” The woman asks when the silence stretches between them, maybe seeking to cut the thread or to walk around it to avoid how overwhelming it feels.

“She died,” Catra answers truthfully, placing the thread rolls back into the basket and stepping back when she feels her hands shivering harder than what she can contain.

Pain floods inside Catra´s chest, the memory of Io´s loss still fresh inside her head and heart, even after too many years have gone by. She will never be able to go a day without thinking of her, and will never burn the meat and fruit and flowers on the candle's wax without praying for her to listen too.

Even with so much added loss, even with so much tragedy, there are just certain things inside Catra´s heart that she doesn´t seem to be able to mend, to stitch together again or to embroider together. The void remains there, flooded with light that escapes through the cracks if she doesn´t pay attention.

And Catra wonders if this woman knows that, if she is able to see the loss and the sorrow scarred in every inch of Catra´s face. If she knows that Catra carries her in her prayers every night too, like a little miracle herself that refuses to be touched.

Catra wonders if it matters at all.

“I want to show you something,” the woman murmurs, ripping Catra away from dark thoughts.

Catra´s eyelashes tickle against her cheekbones where her eyes shift below her eyelids, matching the fast beating of her own heart hammering inside her ribcage. “Alright”

Catra turns around, remaining still and a little hesitant when the woman doesn´t seem to move further either. For a moment Catra even considers if the woman has actually forgotten than Catra cannot see her but then the smell of lemongrass invades her nose, overpowering everything else inside this place.

“I'm going to have to touch you,” the woman whispers right next to Catra´s ears, followed by the faintest of sizzles right behind.

Catra holds her breath, barely keeping herself from either laughing or breaking into cries, so suddenly eager and desperate for even the slightest of the phantom touches possible.

“That's alright. I don't bite,” Catra grins with a shrug, trying to bury the true nature of her feelings with playful banter. “Most times”

A chirp of a bird echoes inside the cavern and a stray light of the sunlight falls over Catra´s face and then she is being touched, carefully, softer, more tender than she has felt in her whole life.

The hemation of her mother is gently placed around her arms and the back of her waist and then a long palm rests over it, laying flat and just a little bit hesitant over the fabric as it guides Catra´s body across the still unsure ground of the cavern.

Catra follows because there is nothing else she would rather follow right now than this, than her, this woman who still refuses to touch Catra´s skin at all costs, walking her past moss and

grass and errand sharp rocks that have dug their ways one too many times over her soles.

The slightly colder air of the cavern's entrance falls over Catra's face, a striking contrast to the humid warmth she has become so used to in the last weeks.

“This is the entrance,” the woman says, indicating Catra where they are even if Catra doesn't really need it.

“Yes,” Catra nods, “I know because it's colder”

The pressure of the hands around her waist and forearm shifts, and even below the thick fabric it makes Catra shiver from head to toe.

“Step a little bit to the side,” the woman instructs softly, her hands leaving Catra's body completely. “Feel carefully with your sole”

Catra frowns but does as she is asked for. She gives a hesitating step to the side and then forwards, resting her weight fully over the ground.

The bare skin of her sole meets moss, then grass and then there, *there,* softness, slightly colder than the rest, mercifully steady. Smooth and deeply dug in the ground and also familiar, purposefully donde in long lineas across the cavern.

Catra didn't even notice the pebbles were gone from around the edge of the lake until now.

“Stones?” Catra opens her eyes, light filling every corner. “It's a path”

“They are lake pebbles. They are soft for your feet,” the woman gulps, audibly, her bracelets shaking when she does. “I buried them inside the moss”

“You made me paths?”

“They reach basically all the sides of the cavern where you go. I– I watched you walk around and guided myself from there.”

The woman's hand moves again, this time very softly resting against Catra's. Catra holds her breath, her fingers twitch and wrap around a smooth surface when the woman places something inside her palm.

It's like a spear almost, long, also smooth, marble and definitely hand made. It extends in front of her and carefully helps her feel the extension of the stone paths. A cane for her to guide herself without falling again.

A shaky breath, Catra cannot move.

“Your temple, the fireplace and the waterfall are to the left.“ The woman moves Catra softly, hiding her sole to step across the lines where the paths divide. “Lake and your loom in front of you, and beyond that your trees“

Yours , as in pertinence, as in belonging.

“You've never gone to the right and I'm grateful for your respect, but it's also yours to walk around if you want. The second loom is there, and– my bed is there too”

“You made me paths”

“Yes”

Gods. But then again, maybe this beautiful being living in the light that fills Catra's eyes is something much more tender than a god. Much softer and much more dearer.

“You didn't have to do this,” Catra's lip trembles and she doesn't even try to hide it this time.

All the feelings that had been quietly gathering up on the base of her throat, below annoyance and desolation, finally pour out, still standing over the stone paths with her bare soles.

“I know I'm– I know I basically forced you to let me be here, and I have been fucking annoying for days and a burden to your safe space.”

“No. You have not,” the woman interrupts, her voice still soft above it all. “You are– chaotic, like a newborn star inside this place. Your own very sun skipping over my stones. It's strange after being alone for so long but you're warm.”

Catra damps her bottom lip with her tongue, pressing her sharp nails against her palms.

“And you? Aren't you also a star?”

“I'm just the void left when one dies.”

There is a soft tug at Catra's side, in one of the errand pieces of fabric from her dress; almost like a hand tangling around it and pulling from the edge softly.

“I haven't been fair to you these days. It's not your fault being trapped here. And you haven't done anything to deserve me being cold towards you.”

Catra inhales deeply, holding the air inside her lungs, still keeping her eyes open to try and drink off all the warmth the light can give her today.

“You said you were scared,” Catra whispers, sighing, tension unfolding off her limbs little by little. She can still feel the smooth pebbles below her feet. “You asked me to respect it and I- I can understand that. It's not easy, trusting again.”

Soft breath hits her face, close, very close and then away again; lemongrass and fresh mint leaves. The laces of Catra's tunic are still being softly tugged, a nervous stimming to keep calm.

“I was a twin once,” the woman whispers, her voice soft, her voice broken. “My brother was a kind man”

Catra can't help herself when she smiles, the twitch on the corner of her lip sweeter than the storm she feels unleashing inside.

“I figured”

“Why?”

“Because you are a kind woman”

The woman grunts, something that sounds more pained than angry. “C’yra–”

“I'm Catra,” she shakes her head, errand curls brushing over her nose and face. “Just Catra”

The woman holds her breath, letting go off the hem of her dress. And Catra misses her immediately, like a second heart beat.

“Catra,” the woman repeats, rolling the syllables on her tongue. “Catra, would you still want to know me even after knowing all that I have done? All that I've had to do to survive?”

It would be so easy for Catra to say yes, yes, *yes*. To throw herself on this woman's arms and vow unconditional devotion. In a way Catra knows she has already sworn herself to her, heart and soul no matter what, that no matter what she might say Catra will still cradle her inside her ribcage all the same.

But she also knows this is not what the woman needs right now. And in a way, she also knows it's not what she needs either. The path there needs to be built with patience, just like the cane in her fingers and the stones below her feet.

“Tell me your name,” Catra asks instead, and she knows this time it will be granted.

“I'm Adora”

“Adora,” Catra repeats, a sun blooming in her chest. “Can I ask something of you?”

There is a nervous shuffle and then a very soft sigh. “I– alright”

“Don't push me away,” Catra pleads, feeling the pressure inside her heart. “If you don't want to us to be friends or acquaintances that's alright, but don't push me away please.” She takes a breath, the silent confession seizing her around the throat. “Silence scares me”

She can hear Adora inhale sharply, maybe surprised, maybe pained too, maybe she can feel what Catra does inside her heart.

“I can do that.” Adora hesitates, her heart beating so hard that Catra can hear it too. “Can I ask something of you in return?”

“It's only fair” Catra nods, shivering without even realizing it.

There is a second of silence and then Catra can feel Adora move. She can feel her fingers holding an errando curl off Catra's face and placing it softly behind her ear, still avoiding her skin the whole time.

“But you need to promise it”

Something sadder cover Catra's chest, a little bit like dread and a little bit like shared sorrow.

“Alright,” Catra agrees after a beat.

Adora sighs and steps away, letting go from her hair.

“Don't fall in love with me”

Es la historia de un amor, como no hay otro igual

Que me hizo comprender todo el bien, todo el mal

Que le dio luz a mi vida, apagándola después

Ay, qué vida tan obscura. Sin tu amor no viviré

– Historia de un Amor, ***Luis Miguel (cover by Paty B)***

Chapter End Notes

NOTES: Chloros (chartreuse yellow-green), glaucos (greyish turquoise), kuanos (navy blue), rhodos (reddish pink), and phoinos (reddish orange)

Thank you so much for reading! I wonder if you caught on who is leaving the meat and thread and killed those guards :3
Comments, kudos, suscriptions and bookmarks are deeply appreciated. See you soon, be good.

Verse V

Chapter Summary

"The sun, at the center of everything"

Chapter Notes

HAPPY NEW YEAR!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse V.

Blue Birds

شجر الزيتون (the olive trees) مربوط في الأرض (are rooted in the ground)

والشمس تحميه (& the sun protects them)

والشجر المحروق (the burnt trees) بضل (stay standing)

الحب بسقيه (they're watered by love)

والنجم (the stars) والقمر (the moon)

والمي (the water) والبحر (and the sea)

ما بنسى من وين أنا جاي (I won’t ever forget where I come from)

عصفور طار بالهوا وعلى ايدي (a bird flew in the wind and onto my hands)

– *Yafa,* **Lana Lubany**

The owl tilts her head to the side, turning and turning until it is almost completely bent in half, staring with unmoving eyes at the entrance of the quiet cave in front of her.

The tree she is hanging upon almost snaps in half with her weight, the branches and trunk creaking and barely holding on as the owl leans her entire body forwards, staring at the

decomposing bodies of the men over the ground.

Rot, dead, it has already placed its claim over the corpses, eating its way inside and out from the limbs and guts that have been feasting the scavenger animals for the last days. Ravens and vultures but owls too, huge too, children from the one that blinks slowly at the scene from her place above the ground.

The owl moves then, heavy and at the same time so light that the air doesn´t even change. Her neck stretches, past bones and muscles and flesh, past what is supposed to be possible, stretching and stretching long enough until it's almost as huge and mighty as the tree she holds herself onto, hovering it´s ethereal look across the forest just so she can look a little bit closer.

The human mask she wears above the feathers cradling her face shifts a little, like an expression almost, cheekbones and nose and hollow eyes placed above her head like a theater mask. It mingles like poured gold against the back of her neck and falls in droplets that become feathers across her wide chest and long arms, the claws on her paws wrapping around the woods and leaving wide marks behind.

The feathers make their own kind of gown for her body, cradling her, protecting her, making a nest for the serpents that travel across the bend back shoulders. These last circles all over her neck and torso, an armor yes but also a reminder of wisdom and artfulness, waving tapestries over the godly skin of her legs and soles.

This is her helmet, when she is like this in her true form, too magnificent and horrid to be seen by mortal eyes. This is the way in which she presents herself, void of any kind of human resemblance as she is none. A goddess of strategy and war and wisdom and arts, watching in silence as the entrance of her favorite devotee reminds dark, as she always does when she drops the meat and the thread for her to feast and work.

Mingling with the mortals is prohibited, sister. I trust you know that as you were the one that placed that rule

The dog emerges from the trees around her, dragging alongside him the steel smell of battles and the perfumed scent of sea flowers. The goddess turns her owl eyes towards him, watching as he stands below her dripping gold neck and sits down, dark eyes staring at the scene too as his vultures screech in recognition.

There are hands wrapped around his head, across the forehead and the nuzzle, closed now as flower petals, the dark skin glistening with golden rings and bracelets that drip with sea pearls from the temples to the neck and the rest of the body. A gift from his sea born lover that cradles him in beauty where his limbs and tails are soaked in never drying blood.

He sits on the soaked ground below the tree where his sister rests, dragging his sight from the corpses to the quiet entrance of the cavern in front of them, weighing the silence as the goddess chews her teeth around the words of his brother.

But she is not a simple moral anymore, isn't she? The goddess whispers back, turning her head back again. *Neither is the gentle lover that accompanies her*

She is not her lover yet

I guess she isn´t, but didn´t they write their own fates already? On the fabric of the universe?

The god thinks about it, humming under his breath. There are flower blooms hanging from his ethereal fur, even after the brutality of battle and the war; violets and poppies braided around the thick strands. Gifts from the errand temples around Eternia where honorable women are treated as the honorable warriors they are and where they still burn the petals for his blessing.

The god´s head turns around, up and up and to the side, finding his sister among the branches. The hands around his muzzle open like flower blooms, flapping at his temples as vulture feathers when his eyes meet hers, ichor and galaxy like.

Your guilt will not stop choking you just for leaving her meat and thread, sister

The air around the woods goes silent immediately. The god's words drown every single sound, no matter how quiet or how loud.

Animals already unmoving at the presence of the godly predators run away, hiding in empty trunks and below the ground. The already bleeding red sky becomes even more virulent, swirling above them in thick dark clouds that clash against each other with deafening strength.

Even the earth seems to be terrified of her, the goddess of war and wisdom fluttering like a puppet with a human doll´s head, but her brother remains impassive, unbothered by her unfiltered rage.

You already forsake her, he keeps whispering, opening his fauces like the mock of a smile, *She was beloved on your sight yet you turned your eyes away while chaos consumed her. You are as sinful as the rest of us*

The owl blinks, all of her eyes moving with her, reflecting the iridescent surface of his pearls. She could strike him down, in her rage she could tear him into shreds and he would strike her back, a never ending dance of immortal grudge.

She shrieks, hisses, screams in so many languages that the very fauces of the vipers around her long neck crack and dislocate, the sound following her like a war whistle announcing for death when her neck stretches impossible more and faces her brother directly, screeching like a bloody harpy against his canine face.

I know that, brother

But grudge was what got them here in the first place, and she knows quite a deal about that too.

It was her who blessed that man thinking he would be a dignified warrior, after all.

She returns her head to her place, still twitching like the shadows of a sun clock against the stone. Her eyes hover towards the entrance of the cave instead, blinking around the darkness

when she tries to look inside and only fog meets her.

Can you see them? Her brother asks, the hands closing back around his muzzle. She tilts her head to the side, running her slithered tongue against the sharp mouth.

No. None of us can

Then why do you remain here, veiling the entrance every morning instead of being in the bloodbath we caused?

The goddess considers it for a second, her long and dark hands stretching from below the angle of her heavy wings, even longer fingers threading around the silver spider web in intricate patterns.

There are many more kinds of battles than the ones that exist on the fields by the sword and the spear.

Movement is seen through the branches that hold thorns and dry leaves, almost invisible for the mortal eyes but these are not humans that observe them after all.

What about your lover, brother?

Bloodthirst. The god smiles, from ears to ear of his canine face, pride clear on every single corner of his body. *She has cursed Menagerie and all within it. Not a single soul of the trial was spared and those who survived were sucked dry by the starve.*

I´m aware, the goddess says with a nod, familiar with the thirst of the love goddess and the strength of the harvest.

She walks alongside the daughter of the moon queen. Her brother adds, looking at the sky over them where no moons or suns or stars have been seen in months now. *She will bring them to glory*

The mother will die

And the daughter will rise. We have no say on fate but we know about that

The goddess stretches her limbs towards the floor, resting all of her weight on the earth that receives her with a shudder and then dies. No bloom grows on earth now, no flower and no sprout. Only coal, only blood.

War will not kill him

It will not. But it was never his fate to perish in battle after all

The rustle on the thorns becomes more insistent, constant, the flutter of blue feathers peeking through the sharp ends without getting to harm it.

Why are you here, brother? Have you come to slain throats like you did to these men?

You know what they whispered

I know, I sat to watch you bleed them dry

The dog grins, clicking his teeth together several times with satisfaction.

Every now and then I remain and wait

For what?

To the rustle another joins and then they are finally visible, two blue birds like turquoise and a clear sky no longer seen in the world nuzzling against each other before they take fly, circling the earth that hides the cavern from the rest of the world and dipping into its secret waterfall once again.

For the time of her vengeance



Living with Catra is a hurricane.

It sweeps Adora right off her feet and sends her spiraling from side to side inside this cavern that before had felt so oppressive and now feels like a breath of fresh air.

Terrifying, exhilarating and highly intoxicating.

None of it is good for Adora´s heart.

From one second to the other Catra becomes and looks so attuned with the entire cavern that it is almost breathtaking, moving and existing around it as if she herself had sprouted of the grass and moss, always belonging here and just now arriving to its confinements with confidence and elegance. And it takes Adora by surprise.

For her, this place had always felt like a hell personally created to punish her and drive her mad, so consumed by her rage and her sorrow and the reflection of the covered copper mirrors that it had almost killed her the first years. For Catra, whose curiosity seems to rule her life and who followed it like a starving student, the cavern had become a fountain of newfound knowledge, so different from her life before.

She thinks about her life here in a different light than Adora, brighter, curious, avid to survive no matter what. So drenched in hope that it makes Adora bend on herself but also forces her to look back, unable to keep her cursed eyes away from her for too long.

The stone paths around the cavern give Catra a newfound freedom that she had not experienced before, at least not around this place. She skips around the smooth stones that Adora had dug for her on the ground, running the edge of the marble cane around the limits and edges and learning every single corner and wall across the warm place.

Adora observes her from several places around the cavern, propped over tall rocks and the creeks where the lake and the tree line meet. She wraps herself on the fabric of her chiton and around the leather bands around her waist, wrists and ankles and answers Catra´s questions when the directions of the paths confuse her.

“What's here?”

“Baskets with clothes”

“And here?”

“Another broken column from the temple”

“I´ll just ask once”

“You can ask as many times as you need”

"Alright," step, “And this?”

“A knot of roots”

For the first couple of days after their gentler meet Adora still keeps herself as far away as possible, wound up like a knot and nervous every single time Catra walks around her. Catra, on her behalf, simply doesn't seem to care at all about it, and if she does she does not let it show.

Once she learns the paths she walks in around them several times during the day, sometimes not even minding to use the cane or clicking it around her to raise pretty echoes of sounds when coming in touch with stone or water or the earth, placing the things around her with a twitch of her ears.

Adora even catches her whistling once, sitting in front of her loom and waving the prettiest shapes and patterns over its surface; tapping her feet over the poodles of water left by the waterfall and jumping inside them until her tunic is soaked to the knee and her hair as come undo around her, learning through play the depth of them and the strength of the flow.

They fall into a kind of easy routine, which Adora appreciates, only thrown into sudden oblivion every once in a while a week by Catra´s curiosity.

Adora still wakes at dawn and Catra sleeps until very late in the night. Adora showers, slips into clean clothes and sits on her loom to keep waving plain but useful rolls of fabric all while Catra sleeps. She only awakes either by the louder and louder sound of the birds that seems to have made a home on the tallest part of the trees, or by the feeling of the hot sun tickling on her face through the canopy.

Adora cooks for them, which means serving the stored meat and a couple of fruits on plates and eating on different sides of the cavern while Catra talks about the cavern or the trees or the way the fruits sprout and grow and when it's the perfect time to collect them. About the pebbles of the paths or the slippery mud or just what kind of animal Catra found swimming around her toes while she dived inside the lake.

Catra talks and Adora listens and it works for a while. Adora never comments just how tired Catra looks sometimes, even after just waking up.

At the beginning of the fourth month huddled inside the same space, Adora comes back from fetching the basket filled with salted meat and thread from the mouth of the cave and Catra practically tackles her halfway to the pyre, jumping from somewhere at her side and managing to make Adora yelp with surprise.

“What did you bring?”

“C´y– Catra!”

“Oh, it smells like meat. Give it here.”

Catra rests the cane against her hip and searches for the handle of the basket, twitching her ears to search for the sound of the dry wheat against her fingers and seizing it quickly once she finds it.

She is so swift and gentle with it, not even coming near to touching Adora´s skin at all, that it leaves Adora slightly breathless swiping on her ankles to stare avidly at her face.

Sometimes it scares Adora just how easily it became to turn around and stare at Catra´s face without her turning into stone. Sometimes Adora still thinks she might.

Catra hums, running her fingertips across the soft material of the thread rolls placed on the side of the basket, tilting her head to sniff quickly at the meat packaged inside thick leaves.

Her face is very expressive when she is like this, with her eyes closed and her eyebrows arched over her forehead, curiosity and wonder written on every single freckle of her face as she studies the contents of the basket in her hands. She looks young, younger than Adora even if they are the same age, without the hardened lines around her forehead or mouth or the paleness that comes with forsaking herself.

There are more freckles in her face, Adora thinks, clustering over her cheekbones, the side of her temples and the fall of her nose and chin, growing like sprouts after hours of laying under the errand sun through the domes. Her chiton is of a very deep purple right now, and Adora thinks swiftly that she looks very pretty in colors like that, and also that it is none of her business at all.

“Are you ever going to tell me where you get all of this?” Catra asks, completely oblivious of Adora´s thoughts or stares, leaning her face towards her. “After so long together I think it's only fair, don´t you think?”

Adora bites into her bottom lip, shifting nervously from one foot to the other. She doesn't quite know what to say without it sounding either absolutely insane or like a hopeful fool. And she does not want to feed Catra with fake hope either; Adora has been forsaken here for enough time to know that.

The silence between them stretches so much that Catra misunderstands it, her face falling completely from one second to the other. Adora is sure she can almost physically feel it in her bones, her body temperature falling and then skyrocketing immediately after.

“It's just a joke–”

“I don´t know,” Adora hurries to say before Catra can backtrack, running her eyes to the partially hidden entrance between the cave and the rest of the cavern then back to her, sight pleading even though Catra cannot see her. “I've never known.”

Catra´s trail gives a nervous swift from side to side over the soft moss, tilting her head to the direction of Adora´s voice.

“Umm.” Catra´s eyebrows twitch, lowering the basket towards her lap. “What do you mean?”

Adora sighs, sitting over the flat rock behind her. Unlike Catra´s, Adora´s tunic is grey, like a pearl´s shell and so simple she could wrap herself in it and disappear alongside the surface of the rocks.

“They are always there the first day of every week,” she explains, watching Catra´s fingertips drum nervously over the handle of the basket. “I just go and collect them from the entrance and then come back. It's nothing I do.”

Catra wrinkles her nose, letting her eyes flutter slightly open to gaze at the play of light and shadows around them, placing Adora somewhere feet in front of her.

“How did you even find out they were there?” There is no accusation on her voice or distrust; she really is curious, blinking rapidly when the light aches her too much and she closes her eyes again.

Adora rubs her palm against her forearm nervously, biting into her lip until it hurts.

“I found out the only time I tried to escape,” she admits in the thread of a voice, flattering even though Catra remains relaxed around her. “I don´t know who put them there or why, I've never seen them arrive or leave. But it's good meat and it is safe to eat, which is the only thing I cared about in the end.”

Adora doesn't say it all. She doesn't say that for the first weeks of her seclusion here she did not eat a single crumb of food or drank a single drop of water. She doesn´t say that, after tearing the iron mask off her face with her own nails, she huddled in the dark and hoped for dehydration or starvation to consume her whole.

She doesn´t say that, when that moment didn´t come, she crawled on her hands and her knees across the sharp ground of the cave and reached the twisted branches full of thorns fully expecting to stumble into the cold day and find some vengeful or hatred hero that would slice the snakes off her scalp and maybe her whole head off too.

She doesn´t say that she stumbled upon the basket filled with meat and bread instead, and that in a haze she brought it back whole inside her arms. That she let them rot for weeks more

hunger was stronger than her and she roamed against the contents until everything spilled on the floor and even then she ate, hoping in a way it would be poisoned and finding instead that it only gave her strength, so much more strength.

Adora doesn´t say that she is slightly grateful for it now because it feeds Catra too and that matters, that *has* to matter so much more than her own life.

Catra is quiet now but even then she is not silent. She rocks back and forth on her ankles, thinking about Adora's words with a rhythmic hum.

She finally seems to reach some kind of conclusion from her deep thoughts because she nods with a little click of her tongue, spinning the basket softly on her fingers.

“Well, it's good to have a patreon,” she says with a little chirp, shrugging.

That's it, just like that, no more questions asked or more pressure for Adora to answer them even if the latter knows Catra must be eager to ask them.

Catra starts walking toward the lit pyre, still basket in hand, helping herself find the way across with the cane as Adora observes her slightly stunned from her spot.

“What are you going to do?” Adora asks when she sees her kneeling maybe a little too close to the fire, running her fingertips through the edge of the bowls and plates around her.

“Cook” Catra announces, smiling broadly. “No offense, Adora, but sliced figs and unseasoned meat are not really a good dish. Actually I don't think it's a dish at all, how did you even survive all these years?”

Adora blinks, stunned for a second before she catches the shit eating expression curling in Catra's mouth. Disbelief falls over her completely, chasing away the shadows crawling her memories with the light from Catra's teasing grin.

“Hey!” Adora complains, fighting for her life to keep the corners of her own mouth from twitching.

“Oh, this is wine and bread too. Be good and bring me some vegetables, won't you? I'll make us my mom's stew”

“I, um”

Catra tilts her head towards her, smiling. “Yes?”

“Fine.” Adora huffs, grumbling the whole way as she stands up from the rock and does what she is told without a second thought.

Catra hears the jingle of her ankle bracelets and her low muttered groaning and her smile only widens, her tail drawing lazy circles on the ground behind her,

“Good girl”

Adora turns every single shade of crimson under the sun, putting the very virulent sky beyond the domes to shame. She turns around her ankles and bolts it towards the inside trees, ignoring completely when Catra cackles loudly behind her.

The next time Adora goes to fetch the baskets, Catra is already waiting for her on the entrance of the corridor, clicking the end of her cane against the surface of the stone wall where she is leaning into.

“What are you doing?” Adora asks without being able to stop herself, pushing aside the heavy fabrics that hide the entrance.

Once upon a time Adora lived out of her curiosity and wonder for the world; it fed her and fulfilled her with wonder and amaze. She lost that many years ago but next to Catra sometimes Adora thinks she can feel the tickle of it once again against her bones.

Catra shrugs, turning around to face the cold air from where it slips inside the cavern through the corridor.

“You´re going for the meat, I want to come too.”

Adora blinks, staring at her calm face for a second before turning her eyes away. She wrinkles her nose, wrapping her hands around the sturdy stone of the wall until it aches on her knuckles.

“The cave is cold and miserable,” Adora says under her breath, her shoulder flopping forward. “You don´t need to come, I can do it for us.”

Catra hums, tilting her head to the side and then back up, following the echo of the birds chirping and the waterfall, cracking with the warmth of the sun and oh so different from the skeleton hands of the cold that lingers beyond the corridor.

“I still want to go,” she says after a breath, licking her bottom lip. “I told you, I want to know and learn everything. Including the things that waren´t warm.”

Adora is so absorbed by looking at her that she doesn´t even realize the cane is coming for her until it connects against the back of her ankles, making her jump with surprise. It's not violent and it doesn´t hurt, but it makes the coins around her ankles jingle loudly against each other and it rips a yelp out of Adora´s mouth when she realizes Catra actually just shoved her with the cane like a grumpy old grandmother.

“If you are not going to move then step aside, Adora.” Catra says around a smile, nudging her with her hip. “I'm curious and I´m hungry, so take a choice.”

Adora finally moves, maybe motivated by Catra´s apparently unending hunger or by sheer annoyance, She clicks her tongue against her teeth and grabs the sides of the open wall, jumping swiftly inside in a second. Once she is inside, she turns around but Catra is already inside too, climbing instead of jumping, the cane temporarily in the ground as she feels the sharp rock with her fingertips.

Adora presses her lips together and keeps walking across the corridor, looking at Catra walking behind her out of the corner of her eye.

The cave is, as always, cold and miserable. It is void of any kind of color and any kind of warmth, crawling with shadows and freezing cold that makes Adora´s breath visible as steam.

The broken pieces of the dead statues around them salute Adora as always, quiet and unmoving, their eyes firmly gazed upon her in immortal judgement. Adora bends around the weight of them, her shoulder curling and her eyes narrowed when she turns her head sharply aside.

The sound of stones rolling around the ground calls her attention, whipping her head around to catch the origin. For a second there, she had forgotten she was not alone inside this place anymore.

Catra is feeling the bare ground with her soles, suddenly hesitant after weeks of making herself familiar with the stone paths of the cavern. The end of her cane meets the edges of the stones around her but even then she doesn't seem comfortable, her nose wrinkling with annoyance and her ears suddenly pressing to the side.

“The sounds are different here,” Catra says, unable to place the sounds when the echo comes back to her out of every single direction. “Loud”

Adora´s skin raises in goosebumps, traveling from her shoulders to the fall of her back. She absently stretches her arm towards Catra, not daring to actually touch her but still hovering between them, hesitant and without knowing what to do.

“Just tell me where things are, would you?” Catra asks, almost as if she could read Adora´s mind or feel the turmoil inside her heart. “I'm a fast learner, I just don't want to fall on my face.”

Adora takes her hand away from the air and back into her mouth, biting into her cuticles again. She nods, slightly beating herself when she realizes Catra is still waiting for her to answer.

“Yeah, alright”

They make it to the entrance of the cave with patience, slow. Adora guides Catra with gentle words and lengthy descriptions, biting her tongue until it aches every single time she has to describe one of the broken statues that are her fault. But she does it anyway because Catra asked her to and, in a way, she sometimes thinks that she owes it to her for being trapped here with her.

Catra doesn´t even trip once, following Adora´s words and the feeling of her soles and her cane against the floor. There stones on the entrance of the cavern are smoother here but the branches are dangerously knotted together, thorns and dry bark mixing with each other into a visual warning that is not impossible to cross but that it should root fear on the people that could ever walk by.

Adora asks Catra to wait on the base of the rocks before climbing up, her eyebrows twitching when the stones dig a little too painfully on the soles of her sandals, holding herself from the thorns that dig inside her palms and fingers. The basket is, as always, carefully placed right underneath the branches where the sun cannot begin to spoil it rotten, big and heavy with the content inside.

Ever since Catra came stumbling inside this place more food has been appearing inside the basket. Bigger pieces of different kinds of meat, jars with wine and still steaming bread with the crust cracking the inside soft.

Adora´s mouth, usually cursed with inappetence, waters at the sight. She is not used to hunger as well as she is not used anymore to the small sacrifice of portion Catra does quietly every meal, another little pebbles to the pyre of changes in her life.

When Adora clumps back down she finds Catra leaning against one of the tall columns, resting her palm over the marble. The shades of green beneath her fingers call Adora´s attention but the unreadable expression in Catra´s face calls for her more.

“Are they still there?” Catra asks, trying to hide just how nervous she actually is and unable to hide it, at least from Adora. She can see the way her ears twitch, even among the shadows. “The ones that brought me here”

They are but not in the way she thinks. Adora sees their festering corpses every single time she reaches for the baskets; she has seen the progression of their rot, from eaten flesh to putrid muscle to frail bone, crumble under the weight of the vultures and owls that still lingers over them as if they refused to let them go, even in death.

She knows it is neither a sight or a tale she wants for Catra to listen.

“No, they are not.” Then after a beat. “Do you want to try to walk outside?”

Catra wrinkles her nose, pulling her hand back against her lap.

“No,” she says, so quickly she almost doesn´t seem to think about it at all. Then the corner of her mouth twitches with a frail smile, still holding the handle of the cane until her knuckles go white. “I'm hungry”

“Alright.” Adora slides down the cave´s stones, standing hesitatingly next to Catra´s cold body. “Um, can you make more stew like the other day?”

Catra´s slight apprehension melts down her face like water, replaced by a bright expression filled with pride and the slightest hint of cheekiness.

“I knew you would like it,” she announces happily, turning on her ankles and skipping away on the stones, more confident now that she has done the trip across the cave with Adora to do it on her own.

Adora watches her go, unable to not smile when Catra´s tunic tangles with a sharp rock and she curses a little at it, tilting to the side and then straight back again. Adora walks behind her

and doesn't even try to hide her eyes lingering on the moss and blooms that grow below every step of Catra's soles, filling the gray cave with green.

“Yes I did”

They fall again into an easy routine once again, breathable, a line painted on the earth of their life inside the cavern that Adora, even with all of her fear, starts to grow used to.

Easy until Catra decides that too long has gone by and she tries to give Adora a heart attack.

It´s irrationally early in the morning, even for Adora, the dawn barely breaking through the open domes when Adora hears a bit of a turmoil and she scrambles out of the hole of her bed to glance around. The pyre is quietly cracking around the heated stones, the waterfall is calm and the temple is unmoving, drowned in shadows as the first strands of the sun start to progress through the sky.

Adora glances at the open domes and blinks through sticky eyelashes at the purple sky, dropping her eyes towards the rest of the cavern, sleep lingering on the edges. The lake, the moss and grass on the ground, the thick trunks of the trees, Catra starting to climb her way up them and the newcomer birds chirping above her head.

Adora sprints off the stone bed in a heartbeat, stepping on the hem of her chiton and crossing the water line between the waterfall and the lake so fast that her clothes soak up to her knees.

She is not even wearing the bracelets around her ankles but Catra seems to be able to hear her anyway, tilting her head to the side with a sideways grin.

“Ah, there you are,” Catra says as a greeting, digging her sharp nails inside the bark of the tree and impulsing herself up over it. “I was wondering when you were going to show up.”

Catra is already several feet above of her head, moving quickly from branch to branch, feeling the safety of them with the arch of her soles.

Adora sighs, pinching the bridge of her nose with her fingers, annoyance surprisingly taking over the overwhelming anxiety as she watches the skirt of Catra´s dress dangling in front of her head.

“What are you doing today?” Adora mumbles, wrinkling her nose as she looks up again, purposely avoiding Catra's pretty calves when she does so. “Catra”

“Oh, don´t be boring,” Catra wraps her hands around the branches and impulses herself up, further and further above the ground. “You have a whole paradise here and you have never dared to go beyond these rocks?”

“This is a prison, not a paradise.” Adora narrows her eyes at Catra, shuffling nervously on the grass.

Adora prefers the floor, steady and unchanging floor that she knows and has learnt; watching Catra skipping like a bird across the unsure and ever changing trunks of the humongous trees makes her hesitant. At least Catra's tail seems to be balancing her when she jumps.

“Catra”

“I want to see what's near the domes,” Catra grunts, stopping just enough so she can tilt her head backwards, following Adora's worried voice. “If you really want to stop me come get me then”

Dangerous, sometimes Catra is more dangerous than any other so-called warrior slipping inside Adora´s cave. She is not dangerous because she is bold and reckless, or because she never seems to be afraid, no matter what has happened to her.

She is dangerous because Adora moves when she does, and because Adora answers her when she calls for her. Because, if Catra offers, Adora steps forward, resting her hands that had never done this before around the rough bark of the trees and pushing herself up above the damp grass.

She is dangerous because she smiles as if she knew the truth about Adora´s heart and the root of her decision, holding that power precarious over Adora´s heart.

“Watch out,” Catra calls, grinning, maybe oblivious of the storm inside Adora. “We don´t want you snapping your sandals”

Adora grunts, sweat gathering on the limits of her forehead, rolling down her temples in beads as she carefully studies the branches and decides where is safer to go through.

“Shut up”

“Ha!”

Catra makes it towards the crown of the trees before Adora does, disappearing behind the thick foliage of the branches, both tiny and thick evergreen leaves sauntering down when she crosses them. She is there, right above Adora´s head one second and the next she is gone, swallowed alive by the multicolored micro universe hidden through the living plants.

Adora hums, pushing back her anxiety as best as she possibly can, finding her way across the bark much slower than Catra did, looking at everything to make sure it does not hurt her or threatens to make her fall down towards the ground. She specifically avoids looking down, the pit of her belly tightening at the thought of dangling so far above the floor.

She hesitates right at the base of the thick leaves, looking up at them completely unsure. There are twigs and tiny branches here and there, they could scratch over Adora´s skin if she is not careful or could poke her in the eye on the side.

She is not a stranger to pain, she has known more kinds of suffering that she ever wanted, but it does not mean that it makes her bolder to it. It does not mean that she doesn´t hesitate to the change, to the new, to the unknown. That it does not remind her of all the sleepless nights she spent on this place learning it all over again because all she ever knew was destroyed and over, and all that was new might have wanted to murder her.

Adora stares at the calm leaves for a long second, wondering if they will turn into stone any second now, wondering what would happen if she just let go of the bark. The open dome of the cavern is above her head, the warm strands of a new sun tickling on her tightly wrapped head.

She would saunter like one of the leaves towards the ground; she would fall like a bird with its wings cut short. She might not feel it at all, like a stone.

“Adora?”

Adora reaches up and crosses the leaves, following Catra´s voice inside the unknown shadows above her.

It's closed up around her still but there is a whole world up here, waiting for her to dare to meet it.

Here the branches of the three trees tangled with each other, cross up and down and knot themselves around the other, braiding their wood arms into embraces like knots, creating their own kind of domes and their own kind of floors, suspended above the hard stone from below.

You must be careful here still, because the leaves carpet the branches and your foot could slip, but Adora doesn´t really seem to notice that, marveled on the new sight around so familiar yet so different to the space she had resigned herself to live into the last five years of her life.

There is movement on the branches, up and down and fluttering on the walls covered with vines all around her, peeking curiously at Adora from their places with their dark eyes and tiny beaks, blue feathers fluttering every once in a while when the little birds that have made their home there jump to get a little closer.

“Adora,” Catra´s voice comes in a whisper somewhere around the shadows, startling her.

Adora snaps her head to the side, coming face to face with Catra next to her. She is sitting over a strong spot of branches, her knees around the leaves and her feet tucked below her. The straps of her tunic slip a little down her right shoulder, allowing for Adora to catch a glimpse of freckled dark skin below the warm fabric, fabric from the exercise of climbing and from the damp heat accumulating inside this hidden place.

Adora gulps, forcing herself to look away and finding her eyes only manage to move up, catching the rise and fall of Catra´s throat when she gulps and the way her hair curls in a certain kind of way on the base of her ears, like the waves of Adora´s sea back home, washing over dark earth and breaking into foam.

“Shh, sit here.” Catra murmurs, resting the palm of her hand over the branches next to her. Adora observes her in silence and doesn´t even feel herself move, lowering herself over the leaves softly. Catra grins, her pretty eyes searching for the stray rays of light among the branches. “Cup your hands in front of you”

Adora does as she is told because how could she not, stretching her arms in front of her without a second thought. For a second she thinks Catra is going to touch her and her heart sinks inside her chest and then expands like an ocean, crashing over the stone walls of her heart.

Catra doesn´t touch her though, still faithful to her promise made weeks ago. But she does lean towards her, hovering her fingers right above Adora´s extended palms. It takes a second for Adora to understand that she is seeking for Adora´s body warmth among the darkness and for a second it makes Adora full of shame and full of want, eager to hold her hands higher for Catra to find.

Instead Catra takes her hand away for a moment, and when she hovers it back what falls against Adora´s palms is not another skin but tiny beads, soft and fresh, filling the cup of her hands like Demeter´s blessings over the earth.

Seeds, wheat, pomegranate beads, tiny fruits and sweet cubes tumble around each other inside Adora´s palms, filling her skin with sweetness and Adora realizes what exactly this hands of hers that have killed before are offering to the world around her, so filled with peace that Adora´s presence alone on this place feels unholy.

Fear starts to pool inside Adora´s throat, her entire body starting to shiver without her permission. She has not laid eyes with any other living creature in such a long time, not besides Catra. And those who did never ran with the luck of surviving her monstrous face.

Adora is not sure what she would do to an innocent animal approaching her. Will they chirp and flutter around her head until they catch sight of her cursed eyes and fall heavy and unmoving as stones too? Will they die too? Will Adora break this little, light and innocent part of life too?

Their feathers are so blue against the sunlight when they fly directly towards her that for a moment she is left breathless. The color reminds her of the shade of Adam´s eyes, bright and alive. The very same that he shared with her, his twin, before she killed him and her humanity died with him.

The birds are in Adora´s hands. They are warm, a little bit frail, soft to the touch as they breathe and lean into her palm, eating from the small seeds around her fingers. They are alive, they are not stone.

The little birds approach Adora and are not scared of her, instead jumping inside her hands and over her head, chirping to each and to her as they feast on her offering. They meet Adora ´s killing eyes with their dark ones and keep flying, free to come and go as they wish; unaware of the danger Adora is for the rest of the world.

Adora stares marvelled at them, barely daring to blink at all as to not miss a single second of this event. First they are two and then three, then five. Then they are six and nine and suddenly more than Adora really pays her mind to count, flying all around her and standing on the top of her head, her shoulders and the skin over her forearms and knees.

They don´t seem to mind her at all. None of them seem to care at all about Adora terrible face or the bestiality that hides below her veil and that is violently hissing with curiosity underneath the fabric, filling the pretty crowns of the trees with its sizzling yet mingling with the excited chirping of the birds all around her.

Catra is humming right next to her, busying herself by picking the tiny blooms of flowers that grow alongside the branches of the trees. From where Adora sit, still covered in blue feathers, she can see the pretty colors of the blooms, yellow and blue too, some tiny and others bigger, falling on Adora´s palms when Catra pulls them from their stems and lets them fall gently inside.

Where Adora can see the colors, Catra learns them in a different way. She feels the length of their petals with her fingertips and rubs their soft surfaces with her thumb, learning their shapes with her touch alone.

“What's the name of these flowers?” Catra asks, her ears fluttering when a baby bird tries to take a strand of her soft hair for its nest.

“I don't know,” Adora narrows her eyes at them, bringing them close with a thoughtful expression. “I had never seen them before”

Catra hums, her tail softly traveling up and tangling around her own ankle into a motion that Adora is slowly learning to be grounding.

“Nothing flowers,” Catra offers, bringing the tiny blooms towards her face and smelling their sweet fragrance.

There are a few blooms that are darker than the blues, dawn touched because their edges are closer to the purple and slightly further from a gentle pink. They kind of look like the flowers of weeds that grow on the edges of rivers or in the limits of the harvest fields of the palace.

“Pointless flowers.” Adora says back, offering one of the pretty blooms to the birds and watching them take it and fly away back towards the trees.

They remain silent for a while, the sun further and further higher above their heads, showering it all in golden light and chasing the shadows away. Like this the light naked Catra ´s freckles look like specks of golden powder over heer skin and her hair as if someone had knotted star strands over each curl. Like this, Adora can see Catra´s shoulders relaxing, letting her eyes open to be able to take on the shape and light of the things around them, no matter how small or how big.

Every once in a while Adora wonders just how similar they seem to be to each other sometimes, and how different too. They both have had to learn to close their eyes under the weight of things that scare them of themselves. Both of their eyes carry things that ache, things beyond their control. Both of them have wandered here.

But there are so many different things too. In the way Catra carries blindness with grace and Adora carries transformation with horror. In the way Catra still wants to drink from life and

Adora feels every day like she is drowning. In the way Catra is bright and alive and Adora felt herself wearing away.

They are both inside this dome of light and still Adora feels like Catra is far away, sitting among clouds while Adora doesn´t know how to let go of her pain.

I´m a murderer, Adora wants to say to Catra, explain her, beg her, plead for her forgiveness even. Make her understand the true reach of her curse where Catra doesn´t seem to pay the appropriate fear or understatement for. Where Adora doesn´t seem to be able to look away.

“Waiting flowers,” Catra decides finally, leaving them over Adora´s palms. “I´m sure they´ve been waiting for you for a long time”

Sometimes Adora sits on her own loom too, still several meters away, pulling from the strings and doing and undoing the patterns when her gaze lingers too far away from the tapestry and too close to Catra´s seat instead.

Sometimes Adora sits near the edge of the lake, running her hands across the edge of her sore feet and looking at Catra sideways a few times, just enough to drink on the sight of her loose hair and then snap her eyes away when the shoulder of her chiton tethers down the freckled skin of her shoulder or when the arch of her ankle peeks tempting from below the hem of her tunic.

Sometimes, more often than not now, Adora sits close. First on the moss, on the earth slightly damp by the lake. Then on the scattered stones around the place, nervously biting on her fingers until drops of red meet her and she has to forcefully put them down against her lap.

Then, at some point, she is finally on the ground next to Catra´s feet, pressing her knees against her chest and remaining very very quiet as she stares at her pretty hands moving across the colorful threads with memorized expertise.

Every once in a while, Adora blinks to the pretty images on the tapestries and thinks that they seem all too familiar to her, tugging on the edges of her memory. She tries to look into it sometimes but when she does it becomes painful, too close to what once was her home, too near to the memories of that night, so she steps away and focuses on Catra´s work instead. Focuses on what she knows from these images without aching.

For Catra, her proximity seems to fuel something inside her, powering it like the light of a thousand suns, as if Helios themself had set inside of her chest and had turned it aflame. Sweet but chaotic, like music out of control. It makes Adora´s cheeks flush.

“I was a farmer, I already said that. And a weaver, which you know,” Catra says calmly, tangling her fingers around the threads, pulling from them and braiding them back again into shapes she follows with her fingertips.

They are sitting next to the lake today, enjoying the warm sun above their heads. While Catra waves, Adora is polishing on a curved piece of wood she found loose on the ground, trying to make sense of the shape where her memory of it has begun to fade.

Every once in a while, Adora throws a swift look to the sky behind the golden sun, taking on the virulent purple and sick red swirling with dark clouds beyond the open dome of the cavern.

“Did your mother teach you?” Adora asks, running the blunt surface of the knife over the wood.

They´ve been like this for a while now, back and forth with gentle questions all of them for Catra. And Catra has complied gently too, speaking about everything from her childhood and younger days to Adora without even thinking about it or holding back anything.

She has told Adora about her home, the house next to the river of which she remembers the shape of the crooked door and the fall of the wheel that would move the water around the house and the earth. She has spoken about the animals living from their earth, lambs and goats and how she learned to take care of them and the food they would give her and her mother in return. She has told her about the fields of wheat as tall as herself and exactly how the crops feel underneath her fingertips when they are ready to be harvested.

It is beautiful, this knowledge Catra is giving her, about the world as she has learned it through the years without her sight to guide her. All of those little and almost insignificant things that Adora had always taken for granted and have never even considered to be grateful for, not even down here on this place still untouched by the hand of men.

“Yes, all of it. And my grandmother taught my mother before.”

“And who taught your grandmother?”

Catra chuckles, as if there was something either extremely funny or extremely serious about the answer of that question alone. “I know it's going to sound weird but I think she exists for that purpose alone. She knows everything that is to be told from the moment she came to be.”

It throws Adora a little bit off but the air around them remains relaxed, without hanging with that terrifying tension of awkwardness between them. It's almost like an old joke, the way Catra sometimes says things, as if they were quite the old acquaintances and they were talking about all things and nothing in particular.

“My mother, she was extraordinary.” Catra´s hands tremble above the shroud on her loom, thread hanging from her nails and around the heel of her hand and her wrist. “It was not because she was someone else's daughter or because she had or had not been born from someone special. She was special all by herself, she made herself special every single day. It was something I could never learn from her”

It surprises Adora sometimes, how little Catra seems to realize just how special she is. How much of a sun casting elliptic shadows over the moss she has come to be inside the darkness of Adora´s exile.

Maybe she really does not know, maybe she has never stopped to think about it. Maybe nobody ever told her before, though Adora finds that one hard to believe. Maybe it wasn´t

really noticed, out there under the golden day star, and the colors that mirror off her presence are brighter down here, between the open domes and the trees.

“She died. Six years ago.” Catra whispers after a moment of silence, bringing Adora´s head to a stop. She lowers one of her hands towards her lap, the other one hovering over the knotted thread across the shroud. “My aunt poisoned her. I didn't learn the truth until much later, when they judged me and brought me here. She told me to torture me before send me to my death.”

Adora blinks, from the blue shapes of constellations and flowers from the shroud and back to Catra´s face, feeling her jaw falling slack with the horror that Catra´s words bring.

Pain, that is the feeling that blooms inside Adora´s chest and that it is reflected inside Catra´s face. Pain and anger, unfiltered, still bright somehow no matter how rageful. Still painful.

It seems as if Catra had already a long time to mourn, to duel in grief, to keep going after the death of someone that she loved that much and that deeply, someone that important. But at the same time the pain looks anew, a wound torn open once again after years of trying to heal, bleeding her all over again below the rose of her cheeks and the trembling corner of her smiles.

Catra has been betrayed by the people that were supposed to love her. They have torn apart her family and have sold her to a sorrowful end, something she was not supposed to end in this, both of them sitting with their soles soaking on the crystal waters of the lake.

Adora understands, Adora can ache for her too. And in the voids where Catra cannot rage, she can hate for her if needed.

“That´s–” Adora twists the fabric of her hemation so hard that she hears it rip, shivering violently. “C´yra”

“I hope she gets exactly what she deserves.” Catra´s face is tilted to the side so very slightly, her eyes open. The silver moonlights on her irises are dull and dry, unblinking at the thoughts and the words. “I´ve never been a very forgiving person”

Oh. She is still in shock. Adora looks at her face and she realizes this terrible, saddening, scary truth. She has not processed it, has not truly understood the weight of it. Catra thinks she has, after so many months here, so many months since she learned the truth, but she hasn't, not properly.

She remembers the world she knew through rose colored reflections but she is still holding herself tight and mighty above the pain staining her memories. She is still holding herself hard around the realization that her own family destroyed the one person she loved the most.

She is sad and she is angry and Adora knows about this grief, in a different way maybe. After all, Adora has also lost a mother and she has also been betrayed by the very same, by every single person around her. She knows, she already went through it, she already bled for it, in tears and screams and heartache.

The breakthrough will come for Catra. Sooner or later, it will fall over her like it did for Adora.

“I can understand that,” Adora murmurs and it feels like a kind of promise on the base of her throat, that she will be there when it happens.

Catra turns her head towards her following her voice. There is a certain kind of pink blush that gathers on her tear line when she has kept her eyes open for too long, as if a rose had pressed its petals against the high of her cheekbones and the corner next to her nose, deepening her eyes like planets.

Adora has spent a lawfully long time the last weeks learning Catra's face, her expressions and the angle of her jaw and the fifty seven freckles clustered on her skin. She has come to learn how she looks when she just woke up or when she spent a full night without sleep.

She has come to learn the kind of expression she makes when wants to change the subject or when the pain of certain memories is too overwhelming and the brightness of her hopes and dreams too tempting to let it be drowned by anything else.

“Farming and weaving weren't the only things I wanted to do, though,” Catra says after a few seconds, taking the threads inside her fingers again and resuming her work.

Adora regards her curiously, tilting her head to the side. ‘‘You wanted to be different?’

“Different? No, never.” Catra chuckles, running the wood plank over the threads. “I wanted to sail”

Adora's mouth falls slightly open, her eyebrows shooting up across her forehead in surprise. Catra must know somewhere inside of her that Adora is making a ridiculous face because she chuckles under her breath while Adora gapes at her.

“Like Jason and his argonauts?”

“Not exactly, I would never be that greedy. Men spoil everything.”

Catra shakes her head, clicking her tongue against the back of her teeth. Then her expression melts, brightening across her face and making her look years younger.

“I wanted to travel across Eternia and every single corner of our world. I wanted to save just enough gold and buy a ship and visit everything I could, learn everything about it and fill my days with new things.” Catra giggles, tilting her head to the side. “I guess it wasn't very smart of me, it's not as if I could follow the sky or see the islands around me, or where in gods´names I would go.”

Catra sniffles, letting go from the threads to run her fingers through her hair instead, softer than the cotton or wool. She has not braided it this time, falling into loops over her shoulder and held with tiny coins at the sides or her temples.

“But when I was a bit younger than now I had a friend, a kind person with his head in the clouds, and he told me that I could just follow the winds and whatever place the sea would

take me and I could take my course from there. If Poseidon was kind enough to not drown me or strain me somewhere, of course.” Catra grins, lopsided, huffing under her breath at the memory. “I– I want to learn it all, for the things I cannot see and all the things that are left to know. I think a part of me still wants that.”

Adora bites into her mouth so hard it sparks with pain, filling the back of her throat with bitter spit and the traces of blood.

All her wonder and her tenderness trembles, casted into darkness suddenly by the shadows of guilt. Another bitter reminder that Catra does not belong here, inside these stone walls and treacherous floors where her soles could trip. That as much as Catra is trying, as much effort she puts in trying to coexist with Adora, who is afraid to even call her a friend much less something else, she is still untouched by the world.

Being so near someone that is so filled with hope it's sometimes overwhelming, and most of the time it makes Adora wish she could be better. Not a monster.

“Tell me about you.” Catra says, blinking towards Adora´s direction, finding the shape of her body among the shadows and following the strong breathing from her lungs.

“Me?”

“Yes. Tell me about the you that is more than this place.” Catra bites into her mouth, flushing. “About the you here, and about the you before here too.”

Adora takes a heavy breath, blinking sudden tears away. But Catra doesn´t know this, she only hears Adora´s silence and her palpable hesitation, Catra´s pretty ears fluttering at the sides of her head.

“We made a compromise, miss *don´t fall in love with me.”* Catra mutters around a soft drag of her words, wiggling her eyebrows but with her face relaxed, letting Adora know she means no ill with her words.

Still, Adora loses the grip and gasps, flushing until her entire neck and chest burns with red and the snakes knotted on her head sizzle violently at the top of her head. She stutters, loudly, tangling on her own vocal cords as her own words bounce back to her.

“You didn't even promise it,” Adora finally manages to push out, mortified as she lets her face fall inside the cup of her palms.

“Eh,” Catra shrugs, pulling from another thread. She doesn't seem to know the shapes she is waving but Adora does, the sharp but gentle falls and creases of the ships crossing a calm sea made of stars. “For your knowledge, I´m already vowed for.”

Every single thought inside Adora´s head comes to a halt, her heart sinking so deeply inside her chest that it makes her stomach twist and turn with dizziness, pulling from the cords of her heart and painting black stains on her peripheral vision.

She stares at Catra´s pretty profile, completely taken aback from one second to the other where Catra seems to not even realize she has said something so monumentally earthshaking.

“What?”

“Just like you heard. I was promised-for a long time ago. I´ve known it since I was very young.” She is smiling, smiling as if it was something deeply tender for her, as if it was fundamentally beautiful and important for her and her life. “So it doesn't really matter what you say.”

The bitter feeling stirs deeply in Adora´s gut, clinging to the back of her throat and making her ears ring. This feeling is new for Adora, unknown; it's neither sorrow nor sadness or uneasiness, strange and terrifying and honestly annoying.

“Oh”

Jealousy, that's the feeling. And anger, mostly with herself.

Catra has noticed something has changed. She drops the shroud and the loom and turns around, searching for Adora in the newfound quiet. The tip of her tail flickers from side to side every time she is nervous.

“Adora?” Catra frowns, playing with the edge of her hemation. “Are you still there?”

“I am.” Adora doesn´t mean to snap but she does, her voice biting among the previous quietness. She cringes when she sees the way Catra´s ears press at the sides of her temples, her mouth twitching with surprise. Adora stands up on uneasy feet immediately, tripping on the hem of her own tunic twice. “Sorry, I just need a second”

“Adora, wait”

“I´m sorry.”

Adora was much braver, before. Before the cave, before the stone statues, before the curse. She was much braver before becoming a monster.

She is not brave now, she is not brave at all. She has asked Catra to stay away and still seems to be unable not to dwell on the realization that Catra might already be someone else entirely. That she might love and be in love already.

What a selfish hypocrisy, from Adora, to be unable to breathe from a pain like this.

She leaves Catra's side and retreats inside the corridor that leads to the cave, not being able even to step to the other side as she doesn't think of herself strong enough to look at the green life Catra's presence has created even there.

Maybe Adora could just be brave enough to stay but today is not that day.

It's much later when they speak again. Adora is huddled on the side of the lake, her feet, bottom and legs soaked by the water that reaches her ankles and part of her calves. The fabric of her tunic is slightly stained by mud and by moss, slipping through her fingers and covering her skin.

This time she is the one that hears Catra arrive by the jingle of the coins in her hair, letting Adora know that she is near. The tip of her cane runs softly over the grass and moss, feeling and hearing the echo of the marble over the things around her.

The soles of her feet feel the damp fabric of Adora´s tunic and she exhales, walking just enough as to be right next to Adora without coming to touch her. She sits over the edge of the lake next to Adora, dipping her soles inside the water too.

Adora watches as Catra rests her chin over her knees, her ears pressing at her sides and her eyes halfway closed. Adora shuffles, her skin raised in goosebumps but Catra is calm, running the cane over the calm surface of the lake.

“Can I tell you a story?” Catra asks, curling her tail around her ankle.

Adora holds her breath, unable to tear her eyes away from Catra´s nose. A tale it's the last thing she expected for Catra to ask her. “Yes”

“It's about Helen. Helen of Sparta.” Catra leaves the cane next to her over the grass, right between both of them. “You know the tale”

“In a way,“ Adora looks away, wrapping her own hemation over her shoulders. Unlike Catra ´s, hers is much simpler, red and worn out, without embroidering or soft edges. “I was never one for love stories“

“I don´t think it was ever a story about love.” Catra whispers, her eyebrows wrinkling. “I don ´t think it was ever about love for her, even before she was born”

Adora observes her, from the fall of her nose to the angle of her jaw, the way Catra´s mouth twitch with displeasure and her shoulders curl around herself, and the way she still speaks the words softly, as if she wanted to honor the story still, for it´s protagonist´s sake.

“I'm listening.”

“Her mother was Leda and in her tenderness for a swan she was deceived by Zeus and taken as men rip women like fruits.” Catra grimaces, the corners of her mouth curling into an expression so full of rage that it makes her look dark and dangerous for a second. “From that defile Helen was born and from that moment on her life was consumed by the curse of her own beauty, always placed above her intelligence and her heart”

Adora flinches, dragging her eyes away. She wraps her arms around herself, digging her sharp nails against her forearms, feeling the pinch to the very marrow of her bones, all so familiar to her.

“She was barely more than a child when her hand was won by Aggamennon and then given to his brother Menelaus. And she did as people expected of her, she bore him children and bore him kingdom and status and power.” Catra leans forward, resting the palm of her hand over the quiet water. “Some people say that she loved him, that she learned to love him, truly. But can that be true? Even inside the halls of her childhood home she was a prisoner”

Adora exhales, looking at the water too. Her expression stares right back at her, looking without moving. She looks at her own eyes, dark, at the scars crossing her face and the purple veils wrapped around her head like fallen crowns. It does not turn her into stone but it freezes her over the moss.

“And as if it wasn´t enough, Paris came and took her from her bed rest and dragged her inside of Troy. Ten years, bearing children that would die at the feet of the city's tall walls.”

Then it transforms, shifts, softer factions, dark skin, skull short darker hair, the face of Helen that Adora saw on the mosaics and tapestries of her home, always behind some war-worn tragedy for a man seeking her like a dog in rut. Menelaus, Paris, the gods.

“None of them ever cared about who she truly was, a woman that wanted to love and be loved in return, a woman that wanted to be free.” Catra turns her hand around, closing her fingers around the soft feeling of a lotus that comes to rest over her palm. She lifts it above the water, just enough for the stem to stop her without getting to completely rip it off, letting it fall back inside the water gently. “Maybe that´s the fate of all of the gods´ sprouts, tragedy.”

She says it heavily mournfully, like it weighed something inside of her. As if it was somehow also a part of her. Adora tilts her head and rests her cheek over her knees too, glancing at Catra´s face, mirroring her posture like the lake´s reflection.

“Tell me more”

“About the war?”

“About her”

It starts to rain, they spend hours here, right below the domes and the lake. The drizzle falls over the water and splashes softly over their clothes and faces, dampening from head to toes but they don´t move, sitting next to the other almost stubbornly.

Catra speaks about the years of the Iliad, the endless days and weeks and months, spoken through dozens to hundred of mouths across Etheria and Greece, War and sorrow and resignation, not from the eyes of the so called heroes but from the hearts of the women that bore with the consequences of hubris.

Years of tears and blood over torn tunics and children beds, so much holier and so much more important than the blood spilled over the surface of armors, spears or swords. Love as an excuse for loss. Love as a payment for heartbreak. Not the cause but the bribe.

It's still raining when Catra´s voice flatters, the words of death brought through chivalrous wooden horses and surviving souls being sold and exchanged among princes and kings. Destroyed cities and destroyed lives.

“We are not so different, us to them.”

Catra runs her fingertips over the soft petals of the flowers, cooing them open with her touch without even realizing it. The drizzle of the rain is still falling over Adora´s face, mingling with the tears falling down her cheeks.

“Helen. Cassandra, Hecuba, Iphigenia, Andromache.” Catra tilts her head back, facing the rain. “You. Me. We were all ripped away from our homes, weren´t we?”

Adora´s eyes open wide, her mouth falling open. “I–”

“We were all promised love and given sorrow in its place. Displaced, deceived, abandoned. I was scared when it happened. I'm sure you were scared too.” Catra is almost not blinking, letting the rain fall down her face and maybe Adora is not the only one hiding things among the droplets. “And yet, I still hope Helen was in love at the end and that she was loved in return. I really hope she found a way to be true to herself and to allow herself to love the remains of this world in return.”

Catra tilts her head towards Adora, closing her eyes back again. “And I hope she got justice for the innocence she got ripped out of her.”

Adora gasps, curling inside herself and then loosening like the cord of a bow, spilled raw and open over the lake and the stones.

Catra hears her but she doesn´t move, she doesn´t even seem to breathe. She extends her hand until her pads find the edge of Adora´s torn hemation and holds herself from it.

“I'd like to do this for you, for both of us, if you want to.” Catra wrinkles her nose but she is grinning, twitching in a way that gives away how nervous she truly is. “I'd like to tell you a thousand and one stories. One every other night”

Adora gulps, overcome for a moment with her own emotions. “Why only that number?”

“I just know that many.” Catra confesses, making Adora chuckle. “It might take me years”

Adora exhales, not even cleaning the tears off her face this time. “How many years?”

“Maybe five.” Catra kicks softly on the fresh water of the lake, tilting her head. “Maybe much more.” Then she turns her head towards Adora again, still grinning. “Sailing is not the only thing I ever wanted to do. I also wanted to share what I learnt.”

Adora opens her mouth, lets it hang for a second too long, chewing on the words she wants to say and the ones eating their way on her ribcage and that in the end wins the silent battle.

“Would the love you have vowed to wait for that long?”

It tastes bitter, even for Adora, and she regrets it the moment she pushes the words out to the world between them.

But instead of making her uncomfortable or diming her down, Catra´s little grin just grows, throwing it blindly towards Adora. It´s like a secret that Catra still holds but for some reason Adora feels a part of it now too, and she cannot help but for her own mouth to twitch too.

“What do you say then?” Catra answers instead, making Adora give in.

“Yes. I think I'd like that”

Catra´s smile is so bright it seems to lift the rain all by itself, clearing the skies above their domes and letting the frail light of the half moon and the cluster of stars around it wash over them, still mingled with the bleeding oranges and reds from the sunset.

Adora stares at it, the way the shadows cast elliptical shapes over the water and over them; the way the tide moves alongside the moon´s journey; the way the stars cluster themselves in known patterns, constant yet ever moving.

All those things Adora used to see and know and drink of when she was much younger and much less tired. All those things that made her herself before this, before guilt, before exile.

“I was a scholar.” Adora blurts out, staring at the circles shining over Catra's skin. “I studied and read and learned too. I loved learning, I wanted to know everything about the world and beyond it”

Catra beams at her, brightening like a sun when she understands what Adora is doing. It´s a sight to see, for some reason only granted to Adora.

“What did you like the most?” Catra asks, resting her face on her palm, herlong eyelashes casting shadows over her freckles.

“Architecture.” Adora gulps, chewing through the sticky sweetness suddenly gathering on her tongue. “And mathematics and astronomy. They can both be mirrors of each other, they all coexist in perfect harmony. Science and magic and the universe”

Catra smiles at her, fueling the fires sparking back to life inside Adora´s chest. Now that Adora has opened her mouth and spoken the words she does not seem to be able to stop herself, stumbling upon each other as they rush to come out after years and years of being buried deep below the cracks of her heart.

I learnt about planets and stars and constellations and the way they could mold into columns and ceilings.” Adora gasps, holding to herself and to the droplets of rain still hung from her eyelashes. “I dreamt of building a place that would feel like touching the point where the sun meets the earth. I traced things, painted them on parchment and dug them with my nails on the walls of your temple. Something constant that was to survive the pass of time. Something more than royalty or gods, something meant for the everlasting sky.”

Adora closes her eyes, pinching the corner with her nails. Something seeing the world hurts, sometimes it aches too much, being cursed with a sight. She can still see the polished edges and confident strikes of her own hand over the fabrics and papers, building the stars inside columns and ceilings, dreaming of other kinds of open domes that would cradle the skies inside the mortal world.

Dreams so filled with her curiosity and her hope that were testimonies of the person Adora craved to be, not Etherian´s beauty but a teacher and a builder. A lover.

“The heavens… the heavens are simple.” Adora lets her eyes open again, following the twinkle of the stars with her irises. “The earth moves, around the heavens, around the skies. There are… people, scientists, mathematicians that theorize that all things wonderful in our world might be because of us moving across the everlasting skies.”

“Moving?” Catra´s ears flicker, leaning ever so slightly towards Adora. “Like a bird?”

Adora shakes her head even if Catra cannot see her, humming under her breath.

“Like a fruit, circling around its own stem when given a little nudge.” Adora digs her finger on the softened earth around the lake, drawing an ellipse there. Then very gently she takes the hem of the fabric around Catra´s sleeves, guiding her hand towards the carving so she can follow the shape with her fingertips too. “Nothing but an optical illusion of the planets around them and us, around the sun. Ever changing yet steady. Moving alongside other planets but never against the paths of the stars you weave“

“Me?” Catra breathes, her pretty eyebrows raising on her forehead when she understands, shooting her hand towards the embroidery of her hemation, “Those are stars?”

“Yes. You weave celestial maps.” Adora grins, staring at Catra´s fingers drawing her own kind of shapes on the earth. “And you are so precise, it's as if you had the heavens painted inside your irises. What you remember as shapes are constellations. And in the middle, the sun”

When Adora raises her eyes she finds Catra´s cheeks quickly colouring in red, making the golden of her freckles pop even more against her skin. Catra´s face is full of wonder too, her half opened eyes wandering among the silver light of the night and the shadows around them, as if she was painting an image of the galaxies inside her head.

“The sun at the center of everything,” Catra whispers to herself, seemingly truly marvelled, making the dimple in Adora´s cheek curl.

In all her years, nobody had ever stopped to listen to Adora´s rambles about the sky and its wandering marvels, too distracted by her so-called physical beauty, too amazed by her face to actually pay attention to what she truly cared about.

“Yes. An heliocentric model they called it.” Adora murmurs, shivering. “My father used to call the sun the *queen of the stars* , making us just another wanderer on her path.”

But Catra is listening, she truly is listening to Adora´s voice, uncaring of the look of her face either beautiful or monstrous or of anything physical. She is sitting right here next to Adora and listening.

“That's… wonderful.” Catra exhales, bright herself as a sun.

“It is.” Adora leans back, unconsciously uncurling from herself as she rests her weight over her palms. “I loved learning about it all.”

Very very softly, almost without sound at all, Catra scoots closer to Adora over the moss, the fabrics of their tunics mingling with each other. It's not a touch, not just yet, but it's the closer they have gotten in months and it feels light, easy and familiar between them.

“Tell me.” Catra asks and when Adora looks at her she finds out Catra has already tilted her head towards her, following her voice like she follows the sound of the bracelets and the wind.

“Which part?”

“Everything”



Adora is accustomed to nightmares. She has been living with them every single night for the past five years, plaguing her dreams with their hark hands and drowning her inside their silence and their fear.

It always goes like this, running. Running until her chest constricts and her lungs burn, past the tall columns of the corridors of her home. White, golden, red tapestries that then bleed into green, a green so sick and so unnatural that makes Adora gasp and arch over herself, threatening to tumble her into the ground by their sight alone.

She goes like this for endless seconds, stretching into infinite minutes and hours and whole lives, the shadows closing around her like a bad omen and a promise of terrible sorrow. Then, there comes the screams.

One by one, all around her, inside her, chasing her down and seizing her by the throat. Pained but in a different kind from sorrow. Angry, furious, spatting at her and screaming the most unholy of things. Cursing her, slapping her, dragging her name into the ground when they cannot touch her body, destroying her in a different way than dying.

And she knows these voices, the inflexion, the tone, they are familiar to her. They belong to every single person of her homeland, of her palace and her market and her temples. From the little child at the ambulant market to the priestess on her altar to the royal woman at the foot of the throne. To her parents.

They are there too, standing in front of her, hovering above her like the judgment day, both dictator and executioner. Marlena´s and Randor´s eyes are void, black pools of voids that

stare back at her with disdain and that make her inadequate, wrong, guilty. A monster.

You killed him, it's all Adora can hear from their mouth even if they don't move at all, dolls from a theatre play meant to make her mad. *You are going to kill her too. You kill everything you love.*

Adora looks at their faces and tries to scream, to beg, to push back towards them but she is unable too, frozen in place as they fall against her with their hands covered in steel, wrapping Adora´s mouth and eyes and her whole soul inside their merciless gasp.

This is, in the last weeks, where the music starts slipping inside the dream. Sweet as a lyre and tender, a golden string of light pulling Adora outside the thick and heavy darkness of the dream.

Today however the music is different. Today as Adora trashes and sleep fights on the hard stone that makes her bed, what awakes her is not the hum of lullaby but her own name, called from the real world and into the dream one with urgency on every corner.

“Adora,” Catra calls again, and it sounds pleading. “Adora, please wake up”

Adora´s eyes fly open, the dream crumbling into pieces all around her much like the mask that once drowned her face and her breath. She gasps, a sharp intake of air that even among the silence sounds deadly quiet, jolting awake and trying to place what is truly happening around her.

The dim light of the moon slips a little inside the cavern through the open domes, shimmering above the calm waters of the lake and illuminating partially of the sleeping cave.

Everything is calm, calmer than the turmoil inside Adora´s dreams, the trees quiet and the animals living inside of them peacefully sleeping. The waterfall is constant and calm and the fire of the pyre still creaking a little over the slightly damp stone, a fountain of both warmth and light falling across every corner of the cavern walls.

A shadow hovers softly above Adora´s head, present but still far away enough that when Adora jolts her whole body to take on the sight of it she doesn´t accidentally hit her in the face with surprise.

“Adora,” Catra calls again, her hand partially extended in front of her but never getting to touch Adora at all.

She is on her night chiton, long and of a deep blue, brushing her bare soles and embroidered in the hem with stars. She is wearing her mother´s hemation too, tossed across her back and the angles of her elbows, deeply red and colorful by the intricate scenery woven on the very strands, falling behind her like a long veil over her ankles and across the stones and the moss.

All of her hair is loose, bouncing below her waist and against the small of her back, framing the edges of her face sweetly. And she smells good, like fresh oranges and the mountain laurel that grows at the feet of the temples.

Her expression though, her expression is terrible. Her eyes are sunken inside their sockets, rimmed by deeply purple circles and pulled down. She holds them halfway open, slits of silver visible through her long eyelashes, but it is obvious that she can barely hold herself on her own feet, tilting dangerously to the side every once in a while.

She looks exhausted, utterly and completely tired to the bone, looking for Adora among the darkness that blinds her further. And she looks unsure too, as if she didn´t know if Adora was really there at all, simply calling for her among shadows.

Adora scrambles on her makeshift bed, straightening up with her heart beating wildly inside her chest.

“What is it?” Adora gasps, blinking away the last traces of sleep and nightmares from her eyes. “What happened?”

Catra wrinkles her nose as she always does when she is nervous, a motion that Adora finds quite frankly adorable, shifting on her toes as her ears flicker at the sides of her head. She bites onto her bottom lip several times before speaking again, tangling with her own vocal cords when she pushes the words into the space between them.

“Can you sleep with me?” She asks, pressing her ears at the sides of her head.

Every single thought goes extremely loud inside Adora´s head, swirling and eviscerating themselves against her head and the pits of her heart. Adora´s eyes go wide as copper plates, her mouth falling open already with a negation clearly sealed inside her mouth.

“Catra–”

“I can't sleep.” Catra cuts her, twisting the hem of the hemation around her fingers. “I can´t sleep and when I do, I have nightmares every night. I'm exhausted”

There is urgency in Catra´s voice, a kind of desperate exhaustion that makes Adora´s heart squeeze inside her chest. She sounds like she might collapse in any second, angry with herself for asking for help in the very first place and completely drowned from any kind of energy. She isn´t even using the cane, finding her way across the pebble paths by the touch of her soles alone.

Of course Adora knows Catra is not sleeping either, she is not ignorant either to the way Catra also tosses in bed and grunts in her sleep. Adora saw her floating in the middle of the lake to try and drown the tiredness, and she has seen the red that rims her eyes, pulling her down even when she is trying to remain bubbly and excited around the cavern.

She knows even though she tries to sleep more she is always awake at dawn, even when she remains curled on the tree bed for hours after.

Adora knows a great deal about pain and about exhaustion, Catra does too.

She knows Catra is not ignorant to Adora´s nightmares either, her songs have guided Adora outside the dark for weeks that have started to become months. It would only be fair, isn´t?

“Please, just– we don't have to touch. Just lie next to me.” Catra asks again, her voice growing slightly more restless, shattering in the edges as she starts to feel herself more and more unsure about what she is doing standing here. “Please”

A beat and then..

“Alright,” Adora gasps, almost as if it wasn't her speaking at all but something deep within her soul. “Alright”

Maybe Adora wants to be selfish, just a little bit just for a little while. Just enough to get a glimpse of what could have been in another life, a single excuse to be as near as possible without harming her at all.

Catra exhales heavily, visibly trembling from head to toe as, even at night, as if she didn't actually believe Adora would agree with her at all. She nods before turning around on her ankles and starting to walk down the pebble path. She follows the stones easily, as if she knew them by memory alone and for a second it makes Adora wonder if this is the first time Catra has wandered here veiling for Adora´s violent dreams.

The ground is freezing cold when Adora stands up in slightly wobbly feet, chilling her to the bone. Even when the days are almost unbearably sticky hot as the last of the spring and the start of summer rolls by, the nights are still cold, Adora shivers and walks behind Catra´s steps across the cavern, passing right beside the fire pyre and next to the lake.

She follows the hem of Catra´s hemation against the pebbles, dragging behind her alongside the ends of her night chiton and for a moment Adora has the urge to bend down and grab the soft fabric between her hands, carrying it off the moss like a veil so it doesn´t stain as Catra guides them both back to the olive bed.

Adora doesn´t.

The temple is slightly warmer when Adora steps inside, the first time in four months after Catra´s arrival. There are a few oil lamps lit on the sides, hanging on their small copper and clay plates and creaking with the air from the waterfall, but Catra leans over them immediately, deeply aware of where they are placed as she blows into them and submerges the temple´s chamber into further darkness.

Only the frail moonlight illuminates the floor and partially the bed now. Adora blinks a few times around the newfound darkness, adjusting to it as she watches Catra move quiet and quick among the chamber, blowing up the candles and gathering the bundle of sheets thrown on the floor.

Adora stares at her in silence, opening and closing her hands nervously to her sides. She feels dizzy enough to be nauseating, biting back the sudden dread and apprehension deeply gathering on the back of her throat.

Catra has told her before that she can distinguish shadows and movements around her, especially if there is light nearby. Adora has seen her wander around the stone paths of the cavern lighting candles to illuminate her way when night has fallen. And she has seen her

sitting under the plain ray of the sun coming from the domes, stretching lazily around the golden light.

Adora knows why she is doing this, moving around the bed to unclip the fabrics of the canopy and finding her way towards the bed in the shadows, modifying immediately and without a word the little peace she has made for herself inside the temple.

She is allowing Adora comfort, of a safe place even when Catra cannot see her. Of being able to surround herself with shadows if she wants and take a breath from herself, even if just for tonight. The snakes curling on Adora´s head are still wrapped with fabrics into knots, itching her scalp and making the corner of her eyes damp.

It´s a small mercy maybe, or maybe it is pity, washing over Adora and her curse in the middle of the night. A warm feeling very similar to fondness and terrifyingly close to gratitude starts to bloom inside her chest, making Adora recoil with herself for a second.

Catra climbs inside bed, past the canopy of soft fabrics, resting on her side. She is the furthest away from the entrance of the temple, facing the slightly crumpled pieces of what once was the altar. It's very hot inside the cavern so she doesn't cover herself with the sheets, but she does push them slightly to the side, in Adora´s direction.

Adora lingers her gaze from her back, curved and pretty below the soft fabric of her chiton, and towards the columns of the temple´s entrance, frozen for a second. She had never shared a bedrest with anyone, not even once. The only person she ever got close to was her own brother, on kind circumstances and gentle sleepovers when they were children and the night before he died.

Adora can still hear the voice of her nightmares inside her head, tormenting her, repeating over and over again and telling her that, if she dares to step inside the sacred space of this bed she will pay the painful consequences later. That, if she allows her heart to bloom open and nuzzle on the warmth of a shared bedrest, she will not survive the heartache later.

She could still leave. She could still walk out of the temple and go bad to her stone bed; Catra has given her the side towards the columns, where Adora doesn't feel caged and where she could just walk out if she wanted.

Adora slips inside the canopy, very carefully climbing the bed and letting herself fall flat over the very corner.

She holds her breath, frozen, staring at the pretty branches of the olive tree above their heads, twisting and turning into lovely knots as their leaves form a makeshift ceiling, covering the bed from the rest of the world.

Like this, Adora is several inches away from Catra yet she can still feel the warmth of her body there, right next to her. She can feel the cadence of her breathing, heavy and relaxed, to the very ends of her toes; and she can smell the scent of her sleeping body, night sweat and sweetness coming from her skin that gathers on Adora´s nose and makes her mouth water.

Adora narrows her eyes, staring at the pretty leaves and the fruits hanging above her head and heart, the green of their surfaces almost indigo underneath the shadows of the quiet night. She can hear Catra sighing next to her, she can feel her tail wrapping around her own waist and the way she seems to very slowly unfold from herself, as if Adora´s presence here alone had managed to free something deep within herself, allowing her to rest.

In a way, Adora can still hear Catra´s voice echoing across every single corner of the cavern, carrying the words of her stories and her life, falling alongside the droplets of the early rain that made the waterfall run quieter and the lake bigger. There is a lot of trust, in there, in here, inside this bed, a lot of trust placed inside Adora´s chest by Catra´s hands, blindly hoping Adora will be its safe keeper and still asking nothing in return.

It pulls something off Adora´s chest, something that feels a lot like letting loose too, like a knot not being cut open by force but just gently pulled undone with patience alone.

"I was a princess."

The words echo inside the canopy and only inside of it, not going beyond the limits of the bed but still loud, a whisper filled with such a heartbreaking emotion that it splinters like a crystal.

Adora gasps, her eyes going wide as her own words sink into her. It has been almost six years since she referred to herself as that, since she even thought about herself about what she was once. Such a long time that now that she confesses it to the middle of the night it almost doesn´t feel real; like a dream, long ago had that was so detailed that it felt almost real but that it never was nothing else but faux hope.

Adora bites into her mouth until it hurts, until it feels bitter instead of sweet, feeling as if the branches of the bed itself were closing over her, eating her alive inside of shadows and closing around her throat, robbing her off her breath like copper masks did before.

Catra´s tail brushes very softly against the side of her hip, right above the fabric, tearing Adora away from the shadow with her voice.

"I'm here"

Adora gasps and it's only when a tear falls against the curve of her temple and her sharpened ear that she realizes that she has started crying, rolling down her face quiet and unstoppable for the first time in many years.

"I was Etheria's Princess. I was heir to the throne." She keeps going, her voice breaking in all places. "The only daughter of mother and my father, the only sister of my brother"

"You miss them." Catra whispers, calm, so very calm. It does not throw her off at all and it doesn´t make her weary. Nothing about Adora´s confession makes her change and it gives Adora enough strength to keep going.

"Yes." Adora gulps, closing her eyes again. "And no. I know they did the best they could"

There is a moment of silence but it's not oppressive. Adora can feel Catra shuffling over the bed, almost as if something was bothering her, her tail stomping on the space between them.

“Adora”

“Hmm?”

“Don´t lie.” Adora holds her breath, Catra´s voice ringing in her ears. “Not to me.” Then she feels Catra move again, stilling over the bed. “It's just us”

It's true, it really is just them in here. There are no gods, no warriors, no fake kings here. No man or woman or folk but their two souls, laying on the same bed because neither of them can sleep. And if it breaks Adora in the end at least it was for allowing herself of some kindness.

“They betrayed me.” Adora says finally, the truth from her own mouth, loosening some of the grief rooted inside her heart. “My brother died and my parents betrayed me. They did not caused this but they allowed it to happen”

Adora exhales, finally moving, resting the back of her hand over her mouth, her teeth lightly grasping the skin of her knuckles when she bites back a sob against them.

“I don't hate them, I never could, I loved them.” Adora grimaces, shaking. “But I don't know if i will ever be able to forgive them”

“You don't need to,” Catra murmurs, her ears pressed tight down her temples, her back still turned, her voice still soft.

“I guess I don't.” Adora hiccups, letting her other hand fall to the side, grasping the hem of Catra´s tunic and holding herself to it with all her strength. “I wish I could learn how to let them go”

Up on the crowns of the trees that shelter this new kind of home, the blue birds stir slightly away, chirping, consoling each other. There were birds in the palace, inside Marlena´s chamber; they used to fly around the chamber with their colorful wings extended and free.

“I miss my mother,” Adora takes a shuddering breath, tears rolling down her cheeks cold and tired, the first ones in years here next to Catra´s body. “Not the person that allowed this but the one before. The one I had when I was a child. Who taught me about magic and about science and about love. I miss her, I think I started missing her way before I was send away”

The last time Adora saw them they were caged, feathers falling behind their golden bars, looking back at Adora as if they were one and the same. The last time she saw them they tumbled from the balcony from where Adora let them go, the hinges of the cage broken by her own hands.

“Why did she change?” Adora asks, not to Catra but to the air, to the darkness around them; to the cavern and the waterfall and the universe. And she sounds frail, like a scared child all over again, hiding underneath her blankets. “Why did she do it? I didn't want her to change.”

Catra shifts her weight, turning around fully. Adora holds her breath for a second, suddenly unsure about what she is going to do, but Catra only rearranges in the pillows still far away but facing Adora now. Her dark hand rests in front of her lap, knuckles down, palm up, open like a flower and waiting.

“Tell me,” she whispers and it feels like an opening.

“About what?” Adora murmurs back, slightly drowned by the stream of her tears.

“About her,” Catra opens her eyes, just a slit, silver color among the shadows letting Adora know she is right there next to her. “About your mom, the one you knew. I want to know all about her.”

Adora takes a breath, gazing at her calm face before letting go of all the tension inside her body. It feels like floating among the galaxies; like circling the universe, following the tail of the planets around a single star.

“I think–” The sun, at the center of everything, freckled and sweet and there. Adora lets her palm fall inside Catra´s, she holds her hand. “She was warm”

I used to shine bright like gold, now I'm all indigo

My colors are darker and cold, I think it's time that I went home (...)

I gave up a piece of my heart, then I turned to run

Oh, my head's in the clouds

But I don't feel close to the sun

– *Indigo,* **Sam Barber & Avery Anna**

Chapter End Notes

*Notes: Adora´s character in Medusa is slightly inspired by Hypatia. She was a Hellenistic woman who became the first female mathematician, astronomer and philosopher. She was a teacher and director of the Neoplatonic school in Alexandria, Egypt. She was born in a very turbulent era and sadly died too young and too fast.

Adora´s character has always been a highly intelligent person to me, which sometimes gets underseen by her role as a warrior and as She-Ra on the show. She definitely deserves more recognition for being more than a soldier but a smart person full of curiosity that otherwise would definitely become someone that loves learning new things. There is strength in wanting to study and learn just as much as being in battle.

However, that also has made her highly practical, especially after what happened. There is a full circle conversation about the birds, the sun and how they mirror Catra´s presence in Adora´s life.

Note 2. The characters at the beginning of the chapter are Athena and Ares. You will see traces of the gods and of course things that are happening in the war outside but I won't dive into it. That's not a part of neither Catra nor Adora's story for now.

Also HURRAH they have held hands, they are officially friends. This slow burn is killing me but we are one step closer to them smooching.

Thank you for all your support this year and happy new year. See you very soon, be good <3

Verse VI

Chapter Summary

"Catra was right, she is safe"

Chapter Notes

Do you rememeber when I said that I was going to write shorter chapters? Yeah, no, that didn´t happen because for some reason this is 20k words long and I wrote it in a week TT.TT

But! Let´s hope I can deliver a good chapter today for all of you! I wasn´t excepting on liking this chapter as much as I did but I really do!
Some warnings before going into it:
- Descriptions of wounds, blood and gore at the beggining of the chapter, nothing related to the girls
- While I stablished that there isn´t any kind of SA metaphors on this, nor there will be ABSOLUTELY ANY OF it, there is a conversations between the girls that might remember some people a little bit about those matters, especially given the roman myth of Medusa. I knew it could happen so I wrote it in hopes that it might help someone that is reading this story and that might need it

Also, as the girls progress on their frienship so does their immediate attraction for each other because they are SOULMATES, so I hope you enjoy some real good romantic and a also a tiny bit of sexual tension (which will be marked with **** in case you want to jump it over).

Without more to say, see you downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse VI.

Golden Spears

Only I know who I am,I am not woman or man

Protector of water and land, a voice of the meek and the damned

I rally all who are chosen, who don't let society hold them

Asylum for the hurt and the broken

Precious metal, I am golden

— *Yosemite,* **Iniko**

The halls of Castle Grayskull are covered in red.

Old, new, future, the crimson stains everything like clay, from the mosaics of the floor to the marble of the columns, soaking on the hems of the torn banners and tapestries. The blood spilled from war and greed stains the once golden corridors, drowning anything beautiful inside this place.

What once was the guiding light of the kingdoms, a tall jewel on the blue skies, a castle as tall as the mountain behind that reached towards the gods´s home, is now nothing more but crumbled pieces of past mightiness and spilled blood and wine.

If you were to step on the corridors of the palace, once upon a time, you would have heard the echo of the lyre´s strings against the high ceilings; or maybe the chattering of the philosophers and mathematicians on the atriums; the sparring battles of the soldiers from noble and humble houses, teaching each other how to win death by playthrough; or maybe even the far away steps of the princess and prince, walking side by side with their golden hairs and their crystal blue eyes.

Now, all that remains is the echo of the sounds of a once bright and prosperous kingdom. Now, all that remains is the blood of its suitors, of its people, fallen both by choice or by force against the whites of the royal walls.

The red matches the bleeding green of the flags, hanging from the golden spears above the floors. The guards' sandals stick on the floor by the drying floor, making them wrinkle their noses with each step. It´s a horrendous noise, blood holding to the soles from the ground, something barely heard in battle but that in the quietness of the empty palace rings like a thousand war horns, haunting to the bone.

The guards step inside the throne room, surrounded by columns of red and green, with the open domes of the high ceiling falling right above their heads. The moon doesn´t shine anymore, not in this sky, not in this land, taken away by the revengeful hands of Selene and Artemis, washing instead everything in the same kind of red fog that has plagued this earth for years now. In the sky, the clouds are virulent, gray and purple and deeply black, sliced in the middle by powerful lightning that never gets to actually fall against the earth.

Nobody mutters the names of the gods anymore, not the ancient ones or the new; nor the revengeful ones filled with dread or the ones death, their celestial bodies rotting on the dry earth below everybody´s feet. And those who do call their names are either filled with desperation or destined to die, waiting with their knees dug on the earth for the sword or the arrow to fall against their throats or hearts.

When the guards walk inside all they know, all they are allowed to worship, is the man sitting on the high throne of the Etherian kingdom, staring down at the old blood with green eyes. He is mighty, all on its own, with his pristine white robes and his sandals soaked by pure gold, with his crown of sharp spears instead of laurel and the broken wings hanging from his white hair. A mockery, a spit of the ground of this falling kingdom, disrespecting the queen and queen and the memory of their children.

If they had more power, the men walking inside would do the same. They are not so different from each other.

They stop in front of the grave of the prince, his form still kneeling on the ground, almost like surrendering himself down the feet of the men that had taken everything from him. His eyes, however, his eyes remain up, his face slightly tilted to the side, his mouth curled into a smile. He looks not afraid, not rageful, but loving, one last defiance towards submission and conquer and fear, expressed in one last look of love that the so-called Emperor has to bear over him every single time he sits in this place.

No matter how hard or violent he has tried to destroy the statue, no matter how many men or spears or sharp ends of swords have slashed against the white marble of the prince's last bed rest, the stone remains untouchable, unscarred, unbroken. It never waves underneath the pass of time and it never crumbles; it never gets stained by the blood or the ash and never wears done.

The statue remains as it was from the very same moment it was created, one last symbol of resistance that the people still look up to and that Emperor Prime hates.

“Speak then, little brother,” Prime drawls around his tongue, sly as as a hydra, looking through bored eyes at the scrunched figure of Hordak, flanked by the guards at his sides.

Hordak avoids his brother´s stare, looking at every single side and refusing his eyes. He too can see the blood staining the stairs of the throne and the hem of the Emperor´s tunic. He too can see the piled bodies without limbs or heads, devoured by the famished guard dogs of the Emperor or by the teeth of the soldiers driven crazy by hunger and rage. He can see it all.

Sometimes, sight is a curse.

“Menagerie has fallen,” Hordak says finally after a painful second, only coerced to speak by the feeling of the sharp end of the guards´blades against the divots of his back.

Emperor Prime hums, rolling his head backwards on the golden throne as he stares at the purple sky, smiling to himself when he lets his chin fall back against the points of his fingers.

“And why is that?” He is dragging this out, making it more painful, more terrifying. More fun. Hordak can hear the little *drip, drip, drip,* of the fresh blood falling over the mosaic floor next to where he stands.

“I–” Hordak tries but his voice falls flat, quiet and miserable among the mighty halls of past kings and queens.

“Well?”

“The woman that calls herself queen of Brightmoon invades us,” Hordak finally pushes out, biting into his tongue until it bleeds. The stench of blood makes him want to puke. “But it's just a province! One simple part of Eternia trying to play the heroes! The woman and her daughter have self proclaimed themselves and have no weight for your divine title!”

“And yet, your men lay dead by their arrows or by the plague and you have lost the land,” Emperor Prime taps against his temple with his nail, clicking his sly tongue against the roof of his mouth. “Did I not tell you to kill every single person that could have any reclaim to the throne? And still you let live the Brightmoon blood because you forgot?”

Hordak chokes on his tongue, pushing against his own words and the sharp stare of the man hovering on the throne above him. Under this light he almost looks wrong, green and red in a place that once was golden and laurel green.

“Brother,” Hordak tries, gasping when the man's eyes flash above his head, the weight of the guards still standing all around him closing further around his neck. “E– Emperor, the soldiers speak that she walks accompanied”

“By whom?” Prime asks, swirling on his hand the red wine inside the bright golden cup he is holding.

Hordak opens his mouth but he hesitates, shuffling on his feet. He knows a different kind of storm is starting to swirl inside the man in front of him, gathering inside his chest with every single word of Hordak´s mouth. But now that he has started it he cannot walk back from it.

“By the gods”

The cup slams against the marble floor, wine spilling on the very cracks with the strength of the outburst. Emperor Prime stands on a swirl, the top of his tunic stained with the spilled wine and his face absolutely furious, breaking into pieces with the amount of his rage.

“The gods?!” He exclaims, sputtering around a gush of red spit. He points towards himself, the sleeves of his tunic slipping down, showing off the long birthmarks like thunderbolts of his arms. “I am a god! I am your gods and every single miserable soul in this land vows to me! I have conquered the green of Eternia, purified it from their useless beliefs of other gods! I have taken it´s people by the throat and seized their lives under my will. I have done all of that by myself!”

Hordak grimaces, looking to the side. A spark of both annoyance and anger grows inside his chest too, angry at seeing himself being humiliated under the sight of the rest of the guards, as if he himself had not broken land and people too, as if he had not conquered them and make them his too without his half brother´s interference on it.

“The people say that you have not done it alone,” Hordak mutters through grinded teeth, closing his hands into fists. “They have put your worth at stake. They have said you have been blessed by a woman god and that is the only reason you lay there on the throne.”

Hordak meets Prime´s eyes, purple against bright green, mortal against half a god but never one. “They say you only stand there because your father is a god.”

Prime storms down the stairs of the throne, throwing himself white and green against his brother. He seizes him by the chin, tilting his head backwards until the bones of Hordak´s crooked back creak with the effort, sending him tumbling down the floor when his knees give up under the violence of the hold.

“Look at your wife,” Prime growls, baring his teeth at him. He has grown older, his mouth smells like death. “Look at her!”

Hordak gasps, shaking his head but Prime only holds him harder, forcing his entire head and body to the side, facing the place where the dripping noise is coming from.

Lystra´s body is facing the red sky. Her eyes are open, just as her mouth, forever etched into a single expression as the virulent clouds mirror against the pale green of her irises, fogged and dry. She was screaming, at some point, but there is no more sound inside the chamber anymore.

Instead, there are flies making their way around her, across her cheeks and eyelids, the thick arch of her dark eyebrows and the roots of her shadow hair, making a home on her gums and tongue, both egg and larvae and plague festering from the rotting smell of her skin.

They clean their wings against the gold of the spear that has stabbed her from the small of her waist all the way across the insides of her body, coming through the edge of her jaw and teeth to greet the blood drenched air around them.

She hangs a few feet above the ground where the spear, impaled across her body, lays dug on the marble of the throne chamber, standing like the morbid mockery of a goddesses statue or a spoiled godly offering. Her red tunic is soaked with her own blood, heavy, dark, thick as it spills on the ground covered by her own flesh and wine.

There was no godly hand on this and if there was it was not as a blessing, but as a curse, guided in a way by the breath of love herself, of harvest, of prophecies, of dreams, a retaliation to a woman that forsake her own blood and defiled her trust. The retaliation of betraying a child of the gods, even if no soul standing here knows that.

There was no mercy on this kill, only pain, only torture, only the hand of mortal men seeking for revenge for a land that has been ripped away from their conquer. Prime´s tunic is soaked through with blood, his pale face spotted with dry blood, shimmering crimson on his eyes when he stares at the terrified expression of his brother kneeling in front of him.

“I can take and I can give. I have the Fates on the palm of my hand.” Prime drags out, licking his own teeth clean from meat. No deer or cattle but human folk. “I am the god killer, I have sliced Athena´s face and gathered her ichor on my cup. I have split open the throat of her nieces and nephews. Draw my sword through deities and their sprouts until no other remains but me, and the ones who did ended up abandoning this world.”

Prime walks backwards, still drawing Hordak´s struggling body alongside him, his face splotched with rest where the hand of Prime steals his breath. Prime rests his other palm over the beautiful face of the Eternian Prince, leaving red stains over his stone hair.

“I have taken their honorable Princess and cursed her life and her body and transformed her into *my* monster.” Prime clicks his tongue against the roof of his mouth, not even blinking at all.“There is no god left that wants to roam the earth and there is no other child of the gods to reclaim their divine inheritance over this earth, Just me”

He lets go from Hordak´s throat, dropping him heavy and merciless over the cold floor of the palace. Prime throws his head back, running his red palms over his hair to bring it all back to its place, exhaling with a deep sigh.

“You have disappointed me greatly, little brother, and your failure has hurt me deeply.” Prime starts walking backwards towards the throne, his arms open at his side like some humble statue. He smiles at the sound of his bastard brother´s wet coughs, the grin wrinkling the corners of his eyes. “I believe it is time for us to part”

Hordak´s eyes go wide, his bleeding scleras almost shimmering among the darkness of the throne room. He feels the guards moving around him, regaining their speed and strength like puppets obeying their owner´s silent command.

“What do you mean?” Hordak snaps his head up, staring as the guards turn towards him, grabbing their own golden spears and holding them above their heads. “No, no. No!”

Other guards' arms shoot forward, wrapping themselves around Hordak´s limbs, over his shoulders and elbows and slicing the tendon of the back of his feet, in the same place where the butcher of Troy was condemned to death. It cuts and bleeds and with it takes away the possibility for Hordak to run, to stand at all, anchoring him to the marble floor and to the will of half of his blood.

“I have done everything you asked from me! Everything! I have taken and broken and defiled, I have given this kingdom to you!” Hordak howls, bending in half by the pain, crawling over his body and his head.

“You have filled your own hubris with my glory and you have called yourself a king.” Prime lets himself fall back into the golden throne, tilting his head to the side. “There is no place in this world for another King but me.”

The guards hover the sharp end of their spears over Hordak´s head, ready to fall down like arrows against the ground. They will cross against the eyes and nostrils, past the mouth and the tongue, below the ears and side to side from the throat. Make their way on the chest and the back of the shoulder, past hip and joints and into the very marble floor, slicing him like raw meat in the middle of the throne room.

The screams are so loud that they make Prime´s eardrums ring but there is no discomfort for him. Quite the contrary the fear makes him smile, crossing his fingers below his chin and leaning back so he can watch.

“Goodbye, little brother”

There are no coins for Charon on the dead bodies, not tonight, and even if they were, these souls are destined to roam sorrowfully for a long while, lost on the limits of the rivers, mourning as they have offended the gods by attempting towards their golden bloodline.

After all, Hades is king of the underworld and he would undo the seams of the godly laws for his wife. After all, Persephone was once golden and she held her newborn niece in her arms, half a mortal and half a god, half the wife of a queen to be also defiled of her own innocence by war.

On the earth though, Prime drums his sharp fingernails over the throne of solid gold and hums, tilting his head to the side. Because as much as he will never accept it outloud, no son of Zeus has ever failed to conquer and destroy everything beautiful. Not even once.



“Adora, if you drop me I swear to gods—”

“Stop moving then”

“Stop swinging on your feet then!”

Adora grunts, rearranging her hold over Catra´s thighs above the crumpled fabric of her tunic. Catra´s ankles are digging, slightly painful, above Adora´s ribs and the latter is making a monumental effort to not burst into laughter every single time either of them move.

They are standing in front of the thick barks of the cavern´s trees, dangerously swinging from one side to the other as they try to make a joint effort to unstick the golden arrow dug over one of the wide branches of the evergreen tree.

Catra is sitting over Adora´s shoulder, her belly resting over the back of Adora´s veiled head, grasping herself to Adora´s shoulder for dear life with her sharp nails. Adora can feel Catra´s tail tightly wrapped around her own biceps, grabbing every single inch of Adora´s body as she physically can to not fall from her spot over her back.

Catra did not dimensioned exactly how tall the godforsaken thing was when she motioned Adora to bow down so she could climb over her back instead; just as she did not dimensioned just how tall Adora actually was, the ground disappearing from below her feet as Adora stood up again with slight to not effort at all, holding Catra´s entire weight easily over her back.

But then again they have been here for the past ten minutes and where Catra has been freaking out for most of them, Adora has started to get bored and slightly sore on the arms, biting into her mouth as she focuses to place them both exactly below the arrow´s direction.

This is all Catra´s fault too, by the way, or that´s what Adora mutters silently to herself as she holds Catra tighter over her, digging her fingertips over Catra´s knees.

“Am I close?” Catra asks, stretching her right arm in front of her to try and find the feathered end of the arrow. Her left arm, however, is still wrapped around Adora´s head, digging her nails slightly over the side of her shoulder.

“A little to your right” Adora mumbles above catra´s forearm, narrowing her arms as Catra stretches further up. “Closer, closer, there!”

Catra chuckles in victory, wrapping her entire palm around the slim arrow. She gathers herself with bravery and lets go off Adora´s head too, leaning forward to rest her palm over the bark and use the leverage to pull from the arrow until the living wood gives away under the strength and releases the arrow fully into Catra´s palms.

“Gotcha,” Catra exclaims with a victorious yelp, palming the side of the tree softly. “Sorry for that”

Catra lets go of the tree, losing her grasp on anything solid the moment she does so. Catra gasps, holding the somehow unbroken arrow against her chest as she swings backwards dangerously, gravity pulling down from her with each hesitant movement.

“Oh gods,” Catra mutters, wrapping herself fully around Adora´s whole head, the arrow still tightly held in her hand.

Adora gasps, sliding her feet to the side to not lose her balance and throw them both into the ground. On the back of her head she begs the serpents knotted on the ribbons of her veils to not move a single inch, not to sizzle or twitch or do anything at all. Not while Catra´s chest and throat are resting fully over them, trusting Adora not to fail her and drop her down.

“Don´t be afraid,” Adora manages around a grunt, trying her best to lower herself down very gently over the floor. “I'm going to kneel down”

“Alright,” Catra mutters somewhere above Adora´s head, her nails slightly grasping the edge of Adora´s jaw. “So gentle of you, princess”

“If you keep calling me that, I´m going to drop you. On purpose”

“Oh, I´d like to see you actually do it.”

Adora rolls her eyes, huffing. In another time, maybe months ago, or with another person completely the title would have made her spiral badly inside her own head. But it has been months now, eight since Catra came into the cave and two since the night Adora confessed to her who she used to be. She knows there is no real ill intention underneath Catra´s petty nickname.

There is sweat dripping below the veil and across the back of Adora´s nape and the middle of her spine. She finally manages to kneel on the moss covered floor without falling on her face, taking several deep breaths before palming Catra´s calf very gently, letting her know they are on safe ground.

Catra untangles off her very slowly, almost as if taking her time, dropping her bare soles on the grass and making sure she is steady on her feet before daring to let go of Adora´s arms at all.

Touch has been a new discovery for them lately. In a way, it feels as exhilarating as the first day that Adora learnt about the universe beyond the celestial domes in the sky. A new kind of learning both filled with beautiful and terrifying things.

By all means, Catra never presses it but she always starts it. She places her palm above the bed or her fingers near the pillows of the fireplaces, or her arm and wrist near the baskets of fruits and vegetables, open and waiting for Adora to take if she wishes, and lately Adora has been wishing a lot. She allows Adora to take the step closer, the decision to step away or to hold herself to Catra´s hands and fingers.

The first night, exhausted from crying and with her voice sore, Adora did not sleep at all. She stayed awake the whole night, looking through dampened eyelashes at their joined hands on the bed, staring and staring until she convinced herself that they were two fleshes, two skins warm and slightly damp with sweat, holding onto each other through the night. Until she convinced herself that neither of them were cold stone and that Adora was not holding herself to statues anymore.

And later, the day after, Adora got sick. She got dizzy and feverish and a little delirious, and she scared Catra half to death. But Adora´s illness did not come from plague but from something deeper, a sense of connection after so many years persecuted and tosses aside, looking down as a monster and a murderer by everyone and herself, the single touch of their palms together manages to crumble almost all of Adora´s barriers, tumbling her body down too.

After the fever washed out and Adora ate for the first time in three days, it was easier. Everything, even breathing.

Catra, who had sat next to the olive bed with her face pale and her hands wet from dipping clothes into fresh water to run across Adora´s forehead, had her hand over the end of Adora´s pillows, cuticles bitten like Adora´s when she got nervous too and her lips pressed together as if holding all the anguish of the world inside her mouth. Very slowly, Adora had hooked their little fingers together and they had gone from there.

The touches were easy, gentle, almost like an afterthought. A brush of the fingertips when handing things to the other, be it food or thread or fabric; slips on the back of their knuckles when standing too close, Catra´s freckled skin against Adora´s dark golden one. Their elbows whispering together when taking a walk towards the cold cave beyond their cavern; Catra´s palm resting over Adora´s forearm when the stone paths were too wet by the rain for her soles and cane to guide her alone. Joined hands to sleep, no matter if they were on their sides or on their backs or curled inside themselves as they dreamt, holding each other through the night.

None of them have had a single nightmare since that time.

Today, many weeks later, Adora stares as Catra gives little jumps over the grass, rolling the length of the golden arrows across her elegant fingers. She has a tiny smirk on her face, the kind that stretches on her mouth every single time she is plotting for some mischievous thing that will speed up Adora´s hand or when she is very happy on the day. Adora likes it, no matter which one of the two is it.

“Remind me again who taught you to do archery?” Adora asks, standing up from the floor, shaking off the tiny sticks and leaves from her tunic.

Where Adora´s head is tightly wrapped in veils, the rest of her clothes are looser, knotted on the shoulder and the fall of her back by thick ribbons and clothes. She is wearing leather bands around her wrists and the perpetual coin bracelets on her ankles, right above clasps of her sandals. Catra has told her countless times she does not need to jingle around to announce her presence on the cavern but Adora thinks this is the last she can do for Catra, who is in a way still quite vulnerable to the things she cannot see.

In front of her Catra leans down, finding the polished surface of the bow she had fetched from one of the corners of the cave on their last trip for meat and thread. She is also wrapped in loose clothes, the material of the chiton crossed above her pretty chest leaving exposed the entire skin of her fall, scattered with moles and freckles. The hem of her skirt is held by belts and hooks to the sides of her waist, keeping it from dragging behind her or from hindering her way across the cavern.

All of her long and dark hair falls free across the middle of her spine, held above her head with scarfs and ribbons into a high ponytail, barely managing to push the loose curls of her bangs off sticking to her eyelashes. There is a perpetual flush on her cheeks and neck from their exercise and the fine almost peach-like hair from her long ears dusts over the corner of her jaw in matted spots from the sweat.

She smells incredible too and Adora has to make a physical effort to look away, gulping.

“A young man arrived at my town a long time ago,” Catra says, weighing the fine arrow with her hand as she tilts her head slightly backwards, her fogged eyes slightly open. “He was a real idiot. He got lost in the woods the very first day I met him and I had to guide him all the way back to the town. From then on he insisted on working on the fields and learning things about the farm at the same time he offered to teach me the things he had learnt on his big home citadel”

Catra chuckles, almost to herself, shaking her head softly as she lets her head fall slightly down. She feels the edge of the arrow with her thumb, following the ragged end of the copper material.

“He was my best friend,” she whispers, her ears flattening at the sides of her head.

Adora watches her as she rests her palm over the side of her shoulder, where the clasps of her tunic lay, caressing with her fingertips the limits of the brooch hidden as always by the wrinkles of her tunic. It´s a grounding motion, Adora has come to learn, something Catra does when she is feeling suddenly too much, too fast. Adora does it too sometimes, holding herself to the things of herself that remain the same.

Catra huffs after a moment, dropping her shoulder and her hand with a loud exhale. Her tail lashes behind her a few times, curling over her ankles and softly switching over the moss as taps on the intricate carvings over the wood. Double concave and obviously expensive on its time, coated by leafs of gold and once belonging to a warrior trying to gain their fame from Adora´s death. Once a product of death looks almost gentle in Catra´s elegant hands,

“But he did say I sucked at this, if I´m being fair.” Catra tilts her head to the side, resting the wood of the bow above her shoulder. She seems to understand Adora´s silence, even feet away from her, because the corner of her mouth twitches a little, resting her closed fist over her hip with an annoyed arch of her eyebrows. “Spit it out already, Adora”

Adora hums, resting her palms over her waist, absently mirroring Catra´s posture. She smiles from ear to ear, a shit eating grin making its way across her face as she looks at the bow and then back at Catra´s impatient face, all scorched up and annoyed in front of her.

“Well, do you think it might be because maybe you don't know what you're aiming for?” She asks, grinning like an idiot when Catra´s face falls further, darkening in the edges completely.

“There are blind people who are incredible warriors, excelling with the arrow and bow,” Catra deadpans, drumming her fingers over her forearms.

“I agree. And you are excellent at many things. Absolutely incredible actually,”

Adora looks towards Catra´s loom quickly, catching sight of the long shroud she has been waving there for several weeks. The ellipses and raised edges of the planets and stars that Adora describes for her on nights where Catra doesn´t tell her stories greet her back, colorful and beyond all things beautiful, a miracle in thread from someone who knows the world in a different way as everybody else.

“But maybe, just maybe, archery is just not your thing,” Adora adds, approaching the long satchels hanging from the branches and filled with wheat that Adora had hung as targets for Catra to practice.

Adora hears Catra grunt, deeply annoyed, and she turns her head around just in time to see her grasp the bow and place the arrow again, straightening her back and tilting her head just slightly to the side. She looks beautiful like this, pretty and dangerous, her silver eyes opened wide to catch the silhouettes around them before letting go off the arrow without a second thought.

Adora jumps out of reach just in time, yelping under her breath as she steps to the side and then down, watching the arrow cut across the space between Catra and the target and missing it completely by several inches.

The arrow flies like a lost bee, crashes on the flat surface of a stone and loses strength as it promptly plumpers towards the ground, stabbing its way across a feather pillow placed on the floor to avoid either Catra or Adora from slipping and breaking their necks around the roots of the trees.

“Stars,” Adora marvels under her breath, standing up again with a devilish grin. “Well, that was really close. You killed a pillow”

Catra lowers down the bow towards her knees, scowling deeply. “Did I hit you?”

“No”

“What a pity”

She is bluffing. Adora knows because she saw her just a split of a second before throwing the arrow. Catra heard Adora yelp and tilted the arrow in the opposite direction, completely missing her shot.

It makes Adora grin stupidly. She feels it on her cheeks.

“Alright, hand it over,” Adora chants, approaching Catra with a newfound sprint on her feet. “I don´t know who taught you but I´m going to show you some proper archery now”

“Um,” Catra hums, her eyebrows raising on her forehead. Adora takes the bow from her hands gently, nudging her a little to the side with her hip.

Catra still has that strange and pretty expression on her face but she lets Adora be, maybe feeling the excitement leaving Adora's body in waves. She carefully sits on the arched and huge root of one of the trees, crossing her ankles together and humming.

Adora is too busy reaching for the rest of the arrows, thrown carelessly inside the same basket where they carry bread and fruit towards their fireplace.

It has been a long time since Adora wielded any weapon at all, no matter what shape or size. It has been a long time since she saw an arrow or spear or sword as anything but an object to break against her skin and hint for her head.

She is still quite surprised that she hasn't had a breakdown yet, but for some reason the plain and selfish reason of showing off to Catra's proud eyebrows is enough for her to excitedly pull from the string of the bow and aim with perfect sight at the targets on the trees, letting go of the bow immediately after.

The first arrow crosses the center of the wheat satchel, perfectly placed in the very middle with a swift wind. Adora grins to herself, exhaling softly through her mouth as she takes her hand back and grabs the end of another arrow, easily placing it back on its place against the bow.

The second arrow is sent flying across the cavern, slicing against the second target with so much strength and precision that it crosses it from side to side, the tip digging against the tree behind.

Adora releases her breath, narrowing her eyes. It's exhilarating, standing here in the middle of the golden sunlight and the cavern covered with grass. There is adrenaline pumping inside her veins, very different to the one that runs down her veins every single time someone has pointed an arrow towards her head just to turn into stone instead. This one is familiar, so

much like the one she used to feel back at home, standing among her people and practicing and practicing under the gaze of her father until she was more than good.

A third arrow flies through the air, higher this time on the furthest target from the ground. It digs itself on the loose wood painted with blue tincture with Adora´s fingertips as a way to signal the center. The plank of wood trembles with the hit and the rope gives up, falling with a muted clank over the floor.

There is one last target, placed almost as a joke by Catra when they started doing this out of boredom. The satchel filled with grain floats in the middle of the lake, placed inside one of their bigger baskets so it would not sink down. It moves from side to side unexpectedly, moved by the wind slipping through the open domes.

Adora grabs the last arrow, resting her forehead and cheek against the side of the polished bow. The arch is made of lighter wood than the one she owned in Eternia, easier to move around but also less stable, not meant to endure the pass of battle. Absently she thinks it's almost a joke that someone decided to confront her with this to begin with. Absently she doesn´t even realize the thought comes to her easily, without making her feel in fear but instead making her scowl with annoyance.

The satchel floats in a slow circle over the lake, rolling over itself before facing Adora again. And with the sun of the midday Adora can see the shadows of the dome above it, perfectly elliptical, perfectly in place, not as full of entropy as anybody could have thought before.

Adora inhales very slowly through her nose and tightens the string of the bow until she feels the edge of the feathered arrow cut invisible lines on her cheeks, until her back protests from being held so straight and unmovable and the serpents on her head sizzle very, very quietly with expectancy.

The arrow hits the very heart of the satchel and sends it tumbling backwards, falling against the quiet water with a wet thud, successfully sinking it and the entire basket below the surface of the lake. So perfectly aimed that Adora doesn´t break a sweat at all.

Adora cheers with a loud laugh, dropping all seriousness as she brings the bow against her chest and jumps on her place like an excited little kid, clapping her hands together with delight.

“Ha! Did you see that?!” Adora chants, still laughing, turning around to face Catra with a huge self-satisfied smile.

Catra is still sitting on the root, her ankles crossed and her elbow resting over the twisted trunk. Her cheek is leaned against her palm, fingers drumming over the sides of her temples every few seconds. There is a certain kind of expression in her beautiful face, sweet but also filled with some kind of mirth, an all too knowing smile stretched on her lips as she patiently waits for Adora to realize exactly what happened.

Realization falls over Adora little bit little and then all together, her entire face paling as she drops the bow on the ground. “Oh”

Catra´s grin stretches from ear to ear, the tip of her fangs clear below her lips. “Wow”

Adora flushes red from head to toe, bringing her hands towards her mouth, mortified. “Oh, stars. Fuck”

“I'm speechless”

“Catra–”

“Absolutely flabbergasted”

“Please don't be a little shit”

“Knocked the air off my chest and everything”

Adora groans, covering her entire face with her palms, speaking muffled through her finger. “You are insufferable, you know that?”

Catra throws her head back and laughs, almost falling off the gods forsaken root with the strength of her laughter. The lilac color of her chiton is blazing with golden powder where the sun falls over her and her pretty neck tenses every single time she giggles, distracting Adora completely from all her thoughts.

“I like getting a rise out of you?” Catra shrugs, slightly bending over herself when Adora grunts and she falls into laughter again.

“Very funny,” Adora chews between her teeth, her shoulders drooping after a second. “I´m really sorry, though. I– um”

“You forgot I could not see your archery marvels,” Catra finishes for her, easy and without anger. “I also sometimes forget that we know certain things about the world in different ways. It's alright, I did not take offense on it”

Adora shuffles on her feet, wrinkling her nose. “Are you sure?”

“Yes, Adora.” Catra sprints back into her feet, searching with her fingertips for the marble cane resting near her. Held straight up instead of parallel to the ground, the cane is almost as tall as she is. “You´ve been most kind about this. And you have done a lot of things to make this place easier for me.”

Somehow, Adora thinks Catra is not only talking about polishing the cane or digging stone paths on the unfamiliar ground of the cavern. Adora bites into her own tongue, still unable to let go from the spark of guilt crawling on her guts.

“I´m not– I think is just basic decency”

“Perhaps,” Catra shrugs, turning around as she feels the terrain around her with her cane, looking for something. “Perhaps it's just because you're sweet.”

Adora flushes again, this time for a very different reason than before.

“Anyway, forget archery, there is something I'd like to try”

Adora watches as Catra finally finds what she is looking for, bending down with a small hum and letting go from her cane just so she can grab two of the long golden spears she hand convinced Adora to drag all the way from the cave to the inside of the cavern.

At first Adora thought she wanted them for the fireplace, to help hang the long fabrics of their clothes or sheets after the long hours they spent together washing them; or simply to hold the tulle of the canopy so the moths stop barging into them when they are trying to sleep. But right now she is holding them very surely in her hand, resting one over her naked shoulder as she hands the other one to Adora.

“Here, take this.”

“Alright,” Adora takes the golden spear almost automatically, holding herself to it. She looks at the blunt tip, long ago ripped from the sharp end, and then back at Catra, furrowing her eyebrows at Catra´s cheerful expression. “And now?”

Catra grins, lopsided and cheeky, making Adora´s heart speed up. She then gives a step back, holding the spear in front of her and tilting her head.

“Now, hit me”

Adora gasps, the spear almost slipping off her fingers. She stares at Catra with both her mouth and eyes wide open, all the blood on her body pooling towards her feet and then speeding their way back up towards her heart, squeezing the organ painfully.

“What?”

“Hit me. Swing at me.” Catra´s tail lashes softly behind her, taunting Adora with a little flutter of her ears. “We are going to spar”

She is mad, absolutely insane. Adora stares at her a little more, her throat sore before suddenly realizing she has actually said it outloud.

“You´re crazy,” Adora repeats around a hysterical chuckle, shaking her head. “I'm not doing this”

Catra huffs, letting her eyes open to the daylight around them, finding Adora´s voice in front of her. She wiggles her eyebrows, biting into her bottom lip with her fangs.

“Why? Are you scared I'm going to kick your butt?”

Adora really tries but it is quite impossible not to giggle, nervous or not, when Catra is being like this. Taunting and rebellious and frankly pulling from Adora´s nerve strings.

Adora shakes her head again and lowers the spear towards her own hip, relaxing her posture.

“Catra, I´m not going to fight you– Oomph!” Catra is so fast, Adora honestly doesn´t see her coming.

She swings the spear to the side and then down, hooking the cold metal behind Adora´s knees and pulling forwards, positively throwing Adora to the ground in one single motion. Adora gasps, suddenly facing the ceiling of the cavern instead of Catra, her butt and the back of her head meeting the grass below with a dry hit.

Adora wheezes, all the air inside her lungs expelled off her chest with the fall. She snaps her head towards Catra so fast she almost gives herself whiplash, scrambling into a more sitting, dignified position and gasping for dear life.

“Catra!”

“What?” Catra´s grin is sharp, resting her chin over the blunt end of the spear.

Adora scrambles to her feet, missing the cue and falling again over her knees. Catra giggles again, probably hearing Adora struggle with her own feet like a newborn horse over the moss.

“What do you mean what?!” Adora squeaks, fighting a war between absolute bewilderment and a second fit of stupid laughter.

Catra shrugs from one shoulder, swinging from side to side over the spear. “I didn't do anything”

“You threw me off!”

“And?” Catra tilts her head to the side, considering Adora with a grin. “Are you going to do something about it?”

Adora stomps on her feet again, finally finding her way on hesitant feet. She stares at Catra´s pretty face with her flushed one, the veil in disarray around her temples and neck and her tunic wrinkled in several places from where she fell unceremoniously on the floor.

She clicks her tongue against sharp teeth, harshly shaking her clothes from tiny sticks and pieces of leaves. Adora knows she looks like a hot mess right now and for the split of a second she is grateful that Catra can´t actually see her, as horrible as the swift thought is; though she suspects Catra knows anyway, if the dimple on her cheek has anything to say about it.

“You know what? You're such a little cheater, kitty—”

This time, Adora does feel the air change around her and she snaps her eyes back in time to see the spear hook around her ankles and run her dry towards the ground, but by the time she realizes what is going on it is already too late again.

Adora quite literally sees her own feet flying above her head, sandals with ankle bracelets and all, the cavern and the trees spinning around her head before feeling the bedding of the ground beneath her body once again. The moss is slightly more comfortable than falling on bare rock but it still steals the breath of her lungs.

“Ouch! What was that?!” Adora shrieks again, pushing herself up. The end of Catra´s spear stops her, a little to the left as it hovers over her face.

“Don´t call me kitty,” Catra mutters, wrinkling her nose though she is still grinning, the little shit, well knowing that she already won, “ Or I'll kick your butt, again”

Oh, oh dear stars, Adora thinks, her heart crawling its way up her throat and lacing around her vocal cords and the back of her eyes. Sweat is starting to roll down her spine and the small of her waist, making the fabric of her tunic stick over her chest.

Adora shuffles, still over the grass, trying to find her voice again. She feels a little bit dizzy, her brain fogged as she places her thoughts back in order to form a decent sentence. And failing spectacularly to it.

“Listen, ki–” Catra dabs the pole closer, a silent warning. “Kiki”

Catra´s eyebrows shoot up on her forehead, her mouth falling slack at Adora´s sudden nickname. “Kiki?”

Adora nods furiously, trying not to cringe at her own tremendous occurrence. “That's right. Kiki”

She waits a second, then two, looking up at Catra´s thoughtful face and waiting for the pole to actually smack her in the head for trying to be funny. Instead, Catra smiles like a fucking sun, so wide and bright that Adora can see the start of her molars, a sweet and chivalrous glint shimmering inside her silver irises.

“I'm listening,” Catra nods, taking the spear back and leaning against it again, her tail swishing happily behind her.

Adora exhales, suddenly exhilarated again. Catra´s relaxed posture renews the spark of fire inside her chest, making her tongue set loose and her confidence to skyrock towards the roof again, just like when Adora was shooting the arrows towards the wheat and fabric, and maybe this is how Eros feels every single day too.

“I'm a trained warrior,” Adora says, dragging the words with a little shake of her shoulders.

Catra hums, her ears fluttering around her temples like moth's wings. “Are you now?”

“Yes,” Adora clears her throat, her voice still squeaky in the edges. “I was Princess Commander and First General of our soldiers”

“Ah,” Catra drums her sharp nails over the golden of the spear, completely uninterested in Adora´s past royal titles. It makes something warm to stir in Adora´s belly. “Then why are you still on the floor?”

“It´s a conscious choice”

“Sure.” Catra rolls her misted eyes, narrowing them in the edges when she regards Adora again. She bends down, offering her hand to Adora once more, patiently waiting for her to

take it if she wishes. “Wanna try again?”

Adora chuckles, shaking her head at her, incredulous, but taking her hand anyway. Catra pulls from her with surprisingly great strength, smiling all the way as Adora stands on her feet and finds her balance again.

After a few second Catra steps backs, holding the spear in front of her with a newfound spark in her face.

“Ready?”

Adora grimaces but gives a step back, holding the spear across her face and body as she was taught.

“Whenever you are”

Where Adora is all about defense and guarded steps, Catra is all offensive and steps forwards, launching herself hard and unyielding against Adora's barriers without stepping back even once. In a way, it seems to mirror their interactions living together inside this place.

Catra handels the spear elegantly and smartly, counting the second as she hears Adora moving around and using that to place her in front of her before swinging at full speed towards her. She never throws the hit with the goal to hurt or wound Adora but she brush it against Adora´s ribs and forearms several times, tickling her and throwing her off her balance when Adora gasps.

It takes Adora just a couple of minutes to realize that Catra is actually taunting her with the spear, meeting Adora´s in the middle when Adora blocks her hit and tickling her again against the calf with the end when Adora gets distracted.

Adora grunts, sweat starting to pool on her forehead and drip down the length of her nose and her chest. Catra is not stronger than her but she is more agile and where she cannot see where the hit is coming from she can hear the jingle of Adora´s body in front of her, twisting and turning and connecting against Adora´s coin bracelets almost in a mockery, throwing her head off and laughing when Adora tries to respond to the swings and Catra only steps away from her until Adora is chasing her like a loose deer to a fox.

It successfully pisses Adora off.

Adora gives a step forwards this time and without thinking launches her spear to the side, slipping right above Catra's throw and flying at full speed towards her face.

The golden pole connects harshly against the side of Catra's temple, ripping a gasp out of her and making her stumble on her feet, almost losing her grip on her own spear.

“Uff!”

Adora gasps too, horrified, lowering down the spear immediately and rushing to Catra´s side to inspect her head, dread and guilt immediately taking over any other emotion she could have been feeling before.

“Catra, are you– Agh!” Catra´s pole hits Adora´s arm directly over the biceps, mild sparks of pain rising up her shoulder and down her very fingertips, successfully ripping her mind from spiraling into dark thoughts. Adora gapes, staring at her own arm and then at Catra´s blank face, annoyance quickly taking over. “Seriously?!”

“I'm not made of clay, Adora. I won't break.” Catra bites back, pushing her hair, heavy with perspiration too, behind her bare back. There is a certain mole over her right shoulder that Adora is obsessed with. “You're weaker on your left side but your right arm is very strong. You were a sword wielder, weren't you?”

Adora blinks, tension dropping off her shoulder though still wrinkling her nose. “How do you know that?”

“You're very strength based, throwing yourself fully without a second thought when you attack.” Catra rests her palm over her hip, still holding her spear menacingly in front of her. “It's good but you're not thinking at all”

Adora´s face falls, a ring echoing inside her ears before rolling her eyes deeply. “Thanks”

“I'm serious”

“I know.” Adora runs her hand through her face, cleaning the sweat away. The knots of the ribbons and the veil itch underneath the heat of the day and for a second she wants to rip them off and let her scalp breathe for once. “So, I need to think about your movements?”

“No,” Catra extends her hand forwards, offering it to Adora. Adora takes it without a second thought. ng. “Think about what I want to do. If you know what I want to do you'll know how to react without having to think about it”

Catra squeezes Adora´s fingers once before letting go, taking her spear and connecting it with the end of Adora´s nudging her forwards.

“Remember I can perceive your shadow,” Catra reminds her, tapping on the side of her open moon eyes, tilting her head with a confident smile. “Well, go ahead”

Adora exhales, breathing deep several times before moving too. She observes Catra´s posture this time, slightly leaned forward, her tail straight down the floor to give her balance, her ears relaxed over her head; she is holding the spear across the body but leans her left hand slightly to the side, twisting it in a way that will crash against Adora´s but not seeking for Adora´s face at all.

Adora grinds her teeth and swings the pole at her, meeting the spear in the middle but then immediately dragging it down, stopping the end of Catra´s spear in the middle as it speeds quickly towards the back of her own legs, gasping when it stops their movements completely.

“Good,” Catra says around a huff, smiling brightly. “What did I want to do?”

“Throw me off again”

“Very good”

Catra steps back and so does Adora, returning to their positions once more. This time Adora is the one that attacks without previous warning, stepping to the side to disorient Catra and then back to her place, watching as Catra raises her spear to block the attack and stopping her in the middle.

Adora catches the middle of Catra´s spear inside her palm and pulls from it, throwing it above her own shoulder and bringing Catra´s arm and her entire body forward. Catra gasps, tripping on her feet before her chest crashes fully against Adora´s, bending her back backwards to try and not fall.

Adora exhales, panting where she hovers above her face, her left hand still holding Catra´s arm with the spear up, the other one on her side, her own spear pointing to the ground where it rests the metal of it´s middle over Catra´s hip, a crooked tangle of limbs that almost looks like a dance stopped in the middle

“How about that?” Adora asks, breathing hard.

She is so close to Catra´s face that she can see the faint shade of new freckles scattered above her nose, and she can see her own reflection inside her full moon eyes, looking back without hurting any of them.

Catra´s cheeks are painted in red, tinted as if someone had pressed berries over her skin. She is also panting hard, her sweet breath caressing its way over Adora´s cheekbones and down her throat.

If Adora had known this was what it truly meant to touch, she would have surrendered long ago.

“Better,” Catra´s free hand finds its way beneath Adora´s armpit, resting above her shoulder blade, and she bites into her own mouth, distracting Adora completely. “Cockier too”

Adora´s eyes sparkle, satisfaction and something very close to joy drawing over her fully. “What was that about strength again?”

Catra grins from ear to ear, leaning her face towards Adora. She twists her hand over Adora´s shoulder blade to grab around Adora´s bicep instead and uses the leverage, spinning around and throwing Adora´s entire body over her shoulder.

Adora lands on her butt, again, over the grass, again, staring upside down at Catra´s face hovering above her, all white fangs and devil smile and that hint of being a sweet asshole glimmering on the corners of her eyes.

“Yeah, you were right,” Catra says around a smile, not even winded up. “Sometimes you need a little bit of brute force”

Adora sputters, throwing her neck back and laughing. Catra´s sly grin flatters into a tiny smile and then she is chuckling too, so wide it wrinkles the corners of her pretty eyes.

Their spears lay scattered around the soft ground but that is the last of their worries right now, waiting patiently for them to stop laughing and go back into a training that feels more like playthrough, more like chasing each other like little kids around the green of this cavern.

“Ready to go again?” Catra asks, squatting near Adora´s head. Her hand hesitatingly stretches forwards, searching for Adora around the moss.

Adora wraps her fingers around Catra´s wrist, hoping her voice can mirror her smile inside Catra´s ears.

“With you? Always”

It's much later in the day by the time they are actually done. The bows and arrows are long forgotten near the base of the trees and the golden spear roll downhill until they reach the edge of the lake, the precious metal covered in dark mud and green moss, transforming the once deadly weapons in nothing more but simply sticks for young women to play with around their newfound home.

Adora and Catra lay side by side over the grass, heads facing the ceilings of the cavern, their chest heavy and panting as they seek to regain their breath after hours of sparring each other without taking a breath.

Catra´s hair is messed up, long fallen from the ribbons of her ponytail and slightly knotted in places below the pretty coins embroidered in the strands. Her tunic is wrinkled, rumpled on the sides and undone from her belts, and if Adora looks just slightly to the side and down, she would be able to catch a glimpse of the skin of Catra´s bare hips beneath the side opening of her chiton.

Adora is not much better. The veil has long ago come off, leaving her only in the thick scarf that maintains the serpents away, but even then it has been an almost impossible work to keep them from moving, pulling and twisting from Adora´s scalp as curiosity and joy from Catra´s proximity overwhelmed them.

The head of one of them slams slightly against Adora´s hearlobe, tied tightly over the head and body with a ribbon but still somehow managing to give a very soft sizzle. Adora slaps her palm over it, quieting it down and wrinkling her nose at the pain that the swift hit brings her.

“Done for the day?” Catra asks, oblivious of the whole thing, rolling her head over the grass towards the place she knows Adora lays.

Adora forgets all about the snakes immediately, turning to look at her flushed face, wild strands of hair sticking to her sweaty face. “Tired?”

Catra chuckles, shaking her head. “Sure, princess”

She sits down again, bending over herself to reach her ankles, rubbing them of their soreness inside her palms. Adora follows her, crossing her legs and resting all of her weight over her palms as she leans down on them.

The cavern is hot but the breeze is fresh for the waterfall, reminding Adora a little bit of the summer nights on Etheria, soaking her soles on the shore of the sea after a day of chasing her brother around the sand. Lately she has found it much easier to feel like herself again. Almost completely, never enough.

“Did your friend teach you to spar like this?” Adora asks, undoing the leather band around her ankles and wrists, letting her joints rest.

“No, my grandmother.” Catra explains, shrugging softly. “He was a good warrior too but I don't think he ever liked to fight to begin with.”

Something pulls painfully from Adora´s heart strings but she ignores it, observing Catra´s suddenly quieter profile.

“I'm starting to get curious about him.” Adora says carefully, looking towards her hands and the newformed calluses on them.

Catra sighs, resting her chin over her bent knees, eyes closed again. “I´ll tell you more about him later, I promise”

As curious as she might be, Adora never presses the matter more than simple questions; the way Catra speaks about this young man is enough for Adora to understand that he is not in this world anymore and Adora doesn´t want to hurt Catra more.

For a moment Adora is worried that she has soured the air between them but then Catra turns towards her and her smile is ever present as always, and it manages to soothe Adora´s heart with silent words.

“I´m really hungry tho,” Catra whispers, standing up again, her tail finding Adora´s wrists and curling around it when the latter hands her the cane. “You?”

“Famished”

“Nothing new,” Catra grins, starting to very carefully walk towards the fireplace again.

Adora remains quiet in her place, watching her go without uttering a word. More than once lately, Adora has caught herself lingering her gaze over Catra a little too long, a little to close. A little too yearning.

More than once, she has caught herself distracted over the way Catra´s tunic falls over her shoulder and the angle of her ankle. More than once, she thinks that if she looks just a little bit longer at the cluster of freckles on her soles she might actually find new constellations in them.

More than once and more than all the others, the snakes slide down her spine and neck and she has to remind herself that while touch has been granted and while Catra is a joy, Adora has still been cursed, and there is no cure in the world for that.

Not even love.

Catra is going a little bit more and more insane every single day. But that is not a new occurrence for her.

She has grown accustomed to her life inside the cavern so easily that it almost surprised her deeply, so swiftly that it didn´t even feel like her entire life had changed from the inside out from a second to the other. So deeply marvelled by all the wonders that this place had hidden from the world to actually think about it as a prison.

Instead, it is a safeguard, a hidden place, the last safe spot in the world for Catra to find beauty when at the beginning all she was expecting was death.

She has walked among its stones and dipped her teeth on its waters; climbed the wide trunks of its trees and even fallen on her knees over the hard edges of the cavern, and somehow she had found herself falling in love with every single thing about it.

All of it no matter how sharp and hurtful, or how sweet and tender it could be. She had slowly absorbed it inside her chest and made a home inside her chest for it.

Even among days and weeks of nightmares, she had held onto the hope of her dreams with tooth and nail and found peace in it, found a purpose. Found her purpose, in the the sad woman living choked out inside of these stone walls with nothing but silence and loneliness around her; so drowned by past torture and fear that it almost hurt to hear her, to touch her, but that she was so soft when you got near her that it was impossible not to care for her. It was impossible for Catra not to adore her.

Catra was not, however, ready for the change that touch would bring between them.

She was excited, dumb and stupid like a little child granted permission to grasp the hem of a goddess veil; but she was not ready for the way it would rob her of her breath, or by the way it would squeeze around her heart like a snake making a nest around the spaces between her ribs and resting its head over her lungs.

She is the one that had initiated it, that had opened the door, too eager to break the breach between them, too desperate to ease the sorrow that always accompanied Adora like a second heartbeat.

But she was not ready for the actual feeling of holding Adora´s fingertips on hers, of feeling her sleeping body curled too close and just far away enough from her in the morning. She was not prepared to rest her palm on the skin of someone she had been dreaming about every single night for the last twenty five years.

And even then, Catra grew accustomed to it, she grew fond and she grew calm around the touch, each easier than the last until they were too just a part of her life, as easy as breathing. As if it was just something that had been waiting to happen between them, familiar and known and gentle.

Suddenly they brushed arms when preparing food or cleaning the cavern. Suddenly their knuckles meet if one lends thread rolls to the other. Suddenly Catra held Adora´s forearm to cross treacherous parts of the cave and she didn´t even mind that she already knew the path like the back of her hand inside her mind.

Suddenly Adora was touching her shoulder to call for her attention and the coin bracelets became more of a familiar music than something to alert Catra of her presence.

Suddenly they were holding hands to sleep, every single night no matter what or why, no matter if resting on their backs or the sides or facing each other or away; all of just one of their fingers were laced together, from the thumb to the pinky, letting the other know that they were there.

Catra hadn´t had a single nightmare since that day. Adora hadn´t had a single sleepless night since that time. It eases the pain in Adora´s skin and her breath, in the beating of her hand, and in return Catra had been able to breathe easier for the first time in a long time.

Familiar and enough, it was enough. For a while.

What nobody warned Catra, what nobody actually had the decency to say to her, is that Adora *smells* .

Not in the way you would wrinkle your nose and turn your head if she gets way too close. Not like something bad or nasty or sour. No.

There is a certain kind of smell on her sweeter than figs but also sour. Strong.

Catra can smell it on her skin when they are eating together, saltier and fogged by the ashes of the fire. Familiar and comfortable.

She can perceive it when Adora comes back inside the temple at early hours of the morning, when she just showered and she thinks Catra is still laying asleep and not awake yearning for her. Clean, fresh, like water.

She can taste it in the back of her throat on the moments when they are sparring, now that it has become a coming source of exercise and fun for them. It drips off Adora's body with each drop of her sweat, rolling down Adora's nose and splashing over Catra's cheeks and chin. Musk, bitter, like grabbing a blazing log with her bare hands and pressing it against her face.

Days where Catra grinds her teeth and only wants to turn away from her because her scent is unbearable and she doesn't want to disrespect the trust Adora has given her by granting her touch.

Catra is familiar with it at nights, when Adora's sleeping body is right next to her, inches away and prohibited from her reach. And there she smells sweeter but also much sadder, like nectar for Catra's wings to drink for. It makes Catra sleepy, it helps her fall asleep, it feels her nights with dreams.

For Catra who is not only a magicat but who has relied on her sense of smell and touch deeply her whole life, it's exhilarating, like an explosion, like a revelation, like a fire bloomin inside her heart.

She smells like something that is driving Catra absolutely mad. And it's absolutely not fair.

All Catra has ever wanted was to find her, wherever it might be, no matter how or when, no matter the circumstances; and in the end the circumstances they got were painful and scary. And now that she has she doesn't seem to be able to breathe if Adora is not near her.

How absolutely annoying. Catra has dipped her head inside the cold waterfall and wished she could throw herself off a cliff enough times by now.

But there are days, there are just days where Adora smells beautiful and sweet and where the air is calm between them. When it feels easy to exist and not think and where Catra can sink inside the existence of this moment and not worry about the past or the future, not worry about doing something wrong that will push Adora away from her. Just sit here in this place and soak in existing next to Adora.

Those are Catra's favorite days. Those are days like today.

They are sitting over the bed, chattering with each other quietly. The smell of the wisteria flowers is heavy around them, hanging from the branches of the olive tree, or at least that's what Adora has told Catra they look like, heavy with buttons in bloom and falling over their faces every once in a while.

Catra rests her back over the throw pillows behind her, crossing her legs with her tail thrown across the bed and down the floor, brushing softly above the mosaic below. Adora is sitting somewhere in front of her, opposite over the bed; Catra can hear her shuffling every once in a while over the thin sheets, nervous as always.

She is not wearing the ankle bracelets today but she is still accompanied by the soft jingle and sizzling as always, a soft sound that Catra doesn't think Adora knows she can hear.

It does not matter for her anyway, much less right now. Right now Catra is holding her hand in front of her for a very different reason than holding Adora´s, furrowing her eyebrows and twitching her tongue against the back of her fangs.

“Give it here,” Catra repeats, rolling the thread roll on her other hand with annoyance. Adora sighs in front of her, her voice apologetic, shying away.

“You really don't need to”

“Adora, you've been wearing this for what?” Catra bites, lowering her hand until she finds the hem of Adora´s hemation wrinkled between them, the threads of the fabric fragile and thin after so many years of wearing it non stop.

“Five years,” Adora mutters after a second, dragging the words between her teeth. She is really stubborn when she wants to, adamant and infuriating and if she wasn't so sweet for

Catra´s heart Catra would kick her butt again. She is still considering doing so.

“Five years, straight. There are holes in this thing.” Catra digs her fingers inside one of the tears of the fabric, wiggling them when they come on the other side. “The least I can do is sew them”

“I can do it too”

“Yes but you can't do it like me.” Catra pulls from the fabric again, grinning triumphantly when the tension finally gives up once Adora lets go and the hemation comes completely inside her arms, falling long and light over Catra´s lap. “Let me embroider them”

Catra roams around the objects placed inside the nest of her arms, feeling the edges of the objects with her fingertips until she finds what she is looking for. The long metal needle, the same used to sew her own wounds when she first came to be here; and a long roll of fine thread, the color unknown to her but the material of good quality, nice and soft.

“What are you going to do?” Adora asks after a moment, her voice slightly closer when she leans closer to Catra, most probably to catch a sight of what Catra is doing.

“You'll see,” Catra says with a little smile, feeling the start of the hole in the fabric with her hand and stabbing the needle across it, starting her work over the fabric with ease. “Cause I won't”

Catra hears Adora snort around her own breath, her voice catching on her throat with either laughter or complete horror, Catra is not sure yet. Catra is used to doing harmless jokes about her disability here and there, especially with Adam years ago, but she had never felt as easily funny and perfectly calm when doing them as now with Adora.

“Not funny,” Adora complains, and if Catra had to describe what she thinks a pout looks like, she would describe the sound of Adora´s voice right now.

“A little bit,” Catra raises her hand, joining her thumb and her index in front of her face, grinning softly. “A little bit funny”

Even when Adora sounds horrified by them most of the time, it does not make Catra feel inadequate or weird for doing them, or for being blind. Not at all. Quite the contrary it feels freeing, easy, as if she was just a normal being existing alongside Adora.

And Adora has never made her like a liability or like her blindness was a burden, or even a charity project to realize. She treats Catra and makes her feel as her equal, as if they are the same.

Catra thinks that's one of the many reasons why Adora, the one in flesh and breath and not the one existing in her dreams, has become so dear to her. So precious.

It´s annoying. Catra really did try not to fall in love with her.

They sit in peaceful silence for some long minutes, Adora quiet and Catra embroidering. And the silence doesn´t even feel oppressive and scary for Catra, not anymore.

Catra is busy making her way across the fabric of the hemation, counting the points where the needle makes its way in and out of the fabric. One, two inclined; one, two, three in a straight line; five in an x and o a tiny one right besides the last.

Count, count, count; spot, spot, spot. Up and down and down below, from left to right over the back of the fabric. The thread travels across the tiny holes in intricate patterns, an alphabet only Catra knows and that her mother Io taught her a long time ago. Words hidden in the knots of an embroidery that nobody else gets to understand for her.

What a secret way to keep in secret the truth of her feelings, hidden in thread.

“I used to fix the clothes of the children in my town's market.” Catra explains under her breath, working through the hemation and hearing Adora breath close to her. “I never charged them for it, but I liked it. It was a nice thing to do while the hours went by”

Adora shuffles over the bed, her breathing steady and her heart steady. She smells a lot like oranges today, lemongrass and fruits in front of Catra´s place.

“You like children?” Adora´s voice is deeply curious, soft in the edges.

Catra shrugs, scratching her nose where the strands of her bangs tickle her.

“Some of them are brats. I could barely stand them most of the time.”

Catra smiles, remembering the sound of the little menaces´s voices, screeching and laughing around her, exclaiming with joy when Catra would lend them their ragged clothes back almost as good as new. She remembers hearing them playing all around her stall on the market and hearing them snore when they were to nap over the tapestries. It´s a nice memory, it makes her softer and gooier inside.

“But– when I grew up at some point I realized I wanted it, you know? That maybe I did want to do what my mom did for me after all. Look after a small soul and nurture them for a happy life. Be for them, next to them, guide and love them. I guess–”

Catra cuts herself short, suddenly out of breath. She lowers the fabric and the thread down her lap, frowning to herself as tears start to tickle on the corner of her eyes.

She had never realized just how deeply important it actually seemed to be for her, or how deeply she felt about it well inside her heart.

Catra guesses it was something many people felt, not all of them but some. And from them, only a few were actually fitted to be that, a parent, someone who a child would look up to.

Catra is not sure she is that kind of person. But still, for a moment it felt good to think about it. The possibility; her life is full of those.

“I– I wanted to be a mother.” Catra finally manages to say, exhaling. In front of her, Adora takes a very slow breath. “I wanted to have the choice to be one.”

“You still could,” Adora says abruptly, still soft but eager, with an edge on her pretty voice that borderlines something both sorrowful and desperate. “When you— if you–” a breath, “if you choose to leave, you could”

If you choose to leave. Catra's heart squeezes painfully inside her ribcage, bleeding all inside her.

Sometimes it's actually so much more painful to realize that Adora does not realize how deeply Catra feels about her. Much more painfully that thinking choices have been stripped out of her: it aches deeply and it makes Catra sad.

“I don't know Adora,” Catra plays with the end of the needle, pressing it softly against the pads of her fingers without managing to break skin. “The world it's not a kind place. I don't know if it will ever be one. I don't know if I'll ever be actually ready to become a parent. And I– I don't want to be selfish bringing a soul to the world just so I'm not alone.”

Adora's breath gets much closer, hovering right above Catra's cheekbones, its smell filling her lungs.

“You could never be selfish,” Adora whispers close to her, so much Catra thinks that she can feel her exhale over her eyelids

“I could.” Catra leans down her head, running her hand over the embroidered words she has not the guts to speak, both confession and prayer for Adora alone. “You have no idea how much”

Adora's breath leaves her and for the first time Catra is thankful, taking several deep breaths as she soothes down the race of her heart.

But when Adora speaks again it is terribly heavy, so sad and frightened that it freezes the blood inside Catra's veins.

“When I was younger– I wished to be a mother too.” Adora whispers in the thread of a voice, like all the other secrets they have shared over this bed. “Like you, I wanted to teach all about the world to another soul, one nurtured from love. One that could grow in a free world.”

The sweet natural jingle of Adora's body echoes inside the bed and the temple, still calm but holding herself so tight that Catra, at the other side of the olive tree, can feel her tremor to the very end of her fingertips.

“I grew up with what I thought was so much love around me. I thought I could do it, that I could find–”

Adora cuts herself sharply, taking a painful breath that sounds as if it was tearing her from the inside up completely.

“I didn't want them to be perfect or better than me, I just thought that I could love them with my whole heart and that it would be enough for them to be happy.” Adora sounds suddenly so far away from Catra that it scares her, thinking she might dissolve from one moment to the

other into her sorrow, flown away by the breeze by the amount of her sadness. “I wished to receive them into this world from– from the body of someone I'd love. Or I wanted to carry them myself into my womb. I wanted it all no matter how.”

Catra flushes deeply, her whole body shivering. Her hands twitch above her lap, eager to reach out and hold Adora, any part of her that she could find and touch.

But she remains unmoving, locked into place as she listens. It's so rare for Adora to open like this, so freely, so vulnerable, Catra will not stain it by touching her skin when this is being given to her with so much trust.

“It wouldn't have mattered anyway,” Adora chuckles, dry, filled with bitterness and sorrow. “I was not allowed for the choice”

“What do you mean?”

“I was– wrong. I was born wrong. That's what my mother called it once.” Adora´s voice shivers in the edges and Catra knows it´s not only born from anger but from grief, a deep wound done on her heart by the person that was supposed to love her the most, something that no matter how long has passed, has never managed to heal completely, “Many physicians saw me. Priestess, wise women. But I never bled, not even once”

Catra's heartbeat is soaring inside her sensitive ears, slamming itself against her eardrums and making her dizzy and panting, feeling Adora's heartbreak inside her own body.

She wants to throw up inside her mouth, she wants to scream. She wants to crawl out of this cavern and find her way towards Adora´s kingdom and find her mother and father herself, wrap her sharp hands around their throats and yell at their faces.

How could you forsake her? Catra wants to howl, to them, to the people that failed her, to the things Adora has not told her yet but that Catra knows pain her deeply. *How could you not love her? She is so easy to love.*

“Maybe my mother thought the Emperor, in all his glory, would fix me if he bedded me,” Adora spits, bitter around the words, her breath catching in her throat when she pronounces them. There is rage in them and Catra is glad, she is relieved that she allows to feel anger because there is no other proper emotion to feel after something like that. “Maybe that way I would have accomplished the mission she placed on me. To bear heirs for our house, to continue her half-nereid blood into more children as it was my duty as princess. That's all I ever was, royal breed for their throne.”

“Adora–”

“It's unfair, isn't it?” Adora gasps, sniffing very softly. She smells like salt now, she is crying. “I was so much more than just a woman to carry children, no matter how much I wanted them. I wanted to be a poet, and a singer, and a scientist. I wanted to love and be loved. I wanted to be a mother, but I never did any of it good enough for my kingdom. No matter how much of me I sacrificed for them, it was never enough. I didn't even bend down my head to their new king properly.”

Catra knows about the Emperor.

She knew, way before coming here, about his existence, about the desolation he has left across the earth. He, who challenged the gods and somehow won, he who in return roamed the earth with his bloodstained army and destroyed everything, and with him the earth died everywhere, taking away all the sounds and chaotic beauty of it all.

She knew he was Hordak´s half brother, that he was the only reason Hordak wrapped Menagerie inside his fingertips. She knows Lystra tried to sell her to him for the first reason he seemed to have seeked Adora´s kingdom in the first place, and the thought alone makes Catra want to rip her skin off her face; the thought alone makes Catra want to go insane.

“I was wearing a dress”

Catra´s breath tangles on her voice. She opens her eyes but she can´t distinguish Adora among the shadows.

“When–?”

“When it happened. The day this happened to me,” Adora whispers, she who has never told Catra why people call her a monster. She says it like a secret, rooted so deeply inside her chest that Catra will have to dive inside and tore it from root with her own hands. “I was wearing a red dress”

Something wet and lukewarm falls from Catra´s eyelashes, down her cheekbone and across her parted lips. Only then she realizes she is crying too.

“I remember because that night I refused to wear the colors of the man that had broken my home. Green, like a poison. I remember because after it happened the people that I knew since I was a child and that dragged me here told me I shouldn't have worn the dress in the first place.”

Adora is crying and Catra is angry, angry with everyone, angry with herself, angry with the gods. She is angry, so suddenly and devastatingly that she doesn´t know what to do with herself. So deeply and powerful that if she had any kind of godly power she would use it to destroy the world beyond the cavern into ashes, and for a moment she understands divine rage.

“After a long time rotting here on my own, I came to think that maybe they were right”

There are certain kinds of smells all around them, smells that have nothing to do with Adora. Like flowers, sprouting out of the cracks of the temple´s floor, blooming and then dying immediately after, rotting over the ground into pieces of life succumbing under anger.

Catra digs her nails over her own thighs and tries to take a deep breath, closing her eyes again. It's difficult, eating it all up, guarding all her rage inside back inside her chest and letting it go putrid inside of her instead of in the space between them. But Catra bares it because what Adora needs right now is not her rage, maybe in the future but not right now.

“What color are you wearing today?” Catra whispers in a shaken breath, biting into the inside of her cheek.

Adora takes a long moment to answer her, so long that for a moment Catra thinks she has taken offense or that she is not there anymore, and it's scary, to rely on the presence or absence of her sounds. But her smell is still there and when she answers she does so softly, a little surprised, as if she didn´t know what she expected for Catra to say after that.

“Blue”

Catra tilts her head, holding her breath until her chest aches. “And me?”

“Purple,” Adora murmurs around an exhale, her voice changing in the edges, from confused to tender.

Catra tilts her head, mustering the frail try of a smile. “I don't know what they are like”

Adora holds her breath too, shaky but not trembling anymore. Closer, she is slightly closer, seeking for Catra´s presence like a moth to the tiny sparks of light around it.

“Blue is like–” Adora starts but she cuts herself short right after, unable to find the words.

Catra feels her face going numb and warm suddenly, ashamed that Adora has to explain even this when it is Catra who should be comforting her. But then again …

“Blue feels like the water from the lake.” Adora finally says, words thumbling with each other, eager to pull them off her chest. “Easy, breathable but strong too”

Oh. Catra holds her breath, nodding slowly.

“Purple feels like eating figs and sitting underneath the domes to talk.”

“What about red?”

“Red feels like–” Adora shivers, Catra seeks for her among the dark. “Red is like digging your fingers inside pomegranates. Red is like the sparks of the fire cracking on your fingertips when you are making your offerings, even when nobody might even hear you but you still hope.” Their fingertips brush together, then turn apart again. “Red is like heat and like warmth. Like sleeping under the sun and sparring over the mud”

“Is there red in me?”

“There is red on your cheeks.” Adora´s breath ghosts over Catra´s cheeks, quiet around a smile Catra doesn´t get to see but that she hears. “There is red on your lips, inside your mouth”

A shiver runs down the middle of Catra´s spine, quick and warm. It would be almost unbearable if Catra didn´t feel so safe around Adora´s presence. She wants to make Adora feel the same.

“Is there green on me?”

“Not like that.” Adora whispers and it's sad, rejecting the idea completely.

“Then how?”

“There is moss, on your clothes, on the soles of your feet.” Adora gulps audibly, shifting softly over the bed, as if she didn't quite know where to place her body. “There is green on the olive tree of the bed. It´s a better green, a gentler one.”

The hemation, the thread and the needle fall on the ground, rolling softly when Catra lets go of them. Catra moves across the bed, kneeling instead of crossing her legs, searching for Adora among the softness of the sheets and the tiny flower petals still falling over their heads.

“Can I touch you?”

“Yes.” Adora is there, right there next to her, her heart quick but her breathing calm. “Just my hands, please.”

Catra stretches her own hands and Adora´s meet her in the middle, lacing their fingers together. The single touch is so devastatingly gentle that Ccatra knows this alone would be enough to fill her nights and days for a thousand lives more. Just like this.

Catra wraps her hands completely over Adora´s and turns them around, bringing them towards her chest. Instead of placing them over her collarbone though, Catra lets herself fall forwards a little, resting her forehead over Adora´s cold knuckles.

She hears Adora gasp in front of her, and she can feel her trembling violently, tears splashing over their joined hands and rolling down their wrists.

“It was not the dress´ fault at all, was it?” Adora asks in the thread of a voice and even if she already knows the answer Catra is still sweet, shaking her head and letting her cheek and nose rest over the back of Adora´s wrists.

“No, Adora. It was not, none of it.” Catra pants for air, closing her eyes until sparks cross her forehead and she cannot feel or hear anything else that is not her. “I'm sorry”

“Why?” Adora asks, almost around a wet chuckle, void from joy. “You didn't do anything wrong”

“No.” Catra sighs around her fingers, holding her as tight as possible. “But someone should apologize to you for the pain they caused you”

Adora sobs above her head, still quiet, tears rolling down her face and falling over Catra´s, mingling them in a way together. Catra absorbs it all for her because in this life she can do this, she can do this seemingly small thing for her.

She was not able to protect her when Adora´s kingdom turned their backs on her, she was not able to save her, she wasn´t even allowed to know what exactly had been done, but Catra can

be here now.

After a while, Adora´s silent sobs lower down, from deep sadness to soft whimpering to deep breaths as Adora calms herself enough to be able to speak and breath again.

She squeezes Catra´s fingers a little, a silent signal that while Catra is still holding her hands Adora needs a moment to gather herself. Catra lets go of her immediately, missing her completely the second Adora leans away.

“You are very convincing, Kiki.” Adora mutters around a dry chuckle, still sniffling, clothes shuffling around where she seems to be cleaning her face dry.

Catra drops her hands over her lap, tangling them around the fabric of her tunic to hide just how restless they still are. “I'll take it as a compliment”

“You are not going to kick my butt for the nickname?”

“I´ll let it slide”

Adora chuckles, the frail glimpses of amusement hanging from her voice, trying to make the tension easier

“And what do I owe that honor?”

“Well because you are my friend.” Catra´s voice fails her, sudden dread dropping from her throat to the bottom of her belly, making her hesitant and unsure. “We– we are friends, aren´t we?”

Adora´s hand finds hers again, squeezing her fingers in reassurance and comfort.

“We are”

But then she is gone again, curling around herself all over again.

She is uncomfortable. Adora is uncomfortable with her skin, with her clothes, with who she was and who she is right now. And Catra is so desperate to be able to wrap her inside her arms and against her chest and absorb her whole, guard her in the space right beneath her heart where Adora won't feel inadequate or dirty or wrong anymore, but she knows she can´t do that now. Maybe not ever,

And yet, even though Adora still smells beautiful, being her friend is quite enough for Catra. It´s everything she ever wanted because all she wanted was always to find her.

“It's very clammy today.” Catra comments, already finding her way down the bed.

Adora hums, slightly confused. “It is”

Catra turns in her ankles, facing or at least hoping she is facing Adora´s face. She rests her hands over her hips and tilts her head to the side, regarding Adora with a smile.

“Swim with me”

Adora chokes on her spit, quite loudly too, She shuffles over the bed, tapping her feet over the floor nervously.

“Why?”

Catra extends her hands to her, hoping patiently. If Adora doesn´t want to take them she will step away, this is after all about Adora and the latter knows that.

But Adora does take her hands, again, almost as if one they started neither of them could go without holding the other's hand anymore.

She allows Catra to pull softly from her, standing up from the bed and hovering her tall body in front of Catra, waiting impatiently where Catra just grins.

“Because you are wearing a dress now,” Catra guides Adora blindly across the temple, across the mosaics and down the steps, through the soft moss until the earth starts to give away damp beneath their feet. “And nothing bad is going to happen to you again.”

She is not using the cane, and she can't see. She could make them stumble together towards the floor at any moment or she could make them both drown inside the lake. Adora follows her anyway.

“You are safe”

Catra is the sweetest joy that life has ever given to Adora, she is sure of this now. And she does not belong to her to call hers.

And it's making things so much more complicated for Adora to handle.

Crying is uncomfortable, it aches and it lingers inside of you if you haven't done it for a long time. It stays and takes root, like a fever that is unable to shake off. Adora has always hated to cry, even since she was a child, for the very same reasons, too annoying and distracting to allow her to think clearly.

Which is why she avoids it, with tooth and nail.

Crying with Catra, alongside her, is different, it feels different. It feels freeing instead of overwhelming. Like dropping a very deep weight little by little and very slowly. It doesn´t fix anything but it makes living easier; it makes Adora want to live just a little longer just for the joy of seeing Catra´s sleepy face in the mornings.

Everything with Catra feels different, including breaking down, including being sick.

Adora is pretty sure she is sick right now, which is a new occurrence for her given she has never gotten sick before, not even when she was a child.

Swimming in the lakes is great; letting herself float above the surface of the calm and fresh water and let all sounds get drowned by the muffled echo of the water is magnificent and Adora has enjoyed it deeply from the moment Catra guided her here about a week ago.

Having her head stuffed and her heartbeat on her throat is not nice though. She feels her head filled with fog and her eyes heavy, half lifted and hooded as she roams through the cavern doing her usual activities. She is choked up by it, curling around her throat and making her sleepy and at the same time wide awake.

Adora is slightly on edge and she has no idea why. It might have to do with the fact that she has not been able to look away from Catra the entire day, not even once, which is both terrifying and exciting all the same.

But it's just that Catra is so filled with joy that it makes Adora unable to look away from a single second more. She, who was so terrified to look at her face at all at the beginning, sick with the fear of possibly hurting her or turning her into sharp stone like all the other souls that had wandered here.

Now that the permission of gazing at her freely has been granted, Adora doesn´t seem to be able to stop, which is not good.

And Catra, Catra is just beautiful. She is so beautiful that Adora is in awe every single time she looks in her direction.

She is so pretty, with her round face and her high cheekbones clustered in freckles. With her long eyelashes casting long shadows over her dark skin and the glimmer of her silver eyes when she opens her eyes to catch a glimpse of light inside them. With her button nose and her sharp eyebrows and the way her skin looks powdered by golden dust.

Adora has grown not only fond of but enchanted by the fall of her shoulders below the straps of her chiton; with the cavern of her collarbones, all so sharp always and scattered with moles. With her lean but still strong arms and the way her ankles brush outside the hem of her tunic and they make Adora´s heart skip a beat.

Right now Adora beating herself up because she is sitting on the entire other side from Catra ´s next to the lake and still she can´t keep her fucking eyes away from the way the chiton falls slightly open above Catra´s hips; and the way the shadow of Catra´s small breast brushes against Adora´s forearm when she leans towards her.

Adora snaps her head away violently, digging her nails over her upper arms until it bruises and it hurts, distracting her.

This is new, this is horribly new. This is the first time Adora feels like this and it's driving her mad.

Catra stands up from next to her, running a wet towel behind her nape, chasing away the overwhelming heat that has gathered inside the cavern throughout the day. She holds the cane in front of her and reaches for Adora´s hand at the same time, not even thinking about it, ready to go to sleep.

Adora laces their fingers together immediately but doesn't move, rooted in place. Catra feels the pull when Adora´s body doesn't yield and she turns her head around, her eyebrows knitting with confusion.

“What is it?”

“I think–” Adora wets her dry mouth, purposefully keeping her eyes away from Catra for the first time in many weeks. “I think I´d like to stay here a bit longer”

Catra frowns, tilting her head. She shuffles on her feet, suddenly uncomfortable. “You are not coming to our bed?”

Our . Dangerous, extremely close. Adora lets go of her hand.

“The winter is upon us. It's still nice here but once it falls it could freeze us.” It´s a lie, Adora knows it and Catra knows it too. “I´ll be weaving fabrics the whole night”

“Are you sure? We can do it tomorrow.”

There is a perpetual blush nestled in Catra´s cheeks since a few weeks now, rose and tender. It is deeper today, warmer, as if the heat of the cavern was affecting Catra too, making her nose stuffy. She is panting too, very softly under her breath; and sweat is rolling down the sides of her long neck, tiny drops losing themselves among the wrinkles of her tunic, past the line of her sternum and beyond.

Who would have known, that kindness and sweetness was the most seductive thing of them all? It makes Adora hold her breath.

“I am sure,” she assures her, reassuring her and trying to reassure herself. “I don´t really feel like sleeping right now”

Catra hesitates for a few seconds in front of her, obviously uneasy of letting Adora here on her own. She has been very close to her all week, being sweet and caring towards her since they spoke on the olive bed. It might be one of the reasons why Adora can barely function around her, all her thoughts drunk in her.

“Alright,” Catra mutters after a while, still wrinkling her nose as she starts making her way towards the temple. “Don´t be too late”

Adora´s shoulders relax when she sees her go, allowing for her chin to rest over her knees. Even then, she cannot help herself when she turns around to look at Catra´s soles disappearing inside the mosaic floor.

Adora spends hours in the loom, quite literally. She mumbles to herself all the way there, falls heavily over the uncomfortable chair and starts weaving plain and colorful fabric without thinking about it, letting herself fall in the familiarity and the choreographic movements that involve weaving like this.

The fabric over her loom is red. Red like the juice of pomegranates, red like the morning sky. Red like Catra´s mouth. Adora loves red, it has been such a long time since she allowed to

surround herself in it.

The hemation Catra fixed for her hangs quiet and warm around her elbows and down her back, deeply blue fixed with golden thread. The spirals and tiny flowers sewn over it are a sight to behold, beautiful, raised, easy to follow with her fingers.

If Adora pays close attention she thinks she can understand patterns on it, like little dots that give away to pretty garments instead. She cannot understand them but something inside of Adora tells her they mean something and it makes her ears burn even deeper, making her want to both laugh or run away.

****

The moon is hanging full and heavy right above the open domes of the cavern when Adora perceives it, ripping her attention from the loom in front of her.

There is a smell in the air. Adora stills her hands over the plain design of the fabric, hovering over the threads as her mind tries to place it, her heart speeding like a wild horse inside her chest.

It´s a scent, like the perfume of a flower when it blooms, clinging into every single corner of the cavern. It's familiar in the way Adora had never smelled it before yet somehow it evoques something known for her, something she cannot quite place.

It's dangerous, like a poisonous cup of wine placed against her lips, tempting and delicious and dangerous, making Adora´s mouth water immediately the moment it lingers inside her nostril and makes its way there.

The snakes above her head are moving, defying their ribbon prisons and curling around themselves and over Adora´s ears, hissing deeply. They can smell it too and whatever it is, is making them go crazy, fighting violently against their bounds and trying to reach in all directions to place the smell where their blind eyes cannot see.

Adora slams her hand against their bodies below the scarf, annoyed and angry but all of her emotions are in disarray too, her skin raised in goosebumps and her heartbeat soaring inside of her eardrums, making her head swim when another kind of noise fills very softly the night and she wipes her head towards it immediately. Towards the temple.

Catra is making noises, tiny, controlled, under her breath. So soft that if it wasn't because Adora's curse had also granted her sharo hearing she wouldn't have heard them at all.

Adora stands up, in a haze, like a drunk lady stumbling across the soft moss and earth. Like a tiny moth to a forest fire.

She reaches the base of the temple's columns and rests her forehead over their cold surfaces, wrinkling her forehead.

For a second Adora is worried, wondering if something has happened to Catra while Adora was away, but then she hears it, now that she is near she perceives it.

Slick, soft, all too familiar, the sound of fingers running against damp skin. The sound of a soft gasp drowned by the fabric of even softer pillows, burying pleasure among feathers.

Adora stumbles back, tripping on her fee and almost falling over her back. She drowns her own gasp with the palm of her hand, bitting over the soft skin until she feels tiny drops of blood blooming there.

Adora is aware that Catra is a beautiful woman. She is young, she is healthy, she is nurturing. She is everything beautiful in the world and sometimes beautiful creatures have cravings, appetites. Hunger.

Where Adora is fighting not to be loud to break the santicity of the temple, Catra makes tiny sounds. High pitched and sweet, barely audible over the sound of the waterfall and the echo of the cavern.

But Adora can see her, she can see the shape of her beneath the fabric of the canopy. Her back arching still inside the wrinkles of her night chemise, the curve of her calves, the softness of her ears curling around her neck.

A swan unfolding over her side of the bed before falling asleep. Something to precious to touch and to holy for Adora to ever call hers.

Adora stumbles her way across the cavern, biting into her tongue. She doesn't know is she wants to cry or to laugh; doesn't knows if she wants to drown herself in the lake or throw herself from the highest branch of the tree.

She feels both blessed and shameful, never for Catra who is a miracle all on her own, but for daring to gaze at her body like this. Adora feels like an errand hunter who has stumbled upon a goddess bathing on the river, unworthy of the sight and destined on being cursed in return.

Catra is her *friend*. Catra finds joy in being Adora's friend and Adora meets that same joy with equal force. Catra has trusted her with her sleeping body and her hand in hers and her sweet words mending something inside Adora's sould that she can't even reach by herself.

Adora has no right to have this, not even the quiet glimpse of it, no matter how little it was. Catra is *vowed to* , she told her herself. She is not Adora's.

Adora knows this and it fills her with shame, but– she has been happy. She has been happier, terrified still but happier. Now that the flood gates are open she doesn't know what to do with them.

The snakes are still hissing loudly, deeply rooted on her head.

She has laughed, she has touched, she has cried. Her body is flourishing, healing. And now, for the first time in a long, long time, Adora desires.

****

Adora sits over the warm grass below the trees, hugging her knees and grumbling to herself.

There are apples all around her, golden skin bleeding into red as they mature, even fallen from their stems as they are right now. They roll over her bare feet and stop around her toes, facing her like little judges surrounding her everywhere.

Catra is moving around the trees like a free bird, chirping and talking at full sleep, finishing the last strands of one of her stories while Adora waits patiently and is supposed to listen.

Adora *is* listening, but at the same time her head is somewhere else completely, diving around her own thoughts and finding herself lost in them.

Catra's hair is loose today, curlier than ever and falling in loops around her hips. Her tunic is of a link so deep it melts into red at the edges and she is smiling.

Adora takes a heavy gulp of air and looks away, frowning at herself.

Catra is her friend. That's what she is, plain and simple. They were strangers and then acquaintances, joined by injustice and pain, thrown to the same place by tragedy. Then they were something more, melting down into friendship.

That is something Adora never thought she would have, something she still doubts it's real at all. And now she has gone and stained it all. As always, Adora has ruined anything beautiful that life has ever given her.

“Adora,” Catra rests her palm very softly over Adora's shoulder, calling for her attention.

Adora jolts and cringes away, curling around herself and snapping her whole body completely away from Catra, caught off guard while spiraling into the dark thoughts of her head.

Catra freezes on her stand, her mouth slightly slack and her eyebrows shooting over her head, surprise melting into a worried hitch over her forehead.

“Why are you so jumpy today?” Catra questions her, curling her hand over her chest instead.

Adora flinches, wrinkling her nose at the confused expression in her face

“Nothing, just–” Adora exhales, looking down at the apples again. “Kind of on my nerves”

It's a lie. It tastes and sounds and reeks like a lie, loud for both of them

Silence falls between them, different to the one they have gotten so used to. Instead of easy and calm this one is charged with unspoken things and Adora feels miserable with every single second of it.

Catra's face falls and then shifts completely, her easy going and relaxed expression changing into something much more worrisome, fear crawling to the corners of her pretty eyes and

hanging heavy over the corners of her mouth.

“Did I do something wrong?” Catra whispers, hugging herself.

A dead weight falls inside Adora heavily, turning her stomach upside down. Bile and bitterness pool on the back of her throat, staining her teeth on acid and making her eyes go wide with dread and surprise under the sudden despair written all over Catra's face.

“Of course not.” Adora rushes to say, straightening over the grass.

“If I overstepped–”

“No, Kiki.” Adora stretches her hand, hesitating for a second, placing it very softly over Catra's arms. She wraps her wrist inside her fingers, loose enough that if Catra wants to lean away she only needs to give a step back. She doesn't. “It's alright, I promise”

Catra's dark eyebrows are knitted over her forehead, so close together that they almost touch. She looks completely unsure, thrown around inside her head suddenly, stepping on hesitant feet.

“Why are you lying to me?” She spats, scowling deeply before that too falls, souring her beautiful starry face like a poison.

Adora´s heart hammers inside her throat, violent and angry too, as if it too was annoyed at Adora for staining this, their easy life inside this place. Adora recoils, biting into the inside of her cheeks until they bleed.

“I am not,” Adora murmurs, shaken, not knowing what else to say. “Everything is fine, Catra. I promise you”

Catra considers her, her ears fluttering nervously around her face, giving away just how on edge she truly feels. She nods after a moment, letting herself fall over the grass, away enough from Adora that the distance burns her like a fire.

Adora grimaces, staring at Catra's body before so open and free, now curling over itself. She makes herself a tight knot of her limbs over the floor, hugging her knees close to her chest with her tail tightly wrapped around her ankles. Her ears are dropped at the sides of her head and her expression is grim, sand and confused all the same. Plainly angry on every single beautiful plane of her face.

This is not fair, not for Catra who hasn't done a single thing wrong. This is Adora’s fault, whatever she is feeling right now, whatever she allows herself to feel, it is all Adora's fault. Catra did not ask her for any of it.

She did not ask Adora to grow fond of her, to grow used to her. She did not ask Adora to be broken and cursed and wrong. She did not ask Adora for her to adore her so deeply and devastatingly. Did not ask her to not know how to live without her by her side.

Catra wants to be Adora's friend. She wants to because she is good and compassionate; because there is nobody else in this place. It's not fair of Adora to prohibit her of it by letting

her heart hope for something that does not belong to her; by letting her damned soul wish to hold more than her hand for just a second longer.

Adora reaches on the ground, grasping the still raw edges of the lyre she has been fixing for the last couple of weeks. The strings are mostly tightened over the arch, echoing still too high and little melodic around them.

“You play?” Adora asks softly, tilting her head to look at Catra's face, trying to ease the tension. Catra wrinkles her nose, letting her eyes open a slit..

“A little,” she deadpans, still between her knees. “Not in a long time”

“Oh”

Adora bites into her tongue, dropping the instrument back over the grass. She considers Catra's face for a moment, biting into her cuticles. Her heart is beating violently inside her chest but she tries to settle it down, the need to ease the sorrow in Catra's face being stronger than her own fear.

Adora stands up on hesitant feet, wondering is she has actually grown infinitesimally crazier by the hour as she steps closer to Catra´s side, kneeling in front of her.

“Dance with me,” Adora asks, the second thing she has ever asked of her since they are here. The first Catra has complied but Adora seems to be losing the fight of not breaking it herself.

Catra frowns, her eyes unfocused as she raises her head from between her knees, placing Adora´s voice in front of her.

“Really?” She sounds like she wants to seem angry still but there is a clear edge of hope in the seams. Under the light of the sun, her hair looks as golden as the spears.

“Yes”

“I'm not good at it”

Adora grins, tilting her head. “That would be a first”

“I don't know everything Adora,” Catra mutters, scoffing at her. It´s been such a long time since Catra was annoyed at her that seeing it now makes Adora shift nervously over her place, suddenly afraid.

“That's good because it means I can teach you,” Adora teases, fighting back the echoes inside her head that tell her to back off, that she is too inadequate to give Catra this. Adora cleans the sweat off her palms, reaching for Catra instead, running the ghost of her finger over Catra ´s knuckles. “Come here”

A second goes by, then another and a third one. Adora is just about to lean back and maybe actually throw herself off the waterfall when Catra´s palm turns around, loosely gripping Adora´s fingers without moving further.

She allows Adora to pull her up on her feet, standing awkwardly one in front of the other without actually knowing what to do next. There is no music around them, no lyres or pan flute or pandura; just the sound of the blue birds flying above their heads and the waterfall feet behind them, filling their silence with their own kind of music.

Adora sighs, looking down at Catra´s nervous face. She is shorter than Adora, her forehead reaching around the middle of Adora´s bridge nose and for a moment Adora thinks how easily it would be to rest her lips over her forehead, crawling away from the thought immediately after.

Catra is uncomfortable, this much Adora can tell, not by Adora´s proximity but because she doesn´t know what to do, standing around nothing. Adora grimaces to herself and shakes herself off any other kind of thought, gathering the bravery to give a step forward, closing the gap between them.

Adora lowers her hands, finding Catra´s elegant fingers resting without moving at her sides. Adora turns them around softly and rests her palms over them, not even getting to touch her completely at all, guiding them up until they are raised at the sides of their heads, the shadows of their fingers crowning each other.

“Give a step to your right,” Adora instructs gently, smiling when Catra grumbles but do as she asks her to. “Good, I´ll take a step to the left.”

Adora does so, the start to the dance clear for her. She can remember the steps still, deep inside her mind even after so many years of not dancing at all. It brings back memories for her, of dances done in the palace of her family, being surrounded by people laughing and music. Not all of it was bad.

“Now step to the other side,” Adora whispers, guiding Catra very softly in the opposite direction. It is obvious that she is trying to be annoying about this but she still has some deep elegance to her that is hard to miss at all. “Very good.”

“And now?” Catra asks, closing her eyes and opening them very slowly again. She is blushing, deeply, from the roots of her ears all the way to her cheekbones and down the fall of her shoulders.

Adora smiles, trembling a little on the edges with sadness.

“Now just follow me”

It´s sweet. Catra is just slightly clumsy, tripping a little where she doesn't know the steps and huffing when it happens. Adora is patient with her, teaching her calm and sweetly every single twist and turns, barely brushing her hand at all when she does so until she finally meets her in the middle, wrapping her hand fully around hers and coming back again to twist her softly below her arm.

Adora starts humming very softly under her breath, following the notes of one of the songs she remembers from her times at the palace. Something fun, easy going, a little jumpy and quick that picks up the pace around them.

Little by little Catra starts to learn the repetitive steps, adding a little flourish of her own to them. Little by little the tension in Catra´s body starts to melt down, slipping through their fingers like sand.

Adora grabs her hands fully and pulls from her into a soft twist and Catra grins, stepping over the soft grass and moss below them. Their bare feet trip with each other several times but it doesn´t even matter, they just laugh and bend over themselves, catching each other before straightening again on their makeshift dance.

Catra gets much braver at some point and she turns around, wrapping her fingers around Adora´s wrists and pulling her towards her, tripping in the middle and making them lean. The veil around Adora´s head brushes the ground where she bends backwards, barely caught from falling on the ground by Catra´s hands around her waist.

She looks up in time to catch a glimpse of Catra above her, giggling like brightly and barely managing to not drop them both into the ground before pulling Adora back straight into her feet.

Adora laughs, actually laughs, staring at the disheveled curls falling over Catra´s face. She raises her hands and catches a strand of Catra´s hair, not even thinking about it, placing it gently behind her fluttering ear. The blush in Catra´s face deepens, falling red and beautiful down below her swan neck and losing itself around her collarbones.

Adora grins from ear to ear, barely thinking when she wraps her arms around Catra´s waist and carries her off the ground, spinning her around their spot with a huge smile. Catra laughs like a maniac in Adora´s arms, her back against the latter´s chest and rolling her head backwards, letting her nape rest over Adora´s shoulder as she places her back on the ground.

Catra giggles all the way, turning around on her ankles to face Adora. Her eyelids are casted down, halfway narrowed where the light bothers her and makes her slightly tired. She is pretty, she smells amazing, she is Adora´s best friend.

Catra´s eyebrows hitch on her forehead, still smiling and her face still bright, but the corners of her eyes still wrinkled in the edges with the shadow of worry.

“Are you sure you're alright?” She asks, resting her palms above Adora´s clammy ones, still without touching.

“I–” Adora clears her throat, counting Catra´s eyelashes one by one. “I never had a friend before, Catra. I had my brother and I loved him deeply. And I lost him all the same, but beyond that there was never anyone else.”

Adora takes a shaky breath, wrinkling her nose. Catra´s face is calm, quiet as she listens to Adora without a trace of judgment on it. The hesitance and grief on her face has melted down completely,

“What I want to say is– you're my friend, Catra.” Adora finally stumbles out, biting into her own mouth.

Catra smiles at her, sighing, It´s sincere but there is still a small trace of something in there, fragile and sad. Adora does not quite know what to do about it.

“You´re my friend too, Adora,” Catra whispers, curling her tail around Adora´s ankle. “Nothing is ever going to change that, I promise”

Adora smiles, wet on the edges. “Don´t promise,” she asks of her, shaking her head. “Please”

Catra presses her lips together, wrinkling her nose adorably. She considers Adora, thinking for a moment before leaning forwards. She usually always asks for permission but she does not give Adora even a second to think about this. But then again, this is the first time they do this.

Catra snakes her arms below Adora´s armpits, right above her ribs, wrapping them completely around Adora´s chest and holding her close. She leans her head down and rests it over Adora´s collarbones, breathing against the wrinkles of her tunic.

Adora´s dress is red today, Catra´s is white, both of them painted with green moss in the hem. They are soft, both of them right now, swans untouched by golden spears. Catra was right, Adora is safe.

Adora exhales, gasping heavily the moment she feels the touch, locked into place. Her arms lay fallen at her sides, limp and unmoving, unable to raise them up. Catra smells good, all about her is good, and Adora thinks that she might just be able to do this after all.

“Don´t tell me what to do,” Catra whispers, not even bothered by Adora´s lack of embrace, humming over the skin of her neck. “I do promise”



Catra is dreaming for the first time in five years.

Dreams, not nightmares, not immense void. Actual dreams that gather and swirl inside her mind and that makes her blinks several times around the golden shimmer. She had almost forgotten about them, she had almost thought they had abandoned her completely.

There are winds around her, fresh and warm, and the air smells like trees in bloom and like the mud of the river of Menagerie, its calm current easing Catra´s heart and soothing her nerves where she might be tired and nervous.

It smells familiar and calm, soft, it gives Catra a sense of quietness and joy.

A sudden breath blows over her ears, gentle and strange to the wind. It´s a blow of breath directly over her temples, soft and done with purpose by a mouth next to her.

Catra whips her head around, bringing or at least feeling what she thinks are her hands, towards her ear, covering it as it twitches violently next to her head. A chuckle meets her, as

familiar as the air around her, low and slightly scratched in the edges, so real that for a moment Catra forgets completely that she is dreaming.

“C´yra”

“Adam?” Catra exhales, her voice shaking. “Adam”

The next thing she feels are arms, wide, also familiar. A hug, an embrace, done quietly between friends.

He is shorter than she remembers or maybe she has gotten used to someone taller. He also smells a little bit like lemongrass and much more like oranges and somewhere inside Catra´s brain tells her that she is sleeping; that in the real word, Adora lays sleeping next to her.

“Thank you,” Adam whispers next to her ears.

Catra hums, feeling the strands of his hair around her cheeks. “For what?”

Adam chuckles, very softly and under his breath, almost as if he knew a secret that only both of them knew.

“I told you she was easy to love”

Catra holds her breath, her hands shaking a little bit. He feels faint around her, light, almost like mist, almost like the light around home.

“Take care of her, alright?” Adam asks her in a whisper before leaving again, only granted permission for a second as Catra walks in dreams. One last plea of a brother that has always known Catra would love her unconditionally. “Take care of each other”

The gateway to the world; the gun in a trembling hand

When nature unmakes the boundary; the pillar of myth still stands

The swan upon Leda

Occupier upon an ancient land

— **Hozier,** *Swan Upon Leda*

Chapter End Notes

AND THEY WERE WORSE THAN ROOMATES, SO MUCH WORSE!

Hope you are enjoying the small slow burn because it is absolutely demolishing my patience jsjs

Additional notes to help the understanding of the chapter:
- Yes, Hordak and Shadow Waver (Lystra) are dead, dead. Rest in hell
- Adam can only visit Catra in dreams because she is a dream walker given she is Morpheus daughter, which is also why Adam cannot visit Adora directly
- The girls are absolutely in love already but Adora still needs to heal some things, give her time

Hope you enjoyed the chapter! Thank you so much everybody for your sweet comments, sorry I could not answer them my schedule is crazy.

As always, bookmarks, kudos, comments and suscriptions are deeply appreciated. See you soon, be good!

Verse VII

Chapter Notes

I honestly thought I was going to publish this on the weekend, I told everybody that but I finished earlier and well,now that it's out of my system I need to share it, it's only fair

Welcome to the middle of the fic! Huzzah!
A very emotionally heavy chapter today, shorter than the last but eventful. Some of you already guessed what are we talking about today so let's go right ahead!

Chapter warnings :
--- Mild descriptions of gods and gore
--- The gods described at the beginning are Aphrodite and Demeter
— Panic attacks, meltdowns
— Mentions of mild self harm
--- Descriptions alluding to chronic illness/chronic pain
--- Body dysphoria
--- PTSD, mania attacks, traumatic events

This is one of the heaviest chapters I've written for this story, I hope I can live up to the expectation and male justice of the story I have given to my girls (◜‿◝)♡

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse VII.

Winged Serpents

ع اللي ضاع من عمري وأنا أخبيها من كل عين دوارة

(For all that has been lost of my life as I've concealed it from every wandering eye)

أسيرة بدربٍ مرسوم بخطى مكارة

(A prisoner in a path drawn with cunning intent)

يا معذرة يا أنا، ضليت ونورك ضل يحميني

(Forgive me, my dear self, I have strayed, and your light kept protecting me)

إنتي أصل الأصل وأصلي أنا فلسطيني

(You are the origin of my origin, and my origin is Palestinian)

The sickles fall against the ground, dragging over the death earth with every single step, heavy and judgmental. An instrument, a tool, created with the purpose of helping the human with their tasks, to cut alongside the stems of the grains that would feed them and nurture them, now used as a medium of destruction and death.

The metal shines golden, sharp as a thousand suns, polished on the very forges of Hephestus, reflecting the destruction around it as the Lady of the Golden Blade makes her way through the earth.

They have done this to themselves, the mortals, the humans, with their fingers stained with their brothers and sisters bloods and their chests filled with greed. They have caused this, they have allowed it, burning the ground that once fed them, with their unnatural fires and poisoning the air with the fumes of their breaths. They have caused the rain to fall acid and the river to fill with darkness, venom that lingers on the creatures mouths and veins and that murders them.

They have done, all on their own, the Lady has only caused the retribution, she has only stood and watched them suffocate with the consequences of her actions. She has stepped on the burnt grass and destroyed columns of a home that once guarded her bloodline, her child, her only grandchild, and saw them spit on the remains and has burnt them from the inside out in return.

There is no mercy left of the Lady, as gods are strangers to the word. There are only actions and the consequences of them; there are only games and bets; there are only blessings or death, no in between. After all, they are no mortals to play the ever changing game of morals and they do not bound themselves to human emotions. But they do crave and they do wish for revenge when those who they consider theirs have been defiled.

The lady stands in the middle of the desolated land, staring with inexistent eyes at the darkness around her. There are no colors remaining here, no life; the only shades of vibrant shimmer live now on her head, hanging heavy like pouring off her cornucopia fleshed hair and towards the ground, rich with life and food but dying immediately at the touch of mortal earth.

There are fruits, apples and figs and citrus, hanging from the sides like coins of gold, like crowns. They nestle among the huge leaves of mint, barley and wheat; they live next to the crimson petals of poppies, rich with color and bleeding out like a beating heart, falling across the length of her body in red rivers like clay that poison the ground.

There were poppy fields here, before, before the destruction. Before the seed of the King´s breed reeked through the world and made it all unholy and dirty. There were poppy fields as huge as monuments growing around the small house, hanging from the frames of the windows and finding their ways through dark hair. Around the laughter of a blind child that became a beautiful woman in the blink of an eye, more holy than the temples of the cities, so

close to godlike sanctity that the pantheon was afraid of her. The Harvest Lady´s blood and the Dream´s only sprout, destined for the halls of queens and casted away instead.

There were poppies too in someone else's head, across the other side of the kingdom. Red petals tangled around golden strands of hair, holding them like the feathers of a golden swan around her young head; where the flower blooms were more important to her than the crown hanging like an ax over her head.

The Lady remembers them, remembers her, as she saw them sprout around the exiled princess chamber, as if the flowers themselves were crawling their way from the very edges of the river and across the earth to find her on the other side, love letters and unknown gifts from the half of the soul. And wherever there is bloom there is the lady and her blood.

Because, as the pantheon knows, the two young women were once one. One soul separated in halves; one flesh and one heart, torn apart by the hands of Zeus himself when the strength of their adoration threatened to overpower the holiness of them all and so he made them into two, destined to wander the earth in search of each other until the universe eats itself and all that is left is silence.

The serpents around the goddess´s head sizzle, loudly, curling their bodies around her nape and the middle of her spine, finding their way around her neck and the fall of her shoulders. They are the ones that make the goddess hair, reflecting the pass of the harvest seasons around them, once green, then golden, now black as the void of an extinguished fire.

Their slim bodies slither over each other, the ethereal wings held to their backs curling around her temples and closing over the planes of her face where eyes should be and instead there are only empty holes and impossible skin.

They are one of her most sacred possessions, like her daughters, like her bloodline and the fertility of the earth that comes with it. They are a blessing, a prayer from a goddess for protection.

They were a gift, for her grandchild´s lover.

The goddess did not curse the princess´s eyes, but she did extend her hand. Ran her ethereal fingertips across wheat hair and transformed into something god touched, something that would protect her from mortal touch so the sight of men and no other kind of pain could fall over her again.

It might not be fair and it might not be true mercy, but such are the gods´s blessings.

The Lady´s chariot stops across the ground, the golden dragons pulling from it curling over themselves and spitting blue fires on the still air, creating sparks that might fuel the fires of destruction all over again. She tilts her head, the serpent crawling their ways on the ground as they too catch sight of the goddess standing in ethereal feet in the middle of her path.

The place where her soles and the earth meet does not exist, hovering above it in waves of dark foams that are born from the death river, not a god or goddess left on it to raise her from the pits of the worlds so her body does not touch the ashes of the world.

From her claws, her feet merge and shift, the shape of bird feet clear from the two toes to the ankles and all the way to her calves where they melt and mingle around human-like flesh and feather, softer than any other fabric or material in the whole world.

These ones wrap themselves completely around her, traveling across her body like the phantom shape of a tunic, across the length of her belly and underneath the swell of her breast, climbing as vines over sharp collar bones where the shoulder blades shift and turn, falling in long dove wings that drag behind her with every movement of her beautiful body.

She is seafoam, daughter from the waves of the sea, but she is also petal and iron. Her ever shifting hair, now dark and curled melted into strands of golden, lays long below the planes of her war helmet, falling too through the middle of her spine like the trail of a swan´s tail, losing itself among the pure white of the wings. A striking mirror to the darkness of the burnt moss.

Where the planes of her beautiful face exist there are pearls, imperfect, beautiful, deeply dug into ethereal dark skin that sparkles with the light of algae and star all the same. They crown her temples and her forehead, the fall of her jaw and the corner of her lips. And there are scallop shells on her cheekbones and in the lines of her eyelids; right next to the pressed roses of her lips. A mask of beauty created only for her to wear.

She stands in the middle of destruction, bird and pearl, covered from the rose trail of her helmet to her paws in red, red like the fabric of a dress, red like the poppies from the Lady´s crown. Red, coloring her feathers and her beautiful face and her divine chest. Red like blood, as she is not only the lady of love but also a warrior, lover of war who exists so deeply woven to her very existence that the world would cease to exist without them.

It is all gone, the goddess of love sings and when she blinks tears of pearls fall from her face. *As the Oracle saw, all of them are dead.*

The Lady of the Harvest hums, not quite a sound either but also not a voice at all, echoing across the space as her sight extends far around them. Once she had blessed the forests of Menagerie to grow and to thrive. Once she had blessed the patch of land of her human seed and had also seen it destroyed by men's hands.

Once she lost a daughter, many eons ago, casted away to the shadows of the Underworld with her mouth stained in the blood of pomegranates and her heart tangled in the ropes of love. She roamed the dry earth for her and even after everything she has to learn how to live through immortality with just a part of her.

Then her mortal daughter, Io, laying in the Elysiums in peace, murdered by her bastard sister who had not a single cell of godlike blood, who now roams the Tartarus in sorrow.

Now the child of her child, also casted away, safe on the nest of a cavern and the womb of her lover but torn apart of an earth that loved her.

Is not fair, for a mother. Is not fair, isn´t it? To lose a child for the greed of men.

It´s not enough, the goddess of the Harvest says, her winged dragons clicking their venomous fangs with each other. *It will never be enough to repair the dishonor they have caused to fall over my seed.*

It won´t, the goddess of love agrees as she licks over her blood stained lips.

The Lady stares at her, both infinite forces of nature created for rebirth, for creation, as mothers of all things living, standing over the devastation they have both caused. Their ichor is on the ground too, slipping through the cracks of the earth, waiting to make it anew once the gods learn how to forgive or forget.

It has been a long time since I´ve seen you like this, the Lady says, looking up and down the goddess´s red body, pointing with one of her golden arms at the traces of death on her lovely body.

The goddess of love smiles, all shark teeth and forked tongue, drinking on the blood and the smell of roses that mingles with it, for even before being a symbol of desire she thrived on battle and on passion of all kinds, flesh and heart alike.

Love can take many shapes, old queen, she says, running sharp claws through the loops of her hair, dark and golden braided tightly together. *Tenderness, desire, grief.* Her pupils meet the Lady´s, full like moonlight, round and sun shaped; blind, for after all, love is sightless. *Rage*

The Lady of the Harvest clicks her fauces together and with it the earth itself trembles and breaks into two, creating destruction, creating new paths where fresh water from the lakes can run through for no devastation is far away from new beginnings.

When will it be enough?

Not until Zeus´s bastard lays death on my grounds

He will not forsake him until he doesn't bring him victories anymore, not for any of us. Ten years of blood the Fates have sung off

Then he will have to face my rage until then, the goddess screams, shrieks, bending the world in half. *He will pay for what he has done*

The love goddess smiles, satisfied, breathing from the anger that pools off the other goddess' immortal soul in waves of mistletoe, capable of killing everything and making it anew again. The golden serpents crawl over the earth and find their way around the nestle of her feathers, mingling with a single purpose.

And he will pay for what he has yet to do

Being blind is not easy and it is not always kind. Catra knows everything that there is to know about it.

No matter how hard she tries to act as if it was as easy as breathing, something she has done every single day of her life since she was merely more than a child, something that she has grown accustomed to and that makes her proud, it still aches, deep inside her heart.

Sometimes it makes her feel sad, sometimes annoyed. Sometimes it makes her feel angry.

She was taught to be strong because otherwise she would not survive in this world, true or not. She was taught to never expect for anybody to bend and break themselves in pieces just to accommodate her needs. And even if someone would, she needed to know how to keep living if they ever left. If Catra remained alone.

And for a long time Catra was fine with that, loneliness, the shadow of hope, the perception of light out of the corner of her eyes. All those wonders of the world that still surrounded her no matter if her body had changed. All those things that could make Catra seem as if she had risen up and above, navigating it with patience and grace.

The truth, as many times, is much different.

What people don´t say or don´t about is that blindens is not always just the loss of sense, end and move on. Being blind is more complicated, ever changing, evolving, and in some cases it hurts, many months and years after it has happened, day and night, physical or mentally, it hurts.

What people sometimes don´t remember is that the absence of a sense doesn´t mean that the rest of your body will grow to be magnificently capable to make up for the missing piece of you. Sometimes something missing is just that, something lost, and none of the things you try to replace it with will ever be able to replace it. So you learn to live with it, despite it.

What most of the souls walking their lives through the world don´t get to understand, is that losing a part of you, being from the womb or through some point of your life, will always be a loss and you will always mourn it. Even if time goes by and you think less and less about the pain first inflicted, there will always be a part of your soul that aches for it, that wonders why this happened to you. That tries to imagine how life would be otherwise.

It´s normal, natural. Human. Catra did not become a much better person for it, nor did she become worse. She did not grow stronger from loss or grief, she just grew.

What Catra always tries to hide is that most times she also feels inadequate, she also feels like not enough. That sometimes, less than before but sometimes, she feels like a nuisance for the people that get to care about her even a little.

It's never a welcomed feeling, never once desired, but Catra cannot help herself but to feel it, deeply rooted inside of her when the day has progressed and she hasn´t.

It didn´t matter for her, or at least that's what she told herself. It didn´t matter because for a long time there was not a soul that she cared about nearly enough to feel wrong around them,

and she would be damned if she gave importance to every single person crossing her way and scowling at her eyes, but things are different now.

She has something she cares about, she has someone dear to her heart, again and a thousand times more devastating than any times before. More than her own mother, more than Adam who became a friend and all those who he brought with him.

Life has given her Adora, even after losing faith that she would ever find her, even in the middle of war, it has brought Catra right by to Adora´s side.

Now Catra has someone that she could let down, that she could disappoint, who could grow tired and weary and who would step away any second without Catra even noticing. And the mere thought of it it's so heartbreaking that it leaves Catra speechless for a long second.

Those are such lengths devotion have brought her into.

And the thing is, that Catra is still human, just a mere human and for so she feels, too much and too quick. Catra is still human and for so she is capable of feeling anger, and annoyance.

She is allowed to have wanted to know the world around them, to walk without aid or without help, to learn life differently while at the same time being proud of who she is, who she has become and the work she has done to become it.

She is capable of mourning the things she was never allowed to have in the first place. She is capable of rejecting the idea of being *cured* or *fixed* with every fiber of her being while at the same time knowing in another time she could have craved something different.

And she is allowed to be jealous. Wanting and desiring does not mean Catra´s disability is less significant, it just makes her part of who she is. Young, feminine, hopeful and rageful at the same time. Someone falling in love.

She is allowed to lay on this bed where she rests right now, breathing the smell of Adora´s skin, and wish she had known the sparkle of her eyes when she speaks to her under the shimmer of the day light.

"Tell me about your home town," Adora asks in a low voice, sore, her breath warm where it meets Catras´s eyelashes.

"It's hot" Adora snorts beside Catra and the sound of her candle warm laugh fuels Catra with newfound trust. "It's beautiful. The sky is always clear and the river is the gentlest you could have ever met. There are ripe fruits that fall from the trees all the time, no matter the season, and children always run around barefoot in the mud to collect them and eat them under the tree's shadows."

"Sounds wonderful." Adora slips closer to her over the thin mattress, her voice smiling. Their forearms slide together gently, very softly, speeding up Catra´s heart inside her chest,

"It is"

"Do you miss it?"

"I don't— I don't know. I love that place, I was born and grew there. My mother lived there." Catra lips her sand dry lips, letting her eyes close again.

The cavern is very quiet today, calm and peaceful, filled only by the birds' song and the rush of the waterfall. Catra´s chiton is very thin, soft and fine fabric that still manages to stick to her body by the humid air that hangs inside the cavern and the abandoned temple.

"Catra," Adora whispers after a few seconds of silence, pressing the tip of her fingers against Catra´s. "It´s just us."

The echo of Catra´s own words makes Catra gasp, her stuffy nose and clogged throat betraying her after holding itself together for so long. She knows that she is safe here, inside this place where life has suspended itself for a moment; where seasons seem to have ceased to exist and the days mingle with each other yet they are all different from each other.

Adora is here, right next to her, and Catra promised her safety. Why would Catra not be granted of the same?

Adora´s skin is cool though, fresh as running water and sweet smelling. Her hand feels safe when she laces her fingers around Catra´s clammy once, making the first move for them to touch. Catra holds herself to her right back with as much strength as she can.

"I never felt like myself there, not completely I guess." Catra keeps saying, wrinkling her nose. She chuckles miserably, pressing the heel of her hand against her pained eyes. "I feel like I'm betraying the people that cared about me by saying this."

"You are not," Adora whispers next to her, running her thumb over Catra´s shivering knuckles. "You can feel whatever you want here."

How did they get here? Catra wonders. It has been months now since the moment Catra arrived here. They were strangers for so long, Adora kept her away for so long that Catra started doubting herself and her heart and how hard it would call and long for Adora.

And now they are here, sharing the same bed. And still Catra cannot help to feel that she is too incomplete to truly be next to her. That she is holding back so much truth, so many secrets, that they will eat her and all of this fragile beauty between them completely alive.

Catra feels the burn of tears threatening to fall from the corners of her eyes and she is angry at them for a moment before that too disappears by the gentle pressure of Adora´s hand around hers.

"I was Io´s daughter but for the rest of them I was never– I was never just C´yra. Just Catra. I was the disabled woman of the town, the one who was different from them and at the beginning they acted as if they truly wanted to be kind, but when things got hard and their own comfort was threatened they forsaken me for it. Gods, as if— as if I had chosen to be born at all in the first place. As if they didn´t know how lucky they were to be granted health, to be granted a life without perchances and without pain."

Catra wraps her fingers around a fistful of the sheets below her body, tearing tiny holes there with her nails. Her other hand twitches too, digging suddenly sharp around Adora´s palm too and Catra jolts suddenly when she realizes, trying to let go so as to not hurt her. Adora holds her tighter.

“I didn´t choose to have to go through this yet everybody treated me as if I had done. Worst of all, before the war and the famine and the plague, they treated me as if I should be *grateful* to be so lucky, because I could have had it so much worse.” Catra gasps, fighting to find her breath amongst the strength of her sudden grief. “Even my mother tried to convince me it was a blessing. To see the silver lining. I was not allowed to be mad, to be angry about it, to grieve myself. I just had to be stronger and keep going. I was so sick of it.”

Catra´s mouth stings where she bites herself, the sharp end of her fang opening a clean and tiny line over her bottom lip, making her bleed a little. Next to her Adora holds her breath, tensing her body, as if holding herself from moving a single inch closer to brush the drop of blood away, even though Catra wish nothing more but for her to get close.

Other part of Catra is relieved though, grateful that Adora remains away because Catra needs a single second to collect herself, to not scream, her skin fired on goosebumps where she doesn´t know what else to do but to lay here with her eyes wide open and the shadows and light echoes playing dances on her sightless irises.

“I understand,” Adora whispers, and Catra knows that out of everyone left in this world, Adora might actually be the only person that actually does get it. “It´s not fair.”

“It is not,” Catra agrees, breathing very softly through her nose. Adora shifts in her place, her breath caressing the side of Catra´s face, letting the latter know that she has turned her face towards her.

“Would you—? Uh, sorry. It´s an stupid question.” Adora starts but she stops herself almost immediately, shrinking into herself when she thinks better of whatever she thought to say. Catra pulls from her hand softly, cooing her to ask anyway; no matter what it is she wants to know, she needs someone to ask her. “Would you want to be— different?”

“Sometimes— sometimes when I went to sleep and the day was slow and I had spent hours listening to the people of the town whisper about me, or listening to my mother weep when she thought I could not hear her, sometimes I wished to be someone else completely.” Catra confesses, pressing her eyelids closed until her head pounds. “I would close my eyes and pray with all my heart that when I opened them again I would be different, that I could be *whole* . Even if I knew damn well it would not happen”

“Kiki—”

“I am blind.” Catra exhales, bringing her hand, the one that is not holding Adora, to her face. She feels the patterns of her skin, across the planes of her face and the frail of her own eyelids and eyelashes. She feels Adora´s hand on hers, anchoring her down when she starts to drift away. “And even if someone would offer me right here and now to return me my sight, I would not accept it. Because this time it would be *my* decision. I am blind and I am disabled, it's a part of who I am right now. I don´t want anything or anybody to change me.”

Adora exhales next to her face, her gentle breath brushing the strands curling around Catra´s face like tree branches. Catra did not realize just how close Adora truly was, too submerged suddenly inside her own head.

It's kind of scary sometimes, the proximity, the trust of touch and of listening to the other's pain. It should scare Catra, to be seen so raw and vulnerable when she cannot see the world around her, but the thing is that it doesn´t. Not when it's Adora.

“Here in this patch of land it is different. Here I feel like I can breathe. I don't have to be grateful and I don´t have to be perfect. I´m not the blind girl of the time anymore, or the weaver, or the last one of my grandmother´s line. I´m me, just me"

Catra hopes, deep within her heart, that Adora understands the words that she is saying. That she understands that they are not only meant for herself but also for her.

"I don't want you to feel alone here," Adora whispers after a very long moment of silence. She has nice hands, long, wider than Catra´s, the skiing slightly rough in the palm and the tips; they wrap almost completely around Catra´s. "I know it wasn't much your choice, I regret that"

"I'm not alone. You are here." Adora breath hitches painfully on her chest. Catra feels the need to turn over and stretch her arms towards her but she doesn't. "It may have not been my decision to come but it's my decision to stay. *I'm* choosing to stay"

Catra allows her eyes to fall closed again, and this time is not as overwhelming as before. Darkness is an old friend of hers, just as it´s light.

Being blind aches sometimes but it's also soothing, comforting too. Sometimes it feels like letting your head dunk below the surface of the water, right between the place where the tension is stronger and you can both sink down and break out into fresh air.

Catra guesses this is what being like her is. Good days, bad days, all of them, neither, in the middle. It´s anatomy, it´s a part of her, and she knows it deeply.

Adora, somehow, knows it too. She knows it almost all, Catra has almost given her all.

Adora moves one more time next to her, curling into her side. She gets closer, so much closer, the entire side of her body basically pressed now against Catra´s bare arm, not once letting go from her hand.

Catra holds her breath as Adora´s head rolls to the side, resting her cold forehead right above the fall of Catra´s shoulder. Catra can feel the bridge of her nose leaning against her skin; the phantom of Adora´s lips pressing over the fine hair on her forearms; the edge of the veils Adora wraps her head with brushing almost completely against the angle of her own neck.

Catra can hear the soft jingle and even softer hiss that lives below the fabrics of the veils, also holding back secrets, also holding back part of the truth. Something that makes Adora ashamed but that Catra cannot help but to feel wonder about.

Maybe it is this little secret, so close but also so out of reach too, that makes Catra realize that she cannot possibly call herself Adora´s friend, she cannot possibly care about completely, feel tenderness for her completely, if she is not true to her first.

She needs to tell Adora what lingers inside her dreams.

“Adora?” Catra whispers, choking with her own breath.

Adora exhales next to her skin, nuzzling the bridge of her nose against her shoulder. Her hand has now wrapped itself completely around Catra´s forearm, resting her palm near Catra´s wrist where she holds herself onto with loose strength.

“Hmm?”

“There is something I need to tell you.” Catra whispers in the thread of a voice, much more frail than the ones she uses on the loom to paint unknown images.

“Alright. Adora murmurs, smiling against her skin.“You are warm”

She sounds drowsy, already halfway asleep. Adora has spent so many nights laying awake or being chased by nightmares, so many weeks and months and years that Catra cannot even begin to imagine, that it breaks Catra´s heart to even think of ripping her off the land of dreams right now. A place where she can dive in the clouds of unawareness and rest.

“Catra?”

“Later.” Catra hooks her pinky around Adora´s relaxing her body around hers to allow her to rest. “Sleep first”

It's painful, in a way, and it is not fair. The one thing Adora might want to have the most in the whole world, a single second longer with someone she might have loved, has for some reason been granted to Catra instead.

And Catra, who can´t even describe it but in sounds and touch, cannot do anything else but to be a safekeeper of it until Adora wakes up again. Maybe then Catra will be able to grant her kindness underneath the veils too.



Catra should have known. From the very beginning, she should have known.

They are, after all, so very similar in certain things; and so very different in others. Like feeling the crevices of a coin, with patterns on one side, and different cravings at the other. Catra should have known.

She has been battling herself for the last two weeks wondering how to make the question, how to approach it at all. How to be gentle enough so that she will not accidentally break Adora´s heart in the middle. By all means, Catra could still be wrong; she could be confused or finding things where they are not.

Catra knows she is not wrong, but for a long moment in the days that are to come, she deceives herself with the idea that she has gone insane. The gods, however and as Catra is slowly coming to realize, seem to have placed all of them like pieces of a game in the world for them to take entertainment from.

It has almost been a whole year since Catra came to be in this cavern. She cannot remember when the days mingled into weeks and from there into three months, or six, or ten as they are now, Catra did not feel the pass of time or the change on her mortal body.

Catra does not count the time in seconds, in the movement of the light around her or in the tick of the world spinning with her inside. Catra counts the time, instead, in the change of seasons; in the birth of the crops and blooms and the humid air. She knows time goes by in the way the cavern remains the same around her yet it changes, all of it, filled with more light, cradled with more blooms and with the way the trees go taller and more nurturing, that's the way Catra knows it.

She realizes time is happening, stretching and shrinking and moving around them again, in the way the heat of the sun gives away to the fresh of the rain and then into the chill of winter, sauntering inside a place that has become more like a home in tiny cold drops that dissolve on her open palm when she extends it towards the open domes of the cavern. Then, there is heat again; the flowers never leave her though, not even once.

Catra realizes time is passing them by, in Adora.

She realizes it in the way Adora starts unfolding around her, like one of the winter blooms, little by little and almost all at once. She moves softer, not wanting to be invisible anymore but simply softer; she still wears the coin bracelets but somehow Catra realizes she does it as routine and not because she thinks it might cause harm if she doesn't.

She realizes it in the way Adora sits just a little bit closer to her near the fireplace when they eat; and in the way she sleeps closer, a breath only, but closer when night has fallen over them and the olive bed is warm and quiet in a way that does not scare either of them.

She realizes it in the ways Adora still holds herself away, tight, scared, because now that the real softness that exists on her has started to unfold, those sad parts are ever more striking. And they make Catra grieve, but worse than all, they make Adora live in pain.

Maybe this is the reason why she says it today, why she chooses to speak today. Maybe it's because she is scared that it will make her lose Adora completely, but at the same time, she cannot live like this, knowing Adora blames herself for this.

Catra is sitting on the steps of the temple right now, eyes slightly open, watering by the feeling of the sunlight tickling on her scleras, making her face tired almost immediately. She can hear Adora getting closer, can hear the sound of her clothes brushing over the stone paths and the temple; and she can hear the jingle that always accompanies her.

Catra feels when Adora sits next to her on the steps, still a little bit away but close, leaning her body towards Catra´s, making the latter´s heart pick up inside her ribcage, clogging her throat with emotions.

Catra could cry, right there and then, by the feeling of Adora´s knuckles caressing very, very softly and very slowly across the skin of her cheekbone, gently calling for Catra´s attention with her phantom touch.

There is trust between them, now. So much trust, so carefully built between them. Between Catra who has been forsaken by the world, and Adora who was almost broken by the same. Trust that feels holy to stain with lies.

“What is it?” Adora asks in the thread of a voice, and for anybody it would have sounded curious; but for Catra, who has learnt Adora´s voice like the threats of the loom, it's clear the small tremble of worry carried on every single vowel.

“I´ve been thinking,” Catra starts, cringing at the way her voice breaks in the middle.

“About what?” Adora´s voice sounds even more nervous now, tangible to Catra´s sensitive ears.

“I don´t think I ever told you the name of my town.” Catra murmurs after a second of silence, her eyes still slightly open but her face tilted away from Adora´s.

“Oh.” Adora shuffles, confused. She drops her hand and Catra mourns the distance between them immediately. “Yeah, you didn´t”

Adora needs this, Adora needs to hear this. She deserves to know, she has deserved it since the very first second, since she spoke to Catra about her life in the palace, as a princess.

Since Catra figured out that they were joined across their lives in so many more ways than just hope and dreams. It´s not a secret for Catra to keep because it does not belong to her in the very first place.

“It was Menagerie”

Catra could be wrong. She could be mistaken, deceived by her own dreams.

By the way Adora sharply holds her sweet breath, Catra knows that's not the case.

“You— you are from Menagerie?” Adora repeats in a whisper, her voice distraught.

She is smart, she is the smarter person Catra has ever known. A scientist, a philosopher, a poet, a noble warrior. All of it a part of who she is, a part of *Adora* . All of it so far away from the fact she was ever a princess.

She was also, once, a twin.

“My friend—” Catra wets her dry mouth, digging her sharp nails over her own ribs when she embraces herself. “My best friend, the one I've talked you about, he said he was from Etheria. He had a sister”

Adora is trembling violently next to her. Catra can feel her from the tip of her toes to the roots of her hair.

“He smelled a little bit like lemongrass too,” Catra holds her breath, shivering too. “He laughed like you.”

Catra knows Adora makes the realization before she even says it. She is not quite sure how, or what is causing Adora´s memory to kickstart again, to join the pieces, to knit them together; but the moment she shuffles away from Catra, the latter knows that Adora has placed it all together.

“What was his name?” There is a new change in Adora´s voice, different, so completely different from what Catra has heard for months now that it breaks Catra´s heart. Desperate, pleading, torn into pieces. Afraid.

“Adam.” Adora takes a painfully sharp breath and Catra feels like she is going to break too. “Adora, was Adam your brother?”

There is a thing about heartbreak that feels warm. One would think grief feels cold, freezing to the bone and aching like biting frost, but it's quite the contrary.

It´s heat, bubbling on the middle of the chest, fuzzy, quick. It crawls, bursts open from the very depth of the heart and not even that it´s the most painful part, making its way up and around the ribcage, chewing its way through the muscle and the bone and the pleural and still finding a space to crawl all the way up the throat, nesting on the back of the tongue and the nostrils.

It cannot be shaken, cannot be cleaned for there is nothing to brush away. But it digs, it makes its way inside the skin and the organs and lays living in there, boiling hot every single cell and every single speck of stardust still lingering inside your body, and melting it all into liquid heat.

Heat that gathers on the very same throat and the mouth and the swirls of the nose, tumbling down and running across the face and neck in tears, one by one and then all at the very same time.

Adora sprints into her feet, rushing away from Catra, slicing clean in half their shared touch.

Catra stands up too, stumbling with her own bare feet when she finds there is nothing she can lean into, drifting into nothingness and the fog of blindness. And for those moments where Adora stands up and Catra blindly tries to follow her, she does curse at her sight and she wishes, for the split of a second, to be turned into stone so she could gaze at her sad eyes and comfort her in the ways she cannot do now.

“Adora—” Catra whispers, stretching her hand forwards, and it takes everything inside of her to not burst into tears right there and then when she hears Adora stumble backwards, away from her.

“No, I—” It sounds as if Adora could not breath, gasping for air and still pushing herself away. “Excuse me”

“Adora.” Catra´s hand closes into empty air, the earth and moss that lives around the temple empty when Adora walks away, taking all the jingle and the sweet smells with her.

Catra brings her fist back against her chest, gripping the fabric so tight it might just rip, letting herself fall over the steps of the temple with a heavy exhale. She brings her hands up and only then she realizes how badly she is trembling. She leans her face against her palms and only then she realizes she is crying.

Catra rests her forehead over the heel of her hand and closes her eyes, feeling alone inside the cavern for the very first time in many nights.



Mania. A severe state in moods, characterized by overwhelming energy, intense emotional high and, in some cases, severe lows as follow ups.

Mania, not often in relation with traumatic events but sometimes, just sometimes, hand in hand. Like an uncomfortable cousin that comes visiting once in a blue moon but that when it does it obliterates and breaks everything on its walk.

Mania, maybe not what Adora is feeling right now, but so very damn close that Adora has not other word for it than this one. Mania, manic, madness.

Mania, *μανία*. Excessive, unreasonable, abnormal. Maybe, just maybe, violent. And not her fault, but she cannot possibly comprehend that right now.

Mania, as Adora walks from side to side on the reduced space of the cave closing around her, tears painting tracks on her face and nails painting lines where she digs them across her upper arms.

Mania and pain, so much pain that Adora doesn´t know how it has not bent her in half. How is it possible that the amount of her grief has not broken her in two already and scattered over the cold ground of the gray cave like pieces of a broken statue. She cannot understand how and she doesn´t want to begin too, she just wants to end, she just wants to scream.

Adora reaches a treacherous corner of the cave and spins on her ankles again, muttering to herself the entire time. It hurts to breathe; it hurts to move and to exist, her very skin burning over her muscles and bones, acid pooling in the form of tears and strips of fabric, oh so gentle from scratch, pulling from the scalp of her cranium until she feels like fire crawling down temples and eyes.

There is beauty in this cave now, living in the moss that grows over the once empty statues like stone graveyards. Grass and dandelions and vines, green, blue, white, beautiful made, born from the soles of Catra´s feet, something Adora cannot look at right now, not past the veil of tears gathering on her poisoned eyes and falling like blood across her cheeks and mouth.

Adam, Catra had said, stumbling from her sweet mouth and between them like something dooming and rotten, *Was Adam your brother?*

Yes, gods yes. Brother, twin, blood of her blood.

He was my best friend. And thank the stars for it, that he knew her, that he cared about her. He was Adora´s best friend too.

You killed him, not from Catra´s mouth, never from Catra´s mouth but who can tell if she is not thinking it too, when it´s all Adora can think about.

You killed him, the thought is born from deep within Adora´s chest, festering and bursting open like an infected wound that floods everything that could ever be salvageable inside Adora´s soul.

You killed him, but she did. So many sweet months with Catra, walking, eating, sleeping next to her, existing next to her body, had made Adora forget that the truth, the root of her life, was that she was cursed, stained, wrong. That Adora was long doomed and rotten herself and there was no turning away from that.

She is a murderer, a killer, something *wrong,* and no matter how many days she tries pretending to be something she is noth, trying to bury it all underneath fabrics and fruits and soft hands will ever be able to erase all what she has done.

She killed Adam, she killed her own brother, a part of her heart; and today is just another painful reminder that no matter how deeply she desires, how deeply she craves and wants, she cannot allow herself to love again. Because losing Adam already broke her heart; gazing upon Catra´s beloved face and finding her made of marble and mother pearl too would destroy her completely from the inside out.

Adora is not allowed to have.

The serpents on her head can feel her, can feel the storm inside her chest and hair, twisting and turning painfully against her scalp in a violent way, pulling and pulling and pulling until Adora is sure they are going to split her head in half, finally devouring her whole with their horrendous faces and monstrous mouths.

Wrapping their strong and slick bodies around her throat and choking her until there is nothing left of the person she once was and she becomes only this, a monster locked inside a cave, trying to desperately hold herself to the last piece of beauty life has given her but staining her too all the same.

The serpents crack their jaws against her skin, biting into her head and her temples, tearing apart the ribbons that keeps them trapped until they free themselves from their imprisonment, digging their venomous fangs against her chin and the fall of her neck, falling long and heavy past her shoulder blades and towards the middle of her spine, biting everything they feel near and that they can possibly reach without caring what it is or how much pain it causes Adora in return.

Adora yelps, stopping dead on her racks across the cave, gasping when the pain is so sudden, so out of nowhere and so overwhelming that it makes her bend over her own abdomen, trying to gasp for air. Her legs are trembling violently and she would fall if it wasn´t because she digs her sharp claws over the hard marble of the broken statues, crumbling into dust below her strong touch.

The serpents pull again, reaching for Adora´s face, cradling her completely like the mock of a touch around her cheeks and biting instead, fangs like needles digging past soft flesh and muscles and holding onto her as if they were trying to punish her again. And again, and again, again.

The last fragment of sanity inside Adora´s chest snaps in half and she throws her head back, screaming at the top of her lungs.

It comes broken and *wrong* from every single place, a yell so drowned with sorrow and anger, with uncontained fury that it would have made her scared of herself if it wasn´t for the battle being played inside her heart, consuming it all into green fire that she never seems to be able to suffocate.

Adora brings her hands towards her head, catching the torn pieces of the veils and the fabrics and tearing down from them too until they are nothing but mesh and broken parts of thread that hand sand across the thick bodies of the snakes and fall around her bare feet instead.

The snakes hiss violent all around her, angry as she is too but also terrified, snapping and curling around themselves when Adora´s claws reach for them and traps them inside the death grip of her fingers, squeezing down until all Adora can feel is blindly, white and searing pain all across her head.

It travels down her neck and shoulders and it only makes her madder, hesitating for a single second before Adora turns her hands around their neck and body and dig her nails inside of them like they did with their fangs to her face, tearing down and down and *down* and screaming again when they turn the golden bodies into living tatters, hanging limp from her fingers until they snap awake again and fix themselves, over and over and over again.

Blood starts pooling inside Adora´s hands, overflowing from her palms where she keeps butchering them apart and falling like the mock of the waterfall across her temples and her chin.

It´s not red, because not even this piece of humanity was allowed for Adora to remain. Instead it's golden, godly poisoned, mortality defiled; instead of iron it's gold but it's also acid for Adora's soul and it feels like it boils her skin even if no real wound comes.

Adora feels all of it, every single second to the very deep of her body until the serpent's bodies give away to her own scalp and she too tears from it, hoping somewhere inside her chest that she will either shred them all from root or that she will bleed then dry all over the moss covered floor.

Stones are digging below Adora´s soles, splitting calluses and making her bleed and hiss in pain, hisses that echo on the mouths of the blind snakes, lashing against her when their pain

becomes hers.

Adora stumbles backwards and that's when she feels them, sharp and slicing, painful no matter how many years have gone by since Adora tore the apart and tried to bury them on the dirt; the broken pieces of the iron mask that had been placed around her face like a prison from the hand of the people she loved.

Something breaks very deep within Adora and she doesn´t actually realize what is happening until she is in the middle of it.

Pieces of stone are scrambling on the cave´s floor, sharp and misshapen, broken, destroyed by her own hand when she wraps her fingers around the limbs of the statues and drags her claws against their stone surface instead of her own skin.

She breaks, she destroys, she tears into pieces every single statue of men, woman or folk that has wandered inside this place trying to seek for her head. She screams the entire time, tearing apart her own throat with the amount of grief gathered inside her chest; until it echoes in every single corner of the cave and makes the very ceiling shake, threatening to fall over her and bury her whole.

And she bleeds. She bleeds all over the floor, all over the broken statues and columns, all over the green moss, she bleeds. It falls across her face and mouth, it pools on her lips and it stains over her hands, leaving handprints behind her destruction, golden and warm.

Adora cannot feel them at all, to drown out inside her own rage to feel their suffering on her skin; and maybe, just maybe, they will be able to choke her out too.

Hands find her among the anger, searching for her among the destruction and the shadows, seizing whatever place of her body they can. Fingers, long and soft, cold unlike Adora´s grief; they hold themselves to her wrists and the side of her neck, fighting the tendrils of Adora´s mania with choked out pleas.

“...dora, Adora!” Catra begs, choking around a sob when Adora fights her off violently, smudging golden blood all over her arms and clothes too. “Adora, you're hurting yourself!”

“Take them off!” Adora howls, snapping her hands away from Catra´s with so much force that the latter almost falls into her knees. Adora brings them towards the serpents crawling bloodied and wounded over her head instead, holding them in a bloodied fistful and tearing off their bodies until she can hear them rip and she screams in pain. “Take them off! Catra, please! Take them off. Take them off!”

“Stop.” Catra is sobbing next to her, rushing to her feet as fast as she can, batling Adora´s violent hold with her own hands, “Stop, Adora! Adora, please. Stop, stop!”

Adora shreds the snakes into pieces, feels them come back into place beneath her fingertips, slips down with her own blood as the pain makes her angrier and dizzy and it threatens to make her pass out.

Catra follows Adora´s hands, finds her fingers gripping the bodies of the snakes and holds them too. The serpents shiver around her touch, snapping and curling around Catra´s wrists and fingers, traveling down the length of her arms and wrapping around her neck and face, seeking for her blind eyes and the fall of her mouth.

Adora screams when she realizes this, the horror, Catra feeling the bleeding serpents, acid on her soft skin too, and she lets go of them just so she can push Catra away from her, cringing in desperate desolation.

Catra trips and falls on her back, hissing when the rocks dig on her soles and when the broken iron pinches on her palms, and it makes Adora scream again, so full of rage that when she tears at the snakes´ bodies again she thinks they might as well rip her scalp clean off her cranium, biting viciously at her every time she hurts them.

“Adora, no,” Catra chokes, fighting to come back to her feet, blind to the horror Adora is doing of herself but listening to it all, to the very last part, she hears it all. “Adora!”

“I am in pain all the time!" Adora screams, slamming the heel of her hands against her temples over and over again until her sight swims with white sparks. "The snakes, the— they — they burn. They are poisonous and they burn and it hurts, Catra, it hurts!"

Catra has found her balance again, flinching in front of Adora when the ground scattered in broken stone gives away a little bit under her weight. Adora watches through tears as Catra clenches her jaw and throws herself completely forwards, catching Adora´s convulsing body inside her arms.

Adora gives a drowned yell, shaking herself and Catra in a weaker attempt to shake her off but Catra holds herself to Adora with all her strength, running her arms over Adora´s upper arms and pressing against the middle of her spine, an embrace meant to keep Adora from crumbling into pieces too.

“I'm sorry. I'm so sorry Adora.” Catra sobs next to Adora´s ear, her voice painfully calm in comparison to Adora´s screams. “It's alright—”

“It is not! Don´t you get it?! It will never be alright!” Adora pushes Catra´s chest but Catra does not let go, not even a single inch. “Look what they turned me into! What I´ve become! I ´m a murderer, I murdered all these people! I murdered my own brother! My— I murdered him, I killed him, Catra, I killed him.”

Adora dissolves into a fit of sobs, her words losing their coherence but not their meaning. Adora hiccups around them and breaks, whimpering loud and broken as their weight crushes her down little by little and then all at once.

Catra catches her when she falls, lowering both of their bodies to the ground covered with stone and torn moss, their knees connecting painfully with each other over the torn fabrics of their tunics.

“It doesn't matter, Adora, it doesn't matter to me.” Catra is saying to Adora´s ear, over and over again like a hymn, like a chant, like a promise Adora doesn´t dare to hold onto because

the breakthrough will actually kill her. But gods, she wants. “I´m here, I´m here now. You are going to be alright, I´m not letting you down, alright?”

“Take them off, please,” Adora cries, wrecking her entire body like convulsions, like thunder bolts. “Help me. Catra, help me.”

Adora cannot hold it inside herself anymore and she doesn´t. So she let´s go.

Her sobs break past her ribcage and across her lips and explode in the charged air between them, filling the cave with another kind of screams. Softer, so much more heartbreaking, born from a kind of pain that will never be able to heal, not completely, and that will slowly eat Adora from the inside out if she doesn´t let go of it.

Adora cries, she cries and cries and doesn´t stop for a single second, a single minute, whimpers and tears bursting from her horrendous face like star explosions, falling against Catra´s skin and body as the latter holds her so tightly against her own chest that the hold steals the breath off Adora´s lungs more than the sobs do, absorbing, accepting it, guarding it all too when Adora cannot keep it quiet anymore.

Catra is crying too, quietly, almost invisible but Adora can feel her, cool tears tumbling from her eyes and splashing against the bare skin of Adora´s shoulders, covering her molted and bruised skin with her pearl-like tears, soothing something painful even though they are born from pain too.

Adora hiccups and gasps for air, and she hates herself just a little bit more for seeking Catra´s touch even though Adora is hurting her too, but she cannot avoid it nor fight it.

Adora´s forearms are pressed against her own chest, held in place between her and Catra as the latter holds her close.And it should feel oppressive, overwhelming, like being imprisoned again except it doesn´t, so Adora let´s her hands unroll from the tight fists she has wrapped them into and allows instead to rest the, against Catra´s neck and her chin, silently seeking for her even though Catra could push her away any second now.

Except that Catra doesn´t. She relaxes all around Adora, still holding her close and guides Adora´s tall and broken body towards her, torn clothes and bloodied knuckles and all, letting Adora´s weight fall completely against her when she softly guides Adora closer and tucks her head on the angle between her shoulder and her chin.

A secret space with which Adora has only been able to dream about, nestling her in soft skin and warmth, not caring for the bleeding serpents that twist and curl too around Catra´s neck and collarbones, seeking avidly and sad for her as they are a part of Adora too.

They remain like this for a long, long time. So long that the night gives way to the down and the colors inside the cavern change completely, from the darkest of blues to the most tender of pinks, slipping inside the warm cave from the single corridor that leads to the outside.

Adora watches the change of light through narrowed eyes, her cheek still damp and just a little bit sticky resting against Catra´s pulse point.

They both look battle worn, sweat sticking to their faces and soiling their skins with dirt and drying golden blood. Catra´s hair is messed up, knotted in places where Adora has run her own fingers over and over again trying to soothe herself from the pain. Her skin is cold still but her back is slightly bent now that many hours have gone by and she still refuses to let go from Adora´s frame, wrapping both of her arms tight and sure around Adora´s waist.

Adora feels disgusting, covered in her own tears and in her own blood, her clothes wrinkled around her knees and legs and hanging loose from her shoulders. The blue fabric is spotted in mud and dirt, broken traces of stone tearing the fabric in several pieces around the hem of her skirt.

She sighs, nuzzling her face softly against the column of Catra´s neck, even when the serpents brush against the angle of her jaw and chin. She feels pain everywhere, from her scalp to her very nails, overwhelming and deep, unable to be pulled from the root, so she just lays here, between the floor and Catra´s arms, her own hands brushing limp against the ground.

"I am so tired," Adora whispers against Catra´s skin, letting her eyes fall closed and exhausted.

Catra moves around her, her hands scooting very softly from the small of Adora´s waist to the back of Adora´s neck, drawing invisible circles with her fingertips.

Adora holds her breath, feeling the bodies of the snakes moving heavy and slick around her shoulders and back, free from their confinements for the first time in a long time. Adora feels as Catra´s hand moves just a little bit higher, feeling the length of the snakes with the pads of her fingers, raising goosebumps across her entire body.

"Are they dead?" Adora whispers, flinching at the sparks of pain that cross the sore tissue of her throat.

"No." Catra shakes her head gently next to her, circling the head of one of the serpents with a gentle finger. "Just wounded"

"Don't let them bite you."

"They won't."

Unlike Adora´s voice, Catra´s is much softer, clogged with emotions but calmer, palpably heavy with the strength with which she holds herself from bursting into something much sadder for Adora´s sake alone.

The thought makes Adora cringe again inside her own skin but Catra doesn´t allow her to go further away. Now the worst of it has happened, Adora´s mind starts to comprehend just how deeply the weight of what happened last night means between both of them.

Now Catra knows the true length of Adora´s monstrosity; now she knows everything she did and everything she had to do to survive and what it meant to do so in the first place. It´s a

painful and cold reminder, a shake to reality about who exactly has been sharing Catra´s bed all these nights

But it feels … different. Being held like this does not feel good, with her clothes ripped and her face soiled, with the serpents born from her hair loose and wrapping around Catra´s body. But being held through it inside Catra´s hands feels soothing, as if her touch alone was the only thing that could possibly ease the searing pain inside of her.

“Can I hold you?” Catra asks in the thread of a voice, as if she wasn´t already pressed as tight as possible to her.

Adora tenses immediately, her entire body locking into a terrified shiver before all of that also gets loose, too exhausted to be anything else than this, a tired woman in the arms of a beautiful one. “Yes”

Catra´s hands move from Adora´s jaw and slowly, very slowly, start to comb their way inside the bodies of the snakes, past wounds and bloods and al across their golden and turquoise scales, gathering them around her fingers and palms like spoonfuls of light that she brings towards her chest.

The snakes seem to breathe life again under her touch, staring and circling her elegant wrists, finding her among the shadows of the cave with their blind eyes like hers. And a part of Adora wonders suddenly if she could ever learn to love their sightless faces as much as she adores Catra's eyes.

The golden bodies stir and stretch to all places, finding their way in the dark and accidentally bumping Catra's beautiful face with their blind head, making her gasp with surprise.

Adora jolts back immediately but Catra only giggles. And when Adora looks at her face through hooded eyelashes she doesn't find horror or disgust but plain wonder, written in every single plane of her face for Adora to see.

“What?”

“They tickle,” Catra whispers, laughing again when one of the heads bonks softly against her cheekbones, nuzzling its aching body against her.

Adora stares at her openly for a couple of minutes, feeling both acid and sweetness pool down her throat.

She is so beautiful, how can she ever be so beautiful while holding Adora's bothered body in her hands? And she came, *she came for Adora,* she heard the destruction and she came anyway, past paths she cannot see and broken pieces of stone, she came.

“How can they not… repulse you?” Adora asks out loud, unable to stop herself from dripping the venom she feels for the snakes, for her own body. “How can you not be repulsed by me?”

Catra hums, still working the snakes but calmer, her head tilting to the side towards the place where she hears Adora's voice coming.

Her eyes are slightly open, eyelashes stuck in dark chunks where the tears have matted them together, the rim of her eyelids deeply red and her back pale but still as calm as possible. A quiet ocean where Adora finds herself impossible to drown.

They are still tangled together over the cold ground but Adora has managed a more sitting position, pushing inches between both of them that make Catra's pretty mouth turn into a grimace.

Catra drops her hands into her lap, breathing slowly through her mouth. The simple gesture makes Adora's heartbeat speed, hammering painfully inside her chest, almost as painful as the pulsing wounds on her head, rushing with the fear of expected rejection.

“Give me your hands.” Catra says simply, ripping Adora away from her thoughts.

Adora blinks, chunks of years falling from her eyes, confused. “What?”

“Come on, give me your hands,” Catra coos her forwards, extending her own hands in front of her, palm up, patiently waiting for Adora.

It takes her a moment but Adora complies. She raises her shivering hands and lets them fall hesitantly over Catra's, palm to palm, trembling so bad she can see how it makes Catra tremble too. Adora can see the skin of her own wrists and forearms, already molting with bruises and golden bloodied scratches and it makes Adora cringe with shame,

Catra, however, laces their fingers together immediately, turning Adora's hands inside hers. She carefully and very, very gently starts feeling them from heel to tip, past the shallow wounds to the shivering skin, learning them all over again.

‘You have strong hands,” Catra murmurs, her squeaky voice rising an octave. “Thin fingers”

Catra´s voice echoes inside the once again quiet cave and Adora flushes, wounds and all, staring with her eyes wide open as Catra runs the pads of her fingers across the divots of Adora´s palms, feeling them so gently it feels like petals caressing her skin.

“There are calluses here over the mount and the heel of your palms. They are wide but shallow, which tells me you are a trained warrior and you used to wear leather.” Catra grins to herself, like learning a secret Adora doesn't know. “And here, on your thumb and the middle of your fingers. You are a lyre player but you haven't done it in years.”

Adora holds her breath, cursed to deadly eyes but unable to look away.

“And these ones? On your fingertips? These are from the loom and they are fairly new.” Catra presses her own fingertips against Adora´s, calluses mirroring and meeting. “I know them because my mother had the same ones and so do I.”

Catra brings Adora´s hands towards her face and kisses her palms, cupping Adora´s hands with hers and lacing their fingers together.

“Adora, should I hate your hands?” Catra asks against her skin, her soft hair brushing Adora ´s wrists.

Adora blinks, her heart stopping on its tracks. “What?”

“Should I be afraid of your hands?”

“I— No,” Adora wets her mouth, tears gathering on her lips. “No, I guess no”

“No, you know why?” Catra smiles again and this time is all for Adora. “Because they are an extension of you, Adora. They are a part of you, they tell a story about you.”

She brings one of Adora´s hands towards her face, resting her cheek against her open palm. “So how could I ever hate them? When they are also a part of who you are?” She whispers and Adora knows she is not talking about her hands at all.

Adora sobs silently, too worn out to cry out loud anymore but still exhausted to the bone. Catra lets go of Adora´s hands only so she can search for her shoulders instead, bringing her into a careful embrace.

“You are… dumb”

Adora snorts, wet and surprised. “What?”

“You are dumb” Catra repeats, resting her lips over Adora's temple. “Because, you are the most wonderful person I have ever met. You're a complete knucklehead. You are stubborn and stupidly brave. You're kind and caring, you are so smart and wise. And you don't even know that. So you're dumb”

“They made me a monster” Adora whispers, hiccuping around a sob. “I am a monster”

“Maybe” Catra dips her nose over the angle of Adora's cheekbone, barely a kiss, all of a caress. “I've known plenty of monsters, Adora. And none of them had snakes as hair. None of them tore themselves to pieces for the fear of hurting someone else”

Adora whimpers, crying all over Catra´s arms again. Catra holds her through it and she never flinches, not even once when the snakes wrap around her entire face and hold themselves to her, not when their warm bodies rest above her ears and temples, not ever. She is heartbroken for Adora but she is not afraid of them.

“If you're a monster, Adora, then, by all means, so be it,” Catra whispers and it feels like a vow. “I'd rather be by your side than the ones that call themselves heroes.”

Adora trembles, tears falling over and over again across her cheeks without being able to stop them, but she still nods, allowing for the first time since Adam died to be held like this, over the ground and wounded but safe.

More hours pass them by, or maybe that is just Adora´s perception of time because the light around them has turned just a little bit more golden, cradling Catra´s head like a halo.

Now that the worst has passed Adora can truly feel how much pain her body really is in, pulsing across all of her limbs where the pieces of sharp marble broken bloodied lines on her skin. But the worst of it is definitely around her head, her scalp itching and burning with a

pain so searing that her sight swims a little with dizziness, both by the wounds she caused herself to the serpents and her skin and by their poison, fixing their bodies as they curl almost apologetic against Adora´s nape.

“Can I wash them?” Catra asks suddenly, her voice kind next to the ring inside Adora´s ears.

“Uh?”

“Your head.” Catra cups the snakes, marveled by them as if they weren´t monstrous on themselves. “Can I wash them?”

“I—” Adora chokes on her own breath, taken aback. Why would Catra want to get near them at all? To be gentle to them when they make Adora this?

“When I was younger and I was losing my sight, my head hurt so much. My mother used to wash my head with warm water. It helped.” She sounds so nervous, Adora can hear it now, fidgeting nervously on her knees. “I know it's hardly the same but— maybe it could help”

Adora blinks around the receding darkness, feeling dry blood clotting on the sides of her face and the snakes, wearing her down with their weight, making her sad. Catra has heard and felt the worst now, and she is still here, she didn´t run away. Maybe Adora can allow herself this, for a moment, being looked after for one second only.

“Alright”

Catra helps her on her feet around the treacherous ground, guiding her across the cave and back to the corridor that leads to their makeshift home. She trips several times, unfamiliar con the destruction of the statues and unaided by the lack of her cane, but Adora tries to be there every single time, holding tight to each other as they find together the entrance and slip inside.

The temperature of the cavern is so much different from the cave that it takes Adora a little bit aback, the gentle warmth replacing the boiling heat that had been burning Adora alive all these hours.

Adora sniffs, her sight exhausted and heavy as she lets Catra guide her by the side of the lake, finding a proper patch on the ground for them to sit into.

Adora sits into the soft moss, legs extended in front of her, letting her see the true extension of her anger against herself. Catra tilts her head softly behind, resting it against her palm and tall rock covered in moss and grass that feels soft to the touch. Adora can feel her fingers gently caressing the surface of the snakes, feeling their worn out bodies one by one.

Adora sees through narrowed eyes as Catra leans towards the lake and gathers water inside an empty shell held inside her hand, raising it back towards the place where she knows Adora´s head lies.

Catra lets the cool water fall over Adora´s head, little by little, allowing her to get used to the feeling and stopping by seconds when the pain is too intense and Adora can´t suppress a

hiss.

It's long, tedious maybe but Catra does it with all the patience of the world, going through every single snake and the patches of Adora´s scalp that the latter feels herself growing loose and sleepy under her touch and the water.

Catra washes away the blood and the venom, leaving only behind droplets of water sticking to the shimmering scales. She caresses their heads when they turn towards her and then caresses Adora´s cheekbones when she feels her grow a little bit restless, never going further across her face than this.

It helps, the ache is still there and it probably will never go away, it's a part of Adora´s life now, like a sickness, chronic and unfixable. But it helps.

“There,” Catra whispers after a while, once she has felt Adora´s body go completely relaxed around her hands. “No more blood”

She gently moves Adora´s head, not caring if it is still dripping water everywhere or when Adora points out, resting it over her lap instead of the moss. The water soaks into the fabric of her tunic immediately but Catra doesn´t move away, gathering Adora fully inside her arms instead.

Her head is tilted down, towards Adora, and even if she can´t see Adora, Catra´s eyes are left open, the silver and white in them swirling like clouds in the sky.

Not for the first time, Adora wonders what exactly Catra perceives about her beneath her irises. Now that Catra knows the true extension of Adora´s curse, of what it has done to her body, what does Catra think when she tilts her head towards Adora? What does she feel?

“He was in love.” Catra murmurs, her gentle words squeezing Adora´s heart. “Adam”

Adora takes a sharp and shivering breath, curling around herself in Catra´s lap. Catra brings her infinitesimally closer, running the tip of her finger across the middle of Adora´s forehead and down the straight bridge of her nose, over and over again.

“Really?” Adora asks in a whisper, almost not even a sound at all by the way it breaks in the middle. Catra nods with a tiny smile but the corners of her eyes pull down softly.

“Her name is Teela and she is everything you could have thought Adam would fall in love with.” Catra raises her hand from Adora´s face, wiggling her fingers through the snakes. “Strong, intelligent. Taller than him”

Adora chuckles, choking with tears. She can almost see it, right beneath her eyelids, Adam and his face so much like her own, happy and alive.

“Did he tell you?”

“We didn't have time.” Adora whispers, a sharp spark of pain crosses Adora´s chest, threatening to tear her heart into shreds. “Did she—?”

“She endured it.” Catra wrinkles her nose, fighting her own tears and Adora doesn't even realize Catra is crying *for* Adora, not because of her. “She mourned him like a wife and she endured it. She came to live at my house for months after he left Menagerie. She became like a sister too.”

Adora closes her eyes tightly, letting the heavy tears roll down her cheeks, losing themselves across the fall of her temples and the roots of her head. The gold serpents move very softly around her head, careful as they are still in pain and scared of Adora — as Adora is still scared of herself. But they curl around her cheeks anyway, soothing her and this time Adora doesn´t reject them. She lets them be.

Catra´s hand finds her among the inner darkness, washed up by her own kind of light when she cradles Adora´s damp chin inside her palm, tilting her face towards her. When Adora opens her eyes again she meets Catra´s right above her, golden against silver.

“There is a child, Adora.” Catra whispers and it feels like a newborn star all of its own. “A daughter”

There is silence inside Adora´s mind, out of sudden everything is quiet. The echo of her own screams and the screams of her people the day she became a monster; the yells of her parents and her own peas to the gods when she was forsaken inside this place, all fall quiet, listening only to Catra´s voice.

“Her name is Ariadne. She must be six by now.” Catra hiccups a little, overwhelmed too by her own words. “When Teela came to the house she was pregnant. I— I helped Teela bring her into this world, I held her over my chest too.”

Catra takes Adora´s aching fingers and brings them towards her chest, right above the point of fabric and skin where her heart beats the strongest.

Catra smells beautifully today, like light. Adora wonders if some of it sipped into the scent of a baby niece Adora didn´t get to meet.

She hopes it did, there wouldn´t be a better blessing for that child than a little bit of the light from someone Adora adores.

“I—”

“They are safe.” Catra reassures her immediately, feeling the fear slipping inside Adora´s bones. “Teela took her to the mountains when she was still a baby. Alongside most of the women from my village. They are on the territory of Artemis, under the veils of her Priestesses. They are safe.”

Adora breaks again and she wonders how many times she can shatter before there is nothing left from her.

She rolls on her side and curls against Catra´s middle, burying her face against her belly while she cries. The sobs wreck her body again but she lets them be because Catra´s hands are not judging but kind. Even though she also lost so much, she is still kind.

“He lives in her, Adora. Teela said they were so similar and they smell the same.” There is a shadow of regret in her voice, painting her words with grief. “I´d like to say that if I had known I would have told you from the very beginning. But when I figured it out— I guess I was scared, it was selfish of me and I didn´t want to hurt you more so I didn´t say anything for a while. But you deserve to know, you deserve to know about the people that truly love you, Adora. I can only offer you this now, not all was lost”

Adora can still see him, the last gaze of him that she can remember, kneeling on the floor of their palace with his face tilted towards hers and forever casted in marble. With his gentle smile, no matter how scared he truly was, telling Adora that everything would be alright.

She can still see him in her memory, so small she doesn´t even know if it's a real memory at all, shared crib and holding hands. As a toddler with messed up hair and tooth gaps, so much like each other that everyone would confuse the princess with the prince and the way around.

Young like her, with the weight of the world on his shoulders, telling Adora that she would take her away, that he had found a safe place. A safe place with Catra, who is and would become the half of Adora´s soul in any way. And Adora wonders if Adam, somehow, knew that too.

It was all so close to Adora´s grip, so close yet so far away, slipping from her reach by greed.

“I murdered him.” Adora sobs against Catra´s arms, clinging into her when Catra holds her with so much more strength. “I looked at him and he turned into stone. He was the first, his death is on me”

“It was an accident.” Catra says, her voice firm, still gentle, but anchoring Adora to the now, which is exactly what Adora needs right now. “He loved you more than anything. That was one of the only things I was always sure about him. He loved his sister and he knew you loved him in return. It was enough, you were enough.”

“I was not,” Adora mourns, pressing her face flush against Catra´s body, hoping somehow it will make her fuse with her fabric, that it will make her whole again. “I changed, I got— I got cursed. I got hated so quickly. And the only person who loved me died by my own hand. My parents— my parents hated me for it. I hated myself, Catra. I don´t know how to make it better. I don´t know if I can.”

Adora takes a shivering breath, still gasping for air. She can see herself too, inside her mind. She can still remember the person she was, a princess yes but so much more. She was once a friend, a colleague, a sister. A daughter. A person, just that.

She can remember her own face, her blue eyes and blonde hair. The sun makeup she used to wear over her cheeks and chin, red paint that she used to find joy into. The amount of freckles and moles over her shoulders and the arch of her own soles. The wide of her hips and the small of her waist and the swell of her own breasts. Her skin, her mouth, her nails.

Her body, *hers* , nobody else's´s. Something Adora has not seen in more than five years, ashamed of what she is going to see in the copper reflection, afraid of what she was turned into that night in the palace.

As if she could hear Adora´s thoughts, Catra is there for her too. She can see Adora too, in a completely different way. In the way Adora needs right now. She understands, she knows.

“Adora,” Catra calls for her, resting her lips against Adora´s weeping shoulders. “What happened to you was not your fault”

“But—”

“It was not, Adora. You were barely more than a child.” Catra sniffles against her skin, finding her hand and holding it tight. “The people around were supposed to protect you. And whatever happened after, was not your fault either. You did what you needed to survive. None of it makes you a monster, none of it ever will.”

The sobs are almost uncontrollable now, yet again, filling this time the space inside their cavern. Theirs, a space they have made their own; a place that once was Adora´s prison but that has slowly become a home by the hand of Catra and her own.

Adora allows herself to cry. She allows herself to let it all out, pour it in the space between them like rain and out of her body, and with it some of the poison leaves too, just a little but just enough too.

It´s not complete, and it´s not all, but it´s a first. A tiny, small, almost insignificantly first. It might actually change Adora´s entire life.

“You are not spoiled or rotten or stained. You are alive and you are a miracle, Adora.” Catra whispers to her ears, wrapping her entire being around Adora´s and not letting go, not even once. “I don´t blame you and neither does he. I´m just grateful, I´m grateful I met Adam, Adora, so I could give you this. I´m grateful he guided me to you because you are a gift.”

Adora wraps her arms around Catra´s narrow waist too and anchors herself to her, letting the warmth of her body replace the boiling heat of her hatred for herself.

“I will tell you everything about them, Adora, I promise.”

The grief will never leave, it will always be right there, living next to Adora´s chest, but for the first time she thinks she will be able to live with it, to grow around it, to become better not because of it but in honor of it. Of Adam, of his family, of the people that loved her.

When Catra leans down and rests her cold lips over the bodies of the snakes, Adora thinks she might just be able to grow to love this too, to love herself. Because whatever Catra cares about must be holy, and Catra cares about Adora, so there must still be something good inside of her.

Maybe Adora will be able to learn to see it and love it too, one day.

“You don´t have to hide anymore, you know?” Catra murmurs, and Adora knows she means the serpents and the veils. The coin bracelets and the space between their bed. “We can look out for each other.”Catra´s face wrinkles after a moment, making sense of her own works with a grimace. “Oh, well—”

“I got it,” Adora nods, chuckling wet and devastated still. She digs her fingers on the divots of Catra´s hips and holds her body against hers, and silently begs for this single moment where incurable pain meets gentleness to never end. “Stay with me a little longer?”

“Yes.” Catra whispers, and the serpents kiss their way all over her face. “Always”



They don´t eat or bathe. Somewhere in Catra´s mind it occurs to her that they should, that she should sit Adora down and feed her hot stew because she might fall sick otherwise.

But the thing is that they are exhausted to the bone, both of them. They have been awake for over twenty fours hours now and their bodies are sore and worn out. Adora´s body is frail right now, battered by her own hands and nails and loose with exhaustion inside Catra´s hands.

So, the best thing Catra thinks she can do right now is this, hand Adora one a pair of her night chitons for both to change into and pull her with her inside the bed, resting their bodies on the soft blankets and on the familiar bark of the olive tree, heavy smelling with wisterias all around them.

The truth is, Catra is devastated. She will never be able to pull this pain out of her chest because she doesn´t know if she will ever be able to make it easier for Adora either.

The truth is that Catra is scared. Scared for the amount of grief inside Adora's heart. Out of all things, the serpents cradling Catra's wrists and wrapping around Catra's hair are not what scare her at all.

Deep within herself Catra mourns the fact that she knows she will never be able to truly comprehend the extension of what Adora has gone through, of her pain and her grief. She can ´t even begin to imagine it because their lives up to this point where so different, and as much as she wants to say she is able to stand on her shoes and comprehend, the reality is that the kind of pain and betrayal Adora has experienced cannot be put into words or described, and it shouldn´t be tried to, not if Adora doesn´t want to.

In a way, Catra thinks it´s a little bit like describing blindness to someone that knows the colors of the world. It could not be further apart from each other, but it's the only way Catra has to compare it, the only way she can feel like she is enough to be able to soothe Adora´s grief.

But this is not about Catra right now, none of it is. And the best thing she can think to do is hold Adora and let her know that she is right here, that she will not leave. That Adora is neither a monster nor destined for tragedy.

No matter how many years it takes Catra, she will fight every day to make Adora learn that, over and over again until Adora doesn´t need her anymore and even then Catra will be there. Adora doesn´t need Catra´s rage right now, anger towards the people that have done this to her, her heart; she needs the gentleness, the reassurance she was stripped off long ago.

It´s the only thing Catra can do, and it's the least of things that Adora deserves, because she is worthy of the whole world and the stars she so much love to study, cupped in her hands for her to rest and heal.

Catra climbs inside the bed and Adora follows her behind, their bare feet knocking together softly when they lay on their backs. Catra remains very still but she feels Adora moving around, restless until she finally lays quiet too and Catra can feel the arch of her back brushing against her own forearm.

They remain very quiet for a long moment, so long that Catra actually might have thought Adora has fallen asleep if it wasn´t for the cadence of her breath, still quick and alert next to her.

“Catra?” Adora asks for, her voice sore.

“Hmm?” Catra rolls on her side, facing Adora´s back but still inches away.

“Do you know—?” Adora stops herself, taking a shivering breath before continuing. “Do you know what happened to them? To the kings of Eternia? To— to my parents?”

Catra holds her breath, her heart speeding up. She thinks about it for a second and then —

“No.” Catra bites into her tongue until she tastes copper, hating herself. “I'm sorry, I never heard anything in the village.”

“Oh.” Even among the shadows of the temple, Catra can perceive the disappointment in Adora´s voice, the mingled relief too; as if Adora didn´t even know what she was supposed to feel about it. As if whatever it was, Catra´s words were able to calm the ache for now. “I guess at least they are alright”

Catra narrows her eyes, the shadows and lights of the temple playing tricks on her sightless scleras. She rests her palm over what she thinks is the middle of Adora's spine, feeling her ribcage rise and fall with every deep breath.

Adora brings her hand back, finding Catra's wrist and bringing it forward, placing it against her chest instead.

Catra curls over Adora's strong back immediately, tangling their fingers together into a tight grip and pressing them right above the home of Adora's heart.

The last of the distance has been severed, so Catra holds her.

“Good night Catra,” Adora whispers, her breath even out and her mind slipping into dreamless sleep.

Catra narrows her eyes, letting cold tears fall down her sides. “Good night Adora.”

It is said that King Randor became mad.

That he talked with the gods and when the gods stopped answering that he talked with the spirits, with dark entities pulled from the very Tartarus, filling his ears with lies and with poison.

It is said he was filled with grief for the death of his son, but it is known that he was overwhelmed by guilt for the missing of his daughter, his only one, the star of his eyes.

It is said that he would wander the palace and the temples. *My daughter,* he would mourn, *What have you done with my daughter?* he would ask. *What have I done to her?*

It is said that this is why he threw himself from the highest tower of the Grayskull Palace, his skull fractured against the floor below. It is rumored that the gods taunted him to jump. Retribution for turning his eyes away.

It is said that Queen Malena lost herself after that. That her green robes, once so white, were dyed with the red of sacrificial blood and wine.

That she would mumble, to herself and everybody that would cross her way, whispers of the gods, visions of the fall and carnage that had brought to her own home, chasing her and turning her insane, all of them truth but that nobody would ever believe.

It is said that she would scream in pain, dig her fingers inside her face and tear off it, rip it apart with the burn of an invisible iron mask seared to her skull. A phantom of what she had once done to her own blood. Cursed by her own hand.

It is said that her increasing demands were so incoherent that sooner or later she needed to be disposed of. Nobody says that it was cruel, unnecessary cruel the way it was done, when Emperor Prime beheaded her on the public square and her head was placed on a stick on the entrance of the god's palace.

But these are things Catra knows and doesn't say. These are things she does lie about, things she hides in the depth of her heart.

Catra does not say it, she can't. It would destroy Adora. And Catra? Well.

Catra loves her.

Leave me to the trees and air, I'd rather that the feast was theirs

They can't reserve neighboring plots or buy cuttings of my priceless locks

Leave me for two days or three, 'til my fingerprints turn green

For the first time since I drew breath, I'm undesirable again

— *Last woman on earth,* **Paris Paloma**

Chapter End Notes

They are going to kiss in the next chapter ;)

Verse VIII

Chapter Summary

"It´s enough, it should be enough.

But they are back on the beginning again, incapable of reaching for each other no matter how badly they want."

Chapter Notes

tapping my feet and giggling

I´m not going to entretain you a lot here today. I know why you are here, you know too. Please go ahead.

Also, trust me on this ;)

Special mention and thanks today to Book Smyth ;)) (thank you so much for your support)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse VIII.

Marigolds

Buried in the fields under the marigolds (*La flor de la vida*)

Lie our footprints marked beneath the dirt (*Guarda recuerdos*)

We'd pick fruit from the lemon trees

Or cut off the branches, set fire to the earth

If you would've told me it'd be the last time

I'd have carried, it's worth

— *Marigolds,* **Andrea Bejar**

“Mom”

“Yes, my dear?”

“Tell me about her again?”

The flame of the candle burns golden when touched by fire, lightening the small but beautiful chamber in multi-colored shadows. Outside the temple the wounds of waterfalls and quiet running water is calming, a kind of lullaby only meant for the woman living safely inside this planes of the woods where the mosaics of the floor do not touch the ground and the clouds of the sky swirl around their ankles instead of over their heads.

The mother sits on the edge of the coat, right next to her daughter, her auburn hair held with rings of gold around her temples and forehead; her green eyes like olive leaves, kind and gentle under the night of the candle.

She is tall and strong and smart, a beautiful woman who was already magnificent before the rest of her life unfolded in front of her, before the war and the men and the blood. Before she had to run away from her home to save her honor and her child.

She is a lot of things, a warrior, a merchant, an artisant. A friend, a lover, she was a daughter too once. She was a sister and then she became a Priestess because under the eyes of the goddess she became holy for protecting the women around her.

Tonight, she is a woman, protected by the silver lining of Artemis' bow and arrow, sheltered with others inside her virginity and her strength. Tonight Teela is a mother, taking the young hands of her daughter inside of hers and looking at her eyes, ever so alive.

Unlike Teela, Ariadne´s irises are blue, so blue that under certain lights they look like powdered silver, shimmering inside the almond shaped home of her eyes until they look like moon rivers. Her young skin is scattered with moles and sun freckles and her baby teeth are slightly chipped, the tooth gap in the middle that gives away just how young she truly is, filling her mother´s heart with tenderness.

Unlike Teela, her hair is not auburn but spilled gold, soft, long, falling in waves around her face and neck. It crowns her head, gentle like wheat but royal all the same.

A giveaway of an inheritance Ariadne does not know about, of high walls and thrones of golden. A mirror of the people that loved her, that were her family, the only thing that truly matters, especially now.

“What do you want to know?”

“What was she like?”

Ariadne hums, looking through the open wall of the chamber. The sky here is blue, the bluest Tella has ever seen it, swirling around stars. Beyond the mountains of the Deer Lady though,

the sky is bleeding red, violet and violent.

“Adventurous,” Teela whispers after a second, turning to look at her child with a smile in her mouth. “A little bit mischievous too.”

“Really?” Ariadne beams, her young face splitting with wander. She looks so much like her father. She looks like Teela too, in certain lights, but she is all of her father. She is all of her aunt too.

“Really,” Teela leans towards her, booping the tip of her nose with her finger. “Your father used to say she planned the best kind of pranks on their home when they were children. And she would always help him sneak out of their home to play on the seaside.”

Ariadne giggles, tucking deeper into her blanket. She is six but still just barely more than a baby. Teela still remembers the way she used to cradle herself against her chest, or the way her legs would scrunch when Teela would pick her up from her wheat crib and hold her over her neck.

She was barely a baby so little ago, how quickly have the years gone by. If Teela closes her eyes, she can still remember the smells of their old home, the sounds of Menagerie, all so familiar and kind. If Teela remembers just a little bit deeper, she can still recall C´yra´s home, where Ariadne was born, her calm face and helping hands.

If Teela looks at her daughter just a little bit longer, she can see Adam in her, living in the strands of her hair and the pale blue of her eyes. There he is.

There must be his sister too.

“Now that I think about it, she was a lot like you,” Teela whispers around a knot on her throat, caressing the bridge of her daughter´s nose.

Ariadne smiles but there is a certain edge of sudden sadness in her young face, a foreign kind of sorrow that Teela never wished for her to know.

“I wish I had met her,” Ariadne whispers, only a secret between her and her mother, a feeling not only meant for her aunt but also for her father, only for them to keep.

Even at this young age, there are many things that Ariadne doesn't say,and maybe that's something she shares with Adam and his sister.

“Me too”

The world is changing. The gods on their pedestal thrones have grown worn out of fighting each other, so they have turned against the world below their castles instead. There are few, like their Lady of the Hunt, that still care for humans or maybe for just some of them.

Sometimes, Teela catches sight of an owl or a dove, flying across the tall trees of their woods, visiting the branches and roots where the deer–like figure of her lady habits. And she knows then that they are visited for other gods, royal blood among royal blood.

Sometimes, Teela catches sight of her Lady, scouting through the branches. She catches sight of the long and crooked antlers, pairs, dozens of them, twisted and turned like crowns, wrapped in beautiful vines and even more beautiful flowers, the wild kind that grow inside the hollow trunks of the trees and beneath the patches of moss.

Sometimes, Tella can perceive the length of her Lady´s neck, the fall of her hollow shoulders, the thread of her bows crossed across her chest like armors. Sometimes, she thinks she can see the surface of the boar skin wrapping her like veils, strong, courageous and fierce, a protector of all things wild and all things natural. Of women, beares of wisdom and life.

In the middle of the night, Teela can hear the howl of her hunting dogs and see the goddess throw her head back and extend her neck towards the moon, sister and familiar, and howl too, loud, gutural, inhumane. The call of hunt.

Every once in a while, Teela watches as her Lady turns her impossible body towards her and raises her hands over her face, resting the fack of her knuckles over her hollow sockets, the moonstones dug inside her palms seeing everything and nothing at all. And sometimes, Teela thinks she nods at her and at her daughter, very slowly. A recognition sign.

After all, Teela has become the bearer of royalty too. After all, her child is the only heir of a bloodline now extinct, murdered, casted away, guarding her life inside the womb of the earth.

They are never to leave this place, at least not while the war rages on. If there is something left of it to come back maybe,just maybe, Teela would be able to show Ariadne the lands of her father.The lands where she was born too.

“Mom?” Ariadne rests her tiny hand over Teela´s, stroking tanned knuckles with her tiny fingers.

“Yes?”

“Do you think C´yra is alright?”

There are just a few strands of life that Ariadne remembers, things of her past that the small girl holds herself to with all her strength. The edge of the river, the golden light of the sun. The patches of golden wheat growing in the fields outside the window; the sound of the loom weaving next to her crib.

C´yra´s voice, Adam´s friend, Teela´s friend, humming under her breath as she sits near the windows. Holding Ariadne´s tiny body inside her arms and resting her even smaller head in the crook of her elbow.

Kind heart, kind hands, sweet voice, helping Teela when the world crumbled around her. When she knew, deep inside her bones, that the love of her life was not, and that while the circumstances were not painful it was sorrowful. That it had unleashed a new kind of war, more sorrowful than anything before.

“I hope so,” Teela murmurs, trying not to choke on her knot inside her throat. “I pray so every single day. I know you don´t remember her, you were a baby still, but she got us out of Menagerie, she put us on the paths of gods. Me and out woman, she saved us all”

Ariadne blinks, very slowly, her pale blue eyes silver under the light of the moon.

“I do remember her,” she confesses, her accent thick, something she inherited from her father even though she only hears his voice in dreams. Telling her he is there. right next to both of them. “I remember how she smelled. And she sang to me.”

“She did,” Teela quickly cleans the tears gathering in the corners of her eyes, tucking her back to sleep. “Time to rest, little dove”

“Yes, mommy”

Ariadne nuzzles into her pillow and Teela stands up, slipping into her own cot on the opposite wall of her daughters. With time, Ariadne will have her own chamber too, and she will become her Lady´s Priestess also, if that is what she desires. But for tonight she still shares a room with her mother, barely a toddler and a little more than just a child.

“Mommy?”

“Yes, sweetheart?”

“I think she would have loved aunt Adora too,” Ariadne whispers, already skipping her way between dreams.

“She would have.” Teela speaks against her pillow and the night, letting her eyes fall closed to the night. “I believe she would have saved her too.”

“Here,” Catra places the golden pendant inside Adora´s palm, gently closing her fingers over it. “This is what he gave me”

Catra hears as Adora holds her breath in front of her, taking her hand away. It's very late in the night, one of those where neither of them are sleepy and can´t sleep either so they chose to be here, right here in this moment.

Catra is sitting on the coat, legs crossed and in the very edge, and she knows Adora is sitting somewhere in the mosaic floor in front of her, humming to herself as she sees the pin Adam has gifted her years ago and that Catra had only learnt through touch alone.

A feather, carved in steady metal, gold, wrapped around a crown like a very gentle embrace.

“It´s our family's crest.” Adora whispers, full of awe, her voice quivering a little with the knowledge. She is not crying though, Catra has come to learn the patterns of Adora´s breath when she cries. It doesn´t make it less sorrowful. “The House of Grayskull”

“Adam gave it to me the last day he was on Menagerie,” Catra shuffles a little on the bed, resting her palms over her ankles. She curls the tip of her sharp nails towards the inside, picking softly on the skin of her palms. “He said if I ever needed something it would help”

“He was right.” Adora´s breath shakes, very soft sounds coming from her as she rests her back on the roots of the olive tree. The serpents around her head sizzle quietly, brushing the curve of Catra´s knee every once in a while. “Um, there are a lot of crests out there, I met a lot of generals that wore many, many crests, but royal ones are always worn by members of the family and only by them.”

Adora takes a breath, holding it inside her chest. Catra has the urge to surge forward and search for her hand but she gets stuck in place, waiting for Adora to reach out if she wants to; to quiet the storm of emotions that Catra is sure she is feeling right now, threatening to choke her down if she is not careful.

“By giving this to you he made you one of us— um, a Grayskull, in a way.” Adora finally says after a moment, clearing her throat. She does reach for Catra then, resting her palm over her knuckles and easing her hand open to place the pin back inside. “I´m glad he did.”

“Why would he do that?” Catra questions, her voice unsure. She holds the golden pin and doesn´t let go of it but she also doesn´t guard it among the folds of her tunic again, waiting for Adora to answer with her heart on her throat.

“Adam was very smart, Kiki, especially about politics even if he didn´t want to mingle with them. He knew our family was hanging by threads with Prime´s influence over our parents.”

The snakes snap their jaws together, displeased like every single time Adora is feeling angry and she tries to cover it up, little traitors giving her away. Catra hears Adora shushing them under her breath.

“I think he knew battle was forthcoming much before anybody else did. And— he tried to do the best he could to protect us all. He asked me to go with him to Menagerie that night, and he gave you the pin so whatever weight on our family´s name could protect you. I'm sure he gave Teela something to protect herself too. I just—I guess he just never thought he would never return.”

Adora´s voice quiets, her voice losing among their air.

They've been talking like this for the past two months, on and off about Adam and everything that happened around him. At the very beginning Adora was not able to approach the matter; she would sit on the bed or next to the loom and quietly exist next to Catra, still holding her hand, still by her side, but quietly. Thinking.

For long weeks Catra thought that she would not speak about it at all, but little by little the tension and stress in Adora´s body and chest started to loose on and she started to ask Catra things, just a few, about Adam and his life in Menagerie, the life Catra had known. As if she was trying to know her brother all over again.

It was not lineal, and there were still long days and even longer nights where Adora would undo herself in the seams and Catra would not know to do something better for her but to hold her,hold her until there was no more strength in her arms and then hold her just a little bit longer.

But on the gentler days, days like this where Adora´s breath was calm and her body close and relaxed, Catra thought that things were a little bit better, a little bit easier for Adora to live them. To see the past with gentle eyes and her current life with more tender ones.

Catra doesn´t know in what moments she loves her the most. In the best ones or in the worst. She thinks she might love her the same and also a little bit harder on each of them. And the thought is both so simple and so groundbreaking for her that sometimes Catra needs to lay flat over the moss flat with her eyes wide open towards the light of the sun and try to match the feeling of warmth that grows inside her chest when she is close to Adora.

“He told me about you,” Catra chokes, licking her fig–sticky lips when her mouth starts feeling heavy like cotton fields.

“Oh.” Over the mosaic floor Adora chuckles a little out of breath, letting through just how nervous she truly is by the *tap tap* of her nails against the floor and the nervous sizzling on her head. “How embarrassing”

“Not really,” Catra tilts her head to the side, searching among the folds of the sheets and the coat for the pillows. pushing them back so she can lean the entire side of her body against the bed. “He said his sister, that you were smart and loyal. And undeniable kind”

“Oh.” The sizzling stops, replaced by a gentle murmur that Catra´s wouldn´t even have know it was the snakes humming like tiny choirs if she hadn´t been allowed to hear it a couple times now, when Adora´s heart squeezed inside her chest with warmth. “That´s—”

“And he said you were a little shit too.” Catra deadpans before Adora can put herself down, grinning a little on the offended and loud gasp that comes from Adora´s mouth.

“Are you for real?”

"Yeah, prank master and two left feet." Catra shrugs, smiling against the coat. “Just sometimes, that's what he said.”

She hears Adora give a surprised chuckle, loud and scratching in the edges, almost a full snort and it stirs something bright inside Catra´s chest.

“Unbelievable. That brat—”

Catra´s head pounds a little bit too much today, exhausting pulling from the corners of her eyes and her eyelids, and dull ache scratching on the inside of her temples. It's sometimes like this for Catra, tiresome, worn out after an entire day of keeping her eyes open trying to memorize every single shapeless shadow and bright spot of light, as if that way she could paint herself celestial charts inside her mind.

Lately their cavern is beautiful, with the spring in full blown on each patch of grass and crawling upon the three wide trees on the stone walls. It was in a month like this that Catra arrived at the cave, tossed by her own people into a place hiding so much beauty they could not imagine. But when it happened, the floor was stone cold and the crops in the world were dry, nothing compared to the life inside here.

Lately, Catra has found herself wanting to know everything, wanting to absorb everything; the way the whole cavern seems to bend under her laughter or her sobs, lavenders sprouting or dying back again.

“He said you were very easy to love,” Catra confesses too, so quietly under her breath that for a second she wonders if Adora listened at all.

But she did, oh how she did, it´s in the way Adora takes a deep breath barely a few feet away from her and the humming grows, echoing between them, the sudden tension so palpable that if Catra were to stretch her hands in front of her she might just be able to grab it like strands.

Ask me. Ask me if it's true. Catra thinks frantically, curling her fingers, digging her nails against her own skin. *Ask me, so I can tell you how much I adore you.*

Adora doesn´t ask and Catra does not say it. This is who they are right now, there is trust between them but also an underlying linestill painted on the pebbles between them. Sometimes Catra wants nothing more but to kick and erase and cross and something Adora might not even be aware of, might not even want in the first place.

The mattress dips with a second weight, gentle on its movements as Adora joins Catra on bed. She doesn't bother to pretend to be asleep, Adora would know, so Catra turns around to her other side and is met with the warm breeze of a second breathing inches away from her face.

The sudden proximity after months of careful approximation leaves Catra speechless for a moment but neither of them move. Adora waits patiently for Catra so quietly that the latter thinks for a second that she may have actually drifted to sleep. In the heavy darkness it is impossible for Catra to know, even with the sensibility of her ears.

Catra considers her options for a while but she is aware that they have been dancing around each other in a thin line from the very first moment. She knows that Adora felt it too. The tug. The ethereal force cooing them together, like ellipses of the planets and the birth of stars.. But Adora will also make not a single movement unless it is for Catra 's decision. So she collects all of her bravery and swallows the thick knot on her throat, reaching blindly with a shaky hand in the space between.

"Adora?" It´s asked quietly, so much that if Adora doesn´t answer Catra won´t repeat it again.

"Yes?"

Catra would have cursed the unsteadiness of her voice if Adora 's own hadn't come in the same trembling, almost breathless way. Catra breathes deep through her nose, filling her

lungs with the smell of the temple´s flowers and Adora 's own essence.

"Would you let me touch you?" Asks Catra in a low voice strained with contained emotion.

Different, this is different than all the times they have touched each other already. On their hands and fingers and the crook of her elbows. Catra knows it, Adora knows it too, she can taste it on the back of her throat, she can feel it in the loud hum of the serpents curling across the cot.

Adora 's soft breathing stops mid track and nothing in the room or outside the temple dares to move. As the seconds grow longer Catra 's mortification grows bigger, heavy and shameful over her mortal heart in a way just rejection can make. She squirms on her place in bed and slowly retracts her raised hand back to her chest, muttering incoherent apologies on the way.

"I'm sorry. I shouldn't have asked for that, I don't what was I thinking—"

"What? Oh, oh. No, no, Catra," comes finally to Adora 's voice, snapped out of her catatonic state by the heartbreak on Catra 's voice. “I’m sorry. You just took me by surprise”.

A warm calloused hand grips Catra 's fingers gently and it makes her lose all the air on her lungs in one go. This is not the first time they have touched each other but this one it's such a loving embrace that it´s new all over again.

Adora 's fingers are long and soft, with the pad slightly hardened by mysterious jobs and nothing like the crisp harsh skin Menagerie people whispered about Catra´s hands when she left her village. Adora's hand is also a touch bigger, enveloping Catra's own with a soft caress as she tugs slowly from it. }

Adora guides Catra's hand forward and then up, until she can feel her warm breath dancing millimeters away from her skin. Adora stops there, letting Catra take the next step on her own whatever it may be and the gesture is so thoughtful Catra sighs between teary eyes and lets her hand lean until her pads are resting in the skin of Adora 's nose.

Adora loosens her grasp and allows her hand to fall back into the pillows with a soft tud. Catra hesitates for just a moment more and then starts moving her fingers over her face. Up from the bride of the elegant nose to the amplitude of Adora ’s forehead, down to the arch of the eyebrows.

Catra can’t see their color but she can feel the soft angle framing even softer eyelids in a sure calm expression. Catra's fingers hover over her eyelashes that feel like butterflies wings on her skin and the feeling makes her smile.

Catra doesn’t stay there long, sudden waves of confidence filling her heart with excitement and joy. Catra brushes Adora ’s high cheekbones, and she swiftly wonders if she has freckles or moles where she could rest her lips over, down to the curves of her slightly damp lips, soft like rip peaches on Catra's hand.

Catra's breath hitches on her throat, suddenly unsure again as her movement freezes. Adora seems to feel her hesitation because there is a soft hum from her direction almost like a

thoughtful sigh. The serpents are still around them, resting quietly across the pillows and the cot, brushing the very fine hairs around Catra´s ears and forehead

Before Catra can speak she feels the gentle brush of Adora ’s lips over her fingertips in the sweetest of the caresses. It´s not a kiss, it could not possibly be one because if it was, Catra´s heart would give up, but the way they feel makes Catra gasp anyway as Adora places more tiny embraces over the pads of her fingers, quietly encouraging her with the tip of her nose to keep going.

Catra draws in a breath, letting her hand cup the side of Adora ’s face as she caresses the angle of her strong jaw with her thumb in small circles. There are scars there, old, wide enough for Catra to be able to feel with her touch alone; made with the sharp edges of a steel mask Catra now knows of.

Somehow, they don´t make her as terribly sad as the first time she knew about them. Somehow they just make her fond, so much fond of Adora for the thought alone that she survived, that she is right there, alive.

“Thank you,” Catra sighs, starting to withdraw her hand away. Adora stops her,gently resting her own pal over Catra´s fingers, stroking her skin with her thumb.

“So, am I pretty?”, teases Adora. Yet her voice breaks in the end nervously and betrays her, letting through how truly nervous she feels.

“It was never about that,” Catra whispers back, leaning her head until it rests on Adora ’s chin. “It's just nice, meeting you, touching you.” Catra snuggles closer, tucking her head under Adora ’s chin, nestling the side of her face inside the warmth of her neck. “Holding you”

Being so close to her makes Catra´s throat to clock, her entire body raised in goosebumps. But she remains where she is patiently waiting for Adora to push her back if she wants to.

After a few seconds, Adora´s hands twitch at their sides and rise too, resting carefully over the sharp bones of Catra´s shoulder blades, right where the scars of past wounds live too. Adora healed these ones, Catra still remembers. It was the very first time Catra realized just how kind the stranger in the cave could be; the first one she realized how undoing would Adora truly become for her.

There is comfortable silence between them where Catra starts to drift into a peaceful sleep, one arm thrown at Adora ’s waist where the silk fabric of her tunic wrinkles, the other bent over with her palm resting over Adora ’s heart. The fluttering beating there speeds up when her palm meets the skin of her collarbone. The snakes shiver and curl around Catra´s head, making a nest of her hair.

Catra is basically half asleep when she hears a sniff above her. Catra´s eyes snap open immediately, shapeless shadows and swift dizziness meeting her as she tries to move away to search for Adora ’s face, sudden concern pooling on her belly. But Adora circles her arms around her and holds her tight against herself, hiding her face covered in shadows on Catra 's loose hair.

"Adora?"

"I'm fine," Adora chokes out, her voice shivering but her hands steady. "I'm fine, I promise"

Adora has gone through so much already. She has lost so much, being ripped off so much in her life and in this body that others tried to break and that all she can do now is to try to fill it with as much love as she can.

Her heart is somewhere else completely as it should be, focused on healing not in fulfilling Catra´s hope even when her arms are bound around each other each night with as much force as they can. As much as Catra wants to break the breach and crawl her way inside Adora´s heart, she doesn´t dare to.

In a way she is protecting Adora´s privacy. In a way, she is protecting her own heart from breaking. If Adora pushes her away,Catra is not sure she would survive. If she betrays Adora ´s safety, she is not sure she will be able to forgive herself.

She is blind to the light and to the night and thus she is also blind to the love swirling inside Adora´s eyes.



Adora is lying to herself to avoid getting each other's hearts broken.

It´s a sacrifice, monumental even as small as it seems to be; a shivering weight that she has decided to carry all by herself quietly among the shadows of their shared bed and their calm room.

They hang from opposite sides of a golden and red line that they have danced over for one too many times right now. A line that Catra adores to tease, to jump over, sit on and raise on her tippy toes, testing just how far she can go before it snaps in half and makes her fall. A line that Adora has followed too instead of standing safely on her side, watching the precarious steps that Catra gives blindly, holding her breath for the moment in which they will tumble together into darkness.

It's exhilarating and frightful and, most of all, sacred. The kind of thing Adora cannot risk to rip in the seams because she doesn´t know what neither of them will find in the bottom of the cliff. And Adora has fallen so many times before by now, but she cannot bear the thought of Catra following her into the uncertainty too.

Catra has already accepted with her palms and heart open to all the horrid things that Adora is. Her curse, her eyes, their capability to rip life away and turn it into stone instead. Her hands stained in phantom blood and all of the bodies laying outside as testimony of it. The serpents living around Adora´s temples like twisted flower crowns and the maps of scars scattered across her body.

She has already accepted so much of this peaceful but fake life with Adora, an entire year, and entire turn of the planet across their sun, ellipses over itself and over the golden star.

Adora cannot ask more of her, not a single thing more.

The gods' war will end one day or another. Adora cannot leave this place, she cannot allow herself too; Catra might not think of her as a monster but she is a danger, something that could break lives even if she didn't want to. She cannot leave and she cannot ask Catra to stay the rest of her life here, she cannot tell her how she feels about her.

So Catra cannot know, because if she knows she will stay and if she stays she will miss a lifetime in the sun, not in the shadows that blind her. No matter how much Adora wants her,she cannot do that to her when so much has already been given in return.

No matter how much she might love her.

“There you go,” Catra whispers under her breath somewhere behind Adora, running her hands gently through the bodies of the serpents.

Adora tilts her face just slightly towards her, feeling tiny and painless tugs on the snakes every once in a while. “Whatever are you doing there?”

“Shh, don´t move.” Catra instructs her, giggling when one of the snakes finds its way around her wrist and holds her close. “Good snake”

It should not surprise Adora when she catches sight of golden rings gathered on the tunic of Catra´s lap, jiggling with each other when Catra moves a little and they roll from side to side.

Adora has seen Catra adorning her hairs many times before, in both simple and also complex styles that Adora still fights to understand how she can do as detailed as the embroidering on her loom. She has seen Catra hold her curls in tight or looser braids; wrap it in ribbons around her nape or comb big and free over her shoulders and waist.

She has seen the knots and bubbles and twists, carefully done, lovely done by Catra´s hands, and all the jiggling trinkets that Adora knows Catra likes to hang from them, from thin rings to wide cuffs to beads and even slim coins, golden and silver and copper it doesn´t matter to her, falling across her head and around her temples in crowns.

Now the very same cuffs and soft rings are being very gently placed across the serpents bodies, not as locks or restrains but as garments, as jewelry, far from their necks and embellishing their shimmering bodies, raising and echoing sound like tiny bells, a reminiscing of the coin bracelets that Adora used to wear around her ankles when Catra first came here.

It´s a sweet view, almost beautiful, the way the gold catches on the light of the sun pouring from the domes, making the scales of the animals looks less terrible, less morbid where they born from Adora´s scalp, making her heartbeat pick up with either excitement or nervousness and translating on them twisting and sizzling uncontrollably all around Catra´s smiling face.

And it should not surprise Adora either that as of lately she has been, apparently, having kind of a beef with her own serpents for Catra´s attention.

They reach for her, sizzle and hiss for her the moment Catra gets close enough for them to feel her near. They even hiss at Adora when she pulls from them and, worst of all, they give Adora away every single time, no matter how hard she tries to hide her feeling they will wrap themselves around Catra´s slim wrists and the fall of her face and temples.

Right now they are sliding like crazy over each other, absently fighting the other so they can hover close to Catra´s attentive hands as she adorns them in gold and shimmering powder. Adora catches them snapping their fangs to each other when they twist into a knot just above her shoulder, a silently fight going on for Catra´s attention who is completely unaware of it happening bare inches from her face.

Adora shoots her hand to the side and gets a size of both serpents, firmly holding them inside her palm yet as gently as she can untangling them from each other with a flinch when they pull from the roots of her scalp.

“Behave,” Adora scolds them between her teeth, letting them go with a small pat on the back of their white heads.

It´s a jump, an entire step, completely different of two months ago when she was shredding them to pieces. Under certain kinds of lights, she can still see the lines of scars that her nails left below the scales.

“Oh, come on.” Catra purrs, rubbing the side of her cheek against the serpent's nuzzle. “Leave them alone, they are so sweet.”

Catra laughs with a small grumble with she small exchange, twirling her fingers around the slim body of the tiniest of the serpents, the one that curls around Adora´s temples like her baby hairs used to do before and who, for some reason, is the only one that has no fangs. Which is the only reason why Adora allows her to munch happily on the pads of Catra´s fingers as the latter caresses the top of her head without flinching or making a face.

Adora blinks at Catra and the snake, her hands still hovering over the other two who have decided on pill from the straps of her tunic instead of picking on each other. Sometimes they remind Adora a little bit of herself, of the person she used to be when she was much younger and still a child, picking on her brother in the palace's gardens.

“You're unbelievable,” Adora mumbles under her breath, still staring as Catra gathers as many serpents as she possibly can in her hands and nuzzles every single one of them one by one like one would do to a wool blanket or a very cherished strand of hair.

“Yes but we already knew that,” Catra shoots back with a small shrug, throwing all of her heavy hair behind her back.

Catra scoots a little bit back as Adora untangles herself from in between her legs, searching with her unfocused eyes halfway open for the small tray of tinctures placed somewhere next to them. The wrinkled hem of her sleeves falls softly down the skin of her shoulders, letting see just a trace of the swell of her breast before disappearing out of sight beneath her thick curls.

it's not really fair, if we are honest. The cavern is hot, clammy even, hanging with spring perspiration over them so it's only logical to wear thinner fabrics on their clothes. And it was a mistake, actually, or maybe Catra did not even realize at all because after all she doesn´t know that the fine silk fabric that she has wrapped around her chest and falling free over her hips is just the slightest hint of see through.

And it goes unnoticed even, most of the time, and Adora has been doing an excellent job of keeping her eyes strictly away but every once in a while the golden light of the sun touches the fabric and Adora´s sight is drawn to the barely hidden shapes of Catra´s wide hips and supple skin underneath the fabric, tempting Adora with their proximity before going away again.

It's not fair, it's driving Adora insane.

“Your turn,” Catra exclaims triumphantly, completely unaware of the storm going on inside Adora as she finally finds the tray and drags it forward, turning around to offer Adora the slim brush held between her fingers.

A few days ago, Adora spoke to Catra about the things she used to do when she was a princess, a human, that had nothing to do with her studies or her royal duties at all. Adora spoke very quietly about the tinctures Mycenaean women used to wear on their faces, that she herself used to do, the red suns on her cheeks and forehead like a godly blush and the golden powder in which she would dip her fingertips and run over her lips.

Adora told her about oils of sweet and stingy smells and the polished stone combs that she would run over her hair. She told her about it, all about it, before it was transformed into moving bodies of serpents.

Adora told Catra about the golden strands, long and soft to the touch, running like waterfall waters and curling on the ends right about her waist. The way Adora used to take pride on them just as Catra does on her own curls, tending to them, combing and braiding and oiling them anew after a gentle wash. The way they were a part of who she was, who Adora asa human and as a princess too was, as a sister to Adam who shared the same hair if shorter.

She doesn´t speak about the pain and the grief of losing them like one would rip away all the petals of a flower, She doesn´t speak about missing them and how incapable she still is of looking at herself on the reflection of the copper mirror or the surface of the lakes, no matter how slowly she has tried to accept the serpents now that Catra knows too that they exist. Those are things that Adora reminds quiet about, things that just prove stronger how deeply unworthy she is of Catra´s devotion.

But Catra knows, as always. And as always, she finds her way inside Adora´s pain, not pushing it aside or hiding it away but sitting all around it, accompanying it with her own kind of light as she grasps berries from their trees and powder from their pollen and asks Adora that if she can't do it for herself anymore then she could still do it for her. And Catra will tend to the serpents in return, washing them gently with damp cloths and golden cuffs around their bodies and across Adora´s forehead, dressing her anew not as a human or as a princess but as who she is right now.

Adora breathes deeply through her mouth, reaching for the crushed berries and dipping the end of the brush in them. She makes a very strong point of not looking anywhere else but to the front as she turns back towards Catra´s frankly excited face, hovering the pads of her fingers beneath her chin.

“Alright,” Adora bites into her own mouth, staring back and the pretty cluster of freckles scattered around Catra´s cheeks. “Tilt your face up”

“Sure”

“Don´t move.” Adora mumbles just as the serpents start to search their way again around Catra´s face, making Adora grunt. “None of you”

Catra sneakers but she listens too, letting her gold dusted eyelashes fall closed. That´s good because otherwise Adora would have been distracted the entire time by the silver shimmer of her beautiful clouded eyes and it's been a long time already since she did this in the first time, she cannot allow herself to be more nervous than she already is right now.

Adora bites on the inside of her cheek and presses the brush firmly against Catra´s warm cheek, letting the purple and red paint her skin.

Dot, dot, dot. Catra likes dots, she knows a language in them, a kind that Adora has been curious to learn for a while but that she is too nervous to ask still. She wants to learn to write in a way that Catra can read with her fingers, and she wants to learn what Catra writes too; she wants to understand what is embroidered in her hemation, even if it scares her.

Dot, to. They are good, dots, something simple, a part of the suns that Adora is now drawing over Catra´s skin. She still remembers how to do them, the way the tinier dots would circle the larger one like the real planets do to the sun in the skies. One, two and eight, red colored against the dark of Catra´s face.

Adora paints suns across Catra´s face, one on each cheek, one in the middle of her forehead where the curls cradle her skin like hands; and one over her chin, so small that it almost looks like the moles that travel from the corner of Catra´s mouth to her neck.

Adora´s breath catches on her throat, her thumb hovering right about Catra´s half open lips. And somehow she can hear Catra´s breath stopping too, her eyes still closed but her ears perked up, tilted towards Adora´s direction as if she was waiting for something.

It would be easy, so very easy for Adora. Easy to take the step forward and slice the fine line holding them up with her bare hands and her open lips too. Easy and dooming, for both of them, someone not meant for love and someone so full of the same that she would undo herself into pieces for her.

Adora wants to, oh how she wants to but she cannot. She cannot, she cannot —

A few serpents shoot forward out of nowhere and accidentally bonk Catra directly on the forehead, breaking a surprised gasp from both of them.

“I´m sorry,” Adora rushes to say immediately, pulling away from Catra and from the serpents like a second instinct. “Shit, sorry”

“Ouch,” Catra groans with a wrinkle of her nose, but she is smiling anyway, hushing Adora´s worried mumbles with a wave of her hand. “Hey, I´m right in front of you little ones.”

Catra speaks to the serpents with care, finding their little head and rubbing underneath their jaws when they wiggle and jawn pleasantly around her touch. And she treats them with patience, in the same voice and the same tenderness she usually speaks to Adora and never as if they were just another animal.

Adora can tell the difference almost immediately, in the way she herself treated them, herself, for a long time and in the way Catra does instead.

“They are blind,” Adora sputters out without thinking, too entranced in the way the serpents hover in front of Catra´s face to try to find her, in the very same rhythm Adora´s heart is beating inside of her chest.

Catra´s jaw falls open with surprise, her eyes blinking into a narrow slit. “Are you serious?”

“I am,” Adora assures her, holding back a heavy sigh.

“Gods,” Catra mutters, fighting with everything within her power to not split her mouth into a huge grin.

“Don´t laugh,” Adora begs of her but she is already halfway laughing too.

“I´m sorry, just—” A giggle escapes Catra´s mouth as she rests her forehead against the palm of her hand, shaking her entire head with incredulity. “What a fucking joke”

Adora finally laughs too, wet in the edges where accidental tears fall from her eyes. “I know, right?”

Catra hums, still running her fingers up and down the serpents, feeling the soft scales against her skin. “It feels like they are mocking us”

“My first thought exactly”

Adora brushes her fingers across the curls that bounce over Catra´s forehead, gazing at the fresh makeup on her face. It has been such a long time since she saw someone with them, five, no, six whole years. And the presence of them on Cattra´s face makes Adora feel a kind of calm familiarity that she had not experienced in a long time.

It´s welcomed, among the confusion of her own feelings, the sensation of something that still roots her home.

“And?” Catra asks hesitantly after Adora has gone quiet for a second too long. “How do I look?”

Adora wets the dry skin of her lips, finding her voice again from where it has gone tight with emotions around the knot of her throat.

“Like a sun,” she finally croaks out, the corner of her cursed eyes wrinkling in the edges. “You look like someone that poets would sing poems about”

Once, Adora was compared to the woman of a tale. Helen, first of Sparta then of Troy, the most beautiful woman in the world that brought history to its knees and broke the world. And just like Helen, Adora was cursed to tragedy too, pain and unfairness for something she did not choose.

She doesn´t dare to do that right now, for fear or for superstition maybe, but she is sure of what she has just said. If the world knew about Catra, all about her and her beautiful skin and her sweet breath and her soft hair, all about the blooms that sprout beneath her soles and just how unyielding she can be, they would sing poems for her. Adora would do it, if she had ever been born to be a poet and not a casted away.

“Hmm.” Catra smiles, her silver eyes flashing with something cheerful. Unlike Adora, she is not scared at all. “Like Eurydice?”

The words fall over Adora like a cold shower of water, lowering her heartbeat into an almost instant stop.

“Like someone with a happy ending,” Adora mumbles under her breath, tearing her eyes away from Catra so she can pick at the soft moss beneath their knees.

Catra chuckles in front of her, maybe not completely unaware of Adora after all, gently feeling the now dry makeup over her cheeks. “So nobody greek”

She is trying to make a joke, easing the air between them and Adora´s sudden sadness that had overtaken her. It reaches its goal because Adora does laugh, very softly and trembling but a laugh after all, easy coming on her lips because it seems she is not able to hold herself from smiling if it´s for Catra to hear.

“Yeah, I guess,” Adora agrees, chewing on the inside of her cheek. “As long as it has nothing to do with Orpheus”

Catra huffs, rolling her eyes back closed as she lets herself fall flat over the moss of the ground. The branches of the trees around them are now high enough that they can almost reach the open domes above them, casting shadows in the shape of their leaves all over them.

Adora knows that Catra cannot see them, but she can perceive the dance of shadow and light and she likes to feel them against her face when she tilts her face towards the open sky among the stone of the cavern.

“What's your problem with Orpheus?” Catra asks, facing the open domes with her eyes still closed, her hands curled almost closed around her head.

Eurydice and Orpheus' poem is Catra´s favorite one to tell. She has whispered countless times for both of them in the middle of the night, when one or neither cannot seem to be able to fall asleep. She is infatuated by the tragedy, by the love, by the mistakes, by a tale that in a way feels so human that Catra cannot do something else but feel completely attracted to everything about it. From the path of shadows out of the underworld to the apparent unavoidable grief that is to come right after.

Adora, though, Adora thinks much differently of it, most of the time holding back a yell every single time Orpheus is about to commit the exact same mistake, over and over again. She is annoyed by him, frustrated, looking at his broken face inside her mind and almost seen a mirror of herself.

“He had everything,” Adora blurts out, frowning at the grass where she is still sitting near Catra´s hip. “He had love and lost it. And then he was given an opportunity, he was given something nobody else had and he ruined it just because he could not hold himself from looking back and gaze at Eurydice.”

Adora wrinkles her nose, kicking into a nearby stone with a frustrated sigh. She lets herself fall over the soft ground, opposite to Catra in the way their cheeks are almost pressed together but Adora is upside down, like hands holding each other from different sides of the line.

Adora´s soles touch the cold ground where the light doesn´t reach, mingling around her toes, fresh and alive.

“I don´t know, it makes me mad.” Adora mutters, gazing up at the tree branches dancing around the domes. “I don´t understand him”

“Maybe he loved her too much to live without gazing at her,” Catra says, her fingers finding Adora´s serpents and tangling around them.

“Maybe,” Adora narrows her eyes at the tiny leaves that saunter towards their faces. “But he lost her in return”

“Hmm.” Catra says no more, happy to lean into their shared silence and the sounds of their cavern all around them.

Adora moves a little to the side, tilting her face towards Catra so she can see the angle of her eyelashes against the warm light of the sun. The pretty suns in her cheeks make her look rosy, flushed like *eruthros*.

“You have a beef with Penelope of Sparta and you know it.” Adora dabs back, her heartbeat picking up when Catra grins broadly, shrugging over the evergreen grass.

“Just because I said that it was crazy that she waited for twenty godforsaken years for a single person”

“Yeah but by your own logic, wouldn't you also wait so long for the person you loved?”

Catra falls silent, suddenly finding herself trapped by her own argument. Adora smiles triumphantly at Catra´s apparent lack of words, shaking her shoulders happily with the serpents sizzling to match.

Adora does not know this, not even up close, but Catra knows of herself that she is a hypocrite. She has waited twenty six years for her. She knows she would wait the rest of her life if needed.

Catra runs the pad of her fingers over the smooth surfaces of the snakes, marveling in the sensation of their scales moving against her skin. Her face is full of wonder.

She is so beautiful like this. Her face is showered with the light of the sun and her skin looks like fresh earth after rain; her eyebrows are lifted and her red mouth barely open with curiosity as she caresses the sizzling tiny snakes right above Adora's ears. All of her freckles are stars, constellations of color splashed on her red cheeks; and her eyes are a comet's trail, clouded as midnight mist or a falling star over the surface of a lake.

Oh, oh dear gods.

How much Adora loves her.

"What color are they?" Catra asks, voice raspy and waving, unaware of all the thoughts like poetry running free across Adora's mind. Adora blinks, twice, suddenly confused by the sudden question, curiosity meeting shyness.

"The snakes?" Adora asks, choking with her breath slightly.

She can feel the way blood runs through her own cold cheeks, spots of warmth on the skin there. Catra must feel it, under her palm when she cradles Adora's face inside her hand, because she chuckles good-hearted and tender.

"You want to know what color they are," Adora repeats and it's not even a question at all.

"Well, yes." Catra assures too, shrugging lightly. The thin fabric of her sleeves falls down her shoulder, a spot of freckled skin bare under the sunlight and the shadows of this hidden garden. "They are a part of you aren't they?"

And it is the way she says it, so simple, so caring. They are there, yes, snakes instead of hair, moving under her fingers, alive and weird— for Adora. But for Catra, for Catra these are Adora too, an extension of her. And all that Adora is, Catra adores too.

Adora feels light. Suddenly. Lighter than ever, lighter than she has ever felt her entire life. Not even when she was in her kingdom, in her old home, cradled by fake beauty and boring laziness, did she ever feel like this. Free.

"They are white, I guess, and golden," Adora hears herself saying, mind in a haze, trembling under Catra's touch. The latter doesn't speak of it, drawing lazy circles over Adora's cheek with her thumb. "Maybe even blue in some places"

Adora is not used to this, to describe this— this cursed part of herself as if it was something beautiful instead of monstrous. To see herself over the polished surface of forgotten shields and not curse at herself and her entire existence. To not claw at her own face and pull from the horror where before were golden threads of hair. To not feel not like herself and more like an object; a subject for men and myth full of fear and death and tragedy; a puppet merely used for the gods pleasure. Adora is not used to not hating herself.

Yet here is Catra. Catra who is so full of curiosity and marvel. Catra who has suffered just as much and remains compassionate and tender. Catra who is full of light but also of darkness and that makes her beautiful as a sun eclipse As elliptic movements and the perfect math of galaxies.. Catra who snickers at Adora's description of the snakes, nibbling on her bottom lip as she hums under her breath.

"What does blue look like?" she asks and Adora answers.

"Like the sky."

"What does the sky look like?"

"Like a river during dawn"

"And the dawn?"

"Like sea glass"

"And sea glass?"

"Like your eyes"

Catra beams, smiling bright as a pearl and warmer than the very sun slipping through the branches and leafs of the fig tree. Adora smiles right back at her and Catra can feel the corners of her mouth stretching right beneath her fingertips.

When Adora looks back up to the sky all she sees is blue. Blue and golden and white and the phantom shape of the fresh leaves crowning the open domes like laurel branches. Catra´s breath and smile is right next to her, brushing its way against her cheek like the promise of a kiss not given.

I am promised for, Catra´s words of so long ago echoing inside Adora´s head like a warning.

It will be your greatest joy and your most tender sorrow, it had been said to Adora even longer ago, the promise of an omen.

Adora´s hand rests raised near Catra´s lifted one, almost brushing each other with the touch of their pads. Her fingers twitch a little and touch in the gentlest of caresses and then she takes them completely away.

Something is going to change today. Catra knew this from the very first second she arises from sleep this very morning.

Something vital, something important, something so completely earth shattering that is going to change everything inside their mundane yet still delicate life inside the cavern.

Adora is washing her hair.

Nobody has ever washed Catra´s hair, at least not since her mother died. Catra learned how to do it by herself from very little and from then on it had been a delicate and meticulous task that she had given to herself as an act of love.

It´s not an easy task, known and ordinary for Catra after doing it many times through the years, but not quite as easy to learn from the very beginning. It doesn´t always need washing and when it does it must be done carefully too, mindful of the gentle cluster of locks; dried with care and tended with oils to soften the strands and make them anew.

If it is done too harsh or too cold, there is not only a risk for Catra´s hair to ruffle wildly and uncomfortably, but also to pull from her temples and make her head hurt, and once the dull and continuous ache has started, it is very difficult for her to keep it from crawling all over her forehead and the back of her eyes.

Tending to a part of someone's body should be an act of love too.

Adora runs the end of her nails softly through Catra´s scalp, followed behind by the thick teeth of the marble comb. Catra´s hair is just slightly damp now, hanging heavy across her shoulder and the middle of her back where Adora´s fingers have gently pushed it aside as she works through the thick curls, combing them and then shaping them back together with her fingers.

Catra sighs, letting her cheek rest over the bone of Adora´s knee. She is sitting right in between Adora´s legs, Adora properly sitting on a high rock behind her while Catra has her feet and hips dipped into the edge of the lake.

Catra hums at the feeling of the fresh water all around her, soaking into the fabric of her chiton and dampening her palms and forearms when she stretches her arms forward,following the movement of the invisible waves with her fingertips.

Adora smells beautifully today, sweet like grapefruits and lemon trees, the warmth of her legs and torso sipping into Catra´s very skin where she cradles Catra against her body to tend to her hair and the dull ache beneath her eyes. Catra can feel just how truly carefully Adora is running the comb against her scalp, caressing circles around her temples and the low of her nape to chase the ache away.

Catra allows her eyes to open, just a slit, the light slipping over her clouded scleras with golden shadows. She can perceive the movement of Adora´s hands moving softly somewhere near her temples but that's all she can make off only with her eyes, relying on the feeling of Adora´s soft breath ruffling the peach fur of her ears and the sound of the serpents sliding calmly over each other.

They too fall heavy across Adora´s chest, long enough that one of their little heads is nestling on the crook of Catra´s neck and her shoulder, humming pleasantly alongside her breathing.

Sometimes it catches Catra a little bit by surprise how simple it´s been to love Adora, every single piece and part of her. Her hands and her voice and her warmth, but also her curse, her pain which was not her fault, the serpents sprouting from her scalp,each one a little testimony of the person Adora truly is beneath all those thick walls she was surrounded herself with.

It doesn´t surprise her, but it leaves her speechless for a second, the raw amount of her adoration for the person washing and combing her hair right now. Catra doesn´t even notice that tears have managed to escape her eyes until Adora feels them running softly across her knee, shaking her back into the present.

“Are you alright? What happened?” Adora asks, her body curling over Catra´s head, probably searching for her face.

Catra huffs, dragging her own damp palms over her eyes to try and hide away the traces of tears from Adora´s eyes, kicking herself internally for ruining such tender moment with clumsy tears.

“Nothing, is just—” Catra wraps her fingers around the closest part of Adora she can reach, tangling around the elegant curve of Adora´s ankle next to her hip. “It´s been a very long time since someone helped me with my hair.”

It´s not the truth, not all of it, but it´s enough to be real. Catra hears Adora take a shivering breath somewhere above her head, her hands falling limp and usure over her knees instead of Catra´s head.

“I thought maybe—maybe Adam might have wanted to learn too?”

“No, Adora,” Catra chuckles around a sad sob, shaking her head. “Your brother was many things but delicate was not one of them. I was fond of him but I would not have trusted him near my hair in a whole mile away.”

Adora snorts lightly too, her fingers returning to the base of Catra´s nape, cradling the back of Catra´s head inside her palms. “Yeah, you are right.”

“Besides, my hair was much shorter when I met him,” Catra continues, her voice suddenly losing itself in the memory. Adora moves again behind her, her warmth leaving Catra for a second that feels eternal.

“What do you mean?”

Catra sighs, moving too. She turns around on her place, still over the soft mud and fresh water but facing where Adora sits instead. Catra can hear her controlling her breath in front of her. And she can make out the characteristic sound of her nail tapping against each other and the slightly higher pitched sizzle of the serpents, like every single time she gets nervous and hesitant.

“I asked someone to cut it all off months before he arrived,” Catra whispers under her breath, her eyes aching again with tears. “It was when my mother died.”

“Oh.” It´s a simple whisper but Catra can hear the empathy and sadness overflowing out of Adora´s voice. “Oh, Kiki.”

“I guess, the last person I allowed near my hair was my mother,” Catra suddenly finds herself openly sobbing between Adora´s legs, suspended in a point where Adora is close enough to feel her but far enough that Catra cannot touch her or find her beneath her closed eyelids. “Until you, of course.”

Very, very carefully, almost like the ghost of a touch first and then completely tangible from a second to the other, Catra feels the rough pads of Adora´s fingers against her face, running up and down the arch of her cheekbones and catching every single tear falling off quietly from Catra´s closed eyes.

“Sorry, I´m crying about hair,” Catra hiccups, feeling Adora´s palm cradling the angle of her jaw.

“I think I can understand one or two things about that.” Adora reassures her, her breath closer now. “I´m sorry.”

“I miss her,” Catra´s chin is wobbling uncontrollably, tightening a knot around her throat. “I miss her every day. Sometimes I think about all the things I could have done for her. If I had known, I could have done so much more to protect.” Catra takes a choked up breath, Adora´s other hand finding its way next to her ear. “Nobody helped us, not my father, not my grandmother. Not the strangers that called themselves our friends. They were indifferent, to me, to her.”

To you, Catra thinks but it gets tangled between her sobs and her tears, splashing quietly on the calm water of the lake around her knees.

“I think— I think I might miss her like you miss Adam.” Catra chokes out, finding Adora´s wrists near her face and lacing their fingers together, feeling the shiver of sorrow cursing through Adora´s entire body with the words. “I don´t think we are ever going to stop missing them. I think we will always wonder what if.”

“I think we might.” Adora agrees, so close to her that the proximity makes Catra swoon. “I´m just glad you had someone with you after it happened. I'm grateful that you had Adam and that he had you before he— left. And I'm glad for the women you spoke to me about. Your grandmother too, even if they turned their eyes away. I´m just happy you weren´t completely alone to cut your hair short.”

Adora runs her fingers down Catra´s hair, past the curve of her lowered ears and the back of her head, brushing her thumb over the angle of her jaw like a phantom reminder of cut strands as a matter of grief.

“Adam was a small blessing after it happened. After my mother was ripped away from me by my own family but there rest? It´s just—” Catra cuts herself short, suddenly overwhelmed.

Can she say it? Can she speak the words? Can she confess the truth of her birthright, of those who make the other half of her blood?

The very same that have forsaken and betrayed Adora, can Catra whisper that she is a part of them? That maybe even this, this ordinary and mundane life might be their doing? Pushing them and pushing them together since they were children for their own gaming moves, leaving a path for tragedy when things didn't work out?

Can Catra say that it doesn´t matter to her? That no matter what or how terribly their destinies were stretched and braided together and apart again beyond their control, Catra still chooses to remain here? That she would choose this cavern and this life and this single shared second with Adora kneeling in the lake waters alongside her above any other destiny?

Can Catra say that might be their child but she has seized destiny by the hand and has held Adora with the other and has chosen love above terror? She doesn´t know if she can, she doesn´t know if it might be betrayal, she doesn´t know if Adora might want her or hate her after.

She has washed and tended to serpents. Adora has combed and braided her hairs and somehow both things are terribly more intimate than bare bodies and shared spit. And if Adora has bared a portion of her soul and her fear to Catra, it´s only fair to do the very same. Isn´t it? Catra´s soul it's hers anyway.

“What are the chances a blind wildflower like me is surrounded by mysterious people nobody knows about?” Catra starts blurting out, digging her nails on the soft mud below the surface of the water, right where the fabric of Adora´s tunic mingles with her fingers. “What's the chance of Adam, your brother, finding his way to my land? What are the chances of my soils being nurtured and alive in the middle of war? What are the possibilities of me winding up here after twenty five years of waiting?”

Adora moves again, turning away, coming close again, hesitant and confused but still there, right next to Catra.

“I´m not understanding”

“There is something about me you don´t know yet, Adora. My mother never spoke about it but I knew, I knew it since I was much younger” Catra chokes with her breath, shaking her head until all the freshly and untangled locks of hair fall back inside the water, brushing the low of her waist. “And you have trusted me with yourself, so it's only fair you know, so you can choose if you want me here after all, Adora. It´s only fair, after what has happened to you.”

Adora takes a sharp breath, the entire cavern falling silent as it awaits for her answer. Catra holds her breath too, her face still tilted down, her mouth pressed into a tight line, holding the chunks of mud and water between her fingers like a life line that might keep her from breaking completely.

Adora stands up and Catra might as well break into pieces.

She feels the water moving all around her and then there is Adora again, kneeling right in from of Catra too, her knees meeting hers when she presses herself as close as she can to Catra´s bundled up body, searching for her hands on the water.

“Does it have to do with the blooms that sprout beneath your feet?” Adora asks gently, cutting the spirals of Catra´s words with her voice. The serpents move forward too, wrapping themselves around Catra´s face and neck, holding her too.

“I—” Catra tries but nothing comes out, suddenly out of words. Has she noticed? “Um”

“I´ve noticed. Catra, you've brought life to this place. You grew the trees and brought the birds and made the cave outside green with life. Where there was nothing but destruction there is now a mausoleum. You did that, how could I not notice?” Adora´s fingers wrap around Catra´s chin,tilting her face up and when Catra opens her eyes all she perceives is light. “Does it have to do with your dreams?”

“It does.” Catra whispers, frowning until her head aches. “It's about me being the sprout of those who have forsaken you.”

Adora hums or maybe it´s the serpents, maybe it's both of them. She leans her forehead against Catra´s and whispers against her skin; there are still marks of sun makeup on her cheeks, Catra can feel them every single time she breathes near her.

“C'yra, daughter of Io,” Adora whispers and it feels like guidance. As if Adora was still lost in the shadows but she was determined to pull Catra out of them. “Who is your father?”

“The king of dreams”

“Who was your grandmother?’

“The lady of the harvest “

Adora exhales against her cheeks and her breath mingles in Catra´s mouth. “You're a daughter of the gods”

“Is that bad?” Catra questions with a shiver, gasping when Adora laughs.

“You're a miracle, C'yra.” Adora whispers back and she says it like she means every single word. “Why would that ever be bad?”

“Oh”

The root of their problem is that neither of them think they deserve the other.

While Catra feels herself unworthy, Adora feels herself a monster. Where Catra feels everything in her life is meant to leave her, Adora believes she is cursed to lose everything she loves.

The root of their problem is that no matter the fear, no matter the hesitations, no matter the intervention of the gods, they *are* meant for each other. They *are* halves of each other and

they collide like stars in every single life because their stardust was born from the same source of light. Like the water that surrenders their waist and their wombs right now as they reach for each other like praying hands under the golden light.

Catra lifts her hands from the water, up and up again until her fingers find Adora´s face, cradling their way across the sharp fall of her jaw and all the sweet angles of her face. Adora exhales through Catra´s fingers, her sweet breath clashing against Catra´s half opened lips.

“Kiki,” Adora whispers, tangling her fingers around the soaked folds of Catra´s tunic, wrinkling around her hips and the fall of her waist. Loving, she feels loving, unable to resist, too tempting for Catra to do anything else. “What are we doing?”

“Dora,” Catra whispers only, sore, soaring in their ears like the rush of water. She can´t explain, she can´t say more because she has no words for it. Just this. “My Adora.” She is so close, so close to her, so much that Catra can taste the lemongrass on the back of her throat.

“I have nothing. There is nothing I can give you,” Catra hears, whispered right above her lips, serpents kissing their way all over her face but where she wants them the most.

In a way it is known, expected, this jump of theirs. The fine line has grown too delicate, too frail and it´s shattering completely under the weights of their hearts.

“This is enough. You are enough.” They are like river nymphs, finding each other as if the flow of their waters had met them together anyway and no matter what. Either here among the branches of their cavern or outside through golden fields on the marble mosaics of palaces, they were meant for this moment. “Stay with me”

After all, thay are also a universe law. They are physics, they are mathematics, pushing and pulling and colliding together. Truth, *Aletheia, Veritas* . Olive trees, wisterias and ichor.

They are not the same as they were and still completely as they should. They are pain and sorrow carrying hope and desire. They are gravity, ellipse, the planets around their sun, so far away and unable to live without it.

They are the rule, everything that could happen will happen. It has taken them three hundred seventy one moons. It has taken them twenty six years. It has taken them a second and a step and a full river.

Natural, it was natural, like the birth of a star, like the fall of a comet. Golden light, tender hands, they wrap themselves completely across and through Catra´s heart and she hopes, deep in her heart, that she can give it all back so the woman inside her arms knows exactly how deeply Catra adores her. How long has she been waiting to love her.

There is darkness in Catra´s eyes and then there is only light,slipping golden beneath her closed eyelids when her mouth opens against her best friend´s, pouring all of their sweetness and all of their sorrow inside.

It tastes like water and like fresh air, it tastes like ripe fruits and like warm nights. Adora gasps and hiccups against her mouth and Catra surges forward, catching her inside her hands

when Adora´s strength gives in and she crumbles against the water, loom´s fabric and jiggling rings and tender serpents mingling with Catra´s body, damp curls and high pitched gasps and trembling fingers.

Kissing the sun with your eyes closed would scare anyone, would maybe kill a mortal, but Catra is all of it and more and she embraces the rays of the sun like sizzling tendrils inside her arms and presses her mouth against Adora´s until all she can feel and taste it´s her, *her*.

Adora, Adora, her dream, her only hope, the only thing anchoring her to the earth, the love of her life, her best friend, the half of her soul. Not a monster, never a monster,for monsters don ´t kiss like this, with their trembling lips worshiping the corner of Catra´s mouth and their soaked tongues licking the roof of her mouth. And if they do then Catra is blessed for she rather lay with a fallen angel than living the rest of her life without meeting her at all.

Maybe she is a hypocrite after all, Catra thinks this as she cradles the back of Adora´s head, tangling her fingers through slim bodies and supple skin. She would be Penelope too, weaving her life away for a single second of this, the love of her life in her arms. Even if they were not kissing as they are right now, Catra would do it all too, wait ten and twenty years and the rest of her life for her. She would. She would face the gods and the mortals all the same and lay her throat and her bare heart in the ground for her, she would.

Catra is a woman, a woman that loves and she loves Adora. As she kisses her, as she runs her lips up the straight fall of her nose and the dimple on her chin, as she presses her tongue against Adora´s forked one and wipers against her mouth, Catra realizes that she would, that she already did, that she would do it again.

The gods might have placed her here, destroyed the world and their lives and left them to wander on their own, but Catra has carved Adora´s soul inside her heart with her bare hands. From the very first second they met, she did it and she would do it over and over again.

For the only thing she knows is right is to adore Adora, to love her and her scars and her pain and her joy and her happiness with all the strength she is capable of and then a little bit more and that should be enough.

That could be enough.

Adora rests her hands on the back of her neck and the small of her waist and raises on her knees above the water, arching Catra´s entire body backwards with the strength of a newfound kiss, stealing the breath and the life out of her mouth and drinking it anew with her sharp teeth meeting the bottom of her lips and her tongue lavishing a tale of love inside her mouth.

Catra gasps and whimpers inside the kiss, resting her entire body against Adora´s with her arms tightly wrapped around her neck, laughing around the love worship and the heat when the tiny heads of the serpents find their way against her ears and the angle of her neck and they kiss her too, a reflection of a portion of Adora´s adoration that curses through Catra´s veins like poured lava.

But for what Catra is tenderness and freedom for Adora is a painful reminder, and she is ripped off the haze of their love so sharply that it feels like tearing the flesh out of her living body when she leans her head back, taking away her mouth and her spit and her tongue from Catra´s blessed mouth, gasping horrified at herself.

“Adora,” Catra pleads for her to come back, her eyes opened a slit, her mouth pleading, her face beautiful, resting tiny kisses across a face she cannot see but that she knows better than anything else in this world.

“Catra,” Adora gasps, undone, broken all over, sweet still but trembling, holding Catra´s body and the strands of their fate inside her hands and wondering from which one she should let go. “We can´t”

Suddenly, the star in the sky is cold, colder than anything she had ever felt before and Catra whimpers for a very different reason than uncontrollable love, her fingers digging painfully against the fall of Adora´s strong shoulders and the back of her hands.

“What? Why not?”

“This is not life, Catra,” Adora whispers against her face and Catra cannot see it but the sun makeup on her cheeks has been smudged, by lips and thumbs and sweat, erasing the suns away. “It's not real”

“Not real?” Catra repeats, full of incredulity. She feels Adora´s body locking up and struggling to lean back but she holds her even tighter, suddenly selfish and angry, refusing to let her go. “I've been dreaming with you my whole life. You were in my dreams when I was a child, a teen. I carved you in my soul. I was there where you were cursed, I felt you. I felt you, Adora. ”

“Catra— no—”

“It's you, isn´t it? It's you.” Suddenly Catra´s voice has picked up, strangled, desperate, full of agony. Suddenly the warmth and the tingle of their shared kisses has gone cold and dry in her mouth and she feels like drowning in the very same rivers that have become her home, unable to hold her head up if Adora is not there. “Don´t tell me it's not you. It has to be you. I knew when I came here, I *knew.* I´ve never adored someone in the way I do to you, so please.”

Inside her arms Adora grunts, pained, so full with grief that it bends Catra in the middle, wrecking her entire body like a lethal arrow slashing her heart clean in half. Not off the hand of Eros but from Adora´s own.

Adora successfully tears herself away completely from Catra´s weakened hold, stepping back deeper inside the lake, raising splashing sounds all around them. Catra´s legs tremble and they give up, tumbling her down against the edge of the lake with so much force that her palms and knees bruise.

Catra hears Adora exhale with pain but she doesn´t get near Catra again and the sudden distance between them, beyond the physical, after so many months of carefully built love,

brings Catra so much searing pain that she can barely breath.

“Adora,” Catra begs. She is begging, in her hands and knees, begging. This is the only reason, the only person Catra, C´yra, would ever beg for. This is the only thing important enough for her to tear herself into pieces for. Because Adora is *afraid,* and she deserves to know. “Adora. I love you”

Adora sobs somewhere in front of her, her steps drowned where she walks deeper and deeper inside the water until the same must be reaching her waist and her warm chest. Where Catra cannot hear her or reach her anymore.

Catra slams her palms against her eyes and cries against them, whipping tears and water away as she silently curses at the same blindness that has protected her from Adora´s curse but that now keeps her away from her too.

In front of her, where she can´t see, Adora is crying too, the water reaching the curve of her ribs, her tears falling inside the lake and making it bigger, overflowing, wetting the edge of the soil. She cannot speak about it outloud, but where her mouth weighs light with Catra´s taste, her mind is heavy, choking her with the image of Catra´s beloved face forever casted in stone, another ghost for Adora to cry into. And Adora cannot do that, she cannot survive that, she loves Catra too much and maybe just not enough.

"I love you," Catra cries again, angry, stretching her arms forward and dropping them back again when Adora doesn´t reach back.

“Catra, you are my best friend” Adora sobs and her tone is pleading, overflowing with conflict. The serpents snap their mouths violently against each other, biting themselves and Adora´s skin into self hatred. “You know, you know what I am. I´m not human anymore, I cannot give you this.”

“I love you. So what? I love you.” Catra doesn´t care, standing in precarious feet on the edge and slipping down again. “I know you love me too, please”

“I can't.” The sound of the water picks up again, higher, a turmoil, letting Catra know just how far away Adora is slipping from her, dropping the line and leaving Catra on the floor.

“Adora, don't leave, please. I love you.” Catra slams her fists against the floor and against her chest, grasping for Adora and finding nothing but empty air instead. “If you can´t love me then at least stay”

“Catra. that´s not—” Adora chokes with her own breath, curling over herself with pain. “I can´t–”

“Adora,” Catra mutters between her teeth, shivering so violently that her entire body shakes with her. “It´s my heart. And I'm giving it to you, *you,* just like you are right now”

“Oh, Cat,” Adora takes a breath, holds it inside her chest, the hesitance of her silence filling Catra with some kind of hope and then crushing it back again. “I´m sorry, C´yra. Kiki, I´m sorry, just— I´m sorry.”

The water breaks around Catra´s body and for a moment she thinks Adora might be making her way back to her but then she feels the emptiness, the void, and Catra knows that Adora is gone, leaving Catra at the opposite edge of the colder waters without turning around.

“No, no.” Catra mourns, tilting her head towards the open domes above her head. The light around her has changed and she cannot perceive the golden anymore. Or the love. “Don´t leave, please don´t leave. Please come back.”

She remains there, waiting for Adora. Just waiting, knowing she might just turn around and come back to her arms. Catra could just hold her, only that, no kisses, no desire, just embrace her inside her palms for the rest of their lives. She would be happy with that. The smallest part of Adora that she can give Catra will always be enough.

But Adora, sitting on the other edge of the cavern with her eyes swimming in golden tears and her voice strained, doesn´t dare to go back. They are back on the beginning again, incapable of reaching for each other no matter how badly they want.

And they both sit on opposite sides and they miss each other. And they weep and the red moon falls with the night.

What if I said I'm tryin' to save your love from dyin'?

Baby, I'm too far gone (oh, oh, oh)

Don't wanna see you cryin', but I just know who I am

And maybe that's the hardest part of all

Baby, you can't fix me

I was born with a broken heart

— *Born with a broken heart,* **Damiano David**

Chapter End Notes

Wouldn´t be me without some *drama*

Be patient, it´s not going to last. Just give Adora a moment to breath, she is scared :)

Comments, kudos, bookmarks and shares are deeply appreciated. She you soon!

Verse IX

Chapter Notes

Happy International Woman´s Day!

Hello, I know I left you in a cliffhanger last time but I hope this chapter compensates a little bit of the previous angst. We have 22k words to go so let´s get to it!

I´ve had this chapter ready for a few days but I thought it was the right way to post it until today being the date it is. This is, after all and most important, a story about woman ´s strenght in every single way possible, from the emotional and physical trauma to overcome the oppression and abuse to the journey of healing what you were once into what you are now.

To allow ourselves to trust and love all over again.

WARNINGS FOR THIS CHAPTER:
- Description of minor characters deaths
- Mentions of blood
- Mentions of depression and PTSD
- Mentions of wounds

Ready, I let you go for now :3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse IX. Sand Lines

Please, don't let them see me

Sure there's nothing left to try

I can feel the light shine on my face

Did I disappoint you?

Will they still let me over

If I cross the line?

— *The Line,* **Twenty One Pilots**

The gods are distracted.

It's an unnatural occurrence, an abnormality, the gods are usually never distracted and when they are it is because something is happening. Something, strong enough to rip their immortal gazes from themselves and their own battles and wishes, and down towards the earth just enough to gaze at what is happening among mortals' death beds.

Today, on this cold dawn of the two thousand two hundred and sixty four day of the war, the Pantheon is bent over their thrones as they stare at the blood soaked battlefield of the Etherian land. They look, with their eyes that are no eyes and their mouths that are not really mouths, throwing ethereal coins to the game fields with their soles soaked in pressed grapes and their skin scattered in golden powders.

The moon and the sun are shining in the sky today, above and beyond mortal touch in completely opposite sides from each other, just hovering with their golden and silver shimmer on the virulent red and purple sky clogged with heavy clouds of rain.

They cannot touch, the sun and the moon, reaching for each other through the war, but they still look at each other with their celestial eyes filled with tears and their arms stretched towards each other, the rays of their light brushing for each other like fingers pulled apart.

Down below, on the dry ground void of sprouts or blooms, the earth might as well burst into flames if the sun touches it, soaked in past and fresh blood that slips into the white sand and smooth pebbles at the edge of the shore.

The columns and domes of the Gayskull Palace smoke in black and grey where the fires that are not completely drowned down consume the marble and the mosaic and everything beautiful that once existed on its towers and corridors. It eats its way through tapestries of old and of new too, breaking the green and white tales of the usurper, of the Emperor; and it breaks its way through the old memories of the royal blood that once was born and grew here.

All of it, the beauty and even the destruction, seem to be of no worth for anybody's attention. No god, walking among rows of soldiers lined on the edges of the city's walls and the sea. And no mortal, cradled in lilac and silver or green and white armor, too distracted too, too ignorant to truly see the gods that wander among them.

The Lord of War and the Lady of Love, always so deeply woven to each other, stare with their dripping pearls and their blood stains on the palms of their hands and the soles of their feet.

The Lady of the Harvest beyond the walls, dripping rotten oils into the ground, her face tilted backwards with an everlasting scream. She once too lost a daughter, she once too was a mother fighting the Fates themselves.

The Lady of Wisdom, in her feathered coat and her shield of snakes also covered in blood, both golden and red, both godly and mortal,holding her spear and sword on claw-like hands as she stares without moving.

The king of gods, indescribable, unmoving, with his crown of thunder like bull horns reaching towards the skies and turning the humid air into cloud and the clouds into storm, threatening to tore it all into pieces if any of the gods intervene with the carnage going on in the shore. He will not defend nor stop his breed, neither godly or half of it, so he just stands there, between the sky and the ground. Observing.

On the floor, on what once was a Princess home and now it´s desolated land raped of all its beauty, Emperor Prime throws a slice with the blade of his sword, barely missing the armor of the Brightmoon ruler.

Queen Angella, of noble house, of strong character and even stronger will to live, grunts and turns around on her ankles, gasping when wounds already made on her skin throb and bleed.

She is surrounded, she knows herself surrounded by more evil than friend, she knows that she is not getting out of here alive. She knew it from the very moment she pushed her daughter and the rest of their army away, when she sacrificed herself for the rest of her people so they could have a chance to live, a chance to make this broken world a better one. One worthy of love and tenderness and the laughter of children. Not meant for the greed of one man.

It is said that this man has wounded a goddess. It is said that in war, about to be defeated by the interference of the Lady of Wisdom, the King of the Gods granted him godly sight so the battle would be fair. It is said that this faux emperor managed to gaze at his half sister and sliced her wrist from the thumb to the elbow and that her blood dripped into the earth like acid.

It is said that he collected in a place where it would never spill and that its possession has granted him so much power no man or god on earth could defeat him.

The Queen of Brightmoon knows she has been destined to die since a long time ago. She just fought it off as much as she could because, after all, she is human. She is mortal, and a mother. She is still alive, and a woman, she had different dreams than this nightmare, different hopes.

But for all of these things too, she has realized that she can do this, she can do this sacrifice. It will not be easy, it´s not easy now, battered in sand and blood at the feet of the gods´watch, but she will do it.

She will face the man in the middle of the hunt and she will fall so her daughter can live out of the misery he had brought with him. But she will fall in glory, in Elyseum laurels, and she will fall scarring him so he never forgets those who got away from him and who will be their doom.

Queen Angella digs her sandals on the sand and turns around, throwing her spear towards the Emperor's face with as much force as she possibly can. It´s a good throw, strong, full of meaning, but her arm is already wounded and her strength is already leaving her, slipping down her calves and neck with the blood of her wounds.

The spear does not reach Emperor Prime but it does dig itself inside the wood and metal of his shield with so much strength that the material bends like water and the sharp end crosses

completely to the other side, barely missing Prime´s right eye where it hovers in front of his face menacingly.

Prime grunts, spitting a gush of saliva and blood where his mouth has been split from side to side by an elbow to the face, the silver of Angella´s braces catching on his skin and pouring golden blood into the earth.

The sight of the godly inheritance makes people murmur, chattering on shivering teeth coursing through the rows of soldiers and commanders. But Angella pays no mind for it; for her, his godly father means nothing; for her, who he claims to be, divine gifts or not means nothing at all. He is still a part human, he still can bleed.

Angella tightens her teeth and sets her jaw and holds the spear even tighter against her hand, rushing through slippery sand to reach Prime´s side before he can react.

She jumps and voids stone and shield, her deeply purple cape dragging behind her. A last embrace of her husband, long ago lost in war. And this is it, this is the one, this is the moment where Angella goes she knows it in the very marrow of her bones. This is where she dies.

Angella throws her arm back and gives a strangled yell, full of all the fury living inside her chest, for the destruction of the world, the desolation of her people, the pain and sorrows she doesn´t even know about, she cries. Not a sob but a scream of war, a yell for all injustices and greed that makes the very gods, standing in place, to shake from the very inside.

The sharp blade of Angella´s sword cuts Emperor Prime´s face from side to side. From the high end of his right white eyebrow all the way across his forehead and nose bridge, until it reaches the skeletal skin of his left cheek and the branch of his jaw, a wound that will take shorter to heal than it will to forget, forever painted on his pristine and beautiful face that he so much adores. Staining it forever just like he did to so many others before.

Blood starts pouring from the wound immediately, rushing down the middle of his face like the waters of waterfalls that do not exist anymore. They paint everything red where they go, from his pale and once untouched skin to the heavy fabrics beneath his white armor, staining every single corner and angle in a gold so deep that it looks almost rusted. As if his godly blood wasn´t as pure and powerful as he thinks it is.

Prime gasps, surprised for the very first time on a long time. He stares back at the false Queen with hatred in his green eyes, tasting his own blood inside his mouth.

The end of his golden sword crossed Queen Angella’s entire chest, coming through her back right across the left side of her chest where her lungs and her heart rested.

The gold drips heavy with red blood, mortal and lethal, dribbling down the length of the sword and staining the silver of Angella's own armor, a strange kind of mirror from each other in the middle of this desolated war.

Prime chuckles, his bloodied face splitting for a different reason than wounds, the grin that stretches from side to side of his ears white and bloodied too as he stares at the dying queen with the kind of satisfaction of someone that knows that he has won this time.

Angella takes a shivering breath, broken and gurgling in blood, the remains of the struggle leaving her alongside her life. Her entire body goes extremely hot and then immediately cold, so much that, for a moment, she wonders if snow has started to fall on this desolate land.

“You mortals are so very predictable,” Emperor Prime mutters sore and rotten against Angella´s pale cheeks. “You and your rebellion have lost.”

Yet, right there, before she crosses the gates of death, the God of dreams saunters next to her dying body and covers her lilac eyes with his hand, quiet and cold too, granting her a vision of what is to come so she goes in peace instead.

Her daughter, alive, in a throne of not gold or silver but in a one that will guide their people into peace. The green laurel crown on her head and she looks older and worn out for the war and the loss but she looks as she is. A queen.

And then something more. Something, no, someone she doesn´t know; green land, fields of gold, sprouts of blooms and fruits. Silver eyes and ichor and golden hair. Life, tears, love. More.

Angella gasps at the declaration and her hands fall limp against her sides, spilling red blood on white sand as her head tilts down towards the Emperor still holding her bleeding body over his wounded one. Her pink and red hair frames the pale skin of her cheeks like an eclipse and the darkness of it causes her eyes to glimmer in the middle of shadows, clouded and silver like full moons.

“May your greatest sin show you how little of a man you are.” Angella speaks between agonizing breaths and for a moment she doesn´t sound like herself at all. For a moment, she sounds like every goddess resting their palms against her back. “May her pain chokes you like an invisible hand until you die”

Prime recoils violently on himself, dropping Queen Angella harshly and violently towards the floor. By the time her body meets the whitened sands, she is already gone.

In the space between mortal bodies, the Lady of Love throws her dove head back and screams until all the pains turn into sand and dust, raising with her pain and her fury the very rage of the depths of the ocean.

And the waves, who obey the dance of the moon that now disappears completely on the red horizon, start to rise, high and high towards the virulent sky until they defy themselves the violent thunders to meet them, electrifying the very ocean floor and the walls of the fallen kingdom.

One by one, all the soldiers start to scream, to howl, to run away tripping over themselves and falling over the other's bodies, fighting with all their strength to save their own lives.

Prime snaps his golden and bloodied face towards them and screams at his army at the top of his lungs. *Cowards!* He howls as if he wasn´t a coward himself. *Come back!*

The tall waves reach for the shore, wrapping their damp arms around the lifeless body of the Queen that now rests on the Elyseum like dozens before her. Her body will remain in the floor of the ocean but there will be funeral and mourning days by her daughter, and her death will fuel the fires of the Rebellion for the years to come.

Prime turns around to face the incoming waves with defiance written all over his face stained in ichor, staring and staring at the incoming ocean as if he was waiting for his father to help him again. But then again, he is still just half of a god, still half of a mortal, and in this cold morning of famish and drought, all the King of Gods does is look away.

Prime runs. Just as his men, just as his army, he runs. He slips on his own blood and Angella ´s and runs as fast as he possibly can from the fury of the gods that run in bare soles over the surface of the waters. They cannot harm him, not directly, but they can still try.

The men scatter through the lands.They run for their lives, through the meadows, the forests. The caves.

Nobody guards their entrances.

The Gods are distracted.



Catra is in pain.

She wonders, deep within her chest, if there are just so many tears that she can cry before they are over. If for some reason exists the fraction of a limit where the tears rolling down her cheeks will finally end, and no matter how deeply and hard she aches inside, they will not resurface again.

She wonders. A fantasy, maybe, because no matter how hard she tries to, she just cannot seem able to stop.

At least they are quiet, the way in which they appear and roll down. At least they do not wreck her entire body anymore, bending her in half with the strength of the sobs or the heartache of the whimpers ripping their way through her chest and her mouth. At least, it is a small mercy.

They are there though, she knows. She feels them running cold down her cheeks, pooling in the fall of her chin and collarbones and hiding themselves among the wrinkles of her tunic like little traitors. They are unstoppable, one after the other, for some reason Catra doesn´t seem able to stop them anymore, nor for a single second.

So she let´s them be, it´s the only way. If they didn´t came naturally off the corners of her eyes and down her face, she might as well just undo herself completely from the seams. She might as well curl into the cold mosaics of the temple and shiver until there is nothing more of her; until she becomes nothing else but a little tile broken in the middle, mingling her

limbs with the olive branches and her body with the marble. Until she is no more but a different kind of statue, drowned in silence.

She lives in tears, though. For three whole days, Catra does not sleep and she doesn´t stop crying either.

The cavern becomes cold, humid, all the warmth of the spring leaving the stone walls and the waters and the trees until it feels like winter again. Worse than that, bringing with it cold airs and freezing the frail surface of the lake into ice that will break in pieces if you stand over it.

It sticks to Catra´s skin like a second body, enveloping her in a perpetual shiver that is born from the very middle of her chest to her limbs and neck and head, submerging Catra into an unstoppable headache. Catra curls over her own aching body over the empty cot of the tree bed and tries to close her eyes but she doesn´t seem able to go to sleep no matter what.

During the day, Catra wraps herself in Adora´s chiton, holding it as close to herself as she possibly can, trying to bring back some of the warmth. She recognizes it from her own by the embroidering her own hands had done over the broken parts, counting the tiny dots with the pads of her fingers, each one a quiet confession done with hope, and hating herself with every single one.

How stupid she had been, truly. So naive, so selfish. Out of all the things Catra could have done, she had broken the most sacred of all. She had stepped over a line very clearly painted between them. She had broken Adora´s trust, taken it knowing the root of her pain and her fears and how deeply they ran inside her chest, and still betrayed them after all.

Catra had been selfish, as always. And she had lost it all again, as always.

But she thought, oh how she thought. After so long, after so many months together, carefully stepping around each other´s lives, precariously taking care of this sweet life they had built together in the place and circumstances they had been given, Catra thought she was right.

She thought she could do this, that they could do this together, that love would meet love and it would be alright because they would be together to face the end of the world if needed.

Catra thought and she was wrong. She failed to understand that maybe, just maybe, Adora´s pain weighed bigger than any kind of love could ever be. They were friends, they cared for each other, they looked after each other but Adora´s heart was still a secret for Catra, held around walls of past betrayal where Catra was not allowed to take root.

She failed to understand that maybe, surely, painfully and maybe, Adora didn't want her back. Not like that, not like this. That even with all the love of the world, maybe Catra was simply just not enough.

It's the uncertainty the one that hurts Catra the most. It´s not knowing and not understanding either, the one that turns her dreams into nightmares and her nightmares into sleepless nights. Nights without sounds, without singing, without laughing, without whispered nothings between secret places.

So many terrible things have happened but Adora´s silence seems to be the worst of them all.

There was silence before, when they barely knew each other and Adora was scared of Catra and Catra did not know the reasons why. That silence, it made her frustrated and mad, but Catra understood it after a while, even before she knew everything that had happened to Adora before. All the reasons that had hurt her and traumatized and that Catra could not fix for her but that she tried to make it easier too.

This silence is different, heavier, a thousand times sadder. It's the kind of silence where she doesn´t know anything else but grief and where Catra can´t do more but to sit in the cold ground of the cave with her sightless eyes burning by the tears and cry.

Catra wishes she could be mad right now. That she could be angry enough as to tear the blankets and the bed into pieces with her sharp nails and shatter the cold mosaics under her feet. She wishes she could be mad enough to curse Adora´s absence and scream that it's alright, that she can hide away and be silent and Catra won´t care. That she can live without her.

But it would be a lie.

“Adora,” Catra would say, her voice echoing in the sudden emptiness of the once tender place, returning to her with her own voice until she hates it. And suddenly she understands Echo, in love and deemed for solitude, sitting at the edge of reflections she cannot see.

“Adora,” over and over again, not begging her to return, not asking her for an explanation, not wanting to know, just desperate to hear her voice again.

“Adora,” until the name becomes a sound and the sound becomes a breeze and Catra´s voice turns sore around the dryness of her throat and she is unable to speak more because it feels like ripping the frail cords of her voice.

Catra cries silently, speaks to nothing until her own voice drowns down and all she can muster is the frail try of a gasp. She places plates for Adora filled with meat and fruit on the edge of the frozen lake and waits with her ears pressed against the sides of her head and her fingers against her eyes until the light of day gives way to the night and the food remains untouched. And Catra remains by herself.

It's the kind of silence that makes Catra feel utterly and deeply alone.

The kind of silence that scares her.

Catra hides her face in the wrinkles of Adora´s chiton and breathes on the lemongrass hanging from every single strand until she feels like little by little it washes away too by the dampness of her own tears.

She sits in the cold moss wearing Adora´s clothes and wishes she could take everything back. Digs her nails around the frail skin of her eyes and draws shallow lines over them and wishes she could have stayed as it was before; that it had been enough, just holding Adora´s hand. It was enough.

She wishes she had not wanted for more because she knows now nothing will ever be like it was before.

On the beginning of the fourth day of silence, Catra wanders inside the cave. She leaves the cold cavern before and steps into the even colder cave, her soles slipping on the moss and stone floors where she has forgotten her cane somewhere in the temple.

She welcomes it though, the small ache on the skin of her feet. It helps her not hate herself for taking her own emotions to the extreme, for always letting what she feels run too deeply until everything aches more than what she can bear. It distracts her from thinking, it distracts her from feeling herself like not enough to be able to deserve Adora.

Catra feels the pieces of stone with her toes and doesn´t push them aside, coming face to face with the twin columns where she had met Adora for the very first time. They have grown thinner in the year Catra has been here, crumbling more in the ends but wrapped almost completely from the base and up with moss and branches heavy with the smell of grapes.

In fact, if Catra would´ve be able to see it, she would find out that with her presence living and breathing in this place, the once cold and sad cave has become a sea of green grass on the floor, tall enough to brush the middle of her calves even though the sun cannot possibly reach it.

She cannot see it, but every single statue of new or old, crumbled or still standing, is surrounded by the same branches and moss, by the same tiny blooms and fruits, turning the dark and gray into green and alive.

She never got to see it but if she could have she would have knows just how many times Adora used to wander in here through the year, in the moments where Catra was distracted or asleep, just to catch a glimpse of a place that once had been a prison and that now was almost an oasis.

But then again Catra does not know that. What she does know is the sounds of the cave, gloomy, dripping with cold water from the stone roof, cold at the touch even though she has just walked among dim sunlight. All that she knows is the sound of stones shuffling against each other as they are pushed aside and the snap of branches from the cave´s entrance.

The gods are distracted, Catra is distracted too for different reasons.

The breathing comes almost as fast as the steps. Heavy, humid, filled with desperation.

For a moment, Catra´s tormented heart thinks they might be Adora´s, fighting her way where Catra is, but Adora knows Adora´s steps and the weight of her body moving through the stone walls. She knows the cadence of her breath, the smell of her skin, the echo of coin bracelets around her wrists and her waist. Catra knows them all by heart.

She knows this is not Adora in a heartbeat and by that moment it's already too late.

The man grunts, cursing under his breath as he trips with the tall grass and the loose stone the further he makes it inside the cave. He clanks, not jingles like Adora, but echoes with the

sound of armor pieces crashing against each other, maybe broken, maybe still held tight with leather Catra cannot be sure.

The only time she met armors directly she was dragged in here, she can still smell the sweat and the animal skin in the back of her throat, as a fragment of a memory. This man screaming in frustration and slamming the back of a weapon against the statues until it rings inside Catra ´s eardrums smells exactly the same. Rotten, heavy, disgusting, like a corpse, like blood.

He is close, way too close. Catra can hear him struggling barely a few meters away from her. She hopes and relies on the shadows that should be covering her and presses herself against the crumbling columns, covering with her body the entrance towards the cavern behind her.

She can feel the soft breeze coming from it, if she is quiet enough she can hear the sound of the waterfall falling against the ground and chirp of the birds flying around. She cannot risk it, if she moves from here and hides somewhere else, he might just stumble inside. He might just find Adora and Catra rather die before that.

Catra opens her eyes as far as she can, cursing the immediate shadows and shapeless forms that meet her. There is no light in here, not enough coming from the entrance of the cave for her to distinguish better shapes. Her ears twitch and turn in alert, pressing immediately flat against her back when she hears the man stop for a moment, gasping and panting heavily.

Catra waits with her heart in her throat, hoping the man doesn´t know where he is at all, hoping he has just stumbled in here and now that he has found the cave empty he will leave. She doesn´t realize that, for this man, this is the first time he sees the green of grass in five years; she doesn´t realize that for him what he has come to look for is not refugee or food but something more.

“Where are you?” The man spits, the smell of his breath filling the air. “I know you are here, monster! Face me!”

Catra gulps, closing her eyes quickly to stop the sting of tears. She doesn´t know if Adora can hear the yells inside the cavern, wherever she has hidden into, but for a moment Catra is grateful. Grateful that Adora has retreated into the furthest corners of the cavern where she has the upper hand, where this man cannot find her.

“They speak about you, you know?!” he spats, slamming something against a statue until it breaks under the strength of his angry scream. “The whore princess who killed her own family. So horrid, so ugly and horrible that facing you might actually kill you. Well I´m not like any of them, uh!”

Catra holds her breath, digging her sharp nails against her own chest until she feels them catching on the skin of her collarbones and sting when it breaks into beads of blood. She bites into her tongue, fighting back a scream of hate swirling on the base of her throat.

“I will not leave,” the man threatens, laughing loud and excited. Desperate. “No matter where you hide, I will drag you by the hair if I need to and I will present you to Emperor Prime as a trophy of war. He has killed the Brightmoon queen, he has won, and he will reward me once she finds out I have tamed the one thing that causes him fear.”

Catra tilts her head to the side, her clouded eyes fighting the shadows, tail wrapped around her ankle and her ears high, studying the man. He is tired, he sounds like he has fought his way here. There is water dripping from him, maybe from stumbling from a lake or an ocean, she cannot know. And when she walks, he rests his weight deeply on his right side, the left dragging very very softly behind him. He is wounded, lightly maybe, but wounded.

“I know you are hearing me, beast. I'm going to tear this place into pieces and I will find you. And after I'm done with you and your spoils you will walk out of this place with me and feed me as the Emperor crowns me.”

Catra sets her jaw, frowning deeply as she bends down and searches among the tall stems of grass for a fallen spear, tall enough to reach the top of her head. She feels the end with her fingertips and finds it sharp still, void of the copper end but with the golden metal sharpened and it might just be enough.

She can do this, she has been taught to defend herself. She is smart, she is quick, a magicat. A daughter of the gods, a woman.

She is in love. A man is wandering on the entrance of Adora´s safety and home, seaking for her like a rabid wolf but Catra is here now. Right here standing between him and her. No matter how badly Catra´s heart might break for their separation, Adora is the one thing she would defend with her own life.

“Well?!”

Catra clenches her teeth and steps out of the column, facing the place where the man's face is coming from. Her eyes are wide open even though she cannot see a thing, her back strained straight and her shoulders thrown back, holding the spear next to her both as an anchor and a threat.

Catra hears the gasp of the man in front of her and she frowns, her whole face falling into displeasure.

“Leave,” Catra spats, calm, louder than a whisper, unmoving from her place.

There are things she cannot know, things she cannot perceive without her eyes. In these things, there is the way the man holds his breath and stumbles back just a step, not by fear from the golden spear on her hand, but by the sight of her.

In these things, Catra cannot know how she looks, standing among green ad shadows, golden like a sun of her own. She cannot see the fall of her hair brushing the back of her thighs, or the dark ribbons with which she holds the loops off her face. She cannot she the dark blue of her tunic held with golden wings over her shoulder, nor the fall of the skirt around her legs.

She cannot see her own face, partially hidden by shadows, illuminated by the phosphorus and the quartz of the roof and the walls, bright, beautiful, the most beautiful the pathetic man in front of her has ever been. She is the most beautiful creature his rotten eyes have ever laid sight on and it's dangerous, the beauty no matter how terribly threatening it might be when Catra turns the spear on her hands, pointing the lethal end towards his face.

It´s a common reaction, staring, a mortal filled with wonder as it stares at the face of someone like Catra who is half a god all on her own, standing as a fraction of divinity in the middle of a cave that for some reason has live in it unlike the desolated land beyond the entrance.

The man sputters, his eyes traveling from her face scattered in golden freckles to the spear and back up, lingering horribly on the fall of her chest hidden beneath the fabric of the chiton.

“A woman?” he chuckles, incredulous, licking the roof of his mouth with his dry tongue. “That's it? After all those tales you are still *just* a woman?”

Catra bites into the inner side of her cheeks until she feels the taste of blood against her gums, holding the body of the spear with so much strength her hands go numb.

“Leave. There is nothing for you here”

It´s cold, a freezing breeze coming from the entrance of the cave and turning everything into a faux winter. Catra shivers around it when it licks against her bare skin but she endures it and holds the weapon as hard as she can, clicking her tongue against the back of her teeth.

The man gurgles around his own laughter, bending over himself with the strength of his cackles. The awe of Catra´s presence has worn out, leaving behind something much darker and greeder, lingering his gaze on the fall of her shoulders and the golden bracelets around her wrists.

“Unbelievable,” he mutters, ignoring her completely. “Wait, wait are you saying that the Medusa is nothing else but a simple woman? Is this what everyone is so afraid of? A pretty cunt in a cave?”

Catra cringes, fighting the urge to bend over herself and barf. Her entire body is covered in a cold sweat, sticking the fabric of her clothes, Adora´s clothes over her chest and back, barely managing to hide the real shivering of her limbs below the skirt.

No matter how strong and smart and brave she is, she is still scared. How could she not?

“I'm warning you,” Catra repeats, a threatening growl rising in the back of her throat, bristling the fur of her tail where it lashes from side to side over the floor.

“So what? Weren´t you supposed to turn men into stone with only a glimpse? And yet, I´m still here.” He is not afraid of her, the man. She doesn´t even know his name but she doesn´t think it matters either. Not when she can feel his gaze over her like a predator looming over a piece of meat he thinks he has the right to eat. “You are very pretty, you know? Is that how you do it? You tempt the men that come down here and then kill them? It´s a nice trick but it won´t work on me”

The man moves, so suddenly and quickly that Catra´s ears take a second too long to understand what is happening. Catra takes a sharp breath and moves too, trying to place his location again by the sound of his rapid panting somewhere around the columns.

It´s tricky and exasperating and it makes Catra terrified, the sudden loss of control when she can´t do more but to stand there praying on every single one of her senses to not fail her, not right now.

Sparring with Adora was fun, full of laughter. This is different, Catra is not trying to throw Adora off her feet just to hear her giggle, she is standing between greed and a place that she has called home, a person Catra has now called home and even as much as she tries for it to not stop her, her eyes still betray her, gazing towards the wrong direction when the man moves again.

“Oh. You are blind, aren´t you?” he exhales, laughter sewn on every single of his words, making Catra shiver in fear. from head to toe. He moves from side to side like a venomous snake hunting for its next prey,watching in delight as Catra´s eyes miss him every time. “You are fucking blind”

Catra holds and horrified whimper, holding the spear in front of her as her ears start twitching violently next to her head, searching and searching for him among the sudden sounds inside the cave that make her unsure and distracted.

Stones scattered all around and armor clashing against each other, the ground being clawed suddenly and the sharp and metallic sounds of something as the man finds something at the feet of the death statues of dozens of men like him before today.

Catra holds herself as tightly as possible and tries not to think, focusing everything she has on herself to prepare herself for the blow to come. It will be a sword, maybe, or the body or a spear like hers; maybe even a fist to the face or a kick she is not sure of. The promise of violence clear in the air between them as it´s her fear for everything that is happening and everything that can happen if she loses against him.

His arrival, however, it's filled with a lot more cowardice than she had expected. And Catra has never been particularly good at archery.

The arrow crosses Catra´s shoulder from side to side with a muted splash, ripping the freckled flesh of the space between her collarbones and her armpit with frightful aim. Catra feels it cold at first and then unbearable hot, warm until it´s burning from the wound to her entire arm and chest, covering her into a searing kind of pain so strong that it slams her against the force with the strength of it.

Catra´s knees meet the ground when she crumbles down, exhaling in both surprise and agony as she feels both the body and the tip of the metal arrow moving inside her flesh, the brush of something slim and rough governing above her dirty and bloodied knees before she understands what is happening among the haze.

Before the man grabs the opposite end of the rope he had knotted around the end of the arrow and pulled off it and Catra´s entire body with it, ripping golden ichor on the green grass and white marble around them.

“Ah!”

Adora never wants to hear Catra´s cries. Not ever again.

Loud and liberating or quiet as a shadow and a thousand times more painful, Adora never wants to hear them echoing inside the walls of this cavern or anywhere else. She would trade her entire body and soul for the promise that Catra won´t have to spill her tears and turn her pain into dust to alleviate the sadness inside her chest.

Adora would trade her own life and rip her eyes out of her head if that way she could take back all the pain that her own has caused Catra the last three days. She would give herself completely just to fix a single second of fear clogging her chest and throat like the reminder of a pain Adora doesn´t seem to be able to look past.

She is aware that hiding here is not going to fix anything. She curls on the tall branches of the trees, on that secret space where promised flowers and bluebirds live, making herself a bed and a home from their feathers and their leaves.

She is so close to the open domes that the freezing drizzle and the air fall completely over her, but even then Adora does not climb down nor leave this place, wrapping herself on her own and setting her jaw locked to hold back a shiver and a sob too.

She has no right to cry, after all. And Adora is not well either, she has known this truth for a long, long time, No matter how long has passed, or how deeply Catra´s care for her has run, or how desperately Adora wishes to be better, healthier, less scared, she simply is not. And sometimes she cannot handle any of it.

And for a moment too she is scared that Catra is going to wander in here too, that she is going to chase Adora all the way here, asking her for an explanation or the apology that Adora completely owns her. And Adora is afraid because she knows that if that happens her heart is not going to be able to handle it, not right now, and she might push Catra away in such an irreparable way that it will break them both completely.

So Adora stays here, in this little hidden nest that Catra had created and taught her in the very first place, laying on her side over twisted branches and unable to fall asleep to the sound of Catra´s quiet sobs somewhere in the cavern.

Adora is filled with shame by them, by every single tear that Catra has shed for Adora´s fault, but she just doesn´t know how she could ever explain to Catra. How could she ever tell her the turmoil that still lives inside of her. Not only tangled to the existence of the serpents of her head or the venomous curse of her eyes, but hung to her very body, dug on every single cell of her skin and organs so deeply that Adora might never be able to pull it out completely.

Adora doesn´t know how to explain to Catra without filling her with her shame for her words, that for such a long time she has believed and known her own body as stained. Stained by greed. Broken, bent, pushed, marked, changed, twisted. Wrong, *wrong* until Adora saw her own skin and didn´t recognize it.

Doesn´t know how to say that this is the very same body the one that caused her agony, the one that twisted others' perception of her until she was an object of beauty and desire and not a person.

It might have not been the red dress of the defiance, it might have not been her fault but it still was a conduct of it. A way to punish her for a mistake she had not committed by making her afraid of the only thing that should make her feel safe. Her own body, her own legs, her own hands, her own womb, her own face.

That she had not felt not known love and care until Catra arrived to this place, bringing with her the green and the sun, and that it was all just so marvelous that it made Adora forget how deeply broken she was, it made her forget that she had been diminished and humiliated into nothing but a monster, a piece for gods and mortals to play. That Adora had forgotten the meaning of being loved without being asked for anything back.

That she doesn´t know how to allow herself to be cared for. Not when she is aware every single second of all of the cracks in her soul and her body. Not when she doesn´t know if she might crumble any second under the weight of it all.

Make her understand that embracing Catra, holding her, *kissing* her after so many years waiting for her and wishing for her was the single most beautiful thing Adora has ever known. That Adora hadn´t known something more wonderful than the brush of Catra´s tongue against hers, more sweet than the press of their noses together, more desirable than her exhales against the back of Adora´s throat. Like kissing a sun, like drinking from ambrosia, like being wrapped into adoration.

Adora doesn´t know how to face Catra´s beautiful and everlasting sorrowful face and confesses to her that Adora could live a thousand lives in Catra´s lips. Set a thousand ships for the feeling of her hand around her waist and still decide to remain home just for a moment longer with her. That she understands the heroes on her poems and at the same time she doesn´t understand them at all because why would you give up the love of a woman for glory alone?

Adora doesn´t know how to tell Catra that she loves her too. So much, maybe even more, but that she doesn´t know how to let herself be loved in return. That she is scared to turn Catra´s love into stone by sooner or later not being enough in a world where Catra deserves more, where she could find so much more.

So much better than what Adora can give her, in this place where she can never see anybody else, where she would mean death and pain for everyone else. Where she cannot offer Catra a warm home, a welcomed neighborhood, the tenderness of good friends. Where she cannot give to Catra the festivities of a wedding or the warmth of a child.

Adora doesn´t know and she doesn´t know how to learn so she lays on her back, facing the sky through the open domes, allowing the serpents to twist and pull from her until her scalp aches, almost as if urging her to stand up and move but not strong enough to make her rise up until they too are worn out and exhausted.

Adora grunts and bats them away, narrowing her eyes at the violent sky above her head, clouds of thunder hiding the clusters of stars right beyond them. Feeling errand snowflakes stick to her cold cheekbones and freeze her skin until it's red and aching, a twisted mirror of the sun makeup she used to love and that now marks her skin in scars and flakes.

Adora stares almost without blinking and without sleeping and wonders if this is her doing too, if she has somehow managed to turn the very skies into stone, afraid of her and of what she can do.

Heal me, she thinks, silently begging at the dark sky and whoever might hear her even if she knows since long ago that she has been forsaken. *Heal me, make me right again so I can be with her.*

And when she thinks it, begs it, it's not only about her curse.

Adora hums, low on under her breath. She misses Catra´s voice and songs like a second heartbeat so Adora sings them, shivering and unsure and broken in all places, afraid that if she doesn´t she might actually forget them completely.

She has lost the past of time, unsure of how many dawns and sunsets have come and gone by now. Somehow somewhere inside of her there is something that is restless, that cannot seem to settle no matter what she does. Even the serpents sizzle and curl over themselves with pain, tangling on the branches and slamming their small head with each other to chase it away. It is scratching on the center of her chest, crawling its way out past her throat and mouth into a quiet and confused whimper.

For a moment Adora wonders if she is actually dying. If this is it and her heart will actually give up on her and stop beating all together. But the moment goes on and on and Adora realizes that no, this must be something else completely.

There is a dove in front of her. Adora frowns at the sight of her, wondering if the bird is actually there or she has finally gone completely insane for Catra´s absence.

No, not a dove or maybe both. A colorful bird, huge with the feathers if her tail scattered in emerald green and blues. A crowned peacock that swirls in the air and then saunters down, hovering right above Adora´s head but just out of reach from the dome and it is enough for Adora to realize that this is real and happening. A white and emerald peacock is flying among snowflakes with her wings painted in red is looking at Adora.

Look down, Adora thinks she hears inside her head, sweet like a bell yet still hammering against her temples like a war horn.

Adora, look down, it repeats, over and over again, pulling from the very strings of Adora´s heart until she is gasping, crawling on her palms and her knees to stand up.

Adora´s legs are shivering violently when she rests her entire weight over them but she pushes through, following the now quiet voice. She faces the strong branches instead, wrapping her hands as strong as she can around their wide barks as she starts to make her way down them as quickly as she can.

She doesn´t stop to think about the absurdity of what she is doing or in how sudden it seems to be, because suddenly her throat has seized itself into a tight knot urging her to come back now, right now or else it might be too late. For what, she doesn't comprehend.

Her bare soles slip several times on the trees and she almost falls more than too many times but she finally makes it to the flat surface of the secret garden, the smell of fruits and cold surrounding her immediately.

Adora snaps her head from side to side, scanning the cavern around her with avid eyes, uncaring if she is making too much noise as she starts walking through as fast as she can.

The waterfall is still as strong as ever but the fog that rises out of it when it meets the ground is so much colder than it was before, burning the grass and the moss surrounding it into something darker and drier. Adora looks to the side and sees both looms, empty and forgotten with fabrics and embroidering right left hanging right in the middle; just as it is the fireplace, with the fire long burnt out and the pillows lonely.

A strangled gasp of panic seizes Adora's throat, faced directly with the solitude and quiet of the cavern as she had not seen it in many, many months.

Her eyes immediately fall over the temple where all the oil lamps and candles have for some reason been blown out, choking Adora with the realization that Catra might actually be *gone* as she starts rushing from a walk to a run across the cavern.

She steps on the edge of the lake, but instead of fresh water like the one she had crossed when she walked away from Catra,all Adora finds is a frail layer of ice that breaks immediately under her weight, tumbling her down into freezing water.

Adora gasps at the feeling, immediately panting as the water soaks into her purple tunic from the hem to the waist. She clenches her teeth and makes her way across the lake anyway, breaking the pieces of ice still lingering on the surface with her bare hands and pushing them aside until she is able to reach the other side.

She slides a little on the mud, tripping several times with her own feet but she manages to stand up and by the time she does she is already sprinting towards the temple, leaving footprints over the mosaics.

The tree bed is empty and unmade at the pillows and canopy are pulled aside just enough to let Adora know that there is nobody here. Adora frowns, nibbling on her bottom lip nervously as she scouts the entirety of the temple in search of Catra and not finding her in a single corner.

Adora steps outside again, standing in shivering feet on the steps of the chamber, facing the quiet cavern with her heart on her throat.

“Catra?” Adora asks for her, flinching at the pleading and scared tone hammered on every syllable of her voice. No answer is returned to her.

Maybe she's actually gone. Maybe she got tired of waiting for Adora and turned around and left. Stepped back into an unknown world to search for something else. She said she loved Adora but maybe, just maybe, not even all the love in the world was enough for Catra to actually want to stay here with Adora to the ends of the world. Maybe she had a change of heart.

Adora would not blame her, but the mere thought it hurts. It's selfish of her, who pushed Catra away in the very same place, but it hurts so much that it almost pushes her to her knees over the ground. It hurts so much that for a moment it feels like a real wound, made with a real weapon, scattering red and firing heat across her entire chest and her left arm.

Adora opens her eyes a single slit, narrowing them around the sudden pain as she presses her palm flat against her shoulder. It is then when she sees it, right there in front of her, the red fabric of Catra´s hemation folded near the cold fireplace and the plate of fresh food left next to it.

And not only that but blankets and pillows and clothes, all carefully clean and folded and waiting for Adora to decide to come out of her hiding spot and take them if she wanted. A quiet offering and a sweet demonstration of care from Catra, even in Adora´s cold silence.

If this is here it means that Catra must not have given up in Adora. If this is here, it means that she is still here, somewhere, roaming sadly the place as she waits for Adora to come back.

Adora rushes quickly through the cavern again, leaving the food and the clothes behind for a moment longer. She can take them later, if they are still offered to her and needed, but right now there is only one place left here where Catra might have gone and Adora is suddenly eager, unable to hold herself back as she approaches the entrance towards the cave outside.

There are sounds here, yes there are.

There are sounds, yes, but they are not familiar. Not singing, not whistling, not happy.

Movement, hits, grunting, *voices,* all of them coming like little promises of horror and traveling across the gray and white stones of the corridor. They make Adora immediately weary and immediately scared, freezing her to the very marrow of her bones with confusion and filling the chambers of her heart with red blood poisoned with the fear of a familiar sound mingled among all of the first ones.

Adora narrows her eyes, stepping closer to the entrance.

Catra is screaming.

Catra digs her nails in soft flesh and tears down, opening slashes of red that bleed immediately after with her touch. It splashes on her beautiful and terrified face, clustering her eyelashes in red clots and filling her mouth with bile.

The man grunts, gurgling around a scream of pain when the wound burns across his entire face, scarred for life by the hands of the woman struggling like a furious spirit on his hands. He is lucky, actually, to not die in that very moment because if Catra had actually been able to see or distinguish the shapes around her, she would have dug her sharp nails on his neck and ripped his carotid clean. He is lucky.

He is lucky too, because the magicat is wounded and bound to him from the rope still wrapped around the arrow stabbed on her shoulder, keeping her in place when she turns around and tries to make a run for it, falling hard and violent against the rough floor when the man pull back from her like a wounded animal on a leash.

He is lucky he is a coward, humiliating a woman who cannot see as he fights her fists, bites and spits to drag her more and more across the cave until the entrance of the cave is nearer for him to see.

Catra feels it too, the change of air as she is pushed and tossed towards the entrance too. The way the cold breeze seems to transform into something warmer, stickier, hot in a different way to the one she is used to in the cavern.

It sticks to her clothes like the blood actively running from her wound, carving paths on her forearm and wrist and the side of her wide, dripping over her bare feet covered in scratches and the very ground.

She is dizzy, nauseated in a way that would bring frustrated tears to her eyes if her entire body wasn´t pumpkin adrenaline with the alert of fight and flight from this place right now. And she is scared, no, she is terrified, cursing on her veins like ice itself and making a home in the middle of her chest and her very heart. Catra is scared, she is wounded and dizzy and this man is in such a haze of triumph that she cannot shake him away no matter how deeply she digs her hands on him, and she is scared.

“Get off me!” Catra screams at the top of her lungs, ripping her own vocal cords in half as she digs her ankles on the ground and shakes herself away. “No! Get off me!”

Even the grass and blooms around seem to be fighting alongside her. Catra feels their roots snapping like serpents' heads and wrapping themselves around her ankles and calves, desperately trying to anchor her to whichever piece of rock or marble they can find.

They pull and pull from her, scratching her skin and painting purple bruises on her ankles until the man looks down and sees them, stomping against them with his spiked sandals and a click of her tongue over and over again until they are nothing more but squished pieces of leaves and bark and he can pull from Catra´s entire body once again.

Catra could scream. She wants to scream, there is nothing in the world that she wants more than to throw her head back and yell, howl until she can't go anymore, until she is nothing but a tormented spirit gasping for help. To call for Adora´s name to come, to please come because Catra is wounded and scared and she is fighting as hard as she can to survive this.

She wants to, more than anything else in her entire life, but she won´t. She can´t. Because if she calls for Adora she knows Adora will come, and coming here right now would be a death

sentence all on its own.

And Catra has already decided to sacrifice herself in Adora´s name, to take her place as the Medusa in this man's eyes. That he will try to break her and will drag her to his Emperor and he will know Catra is not Adora so maybe, just maybe he will kill this man if she doesn´t do it herself first. And maybe, just maybe if Fates allow her to not break down, if she is not killed first, she will fight her way to murder him too for what he has done to Adora.

Catra has already made her decision. It does not mean that she is less afraid, it does not mean that she is not trying with every fiber of her strength to escape that fate.

Catra struggles violently inside the man's arms that paint bruises around her waist, spitting at him and throwing errand bites in his direction until she manages to free one of her arms again. This time though, instead of slashing it towards him she stretches it forwards, managing to find the crumbling end of a statue's arm that gives away on her fingers immediately.

She seizes a big piece of stone inside her palm, uncaring when it slashes scratches against her skin and spins her arm back towards the man with all her strength. The stone slams against the man's temples with so much strength that it breaks in dozens of tinier pieces, scattering all around them at the same time the man gasps in pain, blinded for a second by the sudden pain and the blood dripping heavy and immediate from the newfound wound.

In his surprise he drops Catra back into her ground and she does not waste a single second more before she is crawling violently on her hands and belly through stone and grass, breaking the path away from the man as quickly as she possibly can.

The roots and leaves meet her immediately too, covering her and her clothes and blood almost completely in moss, almost as if it was trying to hide Catra away from the man´s unworthy gaze too. And for a moment, for a long second Catra think she might just actually make it, wound and blood be damned, that she might actually manage to reach the corner of the cave where she knows Adora dumps all the past murderers weapons and seizes one with which to kill this man and push him away from both of them.

It happens rather quickly, Catra could say. This time he doesn´t even pull from the rope; instead the man throws himself completely over her, stopping her erratic movements with his hands until Catra is stuck on this patch of grass, sputtering tears and spit in her rage as she screams at him.

“Maybe the emperor will reward me if I come back with the Medusa as my woman.” He whispers sore against her ears, pressing the sole of his sandal against the side of Catra´s face, pushing her against the stones and the ground until the dirt spills inside her mouth and nose and she is choking on them.

“Fuck you,” Catra manages to mutter around a mouthful of mud and blood, cringing when the man laughs.

“You can do that for me when we are out of here. I´m always in a mood before traveling.”

Catra whimpers against the earth, closing her eyes until the spark of pain on them rivals the pounding on her head. And she gives up from her resolution a little, just a second, just enough to whisper under her breath without realizing.

“Adora,” she sobs, the word hidden around struggle when the man bends down and seizes her from the wrist so hard her delicate bones protest violently, ripping her from the arms of the earth until she is hovering inches off the ground and in front of his face. “Adora”

“Gotcha.” The man exclaims triumphantly, raising his hand in the beginning of a slap Catra cannot see come. “Now behave or I´ll *ah*— ”

The thing is that Catra has never been very good at archery, but she is excellent at listening. And this time, she does hear the arrow incoming before it is over them, crossing the entire space across the cave and digging itself against the man´s raised palm with so much strength that it breaks every single metatarsus into splinters with the arrow alone.

The sizzling comes right after.

Catra loves those snakes. She loves them because they are a part of the woman she loves, a part that might seem scary or frightful but that are actually filled with so much innocence and tenderness that it makes Catra speechless sometimes, that the mere sound of their little songs like bells makes her feel at home, safe. She loves them.

This song is terrifying, this sound is horrid. It's like a hundred vipers, a thousand cobras twisting their bodies and snapping their fauces together, dripping venom and drilling their screams like spirit's howls inside Catra and the man's brains with their fury and their rage.

This sound makes Catra´s selfish and scared heart sob out loud with relief.

The man next to the blind woman gapes in surprise, staring at her hand impaled on the arrow like he has done to Catra almost in disbelief, as if he could not begin to understand what was happening or how.

He is still holding Catra's wrist inside his palm strong enough as to threaten to break it if she loves in the wrong way, but he is distracted staring at the red blood dripping from his palm oh so different from the golden blood dripping from Catra's wound too.

And then he hears it again, less sudden than the first, much more calculated, the lethal hissing of a hundred and more serpents snapping their fangs together, eager and hungry by the smell of a coward's blood. And so much closer than before.

The man snaps his eyes towards the dark cavern, searching on every corner and destroyed statues and stone corpses crumbling around him, trying to catch a glimpse of the apex predator hunting him on the corners.

But the shadows betray him and where he thinks he sees movement there is only the fall of cold water, too quick for his eyes to catch when the hidden woman walks almost in calm from one column to the other, her dark tunic dragging behind her like a dragon's tail and her golden hand wrapped around the strong body of the *palitonos* bow in her palm.

She is crowned this woman, this creature. No, not crowned, no laurel branches around her temples or flowers. But there is gold around her head, falling heavy and long across her neck and the fall of her shoulders; moving even as they slide their bodies across the woman's forehead and her gaze, hiding her face from sight where she is purposefully avoiding the man's eyes.

The man gasps with the fear of realization and gives a single step back, still bleeding from his palm, still holding Catra´s wrist firmly inside the other one. He looks from side to side violently but he has lost the figure once again among the shadows, sowing terror inside his chest as he looks down at the beautiful but pale face of the woman that he is still holding prisoner, comprehension drowning down on him when he looks at her hair and her eyes.

“You are, you are not—”

This time when Catra hears the arrow incoming she has enough time to tilt her head away and close her eyes. The hot spray of blood splashes on her face anyway, dripping down her cheek when the man sputters a rush of blood from his mouth where the arrow has crossed his throat from front to back, cutting his voice quiet immediately.

It´s not enough to kill him, as no vital vessels or spine have been severed, but it is enough to make him close his mouth shut. It´s enough for him to know that he is not going to get out of this cave alive.

The sizzling picks up in strength again, so loud and violent that there is not a single corner of the cave where it's not heard and the very roof starts shaking menacingly, scattering stone and quartz all over the place and crushing the remaining limbs of the statues nearby.

“I would have let you live,” a woman's voice joins the hissing, tangling around the dry screams until it sounds like a queen's command and the howl of a beast all in itself. Dangerously cold, ragefully calculated, shiveringly murderous. “Like many others before you think you can take whatever you want, I would have granted you the mercy to leave this place to see another day of your fucking life but you have crossed the line”

Another arrow crossed the air, this time closer, this time less calculated and more filled with unfiltered hate. It digs it´s golden end against the man's shoulder and then another one of the fall of his ribs, right between where cartilage meets muscle and he will not bleed to death just yet.

She is not a monster, all she has ever done has been to survive and every single time it was painful and she was afraid. But she has never done it like this before, slowly, prolonging the suffering as much as she can before she reaches him completely.

She would end it much quicker, if he would just let go from Catra´s arm.

“I'm so fucking tired of all of you, thinking you can have whatever you want. Thinking you can take me. Thinking you can hurt who I love.” the woman spats, stepping into the dim faux light of the cave, her jaw set into stone and her clothes dark amongst the shimmer of gold that crowns her, growling on the base of her throat when the man panics and closes his eyes. “I've had enough.”

The Medusa was a princess once and she was trained under the teaching of the Deer Lady herself. To hunt.

Catra struggles on the man´s unyielding hold, pulling from him and digging her nails against his fingers to try and prey his hand away.

For some reason the bleeding wounds on his body seem to have done nothing but to double his resolution of not letting her go, grunting around a gush of blood as her seizes Catra´s wrists even more violently and shakes her from side to side, holding her in front of him like a human shield. As if that would protect him from the rage of the mythical creature living inside this cave.

The bones of Catra´s ankles shackle together painfully, her ears pressing down and her tails wrapping around her own legs as she grunts in anger and tries with all her strength not to cry.

“Adora,” Catra calls, twisting her entire body towards the back of the cave in a frantic attempt to reach for her. Her scared voice seems to be the only thing needed to break the frail threat of violence hanging in the very air.

The rush of steps breaks the distance so quickly that neither the man nor Catra have time to react before they are already right over them, filling the space between their bodies with the smell of lemongrass and steel and the sound of a hundred serpents hissing violently and ready to attack.

The body of the bow clanks on the sharp ground when Adora drops it sharply so she can wrap her entire arm around Catra´s slim waist, pressing her back against the front of her body with so much strength that the shielding touch steals the air from her lungs and throat.

Adora presses her palm flat over the high of Catra´s ribs and the curve of her chest, unmoving from her hold as Catra lets her head roll back immediately, tucking it on the angle between Adora´s sweaty neck and the fabric of her tunic, her arm still up and still hanging inches over the ground where the man just will not let her go.

The man hears the serpents too, immediately, screaming in terror when all of their heads shoot forward at the twitch of Adora´s mouth and start biting him violently on every single inch of flesh they can reach. They sink their fangs into cold and clammy pale skin and bite, bite, bite, injecting their venom on every single wound too until they are septic and even if he would be able to run away from here, he would not survive the night.

The man struggles like a burning corpse against the attack of the serpents, all blood and no flesh anymore when Adora slams her entire palm against his forehead, pitching the frail skin of his eyelids with her sharp claws.

“Look at me!” Adora screams, scratching his face from eyebrow to cheekbone to oblige his eyes open.

“I will go! I will go!” The bastard howls, choking on the arrow on his throat and begging for mercy now that he is at the gates of death. “Pri– princess. I won't tell anybody about you. Or her! Just spare me this time, please.”

Too late. Now Adora is mad.

“No”

Her nails finally dig into the corners of his eyelids and he cannot help but to open his eyes,bleeding scleras meeting liquid golden irises staring right down at him.

She is so terribly beautiful that it kills.

The transformation happens quickly but just not enough to be over soon. It begins from the very middle of the man's chest, spreading like moss or plague across his ribcage, abdomen and the base of the neck, up and to the sides and down until he is freezing to the bone with the deadly touch of stone touch every cell inside his body and turning it into nothing but vulgar rock. And it hurts.

The man stares down at beautiful eyes, unable to look away and starts screaming even around the arrow until his very vocal cords are nothing but strings of phosphorus and pyrite and he is breathless by it, the newfound weight crushing his lungs and wrapping itself around his heart with merciless grip.

Adora watches it all with her eyes ablaze, dripping golden tears down the fall of her chin and her jaw, rolling like rain teardrops down Catra´s bare arms.

She stares and stares until she feels her own irises burning, watching every single of it as the curse travels up the man´s face and starts to eat it´s way on his cranium like a flesh eating bacteria, killing it all away. And once it is in the cheekbones and nose, once the only thing left alive are the living and terrified eyes of the man feeling every moment of it, Adora twitches her hand and starts to press down.

Down and down until the rock that is his face starts crumbling like sand in her palm and explodes into a thousands of tiny pieces across the cave, beheaded and dead for Thanatos to decide what to do next with him.

Catra feels him go stone around her and feels the exact moment where he is no more because her entire body, pumping adrenaline frantically and holding itself tight with fight, collapses completely all around herself.

She makes another weak try to shake her arm away, his stone hand is still wrapped around her wrist.

“Adora” Catra whimpers, struggling with the stone and curling into her touch when Adora´s body drops it´s own rage and jumps into motion again.

“I got you” Adora exhales against her ears, extending her hand to break the stone off fingers without a single resistance, freeing her. “I got you, I got you. I'm here.”

Catra collapses backwards into Adora´s hold, causing them both to stumble into the grass covered ground with an exhale.

Catra gasps and curls inside Adora´s arms, immediately bringing her wounded hand against her chest in an attempt to soothe down the pain. Adora struggles for a moment as she wraps her over her lap, their legs a mess of tangled limbs and fabric and their shoulders knocking together when Adora reaches for Catra´s arm, gently moving it to the side so she can see too.

There is a truly horrid bruise already forming on Catra´s wrist, painting the dark skin into red and purple in the shape of fingers.

“Ugh,” Catra whimpers with the movement, her ears pressed so flat against the back of her head that they almost disappear around her sweating and tangled curls.

“Oh, oh, it's okay sweetheart,” Adora lulls her, gently running her fingertips over the bruise, making sure no bones are broken. “It's alright”

Adora changes their positions, running her arm underneath Catra´s shoulder blades so she can rest her weight inside her arms much better, already getting ready to carry her off the ground. It's only then that Adora feels the stickinnes clinging to Catra´s skin and running down her arm and back, staining Adora´s palms and forearms when she takes them back to stare at the golden blood soaked on them.

“Why are you bleeding?” Adora gasps horrified, turning her eyes back to Catra to observe her better. The end of the arrow is dug so deeply into Catra´s shoulder that Adora had almost missed it completely, the sharp point brushing sharp against Adora´s arms when she finds the blood soaked rope tied on the other end, still wrapped around the man´s stone hand. “Oh gods. Oh gods”

“I'm dizzy,” Catra manages to mutter, cringing when her voice comes all smudged, her tongue heavy like stuffed with cotton and honey.

“Don´t fall asleep,” Adora snaps on accident, shaking her head forcefully. She returns her eyes to Catra´s beautiful face, catching the way she looks so frightfully pale inside Adora´s palms when she cradles her cheeks with her hands.

Catra tenses a moment with the careful touch and then she breaks down, her silver eyes gathering with heavy tears and dropping into immediate sobs without being able to control them at all.

Adora stares at her crying inside her hands and starts sobbing too, the whimpers wrecking her entire body when she leans down like a second nature, pressing their mouths together.

Adora kisses her fully, wet with tears and messy. Their lips catch with each other in awkward angles and the tip of her tongues mingle with each other, ropes of saliva stretching between their mouths like reaching hands every single time they move apart for a fraction of a second before coming together again.

Catra sobs inside Adora´s mouth, her entire body convulsing with the urgent need of wrapping herself fully around her and fusing them together into one. Her shoulder and wrist and entire body is screaming in pain but for the moments where Adora wraps her palms

around her waist and brings her flush against her chest, there is no pain or the haze of suffering but mind fogging love and want.

She is surprised, she is in love. She missed Adora for three days with so much force that kissing her right now is breaking her entire world.

Adora hiccups on Catra´s mouth, running the split end of her tinge against her lips and her closed lips against the corners of her mouth over and over again until the tears can more than both of them can handle and they are both shivering, mumbling incoherences on each other's mouths.

Adora runs her hand underneath the small of Catra´s waist and the back of her knees and rearranges them both into something much safer, throwing Catra´s good arm around her neck to keep her steady.

“Hold on tight,” Adora mumbles in a threat of a voice, straining every single muscle in her body as she carries both of their weights back up, not even tilting a little bit to the sides.

The golden snakes, still stained on their faces with drying blood, shoot forward immediately and wrap themselves fully around Catra´s head and shoulders, keeping the arrow in place and pressing their bodies on the wound when it starts bleeding again with the movement.

Catra sighs around the feeling of them surrounding her, pressing her nose firmly against Adora´s frantic pulse point. Moving feels like a new kind of suffering cursing through her entire arm all over again but she bears it as best as she can, clenching her teeth tightly together to bite back a yell of pain.

She already can feel Adora shivering all around her, for very different reasons than the straining of her muscles as she carries Catra across stone scattered floors.

Adora is not very sure how she manages to hold Catra and carry her all the way inside the corridor that leads to the cavern without hurting her. Maybe some small divine mercy. But Adora does know that by the time she steps into the warmer grounds of their land she is able to sigh in relief, holding Catra flush against her chest.

Adora rushes in huge steps towards the quiet temple that has made their room, trying to ignore the trail of golden blood that Catra´s wound leaves behind them. The mosaics of the floor and the marble columns are freezing cold when Adora steps into them, stretching her arm to hold the soft fabric of the canopy and push it aside.

She places Catra as gently as she can over the cot of the tree bed, throwing herself immediately after to the sides to light up the oil lamps hanging around them, casting colorful shadows where the light hits on the crystals hanging from the branches.

Catra is a worrisome shade of pale and green, even worse than the first time she arrived here from which she still carries the scars. Her entire forearm and the inside of her palm is coated with ichor, giving away the origin of her divinity from the horrid wound that gives away the reality of her mortality.

Adora dips her hands quickly in the fresh bowl of water next to the bed and leans towards Catra again, climbing on the bed to assess the wound better, trying very hard not to panic yet.

Catra is lucky, in all the horror of today, Catra is lucky because the wound is as clean as it could ever be, the body of the arrow off polished metal so there are no wood splinters dug on her flesh. No arteries seem to have been severed by the copper head of the arrow but she has bled profusely and it´s important for Adora to take it out and stitch it back together right now.

“I have to pull it out, sweetheart,” Adora says between clenched teeth, holding her breath when Catra´s pained face melts into swift panic.

“No,” Catra says, not thinking straight, digging her fingers over Adora´s arms to support herself when her head swims with nausea. “No”

“I have to, I´m sorry I have to”” Adora urges her, pressing her cheek against Catra´s to soothe her fear.

Catra takes several deep breaths next to her, trembling so violently her teeth crash together, both by the fear and the unbearable pain. She searches for Adora´s hand around the folds of their tunics and Adora rushes to hold her right back, wrapping her other hand around the end of the arrow.

She snaps off the feathered end and cleans it as best as she can from metallic remains, leaning over Catra´s back to grasp this time the very point of the arrow, holding her breath until her lungs strain inside her chest.

“Breathe,” Adora whispers against Catra´s bristled ear, making sure she does before clenching her jaw and pulling from the entire arrow off the wound in one single pull.

“Ah!” Catra´s scream dissolves into a sob, her entire body giving up on her and collapsing the side.

The arrow stumbles bloodied and forgotten somewhere on the cot as Adora rushes to throw herself to catch Catra inside her arm, tucking her back against her chest. She grabs the end of her own tunic and presses it immediately against the bleeding wound, silently begging it to clot and knowing she has to stitch it but too afraid and too frantic to be able to steer away from Catra even for the smallest of seconds.

Catra takes a big exhale against Adora´s collarbones, her cheeks covered in tears and sweat being gently kissed by the closed mouths of the snakes singing sweetly for her alone.

Now that the arrow is gone and the adrenaline has worn off, Catra feels her entire body heavy as the very Olympus, weighing down on her and pulling her further and further into the treacherous arms of unconsciousness.

“Kiki?” Adora feels Catra slipping away from her, running her fingertips under her chin and tilting it back gently to stare at her. “Catra. Catra, stay awake”

“Is he gone?” Catra asks instead, her voice drowsy.

Adora nods furiously even though Catra cannot see her, gently cleaning the droplets of blood from her face. “He is.”

“Good,” Catra nods, running her thumb over Adora´s cold knuckles. “You're safe.”

Adora exhales, all wet from tears and desperation, staring at Catra with newfound and sudden frustration burning on her throat. “Why didn´t you call me for me? Why did you face him alone?”

Catra is mesmerizing, even pale and ichor stained, with her moonlight eyes wide open as if she was taking all of Adora´s presence inside of her, her red mouth twitching on the edge with the frail start of a smile.

“You are an idiot, you know that?” Catra chuckles, her entire face scrunching with a pained grin. “I really love you very much, you know?” she whispers, so subtle that if they weren´t pressed chest to chest Adora would have not heard her. Catra´s eyebrows twitch and knit together, sudden sorrow washing over her. “I´m sorry”

“Don´t apologize. Why are you apologizing?” Adora sobs too, her serpents tangling themselves with Catra´s matted hair as if that way they could, too, fuse them together. “Kiki”

“Sorry, I´m just— so tired.” Catra blinks once, long and slow, gently closing them back again. “I can´t sleep without you”

Adora takes a terrified breath, pressing her cheek against Catra´s, side by side, feeling her slip into the unconscious to protect her from the pain and at the same time feeling like if she lets go she might lose her forever.

“No,” Adora spats, not to Catra this time, gazing at the light creeping inside the quiet cavern, reaching with its hands towards them. “No, I refuse”

The cavern remains silent and Adora did not expect an answer back but still she says the words, spitting them inside the olive bed and the cold mosaics and the oil lamps that burn out with a swift of warm wind.

“Don´t you dare, don´t you fucking dare do this to me again,” Adora grunts between clenched teeth, biting into her tongue until she feels blood on the back of her throat. Also ichor, also god touched. “Please”

You´ll have to let her go.

It was a vision, a promise, the prophecy of a future where Adora would have to lose what she loves the most in the entire world to the Fates wishes. And as it turns out, Catra is what she loves more than anything else in the entire world.

“I'm not ready.” Adora is panting, her own heart strangling her throat and choking her with regret. “It's too soon. I'm not ready, not yet. Not like this, please”

No god can come inside this sanctuary but by the Fates Adora hopes that they are listening to her. Her first pray in so many years it´s also a plea, and they have never been good at listening to her pleas before, but she hopes they listen. She hopes her voice reaches the very steps of their cloud palaces and thunder temples and echoes around their immortal existences like a bell.

She hopes the Fates might grant her just a little more time, because if they do Adora will be with her every single day and more and she will not look away from Catra´s face ever again.



Adora is awake, curled around Catra's sleeping body like a second skin.

Her dark skin is feverish, clay with the sweat of her own body fighting against the pain of the wound and numbness of the same. She trembles every once in a while inside Adora´s arms, grunting and whimpering against the damp sheet below her, her hands holding themselves to Adora´s wrists as strong as she can.

Adora caresses the bandages around her wrist and shoulder with her thumb and observes in silence most of the day and night until she feels the fever finally give in under her hands.Adora sighs and rests her forehead over Catra´s spine, right in the middle of her bare shoulder blades where her skin is scattered in freckles.

When Catra wakes up again, Adora moves around the temple´s chamber in soft steps, collecting things scattered all around them to tend to Catra´s wounds. The temple is submerged in colors and sounds, so much that the inside of the chamber looks like casted in sunset shimmers.

Oranges, yellows, pink like reds and purples fall over the branches of the bed and the canopy, washing it all in them from where they bounce in the windchimes hung from the very same branches, made by careful hands with the broken pieces of old bottles and jewelry that had been left to rot inside this place long time ago.

Catra cannot see the colors but she can hear the jingle of the windchimes above her head, pushing away the silence that had been plaguing the cavern for days now. They mingle with the sound of the serpents stubbornly reaching for her, curling around her wrists and fingers and pulling from Adora´s scalp when she gets too far away.

She sits on the soft fabrics of the sheets, still aching and exhausted, and feels Adora´s hands run over hers, painting unknown shapes on her skin with the tip of a gentle brush. From the tip of her fingers to the back of her knuckles and palms and all the way across Catra´s bruised wrists, whispering under her breath to quiet things Catra cannot really understand.

So remains very still instead, breathing through pain and fever, pushing away the confused and overwhelming thoughts gathering on the very back of her head just so she can allow herself a longer moment of gentleness around Adora´s hands.

Adora gathers yellow blooms and stems filled with pollen from the gardens; and she climbs the tall trunks to gather propoleum and honey from the gentle bees living in the fig trees. She collects them inside clay bowls and grinds them all together with the last remains of turmeric powder in the cavern until they are a single yellow clay.

Adora breaths deep through her mouth and dips her entire hands inside the yellow clay, soaking them with it as she raises them back. She rests her palms over Catra´s bare ankles, circling the fall of her feet and the arch of her soles with her fingers before dragging them all the way up towards Catra´s knees, painting yellow paths on her way.

Catra gasps at the touch of the cold clay and Adora´s even colder palms but she doesn´t flinch, somehow locked into place by the touch alone and the calm sound of Adora´s barely composed breath. Not for the first time in the hours that have happened since that man wandered inside their lands, Catra wishes from the very bottom of her guts that she would be able to see Adora´s face only so she could know what she is truly feeling underneath her barely contained calm.

“Adora?” Catra risks instead, perceiving the different sources of light with her eyes open.

“I'm here,” Adora answers immediately, calm but with her hands still moving. This time she lingers them over Catra´s palms, all around her wounded wrists and up, *up,* past forearms and elbows until she can reach the fall of her shoulders where she had stitched Catra´s flesh together once again, a pain that Catra did not feel on the unconscious.

Adora covers the entire wound with the yellow clay, past the rope and the reddened and blotchy skin, never once stopping until she covers the columns of Catra´s neck too and runs the length of her fingers right below her chin, painting her entire skin in yellows and goldens.

“What are you doing?” Catra asks, sighing when her body breathes in relief at the touch of the unknown clay, lifting the pain off her shoulders and allowing her to breathe.

“Just a little bit of medicine, so you can sleep.” Adora explains, pressing her thumb right in the middle of Catra´s chin and her lips, leaving the print of her fingers on her skin. “A lot of people used to arrive at the palace, from many many places around the world. Macedonians, ethiopians, egyptian heralds, bharatas and beyond. They would visit all of Greece too, not only Etheria. From the oceans of Salineas to the Plumeria Meadows.

Adora moves, resting on her knees instead of sitting on the ground just so she can reach Catra ´s face, hovering above her almost completely. She feels Catra holding her breath below her, her hands twitching at the sides and almost knocking down the bowl with clay that Adora had placed over the bed.

“Some of them were merchants, or warriors. Scientists and scholars.” Adora presses her thumbs over Catra´s forehead, right below the roots of her hair, lowering them down across her thick eyebrows and freckled cheek. “Some were physicians. I liked to hear their stories and learn from their experience, they knew so many things from many places. Like how to heal wounds or to ease the pain of the body.”

Adora´s eyes travel down for a second, distracted by Catra´s half opened lips and her silver eyes finding Adora´s face through her voice. Her clouded irises reflect Adora´s face like mirrors, returning her golden gaze with a thousand and more feelings written on her face.

“And the soul,” Adora ends, hovering her fingers right above Catra´s chest without getting to touch her at all.

Catra exhales against her face, her entire body alert and covered in goosebumps. Her ears are flat to the sides instead of to the back and her tail is calm, slowly raising to wrap itself around Adora´s wrists when the latter places them over the bed instead of against her body.

Without moving far away Catra finds the bowl of clay near her hip and slowly dips her fingers inside the cold inside, bringing them forwards once both of her hands have been covered by the clay too.

Adora doesn´t notice until Catra´s fingers are right in front of her face,searching her among sightless shadows. By the time Catra finds the fall of her cheeks, Adora is already trembling from head to toe, shaken up like a leaf left to drift on her own in the warm breeze.

Catra lets a shallow exhale when she finally realizes she is resting her fingertips over Adora´s cheekbones and moves them slightly to the side, finding the strong and elegant fall of her nose and crossing it too with her thumbs soaked in much warmer clay.

Unlike Adora, Catra cannot see what she is painting and she would lie if she tried to replicate the burning suns of Adora´s makeup in her cheeks and chin too. But Catra knows other things, things about Adora; like the tremble of her lips when Catra presses her hand against her mouth or the fact that Adora is in pain too, she is wounded too in another kind of way that Catra is right now.

If this is meant to heal, it might as well heal them both right now.

Catra drops her hands from Adora´s face and finds her way around her wrists instead, bringing them up and towards her own body instead of away.

Her wound is still pulsing with pain and the fresh stitches, and Adora holds her breath in surprise when she realizes where Catra is taking her, but Catra shakes her head anyway. She guides Adora´s soaked hands until they meet the skin of Catra´s collarbones and the fall of her breasts, the only part still untouched by Adora and by the clay.

Catra shrugs as best as she can from the straps of her tunic and lets it fall across her arms, drinking off Adora´s earth shaking gasp in front of her.

It might be the lingers of the fever, or something echoing in shame when Catra´s cheeks blossom in deep red but she lets them be by the sheer feeling of Adora´s hands travelling across her skin on their own, finding her quietly in other ways.

I love you, Catra had said soaked in water days ago. *I know you love me too, don´t you?*

Adora does not touch her in the most vulnerable part of her chest, not quite. But she does runs her fingers across the entire length of Catra´s sternum and all the way to the divot of her belly; and then she goes to the sides, curling the curves of her waist and up towards the sides of her ribs, tattooing yellow rivers in Catra´s skin.

By the time Catra is tilting her head backwards in search of her, Adora´s mouth is already meeting her in the middle, pressing their mouths together against spoonfuls of clay.

Catra sighs against Adora´s tongue, deliciously cold and split in the tip like a river, wrapping her hand around the hem of Adora´s tunic where her bare chest brushes gently against Adora ´s.

“Does it hurt?” Adora asks against Catra´s lips, tracing the twisted ends of the stitches with her fingertips.

Catra shakes her head, breathless and barely speechless, her mind in a fog by the touch of Adora´s so wished for mouth in hers and the slide of the serpents down the bare skin of her back. “Not now”

“Alright,” Adora rips herself from her with tremendous effort, lowering herself back down into her knees between Catra´s legs where the fabric of her tunic twists, spotted by yellow like marigolds too. “Rest, it's alright I'll look after you.” Adora whispers, tilting her cheek against Catra´s bare belly, hearing the pound of her heartbeat right against her ears. “I'll look wherever you need me to”

Then talk to me, Catra thinks, almost angry at the string of tears running down her face. *Tell me what you are feeling. Explain to me why you can´t stay with me.*

Catra gives a heavy exhale, leaning down too towards Adora. She lets her hands fall over Adora´s shoulder blades and presses her bruised and clay painted face against the bodies of the gentle snakes, feeling them hold avidly to her as if they also could not phantom tear themselves away from her.

“I need you here,” Catra murmurs instead, gulping back the ocean of words inside her mouth. “That's all”

When Adora returns to the temple on the third day after the man's appearance, Catra is already waiting for her on the main steps.

She is sitting over the blue and white mosaics of the marble steps, her hair brushing her waist in the bubble knots Adora had made for her the night before, the skirt of her tunic wrapped around her legs and the fabric falling across her chest where Adora´s hemation cradles her back and forearms completely, also spilling on the small stairs and towards the grass below.

She looks better in almost every single aspect. She is less pale and the skin around her wound and wrist are less red, less covered in deep purple. She breathes easier, and she has slept, the

lilac bag under her silver eyes less pronounced where she tilts her face slightly to the sun.

But there is still an undeniable edge of sadness in her when Adora gazes at her. Deeply rooted to the fall of her shoulders and the arch of her spine as she curls into herself over the temple´s steps, waiting with her arms crossed over her lap and her face tilted to the side for Adora to me back.

“Catra?” Adora asks quietly, her steps coming to a slow stop.

Catra´s ears drop from the sides to the back of her head, straightening her back just so she can extend her arm towards the place where Adora´s voice is coming from. “Come here?”

Adora moves immediately, dropping the dry logs of wood into the ground and crossing the distance that separates them in three long steps. She drops into her knees in front of Catra and reaches for her, hovering her hands a few inches away from Catra´s elbows.

“Are you alright? You are trembling,” Adora questions, catching the shiver clear over the skin of Catra´s arms.

Catra shakes her head, silently dismissing Adora as she raises her own arm, finding Adora´s face with so much precision that it seems she has already memorized Adora from the inside out completely.

Catra presses the pad of her thumb in the middle of Adora´s forehead, painting a clear line of the yellow clay still slightly scattered on her body over Adora´s own.

"I missed you," Catra whispers, her face unmoving. "I miss you"

The words fall like freezing water over Adora´s chest; like the frozen waters of the lake across her entire body, ripping the breath out of her. "Kiki–"

"I miss you.” Catra repeats, this time louder and stronger, snapping her hand away.

Catra raises on her feet, walking away from Adora who is still kneeling between the grass and the temple, watching Catra stepping a little bit further away before stopping completely.

“I've been thinking a lot.” Catra starts saying, lacing her hands in front of her, her back still turned away from Adora´s face. Adora holds her breath, already knowing what is to come. “About my life before this, about my life here. What I want for my life and what it´s good for it or not.” Catra turns around, her sightless eyes finding Adora and turning her into another kind of stone. “About you”

This is it, isn´t it? This is where Adora loses Catra. This is where she has to let her go

Adora feels dizzy, like the world and the stars have suddenly spinned around her and turned her entire world upside down. The knowledge that she has done this to herself makes it all so much worse because, after all, this is Adora´s doing.

The expression in Catra´s face and the wounds on her body; the defeated fall of her tail giving away just how truly tight Catra is holding herself trying not to undo herself, they are

all Adora´s fault. She caused them to both of them by being who she is, by running away, by not being able to stay.

“I'm gonna ask some questions.” Catra says, crossing through the overwhelming fear in Adora´s chest like arrows. “And you're gonna answer them,” she frowns for a moment, curling her hand into a fist against her collarbones. “I think it's fair”

Adora stands up, letting her arms fall, heavy and empty, at her sides. “It is”

Silence stretches between both of them for a long second, submerging them in uncertainty. Adora stares at Catra´s beautiful face with her heart on her throat and Catra tilts her face towards her when she hears Adora breath, the space between them growing longer and longer before Catra sliced it in two with her words.

“Tell me why you can't fall in love with me,” Catra demands, loud, politic, like a queen demanding an answer from a knight. She clicks her teeth together then, giving away for a moment the true fear beneath her facade. “The truth”

Adora could lie. She could say a thousand and one things like the thousand stories Catra has told her since she arrived, all but one unknown from those she promised to Adora. Adora could blame fear, guilt, anger; she could say ignorance or indifference.

She could say it all to Catra and end the conversation before it can even start. She could sever the fine traces of thread still joining them together and finally manage to push Catra away. Root grudge and hatred on her beautiful chest and order her to go, leave, never come back, never feel pain for her again.

She could.

But Adora is tired and she is still scared. She has stared at the destroyed face of the most recent statue on the cave for hours and has wondered if the world outside is still as virulent and dangerous as it was. Wondered if his presence here was a promise of doom or a challenge of loyalty or a wake up call.

She has looked at the newfound clear sky and the dim stars and remembered Catra´s words, soaked herself in them before the guilt and the fear overtake her. She has remembered the words told to her many years ago, plaguing her dreams with nightmares,

Adora is tired of carrying it alone. It's selfish but Adora is tired. And Catra is asking.

“A few nights before I was cursed a prophet came to me. The Oracle herself.” Adora starts trembling too, digging her own nails against the soft skin of her palms. “She foretold that I would fall in tragedy and— she foretold that I would have to lose who I loved the most"

Catra´s eyebrows twitch with confusion, her pretty cheeks flushing and then gone pale again.“Loose?”

“That I would have to let her go.” Adora shrinks into herself by the sound of her own voice breaking completely around the words. Adora wraps her arms around her own body,

embracing herself as she takes a single step back over the grass. “I know what you believe about me, Catra, but I'm still a monster. And monsters are not destined for happiness”

Catra snaps her teeth together, snapping her head away. Adora can see how very clearly she is trying to keep herself calm, her cheeks blushing immediately with the waves of anger. There are still medical patches around her shoulder, restricting her movements, and traces of yellow around her neck and her soles.

The dark swirls of the joined dots Adora had painted over her palms and wrists are a shadow over her brown skin, and Adora wonders if Catra has realized already that she has mirrored the invisible words Catra had sewn on the fabric of her hemation months ago.

Adora understands them now.

“Now tell me the reasons why you would fall in love with me.” Catra deadpans, returning her face towards Adora without a single trace of hesitation in her beautiful factions.

The world stops for Adora. For a moment Adora goes breathless, suddenly wondering if Catra can actually see her, in different ways maybe than the ones Adora knows.

Why? Oh gods, all the new and the old. Why? The words swirl in the base of Adora´s tongue and burn on the roof of her mouth and her lips, begging to be told, begging to be spoken. Adora knows them from the inside out, she has learnt them on the days and weeks and months that she has learnt Catra too, from the very first second to this one, right now.

“Before you answer me, I want to say something more,” Catra cuts Adora´s loud thoughts short, relaxing her arms again.

There are small wounds around her nails, a tale told of a bad habit of nibbling on her cuticles when she is nervous; Adora knows this because she does the same thing.

And there are scratches across her eyes, shallow, more pink than red now,a kind that will not scar but that crosses her frail skin from the eyebrow to the lachrymal. Adora saw them when she was cleaning her skin from mud and ichor with a damp cloth; she ran her fingertips over done; she knows Catra did them to herself.

“Adora, I think my whole life has been written in tragedy”

Catra chuckles, void of all kinds of actual laughter. She brings her hands towards her face and cups her face inside, composing herself before lowering them again. Adora is eager, restless with the uncontrollable need of rushing towards her and comforting her.

But this is important, it's very clear for Adora that this is important for Catra and Adora needs to respect it. It's the last thing she can do after what happened to her for Adora´s fault.

“Sometimes it seems that it wasn't and for a long time I did not wanted to be ungrateful because I was taught otherwise but the truth it that it has been fucked up from the very start,” Catra bites into her own mouth until her lips threatens to splinter in half.

“No matter how much my mother loved me she was still the embodiment of sadness. And beyond her, the gods that called me their blood and who walked around me were not there when I needed them.” A sigh, a breath caught on a throat. “I was born disabled and even now it aches until I'm sick. I was casted away from my own people.I had free will but not really, my mother suffocated me sometimes with her need to protect me and when she was gone I was the one choking myself until all of that very same free will was ripped out of me”

Adora gives a step forwards towards her, Catra takes a step back, almost like a dance.

“When I was a child, my father thought he could grant me mercy from losing my sight and from being absent by granting me to walk in dreams.” Catra reaches for her scratched up eyes, feeling her eyelashes against her palms. “And in my dreams there was the promise of someone that would be the half of my soul. Someone bright as a sun on my closed eyes. Someone that I would promise myself to.”

A weight falls inside Adora´s belly, heavy like a thousand stones, burning like a volcano about to erupt. She understands those words, she knows them. Adora had held herself to those dreams like an anchor in the middle of a storm for many years before what happened to her.

“Even in that, the gods had a hand on. Even in that, they got to mingle themselves in my life.” Catra shakes herself, smiling to herself full of sadness. And anger. “I never got to call the shots for myself, not really. I think you might understand a thing or two about that”

Adora looks all around them, taking on every single stone and rock and piece of moss. Taking on the frozen lake that has started to melt down with the warm water of the waterfall and the three trees beyond.

Taking sight in herself, on her hands scarred by the work and the fight; on her skin blotched by scars and by time. On her hair melted into serpents that curl and reach for Catra and brush the floor for how long they have grown. Yes, Adora understands one thing or two about divine intervention.

And she also feels shame. She feels shame and she feels awkwardness, the gotten claws of humiliation staining the chambers of her heart because Catra sounds angry and she looks like she is about to snap and suddenly Adora is afraid for something else completely.

She is to entangled with her own self hatred that she doesn't notice Catra walking up to her until she trips with Adora's bare feet, barely holding herself up by Adora's hand immediately coming towards her.

“But you? Oh, Adora, I adored you the second I knew about you.”

Catra's face is clean bright, so much that she can see the meaning of every single word she is saying clear and honest inside her eyes and the divot of her mouth

“I loved you from the moment I understood you were not a dream. From the very first moment I realized you were real,” Catra takes a shivering breath, matching the panting in Adora's chest. “From the very second I realized I could fall in love like everyone else. Little

by little and all at once. That I could fall in love with someone who was not a perfect dream but a friend. *My* friend."

Adora whimpers, tears gathering in the corner of her eyes and falling thick and cold like liquid gold against Catra's cheeks. "Kiki—"

"Adora, I did not fall in love with you because some gods had promised you to me." Catra speaks in front of Adora's face, running her fingers across the bodies of the serpents wrapping themselves around her hands and wrists. "I fell in love with you because with you I found the rest of myself"

Adora gasps, choking around her own silent sobs as she slams her palm flat against her own mouth, trying to keep them all silent and hidden inside her throat.

"I fell in love with you because you made the silence safe. Those are my reasons, Adora."

Adora shakes her head violently, ripping herself forcefully from Catra's side. In her rush she trips around loose grass and the steps on the temple, almost falling against the floor.

"Catra, I murdered a man in front of you," Adora urges her, twisting the invisible knife inside herself as she looks at Catra's face twist and fall.

"You know, my mother was Spartan too." She blurts, opening and closing her fists at her sides. "So I truly do not give a fuck"

Adora chuckles, hysterical by the absurdity of it all. She brings her hands towards her head and runs her sharp fingers around the bodies of the snakes, pushing them back

"I cannot give you a normal life, not anymore," Adora exclaims, wrapping her arms around herself. "If we had met before, if I had gone with Adam sooner I would´ve been able to give you the world, but it's gone now. I cannot give you a home. I can't give you a family, I can't —" Adora chokes, running her nails across the column of her neck where she feels as if her throat was closing into knots. "I can´t give you a baby. I can´t give you any of that."

Catra stomps in the ground, facing Adora with her mouth twisted into a deep scowl.

"Adora, I don't need any of it! Who told you I needed all of that?"

"It´s what you deserve!" Adora exclaims, angrily cleaning the stream of tears off her face. "You deserve a normal and happy life with someone that can love you without being afraid of touching you, of dooming you. Look at what just happened yesterday!"

"You saved my life." Catra says every single word with a sharp point of her voice. trying to make Adora understand them all.

"You wouldn´t have been in danger in the first place if it wasn´t for me."

"That´s not true and I don´t ever want you saying or believing that again." Catra snaps her head away, composing herself quickly from the frustration and anger piling up in her chest

before speaking again. “That man wandering in here to *hurt you* was *not* your fault, Adora. And me confronting him to protect you was *my* choice.”

Adora shakes her head, unable to believe it. She stares as an errand serpents makes its way forwards, sliding across Adora's arm and finding Catra's hand, holding itself to her for dear life when Adora grabs it by the middle and yanks it back.

“I can´t even give you the gentleness of you touching me without feeling beasts on my body.” Adora looks at the blond face of the white serpent, frowning down at it. “I´m twisted”

“You are not twisted, Adora.” Catra reaches for her again but this time she cannot find her so her hand remains hovering in the space between them, trembling. “Do you think your serpents will scare me? Or your eyes? Or your tongue?” Both of them flush, the memory of each other's breath lingering on their mouths. “How do I explain to you that it is you that I love, not what you could or could be. It's you, with all the things that might and will make you. With all the things you have done. You”

“I´m broken.” Adora repeats because she doesn't know what else to say against the waves of Catra's devotion. “I'm not destined to have you”

“Then I will knit the threads of fate myself so they say otherwise!” Catra basically screams, pulling from her own hair until her scalp aches too. “Even if I can't, I´ll still love you anyway”

Adora presses her hand tighter against her mouth, curling around her own body with the wreckage of her sobs.

Catra finds her around the light and shadows and places her palm against Adora's chest but instead of bringing her closer she shoves her finger against Adora's sternum, her ears and tail bristled with sudden anger.

“Adora, I'm— I'm so fucking mad at you,” Catra spats between clenched teeth, her tears leaving tracks on her cheeks. “I'm so fucking angry at you for doing this to you, for sacrificing yourself like this. I'm so fucking angry at you for depriving yourself of love. You *deserve* to be loved, Adora”

Oh, *oh.*

Oh and Gods, isn't that the truth?

Somehow Catra's anger towards Adora manages to cross the haze of her fear more than her gentleness, snapping something in place inside Adora's chest and very soul.

Adora gasps out loud at the feeling of it, feeling it from the roots of her scalp to her eyes to her heart and very soul, threatening to break her apart and then sew her back together with golden thread.

Adora was adored before, by her people and her parents until that adoration twisted into something stained.

She has loved, Adora has love with all her strength and has lost it all. She loves now and she is loved, somehow and marvelously, strong enough to ache, angry enough to shake Adora back into her life. Nobody had ever told her that she deserves it before.

People loved Princess Adora, then they loved Priestess of Etheria, then the Future Queen, and then they loved the most beautiful woman on earth. They loved and feared and spitted on the Medusa. They loved the myth of her.

Catra loves *Adora.*

“Catra—” Adora gapes, her voice catching on her throat but Catra shakes her head, stepping away. “Oh, Catra”

“I´ve been thinking too that maybe I'm being too selfish,” there is a swift change is Catra's voice, something precarious, tensing the strings of Adora's emotions like a bow's cord about to break. “I haven't done things right for you either. And I´ve scared you and hurt you. And pressured you.”

Adora blinks, suddenly confused. “What?”

“If you don´t want me the same, that will be alright too, Adora.” Catra is opening and closing her hands nervously, her voice slipping and cracking in the middle, breaking into the true fear she has been keeling carefully hidden inside her chest. “When I say you deserve it, I mean it. And I mean too that you should do what *you* truly want. I don´t want you to try to love me just because I'm the only person you feel that you could ever love.” Catra chokes, suddenly overwhelmed. “And I don´t want you to kiss me or hold me because you think I´ll break otherwise.”

Horror washes over Adora as she comprehends what Catra means with her words, what she might believe. What doubt has been rooting inside her head in the days where Adora turned herself away from her.

Even with all the love of the world, Catra still thinks Adora does not want her back in that way, and Adora realizes maybe she was not the only one scared after all.

“Catra listen to me, I don't—”

“You kiss me because I'm sad and because I'm wounded. Because you feel responsible for what happened with that man.” This time is Catra who embraces herself, rocking her body softly over her ankles. “But once I'm healed, once it all goes back to what was before, will you hide away from me again?”

It hurts, it hurts like a.ohydicsl blow like an arrow dug deep in the middle of Adora's chest. She goes breathless at it, scrambling to find again all the words she wants to say.

Catra however seems to interpret this new silence in another way.

“Adora, I can live without you.” Catra whispers, shrugging even though it seems to ache. “I just don't want to.”

Adora whimpers, crying loudly now, unable to hold it back. Catra smiles sweetly at her, tint but immensely sad, a kind of resignation falling over her.

“You know now what I feel about you.” Catra takes a wet breath, closing her eyes for a second as if she wanted to drown the light that aches her. Her body and heart are breaking in. “I know I take back what happened to you but I want you to be happy. I want to respect you and be with you. I want to love you, I want you to allow me to love you in any way that you want me to.”

Adora gives a step towards her, her toes dug into soft earth and evergreen grass and the pretty bloom growing all around where Catra stands.

Then another step, quicker, bare soles over warm ground. The cold of the last days has retreated its claws over their land and all Adora can feel right now even above her fear and her pain, is the strong beating of her own chest and Catra's warmth.

“You are my best friend, Adora. I won't turn away from you and I will not forsake you no matter what.” An accidental sob wrecks Catra's entire body with its strength, shaking her from head to toe with its strength. Adora gives another step. “Even– even if you don't love me in return—”

Adora kisses her.

Catra gasps and whimpers in her mouth and Adora kisses her until the breath leaves each other's mouths, stealing the words out of Catra´s tongue and rooting them inside her own heart instead so she can remember them forever.

Adora cradles Catra´s chin and the base of her nape inside her palms and tilts her face towards her, pressing their lips together until there is no more space between them to go than this, the tiny corner where their tastes and their breaths meet.

Adora feels herself undoing in the edges by the feeling of their bodies meeting, running the flat of her split tongue across Catra´s soft bottom lip and the edge of her teeth. Catra hiccups around the feeling of Adora´s hands brushing a tender line across her cheekbone, her hands coming up to cradle the gentle bodies of the serpents falling across her shoulders and the fabric of Adora´s tunic,

“Adora—” Catra starts to whisper but her voice wanders off into nothing when Adora presses a sweet kiss against the corner of Catra´s mouth, following a trail of gentle caresses from the divot of her cheek to the base of her ear.

“I love you,” Adora whispers for her, letting the flood of her emotions overcome anything else that Catra or herself might feel.

Catra wrinkles her nose, blinking more often than she is accustomed as the tears keep spilling uncontrollably down her face.

“You do?” Her voice sounds so shaken and unsure in comparison to what she sounded before, that it clenches around Adora´s heart until it aches.

“Yes,” Adora confesses around a sob too, nodding where she presses her nose against Catra´s closed eyelids. “I love you. I love you so much, Catra”

Catra wraps her hands around Adora´s wrists, lacing their fingers together. She is breathing quickly, violently, almost as if her heart were to rip clean off her chest and flutter around the cavern before sauntering back down inside Adora´s palms or the frozen lake.

“I don't only need you to love me, Adora,” Catra says, also pressing her mouth against Adora ´s slightly feverish skin, but with her entire body tightly wound up. “I need you to *want* to love me. I need you to choose me back.”

“I do.” Adora reassures her immediately, catching Catra´s anxiety and tears between her fingertips, mingling them with their own. “I will”

“Every single day,” Catra clenches her teeth, the tip of her fangs catching painfully on her bottom lip.

“I chose you,” Adora gently rubs Catra´s lip free of her teeth. “I chose you from the very beginning”

Catra holds her breath and brings Adora flush against her. She misses Adora´s mouth twice, catching on her chin and the fall of her nose before Adora helps her through it and guides them both to the place where both of them need them the most.

Catra tilts her head back and Adora leans forwards towards her. Kissing Catra might as well change the entire world for Adora. Just like the cavern all around them, Catra slips into Adora´s mouth and Adora´s chest and takes a root into her bones and the chambers of her heart.

It blooms flowers and trees across her limbs and the roots of her head and transforms her all over again and for the second time in Adora´s life into something more, something different. Not a statue or a monster but a woman wrapped in another woman's arms kissing her as if it was the very first time all over again.

They part from each other with a damp exhale, clothes and limbs and hands tangled with each other and over the soft mud and grass beneath their feet.

Catra lets her eyes remain open, wrinkling just a little bit at the bright light of the sun coming from the open domes above their heads.

“Do you really love me?” Catra asks, one more time because even now with Adora inside her warm arms she cannot be completely sure. Adora giggles partially by mirth and partially by hysteria.

“How could I not love you? How? You're the only wish of my heart.” Adora kisses the corner of Catra´s silver eyes, breathing the smell of her skin. “I´ve loved you since before I knew myself”

Catra takes a shivering breath, leaning the side of her face against the cold bodies of the serpents surrounding her entire face.

“Don't be quiet,” she says, her anger and her need for reassurance bigger than anything else. “You can answer to me now”

Adora closes her eyes and nods, her voice mixing with the sweet choir of the serpents moving all around them, cradling them in a space that is not quite so quiet nor oppressive.

“Catra, you´re the sweetest joy I have ever known,” Adora admits, breathing slowly through her nose. “I too dreamt of you every single night”

Catra is crying again, softer than before. Adora runs her hand across Catra´s shoulder and the fall of her neck and collarbones, mindful of not touching the clean bandages and stitches wrapped around Catra´s still frail wound.

“Listen to me now.” Adora asks, taking a breath. Catra´s face is so beautiful up close like this, tears and all. “From the moment since you wandered inside this place, from the very first moment I laid my eyes on you even before knowing I could not turn you into stone, I knew you were the love I had been waiting for,” Adora´s eyes wrinkle in the corners, looking at Catra tenderly. “And I´ve been waiting for you for such a long, long time”

Catra exhales heavily, searching for Adora´s face among the shadows of her eyes. Adora takes her palm on hers and guides it against her cheek instead, kissing the inside of Catra´s wrist.

“I´ve killed so many before,” and she grunts when Catra opens her mouth and tries to fight her. “No, it's true, you know that. They are dead because of me, because of these hands, because of this face and these eyes.” Adora places Catra´s fingers over her eyes, letting her feel the softness of her eyelashes. “And still here you are, telling me you love me without regrets, without being afraid of what I have done or what I can do”

“I do,” Catra´s mouth twitches in the corners, both with joy and sadness. “You don't get it, do you?”

“I don´t,” Adora admits, staring at the serpents curling around her own hands, brushing their heads against her palms. “But I´d like to try”

“You are the sun in this place, C´yra. Not only in the cavern, not only for the ground or the flowers you grow. You are a sun to me, you have become the star I gravitate around. You have turned my life from wandering adrift to becoming into the ellipses surrounding your light.” Adora wraps her fingers around the bubbles knots, smiling at them. “You are kind and stubborn, you are sweet and smart. Even now your anger towards me is blessing me. You are beautiful. Beauty and greed and jealousy doomed me Catra, but you? You are the most beautiful thing in the whole world and the only blessing I ever wished for.”

Catra sniffles, snorting unceremoniously when a bubble of snot makes it mast her nose and pops and makes them both laugh at the stupidity of it all.

“You are not selfish, Catra. And if you are by all means keep doing it because I don´t know yet how to do it by myself.” Adora gulps heavily, her voice catching on her throat. “Be mad at me, yell at me, make me understand. Repeat it to me over and over again so I never forget it. So my body finally understands it.” Adora stares at her own body with hatred for a second, trying to push back “My body, my entire being has been on the line for such a long time now, Catra, sometimes I still believe that I'm going to break beyond repair one day”

“Even if it does I don't care,” Catra shakes her head forcefully in Adora's hands, her chin wobbling violently. “Just don't push me away.”

“I almost lost you, Catra.” Adora cuts her gently though undeniably filled with fear. “You could have died in my hands. That man could have broken you because I was gone and I hate myself for it.”

“No–”

“You need to let me feel it.” Adora clenches her teeth until she feels them chip under the strength, running her thumbs over Catra's bruised wrists. “Let me understand that you are here. Let me understand that I saved you and not doomed you. Let me understand that you saved me first.”

“I haven't done anything”

“You have done everything, Catra. I— I love you.” Adora sobs around the words, feeling them free her. “I love you because you are patient with me, and when you are not, you´re anchoring. You don´t allow me to lose myself. Even now after I've hurt you with my absence, you are still here asking me to allow you to remain next to me, as if it wasn´t me the one that should be begging you to grant me a little bit more of your light.”

Catra wraps her entire hand around the celestial blue fabric of Adora´s chiton and brings her towards her, holding her as if she wasn't planning to let go anymore.

“From the very start,” Adora reassures her, running the back of her knuckles over her cheek. “I love you because with you I finally found peace”

Catra exhales around tears, her soft ears twitching at her sides and back up again, following the sound of Adora´s breathing and the hum of her voice.

“Why did you leave?” Catra asks, still weary, still on the edge of the line.

“I´m sorry. I´m scared, I don´t know if I'll ever stop being scared. I don´t know if the Fates will ever come to play their destiny on me.” This time, when the serpents make their way towards Catra´s face, Adora doesn´t stop them. “But I love you. Oh Catra, I love you. I adore you madly. You need to know this, you need to know just how deeply the lengths of my love for you run.”

“I've lost everyone I have ever loved, Adora.” Catra urges her, digging her fingers over Adora ´s forearms, unable to tear herself from her anymore. The serpents kiss her dark skin and she welcomes them and, for a moment as their marble and gold bodies brush across her beautiful

face, Adora sees them beautiful too. “I'm scared too. I don't ever want to lose you, I don't know what I would do of myself”

“I don't know if I can promise you that,” Adora narrows her eyes at the starry sky above their heads; at the cavern´s roof scattered in quartz and moss and the marble of the temple. “But I can promise you that I will always return to you no matter what”

The looms in the middle of the cavern are right next to each other and empty. Adora is wearing Catra´s hemation, Catra is wearing Adora´s. The stars and dots sewn by Catra in the fabric brush against Adora´s skin. The raised ink that Adora painted on Catra´s hands and soles are soft when Catra touches them.

They both think they might understand each other's language after all.

“I would wait for you forever, Adora,” and for a single second when Adora blinks Catra looks a little bit older, a lot more beautiful, surrounded by evergreen and light with her silver blue eyes smiling at her, a glimpse of the future. Then she is herself as she is right now, twenty six and in love in Adora´s arms.

Maybe Adora can do this after all. Maybe she can drink of the beauty of love however it might last and live every single day as plenty and hard as she possibly can.

Maybe she can learn how to forgive herself. Maybe she can learn how to heal.

“I don't want you to wait for me for a single second longer,” Adora whispers and leans down to kiss her fully again.

Catra is here, so Adora can.

Cúrate, mijita, el dolor con nuestra luz del Sol y los rayos de la Luna

Cúrate, mijita, el dolor con el sonido del río, la cascada y la espuma

Con el vaivén del mar que va y viene, deja que te agarre

Con el vaivén del mar que va y viene, deja que te ame [...]

Cúrate, mi niña, con amor del más bonito y enciende el fuego

Entrega tus dolores, que se vuelvan polvo y vengan nuevas flores

— *Maria la Curandera,* **Natalia Lafourcade**

Chapter End Notes

THE SLOW BURN IS FINALLY OVER HUZZAH!!
they still have a few things to talk about but HUZZAH!

Notes:
- The small ritual Adora does to heal and take care of Catra is inspired by Mehndi (an art of skin decoration usually worn by grooms and brides of south asian cultures to symbolize celebration, joy, and happiness, among others) and Haldi (an event where the brides and groom wear yellow to symbolize peace and prosperity, marking the start of wedding festivities). I know it´s not very historical or culture accurate, but I found it appropiate considering what is going to happen next chapter ;)

- I know I gave them a little bit of trauma and I killed an asshole, but consider it some therapy for Adora too. She needs to decompress a little bit poor thing

- Also next chapter there is going to be smut :))) just saying

Thank you so much for reading. Comments, bookmarks, suscriptions and kudos are deeply appreciated. See you soon! Be good :)

Verse X

Chapter Notes

NOTE: MAESTRO! PLAY “WEDDING SONG” FROM HADESTOWN

Warning for this chapter:
- Brief mentions of PTSD y panic attacks
- Smut (marked with ****)
- A LOT OF FLUFF

What are you still doing here? Go read!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse X. Olive Bounds

I have been waiting all my life to be with you

My heart slams against my ribs when I think of the slaughtered nights

I spent all over the world waiting to feel your touch

– Henry Rollins

Before there was a king of the skies, the universe bowed to a single command. Before there was a king of the skies, the halls of stars already had a ruler, holding the wisdom of time in her womb.

A Queen.

She walks among halls made of clusters of stars and through long corridors cradled in twilight night. Her celestial feet are alway bare and they never touch the ground, no godly or mortal alike, for no queens of the heavens should stain her soles by the mud or the starlight.

Insteads she hovers over it all and dances, dances, divine beauty and cosmos alike, bringer of fertility and life into the universe under which blooms of nature and stars are born.

She is the closest to the humans as they are, with the wrists covered in turquoise and her hips cradled in fine clouds. With her legs wide like misty mountains and her breasts plump like never drying lakes. With her face that speaks of a thousand and a million more women embraced in beauty and the short hair made of light, so fine and white that it looks as if mist

had made a home of her head cradled in ethereal crowns made with the ellipses of the planets around their single sun.

She is the one that looks the most like them all, her children, because she is the most loyal. Nearly as much as her dear sister cradled in home fires. And also, because she is the most heartbroken. A mother, carrying both joy and grief on her dark as night skies skies; carrying both life and the undeniable future of loss. Like a flower, meant to grow and bloom and be beautiful before it's gone, just like every single mortal life she sees go by inside her celestial eyes.

That´s who she is, after all, as many like her breathing in mortal lands. A mother, a woman. A goddess, a queen, mother of the universes and of life.

Once a virgin deflowered by swan feathers and all it brought after. And she has been misunderstood and demonized for such a long time because in her pain, in the inevitable breakdown of betrayal, she has dared to cry. And all women who cry are, for some reason, always wrong.

She cries today too, because the mother of skies has not stopped from the very beginning of the universe when her own love betrayed her for less, never for more; but she allows them to be because she does these too will bring life to her other children. These too will fill the empty rivers and gather it´s drizzle on one or two gentle clouds and rain over the remains of war. So allows them to exist.

Today, after all, is not a day of mourning. Twelve days have gone by since another kind of queen departed to the Elyseums, but today the earth is quiet in a way only godly touch can cause. Just a single one so even the world submerged in war can feel the gentleness of an union long ago promised for.

Like all of them, she cannot gaze inside the cavern, but she can feel the light of life coming in waves from the open domes where the sky lingers its eyes every once in a while. She can see the errand feathers that have sauntered to the ground, free from her physical body in a blessing so small it's almost nothing. And yet, the simple gentleness manages to break the fury of the storm inside the gates of the Queen´s heavenly chambers.

That is alright, she thinks, smiling with her dark body covered in silver powder. Quite alright, in fact it is perfect because she was already queen much before he was anything at all but the rock that didn't get eaten. And she has been eager to speak about the almost mortal hilarity of the Fates moving their threads around destiny from the moment she realized it was happening.

The thunderstorm makes his way across her halls, raising static across the nebulas and stars, grunting and growling like an old cloud left dry after thousands of eons minding everything but his own business. And even then, she does not turn around.

The Queen´s long wings shiver to life though, cradling her completely from the tip of her soft toes to the high of her head. Emerald green and deep blue and reds and so many other colors that cannot even be recognized by the mortal eyes, present on the peacock feathers that make

off the hundred and one wings, holding her high above the stardust scattered in the heavenly palace.

They shake a little when the storm stops, right behind her, observing her with golden thunders like eyes as he expects for her to turn around and acknowledge him and remains waiting when she does not do so.

In fact, all the Queen of the Gods do is smile, with a mouth that is not a mouth but a fresh lake of life. She leans down to see the human world through the silver glass of her ethereal mirrors and cannot help but grin in satisfaction at what she sees in them.

Even among the desolation of war and her sister´s and children´s rage, there is hope. A new queen is crowned on the shores of a now calm sea, her hair pink like the blooms that do not exist under their feet anymore and the silver light of the new moon.

At the other side of the realms, a cowardly emperor drags himself back into his flooded throne, wounded and humiliated by the rage of his father's brother himself. He has won the battle but he is battered in return and for the first time in years of war, the souls that wander around him look down at his self placed crown and wonder *what if?*

A king, a son of the king of the gods, might actually be nothing else but another simple man chasing greed. No divine power inherited but the ability to touch the gods, and no royal blood himself. Just another bastard holding himself high towards the sky that has been easily overpowered by a dead woman.

A man, afraid of a woman too. His first and most vile sin. A woman hidden away that has brought him endless nightmares that not even wine or power have ever been able to drown down.

The civil battles are about to begin and they will bring more bloodshed to the mortal grounds, more spilled breath and spilled souls down to the gates of the Underworld, but among them all there is also the incoming fall of the bastard the heavenly queen so much hates.

She hates them all, and it has brought her misunderstandings and hatred from mortal myths stained by men´s beliefs. But the world would hate them all too if they only knew what she does, if they were to feel what she had felt. The shock of the betrayal; the anger of the faux apology; the humiliation of the defile.

The Queen loves the world but the goddess will always hate them, all the sprouts of her husband's treason. But today, just today, she dares to smile at the metal smell around her. Something, a stench, she had not perceived in a long, long time and that is now back.

Fear

You are afraid, the goddess speaks, her emerald eyes sparkling in gold when she blinks and the skies gather with newborn stars.

The thunderstorm roars behind her, shaking the very foundations of her celestial domes, but even then she ignores him. The best payment she has ever found worthy of her husband's

betrayals, have always been retribution in the shape of indifference.

Why would I?

You were afraid before, when they were one. She chants, her thousands eyes blinking around the past sights of an unknown casted away from the heavens and into the mortal world. *Why wouldn't you be now?*

A thunder breaks against the halls and it shakes the entire world to it´s very foundations, cracking the earth and turning the sky into darkness, but she remains unbending. His thunder and lightning has not affected the cosmos, after all, not anymore.

He will stomp into the earth and burn the dry crops and scream and yell until they too become storms and rain, but it will not touch the cluster of stars or the foundations of life itself. It will not touch her breast or her womb or her heart ever again.

And in the same way, it will never touch the souls he was already broken, not in a way that cannot be healed.

They are mortal souls now, no more. He howls with the strength of a thousand volts. *No different from thousands before them. Not less bound to die.*

No, they are one soul split into two because you, my husband, were afraid of what she would have become if you let her walk among us . The Queen tilts her head to the side and from the mighty horns born on her temples and curling around her magnificent face, a hundred lotus flowers spill down. *You were afraid another womb would crown herself more than you so you made them infertile and blind. You were afraid and you still are because against all your games they gravitate to each other again.*

They can die. He screeches, high as an eagle throwing itself towards a prey he cannot defeat, his faux swan neck long and twisted as he pushes his godly face against the goddess. *A thousand times, they can die.*

The Queen extends one of her ethereal hands to the side and wraps it around the long neck, completely from one side to the other until her fingers meet. She could choke it, it would be so easy; twist it in her hand until the vertebrae breaks down and with it the storm raining on her clouds. But she doesn´t.

This is where her power lies. She could but she doesn't because she *chooses* not to do it.

You can kill the flower, but the seed will persist. The Queen runs her nebula fingertips down the length of his neck, gathering thunder blue feathers on her pads and smothering them back in a touch that is so gentle that could be threatening. *Not even you can interfere with them now, not directly. You will have to abide by your own terms and let it play on its own.*

The goddess touches her mirror, reflecting in every single one of them the image of the self proclaimed king that slumps over the golden thrones of the one beautiful Etherian kingdom, clinging to it as if it was a raft left to drift in an unpredictable ocean, breaking in the seams and flooding with salt and water over and over again.

Your champion is wearing down, my love. She purrs between teeth white as pearls, smiling through the words. *There are not any victories left he can bring you. What will you do then?*

I won´t have you mingling in this , he snaps, reaching for her as if he was to strike her down but unable to do so. She has always been more than him and even if in the past he has managed to hurt her to the edge of breaking, he has never been truly able to touch her.

I don´t need to. They were my daughter once, I know who they are. The Queen smiles to herself, watching another kind of mirror, twisted branches and moss covered cave, sprouts of lotus flowers blooming in the roots . *But when you lose our bet, you will be the one walking out of their lives with grace. Husband*

The skies thunder with his departure, shaking the world again around her unbreakable glass walls. And she remains here, mother of life itself, watching to all her creatures except the ones born from and quietly blessing them. Even the ones she cannot see, even the ones she cannot feel.

Marriage bounds, after all, as ethereal as the light pouring in open domes.



“You could have been a Queen.” Adora whispers, hanging a dark pearl from the golden threads around Catra´s hair.

They are sitting on the mattress of the olive bed, slightly too hard underneath them and absolutely perfect as always. Adora is resting her back against the flat branches behind the pillows, running her hands down Catra´s bare shoulders where the latter is sitting over Adora ´s lap.

Her knees stradling Adora´s waist and her weight reassuring when she throws her head back and laughs.

“A queen, uh?” Catra repeats, her beautiful face powdered with gold and the maroon suns in her cheeks stretching with a smile. “Tall and mighty. With a crown of laurel and a ridiculous big throne”

Catra stretches her arms, jingling with golden and turquoise bracelets, towards the sky and then lowers them back again, carefully running her fingers over the beads, coins and tiny gems carefully weaved by Adora´s fingers around the beautiful loops around Catra´s temples and forehead.

With every false hero that had wandered inside the halls of the cave seeking for Adora there had also been treasure, dragging behind them and left to catch root and moss on the ground. Adora has never minded them, not cared about them,indifferent by the amounts of mud they would gather in the cracks.

Catra was a little bit different. She didn´t care about the jewels of the gold, but she cared about Adora and about reclaiming a little bit of the good from the bad things that had

happened,even if they were dug around old arrows and rotting spears.

She dug them all by hand and brought them with her, playing around the intricate shapes on the bed and hanging them around the bodies of the snakes and around Adora´s wrists and neck,smiling the whole time.

Adora had to admit to herself, quietly as she adorned Catra´s arms and ears with the pendants too, that it had been a very,very long time since she had seen herself cradled in gold and copper and tiger eye. It had been a long time since she had been cradled by something but fabrics and veils. A long time indeed.

The jingle of the bangles and the amethyst and mother of pearl tiara over her forehead, right below the place where the serpents are born,twisting around her head and shoulders and feeling the edges of the jewelry with the curious heads, it all feels deeply familiar and at the same time sweetly knew.

It´s welcome, it feels good. Adora feels *pretty.*

“Well, not very tall,” Adora teases Catra with a small chuckle,pinching her button nose with the back of her fingers.

Catra wrinkles her nose and bats her hand away, stretching a finger to poke Adora in the forehead and accidentally reaching the fall of her cheekbone instead.

“Hush, peasant,” Catra commands in a sweet voice, her mouth twitching in the corners with a smile. “Or I shall have thy head”

“Nice.” Adora chuckles, rolling her eyes as she gently tucks an errand loop behind Catra´s soft ear. “Beheaded Medusa. Just the thing that my myth needs.”

Catra leans down and down until her forehead bumps gently against the bridge of Adora´s nose, her lips brushing against the fall of Adora´s face where her cheek meets the angle of her nose and the golden powder in Catra´s skin smudges against Adora´s face like solar waves.

“I can think of better uses for your head,” Catra whispers, her breath brushing right against Adora´s earlobe when Catra tilts her head to the side and presses a trail of kisses from her jaw to the corner of her mouth.

Adora let´s her head roll back against the branches of the headboard, smiling to herself. “Like?”

“Like kissing me.”

When Catra shifts her head to press against Adora´s, the latter is already waiting for her, meeting her open mouth with hers in a long kiss, slow and languid and damp where their lips and tongues brush together and paint themselves and the roofs of their mouth in hitched exhales.

For Adora it has been a declaration, an explosion of knowledge like discovering a newborn star or a law of the universe, always there but hidden until someone looks in the right time

and the right place.

She had never kissed anybody, not before Catra. She didn´t know about mouths and lips touching or about the slide of palms down each other's shoulders and backs. She knew nothing about how to be a lover.

But now Adora is an expert, a master. A student still and an apprentice of all things that are Catra and at the same time knowledgeable enough to know almost every single pull and button of what makes Catra laugh, grunt or exhale against her mouth.

By now Adora knows exactly how to kiss her just *right.* No more messy tongues or trails and fail of open mouthed kisses, no more accidental crashes of foreheads or noses bumping painfully against closed eyelids, and if there are they are sweet and not clumsy.

Now when Catra kisses Adora and when Adora kisses her right back, Adora knows exactly how to cradle Catra´s chin in her palms and tilt her head to the side in the perfectly angle to slot their mouths together and kiss each other in all the sweet and romantic way they can.

“Would you have liked it?” Adora asks, still against Catra´s mouth, lingering a trail of kisses from the corner of her mouth to the freckled arch of her cheekbones.

“Being queen?” Catra tilts her head to the side, her eyebrows rising on her forehead. “Adora, I'm a farmer. And a weaver”

“You are a child of gods.” Adora points out, running the pads of her fingers through the golden swirls that live in Catra´s cheeks. “By all means, you´re already more royalty than me”

“That´s dumb and doesn´t mean anything,” Catra scowls a little, her tails lashing lazily behind her in displeasure.

She is still soft in Adora´s hands though, running her nose up and down Adora´s temples where clusters of soft scales cradle her skin, much like the ones in the serpents themselves.

“I don´t think I´m the right person to rule an entire empire.”

“I think otherwise,” Adora shakes her head, pressing her nose against the curve of Catra´s neck where her shoulders meet the start of her back. “You´re wise”

“Uh hu”

“You´re smart and cunning,” Adora presses her closed lips over the small divot of Catra´s spine, smiling around her incoming purr. “An strategist”

“Alright, keep talking.” Catra grins too, letting her head roll back in Adora´s palms.

“And you´re so, so–” Adora´s mouth splits into a smile against Catra´s neck, pecking her in the lips one for time. “Bossy”

Catra´s head rolls to the side, groaning with such an annoyed sigh that it is born from the very middle of her chest to her face.

“Ugh, get off me.” Catra presses her palm against the side of Adora´s head and pushes it away, grunting when all Adora does is throw her head back and giggle at her as she continues to press sweet kisses all over the edge of her jaw and chin. “No, get off me”

“See?” Adora asks around a snort, smiling from ear to ear. “Bossy”

Catra snaps her teeth closed, crossing her arms over her sweet chest. “Well let go off me then”

“No,” Adora denies, spreading her fingers at the sides of Catra´s waist and bringing her close into a another breathtaking kiss. “Never, again”

The cavern outside their temple is warm too, deliciously smelling with the fruits and flowers that Catra had placed on the altar she had built herself at the sides of the temple, right next to the mosaic steps.

It had been her idea and Adora had respected her through it all, helping her move heavy pieces of crumbled marble columns and braiding alongside her laurel and lavender garlands as Catra placed oil lamps on the flat and dusty surfaces.

Adora was quiet through it all, pressing her lips into a tight line and staring at the golden flames of the lamps until Catra called for her attention instead, with her soles painted in yellow clay and her long hair brushing the back of her waist in thick loops.

Adora´s faith lies on her, on her existence and on the sound of her breath. But there are just some times when Adora wonders if she will ever be able to restore the kind of faith she had before everything happened to her. Sometimes she wonders if she will ever be able to trust in them again.

“Alright, you´ve got me all pretty. Now you stay still, little princess.”

Catra leans to the sides, finding with her fingertips the small bowl with tincture inside and taking the fine brush dipped inside. With her other hand she feels the planes of Adora´s face, from the expanse of her closed eyelids, her –a little too big much for Adora´s annoyance— forehead and the fall of her cheeks.

Catra is taking her time to not mess it up, this Adora knows even though Catra could very well paint Adora´s entire face with the maroon paint and you would not catch Adora complaining.

In fact, Adora can feel the way Catra is counting with her fingers the distance between Adora ´s cheeks and her eyes, yet for some reason the expression in Catra´s face so deeply drowned in concentration manages to rip a tiny chuckle off Adora´s mouth.

“Don´t move or I´ll stab you in the eye with this.” Catra grunts, biting nervously on her own mouth. “I´m serious. It won´t even be on purpose”

“Alright, alright”

Dot. Adora breathes calmly through her nose as Catra presses the end of the brush against the middle of her cheek, feeling with her fingertips the ink painting Adora´s skin until she is happy with it and takes it back.

Dot. This time is Catra the one holding her breath, her frown furrowing a little with concentration and the tip on her tongue peeking from in between her slightly crooked teeth. It ´s cute, it makes Adora want to steal a kiss from her mouth but then the makeup suns would be ruined.

Dot. Dot. Catra goes very slow and she is very careful, finishing one cheek and then going for the other, her hand shaking a little by how hard she is holding the brush.

“Relax”

“Shut up”

Dot, dot. Dot. Until she finally reaches the curve of Adora´s chin, painting it in dots so tiny that Adora almost doesn´t feel the brush at all, the corners of her mouth twitching as she fights against a smile as hard as she can.

Catra leans back, resting almost completely now on Adora´s bent knees. She scrambles on the wrinkled sheets for a few seconds until she finds what she is looking for, a slightly crooked copper mirror that Adora has fetched for her even though Catra cannot really use it.

Very carefully Catra finds Adora´s hand and turns it over, placing the mirror inside with a little shake of her shoulders. “Are they wonky?”

Adora looks at her beautiful face and then down at the mirror, raising it up. She hesitates for a long, long second, so long that Adora thinks the day grows a little bit brighter as the morning gives away to the noon but maybe it´s just the sun playing eye tricks on her nervous heart.

She gulps heavily and frowns down at the mirror, feeling Catra´s patient face hovering just a little bit further away out of the corner of her eye. She knows Catra won´t force her to look if she does not want to, but the thing is that everything right now is so tender and domestic that she truly, really for the first time wants to.

Adora holds her breath and lifts the copper mirror towards her, looking at her face for the very first time in six years.

Golden eyes meet her immediately and for a moment Adora waits, waits to be turned into stone too, just like many before. Waits for the marble to turn her limbs into cold and to overcome her face and the serpents calmly running across her forehead and her shoulders.

It never happens though. Just a small sense of cold and then nothing more. The serpents still kiss over her tan skin and the fall of her face; her mouth is still slightly open and she can see the white edge of her teeth; her eyelashes are still fluttering and pale, like before, so pale they are almost white against the darkness of her skin.

She is still herself, even with golden eyes instead of blue, even with the white and golden scales of the serpents cradling her temples instead of honey hair. She is still herself. Sun makeup and all.

“No.” Adora whispers, biting back a smile at the sight of the crooked dots just a little bit higher on the right than on the left.

Catra grunts in front of her, already smelling Adora´s bullshit and frowning at it when she slaps Adora´s upper arm swiftly.

“Alright, just a little bit.” Adora bites into Catra´s mouth this time, lowering the mirror back down. “They are perfect”

Catra hums in Adora´s lips, running her fingers softly through the spaces of Adora´s scalp where the serpents are born, caressing their length gently until her arms cannot reach the rest of their bodies anymore.

When Adora turns away from Catra´s mouth, licking into her lips to savour the lingering taste from her mouth, she catches right of Catra reaching for her own scalp instead, running her sharp nails through one of the thin brads of her curls,held by golden beads in the end until she slicing it clean off the rest of her hair, falling limp on her hands.

“What are you doing, Kiki?” Adora asks curiously, watching with her heart on her throat as Catra wraps the upper half of her body over her, trinketing with the pretty serpents in Adora´s head.

“Last touch.” Catra mutters between her teeth.

Adora feels as one of the slim serpents that live behind her sharp ear come to tangle around Catra´s fingers, humming on her touch while Catra grabs a golden cuffing from her own thick hair and clips the base of the serpent with the base of her own loose braid, braiding them together until the golden of its scales are mingling with the oak of Catra´s hair, the serpents curling happily from side to side with its toothless mouth open with evident happiness.

“Adam once told me some engaged couple would sometimes braid each other's hairs to carry each other on their bodies.” Catra explains in a low voice, falling back on Adora´s lap and playing nervously with the wrinkles of her chiton. “He gave one to Teela, I think. Before her left.”

Adora´s pupils go wide like full moons on her face, her entire face locking and then relaxing again once her heart has restarted itself again, pumping blood violently inside her bloodstream. She takes a breath that comes all shuttering and broken, watching as Catra´s dark cheeks grown warm and deeply red with a flush a she waits impatiently by whatever brain cells left in Adora´s head to jumpstart themselves too, the tip of her tail coming up to curl around Adora´s forearm to ground her and herself too.

“I have none to give you.” Adora finally blurts out, wrinkling her nose when her voice comes all cracking and weird. Catra hums, resting her fingers over the fine scales on Adora´s temples.

“Scales,” Catra murmurs, letting her fingers follow the curve of Adora´s eyebrows and the fall of her nose. “Make me a crown with them.” She lets them rest over Adora´s parted lips, leaning towards her. “The only kind of queen I want to be is the one that can be in your arms”

Adora opens her mouth against Catra´s, welcoming her inside with a gasp.

They have kissed many times by now. In the creek of the waterfall and the edge of the calm lake; next to the warm flames of the fireplaces and at the feet of the gods´altar; below the thick branches of the secret garden and upside down resting on the twisted roots of the trees around them.

Against the pretty columns of the temple until one or both had to lower them down into the ground; and in the bed, inside the canopy and over the soft sheets of the mattress scattered in olive leaves. On every single little corner and wall and patch of stone and moss, they have kissed, opened their lips against each other and clicked the tip of their teeth together until neither knew where their bodies started or ended and Catra´s skin was akin to Adora´s serpents.

Adora barely understands how it is that she was able to live so long without ripping kisses of Catra´s mouth, or without Catra´s lips running caresses below the column of her own neck and the fall of her shoulders. She doesn´t understand how nor does she want to know anymore; she doesn´t want to live anymore in a world where she is not allowed to wrap Catra ´s beautiful frame inside her arms and bring her close.

Adora is still scared, she still tosses in bed sometimes and lingers her eyes quietly for hours in the dead bodies outside the cave. But now it's different, now she wants, she craves. She is a woman with appetite and with desire and the very same fields of yearning are watered by the rain of Catra´s undoubtable adoration for her in return.

Eleven as they lay in impenetrable walls, even as Adora is still a prisoner fated to live and die in this exile, they are together. And whatever Adora wants, Catra gives it to her immediately.

Adora grunts in Catra´s mouth, her body shivering when Catra´s sharp fang catches her bottom lip and bruises it softly,the mild pang of ache traveling from Adora´s mouth to her throat and chest and then beyond, swirling in the pits of her belly like liquid fire.

Adora opens her eyes just a slit, just enough to gaze upon Catra´s beautiful blushing face through half narrowed eyelids as the latter presses the flat of her tongue against Adora´s lips and licks a thick and damp line from the small of her bottom lip all the way to the middle of the philtrum, drinking on Adora´s sharp exhales against her wet mouth.

For Adora, who was never allowed to desire anything of her own, Catra´s fire and the burn of her want for her craves a volcano and a storm on the very middle of Adora´s heart, eating with her red lips all self doubt and shyness still nestled in it. She still waits for Adora to move further but while Adora gets there, Catra lavishes her mouth in the very same way she does to the rest of her soul, with the utmost devotion and the most erotic of desires.

Adora runs her hand through the back of Catra´s thick curls and gathers them all inside her palm as she pulls from her all the way to the side, tilting Catra´s entire face in the perfect

angle for Adora surge forward and still the words and the breath straight out of she mouth, sucking on her tongue and licking on the roof of her mouth until all Catra can do in return is hold her breath and gasp Adora´s name.

It´s heavy, and it is exquisite. Adora can feel Catra´s entire body melting and rocking against hers, tangling their limbs into braids and pressing their chests and faces together until there is nothing else left between them but the sound of their thick kiss making and the sizzling choir of the serpents above them.

Catra straddles Adora´s waist, the skirt of her tunic pooling around her hips and raising from her bare knees.. The fabric of Adora´s tunic is soft, silk made, cool and tender against Catra´s sensitive skin when kisses Adora back with equal intensity and she paints a line with her hips against Adora´s lap, exploding a new kind of feeling between them.

Sparks of pleasure explode on the corners of Adora´s vision, and they are met by Catra´s sweet gasp, pressing their foreheads together until there is nowhere else to go.

“Adora,” Catra whispers, almost like a plea, letting her closed eyes open just enough for Adora to catch the silver and blue glint living in them.

Adora observes her for a second and then wraps her fully inside her arms, meeting her as her own hips buckle forward, the fabric of their tunics brushing them in the middle without really allowing them to touch at all.

Adora knows about sex, a thing or more. Not out of own experience as there was no one Adora ever wished to touch or to allow to touch until Catra, but that didn´t mean that Adora was not curious about specially as she became an adult.

She had heard things, learnt experiences from traveler women that would take a moment of their day to speak with the curious princess that would hide below veils and sneak on their tents to listen to their stories for hours to end.

She heard all there was about it and maybe a little bit more, where imagination met passion, and for the first years of her young adulthood she was both as nervous as she was excited to meet the woman she would maybe share all of these feelings the women spoke about. That would make Adora feel good and to whom Adora would make feel good in return.

“I know you´ve heard me, before,” Catra whispers against Adora´s face, kissing her fresh painted cheeks and biting softly into the skin there. It should feel weird, for Adora it feels exhilarating. “That night, when you were at the loom. I knew. I was thinking about you”

Adora´s throat clogs, the memory of that time many nights ago hitting her directly in the chest with the strength of a warhammer. “Oh”

“Yeah, *oh.* ” Catra giggles lightheartedly, dragging her hips down as Adora lifts hers up, her soles slipping on the tangled sheets. “I was thinking about you on our bed.”

“Ah,” Adora lets her head rolls backwards, leaving her neck open and exposed for Catra to latch onto, softly grazing with her sharp teeth and lavishing with her lips until warm patches

bloom on the copper skin of Adora´s neck.

“I wondered if you would ever want me like I do”

Adora knows about sex, Catra quite definitely knows about sex too. It is a fine line they have been dancing dangerously around for a few days now, getting too close to each other but never just enough to blur that one line too.

On one hand, Adora knows it is the correct thing to do. That they should learn each other deeper, trust each other more, learn bit by bit the things they love about themselves and about each other before baring themselves in that beautiful and intimate way that might change their entire worlds forever.

Damn, Adora even knows she should wed Catra first, that she would if Adora was not cursed to be here forever, if she still didn´t bore the hope for Catra to have a sweeter future than this cave. That's how she was raised, that's what she was taught, to honor one's partner before reclaiming a body´s sacred virginity for their own. And Catra is more sacred for Adora than anything else.

On the other hand, Adora fucking craves.

Adora grunts and presses her face flush against the side of Catra´s jaw, where her face meets the angle of her neck, breathing deep on the fresh smell from her skin before letting her mouth relax open and catching the frail skin between her teeth and her tongue.

Adora feels the shiver in Catra´s shoulders as she holds her breath and bites down too, painting a red and purple flower in Catra´s skin almost immediately, aware that she has done it as a reclaim, as something that is *Adora´s,* and that Adora should be feeling ashamed because Catra is neither a possession nor an object yet too distracted by the way Catra presses her open mouth against Adora´s temples and straights up moans in delight.

Dozens of tiny gods forsaken flowers bloom violently all around them, crawling their ways on the bed, the branches and even their own bodies, their deep violet and red colors calling for Adora´s attention as she watches with her eyes full of wonder how Catra´s love and desire sprout life out of nowhere.

The deeply yellow stems of the flower seem to take a breath and then a small puff of pollen is also floating around them like gold powder, tickling Catra directly in the nose.

Catra´s face changes immediately, almost comically so. Her nose scrunches and her forehead wrinkles in a swift second of confusion where she seems like she is trying very, very hard not to until she completely loses the silent war and she sneezes spectacularly loud, the sweet ring of her even sweeter sneeze squeezing Adora´s heart, successfully breaking the erotic bubble casted around them.

“Oh, my,” Adora mutters, shaking violently where a giggle raises like sea foam on her throat.

“Gods, please be quiet.” Catra groans, rubbing her nose with the back of her hand and sniffling, scowling at Adora. “We are making out, please”

“You´re–” Adora starts, unable to hold herself back for a single second longer.

“Don´t you dare”

“So cute!”

“Alright, that´s it.” Catra exclaims, red as a poppy and scowling even more when Adora´s giggle erupts into a fucking loud cackle. “Kindly fuck off”

Catra pokes her finger against Adora´s ribs and it only helps to make her laugh even louder, rolling to the side and accidentally missing the edge of the bed completely, thumbling them both messily against the mosaics of the ground.

Catra huffs but Adora just giggles, gathering Catra´s sweet body in her arms and nuzzling her on the floor, still giggling though it all.



On insight, it´s Adora´s fault. She is excited and she did not think about it fully. In fact, it never crossed her mind the possibility that it could happen at all.

Also on insight, it´s a bit of Catra´s fault too because surely, *truly,* she might be blind but she just must knows what she is doing for Adora´s weak heart for her.

It´s not only that she smells especially delicious lately, or that she loves Adora so gently and passionately at the very same time, or that she kisses as if the nymphs themselves had carved her mouth out of flower petals. It´s not only that she has gotten an habit of singing all the time lately, or that every single tie Adora gazes at her she looks *happy,* truly and absolutely joyful no matter what mundane thing she might be doing in the moment, as if Adora loving her back was the only thing Catra needed to live a plenty and beautiful life.

No, it´s not only that, it´s the heat. It´s the summer, clamming their skins and sticking their clothes to their limbs. And it´s that sky blue tunic in Catra´s body, barely hanging from the teardrop fall of her breasts and leaving the expanse of her back bare for Adora to see because there is no other reason why Catra must have knotted it like that with the leather ropes.

It´s the constellations, actual constellations of freckles scattered from the high of her shoulders, down the middle of her spine and spreading fully across her entire waist, barely stopping where the fabric wrinkles around a soft trail that leads to the beginning of her tail.

It´s all of that and the way she is moving towards their bed, her hair held high in a ponytail above her head and her shoulder´s free, clean after a long bath underneath the waterfall that has Adora already fighting herself against the need to glance at her to the point of burying her damn face against a bunch of cold moss.

It's all of that and the way Adora´s blue hemation is draped around her waist and the way she grunts as she struggles with her own knots on the ropes, trying and failing to take them off so she can take the sky blue tunic all together and slip quietly into the long chiton she wears to sleep.

And you know what? No, that simply won´t do.

Adora approaches Catra in such steps, coming to stand right behind her bare back, holding her breath at the sudden proximity. Her blood is rushing violently inside her ears, clogging her thoughts as she stares at her favorite mole in Catra´s back, the one that lives right in the middle of her spine, right in the divot between her ribcage and her waist.

Adora bites sharply on the inner side of her mouth and moves forwards, resting her fingers against the very same mole and then trailing them all the way down, grazing the root of Catra ´s tail before moving up again.

Catra´s entire body locks into a goosebump, her tail and ears bristling with the touch, pressing themselves against the sides of her head and around Adora´s bare ankle.

“Adora?” Catra hisses, too soft to be anything else but tender. “What are you doing?”

Adora doesn´t answer, not immediately.Instead she walks the last steps that keep her away from Catra and raises her hands to rest them over the leather ropes keeping her tunic together, thumbing the loose knots and letting her fingers roam dangerously close next to the gentle sides of Catra´s ribs and the swell of her breasts.

“May I?” Adora asks, pressing the side of her face against the back of Catra´s head.

Catra´s breath audibly hitches on her throat, leaning her entire body backwards to let her weight rest inside Adora´s hands.

“Gods, yes,” Catra blurts out, her shoulders painting in a deep shade of poppies when she catches her own excitement clear on her voice. “I mean– fuck. Yes, uhu, go ahead”

Adora giggles under her breath but doesn´t tease her further, running her fingers softly beneath the knot and undoing them easily, the thin ropes losing apart against Catra´s chest and sauntering over the floor like loose petals.

With them, the fabric of the tunic comes apart too, so soft, so beautiful after being woven by Catra´s hands, that it folds down immediately, barely catching itself over Catra´s chest. Catra holds it with the tip of her fingers but then Adora hears her exhale, taking her hands away and letting the fabric too to wrinkle around her waist, letting her sweet chest bare for Adora to take in.

The serpents sliding down the back of Adora´s legs and her waist sizzle beautifully, joyful and shaking with emotions as they reach for Catra too. They wrap their slightly cold and slim bodies around Catra´s chest and the small of her waist, holding her close when Catra sighs, resting her head against the crook between Adora´s neck and her shoulder.

A puff of Adora´s breath crashes softly against Catra´s cheek, giving away just how nervous Adora truly is right now. Nervous and eager, running the back of her knuckles against the crevices of Catra´s ribs and the middle of her belly where peach fuzz melts into a soft trail, disappearing into the wrinkles of the hemation still wrapped around Catra´s hips and making Adora´s mouth water with what lies beneath the soft wool.

Adora closes her eyes, lingering her mouth against Catra´s ears and pushing every single remaining doubt as away as possible from her.“Should we–?”

“We definitely should,” Catra nods immediately, turning around in Adora´s arms to wrap her fingers around the straps of Adora´s chiton, pulling her towards her. “Come here”

They kiss hot, slow and sweetly as they make their way backwards towards the bed, pushing the fabrics of the canopy away and laughing in each other's mouths the entire time. The temple is drowned in darkness, the new moon taking away all kinds of silver lining and the oil candles long ago burnt out.

Catra grabs Adora´s shoulders and spins them around, opening her mouth against Adora´s and kissing her in such a way that Adora´s entire brain melts down to her toes, the serpents twitching and curling over themselves as Catra pushes her down into the bed.

Catra falls over her, her legs stradling Adora´s wide hips and her bottom nestled over her lap. With the turmoil the fabric of their tunics has tussled everywhere, wrinkling around their knees and making their bare legs brush together.

This is not the first time they lay like this, kissing heavily, but this is the first time Catra´s bare chest hovers over Adora´s face, close enough to tempt her and yet far away to not be close enough. And this is the first time Catra pushes Adora flat on her back, letting her entire weight fall over Adora´s own chest, holding her down fully over the cot as her warm hands sneak around the open edge of Adora´s scalloped bodice.

It feels good, and then Catra´s heavy hair falls completely over Adora´s face. It feels hot and pleasurable and beautiful, and then, suddenly, Adora cannot breathe.

Adora stares at the roof of the bed and the shadows around them. Black, dark, *dark* . Oppressing, overwhelming. Catra´s mouth is on her neck, against her windpipe and her pulse point and there are too many sounds, too many feelings. too much darkness.

Weight, sounds, blackness, a mask over her face, iron, holding her down, suffocating her, she cannot breath, she cannot think and she cannot get it off, help me help me stop stop *stop!* —

“Catra,” Adora gasps, pressing her hands against her back. “Catra, s– stop”

The change is immediate, so fast that from the moment Adora mutters the words and Catra scrambles backwards she has barely a fraction of a second to catch up.

Catra moves away immediately, her chest bright red and her breath heavy, searching for Adora among the darkness with her warm palms. Adora wants to reach out for her too but she

is rooted in place, bound between the cot and the branches of the olive tree, her body and limbs too heavy for her to move them as she wants them too.

Instead of obeying her commands, her body shoots forwards too, sitting on the bed with a sharp sprint, folding her body in half as she stares without really seeing anything at the overwhelming darkness closing around her.

It smells like metal and like tears, like the faint stench of blood and men's sweat. It's not really but it still lives inside Adora´s head, staining even the most beautiful moments of her life with their memory.

The serpents snap against each other pull from her scalp, aching her to the very bone with the reminder that they are still there, that she is still this no matter what, that she will never be able to be who she was no matter how fucking deeply she wants it. And even when she tries to accept it, they still try to drown her, closing over her eyes and ears and mouth like spoonfuls of honeyed cotton, weighing heavy against her chest and keeping her from thinking straight.

“Adora,” Catra´s voice comes from the same darkness, also shaking and almost as scared as Adora feels, but sure, ripping her out of the claws of the shadows with her voice alone. “Adora”

Adora glances at her sideways, taking sight of her among the sudden lighter shadows. No, not lighter, just gone.Catra has lit an oil candle next to the bed, casting copper light over the bed.

Catra´s hair is messy and her dark skin is casted in a light sheet of sweat, clinging perspiration over her shoulders and neck. She is covering her bare chest with the edge of the sweet and her eyes are open, seeking for Adora´s shape among the play of the light as she waits for Adora to return to her.

Adora extends a hand towards her, trying to guide her among the darkness too and anchoring them both. But Adora's hands are shaking violently, traveling from the tip and all the way to her elbows, making her teeth click with each other when she tries to speak. So instead she lets her hand fall flat on her lap, holding herself to the fabric of her skirt until her joints ache.

“I´m sorry,” Adora mutters, cringing over the scared tone of her voice. Catra shakes her head, errand curls bouncing on her forehead.

“It´s alright.” She reassures her, taking a deep breath. “It´s alright, Adora, I´m still here”

“Alright”

Catra is still half spread over Adora´s lap, her legs thrown messily over her hips and knees, pressing her down softly, and her midriff tilted towards Adora´s chest. She is warm and beautiful and she doesn´t smell like metal but it´s too much still, just for a little, she is too precious for Adora to handle right now.

“Do you need me to move?” Catra asks in a low voice, sensing the restless movement of Adora´s body beneath her. Adora scowls, angry at herself more than anything else, but she

gives up after a second, exhaling.

“Maybe just off my chest?” It comes as a question, feeling Adora with a horrible sense of inadequacy. “Don´t, don´t leave, though—”

“I won´t, I´m right here”

Catra moves away, just a couple inches but enough for Adora to be able to take a deep breath. Now that there is pressure over her body and that there is light inside the bed, her heart is gradually calming down, the buzzing in her head lowering down until it is almost not there at all.

Catra waits for her, probably for longer than what Adora considers her own panic deserves, but she waits patiently. Her ears twitching in a small movement that Adora has come to learn is her listening to Adora´s breathing and heartbeat next to hers.

“Can I kiss your hand?” Catra asks very softly the moment she hears Adora sigh, something in her breathing calmer enough for her to try and get a little closer.

Adora stares at her beloved face and nods, reaching for her too. “Yes”

Catra tangles their fingers immediately, holding Adora´s still shivering hand between her two hands. Then she brings it forward, up towards her face until she can place a kiss over Adora´s cold knuckles, tampering down the shaking with the reassuring touch of her mouth.

“Fuck” Adora look at herself and frowns, repeating it this time with much more anger. “Fuck”

Now that the sudden fear and the confusion have begun to die down, ire is taking over inside Adora´s chest, clogging her throat and pounding against the sides of her head with her anger. Anger to herself, for ruining this, anger towards what made her scared in the first place, anger towards her own body and her own reactions.

Anger, plain and simple.

“Can you tell me?” Catra asks her, running her thumb in soothing circles over Adora´s joints.

Adora´s first instinct is to say no. To deny anything has happened at all and play dumb and try to do her best to bury this moment of their lives into the oblivion so Catra never brings it up again and Adora can duel in her self inflicted shame as quietly as she can.

That´s what Adora would have done, months, no, weeks ago. What she has done almost her entire life, even before trauma happened to her. Curl inside her own bubble where she can keep everything perfectly controlled until she can slip on a different kind of mask and face the world.

But she loves Catra, and more important than that, she trusts Catra. By this point in their lives together she knows Catra won´t push her away or judge her for any of it, no matter how unbelievable Adora still finds it. Adora knows that, above anyone else, Catra is the one

person that will listen to her not for being a princess or a monster or her lover, but for being only Adora.

“It felt, *I* felt—” Adora gulps loudly, closing her eyes until all she sees are white sparks. “Caged. Like I could not move or control it.”

Catra´s hold around her hand squeezes just a little bit harder but Adora is already miles away from her again, reminiscing the feeling of that time, when the people she trusted and loved the most caged her like a dangerous animal and dragged her away.

Adora thought that now she had accepted love back in her life she had been able to turn away from it, but it seemed her own body had a different idea.

“It felt like when I had that mask on my face. The pressure was– too much. I couldn´t breathe or move or step away. I was just lying there.” Adora looks towards Catra, seeking for her immediately.

Only then she catches the grim expression sewn to Catra´s pretty face, sadness and overwhelming grief free to see on every single corner of her face. Only now Adora realizes that Catra is also relying only on Adora´s voice and her sounds, and that Adora freaking out below her must have been not only confusing but also scary.

“Fuck, I´m so sorry Kiki”

“No, don´t apologize, I understand.” Catra rushes to say, taking Adora´s hand back to her face, peppering kisses all over her sun freckled skin. “I´ll do better”

“It´s not– it´s not your fault.” Adora blurts out, clenching her jaw. But Catra is already three steps before her, as always, tapping her fingers softly over the hard muscles of Adora´s angry jaw.

“I know, and I know it is not about me.” She says, very slow and very firm, her entire face locked into a single serious expression. “But you are my lover Adora. I love you. It's also on me to learn how to take care of you in the ways you like and to know the things that you don't. The things that can trigger you and the things you can find pleasure on. I got you, and you got me back.”

Adora exhales around a sudden rush of tears, pressing her palm over the hand that is cradling her chin, caressing the soft skin of Catra´s hand and anchoring herself to her instead of anything else.

“This is so frustrating,” Adora mutters, sniffling as the tears roll free and cold down her face and into Catra´s hands.

“I know, Dora”

“I want to be with you.” Adora keeps saying, out of breath, “I want to be with you in every way, Catra. I want to kiss, I want to be naked, I want to have sex. I– for the first time in such

a long time I don't feel ugly and not even like that I can. I want to, I *want* you. It's not fair." Adora kicks into the messed up sheets, "I didn´t thought it would ruin this too"

Catra presses her lips together, leaning a little bit closer to Adora. She does it slowly, not hesitant but respectful, waiting until Adora leans towards her too, resting their foreheads together.

"Hey," Catra whispers, wrapping her tail around Adora´s thigh. "Nothing is ruined"

"Isn't it? Because you are so fucking beautiful right now yet I'm really not in the mood anymore"

"Doesn´t mean that it's ruined, or that either of us is." Catra insists, flushing a little at Adora´s words. "This is important too, it had to happen. And I love you all the same."

Catra takes a shaky breath, biting softly into her lip. After a moment of thought she raises on her knees, scooting a little bit closer to Adora, just enough so she can press the bridge of her nose against Adora´s temple but at the same time letting the sheet fall back down, letting her soft breast rest gently against Adora´s bare upper arm.

"It doesn´t mean I don´t want to have sex with you anymore. I really, really want to have sex with you, Adora." Catra whispers, smiling when she feels the warmth immediately crawling its way up to Adora´s face.

"Sure?" Adora´s heart is galloping for very different reasons than fear, still not there but soothing by the reassurance of Catra unwavering love.

"Absolutely." Catra pecks her in the cheek, tilting her head to the side just so she can pinch Adora´s nose right after. "You are the love of my life, you know? I adore you. I desire you too. It won't change no matter how long it takes both of us to get there"

Adora giggles, pinch and all, warmed up from the very center of her chest yet still sad in the edges. "And if it happens again?"

"We´ll take a breath and share what happened, like we are doing today. I'll respect you and you'll respect me." Catra´s eyebrows pinch in the middle, a thought suddenly crossing her mind that she approaches carefully. "What was different this time from earlier, when we were– you know, brushing?"

Adora´s ears are burning, the seed of desire still present even though she is focusing as hard as possible on the now. She tries to think about everything again, from Catra´s view, the feeling of her bare back, the touch of her mouth, the gentleness of their mouths and bodies together and then complete and absolute panic, so sudden is still confusing her.

"I´m not sure." Adora admits, looking around them. "The darkness, I think? I– I don´t know, I´m not sure what could trigger it."

"Alright, It's fine. Don't pressure yourself to know right now, Adora."

Adora sighs, still frustrated, letting her chin rest over her bent knees. Catra curls around her arms, her hands tightly wrapped around her and her own chin resting over Adora´s shoulder. After a moment, a purr starts making its way on Catra´s chest, traveling from her throat to Adora´s body, slowly easing the remaining fear and hesitance.

“We should rest tonight,” Catra says, her ears soft against Adora´s.

Adora shuffles a little next to her, watching her peaceful face out of the corner of her eye. “You don´t mind?”

“Not at all.” Catra smiles against her skin, truly calm for Adora´s everlasting wonder. “Cuddling with you it's my favorite activity anyway”

Adora waits a second and then, “Even over that thing I do with my tongue?”

It´s a poor and frankly pathetic attempt of tampering her own nerves and the tension still holding her tight like a bow´s cord. But it works because Catra immediately erupts into a laughter, giggling right next to Adora´s skin.

“Alright, maybe right after that”

Adora chuckles, letting Catra pull her in an all too different way than before yet just as familiar, curling inside her arms, like a second skin. She feels Catra runs her lips up and down her forehead, from the middle of her still ever so present frown and all the way to the roots of the serpents, not touching them but letting them touch her, focusing all of her attention in the rest of Adora´s temples, head and face.

“Come here, dummy,” Catra murmurs against Adora´s skin, smiling when she feels Adora smile too. “I love you”

“Wow,” Adora purrs too, still marveling at how beautiful it sounds. So new, every single time Catra says it. “I love you too”

Adora ponders about it, taking a long curl of Catra´s hair in her hands and feeling it on her pads. She is back on Catra´s arms but this time it doesn´t feel overwhelming and Adora wonders just what exactly is what fucked up everything minutes ago. She thinks she knows, but she is not ready to go into that thought, not tonight at least.

“For what it's worth, you are very beautiful today.” Adora adds, tilting her head so she can kiss Catra´s sharp collarbone.

“Thank you,” Catra melts, nuzzling her nose against Adora´s. “You are very beautiful too”

“You are blind, baby”

“I have hands.” Catra murmurs back, cradling Adora´s face inside her palms, guiding it gently and loving towards her. “And I have a mouth”

“Oh, yeah?”

“Yup”

Adora hums, absently letting the serpents find their way around Catra´s neck, kissing their way down her still bare spine. “I'm not sure how does that work”

“It's beyond your comprehension, sorry princess”

“I see.” Adora straightens up, pressing her lips against the pretty curve of Catra´s chubby cheek. “Can I show you how pretty I can be, then?”

It´s not sex, neither will it be tonight. But they still love each other and Adora still can do this. Kiss the love of her life senseless.

“Yes”



It smells like flowers, that´s Adora´s first thought, and it is a beautiful, beautiful day. She knows it the moment she steps barefoot outside of the temple, looking at the light showering the cavern in golden shimmers.

There are still fireflies sauntering softly near the grass and the calm rush of the waterfall on the side. And the cavern is in peace, the perfect definition of what peace can actually be, that's the cavern right now. Warm with the care of the spring turning into summer and beautiful as some kind of good omen about to happen.

Adora follows the sweet smell, finding Catra immediately, standing next to the improvised altar. She is holding a clay bowl in her hand, filled to the brim with lotus petals, wine and honey, gently tossing them into the burning brasses until the amber of the flames becomes purples and reds.

She knows Adora is looking at her, Adora can tell by the way her soft ears twitch at her sides and her tail lashes softly towards her, reaching for Adora even without moving. Adora follows her immediately,softly resting her palm on the small of her waist so as not to scare her with the sudden touch.

“What are you doing, my love?” Adora asks,kissing the side of her head.

Catra hums, leaving the bowl on the side so she can lean back on Adora´s palms. “Doing an offering”

“To whom?”

“Hera. Queen of the Heavens.” Catra moves away again, turning around to face Adora still lingering behind her. “And goddess of women and marriage”

Adora holds her breath, gulping heavily as the words make sense to her. She knows of course, after all Adora was once a devotee of the very same gods Catra still prays to every

single day. Adora was an acolyte of Athena's temple and a Priestess of Hera´s. She trusted and she begged and she knew them.

Catra runs her fingers over Adora´s forehead, combing the thin serpents and pushing them back gently. “You´ve been a bit quiet, these last days since what happened the other night in our bed”

Adora wrinkles her nose, her walls immediately threatening to close up around her as she fights to push them down. “You noticed”

“Of course I did,” Catra mutters, soft but still with that cheeky edge that lets Adora know that no matter how much she can try to bury herself, she cannot hide from Catra´s sightless eyes. “Can you tell me about it?”

“I was just thinking, understanding some things. Wondering about others.” Adora admits after a long minute, tilting her head so she can place a kiss on the inner side of Catra´s wrist. “It´s hard, sometimes. But it doesn´t mean I love you any less. In fact, I think it makes me love you more.”

Catra grins softly but it doesn´t really reach her mouth fully. There are many thoughts swirling inside her head, clearly shown on every single corner of her face and Adora knows Catra is letting them show, loosening a little the holds of her emotions so they can be delivered as raw as possible into Adora´s eyes.

“And, do you still can´t believe that I love you?” Catra asks, dropping her hands from Adora ´s face and taking a step back.

There are loose pieces of colorful thread peeking from the knots of her hemation, hidden away from Adora´s eyes. Catra has been weaving non stop for the last few days, sitting on the loom and singing under her breath as Adora wandered and swam inside the lake, letting their head rest.

She has been patient with Adora´s silence and she has been beautiful through it all. She really is the joy of Adora´s life.

“I know you do.” Adora reassures her, reaching for Catra´s hands again, gently unfolding it from its tight curl around itself. “It's just that sometimes, when things like the other night happen, they make me realize just how unbelievable is that I get to have you”

“You have me.” Catra takes a shivering breath, gathering herself of some unknown strength. “I want you to have me in all the ways possible, Adora, I told you the other day. And I want you to have you back”

“You already have me, Kiki”. Adora smiles at her, approaching her closer. Only then does she catch wind of the tremor running up and down Catra´s shoulders and the skin of her shoulders, making her teeth softly click against each other. “You are trembling”

Catra waves Adora´s evident worry with a shake of her head, reaching from Adora´s wrists and softly lowering them back down when Adora searches for her neck and the back of her

shoulder, feeling the edges of the arrow´s scar with her fingertips.

“Listen to me for a second, alright?” Catra asks, taking a deep breath before speaking again. “I really like to think that I would have found you sooner or later and in any way, even if what happened to us had not occurred. I like to think Adam was our bridge together and I like to think our bond together has always been created out of love, no matter what”

She is running her thumbs over Adora´s knuckles in a motion the letter has come to know is a grounding tick for when Catra is feeling too much all at once.

“I know you want a lot of things, Adora, I know you wish you had been able to give me different things than the ones right now. Sometimes I want that too. I wish I could have shown you my home; the river, the fields, the trees.” Catra´s ears are twitching like crazy, giving away how truly nervous she feels. “I know you still wish you could be different, but the thing is, Adora, that I would have loved you in any way. I would have loved you as much as I love you now. I don´t want anything else but you”

Adora cannot pay attention to her ears, or the waterfall, or the pink flames of the altar right now. All of her attention is placed solely in Catra in front of her. On her shivering shoulders and her strong hold on Adora´s fingers and the way her sightless and silver eyes are open just a little, damp with tears in the edges.

“I´ve been waiting for you for twenty six years, Adora. I want you to know every single day how much I adore you no matter what”

Catra takes her hand to the side, finding the edge of the loose threads and pulling from them softly until Adora realizes they are not actually lose but bound to a single long rope, beautiful woven and twisted into an Heracles Knot, the redsand the goldens braiding and meeting each in a perfect dance that represents the both of them, right now as they are and also as they were.

Catra turns Adora´s palm upside down and Places the long rope over her palm, gently curling her fingers closed over it. “The last step is yours. If you want it”

Adora blinks, thick tears falling down her cheek and running down the small of her chin, dripping against the beautiful woven rope on her palms, a silent declaration of love for Adora to wrap around herself and to hold them both together for the rest of their lives.

“I can never leave this place,” Adora breathes through tears, caressing the soft rope with shaking fingers. “If you to tie yourself to a life like this Catra—”

“Adora”

“Yes?”

“Marry me”

“Yes”

Catra raíces on her tippy toes, reaching for Adora´s face and cradling the side of her jaw as she brings her towards herself, pressing their mouth together into a searing and sweet kiss.

Adora was once betrayed by the bargain of a marriage meant to bring power and to use her as a tool. Catra was once pushed to the wolves for being too sick to be considered capable of wed at all. They are still in pain, they still ache; they live with it and none of it is their fault.

A year ago they were strangers, blindly looking for each other yet afraid. Then they were souls living together and then friends, baring their hearts to each other. Then they were lovers and with the golden light of the incoming spring they are about to become wives, on their own terms.

Adora thinks about it and the last of the doubt casted over her heart and her mind dissipates like cold fog under the warm sun, leaving only spring behind. It makes Adora laugh, it makes her smile and giggle in Catra´s sweet mouth, wrapping her arms around Catra´s waist and carrying her a few inches from the floor with the strength of their kiss and her love for her.

“I don´t know how brides dress,” Catra mentions around a giggle, still pressing her mouth against Adora´s and unable to hold her joy even though she is still shivering.

“I´ll help you,” Adora reassures her, her mouth and all of the serpents kissing their way up and down Catra´s temples.

Catra hums, the corners of her eyes wrinkling when she closes her eyes and smiles. “Were you in many weddings?”

“I was a Priestess of the temple of Hera.” Adora looks at the now green flames, blinking slowly at them. “I helped and saw how things were made.” She returns her golden eyes to Catra´s silver ones, pressing her nose against hers. “We might have to improvise some”

“Good.” Catra whispers, closing her eyes with a sigh, trusting Adora to guide her through darkness. “Let's make it ours”

Adora stares at the golden light of the sun and falls in wonder with the beauty of the cavern around them. When Adora arrived here there was nothing to call pretty or tender. Only coarse dirt and crumbling stones of an abandoned temple. Only cold water from the rain lake and quartz that smelled like phosphorus.

Then there was Catra and spring came with her, like a prophecy turned into a song. And with the spring came the evergreen and turquoise grass, and the golden fields; the three trees bursting with life and the multicolored blooms on the ground; the pink quartz and the warm water and the stone paths made with pebbles.

Then there was Catra and there was light and stars and music inside a cave that had become a prison, and an exile that had become a home. There was Catra and with her, Adora found herself again.

“It´s really beautiful today,” Adora points out, resting her forehead over Catra´s. This way she can feel her smile, this way Catra can hear the beating of her heart.

“Yeah?”

“Yes.” Adora cries, kissing her closed eyes. “I think it's a perfect day”

Adora had been taught everything that there could ever be about weddings, the long days of festivities and the meaning of each of them.

She had learnt the meaning of the flowers and the offerings during the *Proaulia* ; the importance of the *gamos* with its purifying waters and the *pompa* , a declaration of love to the rest of the world.

She knew all of it and how it had to be done, yet neither of them could have nothing of it. Adora didn´t even had a *plepos* to wrap Catra´s bridal body into. And the thought would have made her sad if it weren´t for Catra, again, skipping her way joyfully through their secret garden with her cane in one hand and Adora´s fingers in the other, taking them both to pick up flowers from the bushes and the floor.

It was no *gamos* or *pompa* , but it was quite enough.

It´s not wedding *plepos* , but Catra wears purple for their wedding. She asks Adora exactly which one it is and bare herself completely in front of Adora´s betrothed eyes, not a single doubt underneath, slipping inside the beautiful fabric Adora had once woven on the loom when she was all by herself, not knowing it would be her wife´s attire in a future.

Catra fastens the soft fabric over her shoulders and seeks slowly for the leather ropes tossed somewhere where their other clothes lay but Adora stops her, carrying with her long string of natural pearls on her hands, still slightly wet from where she dug them from the cave´s ground and dipped them in the lake before bringing them to her.

Catra feels their imperfect forms with her fingers and smiles, raising her arms to the side as she allows Adora to run the string on the back of her neck, behind her armpits and all the way across her backs, crossing it twice around the narrow of her waist before fastening the long ends with a red ribbon, quite old, the last piece of the red dress Adora was wearing when she was delivered into this place.

The iridescent white, black and blue of the pearls is bright against the purple fabric and the darkness of Catra´s skin, somehow perfectly in harmony with the golden bracelets and heavy earrings that Catra places around her wrists, ankles and ribs, jiggling with each other like Adora used to do when they first met.

Adora stares at her own clothes, wondering for a second if she is allowed to wear them again, after so long. The flounced and layered Mycenaean skirt falls long against her ankles when she slips into it, closing on the back with almost perfect fit. The fabrics are slightly wrong but after all this is a rough comparison to the ones Adora used once.

Red, blues and yellow contrast with each other in each layer, heavy where Adora dipped them in saffron and other spices. Purple in the bodice where Adora once crushed sea snails to create a purple so similar to the one Catra wears that they are one at the same.

These are the clothes Adora made for herself five, no, six years ago, thinking she would be able to be again who she was before being humiliated and broken. It has been a long journey to get there, but as Adora lips into the short sleeves of the bodice and Catra´s soft hands brush flat the scalloped embroidered on the open neckline, Adora thinks each day was worth it if it was going to get her here in the end.

Adora wraps a thick and heavy belt around her own waist, accentuating the small of her waist and the wide of her hips where the gold and the glass beads fill her with colors she had not seen on herself in such a long, long time ago.

Adora paints suns on Catra´s cheeks and then on her own, looking at herself in the mirror as the long tendril of the serpents bodies fall against her shoulders and her back, painted in golden powders and adorned with gold cuffs and pearls too. Excited, singing. Pretty.

Unlike Catra, she doesn´t wear any more jewelry but Catra fastens Adam´s wing pin on the fabric of Adora´s bodice, smiling when Adora takes a sharp breath and tries not to crumble down. It will never be him, but it´s a way of carrying him today, right next to her heart.

Adora stares at herself on the reflection of the copper and the movement of the calm lake and her own golden eyes look at her right back, staring not at a monster or an exiled princess but a bride, all blushing cheeks and happy smiles.

She is herself, still.

“Adora,” Catra whispers next to her, the fabric of her wedding plepos brushing in soft grass. “Turn around”

Adora does so immediately because she will always turn around for Catra, finding her standing right behind her and waiting with a smile. She has dusted her own face with golden powder and kissed cherries until her lips were berries themselves. She is womanhood and beautiful in front of Adora, sea foam born from the shells hanging from her neck and dusted in golden light.

“How do I look?” She asks and Adora has to fight a rush of tears to fall.

“Absolutely beautiful”

Adora places a veil over Catra´s hair, pinning it safely to her curls with sapphire and amethyst pins, watching as Catra takes the long fabric from the floor and carries it around her arms, the sand near the lake dusting the veil like stardust.

Adora braids flowers in Catra's hair, read poppies and white anemones; daisies of fragile petals and olive leaves instead of laurel branches. Catra sits for twenty minutes inside the canopy of their bed and sews together the pieces of an old Polos, the copper metal of the circle crown scratched and the fabric of the blue veils scattered with tiny pears when Catra helps Adora place it over the curious serpents, who quiet just enough to give Adora a moment of stillness, frozen in time.

They smile and they laugh the entire time, skipping in bare feet over the grass and the mosaics. They kiss the whole time too, smudging red on each other's lips and pinching the others ribs just so they can hear the laughter from their mouths.

Catra is already skipping down the temple and dragging Adora with her, the cane making a sweet sound over the stone paths when Adora stops her briefly, resting her palm on her warm cheek. “Wait”

“Mmm?” Catra turns towards her, blinking sheepishly with her eyes unfocused and deeply white.

“There´s something else.” Adora trembles just a little when she raises her hands and places the slim golden circlet around Catra´s forehead, the soft golden and white wing-like shapes resting right over Catra´s temples and losing themselves around the flowers. “There”

Catra takes her hand towards the fine crowl and her eyes open wide, her jaw slack when she makes sense of the material of the wings.“Are these—?”

“Scales,” Adora shrugs, blushing. “I plucked a few”

“But—”

“It doesn't hurt”

Whatever frail control that Catra had been able to manage while they dressed snaps clean in half, breaking the walls of her tears and making them fall free and warm against her face, splashing softly over Adora´s skin when the latter takes Catra´s hands between hers and bends down to places kiss inside her palms.

“Where–?

“On the trees”

Here, on the circle of their secret garden, the light of the midday sun washes directly over them, showering them in blues and goldens all the same. Adora thinks that is fitting, because Catra is all of Adora´s light, all of it that she thought had been ripped off, in flesh and breathing. Alive.

They stand in front of each other, holding their hands. Each of them holds one end of the Heracles knot, waiting patiently. The grass sneaks between their toes and the birds are quiet, looking at them from their places on the skies.

Catra´s eyes are casted up, half closed but alert, searching and finding Adora among the overwhelming light slipping inside her white pupils. Adora´s eyes are wide open, golden and still cursed but not for Catra, allowed to learn every single freckle and mole of her face, gifted of the joy of being able to press a kiss on every single of them.

“Kiki?” Adora whispers, now the one trembling from head to toe. Or maybe it´s the both of them, feeling the true meaning of what they are about to do, the line they are about to erase between them.

Catra blinks a little, too deep inside the haze of her happiness.“Hmm?”

“When *that* happened to me, instead of flying I started to fall and I could not seem to stop.” Adora says because she needs to, she needs to tell Catra exactly how much she means to Adora. She needs to know and Adora needs to say it after so long in silence. “And all these years before you all I hope was the mercy of a soft landing. But the thing is that you don´t ever let me hit the ground”

Catra sniffles, her tears smudging a little the sun marks. She looks like she wants to say something but Adora quiets her gently, pressing a kiss on the corner of her mouth. Catra has already said so much between them, she was already brave and gave the first step.

This is Adora's turn.

“Spring returned to my life the moment you came into it,” Adora whispers next to Catra's closed eyelids, blessing them. “Thank you”

They tie the knot. It's easy, almost like something already known. Like something they had learnt a long time ago and that they were ready to sink into when they were both ready to come back to each other.

Catra braids her hand against Adora's and Adora does the same, joining the ends of the rope around their wrists and their hearts and making them one eternal circle to which they will always return to.

It's no long festivity, no party, no games. There is nobody else inside this place but the both of them and maybe, just maybe, flying goddesses outside the open domes that showers them in light. It all makes it absolutely beautiful and it makes it enough.

Catra kisses a love confession in Adora´s mouth and smiles, finally filling the silence with their love.

“Now we are together.”

They feast.

Catra makes offerings and Adora observes her in silence and then they feast. Rich meat, almost all of it; ripe fruits, figs and pomegranates and apples and berries; seed and honey bread as their wedding cake dipped in heavy red wine and spiced stew.

Catra is joyful, so is Adora, they are both hungry young women, holding each other as honey drips from their lips. They eat and they steal the pomegranate seeds and bread from each other's mouth and laugh until their bellies are full and they cannot possibly keep going anymore.

It´s only the two of them, as it has always been, and it´s peaceful, Catra lays on Adora´s lap with her wedding veils tangled around her legs and Adora plays the lyre for her, singing for the first time in a long time, lullabies about kind love stories instead of heroic stories.

The golden day gives way to a blue night and even the grass around them seems to mirror the joy, a thousand and more fireflies hovering over the soft moss and grass all around the warm temple. Adora guides Catra there,speaking to her in soft voice around the slightly treacherous ground and holding her hand and cane inside hers.

They sit on the slightly dew damp grass and Adora catches the tiny bugs inside her hands, one by one, letting them rest gently inside Catra´s palms and describing them to her from their tiny paws to their green shine until Catra learns them too from the inside out.

And tonight green is not oppressive and it's not wrong for Adora. Tonight is sweet because after all that happened and all the odds, Adora survived. And she is here, right here, sitting on the grass next to her wife.

It´s late and Adora knows that they should sleep, cradled by the green and pink flames of the altar and the quiet of the spring night, but she is wide awake and she knows while Catra is patient and quiet, she is wide awake too.

A familiar itch has begun to crawl gently beneath Adora´s skin, covering her from the inside out like a soft blanket and raising her heartbeat at the very same time. It´s warm and sweet and too strong to ignore and as Adora steps into the temple and catches Catra lighting every single oil lamp around them so Adora is not surrounded by darkness, Adora realizes this is the moment she wants.

“Catra,” Adora calls for her, barely above a whisper but enough for Catra to hear.

“Yes?” Catra turns around, errand petals falling above her shoulders and dress. “Adora?”

“I want us to make love,” Adora finally asks for, opening and closing her hands at her sides.

Catra´s bangles jingle against each other when she brings her hands forward, silently asking Adora to take them. Adora does. Their wedding knot lays safely on the branches of the olive tree behind them.

“We´ve been making love, Dora,” Catra teases her softly, tilting her head. “Sort of”

Adora chuckles softly, staring as one of the serpents reaches blindly for Catra, nuzzling its face against Catra´s cheek.

“You know what I mean”

“Yes, I do.” Catra bites into her bottom lip, her unfocused and beautiful eyes moving softly from side to side. “Adora, you are allowed to want”

“I want you,” Adora says immediately, pouring all of her want on her voice so Catra can feel it too.

“And I you,” Catra nods, red from cheeks to heart. “All the time”

Adora gazes at her and exhales a few times, gathering herself of bravery before finally managing to speak her desires. “I want us to have real sex”

Catra blushes immediately and so does Adora, stepping closer to her wife and exhaling in relief when Catra wraps her tails around Adora´s wrist, keeping her grounded in the now.

“Are you sure?” Catra asks still because she needs to know and Adora needs to reassure her and herself too.

Adora grins, a smile that goes from soft to absolutely giggling ridiculous, any kind of doubt left behind. “Yes”

“Alright,” Catra grins, big and giggling too. “Good because me too”

Adora kisses her, all lips and slightly crashing lips, drinking in Catra´s soft gasp against her tongue as she melts inside the touch of Adora´s palms. Adora brings a hand towards her head, still without stop kissing Catra, and takes her own crown off, letting it fall somewhere on the crooked pillars before doing the same with Catra´s scale crown and her veil, gently leaving them to the side too.

Catra rests her forehead against Adora´s nose once they manage to lean apart from each other, caressing Adora´s sun kissed lip with her fingertips.

“Tell me,”she asks, waiting for Adora to tell her how before stepping into the last sand line of their love.

Adora takes a shivering breath, resting her palms on the middle of Catra´s spine.

“I´d like to touch you first. I– I need to feel I have some control.” Adora´s half opened eyes fly open, suddenly mildly horrified by how wrong her words came. “I mean– I´m not saying– not control over you like you are a possession or anything or like I own you– just–”

“Adora, I understand.” Catra stops the storm of Adora´s thought in the middle, pressing her hand against Adora´s runaway heart. “Breathe”

Adora closes her eyes, breathing several times and resting her forehead against her wife´s. Wife, how amazing.

“Alright”

“I want that to,” Catra chuckles, pinching Adora´s cheek.

Adora´s eyes open again, finding Catra´s marble white in front of her. “Really?”

“Yeah. I don´t really know what I´m doing and,you know, where exactly to place what.” Catra waves her hand in front of her own eyes, chuckling when Adora gives a surprised hiccup of understanding. “I´d like you to guide us both the first time”

Adora gulps loudly, nodding furiously. “Alright.”

“No pressure”

“Yeah, right,” Adora chuckles, shaking her head softly. All of the serpents are curling around her own legs, too excited to do anything else but lay still. “I don´t know what I´m doing either”

“Well there you go, we are both clueless”

“No, I mean, I have read and heard things. I know the basics.” Adora shuffles on her bare feet, shrugging. “The theory”

“Adora, I´m not a prude. I know the theory too,” Catra´s tail lashes softly underneath Adora´s nose, calling for her attention. “Aren´t you a scientist too? Get to the experiment”

Adora throws her head back and cackles out loud, so taken aback by Catra´s words that for a moment forgets all seriousness and just laughs, her entire body relaxing. Catra tries to scowl but she is giggling too, feeling the way the corners of Adora´s mouth stretch every time she laughs.

“Yes, my love.” Adora accepts the command like a general to her queen, gathering Catra´s wild curls in her palm and cuffing them softly. “Seriously, Kiki. If there is something you don't like, if I´m hurting you–”

“I´ll let you know. And you´ll let me know too.” Catra lingers a kiss on Adora´s cheek, suddenly too eager to still be standing. “Come here”

“What should we–?” Adora wonders, still seeking for Catra´s light.

“Kiss me first, Catra whispers against her lips, shivering. “And then take me to our bed”

I can do that, Adora thinks, too busy kissing Catra´s mouth to speak at all. She smiles against Catra´s sweet mouth and bends down, following a sudden sprout of confidence as she crosses her arm underneath Catra´s knees and carries her off the mosaic floor and into her arms.

Catra gasps on the kiss, delighted by the surprise, renewing the fire of her excitement. She cradles Adora´s face and a few serpents between her palms and brings her close into a new heart melting kiss.

Adora takes them both successfully inside the canopy and over their bed, proud of herself when she doesn´t slip and fall while still carrying Catra in her arms.

Absently and still kissing her, Adora thinks of all the nights that she lay on this bed hoping for death and mourning for a love she thought had been ripped off her. And she thinks of all the night after, where she lay awake hearing Catra´s soft breathing and loving her in silence.

Adora doesn´t want to be silent anymore. She wants to love Catra loudly, so loudly that the sound of their adoration and devotion for each other reaches the very heavens and defies the

Fates themselves. She wants to love her so loudly that their love is written on the very foundations of this world and lives forever.

A kind of love so strong that was woven by their own hands not by Fate. A kind of love that will turn pain into dust and joy into blooms. A love that becomes a vow and a vow that becomes a new prophecy, to always return..

“Adora,” Catra whispers against the roof of her mouth when her wife lays her down on their wedding bed. “Adora ”

“Shh. Shh, I’m here.” Adora whispers because she thinks any other voice would be a sin right now.

“Don’t backtrack on me now”

“I’m not. Never”

Catra opens her eyes, silver moon and marble blessed and for a moment Adora knows that Catra can see her, fully, in different ways that she has ever been seen before. In ways that her curse cannot stain, in the ways Adora needs and Catra loves.

“I want this Adora,” Catra reassures her one last time, opening herself like a bloom in Adora ´s palms” I love you”

****

Adora ’s lips brush over the edge of Catra´s ears, caressing their length with soft touches, first the right then the other side, following peach softness and twitching gentleness against her lips.

Catra can feel her hands brushing gently the width of her own waist, holding between her fingers the silk fabric of Catra's tunic, grounding her hips into the mattress with light but powerful pressure. A fraction,just a fraction big enough to keep Catra secure in place without bending her in half.

All that strength, all that raw terrifying power that mortals and gods tremble under, all of it placed lovingly in Catra 's hands, cupped securely between her palms and fingertips. All that untamed flame that could bend the world in half and snap Catra in pieces, calm like a dormant ocean, placing the sweetest of the kisses over her magicat ears, her forehead, the bridge of her nose.

Catra has never felt as electrified and excited and loved as now, nestled between warm blankets and Adora ’s arms and body.

Catra breathes deeply through her nose, resting her hands blindly over Adora ’s shoulders. She can’t see Adora but she does feel the softness of her skin tickling her upper arms and cheekbones, and she lets out a bubbly giggle when Adora ’s hands travel up to her ribs, painting swirls over her skin.

The lazy knots that keep the front of her tunic closed come undone, falling open right in the middle, right above Catra´s sternum and the start of her ribs, barely clinging to the skin of her breasts and exposing her to the increasingly humid air around them.

For a moment Catra feels subconscious, suddenly nervous as the expanse of her chest is revealed slowly by Adora´s fingers slipping beneath the fabric and pushing it away the small inches left that is needed.

Even though Catra knows that Adora has seen her before, tending to new and old scratches of wounds, right now that they are right here, on their now marital bed about to bound each other's bodies in a different way, she feels nervous because she doesn't quite know how she actually looks or if it´s enticing enough.

They are quite different from each other too, that's quite obvious even without a sight. Where Adora is all strong muscles on her arms and calves, Catra is much more lean, square hips and straight limbs.

Where Adora´s breasts feel supple and big, hanging with their weight and brushing the skin of Catra´s belly past the tunics when Adora hovers over her, Catra´s chest is so small she is basically flat when she rests on her back, slightly arching off the mattress when Adora brush her nose against her neck and collarbone.

Where Adora´s waist and hips and big, beautiful to the touch, followed by the exquisite rolls of her stomach and belly when she bends slight in half, and the warm and supple flesh of her thighs; Catra feels herself almost disappear completely beneath them, not fleshed and supple enough to be considered commonly enticed by a woman that is not only a living sun but that has walked among halls of many other beautiful women of nobles houses.

And it makes Catra doubt herself, her perception of her own body forever casted in the shadows by her own eyes. Just for a moment.

Then Adora is there, right there as if she could hear or feel everything that Catra is going through right now, convincing her otherwise.

Adora´s hands travel from the space between Catra´s shoulder and her collarbones to her ribs, one at each side, traveling up and up until she is able to wrap her entire hand around Catra´s chest, holding her inside warmth and faint perspiration like a lotus bloom floating in water.

And at first Catra thinks she won´t be able to hold anything at all but then Adora´s hand squeezes down and Catra is moaning out loud, letting her mouth fall open when she realizes Adora´s palm is just exactly perfect to cradle Catra´s chest inside and pinch the hard nub of her nipple between her fingers, setting aflame every single nerve ending of Catra´s body.

Who would have thought that Catra would be so sensitive here? Right in these spots of her chest where Adora is leaning again, still holding one breast inside her hand and kneading it gently while she presses her face against the other, cradling it completely against another kind of warmth.

Catra gasps and kicks blindly at the fine sheets crumbling around their legs, unable to keep herself from shaking from head to toe as she feels the flat of Adora´s tongue gathering her nipple over the slippery surface and the move up and down, the split end kissing both sides of her breast in a lazy kind of dance that makes Catra go half insane even though they have barely started.

"Adora," Catra gasps, running her hands across her own face and the roots of her hair, messing the bridal braids when she pulls from them with a wet gasp. “Adora”

Adora hesitates for a second when she hears her and then she is gone, making Catra almost curse herself out loud when she feels her slowly rip herself from Catra´s chest in order to change positions.

Adora doesn´t go far though, just enough so she can rest almost the entirety of her still clothed chest over Catra´s, nuzzling their cheeks together in a gentle caress.

“You are beautiful,” Adora whispers, already sore and patchy against Catra´s ear. “You are beautiful and you are mine”

“Gods. Adora”

Adora's lips brush against hers, softly, tender. It's just a whisper of warmth against a shuddering breath. Catra's breath hitches, stealing a quiet rumble from the depths of her throat, almost like a purr, trembling against Adora's lips. Adora hums in return, smiling against the kiss, tilting her head just enough so she can catch Catra's mouth between hers fully, her nose brushing against her cheek.

The air is hot inside the bed, warm and a little bit sticky with the flower candles burning in the tiny lamps over their heads. The entrance of the canopy is closed shut tightly, the ribbons knotted together to give them privacy in their sleep. Far away, they still can hear the gentle hum of the waterfalls and the night birds singing, their joined music a cheerful background as they bare their heart opens to each other.

Adora exhales, leaning back just enough so she can cradle Catra's face between her hands, placing tiny, scattering kisses across her face. Over the bridge of her nose and the angle of her jaw, the cluster of star freckles and the divot of her mouth when she smiles.

Adora´s slightly crooked teeth catch in the dark skin gently when she nibbles over Catra's chin, making her gasp and sight between her palms.

Catra blinks at her, drowsy, her silver and sightless eyes misted with love and tenderness. Thin paths of tears that neither of them had noticed between kisses make a way through her cheeks, pooling in the curve of her neck and the dips of her collarbones.

Adora presses one more kiss over the corner of her mouth, just to press her mouth over each eyelid, collecting the tears on her lips and washing them away as worry pools hot like lava in the pits of her belly.

"Are you alright?" Adora asks, voice husky, deep, just barely kept from trembling. Catra nods, her head heavy and hands slow when she raises them, tangling them in the honeyed bodies of the lazy serpents that escape Adora's fine veil when the leather band gives away, and sliding sweetly across Catra´s shoulders and belly. “Do you want me to stop?”

“No,” Catra rushes to say, her ears burning by how quick she says it.

Instead of keeping talking, Catra nuzzles her cheeks against the side of her face in gentle strokes. They move together, Catra guiding for a second and Adora following until they are back sitting, Catra sitting in Adora´s lap as a mirror of a few days before.

Catra shifts, wrapping her arms around Adora's neck, climbing over her until her thighs cradle Adora's waist. Adora wraps her own arms around Catra's waist in return, their lips gravitating back to each other like planets to the sun. The blanket slips from her shoulders and into the colorful mosaics of the floor, surrounding them in sticky air and heavy shared breaths.

Now this, this is familiar. And Adora surprises herself by how relieved both of them seem to be by the easiness of something both of them already know. At least while both of them start knowing each other in much more intimate ways.

It´s almost choreographed actually, like a dance, the way their own bodies reach for each other before their minds catch up with what is happening, too distracted by the fog of open mouthed kisses and hands running down the length of necks.

Adora's hips hitch forward in time as Catra meets her in the middle, her own hips dragging a long line over her middle, already wet and slick with the unavoidable feeling of Adora holding her in her arms and kissing her as if she was the most beloved thing in her entire heart.

Adora feels her, of course she does, even past the wrinkled layers of the skirts of their tunics, warm and damp and enticing and all Adora´s. She parts from Catra´s kiss bitten mouth with a wet gasp and stares at her flushed face with her words tangled, licking the edge of her lips in nervous silence.

"Catra—"

"Don't stop," Catra whispers in a rush. She licks small and tender at the angle of Adora's nose, pressing an open mouthed kiss against her forehead. She thumbs the skin below Adora's eyes, once hated by Adora and always beloved by Catra, brushing them down her neck so she can cling to Adora's shoulders, running her hands down her wide shoulder blades, locking their foreheads together, raw and vulnerable. "There is nobody else I'd give myself away but you"

Adora sighs, smiling through her own rivulets of tears. She bumps her forehead against Catra's, closing her eyes against the tenderest if it all.

"I'm yours," Adora whispers back, strong like her quiet vows and the knots of their betrothal ribbons. "Heart and soul. Body. I'm completely yours"

“I know”

Catra smiles against Adora´s mouth, so bright and joyful that her smile alone could rival the light on the sun alone and for a moment Adora feels herself Icharus, sauntering towards the sea of Catra´s arms at full speed and out of control.

Adora is fine with that, in fact, she would fall a thousand and one more times if it meant landing inside Catra´s palms.

“I won´t let you fall,” Adora reassures her, and herself, her heartbeat already speeding up with the incoming necessity of doing it all perfectly for Catra. “I will give you pleasure”

“Give me all your love.” Catra murmurs against her lips, tampering down Adora´s fear of not doing it perfectly with the touch of her lips alone. “The rest will come with it”

Adora smiles and returns to kiss her, stealing all the breath of Catra´s lungs and making her breathless, running her thumbs over the open neckline of Adora´s bodice and the layers of her skirt, still getting in the middle of their love making.

“Clothes,” Catra grunts, slightly annoyed, making Adora chuckle against her lips.

“Sorry”

Adora shimmers out of the purple bodice and throws it carelessly to the side, doing the same with the pearl ribbons still holding Catra´s plepos in place, making the fabric wrinkle down even more.

"Help me out, will you?" Catra asks, voice hoarse, coated with pleasure and trust, her smirk the most beautiful sight Adora has ever seen.

Every time she looks at Catra, it's the most beautiful thing, each time surpassing the other. Adora suspects it will always be like this, forever enchanted by the beauty of walking through life besides Catra.

They struggle with the fabric for a bit, laughing at each other and the silliness of it all until their clothes finally come off, also forgotten in a heap somewhere inside the temple.

They'll worry about that. Later.

Instead, Adora wraps her hands around Catra's waist and nape, guiding her down until her back is resting over the cot, pressed down lightly by the weight of Adora's body over hers once again.

The bed is comfortable and soft, coated with quilts and blankets and feather pillows and Adora swears she doesn't know if some goddess foresaw this years before it happened but she might actually burn some wine for them in the morning. Maybe.

Catra pokes at her forehead with the tip of her nail, smiling mischievously when Adora comes back to Etheria, focusing on her with a tiny gasp.

Her dark hair is splayed below her like copper, illuminated by the golden light of the candles. Her silver eyes are halfway close, unfocused yet searching for Adora through thick, dark eyelashes and sharp mouth, even through the mist of lust and love mixed within herself.

Bare like this, Adora can look at her full. Soft curves, gentle creases, the path that goes from her sternum to her bellybutton, coated by the lightest layers of sweat. She has lines like thunderbolts over her hips and thighs and Adora can't wait to run her teeth and tongue over them, revering them with kisses.

With a shiver she realizes she will get to. They have the whole night today and then they'll have their entire lives. Adora will make sure of it.

Catra cradles Adora's face between her palms, pulling her back into her embrace with the smallest of efforts. She knows Adora will follow. "Stay with me"

Adora does.

Adora makes herself a home inside Catra´s open arms. Without tunic, chiton nor hemation that can come between them, everything is a hundred times stronger and a thousand times more electrified, cursing through both of them in warm volts when their shivering skins slide against each other and finally meet in the middle.

Catra can feel the warmth of Adora´s sex hovering over her own thigh and she holds back a whimper with little success, shivering from head to toe. Even here Adora is ripe as a peach, soft and addictive for Catra like pressed poppies.

Adora´s outer lips are slightly smaller, basically hidden by the brush of soft hair that Catra can feel it travels from below her bellybutton in a pretty trail all the way to her lips, like a closed bloom damp with her own excitement and shivering when it meets Catra´s thigh.

Her clit, though, her clit is big, bigger than Catra´s which she can barely find when she is touching herself. Wide and pulsing under her touch when Catra brushes her fingertips over the hood, ripping a high moan from Adora´s mouth. Catra can feel it shivering in herpalm when she cradles it between her fingers, pumping once and thrice until Adora is almost bending over herself, barely catching on her hands and gasping at the feeling of the love of her life touching her in such an intimate with so much love that it spins her entire world around its axis.

Adora narrows her eyes around pleasure, speechless for a second as she looks down and finds Catra´s face beneath her. Even though she is the one being touched right now, Catra´s beautiful face is so consumed by pleasure that it takes Adora a few seconds to blink off her wonder for her.

Catra shakes and kicks at the bed, pressing the pads of her fingers flat and sure against Adora ´s engorged clit at the same time her hand travels up, wrapping it around her own small breast and kneading into, taking pleasure on the feeling of Adora´s moaning above her body.

Adora locks her jaw and grinds her teeth, finding herself suddenly displeased by the distance between her own body and Catra´s pleasure.

Adora moves away from Catra´s touch, wrapping her hands around Catra´s hips and marveling at the way her fingers almost touch before yanking Catra´s entire body towards her, no effort or resistance at all, moving her exactly how she wants her and needs her as she regains control.

Catra´s breath hitches in her throat and she moans so loudly by the sheer expression of Adora ´s want that for a moment Adora´s sight spots in dark, her ears ringing with the echo of Catra panting and moaning beneath her fingers.

Adora untangles them from their current position and nestles herself between Catra´s spread legs instead, diving forward. It´s all kinds of awkward at first and it takes Adora a few tries to understand how to place her legs but by the moment she finally comprehends Catra is already beyond words, digging her nails against the blankets below and the planes of Adora´s abdomen, begging her to touch her already with faltering voice.

“Adora, *ah,* ´dora”

“I´m here”

Adora rests Catra´s left leg over her elbow, marveling at the natural stretch of Catra´s limbs when Adora slides forwards. Before her legs would cradle Catra´s, her clit brushing a line over Catra´s thigh, but like this, when Adora crosses her own leg leg and knee over Catra´s right hip, their clits meet completely, kissing in a way that only her mouth had done before.

It's exhilarating and hot, brushing the petals of her flowers together as they move at the same time, rocking each other from side to side and finally making love to each other.

Where Adora is engorged, Catra´s clit is much smaller but just as hard already by the slide of their bodies together, pressing open mouthed kisses by another kind of lips over each other.

Adora holds her breath and looks, biting into her mouth to hold back a gasp when she finally sees into Catra´s core, coming together and leaning apart over and over in slick weaves of release. Catra´s clit is smaller, yes, but her outer lips are long, gorgeous, covered in a mountain of curly dark hair and of a brown so beautiful it makes Adora´s mouth water. Slightly curled edges that tempt Adora until the latter lower down her hand and deep it between them. running the entire length of her fingertips across Catra´s labia and gathering her cum in her palm.

Catra raises her hips and meets her in the middle, wrapping her hand around Adora´s wrist as her lover takes her damp hand away from both of their sexes and presses it against Catra´s cheeks instead, leaning down to kiss her fully on the mouth. Their clits brush and they both moan, Adora´s release dripping against Catra´s open entrance and mingling them together forever.

Adora embraces Catra over the blankets, wrapping her arms around her chest before she accommodates their legs, crossed over each other in a braid in flesh and sweat.

Catra arches an eyebrow, swiftly confused until Adora pulls her hips down and then *drags.* Their cores brush against each other fully, not only their clits but also their lips kissing too in

their own way.

Catra can feel Adora dripping, soaked against her skin and her pulsing entrance, and the mere thought that Adora watching her come undone seems to have broken her too, shattering Catra into pieces.

Her head falls back against the pillows with a long moan, grasping at the blankets around her, digging holes in the fabric with her nails. Adora shifts again and leans towards her body, gently undoing her vice grip over the blankets just so she can turn Catra's hands around, palms up, tangling their hands and fingers together, holding to each other.

Adora's head falls between Catra's breasts, nesting her way above her heart as they rub against each other, both of their dams broken and open, falling and intermingling with each other until they don't know where one begins and where ends the other.

Adora can hear Catra's heartbeat like this, quick and joyful as a hummingbird, drumming inside her chest in time with the rhythm of her breathing, long pants and quiet moans that mess up the baby hairs atop of her hair.

Catra's voice shatters around a broken moan, crashing like little songs against Adora's ears, making Adora shiver with one long caress between their bodies.

Catra opens her eyes just a slit, just enough so she can look up at the light that must be Adora's face. She is always so honest about everything, her emotions written on her body, her heart on her sleeve.

Even right now, especially right now, Catra can feel the way her face wrinkles and relaxes with the overwhelming feeling of their love making, desire and want and *love* clear in her voice and in every single of her movements.

It is all so incredibly overwhelming for Catra, who relies on sounds and touch alone, that she sobs, detangling their hands just so she can nest Adora's face between them, bringing her close.

Adora makes a quiet, questioning sound, cleaning the errand tears away with her fingers but Catra just shakes her head, smiling truthfully through her tears, cooing Adora close until she can press an open mouthed kiss in her mouth.

Adora's tongue shoots forward, licking a gentle line over the roof of her mouth and the back of her teeth at the same time, blessed be, her forked tongue.

Once, thrice, drinking in the deep sighs from Catra's throat. And Adora doesn't know how she is going to be able to tear herself away from her in the morning, but she knows once they'll have to part, Catra will take everything Adora truly is and carry it inside her heart, carrying Adora's own heart inside her chest.

Adora gives one more drag of her hips, the serpents falling free and long to the side, tickling Catra's ribs by accident.

Catra parts from her mouth with a breathless laugh, honest and innocent even between everything and just the sight of it alone makes Adora's heart give a squeeze of tenderness, flooded by love and devotion.

She rolls her hips, dragging them slowly over Catra's skin before a quick experimental slam forward. Catra's mouth falls open in surprise and pleasure, a moan ripped from the very depth of her lungs with the sudden movement. It also shoots fireworks over Adora's spine, who gasps and trembles over Catra.

She leans again towards her freckled face, pressing kisses over her cheeks, gently preparing her until Catra is fully relaxed around her, legs falling open wider, pink lips swollen against the heated skin of Adora's own. Adora holds her breath, locking eyes with Catra’s enamoured face until she is sure none of them are going to shy away before slamming against her, deep, long and hard.

Catra's eyes widen, her pupils dilating so much her eyes are almost completely white with desire. Adora's eyes aren't much better, pools of black ringed by a crown of gold, dripping pleasure and want as she looks straight into Catra’s face and slams against her again.

The movement makes their bodies catch in a completely different angle. Their hooded clits, now puffy and bright pink, kiss each other with each slam in the most wonderful of ways, dragging, holding, letting go until both of them are a mess of shared breaths and moans.

Adora drips like rain, wet and slippery against Catra's open entrance, tilting her face to press a kiss over the leg that rests over her shoulder and that alone is enough to almost make Catra go insane, fumbling over the damp blankets and under Adora's strong body until she doesn't know what she wants to do, run away or throw herself to the sky.

Fly. Adora is making her fly.

It takes all within herself to maintain her eyes open, but it's worth it. It's so worthy when she catches the tremor inside Adora's body and feels the fog and the pleasure mixing there like a hurricane and she knows Adora is about to fall.

She feels it all, running her thumb over Adora's ribs and her other hand in the low of her back, guiding her inside, *inside. Inside of me. Fall inside of me until I can't exist without carrying you in my bones.*

"I love you," Catra says instead and that's enough.

Adora snaps like a violin's cord, her face wrinkling and then relaxing with a single gasp. She feels bright as she comes apart in Catra's hold, almost as if she had taken the sun from the sky and poured it inside their bed.

Catra holds her through it all, bumping their slick foreheads together. She knows time is fragile for them, she knows that destiny sometimes is a liar and that the breakthrough might come sooner or later for them and that it will destroy her, but right now, this is hers and she is allowed to dream.

This is hers and Adora's. This little moment here they share, baring to each other, will always live inside of her memories and inside of her heart and that makes worth everything that is to come.

Adora sighs, slowly opening her eyes, catching Catra nuzzling inside her hands with the fondest of expressions, making Adora's heart spin in happiness.

Adora feels dizzy, spun on her axis by the uncontrollable bliss coursing through her entire body, from the tips of her toes to the very middle of her chest. The serpents in her head twist and shiver around each other, singing in choir of happiness by Adora's pleasure and right then they feel natural, like any other part of Adora's body just as her trembling hands or sweaty legs.

Adora takes a half broken breath and looks down again, her body drumming pleasantly with the joy of her orgasm.

Catra is calm beneath her but her hips are still restless and the inner side of her thighs is damp and slick with Adora's release and her own excitement, blindly seeking for her as she whimpers and gasps.

Adora places a kiss over her face, right where the corner of her left eye and the bridge of her nose meet, before traveling down her body, scattering kisses over the feverish skin she finds on her way.

She finds her breasts and stops for a moment there, marveling at the sight of them. They are beautiful and perfect, so absolutely perfect, Adora is forever enchanted by them, forever enamoured. They are just small enough to fit inside Adora's mouth completely when she opens her lips around it and sucks into the hardened nipple, lavishing slowly and tender first the right and then the left.

Catra slams her head against the pillows below and moans so loudly that the serpents react with her, wrapping themselves around her waist when she arches off the mattress.

“Adora,” Catra calls for her but Adora almost doesn't hear her above the beautiful sound that comes right after.

A drum and a gentle shake, born from the middle of Catra's chest and traveling up her throat. A purr, Catra is purring and Adora is in love.

Catra trembles when Adora reaches the angle of her navel, her breath dying in her throat —or maybe not even there at all, when Adora's nose brushes the humid space of her curls, biting down her already reddened lips with force,daring to very, very slowly raise her hand and place her fingers around the beautiful lips, up and down and not inside, not yet they are not ready, just like Catra did for her too.

Adora returns her gaze towards Catra´s face from in between her legs, bright eyes devoted and enamored regarding her with gentleness. Adora holds her beautiful face on her eyes for a little bit, the warm air from her mouth the only touch over Catra's hot skin until Adora looks back down, observing the open flower before her.

Catra is brown and dark pink, the outer lips open, the inner ones puffed and soaked in clear liquid. She smells strongly here too, that natural scent and something musky, like petrichor, rain against earth. Her skin seems almost to have a heartbeat of its own, trembling and pulsing when Adora gets nearer. She is so sensitive already, she whimpers at the mere feeling of Adora observing her, taking her in completely.

Adora can see the exact place where her fingers just were, where her hand has caressed the petals of Catra´s roses and gathered her virginity inside her soul.

“Adora,” Catra mewls, stretching her hands down to cradle Adora´s head inside her palms. The thinner serpents slither around her fingers, holding her close at the same time Adora tilts her head to the side, pressing a fluttering kiss on the cluster of freckles that live on the inside of Catra´s thigh.

“I´m sorry, love. Too much?”

“Yes,” Catra gasps, running her thumbs in grounding motions across Adora´s ears.

Adora nods and immediately leans back, ready to bring Catra pleasure in whatever other way she wants. Catra, however, stops her immediately, scrambling on the bed to stop Adora from going further away from where she can reach her.

“No! No. Adora, don´t go,” Catra rushes to say, sweat dripping down the fall of her sternum and swirling in her bellybutton, making Adora´s eyes darken with want. “It´s just, If you do — If you kiss me there I'm going to come in your mouth really quick”

Adora stares at her in silence for a moment and then a huge smile stretches on her mouth, a try of silliness and complete tenderness etched on every single corner of her movements where she touches Catra´s bare body.

“Are you sensitive?”

“Adora,” Catra grunts, her beautiful face deep red and her curls falling messy and wet over her face like a lioness goddess cradled in silk sheets and sweet. “Your tongue is *split*”

Instead of feeling ashamed or suddenly shy for the fact being pointed out so bluntly, Adora feels a drum of pride, leaning down to press her open mouth against Catra´s half open lips, running the very same tip of her tongue up and over Catra´s bottom lip until she can feel her own body shaking with the strength of Catra´s purr.

“Nice point,” Adora whispers, guiding Catra back down over the pillows and making herself a home between her legs, Catra´s knees brushing softly at either side of her shoulder and her soles sliding down the middle and small of Adora´s back.

“May I? My wife?” Adora asks for permission, drinking in the beautiful gasp off Catra´s mouth at the words. “Just say the words, my love.”

“ *Yes* ”

Catra is already on the edge, waiting for the slightest of pushes to fall over one last time. Adora's eyes wrinkle in the corners with a smile, rubbing circles with her thumbs over Catra's thighs before pressing her completely open mouth against her pink heat in a damp kiss.

Catra whimpers and hiccups, pressing her palm against her open mouth trying to drown her own wet whines, her back arching over the cot in an elegant arch as Adora keeps scattering kisses over her core, lips closed and then open mouthed, pouring the sweetness of her throat in Catra's heat. She tries to think, tries to do anything else but to moan but there is nothing in her brain right now but wet pleasure and Adora. Adora, *Adora.*

Adora hums against her lips and drives her tongue completely across her core, sucking on the long lips and peppering the smaller ones at the same time with her forked tongue, grazing the edge of her teeth above Catra´s pearl clit and smiling where the wetness gathers on her chin and drips down.

Catra tastes like rain and life and something more, something that is not only her but *both* of them, mingling together in the middle. And Adora feels *beautiful.*

It´s not only Catra´s beautiful body and soul coming undone on her arms, it's her own body, it's herself. Adora feels her own body rocking up and down their warm bed, long limbs, strong arms, her aching core sliding across the soft sheets and Catra´s tail caressing absently and slow too.

She feels the pull and stretch of her own belly, tensing with her movements, and the bounce of her breasts, swell and heavy and pink, scattered in sun freckles and the red marks of Catra ´s enamoured kisses.

She feels her own face, sharp jaw, strong cheekbones, straight nose. The way her skin is still tanned and dark even with all the years she has been here. The thickness of her blonde eyebrows and the stretch of her red mouth as she licks, sucks, eats and kisses Catra´s folds and the entrance of her pussy.

The way her head tilts to the side when she had to take a swift breath and all of the waist long serpents scatter across the bed and the floor like golden and marble ropes, like turquoise and amethyst bead threads, singing so loudly they rival all the little noises Catra is making in the middle of the haze, of her love and of the incoming pleasure drowning her whole.

Adora feels beautiful and not only that, she feels hot, strong and elegant and just right for Catra and for herself. She is right, she is something good. Adora bites into her clit and makes love to her with her tongue and she is good.

Catra trips and falls, spilling down her thighs and around Adora's lips with a hoarse sigh that dissolves into a whimper. Adora opens her mouth, drinking the liquid warmth like a marble statue to a fountain of ambrosia, giving gentle laps with the tip of her tongue and the softness of her lips until Catra is shivering and squirming away slightly, tangling her trembling fingers in Adora's messed up makeup and her sweating face.

Adora leans away immediately, peppering her violently trembling legs with kisses before climbing up Catra's body, wrapping her inside her arms. There is wetness and slick between

her own legs too and when Adora moves a shot of white fire comes from her own dripping cunt and all the way to her mouth, whining against Catra´s tongue when she comes too.

****

Catra smiles, bright as a sun, and under her happiness a thousand and one blooms sprout from in between the cracks of the mosaics and open into full grown flowers. Poppies and lavenders and anemones and daisies. Casting the inside of their temple into its own kind of meadow, another kind of wedding bed for them to lay.

Adora brings them close to each other, embracing Catra's bare body below her, kissing the tip of her ears in exhausted and lazy motions. Too lost in the lingering pleasure of their orgasms and the feeling of their bodies together to do anything else but this, hold each other.

"I love you too"

Catra giggles against her chest, breathless, nestling her cheek over Adora's breast, surrounded by the salted smell there. She can't talk right now, she just can't. She is too soft, too vulnerable, too open and raw. If she speaks she knows her voice will break in pieces, shattered by overwhelming love and the turmoil of feelings inside her heart.

She knows what they just did is incredible, important, a proof of undeniable trust, baring what they are to each other without fear. Their hopes, their loves, their pains, their disabilities too. Loving without expecting to be loved back and still being accepted and reciprocated. It's so much to put into words.

Instead, Catra draps her legs around Adora's waist, keeping her warmth close to her. Adora sighs, nuzzling her nose on the crown of Catra's hair. She smells like sandalwood and lemongrass and sweat and something that is both of them, and she feels perfect between her hands, two pieces of a puzzle falling in place together.

Adora feels like her chest is not big enough to contain her heart anymore, like it's about to burst out of her ribcage and fly around the temple like a bird or a shooting star, just so it can fall right back inside Catra's own. Adora knows it will be safe there.

And what Catra just gave her, she will keep it safe and guarded inside her own soul, hidden from the prying eyes of the rest of the world, just letting its light slip through enough so they can see Adora loves someone wonderful, and that this incredible creature had accepted and loved her back.

Catra is purring so loudly and strong that it drums between both of their spent bodies and echoes on every single column, lulling them both into a gently slipping song. Adora giggles at the sound and the feeling, tilting her face to the side and marveling at the fact that she is in the perfect height to kiss Catra´s forehead and the damp corners of her eyes with sweet lips.

The serpents curls between them and make their way around Catra´s temples and ear too, matching her purr too with their own sweet sizzle, kissing all over her face until Catra is giggling breathlessly. Her tail lashes lazily below her, brushing against the inner side of Adora´s sweet thigh and stealing a small gasp from her mouth.

“You?” Catra asks, finding Adora´s face and pressing a kiss there that dissolves into a gentle lick with the tip of her tongue, from Adora´s cheekbone to the corner of her eye.

Adora giggles, shaking her beet red face softly next to Catra´s pretty nose.

“As much as I want to, I don't think I can keep going.” Another flick of Catra´s tail, Adora bites down into her own lip. “At least not in the next five minutes.”

“Alright,” Catra stops her movements but she remains close, breathing right next to Adora´s neck in silence until a bubble of realization breaks through her throat, tripping off her lips. “We just had sex”

“We did,” Adora agrees, suddenly hyper aware too. Her jaw grows slack, mouth falling open into an almost perfect circle. She is naked, in bed, next to her wife´s naked body. There are sweating and the air smells like love making and flowers and Adora still has serpents in her head and she had sex with the half of her soul. “Wow”

Catra snorts and starts laughing, messy and wet and absolutely joyful, so hard that it almost bends her in half with the strength of her chuckles, shaking the whole bed and Adora with her too.

Adora starts giggling and the suddenly she cannot stop anymore, pressing her clammy palm against her kiss bitten face and laughing into it, so full of joy and Catra´s happiness that she feels full and drunk.

“We are stupid,” Adora mutters and Catra laughs again, nodding furiously.

“We are.”

They laugh in each other's arms and feast on each other´s joy until they cannot physically go anymore.

Catra rests her cheek over Adora´s warm chest, right over the spot where she can hear her heart drumming the strongest and wonders how she got so lucky and how blessed she is. How much she loves Adora and how fierce her devotion for her runs.

She will never forsake her and Catra knows Adora will always look out for her too. It´s a promise, an ancient one, done even before neither of them existed like this and stronger than any curse. A promise sealed with a silent wedding of a love that will change the entire world.

“What are you thinking?” Catra asks against Adora´s collarbones, kissing them on her wake.

Adora hums below her, painting circles with her damp fingers around her waist. “How do you know that I'm thinking anything?”

“Dummy,” Catra huffs, letting her eyes fall closed.

Even blind, even without seeing, all she can perceive around her is light. She hopes that light can wrap Adora safely too. She is sure it will.

“I´m praying,” Adora whispers after a second, leaning her cheek against Catra´s.

Catra holds her breath, letting her eyes narrow open again. “What?”

“I´m praying”

“But—”

Adora presses her thumb against Catra´s mouth softly, tilting her face so Adora can gaze at her surprised face.

She has eighty four freckles on her face, twelve more than a year ago, when she arrived at the cave. Adora has counted them because she loves Catra and Catra still has faith.

“When I was younger, my mother told me the gods had granted me a miracle.” Adora explains against Catra´s cheekbones, kissing a trail of love on each freckle. “So I'm praying, because I'm grateful”

“You don´t need to be thankful, Adora.” Catra whispers back but she is trembling again, her entire body shaken by the strength of Adora´s resolution and the amount of her peace inside Catra´s arms.

“But how could I not?” Adora speaks over Catra´s lilac eyelids, worshiíng the frail skin there with her lips that have always been meant to kiss her back. “You were right, in a way or in another and after all the pain, they gave me what I wished for the most.”

Catra gulps, curling inside the warm arms of her wife. Adora´s skin is not cold anymore. “What did they give you?”

“You.” Adora breaths,“You are a miracle, Catra. No matter what, you will always be my most treasured miracle. My love, my only dear and beloved love. For as long as I can have you.” Adora smiles, sweet and just a little bit sad, resolved to love every single second she can have of Catra until her entire soul and life are made of her love. “So I'm thankful”

Their entire lives, no matter what, they are each other´s sanctuaries, they will have each other.

This is where soulmates are truly born, after all, in choosing one another.

Now you’re here and everything we touch explodes, bursts into bloom or burns to ash.

History atomizes and negates itself with our every shared breath.

I need you like life needs life. I want you like a natural disaster.

You are all I see. You are the only one I want to know.

– Henry Rollins

Chapter End Notes

giggling and kicking my feet They had sex! Huzzah!! And they are married, double huzzah!

Also, finally my Queen Hera making her triumphant apparition.

Notes:
- At the beginning of the chapter is hinted that Adora and Catra where once a single goddess, daughter of Hera only, that was ripped into two because Zeus got too scared of her. This is inspired by the myth that human had once four arms and four legs and that they grew too powerful so Zeus cut us into two, which is where soulmates are born.
- It is also mentioned a bt, which is part of the lore. It will be talked about later.
- Next chapter is going to have a lot of smut :D SO BEWARE!

Thank you so much for reading! See you next chapter, be good!

Verse XI

Chapter Notes

Hi :D So, they are going to have a lot of sex. I´m not even going to sugarcoat it, they are going to have nasty sweet lesbian sex in this one. And I mean a LOT, they´ve been repressed for ten chapters. I had to give it to them. This might be a 20+ age restriction chapter, alright? All those spicy tags are coming now, so be responsible.

I totally understand if you don´t enjoy reading that much spicy so I´ve marked the smut scenes with ***** so you can jump them over them. There are several fluff scenes in this one too and some lore but it's mostly sex, no lies. This is porn, throw me holy water or something.

ALSO, on an extra note, I wanted to make a quick heads up. It is officially April which means is SA Awareness Month. While this story does not contain it, the roman myth of Medusa is and should be taken as SA awareness. To however is reading this story that might need it, please remember that you are loved, you are beautiful, and you are still you, no matter what. I hope you find a beacon of light in the world that surrounds you but always remember you are light itself.

Hope you enjoy today´s chapter!

Sorry but also I'm not. Enjoy :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse XI. Steam

En un extraño fenómeno de alquimia su ser se había disuelto en la salsa de las rosas,

en el cuerpo de las codornices, en el vino y en cada uno de los olores de la comida.

De esta manera penetraba en su cuerpo [...],

voluptuosa, aromática, calurosa, completamente sensual.

— *Como agua para chocolate,* **Laura Esquivel**

He sees her everywhere.

He sees her in the sky, virulent red and purple, never once blue after that night. Blue, blue like her eyes. Blue like the sea that brushes the shore, the once that now is darkened outside his window, washing over red colored sand.

He sees her in the breeze, cold, merciless, an eternal winter. She took with her the spring and the sun as a revenge, as retribution, gathered it all inside her scratched palms and pulled it with her towards the abyss.

He sees her in the trees, blackened, meant to burn up quick and easy, not once green or red or orange, not colorful anymore. The olive trees are dead and the fig trees dry, cursed to never hang heavy with ripe fruits.

He sees her in the grass that has long ago crumbled into dust, into mud and dirt. Sees her in the old golden fields of the crops that have been drowned by salted water and burned by pink fires. They cannot feed him anymore, cannot fill him with breath or honey. They cannot feed the cattle and the cattle dies starving and his stomach twists and turns and he starves too. There are no fields, there is no meat.

He sees her on the floors, in the polished marble rimmed with gold. In the old tapestries undoing themselves on the seams, the ones he did not get to burn or to break. In the columns of white stone and in the open domes of the palace, looking towards the stars beyond the dark cluster of clouds.

He sees her in the throne, the single throne surrounded by the swords and spears and bows of every single fool that has tried to kill him before. A throne drowned with old and new blood, like the one drying up on the ends of her tunic where he has murdered the army that has raised against him. For the first time, mutiny. Not the last.

He, Emperor Prime, sees her everywhere. Not as his old desire or as a beacon of hope, but as a curse.

She is everything, *everything,* in the angry scream of the people that screams for their dead prince and stolen princess. On the flags of the Moon Kingdom, lilac and purple and golden, golden wings for the lost Princess. On the sky, on the air, on the ocean, on the forest.

On the face of her brother, forever casted into stone in the middle of the palace, at the feet of the broken throne. Loyal to her even in death.

Emperor Prime has everything and he has nothing at all. He has conquered Etheria and broken every single kingdom under his foot, taken and taken and taken until there was nothing else in this land that he could defile. Broken and torn into pieces, ripped apart and burned. Hurt, death, his.

For six years he has gotten everything, power, godly providence from the selfish god that calls himself king of all others, also meant to fall when Prime decides he does not need him anymore, when he has become a god himself for purifying this world to his image and likeness.

He has made gods bleed and has bleed this mortal world to its deathbed. He has everything and even within it all, Prime will never have it all.

Even within it all, no matter what he does, her shadow always looms over him like a curse, like her own curse, following him behind with her voice like a whisper and her screams like a hand. A hand, a real hand, dooming him for failure. Dooming him for a fate worse than death.

He will do everything to stop it, of course, it´s already known he will. He will break and demolish; he will burn and kill, kill and kill trying to hold the reins of his power, gripping his stolen throne with teeth and bloodied spit until he cannot go anymore. And still, it won´t be enough.

No matter what he does, no matter where he does, Adora, *Adora,* will always make Prime fall. She has his Fate deeply strung around her hands.

He can already see it start, crumbling everything he has worked for all around him. Even far away, humiliated, bruised, dead maybe, she has managed to wrap her hand around his throat. This he knows, this he sees, like a Fate's thread pulling tight around his head, threatening to cut it out.

His Father can see it too.

It won´t be long now.

Adora was once the most beautiful woman in Etheria. Yet she never quite saw it.

She would look at herself on the copper mirrors of her chamber in the palace, being dressed by her maidens with heavy chitons and gold trimmed hemation; being placed in burgundy and deep blue layered skirts and bodices heavy with the pearl and crystal beads carefully embroidered in the short sleeves and waist, with her golden hair twisted in braids and also heavy with sea shells, and still she would not understand what everyone else seemed to crave out of her.

After that horrid night years ago, after the curse and the humiliation and all the pain, Adora has not dared to glance at herself a single moment, not even by accident, too horrified by the monster that would stare back at her on the calm surface of the blue lake.

Too angry that even in all her horror, that reflection did not have the mercy of also turning her into stone, into marble, something capable of crumbling down so she never had to feel this twisted body around her soul.

The betrayal of her people, her parents forsaking her, Adam´s death. Prime presence on her body like a lingering phantom hovering over her head, and the war that had come right after, they all had stripped Adora of what made her who she was. They had twisted her until she

was something sad and ugly, too dangerous to even gaze at and too lost to be able to be saved.

It was like that for a very long time. Until Catra, until love, until light and open mouthed kisses and bodies slidding against each other.

Love and sex cannot fix the pain or the fear or the way Adora sometimes still frowns at herself in the copper reflections. It won´t make all of her cracks disappear and Adora does not depend on it to do so. Adora, better than anyone else in the world, knows how frail the adoration to only the body can be, how quickly it can change as our bodies change with time and with joy and also with pain.

But what it does do is to fill all of her fissures with liquid gold. What it does do is to drip stardust inside her heart and her body until she is whole with its sharp brightness and tenderness, so similar to Catra´s life next to her that she can feel the cutting edges of her own soul slowly turning soft too.

There had been many times where Adora has felt scared, where they have had to stop once or thrice to gather each other on their arms and breath, not always speak, letting the lingering venom run its course and leave Adora´s body completely. And little by little, not always linear and difficult most of it, Adora has felt herself alongside it.

Now, when she glances at herself on the copper mirror propped next to the columns of their temple, facing the side of the olive bed, instead of a monster staring back at her all Adora sees is a woman in love, holding in her arms at the love of her life, whose golden heart has chosen to love Adora right back.

Adora stares down at herself and sees it all, from her toes to her head. She can see the expanse of her tanned skin, slightly darker the more she spends on the sun of the open domes, scattered in white faded scars and sun moles like stars.

She sees the circlet of her ankles and the wide of her calves, strong all the way past knotted knees and thick thighs. She sees the thunderbolts embroidered in patches across the skin of her hips and the bottom line of her belly, cradled on the middle between her navel and the damp cave of her labia with fine golden hair, the last reminder of what used to be, skipping its way soft in a line towards her raised bellybutton where many kisses have been placed in the last few weeks.

If Adora narrows her eyes, she will be able to see the curves of her waist, smaller than her waist and rib cage after many years of bone corsets on the palace, an old minoan hymn for a snake goddess that turned out to be Adora´s future after all. She can gaze at the straight line of three moles that live right above her sternum and that give away to the heavy swell of her breasts, maroon and copper in the nipple and mouth kissed deeply.

When Adora turns to the side, tilting her head to catch a better sight on the divots of the mirror, she can see her strong arms, elegant wrists wrapped in golden bangles and coin bracelets and not chains; strong forearms and even stronger biceps,managed after years of carrying marble stones around and meant for only the softness of embraces. They match the

wide muscles of her back, most often sweaty now than before, by the spring heat or the love making or both.

And finally, finally, when Adora turns her golden eyes to her face, she sees someone standing tight in front of her. A woman, with high and sharp cheekbones painted in red suns; a woman with a straight and strong nose, golden ring hung from the bridge.

A woman, with a cutting jaw and fine chin, red paint smudged by foreign lips all the way to the corner of her mouth where the divot of secret kisses live and the philtrum creates a heart shape on her skin.

A woman with strong eyebrows darkened by time into a copper so deep is almost hazel, hovering over almond eyes and lilac eyelids powdered in golden paint that clings to the white of her eyelashes.

She had blue eyes once, deep as seas and as bright as lapis lazulis brought from foreign kingdoms, but now they are golden too, liquid as if the sun had melted itself and made a home on her irises. So enchanting in their own way that they are capable of death with a single gaze but also of the most loving of expression, physically meant only for the person she loves the most.

Adora blinks at herself and looks at her head, sometimes cradled in loose veils by the gentleness of the fabric against aching skin but no longer a prisoner of them. Most of the time bare as she is in front of the mirror, gazing at the long serpents taking root on her scalp and falling slim but heavy over her shoulders, like an echo of the braids made with golden threads she used to wear.

Adora gazes at them, so long they reach the back of her thighs and wrap around her skin like an anchor grounding her to the real world, with their marble white, pale golden and bright turquoise bodies also cradled by the touch of love, in yellow clay and golden cuffs, nuzzling their tiny blind heads against the unbroken skin of her body with self given tenderness.

Adora finds that while she will always resent them she cannot bring herself to hate them. Not anymore, not in the way she did before. Because would mean hating someone that has survived, against all odds; someone that is loved even when destiny wraps itself around her throat. Hating them would mean hating a part of her body that once was filled with poison but that now thrives with the promise of unwavering love and Adora cannot do it, not anymore.

Because she knows now that yes, this is a beautiful body. A beautiful body capable of cradling the even more beautiful body of her wife and making love to her and allow to be made love to, too. This is a beautiful body and it is all Adora´s, and Adora is loved so she can bring herself to love herself too.

****

Adora looks at her reflection on the mirror from the corner of her eye, the golden light of the sunset washing inside the temple and painting everything in copper echoes.

Like this, Adora can see Catra nestled in her arms, sitting over Adora´s bare lap with her arm tightly crossed around the back of her neck. She can see all of Catra´s long, long dark and beautiful hair falling down her back, brushing over the joints of Adora´s knees like a soft feather over her skin.

Much like the feeling as she dips her face on the crook between Adora´s shoulder and her jaw, and places a trail of kisses against the column of Adora´s neck.

The gentle snakes wrap themselves over Catra´s eyes and the pressure against her closed eyes makes Catra moan, her entire body shivering under the familiarity and eroticism that it´s used for, lighting her body like an ember in the middle of the night.

Adora's hand runs under the hem of Catra's long, white tunic, brushing the shivering skin of her thighs, rising goosebumps there. Catra's breath shivers, coming off a tiny hiccup when Adora hooks her fingers in the threads of her undergarments and pulls down, exposing feverish tender skin to the humid air of the bed.

Adora makes quick work of the laces, taking the fine clothes away and throwing them somewhere behind Catra, not even bothering to check where the offended fabric has fallen. Catra rests her cheek against the disrupted bridge of her nose, closing her eyes firmly, eyebrows knitted together into a single tender expression as Adora's cool fingers brush over the most guarded place of her body, close and yet too far away. Her thighs are damp like shores of rivers and her center is a cave, liquid and open like a blossom under Adora's reverential touch.

Adora tilts her head enough so she can press a kiss under Catra's jaw line, careful of the fragile skin there before cooing her beloved's face downwards, kissing her fully again. She wants to taste the heated moan off her lips when her fingers finally brush where Catra's needs her the most.

Catra's entire body shivers on her arms, her sharp teeth biting into Adora's lips accidentally when it happens, shaken by the oh so desired touch against the damp velvet of another kind of lips. She gasps in worry by the bite but all Adora can do is moan in return, devouring Catra´s mouth until both of their lips are red and swollen by the kisses.

Adora thumbs at Catra's hidden pearl, so small she can barely find her by the delicate gasp of her lover against her face. Adora once had no idea what it was like doing this with someone else, besides what she had learned from her own body, but now that she has learnt Catra from the inside out dozens of times she doesn't feel nervous.

Doing this with Catra feels like another kind of breathing or a second heartbeat, natural and easy, free of doubt and fear and any kind of inadequacy Adora could have drowned in. She doesn't feel like an imposter or a failure in Catra's arms. She just feels like *Adora,* and that's the most freeing feeling of it all.

Catra rocks her hips again, meeting Adora's strokes with that same passionate impatience that characterizes her. The laces that hold the front of her tunic come undone with the movement, opening just enough that a small, round breast peeks from beneath the fine fabric, tempting Adora with its gentle curving.

Adora latches into it without a second thought, still moving her hand relentlessly between Catra's heat. The skin is, as everything with Catra, tender, warm, rebelliously slippery against Adora's tongue as she reverents it, sucking and nibbling until Catra almost comes undone of that caress alone.

Adora looks at her from under her golden eyelashes, blinking slowly once with a gentle hum, a quiet question of consent answered by the lightest of nods before Adora's finger curve and then pulls forward, not yet inside but close. So close.

Catra breaks apart with an exhale, trembling like a dove as Adora caresses the surface of her intimacy with the same gentleness with which she kisses her.

The breakthrough is intense, white light, a push and pull and then a fall followed by a second and then a gentler third one when Adora's fingers caress against a hidden spot in Catra's body that makes her eyes water and spill, lost in the feeling of someone that holds her, and loves her, and it's completely devoted to her.

Catra is quiet through it all, small gasps and drowned hiccups barely audible over the crack of the oil lamps and the serpents singing happily around them. And Adora would live and die a thousand times and more, for eternity itself just for this moment where she gets to see the way Catra's eyebrows knit, where her eyes close and her mouth parts into the most beautiful of ecstasis, the liquid gold of her release coating Adora's fingers and hand, mortal skin too unworthy of the treasure and gift of witnessing it all, holding it all right between her arms.

Catra exhales heavily, parting from Adora's red mouth to rest her face over her collarbone, breathing hard. Adora pets over her messed up hair, curls curving over her fingers as she waits for Catra to return to her body.

She can feel her come back by the way her lips start to drag languid kisses over Adora's neck again, and her hands mark a path under Adora's chest, right over the three moles like planets.

Adora hums, sliding her hand outside Catra slowly, lovingly, pressing kisses in the spot below her ear as she gets used to the feeling, just so she can take off Catra´s tunic in one smooth swing, leaving her bare from the waist up and open to Catra's fogged eyes somehow perfectly placed on her.

Catra runs her fingers down Adora's collarbones, brushing carefully over the pink and old scars that years of false heroes have left behind, down to the swell of her breasts and perked up nipples.

Adora smiles at her, suddenly feeling rather shy under her bright touch, but Catra just smiles back, caressing the scars like kisses at the same time she tries to wriggle herself out of the rest of her clothes, giggling in annoyance when she fails.

Adora chuckles under her breath and then it becomes a full blown laughter, joyful like a bell when they wrap their limbs together and fall back in a warm mess over the bed, stealing the smiles from each other's mouths.

Adora still can gaze at their embracing bodies over the reflection of the mirror but she doesn´t pay attention to it right now. She already knows what's in there, deep inside her heart and maybe, just maybe, Adora thinks that some god took pity on them after all.

So she kisses Catra´s mouth and her body and sinks inside her heart and all Adora sees is beauty and light.



Catra is so in love that sometimes she forgets what it was not to be at all.

Sometimes, most of the time lately, she cannot remember how she was living before loving so avidly, so openly, and without being loved with the same ferocity in return.

It´s kind of funny in a sweet and also a little bit fucked up way, because she once told Adora that she did not need her to live but every single time she lays in her arms, every single time she feels Adora´s breath against her cheeks and hears the beautiful and strong drum of her heart against her ears, she is proved wrong.

Because the thing is, Catra could live but it would be such a void existence that it would not feel like a life at all. She would live, but every single day she would wish she wasn´t, and every single day she would curse at the heavens for making her live a second longer on her own.

She could live, but she would live so angry, so furious at everything, that she might as well break the universe in half and tear it piece by piece just so somehow she could have Adora and if she couldn´t just she wouldn´t have to live in a universe where Adora was not next to her.

It´s frightening, a terrifying thought borderline in delirium and in hot tears of anxiety in the middle of the night, but in a way is expected for. Loving Adora, *being loved* by Adora is the most beautiful thing in the world, the most sacred, stronger than Catra´s faith and sweeter than any other pleasure in the world.

Being allowed to love and have Adora would drive anyone to madness with the devotion for her. She would also burn the sea and break the starry sky in two for her, just so her light could shine in the moon rest of her own eyes. Just so she could hear her laugh one second longer and sigh in a single suspended second.

Loving like this was not supposed to happen to Catra, not after losing her sight, not in the middle of war, but it has happened. And now that Catra has it in her hands, now that she has been able to catch sunlight in her fingers and wrap herself with her, she doesn´t know how to ask her heart to beat without Adora´s one right next to her.

She can hear Adora breathing very calmly next to her, humming on the back of her throat as she splashes cool water all around them when she moves.

They are waist deep on their lake, dipping their tunics in the fresh waters after a day of rain and washing them clean. It has become a kind of habit, doing this each few days and letting the long clothes hang on the branches of the wide trees, right below the open domes and the warm sun of her spring.

Before one of them would do it and the other would just linger around, and there were always dry tunics and chitons laying around to wear while the rest hung to dry. But lately, after the wedding and the sweet night that came after,both of their shyness had started to melt down, giving way to boulder movements around each other.

Lately, Catra had gotten a kick of walking bare from head to toe while the clothes dried, wearing only Adora´s hemation around her waist, just so she could hear the breathless gasp coming from Adora´s direction no matter where in the cavern she was when she caught sight of her.

And lately also, Adora had gotten a habit of doing the very same, wearing only her minoan layered skirt and leaving her bare chest free to press against Catra´s back when she would hug her from behind.

It was all a kind of dance, like the ones Adora had patiently taught to Catra long ago, and Catra was drinking on the light of it with her arms wide up, chuckling under her breath every five minutes when Adora would turn around from soaking a tunics just to kiss Catra´s cheek sweetly and wet before scattering away with a laughter.

Today, though, today even with all the sweetness Catra´s head has been buzzing more than normally, distracting her and making her movements slow and lazy, and she would have been a fool if she didn´t think just how quickly Adora was going to realize something was happening right now.

Catra hears Adora raise her hand from the water and stretch it to the side, heavy drops falling everywhere when she brushes Catra´s cheekbone, gently calling for her attention where Catra has failed to hear her calling her name twice now.

“What are you thinking about so deeply?” Adora whispers, softly brushing her fingertips past Catra´s freckles.

Catra wrinkles her nose, blindly searching for a new tunic and dipping it almost too hard into the water.

“How do you know I'm thinking anything?” She shoots back Adora´s words in an attempt of a joke but Adora does not bite it, stepping closer in the slippery mud just so she can wave her arm around Catra´s and press their cheeks together.

“You are always thinking about something.” Adora whispers, nuzzling their warm skins together.

“I'm mostly thinking about you, Princess.”

At the beginning she used the gentle title carefully, scared of bringing painful memories for Adora. But now it has become something sweet between them, a reminder that no matter what happened Adora is still herself.

“Charmer,” Adora hums, resting her chin over Catra´s shoulder. “You are my wife, you know?”

“Yeah, I remember. I´m the one that proposed to you,” Catra lets her eyes open a slit, blinking quickly at the sudden light. She can feel Adora slowly smiling against her skin, the gaze of her teeth giving her away. “Why are you smiling like that?”

“Because you're my wife and I´m a princess,” Adora repeats for her, very slowly, lingering a kiss against her neck. “Which makes you–”

“Oh, no”

“ —a princess too.”

“Ugh.” Catra closes her eyes again, pressing her palm flat against Adora´s cheek and pushing her gently but determinate away. “You´re so annoying”

The serpents sizzle around them, curling around their bodies and searching for Catra´s face during their gentle push and pull on the lake. The graze at her eras and latch onto her forehead and curls, kissing their way over Catra´s skin and making her laugh, all annoyance crumbling down the moment she feels them sheepily smooch her face with their cold bodies.

“Not you, I adore you all,” she mutters around a giggle, pressing quick pecks over their tiny heads.

It should be weird but it isn´t because after all this is Adora kissing her too. Adora, though, seems to have forgotten about it for a second because she grunts, holding Catra´s wet wrist in her hands.

“Hey,” Adora calls, pulling softly from her. “Don´t I get kisses too?”

“No.” Catra deadpans, grinning when she hears Adora groan.

“You know, when you kiss them I can also feel it”

“Do you, now?” Catra raises her eyebrows, smiling wide because of course she knows, that's why she kisses them so often, so Adora can know she adores all the parts of her. Another thought crosses Catra´s mind and she tilts her head, following the bodies of the snakes until she reaches the root. “Does it ache?”

Adora shakes her head in negative, pressing a fluttering kiss over Catra´s wrist.

“Not today,” Adora shrugs in Catra´s palms. “Good days and bad days”

“I know”

“What about you?”

“A little in the morning. It got better after eating.” Catra can´t help the automatic rub of her hand over her closed eyes, the echo of pain still lingering a little bit. “One day at a time”

“Yeah.” Adora rests her nose over Catra´s cheekbone, whispering promises over her skin. “I look out for you. And you look out for me.”

“We do”

****

They kiss lazily in the middle of the lake, their tunics already soaked through to their waists. The serpents fall over the lake too and wrap themself around Catra´s waist, bringing her closer to Adora´s body and tangling themselves with the long loops of her head.

It´s the kind of kiss that makes Catra so at peace with the world surrounding her that she hums and let´s her body melt inside Adora´s sure arms, almost being carried completely inside the lake as their limbs unavoidably gravitate towards each other and their bellies and breasts meet, firing up the logs of Catra´s desire that had already been itching at her from underneath her skin the entire day.

“Hey,” Adora whispers against the corner of her lips, leaning back from her mouth just enough so she can murmur in Catra´s shivering ears.

“Hey”

“Are you asleep?”

“Not anymore.”

Catra catches Adora´s mouth again and this time is with newfound hunger. The tips of both of her fangs catch on Adora´s soft lip and pull down from it, feeling it swollen immediately under her touch even when she tampers the quiet sting with her tongue before dipping it inside Adora´s mouth.

It steals a gasp off Adora´s throat and a purr from Catra´s, already halfway climbing over Adora's gorgeous soft body when Adora starts speaking again.

“Kiki? What is it?” she asks, suddenly surprised by the intensity of Catra´s desire. She must see the brush of her tail on the water or maybe even the perk of her nipples under soaked fabric because she chuckles a little, that new confident tone of voice that had accompanied her for a few weeks now slipping in her mouth and making Catra´s thighs soaked by different reasons than the lake. “Are we restless?”

“It´s your fault,” Catra grunts, dipping her head down so she can nip blooms over Adora´s collarbones. “You´ve got me all worked up this week and still haven't touched me at all”

“That´s not true.” Adora defends herself, painting circles with her fingers over the small of Catra´s waist, brushing right over the spot where her tail is born. She knows what she is

doing. “I´ve been kissing you a lot”

“And I love you for it but I want you eating me out too.” Catra snaps, uncaring of the fake scandalous gasp Adora takes.

Adora thinks about it for a second and then moves again, resting her palms fully over Catra´s soft belly, pressing her fingertips on the spots between her navel and her thighs where Catra can´t answer in any other way but with a deep whimper.

“I thought you were cramping very badly.” Adora explains, her voice falling from sultry and flirting to something deeply caring.

She takes mind of everything that is Catra including the bleeding weeks each month where Catra can do nothing more but curl in bed and try to sleep it off. And while Adora has never had to go through that herself, she knows what it means and just how painful and exhausting it can be.

Catra exhales, her defence dying down too as she lets her forehead rest over Adora´s shoulder, speaking in a calmer voice. “I know”

“And you were happy with warm baths and sleep.” Adora adds, kissing the fall of her shoulder.

Catra grumbles, her tail stomping in the calm water when Adora starts to rock her very gently from side to side. “I would have been very happy with an orgasm too”

Adora snorts, running her lips up and down Catra´s entire face. It´s sweet until it is something more, heating up like the spring sun as Adora´s hands slip between the soaked folds of Catra ´s tunic and she starts dragging them down, her wet fingers circling invisible swirls over the shivering skin of Catra´s breasts and her sternum.

Catra cannot help herself but to moan, letting her head fall backwards where Adora is embracing her now fully from behind, feeling her heating breath against her cheek and her gentle hands traveling past her belly button, pressing all of Catra´s secret buttons that make her squirm and purr even here in the middle of the lake.

“You know, to make it up to you,” Adora whispers, breathing in Catra's smell. “There is something I´ve been wanting to try”

Catra holds her breath, loosely wrapping her hands around Adora´s wrists to guide her lower. “Uhu, I'm listening”

“I really love touching you,” Adora nibbles softly on the cartilage of Catra´s ear at the same time she finds her way across soaked and wrinkled fabric between her legs. “And I love tasting you”

“Ah”

“But there is just so many other things we can do,” Adora speaks just as her fingers lower down, grazing at Catra´s petals just above the soft fabric and then a little bit further, the

pressure almost unbearable against Catra´s swollen heat with the quiet promise of deeper ends that Catra understand immediately.

“You mean—”

“Yes.” Adora kisses her eyelids, now completely carrying her above the water. “ *Inside* .”

Catra snaps herself away from Adora´s arms only so she can turn around and wrap her arms around Adora´s neck, bringing both into a searing kiss that immediately steals the breaths out of their lungs.

Adora gives a surprised exhale against her tongue but then she melts down too, dipping her fingers on the divots of Catra´s back and bringing her even closer, the soft jingle of their bangles meeting each other when they wrap their limbs together as strongly as they can.

“Is that a yes?” Adora asks with a breathless laugh when they turn apart, giggling at the way Catra´s ears flop up and down like firefly wings with excitement.

Catra huffs, shoving Adora´s shoulder at the same time her tail wraps tightly around Adora´s waist. “It´s a shut up and why are we still clothed?”

“Pff.” Adora shakes her head against Catra´s face but leans to kiss her again, licking into her tongue.

She guides Catra´s out of the lake and the treacherous mud, their soaked and half clean clothes forgotten for later. Catra walks with her eyes closed, not even needing to open them to catch sight of the change of light and shadow around her. She trusts that Adora will take her safely where they need to.

Still, she frowns in confusion when instead of feeling the smooth stone paths that lead to their temple all she keeps feeling is soft moss under her soles, the sound of the waterfall closer and stronger the more they get near it.

“Why are we going to the waterfall?” Catra asks, wrinkling her nose with confusion.

“We are going to take a shower and get clean first,” Adora explains, the gentle serpents still kissing over Catra´s face.

Catra can feel her own face falling, a spark of restless annoyance itching underneath her skin like barely contained fire in a forest, “Adora–”

“ *We* , Catra.”

Comprehension falls over Catra at the same time Adora´s hand changes from holding her fingers to traveling up the leather knots keeping Catra´s tunic in place, undoing them quickly and gently as she pushes the fabric down her back and chest.

Catra lets her head roll back and smiles at the bright sky above them, happy in trusting her naked body in Adora´s hands.

One by one all of her garments come undone. The leather ropes and the lines of wild pearls; the heavy and wet fabric of her chiton, falling on a hoop around her ankles and baring her to the warm air of the cavern; her bracelets and rings and the serpents like necklace around her neck and hoops on her ears. Leaving her only in her own frail skin and long hair, tiny lake shells and serpent scales still held from her temples like a gentle crown.

“Alright. Lead the way, princess.” Catra mutters, smiling when Adora presses a kiss against her cheek.

“Yes,” a beat, “Princess”

“Ugh”

Adora joins her in bare body soon enough, her wide hips and chest meeting Catra´s body when she embraces her close and brings them under the warm stream of the waterfall, holding each other tightly above the wide rocks long ago smothered by the rush of water and clustered in moss that Catra can feel slipping around her toes and keeping them both from slipping into the floor.

Catra can feel Adora running her fingers gently through her scalp, careful of not tangling her curls and washing away the sweat of the day and fine dust from the winds off Catra´s body and her own. Adora has gotten the gentle habit of brushing gentle oils in Catra´s hair, forming their shapes one by one around her fingers and letting them dry slowly. She has learnt and she has gotten good at it, so good it had been a good minute since Catra had taken care of her own hair.

But they had never showered together, not even in the sweet aftercare of their intimate moments together. It just had never crossed Catra´s mind but now that she is right here, under the water and with her cheek resting over Adora´s shoulder and inside her arms, she cannot believe she went so long without this, letting herself being taken care of and taking care of the person she loves in return.

“I love you,” Catra whispers in Adora´s pointy ears and she can feel her smile.

“I love you too”

She almost forgets why they were here to begin with until Adora gently pulls them both out of the water, wrapping a dry cloth that Catra had not realized Adora had brought near and drying both of their bodies as best as possible.

Catra´s hair and the gentle serpents remain slightly wet but neither of them pays them attention, holding each other´s hands as they walk carefully and still plainly naked towards their temple, past the mosaic floor and the fabrics of the canopy.

Catra´s heart is racing when Adora gently guides her to sit on the edge of the bed, feeling her kneel between her legs and take her hands just so she can press a slightly damp kiss on each wrist.

“Can we now—?” Catra asks with a heavy gulp, nibbling into her bottom lip when she feels like the weight of her heart and her expectations are going to crush her down into a warm heap on the bed.

“Yes.” Adora holds her breath for a moment, brushing a line over Catra´s cheek to let her know that she is right there. “Kiki, before we do this we need to speak about boundaries”

Catra groans, letting her face fall inside her open palms as she tries to fight against the waves of frustration. She is already wet, there is no denying that, not for the lake of the waterfall but for the bittersweet wait of Adora inside of her, as she promised, caressing the parts of Catra that have never been touched before.

She can barely wait for it now, naked as she is and kicking on the floor. But she also knows Adora is right and nothing good has ever come from rushing into their intimacy without talking about it first.

Thought, if Catra could be honest, she would let her body fall open so Adora would do whatever she wanted to it.

“Alright, yes,” Catra accepts, scowling but still nodding her head. “You´re insufferable but yes”

Adora hums, bending to press a kiss over Catra´s nervously bouncing knee which doesn´t help at all.

“This is— different. A little bit.” Adora starts, searching for the right words. “It´s deeper”

“I *know* that”

“It can hurt, if not done properly. I can hurt you”

“You won´t.” Catra shakes her head, eyes open to find Adora´s light, helping her cradle her jaw inside her palms. “I trust you”

“I know. But we still need to speak about it.” Adora rests her head in Catra´s hands, kissing each one of her fingers and the entire space of her palms, calming down Catra´s palpable anxiety with her soft voice. “You know I don´t believe in the purity of virginity, it´s just fucking stupid”

“What a filthy mouth.” Catra chuckles, running her finger of Adora´s eyelashes. “Me neither”

“But this one, Catra, is a different way of making love.” Adora lowers her hands, pressing only her fingertips against Catra´s soft belly, stealing her breath.“It's an opening for many more things. It can be even stronger than eating you out. Which I love, I love licking you and kissing your lips.”

Catra can´t help but to giggle, flush covering her from the cheekbones to her neck and chest, making her pant as if she had just spent hours underneath the very ray of the sun. In a way she has, kneeling between her legs and caring for her body with soft words and sure body.

“You speak like an expert by now. How cocky.” Catra points out with a lighthearted joke, but instead of hearing Adora chuckle she hears her breath deeply through her mouth. “Adora?”

“What you´re going to feel.” Adora lowers her head, this time pressing her lips over Catra´s navel, a promise of more to come. “It can both be so pleasurable and uncomfortable. So if you don´t like it I'm going to need you to tell me. I´ll be happy to make love to you in any way you want, even if it means eat you and caressing you the rest of our lives”

Catra bites back a moan, her head pounding with heat. “I know”

“No, I need you to promise it.” Adora whispers firmly, leaning away from her so she can cradle Catra´s face in her hands, pressing their noses together. “I need you to promise me you ´re not going to force yourself to keep going for my sake alone”

“Alright. I promise it.” Catra knows this is important for herself, and for Adora. They respect each other and Adora is right. “Can I do it to you? After?”

The serpents sizzle loudly at her words, giving Adora away of how badly she truly wants this. It helps ease the nervousness in Catra´s chest and it helps Adora relax too, her own excitement clear in her voice when she speaks again.

“Yes”

“With the same boundaries”

“Yes. I promise it too.” Catra nods, biting nervously in the inner face of her cheek. Adora hums, rising off the floor, her warm body hovering above Catra´s and gently guiding her backwards. “Lay on the bed, sweetheart.”

Catra gulps and does as she is asked to immediately, the purr in her chest also giving her away. She lays back over the numerous pillows, resting over softness as tries to relax all of her limbs over them and too nervous to actually manage it.

Adora follows her close behind, resting her entire body over Catra´s and enveloping her in another kind of warmth. Catra loves it, the feeling of Adora´s body tightly, intimately pressed against hers. She loves her breath on her cheeks and her breasts against hers and the soft, almost accidental, brush of their cores together speaking of nothing but even more beautiful things to come.

“Adora–”

“Words?”

Catra´s fangs click together when she closes her mouth quickly. “Seriously?” Adora hums again over her, not touching her at all still, leaving no room for interpretations. “Fine. Sun to go, sea to slow down, sand for a break”

“And to stop?”

“Apples”

“Good girl”

The next time Adora kisses her Catra is sure that she might actually come from the kiss alone. Adora´s tongue runs split through the roof of her mouth and tastes the back of her teeth and her own tongue at the very same time, sucking wet kisses over her lips and the corners of Catra´s mouth until she feels tears gathering in her eyes and spilling down, joining the drops of sweat traveling down her temples when the temperature shoots up all around them.

It had been a long week, an exhausting week, and while Catra was happy to eat Adora how every single day to pleasure her and ease her own want, her body had missed Adora´s body taking hers like a heartbeat, too in love with her to do anything else but want her and think about her forever.

Adora might have just missed her in the very same way because now that she is here, over Catra, she is insatiable, hungry as she eats and kisses and licks her way across Catra´s body, worshipping and preparing her with lazy but purposeful kisses and her thigh between Catra´s heat already stroking circles on her.

Catra lets her eyes open and blinks to the unwavering light around them, suddenly overwhelmed.

“Adora”

“I’m here”. Catra feels Adora pressing her foreheads together, noses brushing one with the other. “Word?”

“Sea,” Catra takes a deep breath, closing her eyes again. “Speak to me, will you?”

“Of course”

Adora wraps both of her arms around Catra´s back and holds her close, bringing her knees up and slipping them right beneath Catra´s butt, wrapping herself completely around every corner of Catra´s body and holding her just as lovingly.

“Tell me the ways in which you have touched yourself,” Adora starts, still heated but patient, waiting for Catra to set the rhythm for both of them and this thing they are about to do together.

Catra gups heavily, effectively distracted from her own anxiety. “Just–”

“Yes?”

“Just outside,” Catra confesses, thinking about the times she used to lay awake on her own chasing a pleasure that never quite felt complete. Adora hums in wonder next to her, matching the goddess Peitho herself with the seduction that lives inside her voice.

“Never inside?”

“Just once, that night.” Catra confesses, knowing Adora will remember exactly what she is talking about. “I craved it but– it never felt exactly right. The angle, the depth, it was all

wrong”

“Mmm”

“Take it.” Catra rushes to say, licking Adora´s closed lips from her chin to the tip of her nose, unfolding herself beneath her once all of her anxiety has melted down. “Sun, my sun. This is me giving you permission, Adora. I give it to you”

Adora´s hand runs downwards, slow enough that Catra could stop her at any second, eagerly enough that they leave a flushed path of skin behind. She finds what she is looking for immediately as she takes Catra´s small clit in her fingertips and starts rubbing it softly, feeling the gush of slick wet the inside of Catra´s thighs almost immediately.

“What about you?”

“I´ve heard things, many things.” Adora explains, now lowering herself down too. “The women in the palace and the markets, they told the most wild stories, things they learned around the world, with their wives, with each other. So many ways of bringing ecstasy that I could write full poems about it”

Adora, a scientist and a poet. Catra could sing sonnets about her too if she wasn´t so busy moaning out loud, kicking on the damp sheets and feeling herself being caressed like a waiting flower in Adora´s touch.

“I tried some, a few times in the solitude of my room.” Adora adds, biting on the inner face of Catra´s thigh. She is so soaked by now whe could turn into a sea and drown. “I brought myself pleasure”

She is close, so close Catra is driving insane and Adora knows it because Catra can hear her smile. She also feels Adora moving them around, just a little bit, just enough so she can take Catra´s legs and place them around her sides, Catra´s soles slipping over Adora´s waist, opening her in a different way.

“Tell me about it”

“No pain.” Adora presses a kiss right above Catra´s navel. “Passion only, it needs to be done carefully.”

Then, with the gentleness of a poet and the strength of a miracle, she dips her hand down and spreads her fingers through Catra´s heat, opening her fully with her fingers caressing the outside of her labia and bringing sparks of pleasure all across Catra´s heart.

“ *Ah* ” Catra can´t help herself when she begins to moan, her breath hitching in a whimper and dissolving around a rapid breath that speaks of nothing but how badly she wants this. She wants it, she wants to be open and taken completely. “Adora”

“Should I describe you?” Adora gasps, eager, so hungry her teeth click together. “Should I tell you exactly how you are? The lengths of your beauty in my hands?”

Catra hisses and with her the serpents do too, slipping down and wrapping around her head, her eyes and her wrists, holding her in loving touch before Catra is picked apart. “Yes”

The next moments will forever live embroidered in the depths of Catra´s mind. Adora is erotic and beautiful in her hands, above her, all around her, holding Catra down with her weight and at the same time carrying her heart inside her palms, palms she uses to caress Catra´s heat with such a loving touch that Catra will never live another day being someone else but Adora´s.

She feels Adora resting the pads of her calloused fingers over her entire pussy, feeling every single corner around her thighs and the thick bush of hair above that Catra realizes her body is no longer anatomy and biology but Adora´s parchment to write poems onto.

“Here, you hold the entrance, soft and plush like a ripe fruit. Catra, if you knew— you´re the color of peaches against the soil. You´re the sun, warm, fluttering like dragonfly wings.” Adora gets her head closer, letting only the tips of her tongue sneak out and gather slick on the flat muscle, tasting her in her mouth. “You´re swollen and you are already soaked.. That's how I see you every single time”

Catra slams her head against the pillow below her and shoots her hands around Adora´s back, closing her fingers in fists to keep herself from stretching Adora´s back. “Keep going”

“These are your lips, they rest here plush and open. They must be touched very softly, like unfolding a flower button to gaze at what's beneath.” Adora runs her fingers through her external labia, one by one, and then gently pushes them open, looking at what is hidden underneath. “Here you are softer and gentler. Delicate, you know this place too, you must.”

“I do.” Catra agrees, feeling Adora´s sweet breath over her inner labia, fluttering her like a loose dandelion under a tornado.

“You are like a poppy flower here, soft and damp. So damp already. Which cloud rained over you?”

“You”

Adora hums and licks a line over these lips too, this time firmer, something that has become familiar by now but that makes Catra moan so loudly today that it echoes across the entire cave.

“ *AH* !” Catra feels Adora´s fingers brush something else, something that are not her lips at all but that is still too external to be inside. She has felt it before too, she is educated in all things including this, the shape of bodies of her own body. It still manages to steal her thoughts and makes her legs tremble above Adora´s ribs. “What–?”

“Your hymen is like a moon.” Adora contemplates so full of wonder she might as well have found the stars of the galaxy in Catra´s heat. “Right here, here is the threshold between the earth and the holiest of places. You smell like petrichor here, rich, heavy. I can taste you already in the back of my tongue. I love the way you feel and you taste, holy.”

“Adora.” Catra is gone, gone, no turns back. All she can feel is Adora, all she can feel is her, all she wants to speak is her name. “Adora”

“Here is where it is said that erotism lives.” Adora is panting, her voice still sure but wavering in the edges, unable to fully conceal her own desire. “Here our sexes become one. Here my hand that creates music plays the chords of your lyre. And later your fingers that work the loom will wave a tapestry inside of me”

“ *Ah, oh* Adora. Adora”

“Do you want to? Do you want to unfold me too?”

“Yes.” Catra wraps her palms around Adora´s jaw and pulls from hersoftly, silently asking her to come back into her arms and holding herself to her neck when Adora immediately does so. “I can´t hold on”

“You can”

Adora circles Catra entrance with her fingertips once, stopping patiently, waiting. This is it, right here right now. Catra pushes against her and nods furiously against a kiss.

“Are you sure?” Adora asks once more in her lips, gathering Catra´s slick in her hand and caressing the fall of her ribs with the other.

“Yes.” Catra snaps, narrowing her eyes. “You´re my wife”

“I am. I would still be your wife no matter what”

“I know.” Catra hiccups, feeling her so close yet too far away that she feels herself driving crazy. “But Adora, I need our skins together. I need your body inside mine, please.I need you inside me.” Catra kisses her mouth and her tongue, buckling her hips down. “I´ve waited years for you, please become mine again. Please then let me make myself yours all over again.”

She hears Adora hiccup a tiny and deeply loving sob and all is good in their world. “I love you”

“I love you”

“Breathe”

Adora presses forward past flesh, fruit, petals and moon until her knuckle is brushing the skin of Catra´s navel and her finger is completely inside, curling it inside itself until it brushes something deep and full of ecstasy inside Catra´s body and all she can do is throw her neck back and sigh.

“Ha! Oh”

“I´m here”

Adora´s finger stills inside of her, waiting patiently for Catra to get used to it before slowly starting to pump it out and in all over again, ripping such delirant and erotic moans from Catra´s mouth that she almost doesn´t recognize herself nor she cares for the pleasure of being fucked like this by the love of her life.

“Kiki”

“Sun.” Catra opens her mouth and moans against Adora´s tongue, feeling her entire body slip open by Adora´s hand inside of her. “Tell— *ah* , tell me more”

“I can only think about you”

“Tell me anyway”

Adora takes her finger aside for one moment and before Catra has time to realize she slips it inside once again with such delicious drag that her legs accidentally close together, knees buckling and hitting softly against Adora´s ribs with the sudden movement.

“You´re warm.” Adora describes, gulping heavily. Catra is not the only one beyond words right now, she can feel her own desire pulsing across her body in sweat and the choir of the serpents, taking Catra in a new way. “Firm. Wet, so wet.” Catra can feel her inner muscles pulse under the words and Adora answers with a delighted gasp, pressing her mouth against Catra´s ear. “You´re sucking me in”

“ *Ngh* ”

“Spread your legs, sweetheart.” Adora eases the tension in Catra´s legs, helping Catra hook her ankles around the small of her waist before starting fingering all over again.“Tight, so tight”

“I–”

“It´s wonderful.” Adora rushes to say, easing and reassuring Catra with loving words. “Gods, Catra, you´re so beautiful you feel so godly. You melt and mold around me, you let me in”

“Mmm. Ah.” Catra lets her eyes roll inside their sockets, uncaring if the movement shoots a spark of pain on her temples as it is eased immediately by Adora´s lips over her forehead.. “Can you– another?”

“I think so, yes.” Adora´s hot breath disappears for a second, looking down at Catra´s flushed and swollen heat before nodding. “I have to leave you for a moment”

“Alright.” Catra grumbles. “Just come back”

Adora´s absence, as small as it is, almost breaks Catra´s world in two. Her heat pulses empty and she can feel her thighs and the back of her butt soaked completely, matting the fine hair there and making her deeply restless.

Adora is not gone much, as she promised it, because the next thing Catra knows are Adora´s fingers, three not two of them, massaging the plush flesh of her entrance before slowly

pushing forward.

For a moment Catra think it won´t work out but she is already so soaked that they slip inside without any resistance, entering Catra´s heat and caressing her from the inside out until there is no space left of her where she cannot feel Adora´s touch.

“Nngh!”

“Don´t cry,” Adira whispers, cleaning the pleasure tears that have managed to escape Catra´s eyes. “I got you”

“Ah!”

“How does it feel?”

Catra wants to answer, she really does. She wants to tell her that she has never felt something like this, so erotic, so deeply intimate that she is sure Adora is writing her name in the flesh inside of Catra and placing half of her heart in her own chest so she will never leave her again.

That Adora is the most beautiful, most seductive person and that Catra is so grateful she gets to call her wife and she gets to lay in bed with her and be taken like this, with Adora´s split tongue in hers and the serpents around her waist moving her body up and down at the same rhythm as Adora´s fingers move.

She wants to say all of this and more but her throat is clogged with moans and her lungs are collapsed with pleasure, so all she manages to do is press her cheek flush against Adora´s and whimper, licking into Adora´s blessed eyes when Adora curls down her fingers.

“That good?” Adora giggles at the lack of words, meeting Catra´s kisses with her own.

“Full,” Catra finally manages, the base of her back growing tired by the rocking of their bodies together. “I– I can feel your callous inside, *ah* ”

“Fuck,” Adora grunts, something she sees or feels inside of Catra showering her in a kind of possessiveness that only manages to make Catra desperate and hungry for all of it. “What else?”

“Your skin, in there, you´re painting”

“More”

“You´re brushing me like you do the lyre, *ah* !” Adora moves her fingers in a different way and the pads press against a soft and plush part inside of Catra that makes light explode beneath her eyelids, the slick between her legs dripping like waterfalls over Adora´s own skin. “And you– *ah* , there, *there! Ha* !”

Adora coos, pressing her nose against Catra´s temple and smiling over her skin.

“Oh, this feels wonderful”

“How do you know–?”

Adora nibbles into the soft cartilage of Catra´s sensitive ear, drinking on her gasp without stopping from bumping her fingers in and out.

“Do you want to know how you feel?”

“Yes”

“You feel like sinking inside light,” Adora kisses her, loving her deeply. “It feels like I'm making love to a sun”

She takes Catra again, never once tearing herself from her side. In and out, in and out until Catra feels like she is nothing but liquid and sun in secure arms, held above the rest of the world and sheltered from anybody's eyes but the ones of her wife, who she loves more than life.

“Wrap your legs around my waist, Kiki.”

Adora moves them both around, cradling herself between Catra's legs deeper, better. Then she rearranges her own legs, digging her knees firmly on the cot and lowering her chest over Catra´s, breasts and hearts pressed together.

Adora takes Catra´s hand and brings it towards her lips, kissing her knuckles and then placing her fingers inside her mouth, wrapping her forked tongue over the tips.

“Listen to me, sweetheart,” Adora´s voice is thick, sore with their love making.

Catra blinks away tears, holding herself to her.“I– I am”

“I'm going to take you now, alright?” Adora announces, litting Catra´s golden fire with her own. Catra moans, shivering inside Adora´s hold.

“How? Tell me how.” She asks for, slightly annoyed for how desperate she sounds but too in love to care at all. “Tell me about your want, let yourself want”

“I´m going to caress you.” A kiss on the cheek. “I´m going to touch you, open you. I´m going to slip my fingers past the petals of your lips and inside the bloom of your sex. My hand will caress inside your womb and then my tongue.”

With each word comes a promise in the way of touch, brushing over Catra and inside until she feels loose and damp.

“I´m going to make love to you, bed you. deflower you, marry you again. I'm going to bring you so much pleasure, I´m going to feed your desire with my want for you.” A kiss on the mouth, licking the honey from each other´s wants. “You are going to be mine”

With her fingers still pressed inside Catra, Adora gives a small careful shot forwards, her pelvis slamming against Catra's and the fingers inside of her with a bone aching thrust. Catra throws her head back and moans, legs trembling as her entire body gets taken again.

“ *Gods* ”

“No,” Adora denies, taking Catra´s breast inside her mouth. “Just you. Just me”

Another thrust, soul crushing and heart filling. Catra doesn´t know what it is but the slam of their bodies together and the brush of the clits against each other make her want to laugh and scream.

“I'm going to do it slowly first.”

“No”

“I have to.” Adora reassures her, kissing her throat. “Be patient”

Adora gives another thrust of her hips and then another, speeding further and further at the same rhythm Catra's whimpers do too. Adora's clit strokes against the back of her own hand, still deep inside Catra, building her up into a frenzy that only matches Catra´s pleasure, clear in both of their bodies and voice as they moan against the other's throat.

“Adora,” Catra calls, freely crying. “Adora, I love you, I love you”

“I love you too.” Adora´s own tears splash over Catra´s heated cheeks, holding her secure in safety. “More than anything”

“Deeper,” Catra hiccups, her eyebrows knitting together. “Please”

Adora obeys to her pleas immediately, like she had found another vessel to pour all of her faith and her devotion, one that is warm and soft but also strong. One that moves beneath her and moans in her mouth and that loves her so deeply that when Adora kisses her and roams into her Catra cums swift and strong around her fingers.

“Here?” Adora asks, her hips lowering to a stop but her fingers still pumping inside Catra´s sex, helping her ride it out.

“ *Ha* , yes, *ha. Ah, HA* !” Even though she just came, Catra is not nearly done. In fact, her swift orgasm has just managed to make her grow even more restless, spider like webs of her own saliva stretching between her lips when she opens and closes her mouth, trying to find her voice again. “Don´t stop”

The snakes act like ropes, in a way, holding Catra from bending around herself when Adora gives another thrust so powerful that her entire back arches off the bed, all of Catra´s senses consumed by pleasure that she doesn´t know where else to go.

“Don´t curl away from me.” Adora asks, the serpents obeying like her hands do too, finding their ways around Catra´s knees and lifting her legs open and still against the small of Adora ´s back, knotting them together like the Heracles knot they wear around their waists.

“Adora.” Catra blurts, too far inside pleasure to think of something else.

“Please, I need to see you,” Adora pleads this time, thrusting into her hard and without stopping. “I need to see you”

This time Catra does not inhibit herself nor she wants to. She relaxes all of her muscles and lets the fall open for Adora to see, for Adora to transform her into another kind of statue, one made of flesh and pleasure that Adora can embrace and love and that will do the very same for her in return.

She is Galatea right now, created from the earth and brought to true life by the strength of Adora´s love for her, allowing herself to be taking in such profound ways that even if the gods were to tear them apart right now they would never be able of truly separate Adora from Catra nor Catra from Adora.

“Just like that.” Adora marvels, worshipping at her body with each long and deep trust. “Stars, were you born from the seafoam?”

“Oh ”

“Your neck is long and soft, like swan feathers”

“Ah”

“Your breasts are beautiful, round, small like pebbles, you fit perfectly in my hand, in my mouth” *Ha!* “Do you think I can drink the godly nectar from them?”

“Adora”

“Your abdomen is soft, curved here, so tempting. And it tightens when I do this” *Ha! HA!* “I can see myself in you”

Catra can´t help herself when she turns her head around and moans, digging her fingers so deeply over the soft skin of Adora´s shoulders that she is sure she is painting blooms on her skin, blooms that she cannot see but can feel, warm under her mouth.

“Catra–”

“Keep talking,” Catra gasps, lowering Adora´s head back on the middle of her breasts, cooing her to suck blooms in there too. “Tell me, *ah* , how you see me, tell me everything. Paint the world in words for me”

Adora thrusts against her, her clit kissing Catra´s and with the strength of their love making the wisteria flowers above their heads have begun to fall over their bodies, mingling with cum and saliva and their sweat.

“Our bed, our bed is messy. *Ah.”* Adora is dancing on the edge too, driven insane by the sight of Catra´s dove body as she fucks inside of her. “The sheets are damp with our sweat, they cling to your body and to mine. The olive tree is blooming today, flowers are falling over your hair”

Adora´s hand moves through Catra´s curls, picking up soft petals and brushing past Catra´s flushed cheek with another thrust.

“Sorry, sweetheart. I'll help you detangle it later”

Catra shakes her head violently, like she could not give less of a fuck about that right now. But Adora does care because even in the middle of fucking her wife, she cares about everything about her, not only her sex.

“I´m naked.” Adora points out, describing their devotion for each other so Catra can forever remember their intimacy inside her heart. “Your sex is warm, earthbound, damp and sweet. I can see my fingers slid inside and out of you. I want to live inside you forever”

Catra whimpers, tears and saliva slipping down her face that Adora cleans with her tears and her tongue gently, devoted. This is devotion, tenderness among the fires of lust.

“Your legs wrap around my waist, they fall against the back of my hips. Your arms are around my neck, guiding me to you. Your lips are pressed roses and your eyes hold the moon.” Adora kisses every part she adores, her thumb coming to gently kiss over Catra´s soaked clit too. “You are sweating and you are so wet. So soft for me”

“Adora, Adora I´m going to—”

“I'm over you, wrapped around your body full. Every time I thrust inside of you, your whole body moves up and down. You're loose around me and pliable like warm clay.” Adora presses her mouth open over hers, kissing her very heart. “You´re the most beautiful sight I have ever seen. Erotic, sensual. You make me feel beautiful too. I love you.”

Catra tangles her hand around Adora's neck and comes heavily, spilling all over Adora´s hand and thighs with a wet squirt. Her back arches several inches from the bed, holding herself to Adora´s shoulder blades like a life line until the peak of her orgasm starts to lower down, just a little bit, and she flops back into the bed, gasping for air and feeling herself the most beautiful woman on the entire earth.

Adora kisses Catra´s cheek, helping her ride the waves of her pleasure as she takes her fingers very gently from inside her, thumbing lovingly at her fluttering entrance when more warm cum follows their departure.

Adora´s hand is cramping a little bit and for a moment she has another thought, an idea, of something told to her long ago. She has not cummed entirely, not yet, too entrailed on Catra´s pleasure to pay attention to her own but now that herhips are still and she can gaze at Catra´s beautiful and love made body. that her body starts to urge her for it desperately.

Adora holds her breath and takes Catra´s legs inside her damp hands again, stretching them in front of her to ease the cramp off her muscles and at the same time crawl above her body, lowering herself down over Catra´s abdomen until her own aching lips are brushing over the soft skin of Catra´s belly.

Catra opens her moon eyes, her mouth falling open in desired surprise when she understands exactly what Adora is doing, her hands immediately wrapping around Adora´s waist to hold her still.

“Adora”

“I´m sorry, I need to—” Adora whispers, cutting herself when Catra nods quickly, raising her abdomen as best as she can with her loose body to meet Adora.

“Come here. Do it.” Catra coos her forward, sneaking her hands from her waist to her breast, kneading them lovingly. Adora closes her eyes and throws her head back, pleasure immediately filling her the moment their skins touch.

“Seeing you in pleasure gives me so much in return, Catra. *Ah.* ” dora bites into her mouth, rolling her hips down. “I adore you”

“I love you. I adore you too, Adora.” Catra speaks against her skin, lettingAdora ride her out. “Go on, please”

Adora sits against Catra's belly, rubbing herself over the soft skin there until she is coming down too. Catra can feel the drag of her slick heat against the sweaty skin of her abdomen, over and over again until there are lines painted between the both of them that Catra feels dribbling down towards her belly button and the middle of her legs.

Adora cums as she always does, loud. Beautifully loud, spreading herself completely in her wife´s skin. Catra shakes and sighs heavily into Adora's mouth, following her in her orgasm by the sheer feeling of Adora cumming against her and the echo of pleasure that has left her core sensitive and swollen.

Adora falls on a heap over Catra´s body, her forehead against the pillow and her arms nestled between the both of them, trying to recover her breath as Catra opens her eyes and starts caressing circles and dots through the expanse of her back.

“Wow,” Catra mutters after a few seconds of silence, completely in awe for what just happened.

Next to her head Adora snorts, tilting her face to the side so she can kiss Catra´s cheek with a smile. “You said it too now, can´t make fun of me now”

“It´s just because you´re so gorgeous at this.” Catra sighs, wrapping her grateful and spent body around Adora´s. “Now I know what it is to have your brain. Nothing is working in here”

“Hey”

They laugh together and then fall into silence again, enjoying each other's presence. This is it, Catra thinks, blinking lazily only for the sake of cleaning down her tearful eyes, this must be what all those poets meant in their sung verses about the power that the devotion for one woman can bring.

Catra feels like Persephone's pomegranate right now, gently split open with her seed devoured by quiet adoration, taking root on her womb and growing strong trees of love and loyalty. What once was nerve wracking to hear on other people's tongues, about the pain that it could be or how it could break her if done wrongly, is nothing for golden joy. And she is grateful because she has gotten the privilege to be deflowered by the love of her life, for all of her petals to be stroked and kissed instead of ripped apart and her heart to be fulfilled instead of broken. She is grateful.

And she is grateful, because she gets to do this for her in return.

“Adora?” Catra asks, gently calling for Adora from the land of the dreaming, feeling her stretch over her with a lazy hum.

“Yeah?”

“Are you sleepy?” Catra questions, taking her caresses from Adora´s back to the small of her thighs.

Adora exhales next to her, her body warming up again. “I am wide awake”

“Good.” Catra grins from ear to ear, her fang catching on Adora´s lip when she bends to kiss her. “Because I'm going to eat you out now”

“Yes. Gods, yes”

Catra presses her palm flat over Adora´s chest and firmly pushes her back until she is lifting herself from Catra´s chest and then falling backwards right after, stretching on the flat cot with all her soft and beautiful limbs resting beneath Catra´s.

Catra crawls towards her and finds her legs with her palms, making sure Adora is well resting on her back before hovering over her navel –never her chest or her face, not for now maybe not ever — but securely in here, right between the wide flesh of Adora´s thighs, breathing in the lemongrass and musk that is born from the slick still smudged on her skin.

Catra grins and presses a kiss over Adora´s knee, taking her time to linger tiny pecks like the stone paths of their home, just so she can drink of the joy of Adora´s loud whimpers and barely contained moans, grunting with frustration every single time Catra gets too near from the soft place where Adora craves her the most just so she can lavish the other thigh with the same languid path.

“Catra,” Adora grunts, her long hand coming to wrap around the hair of Catra´s nape, absently pulling from her as her hips rub desperate circles down the already damp bed and Catra´s cheek.

“So eager,” Catra whispers, giggling when Adora moans angrily. “Word?”

“Fuck. Catra, please”

“Wrong word but alright”

Catra rests both of Adora´s legs over her left shoulder, locking the tender space that lives behind Adora´s knees against her own shoulder blades. Like this, cradling Adora over her, Catra almost feels sleepy, brushing feather kisses over the shivering skin of her thigh. But above that sleepiness there is also want, and desire, and undeniable love.

So close, Catra can smell her, heavy and deep, almost like damp earth. So close that Catra´s nose almost brushes her. Catra can feel all of her; the back of her thighs against her cheek, the brush of the fine hair that lives here against her nose, the softness of her folds barely brushing Catra´s closed lips.

Catra sighs, full of tenderness and content and she can hear the way Adora whimpers above her, the sudden rush of warm breath caressing her where she needs it the most.

“ *Ah* ,” Catra hears the smallest of moans, high and as precious to her as the sun rays falling over their heads, and she can feel the way Adora is moving her hips softly against the makeshift mattress, chasing the rush with increasing want.

Adora is holding her own legs with her arms, keeping them up as much as she can, looking to not crush Catra under them even though she is barely coherent herself, unable to contain a moan when Catra blows warm air over her swollen heat, a rush of slick eagerness dripping down from her and soaking her completely, tempting Catra with its smell and wet sounds.

Catra thinks and thinks, here in these small seconds where she can almost taste her in her lips. She thinks on what Adora just did for her, thinks of her warm hands against her hips and her nose running down Catra´s breasts; she thinks about Adora´s heated kisses against her mouth and her tongue against her aching folds and she knows she wants to give it all to her in return.

Catra leans forward, opening her mouth just a slit, just enough for the tip of her tongue to peak outside her parted lips. She follows an invisible trail like a second heartbeat and feels the wet press of Adora´s thigh against her cheek when she opens her mouth against Adora´s labia.

She miscalculates the distance a little because her nose bonks softly against Adora´s open entrance, missing her for a beat.

“Oh” Catra sighs around a shy giggle, surprise and tamed embarrassment washing over her. “Sorry”

She halfheartedly waits for Adora to say something or even to laugh too, but none of them come. All that comes is the most heart wrenching, soul fulfilling moan Catra has ever heard her make, Adora´s hips buckling against Catra´s face chasing desperately for her.

“Catra.” Adora pleads, holding Catra´s hair and the sheets with so much strength the latter rips. “My love”

“I´m here”

This time, when Catra opens her mouth and presses her tongue against Adora, she doesn´t miss her at all.

At first, they are kisses, open mouthed and sweet pouring. Catra pressed her open mouth against Adora and kisses her relentlessly, soft and slow; against her damp folds, soft against the roll of her tongue; against her clit, hidden as a pearl under its even more precious hood; against the tip of her entrance, barely touching her there at all until Adora is shaking above her completely

Adora is moaning, soft and tender, and then loud and hungry slamming her precious head against the pillows. The bell-like ring coming from her head almost mimics her, and Catra can feel the smooth run of scales against her own bare back, embracing her and holding her close.

It´s beautiful, all of it. The sounds she is making, the way Adora is moving, the curl of her body around Catra´s head when she licks her in a certain way that makes a rush of slick fall directly into her mouth, dripping down Catra´s chin and across her collarbones.

Not for the first time Catra thinks that she could live her entire life here, right in this moment where Adora is hiccuping with pleasure and smiling with every tongue of Catra´s tongue.

Where Catra gets to hear her and feel her enjoying herself in Catra´s arms and chase for her pleasure against her tongue instead of curling around her beautiful body in shame for something she had not a play in.

Where Adora gets to feel beautiful, to know herself pretty and desirable and deeply loved; where she knows Catra would burn the world for her too and would lay in this bed opening her mouth against her open pussy and drinking from the nectar of her cum for the rest of the world´s life.

Catra holds her breath, giving the soft lips and swollen lip one more languid stroke of her mouth and dips her tongue inside the place where Adora is so eagerly waiting for her.

Catra feels the firm but pliable flesh against her tongue and laps at it with a lazy rhythm, happy in the way Adora basically screams at the touch because, after all, Adora is not the only one that has learnt the other´s pleasure points by now.

Catra tries to push forward, further, *inside* , but Adora shivers away slightly, shaking her head in negative, already beyond words.

“Not— not yet.” Adora gasps, pulling softly from Catra´s hair. “More. Kiss me more”

Catra lingers an apologetic kiss over her thigh, stroking the feverish skin there until Adora relaxes again, seeking for Catra´s touch without words. Maybe Catra can´t see her, but she can feel her all around her, inside her very bones. She understands.

She kisses tiny blooms across the angle of Adora´s butt and then gets a little bit bolder and a lot more hungry, actually nipping down a small bite on the soft skin of Adora´s thigh, right below the soaked skin there.

Adora throws her head back and she screams, the serpents following her behind but Catra is already eating her out again, dipping her face deeper until the entire middle of her chest from the nose to the chin is soaked with Adora´s release.

Catra lavishes Adora like a poet would sing a prose to a rose, tender and warm, passionate and feverish. She carries the weight of Adora´s legs over her shoulder when Adora gets too tired of doing it on her own, rearranging them both until Adora is sitting with her back flat against the branches of the olive tree and Catra is curled between her legs, enjoying the feeling of Adora´s soles slipping down her own damp waist.

Adora comes again with a gasp, grasping Catra´s hair with sharp nails and writing against the sheets and pillows. She slips inside Catra´s mouth, dripping like rain over a forest all over Catra´s mouth and yet still restless once its done, chasing so much *more* on the mouth of the only woman she loves.

Adora pulls from Catra´s hair softly but insistent, barely waiting to run down the high, running her fingers on the base of her ears in soothing circles. When Catra is back at her height Adora kisses her, open mouthed and wet, drinking on the surprised hitch of Catra´s voice when she feels how eager she is.

“Now?” Catra gasps, her tail lashing from side to side behind her and the bites into Adora´s neck.

“Yes.” Adora nods, licking Catra´s cheekbone.

“Alright.” Catra presses one more kiss over her warm mouth, smiling when Adora moans. “Do you want us to change position?”

Adora stops, actually pondering on it for a moment.

“No,” she finally decides, sighing when Catra starts lowering herself back down again, making herself a nest between Adora´s legs. “Stay right here”

This time, when Catra touches her it is much slower, with so much more purpose. And somehow, it is more erotic than her tongue against her heat. Catra feels the outer labia and then the inner way, running her fingers across their length and marveling at how different it is from hers yet so familiar, so the same like they had actually been sliced in the middle with a sword.

“Threshold,” Catra whispers against Adora´s open and wide hymen, loving it as she loves all of her, with her whole heart. “You are so soft here,” a gush of release dribbles down Catra´s palm. “So eager”

Adora gasps above her head, tangling her fingers across Catra´s hair again, holding her close when Catra leans to kiss her open mouth again just to hear the whimper from Adora´s mouth.

“I can´t see you but gods I can feel you Adora,” Catra whispers, running her fingers with the nails retracted all the way down across all of her labia, gathering Adora´s cum and her own

saliva between her fingertips. “And I can hear you, I love hearing you, Adora. I love hearing your breath when you are coming apart. You gasp and you hold your breath and you whimper a little in the end, did you know that?”

Adora does exactly that now, pressing her palms firmly around Catra´s neck, feeling her feverish skin run even warmer on her palms.

“Beneath,” Catra whispers, leaving tiny kisses over Adora´s intimate lips, happy in the way the eagerness is edging her to the point of moaning without being touched. “You are right, it feels like petals. And you´re making such a beautiful sound right now. Am I close? You´re like a treasure.”

Adora grunts, bending herself in half when she feels Catra´s fingers circling her soaked entrance, gently making sure she is ready like she did for her before.

“You have such beautiful fingers, Adora. Wide, strong.” Catra coats her entire finger with slick, licking a line over Adora´s clit at the very same time. “My fingers are not like yours”

“Catra, your fingers are made of beauty. *AH!”*

“Here we are,” Catra smiles, resting the tip of her finger over Adora´s entrance, right outside, and circling it over and over again like the rim of a wine glass, feeling the way Adora grows more and more soaked as the second goes by. “You know what other sound I love? I love the sounds you make when you are fucking me”

“ *AH, oh.* There”

“When you were inside of me right now Adora, I could hear you grunting next to my ears. I could hear you moaning and calling my name.” Catra tilts her head, sucking a love bruise in Adora´s pussy. “I love those sounds”

“There! There, Kiki”

“Can I now?”

“Yes,” Adora pants, tears falling from her eyes to Catra´s forehead. “Do two fingers”

Catra hesitates for a second, blinking around confusion. She is trying to be careful, mindful and beautiful like Adora was with her, her finger already prepped and ready. “But–”

“Sun. I can take them, please.” By this point Adora sounds desperate, and Catra has no heart to deny her the pleasure of her own sex.

“Alright,”Catra exhales, coating a second finger and then, gently and little by little, sinking them inside Adora´s warmth.

She can take them. And with them, Adora takes Catra´s entire heart.

Catra does not like the comparison, not with their story, but the feeling of her fingers against Adora´s walls is godlike. She is warm everywhere and she is liquid heat, the strong muscles

of her sex pushing against Catra´s fingers and then pulling her in with so much strength she feels her entire body shivering.

There is wetness all around her, around her fingers and around Adora´s intimacy, dripping down on their skins and then past Adora´s entrance, dripping down the mattress and Catra thinks that´s quite a pity so she lowers her head down and presses her mouth underneath her own pumping fingers, lapping Adora´s cum and humming when she violently moans.

“You are very loud. I love that you are loud.” Catra whispers between kisses, rolling Adora´s labia between her lips and sucking from them at the same time she curls her fingers like Adora did, gaining a high pitched gasp in return. “You know what else I love? The sound of our bodies together. Wet, slick. The clap of your skin against mine, your beautiful thighs wrapping around me like they are doing right now”

“C´yra,” Catra´s full name slips off Adora´s mouth, her hips hitching over the bed as she chases for Catra´s mouth and her restless fingers.

Catra can feel her echo of Adora´s heavy breasts bouncing over her head, brushing the soft fur of her ear, and Catra wishes she could have more hands so she could need them in the way she knows Adora loves.

But she is too busy right here, with her mouth seeking for Adoraps engorged clit and her hand making love to her sex over and over again, her other hand gripping the soft rolls in Adora´s hips and leaving her mark in them.

“You are so erotic when you are taking me Adora, and so intimate when I'm taking you in return.”

Adora inhales sharply and whimpers, slapping her palm against her mouth with so much strength it sounds like a slap. That just won´t do so Catra´s hand travels from Adora´s hip to her arm, finding her wrist and pulling gently from it, guiding it towards her hair instead.

“Don´t be quiet. I need to hear you,” Catra whispers, opening her eyes and knowing that Adora will hold them in hers. “I love you”

Adora has a split tongue but Catra´s in long and when she dips her head back again she uses it to lick over Adora´s clit before dipping it down, right between the two fingers deep inside Adora´s sex and following them inside. Catra holds her breath and then, with a long swipe, she licks against Adora´s soaked wall, pushing her over the edge.

Adora all to but screams, curling herself impossible close around Catra´s head as her orgasm peaks until her moan becomes a low whimper, sore and breathless against Catra´s ears when she crumbles down into her side.

Catra leans back immediately. She helps her ride down the overwhelming orgasm, massaging her body instead of continuing to lick her up no matter how much slick keeps coming out of her, as she knows Adora is especially sensitive after cumming and she does not enjoy the over stimulation.

Instead she starts peppering kisses over Adora´s thighs and her hips, and rubbing soothing circles over the exhausted skin of her back and legs, traveling from her calves to her lower waist to her shoulder blades, kneading on her skin trembling with sweet aftershocks until she feels her go loose and tender once again under her touch.

Adora´s deep and content sigh is the signal Catra needs to know that Adora is with her, back from the subspace that the sex has submerged her into and slowly recovering sense of her feelings and her own body.

Catra smiles and wraps herself over her back, running her arm over Adora´s upper arms so she can wrap them fully around her chest, holding her close to her chest.

They remain like this for a few good minutes, basking on each other's warmth and happy, so happy their bodies are loose and their hearts are full, filling them with the same kind of giddy happiness as young newlyweds get to have, young and in love.

“Was that good?” Catra whispers against Adora's warm skin, kissing her shoulder.

Adora chuckles stupidly, running her hand over her face. “Good is too little of a word”

Catra laughs, then she keeps laughing, suddenly unable to contain her own limbs as she rolls in the bed, giggling and kicking at the sheets and covering her face with her hands, so happy she had to take a second to place all the joy inside her heart.

Adora turns around, facing Catra instead of far away from her. She giggles with Catra too, running the back of her sweaty knuckles across Catra's sticky cheekbone, and Catra can just feel how sweetly Adora is gazing at her right now.

“Did you like it then?”

“Did I— Adora I want to have sex with you every single minute for the rest of my life,” Catra laughs, throwing her arms to the sides with a loud giggle.

Adora giggles too, gathering her inside once again. “We need to eat”

“No we don´t,” Catra fights, kissing her chin.

“And sleep”

“Debatable,” Catra nuzzles her nose against Adora's, smothering them together. “We could just turn immortal and have sex forever”

Adora hums, deeply considering for a moment. “I like it when you sing too though”

Catra rolls her eyes, content in living in the space between Adora's neck and her ears. “Fine, I ´ll consider our exceptions”

Adora chuckles next to her ears, pressing kisses over her forehead while the serpents press their own kind of kisses over Catra´s back, turning her smooth skin into goosebumps. “Are you having fun too?”

“So much,” Catra stretches in Adora´s arms, her tail drawing lazy swirls between Adora´s legs where she hears her gasp. “Fun is not the only words I´m looking for though”

She wishes she could see the expression in Adora´s face, the change in her eyes or the twitch of her mouth. Instead she feels Adora´s hands, strong and wide, wrapping themselves around Catra´s back and turning them around.

Catra feels winded, her breath stuck to her lungs as she feels herself suspended on air, her knees dug on the mattress and her nails deeply dug on the olive branches and the pillows. She can feel Adora beneath her and for a moment she feels confused until she realizes that Adora is lowering herself down on the cot, her hot breath caressing the swollen heat between Catra ´s legs when she places directly underneath it.

“Dora? *Ah* ”

“I´m sorry,” Adora whispers, kissing Catra´s inner thighs, her mouth brushing on the place where Catra can feels herself warm and damp. “But now that I have tasted you I can´t stop”

“Don´t stop then” Catra gasps, lowering herself down on Adora´s mouth. “Never stop, ever again”

****

Catra must have done something genuinely good in her past lives to be able to say she is lying with the most wonderful creature on earth.

Truly, she adores Adora, she is incredibly fond of her for who she is, for her beautiful heart, so selfless and that she always wears on the sleeve of her tunic like a second skin; for her soul, that she wraps around herself and around Catra lovingly.

But intimacy had brought a new kind of joy for her, for the both of them, so many possibilities of baring their bodies and hearts to each other and be vulnerable in a sacred way, that she does not know how she went so long without knowing what is to have Adora between her legs and without tasting the pleasure out of her heat.

It makes Catra laugh, it makes her happy, tremendously and earthshaking happy. The fact that she is loved, that she is allowed to love; that she is someone being worshiped by someone wonderful; that she is someone worth to make love to, worth to devote and devour and adore. That this is her life, it fills her with joy.

“Why are you smiling like that, sweetheart?” Adora asks sweetly, ripping Catra away of her own thoughts with a gentle kiss on her cheek.

Catra sighs, a breath that comes as a chuckle, her mouth working faster than she gets to actually think what she is saying. “I´m just thinking, if we keep going like this you´ll actually manage to knock me up”

Catra tenses, worried out of sudden. She didn´t mean it, no, she did mean it but as a joke, not like that. Not like something that can remind Adora of what she could never have.

They´ve been so happy these past weeks, so joyful basking on the light of their open love, on the meaning of being allowed to love each other, that Catra sometimes forgets herself and she slips into dangerous territories, the kind that can hurt Adora is she is not careful and doing that would break Catra´s heart.

Catra can feel her bloodstreams rushing violently inside her eardrums, waiting with pinpoint anxiety for Adora to gasp in pain or horror and to the golden day they are having to be over, but all Adora does is sneaker between her teeth, giggling next to Adora´s ear until she can´t go anymore.

“I don´t think that´s how it works, my love.” Adora murmurs, pressing a strong kiss over Catra´s temple.

Catra relaxes immediately, her mouth twitching in a lopsided grin because of course, this is Adora she is talking about.

“Well it should.” Catra shrugs, wiggling her eyebrows. “Because we are having a pretty eventful honeymoon”

Adora snorts and cackles out loud, her breath sweet smelling from the figs and honey they shared in the morning and her hands slightly clammy with spring sweat and the paint she has been using the last two hours to draw dots and swirls over Catra´s soles and her palms.

“What else are you thinking about?”

Well, fuck. Of course this is Adora, and Adora is completely attuned to all things that Catra is and feels, including the smallest echoes of doubt living in her chest.

Catra could lie, save herself a little bit of dignity and shrug it off but it would be useless, she knows Adora would know anyway and it would only draw a line between them all over again. And Catra is quite sick of lines by now. She wants them gone. She wants to be happy, with Adora.

“I guess— I never thought I would be desirable for anyone,” Catra confesses, resting her chin over her bent knees.

Adora takes a second and then moves closer, her breath right above Catra´s closed eyelids when she leans to kiss them sweetly. “Why not?”

What´s wrong with her eyes?

Even so long after it happened, Catra can still hear Hordak's voice inside her head, that night where she was deemed too sick to be a proper meal for the Emperor´s bed.

You need to marry her now that she is young and desirable before her limitations weigh more than her pretty face.

Catra can still hear her own aunt´s voice, a woman that was supposed to love her and care for her, speaking about her in such a hateful voice, as if Catra was nothing but spoiled goods from the very crib; someone too complicated to deal with and to love.

“Because I´m blind and I have, you know, different needs and it's not exactly a very seductive feature.”

This time she does hear Adora take a sharp breath, almost violent, the serpents hissing and snapping their fangs against each other. Catra curls into herself even further, wrinkling her nose and tilting her face away hoping this way Adora won´t get to see the ways in which Catra still doubts herself, even after everything.

It´s alright, she expects Adora to reassure her, *Don´t listen to them.*

Instead she feels Adora´s firm hands taking a hold of her jaw and bringing her face to the other side, pulling from her gently but without room to snap away until their noses are almost pressed completely together. And Catra cannot see her but she can smell her breath and feel the strength of her gaze over her own face, rooting Catra in place.

“C´yra, you are the most beautiful, most erotic person I have ever known.” Adora snaps in that voice that makes Catra´s mouth salivate and her palms to start sweating, something dark and desirable like wine and honey.

“Oh, we are in full name territory now?” Catra chuckles nervously, dying flat when Adora grunts.

“I´m serious”

“Alright”

Adora runs her fingers down Catra´s spine, brushing her hair to the side so she can press a damp kiss on the back of her neck. “I thought me not being able to rip myself away from you was clue enough”

Catra huffs, a quiet pant making it in her voice but still quiet. “I was guessing it was for my charming personality”

“That too,” Adora smiles against her skin, her cheek softly pressed between Catra´s shoulder blades. “Your little shit personality turns me on a lot”

“You speak like that to your wife?”

“Yes when she is doubting herself.” Adora tears herself away from Catra, shifting around her so she can face her again, her warmth so close Catra knows if she moves just a little but forward their noses will meet. “Hey”

“Hey”

“Do you know how many times I fought myself from gazing at you too much before we were together?”

Catra opens her mouth, closes it again, exhaling heavily. “Alright, I bite. Tell me”

“Oh, yes. I would have to force myself to look away when you were too sweaty from the heat because your tunic would always cling to your breasts right here.” Adora presses her palm right above Catra´s sternum, between the soft swell of Catra´s breasts where her entire skin shivers. “And when you were sleeping next to me, your skirt would wrinkle up between your legs and your breath was always so sweet between your open lips. It was maddening”

Catra´s ears press to the sides of her head and then shot up, her chest heavy with her rapid breathing. “You never showed that tho”

“Only because you can´t see me making a fool of myself. I thought you would notice how aggressively I was waving at some point. I almost broke my loom. Several times.” Catra snorts. biting her lip. “I even had to bury my head on the moss at some point. Right into the dirt”

“I don´t believe you”

“You will when I tell you exactly how mud tastes like,” Adora murmurs, easing Catra´s lip off the confinements of her sharp teeth, caressing the soft skin.

“You´re such an idiot”

“I am”, Adora shrugs noticeably with a hum, her palm still wrapped around Catra´s throat. “Eh, I´m not better than a horny idiot”

“You are so much better.” Catra whispers back, her entire face burning up. “Your tongue skills are god like”

“Careful, that's what got me into this mess. *Hiss, hiss* .” Catra´s head clocks for a second and then she is laughing, her entire body folding in half with the strength of her snorts and cackles, filling the cavern with their sound. “What?”

“Did you just say *hiss hiss* ?” Catra manages between loud laughter, cleaning tears off the corner of her eyes.“Outloud?”

“Hey don´t judge me!” Adora complains but it's quite clear that she is already laughing too, fighting so Catra does not notice and failing miserably at it.

“Too late!”

“You´re the one that told me to love myself!”

“Hiss hiss, was not exactly what I meant.”

Adora wraps her arms fully around Catra´s waist and brings her flushed against her chest, holding her sweetly inside her arms as she blows raspberries over Catra´s neck and Catra laughs even louder, all squeaky and messy and frankly ridiculous.

Catra hasn't laughed like this in a long time, not in forever, too wrapped around sorrow and sickness and war to even begin to have reasons to laugh at all. She might have, a while ago when she was much younger or when she held a newborn baby she didn´t know it was the love of her life's blood inside her arms, but not like this. As if she was free from the restraints of the world outside their cavern.

“You purr when we kiss,” Adora points out, kissing a breathless Catra to prove her point.

“But I´m a magicat”

“And I´m a—” Adora hesitates, suddenly lost in her words. Even after everything she still doesn´t know what she is at all. “Hmm”

“You are the love of my life.” Catra whispers because that´s all she knows to say and as it turns out is the only thing that matters.

“Yes I am”

****

Adora kisses her with purpose, with a goal. She always kisses like this, like it was her personal mission to make Catra squirm and purr inside her arms just so she could hold her a little closer and kiss her a little bit deeper.

This time, Adora places them over the soft moss of the cavern, right between the fireplace and the mosaic steps of the temple, at the feet of an altar that today burns pink with poppies and that it smells like seafoam.

“Hey,” Catra gasps, smiling when Adora wraps her hands around her waist and brings her closer.

“Hey,” Adora answers back with that very same edge of soreness that makes Catra´s entire world burst into flames, running her fingers underneath Catra´s tunic and pushing it up her legs until it wrinkles around her hips,

Catra purrs even louder now, stronger, closing her eyes with a delicious smile and arching her back over the moss. “Mmm, we woke up in a mood?”

“A little bit”

“I love when you wake up in a mood”

She hears Adora chuckle and the next thing she feels is herself being dragged down over the grass, her waist secured with firm arms that keep her from moving her hips away.

“My tunic,” Catra whimpers, already slick with want when Adora starts kissing the back of her knees and all the way up her thighs, lavishing her skin in kisses.

“I´ll make you a new one”

Catra gasps, nuzzling over the mess of fabric and moss, running her hands across the slim serpents that wrap around her arms and wrists and hold her open but also reassuringly on their touch.

“Adora,” Catra hisses with a barely contained moan.“We are on the ground”

“Yes,” Adora snaps right back, groaning deep inside her chest in a way that makes Catra whimper in pieces. “I can´t hold until the bed”

Catra doesn´t know where she gets it but Adora places something very similar to a pillow below Catra´s hips, angling them in the exact point she loves where she can lean down her head and perfectly eat her out.

“Dora,” Catra begs, pulling from Adora´s beautiful face closer between her legs.

“C´yra, wife of Adora. You are a princess of the old Etherian Throne.” Adora whispers thick and heavy against her damp folds, smiling with the silent promise of letting Catra know exactly how erotic she finds her always. “I desire you in all ways. I will love you forever”

She makes Catra cum three times with her split tongue alone before giving her a break and only so she can kiss her mouth instead as her long fingers start pumping deliciously slowly inside her heat until Catra is coming all over again for a fourth time.

By the time she is finally satiated enough of devouring Catra´s virginity beneath the lit candles of the altars, the sun is much lower on the sky outside and their cavern is much darker, submerging them both in the light shimmer of the full moon and the fireflies and crickets are fully singing all around them.

Catra rests her cheek over Adora´s naked shoulder and exhales, her body still trembling with the sweet aftershocks of their sex and her mind fogged with pleasure.

“You´re—“ Catra licks her own mouth, finding the words like a drunk lover. “Hungry”

“I am.” Adora agrees, her mouth traveling up Catra´s forehead and down her ears with reverential touch. “Can you blame me?”

“No.” Catra smiles, pressing herself closer to Adora´s body “I'm starving too”

Catra nuzzles on Adora´s sweaty breast below her cheek, shivering when she feels Adora´s long fingers finding their way back between her legs, gathering her pleasure between her fingertips and pulling from all her strings until Catra is gasping again.

“You know what else I've been thinking?” Catra asks, biting into her mouth.

“Tell me”

“I´ve been thinking about that story you told me about”

Adora makes a questioning sound, dissolving into a light moan when Adora´s fingers find their own way between her long legs. “Which one, pretty?”

“The one of the Mileto women that traveled to Lesbos.” Catra kisses her way down Adora´s feverish shoulder, feeling her trembling against her as they chase each other´s pleasures at the same time. “The one where the women would caress themselves when their wives were out in battle. Where they would touch each other in other ways. Deeper ones”

Catra whimpers, throwing her head back when another orgasm overtakes her, only managing to make her own restless hand work deeper and sweeter inside Adora´s heat. “The one with the *olisbo* ”

Adora grunts and presses her hot mouth against Catra´s ear, biting into the soft cartilage.

“Would you like that?” Adora asks, buckling her hips at the same time Catra fingers her. “Me taking you with it?”

“ *Yes* ”

“Yes? Do you like thinking about me? Me, thrusting inside of you where my fingers can't reach you?”

“Gods.” Catra presses Adora´s wide thigh between her aching legs and starts riding the soft flesh with her soaked lips, masturbating each other until their bodies are covered in perspiration again.

“Would you like to feel me riding you after you came? *Ha* , rock over your belly as I sink into it, still covered with you?”

“Mmm.” Catra nods, wrapping her free arm around Adora´s neck, bringing her close to the heavens with the other. “Do you know then? How to–?”

“I do.” Catra can feel Adora smile and her entire body smiles with her too. “That one I've never tried”

“Good. Because I want to be the first you feel inside this time”

****

Adora stares at the bright sun hovering over her head on the open domes and she thinks herself blessed.

She knows, of course knows, every single day that it is not the case. That she has been casted into exile and doomed to never see the world again beyond these stone walls. That her body has been changed with no possibilities of return and that she is cursed to never see her nephew´s face ever because she would doom her to the same fate her father fell into for being a good soul with a gentle heart.

Adora knows all of this, she repeats it to herself every single day.

But she is blessed, because Catra is here with her, holding her in her arms every single morning too.

There is a sun above Adora's head and beneath its light there is Adora's own sun, hovering over her face as she feeds Adora ripe figs and berries, brushing her fingertips over the creases of Adora´s forehead and the edge of her copper crown, learning her skin all over again as she does every single day.

She is especially beautiful today too, with her long hair held in lops by golden rings and colorful ropes around her face and neck, keeping up to ease a little the heat and sweat gathering on the back of her neck. She is wearing one of Adora´s older tunics, turquoise blue with the seams sewn in golden thread, purposefully lose on the chest for Adora to gaze at the peach pebbles of her breasts and pooling half open around her waist where she sits cross legged on the soft grass of their secret garden.

The golden and crystal beads of the bangles around her ankles and calves jingle a little every time Adora moves, propped long and stretched across Catra´s lap, staring at the sun and at her precious face with the very same awe, counting the seconds on which the ellipses painted in shadows across her cheeks appear and disappear as the light crosses the thick foliage of the trees above their heads.

Adora sighs at the sight of her wife and accepts another red berry pressed against her lips from her dark fingers, smiling around the sweet flavor and the warmth she feels on the pads of Catra´s fingers when she presses kisses over her sticky fingers.

“Just please don't choke,” Catra mutters through a smile too, the pearls of her heavy earrings jiggling with each other when she leans down and pokes the middle of Adora´s forehead. “I've gotten kind of fond of you”

Adora´s broad grin only manages to grow even fonder, her hand also cradled in golden bracelets coming up to poke at Catra´s button nose. “Oh, I knew you liked me”

“I don't like you, Adora.” Catra says, wrinkling her nose. It's sweet, Adora loves when she does that because she knows exactly what follows, this, “I adore you.” That. “I need you.” And then “I love you”

Adora sighs, joyful as she runs her palm over the warm skin of Catra´s neck and pulls her down towards her, slothing their lips together. It´s kind of an awkward position, with Catra almost bent in half and Adora nestled on her lap, but it is as warm as the sun shining right above their heads, blessing them with golden light and clear skies, like a small mercy for women that love each other. For newlyweds and old lovers and one soul finally falling together in the cracks of each other's hearts.

“I have something for us.” Adora whispers against Catra´s lips, her heartbeat picking up with expectation and excitement as the thought of what is about to happen starts filling her veins like boiling water. “But I need to stand up to get it.”

“No,” Catra complains, wrapping her arms around Adora´s head, serpents and all, and pressing it against her chest, keeping her from moving a single inch. “Stay with me”

“I promise it´ll be worth it,” Adora kisses the falls of her wife´s collarbones, joyful in the fact that she gets to call this beautiful sun wife to begin with.

“Ugh, alright,” Catra lets go from her, crossing her arms around her chest with a huff. “Leave, see if I care.”

“You are so pouty every time I leave,” Adora points out with a smile, not even paying attention to Catra´s fake annoyance as she runs her thumb over Catra´s pout, easing it into a gasp when she rubs her bottom lip until it open sweet like a flower under her touch.

“Stay here,” Adora instructs, and then with a bigger smile, she adds as she stands up. “Close your eyes”

“Uhu, very funny Adora”

Adora does not go far, not even stepping out of their secret garden. She crosses the blankets thrown on the soft ground and the baskets filled with food and wine and reaches the bundle of soft clothes where she had hidden her own craft project for the last couple of days.

Adora knows she should be ashamed about how quickly and excited she jumped to do it, but then again, she is young, a young woman in love, a young woman married for some blessing to a beautiful sun, to the very stars of the universe. A woman who likes to kiss and to touch and be touched in return; who loves to bring her love pleasure and to feel it too.

A woman who for the first time in years, or maybe even for the first time in her life, feels truly and authentically beautiful. Who feels and sees her body supple and pretty, covered in moles and suns and kisses, and even the golden and turquoise shimmer of scales, the ones that surround her and hold to her calves and her waist like embellishments.

A woman that, next to the woman she loves can feel beautiful even with all her changes.

****

Adora approaches Catra again, sitting on the soft blankets and grass and gathering her inside her arms again. She lets what she just went for fall in her lap and then brings Catra towards her, allowing her to slide over her back at the same time Adora kisses her, all tongue and heavy breathing.

Catra feels the soft curve of something more between them and gasps, her confusion dying as she realizes exactly what is happening between them.

“Ah, Adora.” Catra raises her eyebrows, her pretty silver eyes opening for Adora to see herself reflected in them “.You did it”

“Yes.” Adora sits Catra over her lap and rolls her hips forwards, meeting Catra´s soft and damp skin beneath her tunic with the touch of the *olisbo* placedon Adora´s lap.

“What is it made of?” Catra gasps against her mouth, her eyebrows wrinkling with pleasure.

“Marble.” Adora whispers, sucking on Catra´s kiss bitten lips, “I polished it while you slept”

Catra straight up purrs in Adora´s mouth and opens their lips together against each other, licking the roof of her mouth and catching her gentle lip with the sharp angle of her fangs.

Adora gasps, her head falling backwards in a way that leaves her neck completely exposed for Catra to latch into, biting soft and then much harder against the frail skin of her throat. If Catra loves the feeling of Adora´s split throat against her body, Adora is addicted to the sharp edge of Catra´s teeth over the most tender parts of her limbs, blooming lilac bruises that only Adora gets to see.

“Actually,” Adora asks around another gasp, her neck already sweating with the sun and the heat of Catra´s mouth on hers. “Do you mind if I try out first”

Catra stops for a second, throws her head back so Adora can look at her again. And when Adora turns her eyes towards her the first thing she sees is Catra´s beautiful, wrecked face above her, her breath hot as an exploding volcano and her cheeks red as pressed poppies. Strands of her hair have escaped the laces around her head and are bouncing around her flushed cheeks, her sightless eyes shimmering without a thousand and one emotions.

“Yes,” Catra rushes to say once she realizes she has been quiet for a little too long. Then she starts nodding, fast and excited, almost laughing like a maniac with the amounts of her joy. “Oh, absolutely. Yes, yup. Yes”

Catra starts kissing and smooching all over Adora´s face, damp and loud, and Adora laughs, resting her palms over Catra´s slim shoulders, her fingers feeling the soft edges of the scars that have long ago healed from the pain.

“I´m very happy you want to try.” Catra murmurs against Adora´s nose, cradling her jaw and bringing their foreheads together “But can I ask why? It's not only for my sake right? Because I know you”

Adora sighs, closing her eyes at the touch and the proximity. It is impossible to hide anything from Catra by now, she knows this.It is a part of their trust in each other, a part of their compromise as best friends, as lovers, as spouses. It still surprises Adora how important it is, being able to feel completely safe when leaning her heart and her body into someone that loves her.

“In a way. a part of me wants to make sure it is safe.” Adora admits, smiling when Catra hums. “The other part of me, the stronger one, just wants to ride you until I come”

Catra´s smile defies the very sun when she grins, pulling from Adora´s body towards her.

“I´m so in love with you right now”

It´s a bit of a push and pull for a second, or more like a lot of a pull. Catra takes Adora´s hands between hers and brings her fingers towards her mouth, kissing her way from the pads to the heel of her palm and waist, up and up across Adora´s green veins across her tan skin like the olive branches, finding the crook of Adora´s elbow and smiling against it.

Adora doesn´t even notice that she is being pulled on her feet until she is planted over her own bare soles, dizzy for a moment and tilting dangerously to the side when Catra skims her way down and finds the smooth and slightly curved surface of the olisbo, wrapping it completely inside her palm.

It might not be exactly accurate, as Adora never got to see an actual olisbo before. But she still remembered the drawings the woman of Lesbos would made for her during their stories and she could still remembers the flush in her face as they told them, so similar to the flush on her cheeks when she was polishing it next to the edge of the lake or the warmth on her face right now, feeling Catra pump the marble on her elegant fingers with slow swirls, meant for Adora and only for Adora to see.

“Put it on me,” Catra whispers in her ear, smiling until the corner of her eyes wrinkle when Adora can´t help herself and whimpers miserably.

Adora has managed to hold the slightly wider base of the olisbo tho curated leather ropes, and she had messed it up as many times as she had tried it until she finally managed to make it hold between her legs and securely knotted to the back of her waist. It was probably not perfect but she hoped it would just be enough for the both of them.

Once Adora helps Catra steps into the straps of leather and knots it in the back, all the breath inside her lungs is already gone, stolen by the sight in front of her. Between Catra´s long and elegant legs and the blue fabric of her skirt, the olisbo looks almost like another piece of jewelry over her dark skin.

It´s white, as it is made from the marble from their temple, and not very big. Just enough for Catra´s fingers to wrap around perfectly as she feels every round edge in front of Adora´s sharp gaze, learning it and its gentle curve in the middle. And it is perfectly tempting, right there on the hold of her wife, so much that Adora´s legs start to tremble, already coated with a fine string slick between her thighs.

Catra must hear something on her breathing because her silver eyes gain a knowing edge, almost mischievous, stepping close to Adora´s hot body until they are pressed flushed together, the tip of the olibso brushing against Adora´s hip when she cradles Catra between her thighs.

They stumble a little backwards until Adora´s back is resting against the smooth stone wall of the back of the cavern, the serpents holding themselves to the smooth pink quartz scattered around her shoulder and head.Like this Adora is able to rest a portion of her body over the flat surface of the stone, almost sitting instead of squating.

It does not matter anyway because Catra is already there, for her, running her arms below Adora´s knees and placing them firmly at either sides of her own waist until Adora´s ankles are crossed over the back of Catra´s calves.

And Catra is almost holding the entirety of Adora´s weight in her arms, their chests so different yet so very similar pressing flushed together into another kind of kisses; and Catra´s hands running their way below the hem of Adora´s tunic, pushing it all up until it wrinkles around her belly.

“ *Ah,* ” Adora moans, her eyes rolling inside their sockets as she feels the head of the olisbo run deliciously slow across her damp folds, far away enough that it doesn´t get to come inside but close enough that its presence against the skin of her heat is a promise of so much more to come.

“How does it feel?” Catra asks, her breath boiling against Adora´s skin. The very murmur of her throat when she speaks makes Adora go crazy, her hips buckling up and down to allow her soaked folds to kiss the smooth surface.

“Cold,” Adora describes, biting her bottom lip when she sees Catra let her head fall forwards, taking Adora´s supple breast inside her mouth. “Delicate.”

“So like you,” Catra teases around a smile, sucking off the hardened pebble of Adora´s nipple with another torturous drag of her hips.

Adora grunts and moves quicker than her own brain can begin to comprehend, unable to warn Catra before they are already moving. Adora pushes them both towards the ground, staring at Catra´s surprised expression and calm huff when she falls on her butt and back over the soft blankets of the floor.

She is beautiful and delicious like this,searching for Adora´s presence among the bright light, her hand finding the body of the olisbo instead and bumping it several times with the slick smudged over it, purring the entire way.

Adora holds her breath and lowers herself, pushing down the straps of her tunic and letting it fall completely open across her chest, wrinkling around the divots of her hips. The arm air meets her cold skin immediately, making her shiver but she pays no mind to it, sucking in her own lip as she starts stradling Catra´ships between her legs.

Like this, moving like this, breathing like this, like a serpent enchanting a butterfly or a river surrounding the waist of a mountain, Adora feels herself seductive, gorgeous with her breasts bare for their own small world and Catra´s warm palms when they fold them hungrily.

She feels herself beautiful beyond reason, the actual most beautiful woman on earth besides the one spread like a muse underneath her and between her legs. She feels herself loved, yes, but also deeply desired, every single inch and corner of her body craved for. waited for from the scales to the perspiration hung from it.

Adora feels herself capable of love and sex, not only tender but also heated, allowing her body to relax and be taken as well to take in return, a gift and be given going on in circles where there are no conditionals to be adored.

She feels herself safe, taking the olisbo from Catra´s hand and guiding its heat towards the entrance of her heat, lining herself with it before letting her hips fall down slowly, inch by inch, welcoming a new kind of intimacy inside their marital bed.

The marble caresses against the hidden spot inside her walls almost immediately, ripping a loud gasp from Adora´s mouth, the kind that echoes all around them for several seconds and that makes Adora´s lips even more soaked than before.

It´s different, miles different from the feeling of Catra´s gorgeous fingers or her own, but it´s a good kind of change. She would not trade one for the other but the way in which the olisbo starts filling her, stretching the tight muscle and fucking her in delicious strokes almost drives Adora insane, too drowned by raw pleasure to think about anything else.

Underneath her Catra´s face is a whole masterpiece of its own. Her face is pleasurable and red, popping every single freckle in her cheeks and making the silver and white of her eyes to shimmer like breathing moons on her unfocused irises.

Her ears are wide and shoot completely up, twitching as she takes on every single sound that Adora is taking over her, from the hitch of her sweet breath and the deep moans, to the drag of the olisbo held to her hips against Adora´s walls and the wet whistle of both of them together.

And she is moaning too, whispering and holding her breath, kneading Adora´s breasts and repeating her name over and over again. It´s borderline obscene, the sounds that they are making together, the echoes that they are creating by meeting their bodies in different ways.

Obscene and sweet and Adora drowns into it, taking pleasure not only on the olisbo penetrating her like a sun to a void but also for being able to do this, for being the cause of it. Her, Adora, someone deemed objectionable and then disgusting, being able to create sounds of lust and of pleasure, to bring heat and sex to herself and her lover, to make her body warm and pliable as she humps over Catra´s lap and to make Catra´s face wrinkle in that way that always speaks of the deepest of subspaces where only both of them live and she is happy. They are both happy.

Catra can feel the almost invisible bulge against Adora´s belly when Adora finally slips to the very hilt with a wet grunt, her fingers shivering against the frail skin of her navel.

Shots of pleasure snap below Adora´s eyelids and she flops forwards, suddenly too overwhelmed with pleasure to be able to hold herself up any second longer. She is not there yet, she is close but not there, bouncing her hips wildly until her waist is pulling with the effort.

She is feeling so much right now, so much is overwhelming in all the right ways. The drag of the olisbo, the smooth material coated with the slick of her own body; Catra´s body sweet and loving below her, her smell on the tip of her tongue. The sun above their heads and the green grass; their love making and their sounds.

It´s all so much and suddenly Adora is lost in joy, truly lost, not knowing where to go next.

Catra is there for her, immediately.

Her hands find Adora in the light, one wrapping around the back of her neck and the other on the base of her back, kneading and painting circles on feverish skin with her gentle fingers until Adora is shivering, letting her know she is right there.

“I love you,” Catra gasps, pressing kisses over any part of Adora´s face that she can reach. “You are doing so well Adora, *ah* , so beautiful. Do you feel beautiful?”

Yes, Adora gasps or maybe just thinks, tears gathering on the corners of her eyes and spilling down between the space of their bodies, mingling with sweat and love.

And when Adora´s legs and hips cannot go anymore, Catra is there too. She plants her sole firmly on the ground, lifts her knees and starts bumping her hips up and down too, faster than Adora can go on her own, meeting Adora´s needs with sweet strokes, gently but still firm, slamming against Adora´s heat until she feels her lips swollen and completely soaked.

Catra runs her hand across the serpents and gathers them all on her fingers, pulling them to the side just so she can discover Adora´s neck below and can press her lips over the skin of her nape, licking, sucking and adoring as Adora chases her high and Catra helps her through it, firmly decided to make Adora feels the sweetest of pleasures now and for the rest of her life.

In the end is Catra´s own precious face, the one that pushes Adora off the edge. She fucks Adora slow and hard and when Adora tilts her sweaty face to the side to gaze at her she sees her beautiful features completely destroyed by the strength of her adoration for Adora and that is enough.

Adora comes so hard that she sees sparks of white, born from the center of her eyes and all the way across her entire body, through her neck and chest and every limb, spreading hot and deeply sweet inside her womb and heat as she melt down in a mingle of high pitched moan and liquid warmth, spreading through the olisbo and her thighs and Catra´s navel below her.

Adora falls limbless over Catra, her body loose and pliable resting above her chest as her own arms fall across the grass, too exhausted to hold herself to anything right now. She can´t think, for a whole minute the only thing she can do is feel the aftershocks of her orgasm coursing through her body in golden sparks and the weight of other arms holding her secure to the earth as she slowly starts to feel like herself again.

She doesn´t even notice there are sounds around her until she makes up Catra´s voice next to her temples, softly speaking to her and waiting for her to come back.

“ — fine, princess, you´re alright. You are in control and I´ve got you,” Catra is saying, her voice trembling with the amount of her love and want for Adora but still gentle. “You did so good, it was beautiful. I´ve got you, I´m not letting go.”

Slowly, very slowly, Adora takes a breath, her sweaty face rising from its place over the soft moss and blankets to rest her cheek against Catra´s warm one. She feels the slow intake of air from Catra´s mouth when the later realizes she is back but she doesn´t move away, firmly keeping her arms around Adora´s waist and rubbing the exhaustion out of her muscles as Adora´s hips keep shivering every once in a while.

Catra´s eyes are slightly open, narrowed against the light of the sun but just enough so she can make out Adora´s body around her. Her hips are still moving too, Adora realizes, up and down and in soft circles, dragging the olisbo that has slipped off Adora´s heat around her swollen lips instead, firing up the golden sparks into something crimson and mouth watering.

It´s so much, so very much that Adora can barely contain herself. She has been pushed over the edge and held from falling at the same time, securely suspended in Catra´s hands off the black and green void. And as the seconds pass Adora knows she cannot hold herself anymore either.

What she just experienced was so beautiful that she wants to give it in return to Catra, right now. She can already feel the slick of Catra´s own barely contained pleasure between their bodies.

“Kiki,” Adora whispers, planting her palms on the soft blankets and pushing herself slightly up, just enough to hover over Catra´s body instead of resting completely above it.

Below her Catra chuckles, her smile sincere when she finds Adora´s arms and tilts her head to kiss her wrists. “Stop calling me that when we are having mind blowing sex, Dora.”

That red something spreads inside Adora´s chest and blooms, exploding around her heart, throat and womb like a newborn star about to lighten the entire universe with her colors.

Adora grunts, lowering her hands immediately towards Catra´s hips and undoing the knots of the straps around the wrinkled and dap fabric of Catra´s tunic and slips the olisbo gently but quickly off her also shivering legs.

Adora makes quick work of her own clothes, tearing the tunic to the side and slipping inside the leather ropes of the strap, all without tearing herself away from Catra´s warm and restless body, already shivering beneath her with the strength of expectation.

The olisbo hangs slightly heavy between her own wide thighs, smooth and wet with Adora´s own cum. It drip slightly in her hand when she holds it and it makes her feel beautiful beyond words, lowering down towards Catra´s flushed body and grabbing her gentle ankles between her damp palms.

“Open your legs for me,” Adora instructs against Catra´s ear, sore and firm. “C´yra”

Catra´s entire body locks in, her back arch in Adora´s hands when she wraps her waist and drags her towards her over the blankets in one swift motion. “ *Ah* ”

Catra legs fall open at either side of Adora´s hips, resting her soles over the small of Adora´s back and bringing her hands towards her face to try and keep the keen whines inside her throat.

Like this Adora can see her fully, open and swollen already, the tale of her slick excitement sticking to her inner thighs and stretching translucent spider webs between her pink and brown lips. Adora can see the way her heat pulses against the warm breeze and a gush of her arousal slips from her core and drips on the blankets, calling for Adora to kiss her from the inside out.

“You are so wet, sweetheart,” Adora marvels, resting her forehead over her navel and running her thumb over the fluttering lips near to her nose. “Did you enjoy taking me?”

Catra giggles nervously above her head, stretching her hand in a silent plea for the serpents to wrap around her. They do. “Of course I did, dummy”

Adora hums, narrowing her eyes as she circles Catra´s entrance once and then dips two of her fingers inside of her, quick and smooth, stretching the soaked muscle inside in firm circles. “Don´t call me that when we are having sex”

Catra slams her head against the soft moss and moans, barely managing to cover her mouth. “Adora,” she gasps, her eyes narrowing with the pinch of fresh tears. “Adora”

“You are so very wet,” Adora continues, pulling her fingers out of Catra´s warm cunt just so she can line the head of the wet olisbo against her entrance, teasing her with its cold touch. “Do you think you can take me like this?”

“Yes” Catra nods violently, wrapping her arms around Adora´s neck to bring her close. ”Sun. Yes”

“Good.” Adora smirks, getting a hold of Catra´s hips. “Because I can´t wait”

Adora drags Catra´s hips towards her and thrust her own forwards, slipping the olisbo inside Catra with a smooth and wet sound. Catra is already so loose that it enters her almost completely in one single movement, ripping a whine so beautiful off her throat that Adora has to take a second to breath and stare at her.

She gazes at Catra´s eyes almost completely closed with the sparks of pleasure and her half open mouth, puffs of steam leaving her lips when she pants mingling with the tears born from raw desire that dribble down her soft cheeks, sweet as honey when Adora leans down and licks them sweetly off her skin with her tongue.

She gets a good hold of Catra´s hips and holds both of their breaths inside her throat as she pulls her hips back and then thrusts inside her, hard, bottoming out to the base and bringing them impossible together.

“ *Oh* ,” Catra moans, letting her eyes open as they roll inside their sockets. “ *Oh* , Adora”

“I know,” Adora reassures her, kissing her hand. “I love you, I´m here”

“I can feel you,” Catra whimpers against her lips, trembling when Adora rolls her hips still deeply buried inside her. “You came over it and I can feel you know”

“I'm right here,” Adora says around a gasp, taking Catra´s hardened nipple inside her mouth and sucking it gently until the brown copper skin turns red and slick under her touch. “Listen to my voice, hold onto me.”

Catra whines, exhaling in Adora´s skin when she feels her drag the olisbo all the way back, almost slipping off her until only the smooth head is resting inside her, kissing her lips and stretching her open for Adora. She is ready, she is more than ready. Adora is ready too.

“I won´t let go from you either”

Adora exhales heavily and slams her hips forward, hard, entering Catra all over again until she hears her moan.

Adora catches a rhythm almost immediately, guided by the shiver of Catra´s body and the sound of her moans. She pulls back almost completely and then rams inside, over and over again, thrusting inside Catra´s heat until she is being rocked completely, their bodies sliding together and against the blankets.

Adora drinks on every single sound, Catra´s tiny whines and high pitched moans and the wet meet of their bodies, pulling together and pushed apart, joined by the webs of arousal dripping from both of their bodies and that makes the olisbo glisten silver between them.

Adora means to be soft and gentle, slow, but she cannot help herself and Catra doesn´t want it right now either. Adora fucks her like wild, her thighs slamming against the back of her butt, the strength of her strokes lifting the middle of Catra´s body off the ground with each delicious thrust.

Catra moans and rests her hands against Adora´s bare and sweaty back, one over the middle of her spine, the other near her ribs, holding her like a lifeline. Her nails accidentally slip off when Adora thrusts inside of her with a stroke so delicious that she cannot help herself when she digs the sharp ends over Adora´s soft skin, breaking it into shallow scratches that sting immediately and that make Adora gasp against Catra´s damp tongue.

“Sorry,” Catra apologies immediately, her arms slipping off Adora´s shoulder and falling flat and open on her sides, twitching as she is taken over and over again yet distracted by the immediate regret of hurting Adora even a little bit. “Gods, I´m sorry”

“No,” Adora snaps, loud and strong, watching the way her voice makes Catra´s body shiver and her cunt grows wetter, driving Adora insane. She grabs Catra´s wrists again and throws them against her back, dipping her own face against Catra´s pulse point and biting into her flesh with a single command. “Do it again”

Catra holds her breath until it turns into a moan, tears slipping off her eyes when Adora´s fingers slip between them and start rubbing tight circles over Catra´s clit.“What?”

“Scratch me again.” Adora asks her, begs her, licking her neck from the base to her jaw, her hips working insatiable as she works the olisbo deeper and deeper inside Catra´s walls. “Bite me, mark me up and down. I´m yours to take.”

“But, *ah* !”

Catra´s confusion dissolves into a scream when Adora wraps her hips and tilts them *up,* making her legs fall open in a way that allows Adora to fuck her deeper, sweeter, brushing the end of the olisbo against the very bottom, brushing something inside Catra never touched before.

Catra´s body answers on its own. Her nails unfold all the way up and she digs them against Adora´s skin immediately, dragging down and painting beautiful red lines over Adora´s skin.

After being marked up for so many years by fake heroes and murderers, covering her in scars and patches that will never get to fully disappear, being marked by the pleasure of the love of her life makes Adora moan, gazing at Catra´s face lost in lust and pleasure beyond her and smelling the honey off her skin mingling with the quick spark of her own blood, gold against stardust.

“Just like that,” Adora mewls, proud of her wife´s body and pleasure, fondling her soft ears on her fingers and pressing a kiss to her temple. “I love you, gods, I love you”

Catra is beyond words by now and Adora follows her quickly into the same subspace. All they can think, smell and taste is each other; all they can hear are their bodies slapping together;all they can feel is the sweet sting of their love making, the way Adora penetrates every single layer of Catra´s skin and soul and the way Catra´s moans dig a path inside of Adora´s heart and take root.

Adora runs her hands down and takes Catra´s legs inside her palms, stretching them up. She has a plan but she gets distracted for a second, watching the way the olisbo slips out of her cunt and with it their joined arousals drip into the blankets, thick and white.

Adora grunts and lowers her head down, opening her mouth fully across Catra´s entire heat, fighting a smile when Catra screams and Adora slips her tongue *inside, gathering* it all in her throat and living off it.

It does not last much, Adora wants to feel Catra coming apart in her hands, around her hips, inside of her, not like this today. Right now Adora is taking and Catra is allowing her to take too.Adora is selfish and Catra blooms under it, smiling around her own pleasure.

Adora takes one of Catra´s legs and hooks it over her shoulder, resting the other one over the high of her own ribs. Like this Catra is almost bent in half, open in a way that allows Adora to slip inside somehow even deeper.

Adora wraps her arms around Catra´s shoulder and neck and rest her face against her pulse point, thrusting, fucking inside of her with so much strength that makes them both breathless and trembling

Catra crosses her arms behind Adora´s neck, holding the serpents between her fingers and presses her nose and mouth against her cheek, hiccuping around a moan.

“Adora–” she whimpers, gasping when Adora thrusts inside, out, inside, inside. “I can´t–hold on”

“Don´t,” Adora gasps, tilting their face so they can kiss each other's mouths. “I´ve got you”

Catra hums inside Adora´s mouth in a way that sounds like a song and she cums heavily, all white sparks of the moon light meeting the sun. She is quiet through it all, tiny hitches of breath that travel through Adora´s body and somehow make her cum too, shivering against Catra´s legs and crumbling down over her spend body all over again.

Adora can hear Catra´s heavy pants next to her ear, fighting to recover her breath and deeply soaked in pleasure. She is trembling too, almost volent, her teeth click with each other and it ´s all Adora needs to know that Catra needs her right now.

Adora untangles their limbs from their tight hold onto each other´s sweaty bodies and lets herself fall on her side over the soft ground. She gathers Catra´s shivering body inside her arms immediately, tucking her face below her chin and wrapping her arms around her waist and shoulder, caressing her in the same way Catra just did for her too, helping her come back.

It´s always much stronger for Catra, every time they have sex like this, so deep and intimate that it shakes their entire world. It always brings her deeper into the subspace of their bodies together and it always takes her longer to let go from the strings of their passion.

Adora feels her breath deep against her skin every once in a while and her heart starts to steady just a little bit, but she is still trembling slightly and Adora presses her mouth against her forehead, repeating over and over again how much she loves her, *I love you, I love you so very much….*

****

It takes her a few long minutes but finally Catra giggles, closing her eyes and joyfully laughing against Adora´s skin. She wraps her hands softly around Adora´s throat and starts kissing her way all over her jaw and chin, still speechless but letting Adora know the lengths of her love and her happiness.

Adora hums, lullying her back to her with her voice. Adora almost never sang, not even before that night. She did sometimes, alone in this place to make herself company, to ease the loneliness or to echo for herself a funeral song.

Now she sings for the love of her life to sleep, songs that she taught her too where there is no space for loneliness and where the pain is cradled by patience. She is not alone anymore, she thinks she never was not even when she was younger. Even there Catra was right there,on the other side of the world, walking among dreams and reaching for her hand.

Even there, on those five years Adora was here feeling herself wearing away and rotting, there was still sun on her face and then Catra arrived and there was the spring, back from a dry winter and stubborn, ready to take root inside Adora´s life and never leave her ever again.

Adora smiles until she feels it wrinkling the corner of her eyes and runs her fingers across the dark strands of Catra´s hair, admiring the soft loops curling around her fingers and feeling infinitely soft towards them.

“We might actually be able to do this, won´t we?” Adora asks in a soft voice, holding Catra tenderly towards her.

Catra stirs from her drowsy state, blinking awake so she can press another kiss to the corner of Adora´s mouth. “Do what, princess?”

I knew no one was coming to save me so I just prayed for you and here you are now, safe in my hands.

“Live a happy life here.”

Catra stills for a second and then moves, turning her face towards Adora. She cannot see her but she can feel the light of Adora against her silver eyes and Adora can gaze at her in return, without fear, without turning her into stone.

“Of course we will”

Adora remembers perfectly the day arrived at the cave, a little more than a year ago. With her dark hair and her purple clothes. With her bare soles and her stubborn will to live no matter what. With her full moon eyes and her trust in Adora, from the very first second.

“Kiki?”

“Yes?”

“I’m really happy you stayed.” Adora whispers, gulping down tears pooling on her golden eyes and falling across her cheeks and chin. “And I'm really glad that I get to grow old with you”

“Me too.” Catra whispers, smiling and when Adora looks at her face better under the sun she thinks how lucky she is and how grateful that after everything Catra did not walk away.

Suddenly Adora feels drowsy too, her body loose and spent and her heart at peace. Her eyes start to grow heavier and heavier and her eyelashes slightly sticky, called for gentle dreams where Catra does not wander away and Adora stays with her.

“Adora?” Catra whispers near her ears, running her soft fingertips over the arch of Adora´s eyebrows.

“Mmm?”

“Sleepy, sleepy princess.” Catra chants, tangling her fingers over the drowsy serpent, resting their cheeks together into a silent kiss. “Let's stay together forever”

“Yes.” Adora accepts, like wedding vows all over again. “I very much would like that”

“You promise?”

“I promise”

Do you picture me like I picture you?

Am I in the frame from your point of view?

Do you feel the same? I'm too scared to say

Half of the things I do when I picture you

— *Picture You* , **Chappell Roan**

Chapter End Notes

Kids, don´t use marble alright? Use something else and specially done for spicy times. Do as I tell not as I write

Hope you enjoy the chapter! See you soon! Our journey is almost over ;)

Verse XII

Chapter Notes

NOTES:
– Time skip, it's been five years since the last time we saw our girls, so they are both thirty one by now
– “The rest are flowers” equals “the rest is confetti” from Hill House
– This is our longest chapter with 36k words

WARNINGS:
– Descriptions of wounds
– Descriptions of death

Trust me.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse XII. Threads of Time

I try to capture every minute, the feeling in it

Slipping through my fingers all the time [...]

Sometimes I wish that I could freeze the picture

And save it from the funny tricks of time

Slipping through my fingers

— *Slipping through my fingers all the time,* **ABBA**

Time is a curious thing.

It bends, it twists. It folds, it changes, it opens in half and takes different paths. It circles right back to the beginning, it knows and pulls and pushes. It weighs, it floats light as a feather.

But it never breaks, no, time never breaks.

Fate Lines are very much like time, in fact, they might even be siblings, bloodlike, born from the same thread of the universe. After all, time gives the souls meaning and the souls are

embroidered to their own threads, the ones that measure the length of a life, the ones that mirror the purity of it.

They are all colored and all material, not tangible for the mortal world but as real as breathing and as bloodstream. They are copper and silver and, sometimes, they are liquid gold. They are stardust and moss and lake mud. They are marble, they are quartz.

They are strong, yes, stronger than any other thread in the world. They endure everything, the pull and the push. They could hold the entire weight of the world off Atlas´s back and hold the very heavens with their touch, as holy as they are frail and as unbreakable as they are easily corrupted.

They are rotten, sometimes, coated with blood, coated with greed and sins, marked by the own hands of those who own them. And they bloom too, sometimes too, cradled like olive branches with flowers scattered like a breath of fresh life.

They meet in the middle and turn apart, dozens to hundreds of times. Threads that meet others for only a short or an infinite amount of time before they too have to take part. Before they too split open by time and by the hands of those who weave it. By women, three of them.

They are, after all and in their very core, weavers. A different kind maybe to the mortal ones, to the ones that sit in looms and run their fingers over the wool until their fingers are covered in calluses and their tapestries are masterpieces.

Unlike mortals, they do not run their hands through wool or silk or cotton. Unlike them, they do not own marble or copper looms to do their craft. They are infinite, a part of time itself, suspended in the middle of the universe with their ethereal hands extended towards the world as if cradling it inside their palms, shushing it awake and guiding through life and then crushing it back into stardust.

They are blind, the three of them as most holy things are, yet they can *see,* they can see it all. Their eyes are made of the very same threads they wave and knot, watching every single second with devoted care until the sharp edge of time scissors the thread in half and then it´s over, it´s done. Thread cut and soul free to roam towards the halls of the Underworld.

They are neither good nor bad; they are neither just nor revengeful. They just are. They exist with us, with every single individual thread from the very beginning.

First, the spinner, the first mother, weaving the art of a thread in her wheel, whispering life into it and letting it go almost as quickly as it has come. Just a fraction of a second to admire something beautifully done before life takes its own tool into it. She is merciful.

Then the alloter, the one who measures, the one who observes; she sits dutifully though life and watches it unfold, watches the owner of the thread pull and pulls from its own line carelessly and then desperate, their life going on through a split of a second before is also time to part. Unlike her sister, she is merciless, as she knows the fate of those who cross her fingers.

Last, it comes she who cannot be turnable, the unbendable one. She is the one destined to watch the end of each life, no matter how long or short she wishes them to be; she is the older and the wiser and for so the more stubborn, the one who holds the point of the cut and gives a snap, just one perfectly placed, watched the life dissolve into ashes or stardust and leave their domain. Different from her sisters, she is the strongest of them all as she watches death face to face and lives in its hand.

This is the task that has been given to them from the very first second where the world saw itself give a breath. And after everything is said and done, after the universe has gone to eternal sleep and all that remains is silence, they will be the ones running the last thread on their fingertips and bringing it all to an end.

They represent the cycle of the fruit, from seed to ripe to rotten on the ground, and they are opposites of time, walking side by side through this life. They know what is to be done and they do it well.They never fight, never disagree. They are sisters and they are one and the same at the very same time. They have seen every single thread and run its course. They have seen all and know all.

There are, whoever and every once in a while, certain kind of threads that make the sisters raise their blind eyes and stare a little longer, steal a moment of time just to gaze at the light for a moment.

There are threads that hold on, *hold onto each other,* harder than praying hands and stronger than faith itself. Threads that find each other from the very beginning, that are born from the same dust or stardust and instead or running their course next to each other they weave around the other, braid and hold onto each others strands until they are so irrevocable strung to the other that is impossible for them to tell them apart.

Threads that have no faith but in themselves and not life but the one that they share for each other. Threads that could bend the world in half if they wished to, and maybe even time itself. Threads that are so woven to each other's souls that they are almost godly and while they are mortal they shimmer golden under the touch of the sisters fingertips. And they cannot help themselves but to sit and watch them hold onto each other as strongly as they can.

And there are another kind of thread, threads that are god touched yet putrid. Threads that poison everything on their walk and that eat their way across other threads with their greed and their rage. Threads that threaten godlike ones, that think they can make their way between them and torn them apart.

Threads of greedy lives, like the one the tree sisters see on their ethereal reflection, below the surface of water. A thread of a man defeated, chasing his own tail, overcome by the victory of a young queen with wings on her cape and her mother's hair.

A man, dragging himself across dry land, spitting and screaming for what he thinks will bring him the ultimate satisfaction. A man that has made a goddess bleed. A decision the Fates are waiting for, patiently.

Strangely, almost never but every once in a while, those are the kind of threads that the spinner cries about, the alloter dreads and the unbreakable, well, the unbreakable hates.

And as the older sister she gets to decide the culmination of their Fate, the way in which it ends. It is the gentlest of touches laying down on the ground or in blood spilled across stone.

Time it's a curious thing and Fate sometimes takes a little longer to arrive, but it always, always, reaches us. A bet always reaches an end.

After all we are all, no matter who we are, in our dying bed in the hands of a woman. And a woman can love deeply, to the very ends of the world. A woman can hate until it burns the world. A woman can sacrifice every part of herself for love.

And a woman, above it all, can wait.



Time is a beautiful thing for Adora.

She thinks about this every single day when she opens her eyes to a new day, a day where her world is tinted through the rose colored glass hung from the ceiling and where her life sells like wisterias and honeysuckle.

She thinks about it when she tilts her head to the side and sees the colorful tapestries woven with multicolored threads and embroidered in gold, hanging from the columns of the old temple beyond the canopy of their bed. She sees the tapestries and then beyond, to the temple that has become a home with long lines of garlands made with flowers that never wither, marigolds and anemones and daisies; honeysuckles and roses and tulips, hanging heavy like pieces of art around the oil lamps that smell like lavenders.

She sees the heavy trunks of swollen wood licked by sea salt where their clothes rest, chitons and tunics, plepos and hemations, leather ropes and Heracles knots woven in each one of them. They are new but also old ones, the kind that have been eaten by time and so they have been embroidered back to life, birds and flowers made in copper threads that join the fabric together. They are not Adora´s creations but she saw them be born, a miracle all on its own.

She sees the copper mirrors propped on the side, over long columns long alone fallen that now serve them as tables where jewelry waits to be worn. Pearls, raw and imperfect with iridescent colors, amethysts and turquoise hung from either the finest of necklaces or the heaviest of neck embellishments, accompanied by golden coins that jingle with each other. Ambers and pink quartz in gentle crowns and gold wrapped around precious gems, making of the circlet of bracelets and earrings and the cufflinks their wear on their heads.

They shimmer under the light of the sun slipping through the cracks of the old ceiling, washing their colors inside Adora´s golden irises when she turns her head towards them, admiring the way they are scattered almost carelessly through clay bowls of maroon and yellow paints for their faces.

In a way, the temple reminds her of her chamber in the palace, and the last time saw it, about eleven years ago. In a way she thinks she should have forgotten it by now but she thinks that

the soul of it kept living because it was her own, after everything. And Adora is still the person she was when she was twenty years old, just a little bit older and much wiser.

Adora sighs at the sight of it all and lets her drowsy eyes run through the warm bed, taking in the things in it. There is the canopy of course, keeping the bright rays of the sun from slipping inside through the branches of the bigger and older olive tree, hung with precious crystals too. The ceiling of the bed is adorned by windchimes made of lake pebbles and smooth glass, jingling with each other in sweet music when the soft breeze touches it.

Blankets and several pillows are thrown everywhere across the mattress, so many that sometimes Adora does not know where her limbs go and the pillows start but that she knows are important, as they keep the safety of their marital bed guarded like the walls of Troy.

With the light of the dawn, Adora can see the shimmer of their veils carelessly dropped over the bed before they fell on each other's arms and deeply into sleep. Purple and deeply blue, embroidered by tiny crystals that look like the stars hung from the heavens all across the fabric and heavily over the rim of the soft fabrics, sewn in pearls and raw diamonds.

Then up and up, at herself, Adora can see her own legs long and supple tangled around blankets and around brown lean legs, stretching as sleep makes its way back from her head. She can see her own hips slipping from the open slit of her sleep chemise and the angle of her waist where she rests propped on her side.

Adora gazes at her own arms wrapped sweetly across a second sleeping body and can see her hands running through soft strands of dark hair, caressing them curling and gently around her fingertips. And she can see the serpents that always accompany her, a part of her body after so many years, also barely awake with their marble and golden bodies like the veils themselves draped over the warm body of her wife and lover, caressing her and holding her close as she sleeps.

Adora thinks time is kind, for her on this life she has built for herself, because every single day when she opens her eyes she gets to see the beautiful and so deeply beloved face of the love of her life, curled over Adora´s chest and breathing softly against her neck while she wanders inside dreams.

She has grown a little bit older, as Adora has done too, and even more beautiful every single day.

Her hair is so much longer than the first time Adora gazed up at her, long and soft with oils, carefully taken care off by her own hands or by Adora´s, so long by now that standing still and without cuffs or braids it brushes the back of her ankles when she walks at the edge of the lake or when she dances with Adora around the fires of their home.

Her skin is a little bit darker after many hours under the kind sun that peaks on the open domes of the cavern. And there are a hundred and one more freckles in her face than before, traveling down her cheeks and jaw and clustering around her shoulders and hands. Hands most of the time painted in beautiful swirls and shapes by Adora´s hands, a sign of their marriage only both of them get to know.

She is healthy and well fed, her hips supple and her abdomen soft. Adora has looked after her and she has looked after Adora in return.

There Is stardust scattered across her cheekbones and her eyelids look golden under the light of a new day, cradling her sleeping face with life. And she wiggles her nose just a little bit when the sun caresses her lilac eyelids, not ready to wake up just yet so she just curls inside Adora´s arms and sighs, slipping back into dreams.

Adora smiles and holds her closer, drawing invisible patterns of dotted words over her bare back, spelling the words of love across her body in a written language that she has come to learn too because she loves someone that has different needs and meeting them is a whole other way of telling her how much Adora adores her.

Time is kind, yes, and good, and sometimes a little bit too fast. Adora spent five years all on her own, alone in this cavern hating herself. Then love quite literally barged inside her life and for a whole year Adora managed to start the long process to heal, to be loved amongst it all.

Now it has been another five years and this time she has not been alone through it all. Her hand and her heart have been held the entire time. Her body has been cradled and her pain and fear eased, respected as they might never leave. She has been adored, loved, worshiped, and Adora has done all of it in return with the very same devoted adoration.

Tme is kind, because she gets to have Catra by her side.

Adora drowses off with Catra for another half an hour, maybe even more she is not counting. It has been a long time since she counted the hours and the days passing her by hoping they would be over soon.

When she wakes up again the sun is more golden and almost completely above the cavern, showering everything in its light. Adora breathes deeply through her nose and very carefully starts to detangle herself from Catra´s limbs, making sure she is back softly resting over the dozens pillows and blankets before sitting on the bed.

It's warm today even though it's supposed to be winter and Adora´s skin is warm, a long time since it has been cold at all. She throws her arms towards the sky and stretches as much as she possibly can, groaning softly through the nice pop of her shoulders and back.

The straps of her tunic slip off her shoulders, easing the wrinkles of the soft fabric around her chest. Just as Catra, Adora is healthy too and her body has molded to a life where she is loved and where the days inside the cavern are golden.

Her arms are strong but softer, just as her abdomen and her hips. Her chest is heavy and deeply loved by Catra and by Adora too, and her skin scattered in sun freckles that shimmer copper over her tan skin. She looks at herself on the copper mirror when she stands up in weary soles and she sees the image of a beautiful woman, loved and desired, one that still bears scars and that has bad days and then terrible days, but for which there is always a sun to wake up to.

She runs her fingers through the slim serpentes curling awake little by little and sighs, her eyes wrinkling just a little bit sad in the edges. She still misses herself, every single day, she won´t lie about that. She loves her life and she deeply cares about herself now,but she still misses every single day who she used to be, before the curse.

She misses her blue eyes and she misses her golden hair,she misses the parts of herself that she shared with Adam, that made them twins, one and the same. She misses them, they were still torn away from her without her permission and she mourns them every day when she glances at herself on accident of the reflection of the lake or the mirror. When she remembers that she is still Adora but that the changes she went through were not her decision.

It´s easier now, so much easier, but Adora can never forget about that, not a single second she is able to go by that while inside the cavern she has a heaven and a paradise, for the outside world she is still nothing more than a monster where Princess Adora has died.

She knew it would happen because this kind of thing can never fully heal, not without justice sometimes, and she accepted it would happen. She fights every single day for her to wake up and love herschel just a tiny bit more each time until she doesn´t think about it at all.

Today, though, today Adora loves herself especially a little bit more than usual and it makes her happy.

She turns around and tippy toes on bare feet over the mosaic floor, leaning towards Catra to watch at her sleeping face full of peace.

She always looks so young when she sleeps. Her face relaxes and she smiles in dreams, cheeks soft and plumb and lips full and pink. And she smells delicious too, like lemongrass and figs and a kind of scent they both share after so long together.

“I adore you,” Adora whispers, caressing a soft line over her cheekbone and leaning to kiss her gently on the forehead.

Catra smiles, nuzzling on the pillow still deeply asleep, and Adora smiles with her.

The path between the temple and the waterfall is still smooth with the stone paths Adora made years ago. Every once in a while the moss tries to crawl its way past the cracks and over the stones and Adora dutifully weeds it out, making sure there is nothing in the way that might make Catra trip when she forgets one of her canes somewhere in the cavern.

Adora wraps the drowsy snakes inside the white and simple veil she had grabbed from the trunks, gathering them all below the soft fabric before stepping below the waterfall. She had never again knotted the serpents into the painful ropes she wore before Catra, but just as Catra´s hair they had grown too with the pass of the years. Long enough that, stretched as far as possible from Adora´s scalp, they can reach the back of her calves.

Adora knows Catra loves them dearly and she has grown fond of them with the years, because it would be impossible to hate something Catra loves, but just sometimes when Adora is having a specially good day, they also get too excited and get in the way.

So the gentle veils and golden cuffs are never too far away from her to keep them from tangling on branches or holding themselves around Catra´s limbs and throwing Adora to the ground when she tries to stand up and she is pulled back immediately after.

Small mercies and also small annoyances through the days.

Adora can hear the serpents sizzling happily when she steps inside the lukewarm water, falling quick and strong against her face and bare body. It´s a beautiful day today and she can see the reflection of the sunlight against the water in rainbow droplets falling around her hands and shoulders.

There are still many scars scattered in her body, white and pale pink. From her soles to her ankles and all the way through her calves. They match sometimes the stretch marks around the inner side of her thighs and her hips, traveling up and shallow across the curves of her belly and below her ribs.

They also match the ones crossing her face, the ones the iron mask had opened against her cheeks and nose and had made her bleed and scar. The kind that can´t go away no matter what but that Catra likes to run her sweet lips over and over again and paint suns over them with her fingertips.

Adora thinks the worst of them must live on her arms, on the upper side and some thrown on the forearms, born from clumsy slashes with swords and spears or the errand arrow that would manage to scratch its way on her skin when she would try to push them outside.

But it has been a long time too since any fake hero has walked in this place. Ever since the horrid day when Catra bleed ichor on her hands, no other intruder had made its way inside their lands, not even once.

Sometimes, in the months after their wedding, Adora would slip from bed at dawn and sit on the floor of the cave, over the green moss and the broken statues just to observe the entrance of the cave for hours to end. She would wait and wait until her eyes were aching and sore from almost not blinking at all or Catra would call for her to come back.

As the days went by, the mornings where Adora would sit expecting for another person to walk inside became thinner and fewer and suddenly all Adora was doing on the mornings was lingering in bed with her wife and letting herself be carried by quiet dreams.

Adora sighs and narrows her eyes against the water, letting it wash away the night sweat off her body as she sees the light steam rise around her. She has a body covered in scars but they are hers, this body is hers. She wraps her arms around her chest and her belly and she feels her own warmth and her own breath; she feels her own heartbeat below the palm of her hand and hears the rush of blood and water inside her own head.

This body is hers, Adora´s, and while it is covered in scars it is also covered on the lingering hand of love. Her palms and shoulders are tattooed with the shapes of constellations and with the dots of Catra´s love words; her soles are forever painted in yellows and maroons and her face is cradled in sun shapes as well as sunlight.

Each and every single one of her moles swirl around each other as testimonies of days under the sun and not hidden in shadows; and every single one of them too is covered by the phantom pressure of a kiss, left with care by a mouth that loves her above anything else.

This body is Adora´s and lets it be loved and she loves it in return even if it still aches, even if the pain is chronic, a kind of forever one. Even if it exhausts her and saddens her, it's hers. Her own, untouchable in ways that have nothing to do with only bare skin.

Adora embraces herself under the water and closes her eyes, smiling at the softness and strength of her own.

The wheel of time runs its course and with it Fate does too. She doesn't know it, but she is ready.

A hand touches Adora´s bare shoulder blade softly, searching for her precariously inside the water. Adora recognizes it immediately and her smile turns all kinds of tender, turning to the side to grasp dark fingers and gently guide them inside.

Catra steps in careful feet over the moss and hugs Adora from behind, kissing her shoulders as she rests her cheek over the middle of her spine. As Adora, she is also bare from head to toe, her hair loose behind her back and her face clean.

Tiny bracelets and fine rings adorn her hands and arms, making her jingle sweet as a lyre when she runs her arms around Adora´s chest and holds her as close as possible to her, basking on the warmth where she is still drowsy from sleep.

She must have walked all the way here without her cane and taken off her clothes still half asleep because her body is pliable as clay right now, her limbs tangling around Adora´s. Adora finds it beautiful, the way that Catra trusts her enough and so deeply as to wander inside their home without aid, already knowing where Adora is and that she will always receive her with open arms.

Adora hums and turns around, wrapping Catra´s naked body inside her arms. She lets the waterfall shower them together, running her fingertips over Catra´s temples and the back of her neck, chasing away any kind of pain lingering its way there.

“Morning, dove,” Adora whispers, kissing Catra´s wet cheek where her wife only manages to hum, resting all of her weight inside Adora´s palms.

“Mmm”

“Still sleepy?”

“Uhu.” Catra frowns lightly, her still closed eyes cringing when she wrinkles her nose. “You weren't in bed,” she points out slightly accusingly, running her lips up and down Adora´s neck.

“You were sleeping so sweetly, I didn't want to wake you.” Adora explains, grinning.

“Dummy.” Catra huffs, a told tale that she is awake enough now to be sweetly annoyed with her. It does not last much though because she relaxes again almost immediately, nuzzling her face on the crook of her neck. “Hold me a little longer”

Adora exhales, resting her cheek over her forehead. “Forever”

It´s a routine, for the both of them after so many years together. They bathe together under the warm fall of the clear waterfall and hold onto each other until their fingertips are wrinkling and Adora starts pecking kisses over Catra´s ribs, making her giggle.

Then they walk out and wrap each other in dry hemations, walking hand in hand back towards their temple. Laughing every single time Adora trips on her own feet and almost knocks them both over the grass.

They linger inside their sun showered bed and speak to each other in soft voices about their dreams or about whatever, filling their silence with sweetness and each other's voices. the serpents kissing their way over Catra´s blind eyes.

Adora detangles Catra´s curls when they are not held in braids or locks, and clips it with pretty circlets of gold and thin lines heavy with golden coins that fall over her forehead and around her temples. She knots colorful laces around the strands and holds them up and away from her face in the way she knows Catra likes the most.

Catra´s hair had changed too with the years, just a little bit. Her dark brown strands of hair are mingled with lighter ones in certain places, around her forehead and below her nape, of a copper color that almost looks red under the summer sun. And even lighter ones, behind her ears, earth color dissolving into pale wheat, born from the fevers of her own wounds and that never washed away.

Adora thinks that is a little bit as if she was carrying the seasons in her hair. The wheat of the spring and summer, the copper of the autumn trees and the brown of the winter earth. And she thinks it´s fitting because she is a niece of the Dame of the Spring and a grandchild of the Lady of the Harvest and she is still a child of gods, half of a sun sleeping in Adora´s bed every single night.

And when it´s a warm day, like today, she places the finest of veils over Catra´s head and lets it fall across her precious face and her back until she is hidden beneath the fabric embroidered in glass beads. Until Adora can grab the hem and slip inside the veil too, sitting over the bed and in front Catra in the perfect angle in which she can gaze up at the loving face of her lover.

Catra fixes Adora´s serpents. standing between Adora´s legs with her face peaceful, humming under her breath and laughing when every single serpent bonks her softly on the face after she is done painting them over with gold powders and fixing cuffs and pearls over their bodies.

Adora still thinks how beautiful is the way her serpents mirror Catra´s blindness. How maybe it was not incidental at all but the promise of something more wonderful to come after Adora was cursed. How she despised them before, all of them including their blind pale eyes, but

now she cannot bring herself to see them without seeing Catra´s own eyes in them and she has no choice but to adore them so deeply it leaves her breathless.

Adora blinks very slowly at Catra hovering above her, learning all over again every single corner and crevice of her factions before smiling, letting her face fall forward and her mouth to rest over the bare skin of Catra´s belly. She smells the best right here, always, as if the perspiration of the day and the peach hair there held the rawest part of her scent, making Adora drunk off it.

Adora rests her palms over Catra´s waist and kisses her belly languid, soft and very, very slow, running her lips across the divot of her belly button and through the soft curves of her abdomen and waist, feeling them and devoting herself to the no matter how small the seconds or how long the minutes she does so.

Catra smiles, her closed eyes forming faint wrinkles around her eyes. She has laughter lines in the corner of her mouth too, testimony of endless days of laughter next to Adora. Little treats that tell a story of her life and the way she has grown a little bit older and a whole lot more beautiful, blooming even inside this underground place.

“What are you doing, dummy?” Catra asks in a whisper, running her fingertips across Adora ´s big forehead.

Adora smiles around the kisses, the tip of her own fangs grazing softly against the exposed skin of Catra´s abdomen in a way that makes the latter exhale.

“Well, kissing my beloved wife of course”

Catra grins, her sweet smile dissolving into a low whimper when Adora slips her arms below the open fabric of her tunic, wrapping her forearms fully around her waist.

This too is familiar, the soft touches that escalate to heated ones; the way their bodies meet through clothes or bare skin, sliding against each other like perfect pieces of a mosaic. The run of Adora´s hands across the small of Catra´s waist and the brush of Catra´s fingertips through the narrow spaces of Adora´s scalp, easing lingering pain with love murmurs and embraces.

Adora travels down, kissing a trail of slow kisses all across Catra´s skin, down her belly button and towards her navel, lavishing the freckled skin that lives right above the angle of Catra´s thighs and then below, losing herself of the strong and safe smell that lives there.

Catra runs her fingers through the snakes, humming when they curl around her fingers and wrists.

“We just bathe,” Catra points out but even for her it sounds flat, without real grumble behind it.

Adora hums, making a home for her mouth above Catra´s legs.

“So?” She says with a shrug, alternating her caresses between her lips and the tip of her teeth. “I´ll bathe you again.” Adora pulls from her hips, guiding Catra carefully as she lowers herself back over the bed. “I´ll tend to your curls,” Adora lingers her lips over Catra´s heat, exhaling deeply. “Just let me worship you again”

Above her, with her knees deeply pressed at either side of Adora´s head, Catra throws her own head back and moans deeply, allowing their joined sounds to fill their secret paradise all over again.

There is something so deeply erotic in this life of theirs. Mundane, divine. Godly even.

They sleep on the bed filled with fabrics, tangled in limbs and sheets and perspiration, underneath the leaves of the vines and the perfumed blooms that hang over their heads. A marital bed, made of living branches and fresh sprouts. A bed where they love and they dream, long ago left behind the bitter night of night terrors and right next to each other when one or more nightmares managed to reach their claws towards them.

They linger their bodies across the remains of the temple, soles over marble and mosaic, fingers dipped in colorful paints. Hands brushing each other around the columns and below the shadows of the ruins that have made their home, chasing each other with childhood joy. They laugh and then laugh again, feeling young and in love and a special kind of eternal inside this hidden place that is theirs.

They bathe on the waters of the waterfall or dip their bodies inside the lake, bare, soles pressing, breasts kissing. Catra floats over the waters in Adora´s arms and blinks around the spots of golden light all around her, trusting neither of them will drown and kissing the spot on Adora´s mouth when they dip their head below the surface of the water and everything that can be heard around them is the murmur of the earth and their own hearts.

They eat, feast, every night and every day. The altar cracks in golden and turquoise fire, the meat burns in the pyre and the juice of fruit drips off their lips and into each other tongues. The lay as long as they are over each other's laps and speak while they eat, not caring if they make a mess of each other´s or their clothes, too in love with this life to care above the taste of food on their tongues and the touch of their fingers on each other´s mouths.

They dance, every single sunset, every single night. They hold each other's hands and follow old steps taught to Adora and then new ones created only between the both of them. Catra almost never trips by now and when she does Adora catches her. They hear the music of the flute and the lyre and the coins and they dance until they are breathless.

They make love to each other, voluptuous, fleshy, rich. They worship each other's bodies for long days and slow nights, meeting each other, learning from each other all over again.

Adora transforms Catra´s breasts inside her mouth, around her teeth, in the shape of her tongue. She carries them and on her lips they become full, soft, chaste and at the same time infinitely sensual, Adora lives a thousand lives in them.

And when they are loved and warm, Adora lives a thousand lives more between her legs, between her limbs, inside her womb. She learns about her heat, about her hunger, about the

sparks in her eyes and the holiness of her skin. About her need, her want, her longing. The lengths of her waiting.

She enters her with her fingers and her tongue and her very flesh. She makes a home underneath her skin and breathes on her bones. Looks at her full moon eyes and the way she is provocative with her whimpers and her mouth, tempting Adora beyond reason and as she devours her whole until they are one and the same, matching lights over fresh moss, rocking bodies over the bed.

Until Catra gasps and trembles and comes undone on Adora´s mouth and tongue and fingers. Wet. Delicious. Arousing.

Until all Adora knows is her face pressed against the skin of Catra´s belly. Until all she feels are Catra´s fingers painting circles on her head. Until Adora is the one being devoured back, from the inside out.

This is their life, for five years this is their life, as lives are supposed to be. Eat, bathe, love. Smile on each other's mouths. Wave in the loom and sing with the lyre and feel the sun on their skins. Infinite.

Adora thought the isolation would make them mad but it just makes them full. Without war, without battle, without men around them.

They know nothing about the dry crops or the cracking earth, about the tumultuous sea and the poisoned rivers. About the dying cattle or the scarce fruits; the way hunger devours the world quicker than violence and the way the absence of spring and sun would condemn this universe fully in the blink of an eye.

They know nothing about the spilled blood or the corpses piled over each other, first from innocents and then from the rotten souls trying to steal their lands and their lives away for the faux belief of a divine right.

They know nothing about battles and battles and then about mutiny, about the lack of faith from already rotten men when they lose yet again and this time they turn their eyes towards their cowardly leader, realizing maybe for the first time that he was not a god to begin with. Thinking, not for the first time, that the favor of his father has grown as dry as the waters and that he has no choice anymore but to run.

They know nothing about it.

And for five years not a single person dares to enter their domains, not since that night. So long that for a second Adora thinks that the world might have as well burnt down everywhere except here, where the sun and even the rain are warm, and the green gives the food and the leaves give them water.

So long that what they do know is the green of grass and the golden of errands crops. What they do know are the three trees and their birth of a fourth and a fifth one, a gift for every year they have adored each other without restraints. They know the tall branches and the

hidden spots on the crowns where blue and yellow and red coated birds live, singing to them good morning and good night.

What they do know is the waterfall and the lake, clean waters that come from sacred places and that bathes them anew. They know the rain that fills them all over again, fresh and never cold, splashing over their faces and filling their mouths with sweet waters to drink from.

They know the feeling of the damp mud on their toes and fingers; the softness of the moss against their skins; the touch of the grass covered in dew against their faces when they lay flat over them and hear nothing but the other´s voice and the gentle run of the breeze through the green and blue stems.

They know about altars without the strings of unbendable devotion. They know about trust in something that is not only each other. Catra whispers about hopes and desires and Adora learns about Faith. She learns about faith in the way of colorful fires and flowers burning down and the hands of her wife tending to the golden ashes like the Priestess of their own kind of religion.

Adora knows how to trust in *them* again, even if quietly, even if deep within her chest. Even if all her prayers are still silent and still her own, hoping they are enough to reach them and at the same time not caring if they do. Like someone who adores the heavens but that lives her life without fear of not getting to ever touch it.

Adora knows about prophecies and she knows about time and at the same time all she wants to know is about the floors of the temple and the tiny flowers that grow everywhere where Catra stands.

She knows what makes Catra laugh, what makes her giggle and smile, and knows what makes her smile too. She knows about her anger and her fury, her need for justice rooted inside her chest like the sword of a hero heard only in the most incredible of stories. She knows what makes her cry.

Adora knows about her voice when she is singing, beautiful as a nightingale inside the circle of Adora´s arms. When she is annoyed or when she is excited, fluttering her hands around her face as she tells the wildest of stories on their bedrest.

She knows all the nickers and tricks in her body and her soul, the kind that Adora sometimes thinks Catra doesn´t even know of herself. The way her eyes wrinkle when she is truly happy; the flutter of her nose when she is focusing very intently on her loom; the twitch of her mouth when she is irritated and doesn´t want to say it.

The ways in which she still tries to hide her pain and all the small ways in which she cares for Adora´ s own ache in return. The movement of her ears and her tail and the goosebumps of her skin.

All the little ways in which she is beautiful and smart; the ways in which she listens to Adora talk, in which she learns the things that excite her too, the things she was passionate about and that she still adores. She learns the movement of the planets off Adora´s mouth and the name of the constellations she is still blind to.

She learns the theory of the ellipses and the push and pull of the universe all around them, so deeply dug into everything they are and they own, so deeply similar to the threads of life and the wheels of time. She learns them.

Catra learns Adora´s drawings, the ones of temples and libraries that only exist in her imagination, built over marble and around grass, tall towards the sky as if their domes would somehow be able to cradle the sun inside their elliptic palms. She learns them in the way Adora learns the braille of her tunics and paintings, in the way they communicate with each other sometimes without words.

Catra learns about Adora´s dreams and hopes outside this cave, past these walls. Learns in whispers about her hopes for a free world, a green one. One where eternal spring does not exist as it would be too beautiful to bear, but where the seasons run like the threads of a life. Where people have a choice and a voice, where they are allowed a chance to live their lives as they are doing right now.

A world that once was the home of her brother and now is the shelter of her niece. A world, not a kingdom, where they get to breathe fresh air and dip their toes in clean waters. Where women bear children or bows or paintings or anything they want at all and they are safe to do so.

Where the breeze caresses on their ankles and on the hems of their tunics and their navels are still safe. A world she dreamed of when she was young and her dreams were full of Catra and of the sun.

A world where Adora wishes she had lived and which she hopes she could give to Catra fully. A world where there could be wives, and lovers. Maybe even something a little bit more

“You're thinking very loudly today.” Catra whispers, nuzzling in the feather pillows.

Unlike their quiet dawns, their nights are much louder.

The cavern adorns itself with the light of the fireflies dancing over the damp grass and around the flames of the oil lamps scattered in every single corner of the natural formation, their light reflecting over the myriad of colorful crystals hanging around until there is not a single crevice where the light does not reach and the shadows are casted away, even at night.

The cicadas and crickets sing especially loud at night and all of the birds come back to their nests on the crown of the trees. Lately too they have caught squirrels and rabbits wandering around the garden, making their ways through the open domes and the thick trunks to eat a little of the greenery and the fruit scattered on their lands.

It´s like a little promise, that if life can exist down here so it can outside.

Sometimes, most nights, Adora plays the lyre for Catra and Catra sings in return. They´ve got quite good at it too, like true performers of musical arts.

The callousness of Adora´s hands are now deeper from the lyre than from the sword and the bow. It´s a good change, a welcomed one. Adora sometimes watches at her own hands and smiles at them.

Tonight though they lay over the sheets of their marital bed earlier than usual, lingering their bodies over feathers and silks and each other´s warmths where they slide bare against each other. The touch of their naked bodies, even in chastity, is needed for them, like breathing. Something familiar Catra and Adora hold onto, when the nights fall deeply blue and lilac over them and they know nothing but each other and their secret spot on the world where they can love the other.

Adora smiles at Catra´s words, pressing an apologetic kiss over Catra´s exposed belly. “Sorry”

Catra hums. running her fingers across Adora´s forehead. Under the night light, her eyes look bright as pools of liquid silver. “What´s got you so worked up?”

Adora drags her lips over the shivering skin of Catra´s belly, worshipping her with mouth and lips in there, painting celestial maps on her hips. She wraps her big hands around Catra´s waist, against the curve of her hip and the place between her bellybutton and the soft happy trail below, learning her moles and freckles and faint white lines all over again, guarding the sight of them inside her eyes and her heart.

She imagines for a second what it would be, how it would look like, to be able to give Catra a normal life, a normal home, a normal family.

To see her in a different place than these undergrounds, as beautiful as they are, when the sky surrounds them everywhere without the inference stone walls. A place where Catra could sail the seas and Adora could study the skies, still holding each other's hands. A place where she could see her like these on their bed with her freckled skin stretched around the weight of their baby and her face tanned by the sun on her skin.

She also imagines herself, sometimes, in nights where she allows herself the selfishness of desire for another life. She imagines herself dressed in the clear clothes of the maternity chambers of the palace, sitting in front of Catra´s beautiful and excited face as she rests her hands over the curve of Adora´s own growing belly. Having the gift of being able to choose to bear them or not, knowing she would love them regardless of their origin.

Those are things Adora cannot have, things she was never allowed to have. Those are things that sometimes make her feel angry with herself and then sad and ashamed, because she should be grateful for what she has right now and she is, but sometimes she cannot help herself but to desire.

Things she should not speak for the fear of cursing them, of staining them with her own shame and smearing them in Catra´s hands.

But then again, this is *Catra* after all. And Catra is the most stubborn being Adora had ever known. Especially about everything Adora is.

“I´ve been thinking, about our baby.” Adora confesses in a whisper, because one thing she is unable to do now is lie to her wife. “It´s dumb, but I´ve been thinking a lot about that lately”

Above her head, over red and purple pillows, Catra exhales, her beautiful cheeks scattering in red flush that makes her silver eyes look even more tender than before.

“I see,” Catra murmurs, full of wonder too. She finds Adora´s hands sitting around her hips and joins their fingers together, smiling when she feels Adora´s cheek resting against her hip bone. “What have you been thinking about?”

“I´ve been thinking if they would have your hands,” Adora continues, because Catra has asked and she needs it too. “And your nose. Your ears too, and your freckles. I´ve been thinking if she would have the mole in my chin that Adam and I shared. I´ve been thinking of them, newborn in your arms.”

It should be natural, a thought like this. A natural progression of their lives. They have loved each other for so long and have been together and married for equally as much. These are the kind of questions they would have had, no? In another life.

“I´ve been thinking I´m dumb because we cannot, no matter what. I cannot carry them and I would not ask you to.” Adora closes her eyes, breathing in Catra´s scent and feeling her hands around her face. “But I can´t stop thinking, *what if?”*

There is silence for a moment and then Catra is moving again. She stretches on the bed and lets her legs fall slightly more open, pulling from Adora´s face at the same time, slowly but steadily bringing her body towards her own.

“Come here.” Catra calls, breathing deep through her nose when she feels the brush of Adora ´s thighs against her knees and the secret kiss of the olisbo gently meeting the damp lips of her entrance..“Come, my love”

Catra caresses Adora´s cheeks, her eyes open and her face deeply in love, and softly guides Adora inside, guiding Adora´s thrusts inside of her womb with the tandem of her hips.

“I would” Catra whispers, hiccuping with pleasure against Adora´s dew warm mouth. “I would carry them for us, for her. She would be ours.”

Adora gasps and kisses Catra´s cheek, feeling the heartbeat of her soft walls all around her, in and out and inside again, a night dance that between them is holy, Catra wraps her arms around Adora´s soft and strong back and Adora holds her in return, burying her face on the crook of neck and letting herself be guided by the happiness and hope in her voice.

Catra sighs around a thrust that makes her arch her back off the bed and opens her eyes, gazing at their world with sightless moon eyes. “I would love her with all my heart because she would be a part of you”

Adora holds her breath, her eyes opening too. As Catra´s they are also bright in the middle of the night, golden like the sun and too beautiful to gaze upon without burning down. She has

met her own eyes on the reflection of the waterfall and cried at them, plead them, begged them for a chance, just one, just one more opportunity of doing it right.

“And if they were like me?” Adora asks, unable still to not press her eyes painfully shut when serpents curl around her forehead instead of golden strands mingling with Catra´s.

“I would love them all the same, the same as I love you. Maybe even a little bit more.” Catra says, as she has done many, many times before, letting Adora know how much she is loved. “What if they were to be born blind? What if they were to be disabled, like me? Would you not love them?”

Adora shakes her head hard at Catra´s words, holding her even tighter, stronger, her hips moving Catra´s and delicious touch, their fingertips brushing against each other's shoulders and their mouths painting flowers over the other´s skin. They have known each other for so long and for so little still, body and soul, and yet still feels like the first time all over again.

“Catra you are beautiful. All about you.” Adora narrows her eyes around tears, her nose touching Catra´s pulse point at the same time her hands travel down, pressing them flat over Catra´s belly where she feels it soft and warm under her palms. “If they were to be blind I would adore them deeply, just the same”

“See? I would love them and you would love them in return.” Catra hiccups, her knees brushing Adora´s ribs with each movement, her fingertips painting invisible swirls over the divots of her waist. “That's enough”

Adora shivers, mirroring the tremble of Catra´s legs and her abdomen, holding her dear and gentle inside her arms and against her chest as they both strip vulnerable and open around each other.

Catra hiccups and whimpers, her expression suddenly shifting to something drowned in longing, in the small start of a spark that might ignite a whole fire. She is suddenly thinking too, just as Adora, overwhelmed by hope and by desire.

“Adora—”

“We can´t”

“But we have made a home.” Catra closes her eyes, her jaw growing slack where Adora presses kisses against the corners of her mouth.

“And still, I could not condemn them here for eternity. They deserve more, like you do.” Adora hiccups too, gasping and humming, the sound of their voices and bodies making their own kind of music, slick instead of lyre and moan instead of song. “You have already chosen this, for me, because of me. I cannot ask for more. *You* is what is enough to me”

“And still. I would do it.” Catra holds her breath, tilting in the very edge, stubborn as ever and brave. “And even if we never can, even if they can't never exist, I would do it all, exactly the same just so I could be with you. Exactly as it was just so I could find you, outside or here, it doesn't matter to me.”

Adora presses her damp mouth over Catra´s lilac eyelids and runs her hands beneath the soft base of her ears, tears slipping down her face when Catra´s trembling yet always warm hands cradle her jaw inside her palms, keeping Adora close.

“Really?” Adora asks because after so long she still needs to. “Even after everything I've made you sacrifice?”

“Adora, there is no sacrifice between us. It's just you, it's just me.” Catra whispers, undoing herself inside Adora´s arms, holding her against her chest when Adora trips and also falls. “The rest are choices, made with love. I chose to be with you.”

Adora gasps and trembles inside Catra´s palms, kissing the inside of her wrists and her cheeks, smiling when Catra paints a trail of kisses across the column of her neck and the bodies of the serpents holding themselves to her, loving every single inch of Adora´s body no matter how it is.

“And I chose you in return,” Adora smiles, watching as the petals of the yellow wisterias hanging over their heads saunter down over Catra´s long hair, coloring in goldens for Adora to see. Small mercies. “The rest are flowers”

Catra grins, wrapping Adora inside veils and her arms. Adora still carries the weight of the world, but Catra carries her heart.

“The rest are flowers”

Time is a gentle thing. It runs slow through the course of years. Yet again, it suddenly runs too fast.

Their cavern has also changed with the years, as they have.

Most of it has been by their hand, by Catra´s hand, and Adora´s, held right behind. The cold and void stone walls have been adorned everywhere with tapestries and long fabrics embroidered with beautiful swirls and crystal beads. There are pillows on the floor, colorful and many of them, each one making the floor safe to sit down and rest or long their bodies under the sunlight.

The errand roots dug on the tallest part of the walls have been hung with windchimes and pretty ribbons through which the birds sometimes decide to make their nests. The grass and the moss scatters the ground and with it so do the stone paths, long ago done, long ago well loved, gentle underneath their soles where Catra and Adora wander.

The lake is just as it has always been yet it has also changed, grown in a way. There are flat and big stones, of a light blue and white after being licked by the calm waters for years to come. Smooth pieces of the broken columns that once used to surround the perfect circle of the lake, hung with clean cloths and used as seats for both of them when they were to swim, bathe or simply sit to rest as they made each other company.

Lotus flowers have grown inside the waters and with them green leaves and petals are always stuck to their heads and feet when they walk outside the waters. The flowers travel all the way towards the waterfall and then towards their secret garden, where Adora has learnt the fields from Catra´s hand and the crops in the autumn. Where she has dug river paths to feed them with water and collected their ripe fruits on the wrinkles of her skirt that feeds them both into something healthy.

The nook where their looms rest is dry and clean, together. They rest back to back on a spot of the cavern where the sun does not hit too strong and the shadows are always the perfect kind of warm. It´s always a little bit messy and always well loved, baskets filled with threads placed everywhere on the ground alongside more feathered pillows and loose pieces of strand stuck to the wood legs of the looms.

Adora´s is empty for now as she has enjoyed her days laying on the pillows by Catra´s feet and playing the lyre for her as Catra weaves, focused and perfectly as always.

Adora gazes through drowsy eyelashes as Catra weaves above her head, her hands running through the soft threads in known motions, practiced, a second nature by now after weaving for almost her entire life. She pushes and threads and knots and never cuts, moving the heavy pieces of wood with no effort at all and counting the endless movements under her breath, somehow still remembering which ones are different from the others.

The fabric in the loom is beautiful, neither white nor yellow either but a gentle middle, rimmed by golden threads and then a dozen others more colorful ones. Adora has been watching her weaving for the last twenty days, gazed full of wonder as the blues, pinks and lilacs mingled together; as the golden, whites and sage greens became one; as the shapes took form and with them Catra´s sight, beyond her blindness and her white eyes, her true sight, created from the lights and the shadows and her own memories.

A piece of art and of comfort so beautiful that it makes Adora tear up every single time she sees it growing, that brings tears to the corners of her golden eyes that fall across her cheeks and damp her face.

They are not sad, those kinds of tears. Not when they are born from something beautiful born from Catra´s hands. In fact they are a gift, just like the tapestry in the loom, a gift promised to Adora the moment it's finally finished. One with which she can wrap her shoulders and keep herself warm.

One light enough to cover her head if that's what she wishes, and long enough to brush past her shins and brush her ankles. A kind that can be both a hemation and a veil and a tapestry.

One that reminds Adora to the ones once hung in her bedroom in the old palace that she once called a home. A place where the air was also warm and the sun was also golden before it was drowned by green and by crimson. A place unstained by other´s hands as it was hers once, and she surrounded herself by the beauty of the tapestries brought to her from Menagerie without knowing that they were done by the love of her life, protecting her and wrapping herself around Adora without even realizing it, much before they were to find each other.

Adora looks at it and smiles, feeling warmth spreading from the middle of her chest to the chest of her body. Her eyes get distracted from the loom, following instead the thing and elegant fingers wrapped in colorful threads and the gentle wrist that follows it. Forearms and elbow and shoulder, the dark skin adorned by gold powder and sun paintings, flower shaped bracelets and bangles on her wrists and dainty rings on her fingers, adorned like a queen herself in front of Adora´s eyes.

The white of her tunic is so pure that she almost looks cradled by dove wings, a spot of sun against the red of Adora´s dress. And in the moss covered ground, both of their feet are bare and painted in maroon inks from the ankle to the sole, leaving their footprints on the stone paths where they accidentally walked without walking for long enough for it to dry.

Adora sighs, taking in the sight of her wife fully, every single second, every single inch. Her warm skin washed by the midday sun and the shape of her button nose. The sharp edge of her silver eyes and the cluster of freckles on her cheeks. The flutter of her soft ears and the heart shape of her closed mouth, stretching into a smile when she realizes Adora has gone distracted once again by the way the lyre remains quiet somewhere next to her.

Adora extends her hand and wraps her fingers around the ends on Catra´s long braid, watching as they brush against the grass and very, very carefully picking them up and resting them over the pillows instead.

“You owe me a story, you know?” Adora whispers, smiling at nothing when she hears Catra´s slightly surprised sigh, her tail giving her away as she has also gotten distracted by Adora´s presence all around her.

“Uh?” Catra tilts her head down so Adora can see her, cheeks red. After so many years Adora should have grown accustomed to the sight of her flush but she has found out that she has not. In fact, every day she loves it a little bit more.

“Years ago, you told me you would tell me a thousand and one stories.” Adora whispers, her voice slightly sore after remaining quiet for a few hours. It's alright though, she knows silence doesn't scare Catra anymore. “You´ve told me a thousand, I've counted them. So you owe me one”

“Oh.” Catra blinks, her frown, wrinkled with confusion, relaxing and raising on her forehead. She giggles, her face bright as the sun hanging behind her. “You are so silly”

“I want to know,” Adora pleads, pulling gently from Catra´s braid. Catra sighs deeply in a motion that tries to be frustrated and only manages to be endearing and lowers her hands from the loom, leaving the tapestry half done, colorful threads falling over the grass.

“Alright, princess.” Catra stretches her hand, patiently waiting for Adora to take her fingers. “Help me out.”

Adora smiles and sits straighter over the plush pillows, taking Catra´s hands fully into hers and helping her out of the small bench of the loom and into the warm nook on the ground. They struggle just a little bit, their feet catching around each other and the throw blankets until they finally find their way in each other's arms.

Catra sits over soft grounds and blankets, her back resting slightly leaned against one too many pillows, almost burying her on their colorful softness. Her legs are stretched in front of her, hips just slightly bent to the side as she welcomes Adora´s head over her lap.

She cradles her inside her palms and against her belly, laughing when the serpents grow excited too and start making their cheeky trips across her arms and knees, seeking to latch into her any way possible and never let her go.

Like this Adora is still looking up to her yet closer, just enough to feel Catra´s warm breath against her cheeks, sweet like honey and red lips like the pomegranates and figs they shared this morning.

It´s not a special kind of day. It´s a mundane day, a calm day.

“Let´s see.” Catra thinks out loud, narrowing her eyes as she tries to gather her thoughts. “Time is a curious thing for souls in love”

Adora smiles, familiar by now with the way Catra starts every single one of her poems. Catra starts running her fingertips across the bridge of Adora´s nose, from the tip to the middle of her forehead, familiar motions that threaten to lull them both into sleep if they are not careful.

“There was once a Princess who was a little bit dumb.” Catra continues, pinching Adora´s nose when she gasps, amused and not once offended.

“Hey”

“She was a little bit dumb because she had a kind heart that she wore like a bracelet around her wrists.” Catra ignores her, feeling Adora´s fluttering breath against her fingertips. “She was good and gentle with her people. And she was so, so smart. So smart that she would have been the best scientist of her generation. So sweet she would have been a tender mother.”

Adora holds her breath, suddenly overwhelmed. Catra feels her immediately, wrapping her fingers around Adora´s and bringing her close, pressing a kiss with every single one of her knuckles slowly and gently until she feels the shadow of Adora´s tension slowly drift away.

“She was good,” Catra repeats, closing her eyes and resting her cheek over the back of Adora ´s hands. “And she was beautiful. All those things that made her a woman, a wonderful one. Sweet and brave and smart. And still, a little bit dumb.”

“What happened to her?” Adora asks, suddenly urgent. She curls inside herself but Catra catches her before she drifts away, soothing her apprehension with loving fingers.

“She was betrayed,” Catra whispers, apologetic when she speaks the truth because it is a part of the story, of her story, and forgetting it would mean in a way forget a part of herself. “She trusted her people and she was betrayed by greed. It was not her fault”

“And if it was?”

“It was not.” Catra deadpans, firm as the trees and steady as water. “Trust has never been a sin. The kingdom´s decisions were their own, as it was her parents´s and even the gods.” Catra´s breath shivers, her eyes fluttering closed. “If anything, it just made her even more beautiful. It takes a special kind of beauty to remain kind and gentle when life has betrayed you that way. A beauty different to a face or hair.”

Adora sniffs. wrinkling her nose at the stream of tears falling down her face. Catra catches them all, one by one, kissing them away with her sweet lips. Her tail wraps around Adora´s knee and the serpents wrap around her arms in return, locking them together.

“Keep going.” Adora begs, still with her eyes closed.

“She was casted away. And she was alone for a very, very long time. It made her feel lost and it made her feel sad.” Catra´s breath catches on her throat, giving away just how deeply she feels for Adora. “But I think she forgets something, sometimes”

“What?”

“That she was always loved.” Catra wrinkles her nose and Adora is in love with her all over again. “All the time, through it all. She was loved. Her brother loved her more than anything, I think he was always there, right next to her heart. I think in a way that love also protected her.”

Adora whimpers but Catra doesn´t let go of her hand. In fact she holds her even closer, pressing their palms together and tangling their fingers with each other. It's nice, the contrast, dark skin against sun tanned one, like the sun meeting another kind of star.

“I think it did.” Adora whispers, her voice clogged on her throat where her emotions get the better of her. “Talk to me, please”

“There was a woman hidden on the corners of a cave.” Catra speaks, her silver eyes meeting Adora´s golden ones. “The walls were cold, the ceiling dripping with water, the corners scattered in quartz. A woman curled up on the floor, knees pressed to the chest, arms around her face. She thought she was a monster but she was an angel, with her wings in the shape of serpents.”

Adora surges forward and Catra is already waiting for her, wrapping her arms around Adora´s waist when Adora hugs her fully. Adora leans her face against Catra´s pulse point and her hands against the small of her back, breathing the lemongrass from her skin.

“She thought she would be alone forever. But as I said before, she was a little bit dumb.” Catra chuckles under her breath, right next to Adora´s ear, kissing the back of her neck. “And she had the good luck that the most stubborn brat on earth wandered inside her cave too.” Catra exhales and when she does Adora can feel the stream of her tears down her skin. “She was also a little bit sad and so, so lost.”

Adora leans back, just enough so she can circle Catra´s face inside her palms, brushing the tears off her cheekbones with her thumbs. She gazes at her beautiful face under the sun, marveled at her growth and how she is still so young, how both of them are.

“And then?” Adora asks, smiling when Catra does too.

“Then they fell in love”

They kiss under sunlight, very much like the very first time. Adora exhales on Catra´s lips and Catra sighs, kissing her back with all the knowledge about her body and all the love inside her heart. They wrap each other inside their arms and hold flush over soft ground and green walls, a green of life.

Catra tilts her head slightly to the side and guides Adora´s back towards her, closer, giggling when the serpents kiss they way all over her face. Adora rests her palms over Catra´s shoulders and hums inside the kiss, her legs bent to the side while her body rests almost completely against Catra´s hands and chest. That's alright though, she knows Catra will hold her.

They kiss each other because they are married, they are partners, they are wives. They kiss each other because they are lovers, knowing each other´s skin. They kiss each other because they are best friends, holding the other's hearts. They kiss because they are each other's hearts and half of their souls and they are in love, Adora is in love.

She was in love so she forgot she had been cursed. Not by goddess or by a god. But by a man.

A crack calls Adora´s attention, ripping her off from Catra´s embrace. She leans back from their kiss and tilts her head to the side, staring at the entrance of the cavern, covered with soft tapestries to keep the cold air from the cave to slip inside.

Another crack echoes past the entrance, very soft, almost not there at all, but it makes Adora frown, her heartbeat picking up inside her chest for some reason she cannot yet to determine.

Catra notices Adora´s change of demeanor more than she notices the noise, too enveloped in everything that Adora is and their kisses. She starts running her fingers through the shell of Adora´s ears, kissing her cheek softly.

“Are you alright?”

“What was that noise?” Adora asks instead, narrowing her eyes when another tiny crack makes it inside.

This time Catra does notice. Her ears twitch gently at the sides and then lift high on her head, catching the crack, crack, *cracks* at the same time that Adora starts standing up from her place inside Catra´s arms.

“Another doe?” Catra offers, her arms slipping from Adora´s limbs and falling sadly over the ground, wrapping them around herself in an attempt to chase a sudden cold that has nothing to do with the clouds covering the sun above their heads.

“I—” Adora´s breath hitches on her throat, every single muscle in her body tightening and locking as if she was about to start running. “I don't think so”

Crack

Adora gives a step forward, past soft blankets and gentle moss and into the stone paths that lead towards the cave. She is suddenly very, very quiet, a silence different to the ones that they have become accustomed to in the last years.

“Dora?” Catra starts standing up too, her white as a dove tunic falling heavy over her bare feet and her face scrunched up in barely contained worry.

Adora gazes at her beloved face out of the corner of her eyes and then looks away, pressing her mouth firmly into a line. “Stay here”

“Yeah, right.” Catra chuckles, stepping in the stone path too, right next to Adora. “I´m coming with you”

“Catra,” Adora mumbles between clenched teeth but Catra just shakes her head hard, crossing her arms over her chest.

The blue Herculean Knot wrapped around her waist makes the tiny coins of her belt to jingle against each other softly, creating a sound that once allowed Catra to know where Adora was and now is a gentle reminder of their life together.

“What if it's someone? Like that time?” Both of them have dropped their voices into a whisper, heated as they face each other in front of the entrance.

Adora sighs, mildly exasperated as she throws swift looks between the entrance and Catra´s face, urgent. “That's why I need you here”

“ *That's* why I need to go with you.” Catra cuts her dryly, turning her back to Adora as she searches for the wooden rack they keep next to the entrance, where a few collected weapons lay just in case.

Like this Adora can see the expansion of Catra´s bare back, the constellations of freckles interrupted by the ragged scar that the arrow left behind a little over five years ago now. Most of the time Adora will kiss it better and worship the raised and pale skin with her hands and lips, but it will always be a permanent reminder of what can happen.

“You are so—” Adora starts but it´s unable to keep going, her urgency to make sure everything is safe and her need to keep Catra close colliding in the middle.

“Stubborn? Yeah.” Catra giggles, handing a slim sword to Adora, holding in her other hand a small knife with a golden handle and moonstone in the blade. Adora takes the sword absently, still looking into Catra´s whitened eyes. “Come on then.”

They hold the hands that are not carrying the weapons and approach the entrance together. Adora guides them both down, squatting in the ground instead of standing up in plain sight, as she pushes the heavy tapestries to the side.

The smell is the first thing that hits them, not that the fabrics are not there to keep it contained. It crashes against Adora´s and Catra´s faces with a vicious stench, extending the

gray and black claws of smoke right after.

“Ugh.” Adora wrinkles her nose, snapping her face to the side subconsciously.

Next to her Catra´s face wrinkles in disgust, her hand letting go from Adora´s to come up and wrap around her nose, fighting not to gag. “What's that smell?”

The heat comes second but Adora feels it more sooner than Catra. Is like standing way to close in front of the oil lamps or the pyre of the altar, so close that the serpents around her head curl and hiss in discomfort, immediately feeling the threat of fire way too close.

When Adora snaps her head back towards the cavern she finally notices the red and oranges and green shadows of fire mirroring their ways against the dark stone, a told tale of the flames that make their origin and of the raging fire eating its way inside the cavern barely a few feet away from their home.

“Adora?” Catra is calling for her, the dark skin of her forehead gathering with the first beads of sweat dripping down her temples.

“It´s fire.” Adora answers absently, not looking at her yet already missing the gaze of her clear eyes on hers. “The cave is burning up”

The people of Menagerie burnt Catra´s home to the ground. Adora knows this because Catra told her, many years ago in the solitude of their barely forming home.

She told her about the unbearable warmth of the fire against her skin, so different from the sunlight or the oil lamps. She told her about the scent of the fire, like rotten eggs and lighting against wood. Told her about the feeling of ashes against the skin and how, even weeks after arriving here and no matter how much she dipped inside the waters of the lake, it took Catra many, many months to feel the touch of the ashes had completely left her body.

“What?” Even now Adora can hear the slight tremor inside Catra´s voice. The way that the mention of fire, so close again, makes her body lock down and her mind come to a stop, chased by memories like Adora´s still do for her.

Adora gulps heavily, staring at the beautiful face of her wife, her best friend and the love of her life, before daring to look away again, towards the corridor threatening like the open fauces of a beast about to devour them both whole.

Adora runs her thumb over Catra´s knuckles and holds her breath, searing the memory of Catra´s eyes inside her mind. “Stay here.”

Adora does not wait for Catra to answer or to react to her words. She leans on her ankles and jumps swiftly the distance between the floor and the corridor, slipping inside with one smooth movement, sword still firmly grasped inside her hand.

“Wait, no! Adora, wait for me!”

Catra gasps behind her, her body moving sharp and quick yet too slow to stop Adora. She wraps her fingers loosely against anything that she can reach from Adora, which is the hem

of her own red tunic, but Adora is already slipping away from her, falling through Catra´s fingers like sand.

Adora fights against her own instincts and refuses to look back at Catra, walking with firm steps across the damp corridor.

In here, away from the gentleness of her cavern, everything is clogged up and overwhelming, the heat of the fire turning the stone corridor into a copper bull placed right above the flames, making Adora sweat and her clothes to stick to her back and front.

The serpents have gone slightly mad above her head, curling and biting at each other sharply, digging their fangs inside each other and sizzling with anger and fear as they curl right back down, flush against Adora´s neck when she finally steps inside the burning cave.

Fire meets her immediately, but not as close as she thought it would be. The green flames lick their way across the bent roots and wide thorns of the entrance of the cave, the one that leads towards the outside. It's violent and sharp, snapping flames against the wood and covering the narrow exit from the ground to the very ceiling of the cave.

Water is dripping off the quartz roof and evaporating at the same time as it meets the stone below, the grass and moss quickly eaten away into dark ashes where the flames start spreading long and uncontrollable across every single corner and inch, uncaring of what it eats on its way.

Even the crumbling statues of the dead murderers are being devoured by the fire, gray rock set into violent red flames that reaches the very top of the cave, making already fragile rock to break down into rubble and dirt over the darkened ground.

Adora gasps and it is an immediate mistake because she breathes a deep mouthful of smoke instead of fresh air. The dark smoke burns her immediately, overwhelming her chest, constricting her lungs, and tickling on her throat like a thousand red ants eating their way on her very flesh.

Adora starts coughing uncontrollably, her palm pressed flat against her chest as she tries to clear her lungs and all she manages is to breathe even more of the hot air all around her. It clogs her throat and starts making her dizzy immediately, clouding her thoughts and her eyes with both the smells and the heavy air all around her.

Pieces of stone engulfed in flames have started to fall down towards the ground, sauntering like heavy arrows and burning the soft moss below into nothing but darkness the moment they touch. Adora stares at them as tears start to roll down her eyes, violently and one after another, covering her both in sweat and tears as she stumbles dangerously to the side.

“Fuck,” Adora sputters, gasping for air. “Fuck”

She is trying to see, now more than ever she is trying to see and she doesn´t seem to be able to. Adora presses the heel of her palm hard against her eyes and wipes the tears harshly away, fighting the smoke and herself as she tries to gaze around her, past the raging fire and towards the clear sound of soft steps that she can now hear echoing somewhere in front of her.

“Who 's there?” Adora exclaims, dissolving into a fit of coughs right after. “Are you insane? Get the fuck out!”

The steps stop, hesitate, becoming unnervingly quiet suddenly. Adora holds her breath inside her chest, pressing her palm against her nose as she gives an unconscious step back.

She cannot go to the cavern, no matter how much she wants to. She cannot risk guiding whoever is here towards her home, if there is someone here at all. Maybe Adora has gone crazy, now after everything. Maybe she has lost her mind finally and all the echoes of steps, all the drowned down pants she thinks she is hearing are nothing but her own, coming back for her after so many years of peace.

Maybe it's the gods. Maybe they have found their way down the earth and towards Adora´s exile, set the way in and out on fire, tired of her existence. Maybe they have decided now it´s the time for Adora to become a sacrifice herself, all on her own. Coming down to extend their claws towards her and squeeze her heart out of her chest.

Another set of steps moves and maybe Adora is not crazy at all.

“You are going to burn to death! Get! Out!”

Maybe this is the turn of the wheel, spinning over and over again over her head, pulling from the thread of her life. The moment, the time, the bare second where Adora was destined to fall, many, many years ago. So long that she almost forgot it completely, yet remaining in the back of her head for just enough to echo inside her head when the moment comes again.

Is this really my fate?

“Hey!” Adora snaps, feeling herself eleven years younger and as scared as before. “Answer me!”

No voice comes but there is light. White, blinding like the fall of a lightning against the ground, different to the pearl-like of Catra´s eyes. A thousand times shinier, a thousand times more painful.

The reflection of the flames against a polished surface, like a mirror but made of solid gold, falling against Adora´s eyes and making her blind for the split of a second, just enough for the entire course of her life to come to a halt. Or maybe, to kick it back alive all over again.

“Adora,” she hears the whisper of her name but it's not Catra´s, never Catra´s. Not like this, obscure and profand. Not like this, poisonous. “Adora”

When Adora opens her eyes again around the blinding light she finds her own eyes staring right back at her, right there at the reach of her hand. Reflected on the golden surface of the shield in front of her.

Then comes the sword and with it the blood against the ground.

“AH!”

Adora feels the blade against the side of her ribs, cutting swift and deep enough to make her blood run fresh down the side of her body. It pools quickly and soaks the fabric of her red dress into something deeper, almost black.

The pain comes right after, searing and as violent as the flames still choking her out, burning her from the inside out as Adora trips and falls into her knees, dizzy by the horrid pain and the flames of white suffering exploding on every single nerve of her body until there is nothing that Adora can feel but the gaping wound and her own blood seeping through her fingers.

Adora has bled before, many times and in this place too, by the hand of heroes and lost souls. But never like this,never cowardly, from the back, never hunted like a prey whose hunter knows her a little bit too well. Never so well planned, never poisonous, the blade soaked in a venom that won´t kill her but that dries her weak like a dying star the moment it runs inside her bloodstream.

Adora gasps against the dry floor, her mouth falling into a silent scream as she tries and tries to think, to move, to do anything but lay here on her palms and knees over the ground, bleeding and alone.

Except, she is not alone. Not at all. Out of the corner of her eyes, soaked with unstoppable tears, she sees the rim of a golden sandal standing right behind her, securely behind her head and back yet hovering, like a shadow, like an omen, like a never ending prophecy chasing her to the very depth of earth. Her shelter, her home, defiled once again by his presence, by his breath.

He is here, right here, right back for her after so many years. He is here, Adora can see the rim of his green tunic and the white of his hands. He is here and Adora is twenty years old and kneeling on the cold floor of the palace all over again.

“Hello,Adora.” Prime smiles, the mirror of his smile clear against the shield dug on the ground. “Dear, dear Adora. It's been such a long time”

No, no, no, no. No.

Tell me. Tell me what you see

Adora recoils over herself, snapping her eyes away from the shield, digging her fingers over soft ground and bringing it towards her as she crawls on her belly and hands to drift away, *away.*

She cannot think, she cannot breath, she cannot move. She is surrounded by fire and smoke and she is bleeding to the ground. She is holding the shred of her tunic against her chest and looking away, still seeking to look away from him no matter the power or doom of her curse because that's who she is. Kind instead of rageful.

She cannot even take a second to wonder to herself how he is still alive, how he has found out he can gaze at her from the golden mirror and keep breathing, safe from the curse. She is too drowned by pain and fear to think about that.

Instead Adora moves sharply to the side the moment she feels him moving too. His hand manages to grasp the back of her shoulder and Adora screamsout of sheer terror and instinct, tilting her head to the side and letting her mouth fall completely open.

She digs her sharp teeth against the back of Prime´s hand, ripping her way past skin, muscle and ligaments and tearing down. The taste of blood fills her gums immediately, staining her chin and lips in copper blood but it does as it is meant to.

Prime is screaming now too, jumping back over the burning ground just for enough second for Adora to rush away from him, leaving a trail of blood behind her as she crawls towards the back of the cavern, hiding herself among broken columns and fallen statues that keep her out of sight.

Once upon a time she hid here too, between two columns through which she saw the sun in the form of a woman walking inside her life. Now, as she gazes through the spaces between the stone, all she sees is white and green and the living creature that is her worst nightmare, a man chasing her to the very ends seeking to have her one way or another.

“Why are you running away?” Prime screams, howls, slamming his fist against his chest in a way that makes the white gold of his armor echo horribly across the entire cave. “Weren't you supposed to be a monster? The most powerful monster ever known to Greece. Capable of turning folk and kings all the same into stone.”

Adora slams her palm against her mouth and bites back a terrified scream, curling herself over the ground where the ashes stain the hem of her dress in black ooze.

“Weren´t you supposed to be a fierce murderer?”

Adora can see him walking from side to side of the cavern, furious, rageful, yet calculated. Every single step he takes, every single movement is accounted for, practiced, like a sick twist of a dance done over and over and over again until he knew the steps from the inside out and with his eyes closed.

Prime holds the heavy shield in front of him, wrapped tightly around his forearm with leather ropes dipped in gold. He moves like an eagle on plane flight, eyes searching for his hunt yet never waving away from the polished back of the golden shield, a mirror that allows him to see all around him without actually looking at it directly. The only way he can survive the gaze of Adora´s cursed eyes.

He knows, he knows how to approach her, how to surround her, how to corner her. Unlike the dozen of false heroes before him, he knows the origin of Adora´s danger, what causes it, what it can inflict.He knows how to wrap her around his net and pull down from her neck.

He has set the cave on fire and has cut every single way for Adora to run away. Has caged her alone with him. He *planned* this, from the very first second even,maybe, years ago. He planned it.

Adora was wrong, she was never truly free here.

“Shit.” Adora gasps under her breath, looking down at her own palm coated with thick blood. “Shit, no. No.” She cannot help but to cry, the tears clogging her throat in a more painful way than the smoke does. “Please no”

She rolls her head back against the blackened columns and stares at the quartz ceiling above her head, learning the way it sparkles with soft pinks where the uneven surfaces reflect the flames. She stares at it and, deep within her chest because she is still the girl she was eleven years ago, starts to pray.

“But you are not that, right? You are not powerful or undefeatable.” Prime is saying, spitting a gush of bloodied saliva against the ground. “You and I know what you really are.”

He has grown old, much older than Adora thought. He was always older than her, but now it shows. Adora cannot truly see his face where he keeps his back firmly planted towards her face, but she can see the gray and white on his hair and the worn of the skin of his hand where he is not bleeding.

He is still tall, still intimidating, with the broad shoulders and the wide arms, like the images of Zeus plastered on the old temples that Adora still remembers by heart. He is still a little bit as he was when he condemned Adora to her own kind of hell, but he is somehow also lesser now. Shrunk down on his mighty white and emerald armor and heavy cape.

A red cape, with golden swirls of birds mid fly. A red cape embroidered in unbreakable thread that has seen all the horrors and blood of the world but that once it was meant only for warmth. A cape Adora wove for a loved one, the first thing she wove at all, made with gentleness and with love.

This is the cape of Adam, prince of Ethernia. A red cape that once was Adora´s brother, her twin, dragging over ashes and fire and never setting itself aflame.

“Don´t shake from me Adora.” Prime spats between clenched teeth, following the images in the shield without being able to find Adora. “Did you think ten years in this place would make you more than me? That you would land on top? You are still mine, to take, to curse or too kill as I wish”

Adora rolls her head to the opposite side of him, towards the hidden entrance of the cave that leads to her home, to the place filled with colors and green grass and life that she has made her life on. To the place where the love of her life lies, waiting for Adora to return.

“Please stay inside.” Adora pleads under her breath hoping the heated winds will carry her pleas to sensible ears. Unstoppable tears leave clear marks against her ashed cheeks, a mock to the smudged sun makeup she was wearing just a few minutes ago. “Please, please. Stay inside.”

“Answer to me now, Adora!” Prime screams at the top of his lungs, his green sandals stepping over the fabric of the cape, avoiding raging flames. He turns towards the remains of an old statue, one of the first ones, chuckling loudly at the side of it when he slams the back of his sword against the rock, gathering dust and debris towards his feet. “Adora! Adora! Adora! That was your name, right?! Medusa?!” “Medusa!”

“Get out.” Adora screams back, shaking when she hears the way her voice comes broken and *wrong*. “Leave me, get out!”

Adora crawls on her hands and knees towards another cluster of broken rocks near her, pressing her knees against her chest as she starts undoing the knots of the leather rope and wraps them around the side of her chest instead, stopping the blood as best she possibly can.

“You still have such a beautiful voice,” Prime whispers, almost to himself,and Adora can see the edge of his sharp smile against the gold.

“But why should I leave?” He wonders outloud, pressing a hand towards the long and messy braids of his hair. “Didn´t you miss me? I´m the proof that once you were human, I'm all that is left for you.”

He is still holding his sword in his hand, a beautiful thing. Long, so long it brushes against the ground, with the handle of pure gold encrusted in pearls, topaz and turquoise. A beautiful thing, master crafted and long generation passed, with the blade encrusted in mother pearl and unbreakable metals.

Adora´s kingdom was one of sealife, one blessed by the ocean and its treasures. She grew up learning about the sand on her feet and the shape of the sea shells on her hands. She grew up wearing pearls on her hair and suns on her eyes. She grew up learning the waves carved on this sword from the hand of her grandparents, a sword gifted as a betrothal gift from the sea nereid that fell in love with her grandfather.

This is the sword of Marlena, the sword of Adora´s mother, the mother pearl stained in her own blood, dripping slowly to the floor.

“I´ve thought of you, Adora, every single day. I even considered coming to pay you a visit to your jail one or twice.”

He is wearing a crown too, Adora can see the shape of it now. Past her own tears and the smoke eating the cave alive, she can see the circle of gold, thick, heavy, royal. Carved on the inside with fig leaves and poppies; shaped on the sides with long wings not of eagles but of doves. With the ruby shaped as a teardrop right in the middle and the iridescent dark pearls on the rim.

A heavy crown for he who calls himself king. A heavy crown that was one of the last things Adora saw before running, before begging for mercy, before being casted away forever in the same of Prime

This is the crown of Randor, the crown of Adora´s and Adam´s father, hung from the head of the usurper he allowed in his home and on his throne.

“And there have been so many like you these years, all of them beautiful and ungrateful. And yet none were enough.” Prime takes a heavy breath that sounds all times slick and poisonous, like fresh blood and venom running together, rotten smell and flesh tasted.

“I guess there was truly no comparison for you,” he spits, “Not mortal,” he laughs, “Not godlike”

He is wearing the treasures of Adora´s family like animal skins. Like trophies of his sins, clung to his faux white body and life, deceiving the world into making him seem royal when he is nothing else but another bastard seeking for the greed of glory. He is not better than all the men before him, before his time, breaking the world trying to reach something that is not theirs to begin with.

He is wearing them like dripping gold yet, when he finally turns to the side, Adoracan makes the mess of his chiton underneath the cape, the pieces of fabric ripped after struggle, the shadow of stabs and the run of swords and bows. The red on the white even though his blood is ichor,letting him know he is still mortal no matter what he does.

Finally, when he leans to the side, Adora can gaze at his face still looking away from her and she cannot help herself but to gasp, looking quickly away when Prime snaps his head back like a vulture´s neck, his entire face twisting into such a rageful face that it steals the air inside Adora´s chest.

“Are you looking at me?” He asks, and when he speaks the wide and long ago healed scar on the right side of his face remains unmoving. When he speaks, the crooked lip and the sliced cheek, the split eyelids and the burnt forehead remains as it is, marked forever by the touch of someone long dead too,someone that managed to mark him forever with the touch of her hand. “Are you?! Looking?! At me?!”

Prime screams at the top of his lungs, stomping on the ground and kicking against the hard rock of the statues, breaking them on his fit of raw rage and clouded anger. He spits and yells and keeps yelling until the sound rivals the raging flames around them. Until the only thing more terrible than his anger is his face, disfigured by war and by justice.

“I´m still a king, you know? I´m still an Emperor!” Prime snaps, biting into his own tongue and dripping golden blood over the ground. “I wiped this world clean and brought it to purity, I erased the faux royal blood. Salineas, Plumeria, Drill. Sparta, Mycenae, Etheria, they were all mine. *I* did it all, I won. They should have rejoiced under my offerings, they should have worshiped me as a god!”

Adora takes a shivering breath, hiding her face between her palms. Her heart feels like it's going to explode inside her chest and she feels dizzy, quietly terrified and locked by the same fear.

“You know what I got? Mutiny, betrayal. Twelve knives to the back as if that could kill me. Me! Prime! The son of the king of the gods. Ichor runs down my veins and they thought they could kill me!” Another column breaks down to the ground. Adora feels infinitesimally small; she knows she could kill him with a glance but he is also wearing her family on his skin and she feels small. “They thought I was done, they thought I had been forsaken, as if I needed anyone to win.”

A tiny serpent makes its way towards Adora´s face, pressing itself against her lips when she lets out a tiny whimper and Prime snaps his head towards her. The rest of the serpents gather

long and strong at the top of her head, protecting her face and her neck with their fauces open wide and snapping against the humid air.

“They thought I was afraid. The Bloodied Emperor, scared of a woman, *a woman.* Scared of a monster living in a cave” He sounds further away, but as in every myth, the monster is always closer than you think when you feel it far away. “Can you believe it? Me, scared of you. You who killed your own brother, you who are the reason that your mother and father are dead”

I see pain and injustice. I see you betrayed, I see you grieving.

“You who killed dozens? Well I've killed thousands. I´ve piled the ground with blood and bone.” He chuckles and from the crushed stones Adora can hear the small sound of liquid against crystal and the rush of fresh air against her nose. “I´ve made a goddess bleed”

It smells like lemongrass, it smells like olive trees and figs dipped in sunlight. Adora gets distracted by it, just for a second, for the tiniest of moments. For a single breath where she smells her homeland, sea land and red poppies, and her new land, wisterias and stone paths.

For the tiniest of moments where Adora is not a monster curling around the ground but a young woman trying to stay alive.

“There you are”

The cloth falls against her face like a promise of doom, rough, dark, the mirror of a metal mask done years ago. This one though, this one is done with fiber nets and sharp thorns, faced to the inside where Adora feels their edges run across the skin of her face and mark her all over again.

She is overwhelmed by its sudden presence, suffocated by smoke and the material against her nose, robbing her from the air and from her sight the second it wraps around her face and her neck. It chokes her, it steals her, it pulls from her backwards like the swan to Leda, like the war to Helen, like death to Eurydice, and sends her thumbling to the ground. Hard.

“No!” Adora howls, digging her nails against the cloth around her face and the rope around her neck, fighting it with tooth and nail as she slams her body against the ground and against the hands holding her down. “Don´t touch me!”

The serpents fight violently too and find their way outside the bag, snapping their bodies and sightless heads up and forwards, towards the place where Prime is standing with his hands wrapped around the bag and Adora´s neck, his knee digging into the middle of her back and pressing her down over the ground.

Adora feels as the serpents pull from her scalp when they finally find the flesh of Prime´s hands and face and dig their fangs *down,* stabbing into him their own venom, burning across his flesh in sharp pain like liquid fire coursing through his skin and muscles.

“Fuck!” Prime screams, spitting blood and venom when one of the serpents catches the flesh of his mouth and rips down, bringing with it a piece of his lip and making him bleed

profusely almost immediately. Adora feels as his hold changes around her, wrapping his fingers almost completely around the bodies of the snakes and pulling them up towards him, the slick sound of the sword slicing against scales loud as a thunder. “Be still. Fucking snake”

Slice.

I see tenderness, I see punishment. I see a sword against snakes and blood in the ground.

Through the rips of the cloth, Adora can see the pieces of bodies falling sadly on the ground in front of her, golden blood and scales scattered on burnt moss and grass. She sees their tiny heads falling on her fingers, clawing to the hard ground and feels the immediate agony of them in her own skin.

“No,” Adora sobs, holding them between her shivering hands. “No”

Broken, sliced, cut in shreds. They caused her pain, they ached, but they were still *hers* .

Adora holds herself to their broken bodies and weeps, pressing her face against the cold floor where Prime is holding her prisoner.

Time is a curious thing indeed,just a few minutes ago Adora was cradled under sunlight inside the arms of her wife. Now she is face down on the hard floor of the cave, overwhelmed by the flames of fire all around her as if Prime didn´t plan to get out of here either or as if he thought the fire would not harm him.

She feels his palm crawling its way across her aching scalp, holding the limb bodies of the sliced serpents and choking the still alive ones inside his hold. She feels the pain all the way to her very bones, pulling and pulling from her until she cannot feel anything else but sharp agony and the smoke inside her lungs and mouth, casting away all sunlight from her body and leaving behind nothing but cold and soaring fire.

“You know she tried to save you, before we threw you here.” Prime spats behind her, twisting the knife inside Adora´s soul. “Your beloved goddess, acolyte, whore of the gods. Your Athena.”

Adora gasps, tears falling unstoppable and hot down her face. Her palms and soles are stained in dark mud, burying the maroon ink with which she had painted them days ago, a little reminder of her wedding anniversary. Her dress is torn in the hem and next to her bleeding rib, and she feels herself small where Prime´s foot presses against her back.

Adora gasps and she whimpers too, the meaning of Prime´s words falling over her like an exploding volcano, setting everything she thought she knew on the deepest of fires.

“Oh yes.” Prime mocks her, the blade of the sword making a sharp sound where it slides slowly through stone. “She disguised herself as a human, as a peasant wielding a sword. She walked among humans and tried to save you but she was breaking her own rules and I could see right through her. I could see her go soft for a human. So disappointing.”

Adora hears him spit on the ground, next to her head, his breath acid and sour. His teeth have rotten inside his mouth, this much she can tell, dead and malnourished after years of famish, after years of dry crops and dead cattle, where nothing beautiful or alive ever grew on the lands.

After years of scavenging from meat, any kind, ripping it clean off the bones of dead corpses where he could find none.

“I cut her arm, from the thumb to the elbow before she could even touch you. I made her bleed and she left you, in the end. She left you to rot in here. Alone.” He says it as if it angered him deeply, as if the words brought a personal offense all by themselves and they do, Adora learns they do. “She betrayed you, time and time again. She turned her face away from you in disgust and even before that, she was the one who blessed me as a warrior. She was my patreon too. She brought me to your door.”

“No!” Adora struggles, slamming her entire body against the ground and fighting off his hands, a new rush of rage coursing through her, begging her to fight for her own life. “No!”

“Don´t you dare look at me!” He screams when Adora manages to dig her nails on the cloth and tear it into shreds, pushing her further down.

“The false Queen from the Moon lands might have thought that she won. That she has defeated me. But she is wrong.” He is gasping, he is struggling to breath, also bound to his mortal lungs under the smoke of the fire. “I will finish this little dance of ours. You will fulfill your purpose now, I will take your head and use it to bring death to those that betrayed me, to that woman on my throne. To every single leaving soul and the Olympus itself if that's what I need to”

Maybe he is jealous, even after everything. Maybe he is jealous that while being on top of the world he could not do anything else but rot inside himself. His body, his face, his power, diminishing little by little until all about him was ugly and terrible. Until There was nothing even close to redeemable or pretty across his face or his heart.

Maybe he is jealous that while he tried to convince himself that he had the upper hand, that he was a step closer to godlike than everyone else around him, the one woman he had not managed to kill, the one one that he had casted away to the depth of the earth, had somehow just grew even more beautiful. That while still cursed and humiliated, Adora had not worn herself down like him, that she had managed to find a way to be bright. Brighter than the very sun.

“I will use you to harm. You will be a monster and you will remain one forever, remembered as a bringer of death to the ends of time. There is no happy ending for you.” He pulls from her head, from her snakes, exposing the soft skin of her neck to the heated air. “Maybe I'll even get a use to that body of yours before I go”

Adora can see herself, both of them, reflected against the golden of the shield dug on the earth in front of them. She can see herself,as she has seen many times in these years, her own body, her own face, her hands, her serpents, her eyes. Ash stained and blood soaked but hers after all, no matter what.

She can see herself and she can almost not see the looming figure of the man hovering above her back, swinging her mother´s sword above his head, ready to slice her head clean off her neck and bringing it with him as a trophy. She can almost ignore it, closing down her eyes and throwing an errand prayer to the heavens, a first one, a last one, begging for the life she loves the most and above it all. Begging for her and hoping she will forgive her after today.

I see a woman like a sun and the blind loyalty of love.

She can see the light of the woman she loves beneath her closed eyelids and that's why she doesn´t see the very same body she loves running through stone and fire towards her, slamming her beautiful body against the body of the man that hates Adora aboveall things, ripping him completely away from her.

“Agh!”

Prime screams, something drowned out and furious, so mad that it would rival the thunder alone yet clogged and buried by the rageful anger of the woman Adora loves.

Adora falls harshly on the ground, gasping for air as she snaps her head back immediately, blinking through violent tears. She seeks for her wife among the fear and the destruction and the cold breath of the underworld licking at her fingers and finds her right there, behind her, standing in ash stained soles and soiled white clothes. Eurydice, standing between the River Styx and the breath of life.

Just like the last time, when her brother's love shielded her, even in the depth of hell Adora has never been alone.

“Catra”

Catra hovers over Adora´s fallen body like a panther, like a Fury, like a different kind of goddess freed from her marble cast and set loose on the hell that is the red cave. Hissing violently until all of her sharp teeth and fangs shimmers crimson where she dug them in Prime´s shoulder and her long claws drip down and down with the remains of his poisoned golden blood where she clawed at his face.

She is not facing Adora but even like this, on the floor beneath her warm body, Adora can see her fully, from the shimmer of her freckles to the gold in her hair and the silver nestled on her eyes, shining so bright and so sharp that it looks as if the moon herself had fallen to the earth just so she could guide Catra through the dark.

Prime howls, feeling with his fingertips the ragged ends of the open wounds in his body, coursing like a spirit pulled out from Tartarus when they burn him deeply with suffering. He keeps his eyes locked into the ground, now that he has been parted from the safety of the shield, but Adora can see him scowling with the claws of immediate hatred, spitting poison like another kind of snake against the ground.

“What the— agh!”

Adora is dizzy and in agony, so drowned out by the overwhelming feeling of everything that she falls to notice the bow and arrows held from Catra´s hip and hands, pointed directly at the place where Prime´s angry voice is coming from.

The fire must be distracting but it's no barrier, no for Catra, not when she raises the weapon from the ashes in the ground and holds it in front of herself and Adora, letting go from the arrow with frightful aim it sliced Prime´s ear cleanly in half.

“You will use her?” Catra spats, angry, angrier than Adora has ever seen her in her entire life, her body shaking with hatred but not her hands. “You will touch her?”

Prime wants to say something, wants to scream but Catra does not allow it. She follows the sharp edge of his breath and lets the arrow fly across the boiling air again, cutting through thick smoke and grazing the side of his body, cutting with its copper edge a wound, mirror from Adora´s, immediately staining the once pristine white tunic in golden blood.

“You will kill her?”

“Ah!” Prime slams his face against the hard ground, kicking blindly at anything to chase away the pain from the wounds. “Fucking bitch!”

“Catra”

Adora stands up in precarious feet, her soles purple and red where bruises have started to scatter across her skin. She feels dizzy immediately, threatening to drag her into the ground once again so she holds herself to the soft fabric of Catra´s chiton, breathing hard.

Catra places herself firmly in front of her, unbendable, unmoving, strong like the walls of Troy where she covers Adora´s body with her own, holding the wood bow and copper arrows in her beautiful hands, her eyes shimmering in liquid silver and her skin golden bright, tiny suns burn from her cheeks.

She is protecting Adora, shielding her, even without a sight. opening her body like a flower fallen from a warrior's armor, living sprouts and grass born from her bare soles, eating the very green fire away,

You have been given hope. Sweet as a dove and sightless as faith. Hope in the form of a dream and a dream in the form of a miracle.

C’yra, daughter of Io. Wife of Princess Adora.

Child of the Gods.

“You are never getting Adora.” Catra spats, running another arrow that makes her smile when Prime screams. “You are never laying your hands on her, ever again”

Tiny sprouts bloom from the burnt surface of the stone and make their way through Adora´s toes, wrapping themselves around her ankles and the length of her legs, traveling through her waist and pressing their petals against the open wound on her side.

It subdues the blood almost immediately and it hurts, but Adora endures it, watching through narrowed eyes at the expansion of Catra´s back.

She wonders, absently, if she realizes what she is doing, with the flowers, with the fire, with Adora. By the violent tremble of her body, Adora realizes she doesn´t. Her mind is somewhere else, driven by instinct alone.

“Get out right now or I'm going to kill you.” Catra hisses, her entire body tense like a cord about to snap in half. “And you won´t even be allowed to lay your eyes on her when you are bleeding out. You are not gazing at her again,alive or dead.”

Prime sputters, mud and blood gathering on his mouth, smudging over pale lips and the ragged ends of the scar, still profusely refusing to look up. And, oh, maybe he really is afraid of what Adora can do, after all. He is afraid of her.

“Do you know who I am?!”

“You are the bad draft of a man.” Catra runs the words through her mouth,slick and poisonous, giving a step back, holding her bow higher. “You are not a god.” She presses her back against Adora´s body, covering her with it. “You are not even half of it.”

“How dare you?!”

There is light inside the cave, silver light skipping its way through the stone walls like a doe roaring the woods. Adora can see it now that the dark smoke has begun to fall, the green flames choked out and drowned under the sharp dew and the violent rain pouring outside, showering the world in fresh water for the first time in ten years.

Silver light and rain and maybe, just maybe, Adora wonder if they are the only ones in here today.

“You wanna know how?” Catra speaks, and Adora can see as the silver light pours against her dark skin and lingers on her palms, guiding her bow and arrow where it needs to be. A blessing. God touched. “Because I *am* one”

The copper end slices clean through Prime´s heel, from side to side, breaking the tendon there and making it snap with a wet tug. Catra once told Adora that this was how the butcher, Achilles, died; dipped in godly waters yet undone by the weight of his own mortality. As Adora stares at the pouring blood soaking into the black ground, she thinks Catra might have been right.

Prime´s screams are so violent and unholy that they hurt, echoing inside the cave and their ears until Adora curls into herself, thinking they might actually bleed. She sees his back as he stumbles towards the debris of the stones, hiding among them where he wraps his pale hand around the body of the arrow and then, in one horrid and swift motion, pulls from it with his entire strength, flesh and clots of blood dribbling towards the floor.

Catra does not stay to wait for him, she turns into her ankles and seizes Adora, whatever part of her she manages to find among the shadows and chaos, dragging her across the unsure

floor until they also stumble with a gather of high stone and kneel behind them, hiding from Prime´s bleeding red and rageful eyes.

Adora gasps once she is on colder ground, her body giving out on her the second she feels herself away from him again.Her teeth start clicking together violently and her knees start to shake, sending her painfully against the ground.

She claws at the soft earth digging itself beneath her fingernails and takes several breathes of deep air, gasping and choking on her own spit when she feels the true lengths of her fear finally getting to her, breaking the haze of adrenaline and anger and leaving her war torn and terrified over the ground.

Catra embraces her immediately, the bow and arrows making a soft metallic sound against each other when she drops them promptly to the ground and wraps her arms strongly and firm around Adora´s broad chest, catching her inside her against her chest as the screams echo and Adora crumbles.

“Adora,” Catra exhales, now fully shaking from her hands to her body, resting her cheek against Adora´s ear. “Are you alright? You are bleeding”

She tears herself away from Adora to grasp at the sides of her head instead, and no matter how much Adora wants to howl and scream at her to stop, to not do it, to not realize the terror of what just happened, she cannot move nor talk. She is stuck right here, fighting a war with her own mind and her own body, trying to find herself again among the layers of her fear.

Catra´s hand runs very delicately over the bodies of the serpents and hesitates terribly the moment she realizes what has happened, the moment her gentle fingers who have known nothing but gentleness the last years, caress the aching bodies of the mangled snakes, holding their tiny heads on the heel of her palm and feeling them sizzling pained and weak over her skin.

“Gods,” Catra whimpers, horrified beyond herself

Adora tries to move away but her body does not answer her back so she just remains here, in Catra´s palms as she quietly and frantically nurses the wounded snakes with the broken pieces of her tunic. Adora gazes at Catra´s beautiful and terrified face and gasps, words that come as a whimper when she tries to speak them out loud.

“It´s him,” Adora hears and it takes her a full second to realize that it is her own voice, speaking to Catra as if it brought all the doom in the world. “It´s him”

“I´m here.” Catra reassures her, cradling Adora´s face inside her palms.

“I´m scared”

“I know, Dora.” She is scared too, Adora can see it in the flash of her white eyes and the twitch of her mouth. “I´m here, I´m not letting go from your hand”

Beyond their hidden spot, in the middle of a cave clustered with old statues and dying fire, Prime stumbles back to his feet. He rests all of his weight over his good foot and holds the sword on his hand with undeniable anger, swinging it blindly from side to side as he tries to slice anything, everything, on his path.

“Ahaha! So that´s it?! You have a woman? With you? In here? A woman to defend your stained honor?” He starts yelling, the sound of his voice gathering cold sweat on the base of Adora´s neck. “Where did she even come from?”

“Is the entrance free?” Catra urges in a thread of a voice, holding Adora´s hands when the latter cannot seem to find her voice. “Adora”

“There's still fire.” Adora shivers, glancing at the green flames still fighting their place on the walls of the cave and at the pouring rain from the outside, water, wind and pieces of earth flying violently once against another, an incoming natural disaster incapable of being tamed and unnatural in all senses.

“Let´s go to the cavern.”

Catra is already standing up, searching blindly for their way back. She has only one arrow left and she doesn´t have her cane with her. She is skipping sharp stones blindly with her bare soles and her face filled with determination and Adora cannot do more but gaze at her.

“He will find us.” Adora snaps, wrapping her hand around Catra´s hand and pulling from her, harsh in the middle of her frenzy, making Catra stumble back into the ground.

“He will not stop, Catra. He will never stop.” Adora starts saying, feeling the edges of her sanity running dry as rivers and dripping off her face in teardrops, unfair and very, very real. “I should have known. He will not stop until she has me”

“Adora.” Catra snaps, her fangs clicking together loudly where her voice is sour, ripping Adora from her dark thoughts with her voice alone. They have grown older, the both of them. Older and wiser. “He *won't* have you,” She shakes her head, hard, holding Adora´s fingers gently with one hand and digging iron sharp nails over the rock with the other. “I'm right here with you”

And if we die then we will die, Catra thinks and doesn´t say it, though Adora can hear her loud and clear inside her mind. *If we die, I´ll hold your hand tight and Charon will have to let us through together. I´ll guide you to the Elyseum myself and keep you warm until I can deliver you into Adam´s arms again.*

If we die we will be together, Catra thinks, loud and strong as a bell. *And we will die on our own terms, because you don't belong to him and I will not leave you alone. Ever.*

Adora exhales, her entire body shaken up by the strength of Catra´s adoration for her, clear on her beautiful factions and on the strength of her voice.

“You are your own, Adora,” Catra whispers, running trembling fingers over bleeding snakes, wounded but still alive, stubborn, refusing to let themselves die by his hand. “This body is

yours, these hands, this chest, these eyes. You are my wife, you are your brother´s sister. You are Adora and you are alive.”

Somewhere in the cave Prime runs his bleeding palms through the ground, finding the soft ends of the Heracles Knot Adora wraps around her waist every day. With the fight and the struggle, the golden threads had come undone on the back, falling sadly between the dark ash and the damp water dripping from the ceiling of the cave.

“Oh, I see. Is she your sweetheart?” Prime laughs, holding the lace high over his head, looking at it as if the thread alone would answer him before tossing it recklessly to the green fire still raging behind him. “Is that what this is? You find someone not repulsed about you and you wed her? Bed her?”

“Adora, look at us”

Catra speaks a little bit louder, her shaky yet firm voice drowning his away, making Adora steady on her feet all over again. Anchoring Adora to the now, right now, where Catra is holding her hands and Adora wears gold on her skin and head. A now where she has survived.

“Look at your life now. Look at who you are, that never changed. Not for him, not for anyone. You're still you, no matter what he did or what he does, you're still Adora.” Catra sniffles, resting her cheeks over Adora´s palms. “My Adora”

“Are you her whore? Or is it the other way around?”

“Catra.” Adora speaks and it is her voice, her own. It is her body, her pain, her heart, her desire to live above all things. To live in this world where Catra exists too. To live in a world where herself, Adora, can exist no matter who or what. A world where she will always be Medusa for the world but she will also be Adora, where nobody can take away that from her, no matter how much they try. “My Catra”

“Yes”

“I´m tired.” Adora grinds her teeth, sinking her nails on the stone too, feeling so much love inside of her, for Catra, for herself, but also something more. Something almost equally as strong. Rage. “I´m sick of him”

“I know”

“I hate him.” Adora spits, hearing the man that tried to break her time and time again screaming in her lands, thinking he can take from her again, and again and again. Thinking Adora is some kind of possession he can throw again and come back to crawling when he has faced defeat. She is tired and she is angry.. “I´ve always hated him. For what he did to me, to my people, to my parents. To Adam. I don't want to be forgiving or benevolent. I want him death”

“Good, because he is not leaving this place alive. I won´t allow him to chase you any longer.” Catra exhales, accepting all of Adora´s anger and resentment inside her palms, inside her

hands, unable to hold it for Adora but holding all that Adora is in return.

There is no room for forgiveness today, not in this, not with the fire grasping at the entrance of their home and a man feeling himself a god seeking to break them. There is no room to be the bigger person or the kinder one, not in this, not with someone like this, who has broken so many others, who has broken the world.

Sometimes, the only answer is to finish it, sometimes the only answer is to pluck the rotten from the very root.

“Adora!”

“He made me a monster,” Adora mourns, among her anger, wrapping her fingers around the bodies of the wounded serpents and pressing her fingers against her golden eyes. “A murderer. If I turn him into stone, I will be what he created me for.”

“No you won´t,” Catra reassures her, all kinds of sure and all kinds of frantic, her ire for him and her love for Adora playing a dance inside her silver eyes that could set the entire world on fire if she wanted.

“Won´t I be then truly Medusa?”

“You will be a woman, surviving, saying no”

“I won´t be a monster?”

“You will be Adora. A sister, a daughter, a wife, a princess. You will be you. You have always been and will always be you, no matter what happened ten years ago or what happens today.” Catra takes a shivering breath, suddenly out of air with the strength of her devotion and the lengths of her bravery, the set of her jaw, reaching resolution even at the feet of the underworld, even amongst fear. The golden thread of her life knots around Adora´s and tightens in one. “He has no right over you, not even over your eyes and what they can do. A man has many ways to die.”

The golden shield that Prime has been carrying with him gets slammed against the surface of the statues, rising a sound so high and horrid that makes every single living being in the cave to cringe a little,

“Adora! Come here! I´m not fucking scared of you!”

“I have to face him.” Adora whispers, all kinds of sour, all kinds of brave, nestling herself in the touch of Catra´s gentle hands cradling her face.

“We will. You are going to be alright. We are going to stay together no matter what. I´m not letting you down, alright? You are the love of my life and I love you, always will” Catra reassures her, kneeling in front of her. Her knees are on the damp earth, her hands are around her face, her heart around Adora´s heart. Adora already lived through this, many years ago; someone she loved was kneeling in front of her, promising her everything would be alright

again, loving her, sheltering her, being brave. “Nothing bad can really happen as long as we have each other”

Adora wants to be brave too. She already is, so very more than what she gives herself credit for.

Catra leans towards her and Adora meets her in the middle, right there beside marble stones and softened earth, with their hands soiled by ashes and their faces coated in tears. They kiss with rings of gold still held to their heads and and their tunics made for each other wrapped around their legs and their chests.

They still taste the same as five years ago, the same as this morning. The same as every single day, wrapped on each other's love.

“I love you, so much.” Adora vows, feeling her smile against her mouth.

“I love you too”

Catra holds Adora´s hand tightly inside hers and stands up, still placing herself in front of Adora as they take a single step forwards.

She leaves the bow and the loose arrows on the ground but Adora watches her reach for the fold of her white tunic smeared with moss and pressed flowers, unfolding the slick blade of a copper knife and holding it with practiced movements between her fingers.

Adora holds herself to the ribbons of Catra´s dress and follows her among the shadows and the smoke, letting herself be guided like an errand spirit that is walking through the halls and stairs of the underworld hoping to see the light of the sun again.

Prime is standing in the middle of the blazing cave, his tunic soaked by his own blood where Catra´s wounds have soaked the fabric. He is backwards to them, looking at Catra and Adora, finally stepping from the cluster of stones behind him, smiling at their reflection through the bright gold on the shield engraved with thunder and dead crops.

Adam´s cape still hangs heavy and beautiful from his shoulders and just the sight of it makes Adora´s blood boil, a rage and a grudge so deep that she is almost undone by it.

Not even the sight of the sword nor the crown are able to make her as rageful as the sight of her brother´s beloved clothes on him, on his body, on his presence that makes everything putrid and wrong and that stains everything. Kingdoms, lands, memories.

Everything but Adam´s bravery, Everything but Catra´s loyalty. Everything but Adora.

“Stay. Away.” Catra warns him, holding the knife in front of her face.

She is making a monumental effort to not tremble, to not let her eyes wander around, confused by the movement of shadows and the lack of light. Adora holds her hand hard and tries to pull her back, place her behind her own back and go first but Catra pushes her away with her hips, straightening her back in front of Adora so Prime does not get to have a single glance of her.

“Did she tell you?” He spats, furious when all he can see is Catra´s angry face and the fall of Adora´s bare shoulders behind her. “Did she tell you she was mine?”

“She was never yours.” Catra scowls, her pretty lips retracting over her gums when she hiss, loud and threatening. “No woman is. None of us belong to you”

Prime chuckles, straightening up on his place, Catra gives another step to the side, followed by Adora, the three of them circling each other on the treacherous space of the cave. Prime trips and almost falls several times, betrayed by the dry earth and the crumbled statues, as not even the earth wants him here.

Neither Adora nor Catra trip, not a single time, holding to each other so hard their knuckles and joints ache with the strength.

Prime catches the sight of their hands laced together through the back of the shield, soiled and bleeding but still together as they face him directly. He is the one that remains on his back, he is the one that looks away,that refuses to turn around. Coward.

Catra twitches her tongue against the back of her teeth, deeply displeased and further angrier. Adora feels herself tense as a bow´s cord, about to snap any moment now with the amount of her anxiety and her anger.

They want to move, both of them, they want to get it over with but neither of them will do it from the back. Not like him.

“What are you waiting for?” Catra taunts him, feeling herself big as a temple and yet so very small, the sprout of bravery fueling her chest into a fire more blazing than the very green flames around them. Outside, in the world beyond the cave, the sky has gone virulent and the rain violent, lashing against each other as the pantheon holds its breath and stares. “I thought you were not scared of a woman.”

“You are a pretty thing.” Prime cuts her, suddenly cold. Cold, colder than the rain, colder than white lightning cutting the skies and the air. Colder than anything inside this place that has become warm and holy even with his sudden presence in it.

He must see the way Catra´s breath catches on her chest, he must hear the way Adora gasps with fear, because he smiles. He smiles through the back of the shield, victorious in a way, joyful. He is already imagining the stories that will be told about him, about the Emperor that conquered Etheria with Medusa's head, the one that beheaded the monster and took the world for himself with her.

Even battered in wounds, he is sharp, the golden shade of his pale green eyes shimmering when he realizes he has found Adora´s source of strength but also her most beloved weakness. Like Achilles, like Andromache, like Orpheus. The vessel of her love and her life in the form of a woman, contained in the flesh of her wife, mingled in the breath of Catra.

“Your monster was also a pretty thing, once. She refused to share her loins and now she is here.” Catra takes a sharp breath and Adora wraps her hands around her waist, holding to each other and shaking with anger, both of them. Prime sees them move and smiles, tilting

his head to the side as he locks his eyes with Catra´s silver ones. Open eyes, slightly unfocused eyes. “How are you even still alive?”

It happens very quickly. Time is a curious thing and sometimes it goes slow and other times goes too fast, pulled by the anchors of Fate that strain threads of life into what must happen.

And this thing, this thing that happens right now was already written, many many years ago, maybe eons even. It was in the fabric of the universe, woven on the stars and embroidered between galaxies.

It was written since before they were born, sealed and done from the very second the unknown goddess ceased to exist and two mortal lovers took a breath into this world instead.

Time is unbreakable and so are prophecies, the kind told to young lovers many years ago.

Prime holds his breath and suddenly he is moving, fast, faster than any mortal as he is still the sprout of a god, as he is smart, so smart he was blessed by a goddess once.

He lets go from the shield and turns on his ankles and, before neither Catra or Adora can react, throws a lighten torch on their direction, the green fire spreading like an stars explosion everywhere from the moss to the quartz ceiling into a single wall that cuts and divides Catra and Adora painfully into two.

“Shit!” Adora screams, covering her face with her hands when the fire licks dangerously close to her eyes.

She takes a ragged gasp and at the same time pushes Catra to the side, away, making her dizzy as she stumbles and falls against the ground, rocks and broken twigs digging into her palms and cheeks, cutting shallow lines in her skin.

Adora falls into her knees to try and escape the line of fire at the same time Catra crawls into her palms, seeking desperately for Adora among the thick smoke and the roaring fire coming everywhere around her.

“Adora” Catra yells and she sounds terrified,so deeply frightened that it locks every single nerve inside Adora into white fire and makes her snap her teeth together.

Adora reaches for her immediately, fire be damned as she extends her arms towards the place where Catra is confusingly trying to find her and herself, hissing in pain the fire bites her arm and licks painful red lines over her wrists and foreman.

“Catra, stay there!” Adora screams, as loud as she can above the roar of the flames. “I'm coming for you!”

“Adora,” Catra mutters, her voice so brave, finally breaking in the middle, overwhelmed by finding herself thrown from her axis in unknown lands and torn apart from the hand of her wife. “Adora, where—”

“She is blind.” Prime's voice comes full of sick realization from behind Catra's place, walking from the shadows with his back turned to Adora but his voice loud and clear like a

war horn “Ha! Fuck. Fuck!”

Something slick and nasty spreads through Adora's chest the moment she hears his words, her own realization that he has discovered their secret covering her in a sheer layer of a terror so profound that Adora feels like screaming and crying all at the very same time.

At the other side of the line of fire, Catra's eyes open wide and beautiful as a doe, seeking for Adora blindly and filled with their own kind of panic. Her rich skin goes pale and she is stuck with a cold sweat that makes her start trembling from the head to the toes, grasping handfuls of damp earth where she hears Prime approach her little by little and without knowing where else to go.

“A blind woman in love with the Medusa.” Prime drags the words around his slick tongue, sharp, red, poisonous. “How beautifully destined to be together”

Adora rushes to her bleeding feet, her hands into fists and her nails cutting the skin of her palms where she close them until her joints hurt. She cannot see Prime's face but she can see the cave around her drowned in fire and she can see Catra, curled in the floor where she has been cornered between Prime and the fire, flowers blooming and immediately dying all around her.

Adora grunts and gives a drowned yell, ready to cross the fucking fire even if it burns and melts her skin over her bones, she cares all the same, her arms stretched to cover Catra and place herself between them.

But in her desperation she does forget than Prime was once a skilled warrior and she does not see the spear coming towards her nor the second shield dug on the ground until the copper head is digging itself across Adora's arm, knocking her to the ground with a bloodcurdling scream.

“You got everything, didn't you Adora?” Prime asks above the sound of Adora's screams, looking at her convulsing body across the reflection of the shield before turning towards Catra once again, watching her weep and kick her way towards Adora's voice. “You got it all, right here”

“Adora,” Catra calls for her, meeting too the flame by accident and whimpering when they burn her skin. “Adora”

“Kiki,” Adora gasps, her hand curled around the spear and her golden eyes narrowed where a river of tears have begun to fall unstoppable across her face. “My love”

“You got everything and I got nothing. It doesn´t seem fair, Adora.” Prime leans down and grabs the back of Catra's white tunic in his hand, lifting her a few inches and then throwing her back on the hard floor with so much force that Catra gasps and tears start to sprout down her eyes the second her head slams against the ground. “I'm a king. You're a monster.”

Adora screams, howls, both by pain and by absolute rage. She grabs the middle of the spear and starts pulling from it, feeling flesh being ripped and blood pouring into her palm.

Prime does not glance at her, not even once. He grabs Catra by the throat and anchors her to the ground, letting his knees fall heavy over her legs to subdue the struggle and violent fight of Catra's body beneath him.

“You are so very brave, aren´t you?” Prime grunts, choking the air out of Catra's lungs when he presses down. “Sacrificing yourself for your Adora. Burying yourself in stone for her, for being the only person she could ever love”

Catra spits on his face, her hands coming up to wrap around Prime's wrists just so she can dig her nails against the bruised skin there, craving lines that bleed immediately between them.

“Fucker.” Catra spats, kicking violently and struggling to get him off. With the fight her knife has been knocked off, fallen near her knee where she cannot feel it.

“I thought she would kill me, I won´t lie. I thought she would become a true monster and kill me.” Through ashes and flames, Adora sees the movement of Prime's hand searching behind his back, reaching for something crystal and liquid filled, golden, as if he had poured the sun's blood by hand there. “So thank you for being here, making her soft.”

Catra howls, beyond her mind with anger. She slams her own head against the ground and nails at every single part of Prime's body that she can reach.

“I´m going to fucking kill you if you touch her”

“It will be useless.” Prime says slowly, taking pride in Adora's howls somewhere next to them. “You know, my father is a god. Zeus. And he gave me a few things. A crown, a divine privilege, he baptised me in royalty.”

Prime laughs, actually cackles, loud and hysterical, screeching like an animal in the hunt. His long and sharp nails make a ticking sound when they runs against the surface of a crystal vial, strongly held inside his hand.

“And he gave me the ability to take. I am, after all, god blood”

He lets go from Catra's throat just so he can dig his long nails against Catra's eyelids, prying the golden lilac skin open until he can gaze into Catra's beautiful silver and white eyes.

Catra cannot see him, her unfocused eyes roaming violently all around her trying to place him. And he takes pride on it, leaning his face until his mouth is pressed against the side of her ears, speaking to her the truth because he knows Catra loves Adora and the knowledge will torture her forever.

“The gods might have forsaken her but it was me. I cursed her to never see a living creature without death.”

He smiles, watching Catra cry with the amount of her rage. Watching her bright eyes and golden freckles. She is so much like Adora too, two parts of the same soul.

“Her eyes were so blue.” He whispers, biting on his tongue. “You have pretty eyes too”

Prime forces Catra´s eyes open and Adora watches horrified as he drop the golden liquid inside them, goddess ichor, Athena's blood.

Many things happen at the same time.

The crystal vial falls into the ground and shatters, cutting Prime's palm and making him bleed into holy grounds.

A thunderbolt breaks the red sky and crashes outside, against the cave, breaking the rain and the winds into a suspended time.

Adora tears the spear out and turns to look at Catra's face with golden eyes.

Nobody gets to reach for her, not for anything, not in time. The fire crackles with a vicious screech and it dies down completely, drowning the cave in darkness.

And then, Catra starts to scream.

“Ah!” Catra rolls her head back, every single nerve ending on her body on fire when she lets her mouth open and screams. “Ah! AHHH!”

“CATRA!” Adora howls, raising on her feet and falling immediately back down when the wounds make her dizzy and her legs give up below her, “Fuck! Catra!”

Catra bends over herself in the ground and screams, howls, jowls until her jaw bone hurts and her lungs are burning, until her eyes are drowning in tears falling down her eyes and soaking her cheeks, until her body feels like it is breaking in two pouring godly ichor into the floor.

“Adora!” Catra calls for her, bringing her hands towards her face and cradling her eyes inside them, gold dripping liquid from between her fingers. “Adora”

“You see Adora?!” Prime screams, out of his mind. “You will only hurt who you love in the process!”

Adora raises again on her feet, another kind of fire burning inside of her. One crimson red. Red like mortal blood, red like poppies, red like her dress eleven years ago and her dress today. Red like Catra´s mouth, red like the skies.

A red that is not love nor passion but all battlefield yet the same, carefully woven to each other. A kind that is war, each day lived, all too familiar. The kind that women know from the womb to the tomb and that is unfair but that it exists, that makes them holy beyond any other creature in the earth.

“Leave her!” Adora screams, grasping the body of the spear soaked in her own blood. She steps over the burnt earth still sizzling hot with the consumed fires and doesn´t even flinch when it burns on the skin of her soles, eaten away by the wedding inks in her ankles and toes. “Leave her alone!”

And when Prime doesn´t do anything else but laugh at her. When he presses both of his eyelids firmly closed and laughs and laughs feeling Adora´s wife runs her nails across his

arms and pushing him away with all her strength, Adora raises the golden spear and for a second she is also god touched.

Adora stabs the sharp end of the spear against Prime´s ribs, past flesh and muscle and cartilage, so deeply dug inside that blood starts pouring immediately, lung collapsing and just by some miracle not crossing the heart from side to side.

“Look at me! LOOK AT ME!” Adora screams until her vocal cords shred, holding the spear until her knuckles whitened and her flesh rips with the strength. She presses her face against Prime´s, terrifying beauty over rotten horror, her golden eyes bright as the very sun and every single of the serpents, wounded or not, raising up and hissing too, creating together a song so frightful that makes the world tremble. “Turn around and look at me!”

He doesn´t turn around, he would never turn around for her, as he has never loved her and has always feared her instead. Even before, when she was only twenty and barely more than a child, he was afraid of her.

Adora hopes he is terrified now, like she was. She hopes he knows he is going to die tonight.

On the ground, Catra´s hand brushes the handle of her own knife and raises it without a second thought, stabbing it inside Prime´s tight and *squeezing* until he is screaming just like he made her scream.

Prime chokes on his own saliva and blood and howls, falling heavily to the side where he tries to run away from the, hiding his face on the ragged cape the entire time.

Adora lets go from the spear and falls heavily on her knees, gathering Catra's shivering body inside her arms.

“Let´s go, let´s go.” Adora rushes, her teeth catching together where she is trembling violently with the rush of rage and adrenaline.

She runs her arm below Catra´s knee and carries her up in her arms with almost no effort at all, wounds and pain be damned as she runs at the other side of the cave, squating on the ground as she places Catra gently down.

Green sprouts are born immediately the moment Catra touches the dark earth, cradling them both in a gentle circle of tiny flowers and moss. Catra kneels over them, her hands tightly pressed over her arms and her back arched over itself, curling into a tight balls around her own limbs and long dark hair stained in golden and red.

Adora kneels right behind her, her face destroyed and terrible as she wraps her arms around Catra´s chest and tilts her face to try and look at her.

Her heart is beating so hard inside her chest that it hurts, it aches deeply, stealing her breath from her lungs as hate, love and terrible sorrow wave their own kind of tapestry inside her soul, pulling from all the threads that surround her and join her to who she loves the most.

What a wonderful thing it is to love until we ache, a privilege handed to so little, most of the time destined for tragedy.

“Kiki,” Adora mourns, the term of endearment rolling easily off her tongue. “Sweetheart, what is it? What happened?”

“I don´t know,” Catra whimpers, tearing up. “My head is burning up”

“Let me see.” Adora pleads to her, gently caressing Catra´s wrists to try and coo her hands down. When Catra whines in pain she bites into her own mouth, her heart bursting and exploding inside her chest, unable to keep itself whole where her wife has been wounded by *his* hand. “Let me see, baby, it´s alright. It´s alright. You are fine.”

Catra allows Adora to gently move her hands down but she keeps her eyes tightly closed, too drowned out in pain to be able to open them at all. She lets all of her weight fall against Adora´s chest and sighs at her arms cradling her close, seeking for her warmth and her touch as if only that could keep her, both of them, safe right now.

Adora runs her fingertips very softly over Catra´s closed eyelids, collecting tears and golden liquid in her fingers that shimmers when she observes them closer, comprehension falling over her like rain.

“Is this— ichor?”

“Is not mine” Catra gasps, holding Adora´s warm palm and pressing it against her aching eyes, subduing the pain with a low sob.

A horrid *squelch* calls Ador´s attention again, tilting her face to the side so she can see the scene unfolding next to them.

Prime is standing in the middle of the cave, between them and the stone, his feet firmly planted on the ground even where his Achilles tendon has been sliced in half. The spear is gone and he is bleeding profusely in several parts, yet he still manages to stand straight, pushed by his own hatred and his own grudge and nothing more.

Squelch.

Adora stares at his cut tight and his bleeding ribs and see as the golden blood drips and drips and then starts to change, from blessed ichor to dark poison to red, again, nothing but red and thick mortal blood, staining his white and green and golden clothes into a red so similar to Adora´s dress that they are almost one and the same.

Squelch.

He is holding the handle of Catra´s knife in his hand, hovering over his face like the sun ellipses, like a fruit about to fall from the trees. Like scissors from the hand of three sisters,waiting for the moment of his doom. He holds the knife and digs it inside his face without screaming at all.

Squelch.

Adora stares as Prime gouges his own eyes out, laughing like a maniac. The sharp blade of the knife cuts through tender flesh, eyelid, muscles and nerve and soaks his entire face in red blood.

One and then the second, both eyeballs fall gored and shredded over the darkened earth, putrid and rotten the moment they touch the sacred grounds of Catra and Adora´s home.

Adora curls protectively around Catra and watches the scene horrified, her mouth tightly pressed over the back of Catra´s neck in an attempt to sooth her and herself from the carnage.

“Gods.” Adora whimpers, unable to close her eyes. “Gods”

Prime slams the knife onto the ground when he is done, the empty eye sockets clogged with black and red blood and the skin gapping ragged and bleeding. On his terror for Adora and his need to best her, he has doomed himself by his own hand,

“Now you cannot reach me.” He smiles, gums and white teeth soaked in blood.

“Adora,” Catra whispers, trembling furiously inside Adora´s arms. Adora presses her lips over Catra´s temples and her cheekbone and shushes her fear as sweetly as she possibly can, holding her close.

“It´s alright. It's alright, you are fine.” She murmurs, kissing the corner of her mouth. “I´ve got you, everything will be alright.”

“Adora, come here, little Princess.” Prime is taunting her, even wounded, even about to die, focused on breaking her and dragging her down with him even into death.

“You know, your brother was wrong.” He chuckles, cleaning his blood over Adam´s cloth. “Sweet and stupid Prince Adam. He was wrong in thinking you could ever escape your fate, he was wrong in thinking he could save you. And now he lays in pieces on your destroyed palace, in an unmarked tomb without coins for Caronte to let him through,”

Adora closes her eyes and holds Catra against her heart, breathing very deeply.

She can see her brother, right there beneath her eyelids and she does every single day. She sees his cheeky smile and his wise eyes; his golden hair and sun moles; his hands, his voice, his skin when he embraces Adora close.

He was her brother, her twin, he still is, even though he is no longer here. He was Catra´s best friend, he lived in her too. He was a father, a brother, a prince, someone brave. Where Catra is all of Adora´s joy, he was and is still the source of Adora´s bravery.

He is still here, right now, holding her tight through the layers of the Underworld.

“Please protect her,” Adora asks him and then to someone else completely, from a question to a plea. She holds Catra´s hands inside hers and brings them all towards her mouth, hearing her wife´s gasp, praying out loud. “Please protect us both. Please hear me, just this time, just this once. Be with me”

Go home

“Don´t make the same mistakes that killed your brother.” Prime spats, holding Marlena´s sword, slashing it blindly from side to side, hoping to wound, hoping to dismember, hoping to kill. “Do as I say and I will let your lover live. If you come out I will take you and she will live. I assure you that. I will redeem you, I will redeem your sins with your sacrifice.”

“I love you so very much,” Adora says against Catra´s ear, tilting her chin so she can press a heated and close-eyed kiss against her mouth before starting to stand out.

“No.” Catra urges her, holding Adora´s hands and the hem of her tunic, suddenly understanding but too in pain to stand too. “No”

“Either way you will lose her today.” Prime barks, angrier. “I can promise you that”

“Adora, no. It doesn´t have to be you.” Catra begs her, hugging Adora´s legs and holding her ankles when Adora gives a tiny step back.

“He cannot hurt me, Kiki.” Adora reassures her, bending to take Catra´s hands and pressing a kiss over them.

“Adora”

“Creatures like you are destined only for destruction, Adora!”

And fight back

“I love you”

“Adora.” Catra mourns, her face falling inside the nest of her palms as Adora walks away.

It cannot keep going, not anymore. Adora needs to free herself of this, of him, of what he has done to her. She cannot change what happened and cannot heal herself, but she won´t allow him to try and crawl his way inside her life anymore. Not ever again.

He is already wounded, he is already poisoned, he is already bleeding out. He has been rotten for a long time and the Fates have already decided for even longer that he must die.

He will die, but Adora will not allow him from the last words he does. He will not allow him to take anything of her anymore when he is dragged to Tartarus itself. She will not allow him to take the satisfaction of believing that he has broken her, of thinking that he has somehow won over her, of thinking he has stained her or taken her or possessed her.

He, who has been obsessed with her since the first time he glanced at her back through the gardens of her palace. He who thought cursing her would make her unlovable and undesirable for anybody that was not him.

He, who broke the world and was never satisfied because he could never have her, will not lay his eyes on her again. Or his hands, or his breath, or his mouth.

This is all he gets, Adora voice feet away from him, her presence, mighty and beautiful and womanhood in front of him, reducing him into nothing.

“You know, you are pathetic.” Adora spats, the tremor of her body subduing by the strength of her own heart. “You are a pathetic little man”

Prime yells and swings the sword towards her but he is clumsy without a sight and doesn´t even get close.

Instead Adora catches his wrist inside her palm and bends it to the side with a loud pop, her mother´s sword thumbling in the ground near her bare feet.

It would be easy, to bend down and take it, become, do it. Adora loved her mother deeply but she was never like her, not even to the end. Her mother lived from plans and Adora lived from her dreams and in the end the latter will set her free.

“You lost your war, you poor fucker? You were upped handed? By a woman?” Adora swings her arm to the side and throws Prime off, sending him falling against the ground so hard his already wounded ankle bends and breaks completely, making him scream. “Good. I hope she sits on that throne forever. I hope her daughters make it whole again.”

Adora leans down and grabs Prime´s head, just like he had just done to her, just like he had done to Catra. She grabs the rally strands and the edge of the golden crown and rips it whole from his scalp, watching the hairless patches where starvation and cannibalism have made him sick and dying.

Randor´s crown also falls to the ground, the gems thumbling into pieces, the gold scratched. It would also be easy for Adora to place it over her head, to hold it with venomous snakes and call herself queen and king but she was also never like her father.

He thrived in science but in the end he lived by the greed of politics and power. Adora is a scholar and a poet and she lives by the strength of her love. Her love for everything, for the world, for life, for the skies and its celestial children. For Catra.

“You were abandoned by your father? By the gods?” Adora barks, giving slow steps towards him where Prime drags himself backwards, grunting in hate but also in fear. “How does it feel like? How does it feel to be forsaken? Did it hurt? It hurt me. It hurt me so much I thought I would die”

Prime grunts and then whimpers, confused, lost in darkness, finally realizing what he has done to himself, finally realizing that as smart as cunning as he might be, god seed or once blessed, Adora has always been more, so much more.

Adora catches him before he can go anywhere else. She grabs him by the edge of his tunic and digs her own sharp nails over the golden buckles, slicing the metal like parting waters.

The red cape falls into the ground, wrinkled and dirty, smudged with ashes, earth and blood, soaked with the rain that has completely stopped outside and, still, beautiful above it all.

Adam´s cape lays over the burnt earth and the new blooms and it is soft beneath Adora´s soles where she steps over it. Adam was kind and wise, mischievous, loyal to the dead. Loving. Adora is a lot like her brother.

“You turned my parents against me.” Adora tells him, howl at him, holds him accountable, following the trail of his blood. “You cursed me,” she snaps, tears falling but not sobbing. “You threw me here. You defiled my kingdom.”

Adora leans down, holding the fallen Haracles knot inside her fingers, bringing it soiled and burnt but never broken towards her mouth. “You tried to lay your hands on my wife, to break her too. She who is more godly than you could ever dream to be. She who is truly holy. Like me, I am like her.”

Adora grunts, wrapping the knot around her hands, feeling herself big like an ocean, like a sun, like the stars. Still afraid as the presence of fear does not equal the absence of strength. Strength and bravery not in the way that are born from have been broken but in the ways that are born from deep within, from her very soul.

These ones that have accompanied Adora since she was born and that make her who she is. Six years old and dreaming, fifteen years old and a princess, twenty years old and cursed, thirty years old and a wife.

“But you did not stain me and you did not break me and I was not alone. I was never alone”

Adora squats in front of Prime´s convulsing body, still lashing with his nails and her broken body at her, still trying to hurt her no matter how much his self caused blindness pain him.

It´s kind of funny, in a twisted way for Adora who hates him. Catra´s blindness has always been so beautiful, but in Prime his sick attempt to not look at Adora´s cursed eyes makes him horrible.

“You have thought of me?”Adora spats on his face, scowling, sick. Now that she is face to face with him she can see how ugly he is, how insignificant. How afraid. “I have not spared a single thought for you in a long time”

Adora changed herself because of him, she kept quiet, she kept herself afraid, from the world and from herself. And he was nothing. She spoke and was casted again, and he was nothing. She found a life for herself, she fell in love and he remained nothing. Nothing, not at all, not the dirt on her nails nor the mud on her soles nor the smoke on her home.

She is done being quiet, she has had enough.

“After you are dead, I will not ever think about you, ever again, no matter what you do. But you? You will remember me in the Asphodels. You will remember me for eternity. Prime, son of nothing.”

“No!” Prime screams, slamming his hands against his face, trying to touch Adora and unable to do so. “ *You* are a monster”

“I am not.” Medusa, no, Adora whispers. One and the same and still never his. “I am a woman.” She exhales, sweet breath. “I´m a wife.” She embraces herself, maker of life. “I´m still a Princess.” She feels her own body, survivor. “I´m alive. I survived you, and I will do it again”

Adora stands up from the ground looking down at him, right there, kneeling on the floor. She hates him and he is dying, he will die no matter what happens now. She will not give him the mercy of dying by her hand.

“I do not need your redemption.” Adora chants, casting her own protection over herself. Under her teeth, blooms are born too. “Because I didn't do anything wrong”

Prime screams and launches himself towards her but she evades her easily, standing with her red dress and golden serpents in front of him, watching him fall against the ground and lash miserable at her and then at himself.

“Ahahaha.” His neck snaps back and he starts laughing again, all kinds of wrong, and all kinds of dying. “I am a god. I will raise again.”

“You are not.” Adora murmurs, very calm, holding Adam´s red cape against her chest, nuzzling on its warmth. “You are just a man, you are done. And you will never lay your eyes or your hands over me or the world again.”

Prime sputters, thick red blood running down his nostrils and his mouth. Something has changed, something has shifted completely, Adora realizes. In him, in the world, inside this cave. He knows it too.

“Won´t you pity me then, now that I am going to die? Won´t you be the bigger person between us and forgive me so I can cross?” He asks, still smiling through it all.

Adora clicks her sharp teeth together, grunting.

“Prime,” she speaks, loud and clear. “Go to hell”

Outside, on the entrance of the cave, a new sound tricks its way inside. Low, powerful, absolutely dangerous, it breaks through Prime´s ragged breath and Catra and Adora´s calm breathing and drowns everything in silence. A new kind of silence, a dangerous kind, the one that only lives on the heavens after a star is born.

Adora looks towards the dark exterior, past broken and consumed thorns and the shadow of the dead fire. She looks and everything is black, black like nothing she has seen before, black like ooze, black like rotten blood. Black like war, looking at her back with bleeding red eyes.

The hound steps into the quiet cave slowly, almost dragging its humongous paws over the earth scattered with the ashes of the statues, now completely destroyed.

It's huge, bigger than any normal dog or dire wolf Adora has ever seen, so big that when it steps completely inside the cave his back brushes against the pink quartz of the ceiling.

It's back legs are not paws at all, bird claws fused to the body instead of fur, and it's only when Adora catches sight of the black wings soaked in fresh blood at its side that she realizes it is both a hound and a vulture. A hunter, a killer, roaming the sacred land with its beck cradled by pearl serpents.

It's a hound, yes, but it's also fundamentally *wrong,* so detached from what humans consider normal that the plain vision of it makes the breath catch inside Adora's throat, giving a careful step back.

The hunter turns its eyes towards her immediately, sharp and bleeding red and many, many of them cradled on the frame of open human hands that rest over its face, snapping golden teeth at her in a sharp and recognizable stare, regarding her completely.

He is *looking* at her, as gods cannot be afflicted by mortal curses.

Adora has seen this inhuman shape before, many times painted on the murals of the temples in her kingdom. And even if she hadn't seen it before, she thinks she would recognize it anywhere.

“Ares?”

The hound almost seems to *smile* and very slowly bows its head at her before snapping it back to his prey, he who the god has come for, Prime soaked in blood.

Adora throws herself back against the wall of stone and cradles Catra's shivering body inside her arms. She molds herself around her back and holds her tight against her heart, her face pressed against Catra's cheeks and her hands around her heart.

“Adora,” Catra whispers, still covering her eyes with her fingers, the relief that courses through her body palpable for Adora to feel and taste on her very skin.

“I'm here,” Adora whispers back, holding her beloved wife yet still unable to tear her eyes away from the god and his prey until another sound breaks the silence inside.

I was a twin. I was a sibling, a sister to my brother , Adora had said once to Catra. Different kinds of brothers and sisters are waltzing now inside the cavern.

The sizzling sound comes loud as war horns and fleeing to the ones Adora has grown so familiar with for the last years.

These ones are heavy, long, longer, falling with their green and turquoise bodies against the ground, boas the size of rivers slithering their ways across the ground that also regard both Catra and Adora with red eyes.

The feathers follow them, long and stripped, black and also not a single color at all, and by the time Adora has begun to make sense of them she comes face to face with the beautiful face if the goddess Adora used to love and trust above any other, her starry owl eyes blinking directly at hers.

“Athena”

I see salvation but not from your hand

“It´s the gods.” Catra whispers, resting Adora's fingers against her eyes. “They heard you”

This is the time where the gods that forsaked Adora, avenge her.

The gods circle Prime´s broken body on the floor, stepping over the moss soaked in his red blood and squeezing his torn eyeballs under their weight. The hound snaps his fauces together in a chatter that sounds like a funny threat of death, and the owl sizzles loud and clear,flapping her heavy wings against the ground where they dig deep holes filled with dark ooze.

Another sharp sound comes from the entrance and when Adora turns to look at it a flock comes flying violently inside, dozens to hundreds of white birds rushing their way inside the suddenly god-touched cave.

The doves drip pearls on the ground and smell like sea salt and roses, circling each other and then the crown of the gods with their pearlescent feather stretched from side to side until they too look like the seafoam of an incoming wave, dropping their breaks open when they start to sing.

Sin, they are singing, that's what Adora and Catra can hear, holding to each other against the rock like life lines. Except that the doves are not singing at all, nor cooing. They are screaming.

Prime covers his bleeding ears with his palms and starts yelling too, slamming his hands and the crumbled rocks against his forehead and face over and over again, trying to drown the sounds down. Adora cannot hear them but the doves mirror the screams of all those souls Prime has broken and killed; all the innocent and the sinners too, every single one from the voice of his mother who was the first to the very last of them, repeating like shields smashing against each other and war horns across the cave and inside his very head.

They follow him wherever he goes, torturing him, reminding him of all the love he has taken, all the lives he has ended, the very cracks of the earth he has broken, over and over again until his empty eye sockets, his ears and his nose are bleeding from different reasons than mortal wounds. This is Aphrodite´s rage, the twisted gift of returning all the pain he has caused.

Something soft tickles on Adora´s hand and when she locks down from the grotesque scene to catch what it is she realizes they are vines, of soft leaves and even softer flowers, finding their way up and up around her wrists and through her arms,

Adora gasps, feeling them travel through her nape and around the wounded and dying bodies of the serpents on her head, and when they touch them, they shake alive again, spared by some kind of divine force from the goddess that has given them to an unknowing Adora on the first place.

When Adora looks down at Catra, filled with terror and wonder at the very same time, she can see them too traveling across her beautiful body, surrounding her head in lilac blooms

like the wisterias that hang from their bed; tender petals falling over her closed eyes and keeping her warm.

This is not Catra´s doing, this is beyond, a gentle hand from Catra´s blood, a mother that already has lost an immortal daughter once, and then a mortal one right after. A grandmother that for the first time in many years gets to touch her child and her lover, sprouting green life everywhere she goes.

Demeter is, however, also full of rage, and when Adora follows the path of the roots sprouting long and twisted from the ground, she sees the way they are void of leaves and filled with thorns sharp as iron swords. She sees them lashing against each other and throwing their ways against Prime´s convulsing body, wrapping too around his wrists and libs yet holding him down instead of soothing him.

They hold him down in the way he held Adora, in the way he held Catra, in the way he held many others, a herald of death. With the intent to hurt.

A god

The gods chant, one by one and then all together, joining their ethereal voices in something that makes the very foundations of the earth to shake.

A man

They circle and circle Prime´s small and terrified body until he is nothing, until he looks like nothing. A broken man fallen on the floor by women's hand, surrounded by the consequences of his own greed.

Father has lost his bet on you

If you were to look very close, you would see the dark thread of his own life surrounding him, trapping him, choking him when it pulls back. Time is a curious thing and the older sister of life is a curious woman too, pulling and twisting from the thread wondering how much it can hold on, running the edge of her scissor against the thread like he did with many before, cutting the natural curse of their lives with his blood soaked hands.

Suddenly Adora is very, very cold. Suddenly the cave is submerged by a cold so deep that it wraps itself against her very bones and makes her breath visible and white among the shadows, rising in fog that dissolves into nothing almost immediately.

In her arms Catra trembles too, and Adora hears her hold her breath when Adora holds her even closer, hearing the last of the godly visitors step inside before Adora does.

A pair of dark feet stop in front of them, dark skin, so dark that she might as well have taken the heavens and wrapped it around her celestial bodies. A dark and supple skin scattered with clusters of stars and nebulas, alive on her very soles and limbs, cradled by the long peacock feathers of her ethereal dress.

Adora gasps and closes her eyes immediately, feeling herself overwhelmed with the apparition in front of her. She wraps her arms completely across Catra´s head and chest and tucks her as deep as possible against her chest, Adora absorbs Catra´s lean body inside and covers her with hers, shielding her of whatever is to come now that the Queen of the Heavens is looking at them directly from her throne of glass.

Adora expects many things and none at all, after all she was forsaken for many years, after all she was betrayed, things that cannot be taken back or forgotten. After all, her faith lives in Catra´s unbendable trust in them. She doesn´t expect the ethereal hand that rests right above her head with the weight of a feather and the entire world, nor the words whispered to the both of them.

You both are woman, Hera says, **You bow to no one**

Adora opens her eyes and she finds the universe looking back at her, between Adora´s changed face and her wife, a smile stretching in the inexistent mouth of the goddess of marriage.

Honor each other and you will survive this

She is benevolent, as queens are, but when she turns around to face Prime she changes, she becomes terrible, beautiful as the sky and as dangerous as the new lives of stars.

She hates them all, every single sprout of her husband's betrayals, but she hates this one a little bit more than the others, despises him, spits at his name. Pours poison out of her body when she leans towards him, covering his scared body with a darkness so thick he will never be able to forget it no matter where he is. She has, after all, been waiting for a long, long time for this.

You can die now

The hound shoots forward and snaps his fauces around Prime´s arms, digging sharp golden teeth against mortal flesh and tearing up from him until the muscle and the bone, fracturing in splinters yet with not enough force to rip it apart completely, as the hound of war sometimes likes to play with his food.

“No. No!” Prime screams, from suffering and pain and from sheer fear. “I am your brother! I am your blood!”

You are human, the owl descends over him, her scarred arm sharp where he cut it open years ago, her sharp claws painting red lines over his chest. **The Fates have decided for you**

Adora stares and holds Catra´s hands as the gods descend over him like hungry animals, like starving creatures, like shadows, blinding him in other ways than by his own hands, choking him, cursing him, breaking him.

“Adora, help me!” Prime screams amongst the gods' bodies, torn apart alive. “Adora! Tell them you forgive me! Tell them to have mercy!”

The gods stop, for a moment, for a breath,for the split of a universe, turning their galaxy eyes towards Adora´s golden ones. Waiting for her.

Catra tangles her fingers around Adora´s and holds her gently, so very gently, resting her warm mouth and calm breath against her skin, even amongst the sounds of the carnage. She is an anchor, for Adora, a plea of a gentle life and also a reminder that she owns nothing to anyone.

Adora holds her back and grinds her teeth, turning the last of his hope into stone with her voice alone.

“You don´t deserve my mercy”

Each one of the gods take a part of him for themselves and drag him across the sharp floor of the cave, grunting, sizzling and screaming unholy curses to the air he is dragged outside to be feasted upon, like errand spirits roaming the earth, about to pull a condemned soul into the pits of the Tartarus into eternal suffering.

Adora hears him scream and scream and scream first inside the cave, then outside, then across the entire earth, hound and peacock, dove and serpent eating their ways inside his flesh and his bones, sucking him dry from any kind of life or blood, either human or immortal.

He will die today and he will suffer greatly until the Fate cuts down his thread finally. He will not be buried, he will not be honored. He will be forgotten. This is how it was written, eons ago.

Adora presses her cheek against Catra´s and narrows her eyes as she sees him gone, splintered, done, out of her life completely now, like a thorn, like a scratch,like a bruise, fading from her skin as a severed hand.

She exhales, tears finally spilling free from her eyes or maybe already falling from a long while ago, she is not sure. They gather on her eyelashes and drip heavily across her cheeks and against Catra´s, who holds Adora´s palms between hers and kisses them.

Her body is still shivering violently inside Adora´s hold and the soft movement rips Adora completely from other thoughts, nuzzling her nose against Catra´s temples and the curve of her soft eyelashes.

“Kiki,” Adora calls for her sweetly, relief falling over her with so much strength that she forgets about everything else. “It´s alright. He is gone, he is actually gone”

“I know,” Catra whispers, running her soft fingers up and down Adora´s where they still hover in front of her face.

Adora starts taking them away gently, fixed on checking Catra´s wounds and ignoring her own. Catra shoots forwards immediately and grasps Adora´s hands even tighter, pressing them against her face as if she wanted to learn them all over again.

“No,” Catra begs just for a second longer, just one. “Please stay”

“Kiki, what—”

The sound of twigs breaking in the middle rip Adora´s attention and when she turns around she comes face to face with the owl eyes of Athena, crystal blue and green and golden and so many more, observing her with all the knowledge and all the wisdom in the universe as if there were a thousand and one things she wanted to say to Adora and she could not say a single one.

She looks at Adora´s face precariously, studying her, and then down between her arms where Catra rests, and for the split of a second Adora thinks she can see in her an emotion so raw that she looks almost frighteningly human.

This is how it must be there is no other way, she whispers breaking Adora´s heart with it, **I am sorry**

This is and will be the only devotion of your heart. It will be your greatest joy and your most tender sorrow.

Adora watches her go in a swirl of fallen feathers and sizzling golden serpents, her eyes sore and raw and her heart beating with so much strength inside her heart that she thinks it might rip through the flesh of her chest or stop all together,

Slowly, very slowly, Adora returns her eyes towards Catra, Kiki, beloved wife, dear friend. All the love of her heart and all the joy of her soul; her life, her strength and the sweetness of her devotion.

Catra, with her beautiful long hair matted against her temples and the gentle back of her neck with sweat and ashes. Catra with her dark skin scattered in freckles that Adora knows like the back of her hands. Catra with her hands that have seen and touched the world and through which she has learnt it in deeper ways than she has ever known.

Catra, with her white tunic like a dove, not like the twisted white of Prime but in a gentle one, like clouds, like seafoam, like pearls. Catra with her twitching ears pressed to the sides of her head and her face stained by the shimmering gold of Athena's blood, swirling inside her bloodstream too.

Catra, holding Adora´s battered and scarred hands in front of her face, running her fingertips through the patched skin, the sun freckles, the moles, the tiny scars, Adora´s nails and the heel of her palm and the lines inside. Learning them, searing them in her mind and her soul, touching them filled to the brim with love.

Watching them with her eyes wide open.

“Oh.” Adora exhales, her mind and heart coming to a halt.

“No,” Catra is whispering, mourning, very softly under her breath, shaking her hand as she caresses Adora´s hands with all her love. “Oh, no. No”

“You can see”

And in the end, you will need to let her go

It's involuntary, actually, instinct almost when Adora let´s go of her completely. She snaps her hands and arms from around Catra´s body and scrambles backwards on the ash floor, dragging herself away, away, *away,* through broken rock and consumed fire and sharp ground, slicing the distance between them all over again. Separating them, breaking them, splintering them in the middle.

Adora has gone through many kinds of suffering before, she has never felt quite a pain like this, not once in her life.

The pain of a soul being broken into two and pulled apart.

Catra swings in her knees immediately and turns to look back at Adora, also by instinct, also without thinking, her beautiful eyes open and her face streaming with golden tears. But Adora does not see any of them; she curls on the ground and around herself with her arms around her face and closes her eyes until they ache, until they burn, digging her fingers against the scared bodies of the serpents to keep herself from ever looking again at the face of the person she loves the most.

Catra gasps in realization the second she sees, *sees,* Adora curling away from her, snapping her hand away and hiding her face among the ashes and the destruction that has been left of their home.

She must be dizzy, she must be confused, terrified even as the world unfolds in front of her as a blooming flower. She must be scared beyond reason, seeing this for the very first time, the dark cave, the ragged stones, the blackened quartz. She needs Adora now more than ever she needs it. This Adora knows.

But she cannot bring herself to look up, to move, to stop crying inside the hollow of her arms, stuck in a single moment. Because doing it would be a death sentence, Adora is a death sentence now, her golden eyes raising a barrier between them that did not existed before, crumbling the foundations of her heart as she hears Catra take a sharp breath and a heartbreaking sobs before she is moving again, across the cave and with no hesitation at all.

It must be madness what makes Adora look, insanity and also the overwhelming amount of her love for her what makes Adora look back, just a little, just a tilt through the spaces between the fingers she presses against her face.

Out of the corner of her cursed eyes, Adora sees Catra crawling over the floor, her tunics torn apart on the hem, her hands and soles scratched up, reaching for the handle of the knife still blood soaked and still scattered on the floor, dripping red and golden blood as Catra lifts it up without stopping for a single beat and brings it to her eyes

“No!” Adora screams or maybe just whispers, throwing herself fully across the cave too, catching Catra by her ankles and dragging her back against the ground, the knife knocked aside with a loud ring. “No. Catra don´t do this!”

“I don´t care!” Catra screams around a mouthful of ashes and her own blood, crawling into the loose stone until her nails splinter. “I don´t care! I´ll gouge my eyes out too if I need to!”

Catra kicks at Adora´s face, catching her in the chin with enough force that Adora lets her go with the surprise of the hit. Catra doesn´t hesitate for a second longer, stretching herself impossible long until she manages to grab the golden handle of the knife once again, slipping through her fingers with the lingering blood and the way she is trembling so violently it makes her teeth shake.

Adora shakes herself alert again and this time, when she throws herself at Catra, she does so fully, wrapping her entire body around her back. Adora grasps Catra´s wrist with so much strength that she knows the skin will bruise and presses her other palm tightly over Catra´s beautiful and holy eyes, grunting when Catra slashes the knife towards her own face and only catches Adora´s skin instead.

“Drop it!” Adora roars, shaking Catra so strongly their bones protest between them. “Catra, drop it!”

“Get off me!” Catra fights her back, violently, crude, raw. She lashes her nails and teeth against Adora´s skin and slams her head against her cheekbones and tries to push her away until her body is also screaming from pain and they are both panting and aching down to their very souls. “No!”

“Stop! No!”

Adora grabs Catra´s wrist and slams it on the floor, snatching the handle of the knife off her fingers and throwing it away from them, so far away it clicks against the stone wall and loses itself among debris and moss.

Catra cries out, out of rage, out of pain, fighting tooth and nail against Adora´s fierce hold to try and reach the blade again and finding herself completely incapable to. They are both exhausted to the bone yet when they fight each other, today in this once golden day, they are the strongest both of them can be.

One to try to sacrifice herself, the other one to keep her from it.

“No! No! Get off me, let me do it!” Catra gasps, seizing the trembling serpents and pulling from them, begging them too to eat her eyes and allow her to sink into a darkness where they can touch each other freely again. “Let me do it!”

“No.” Adora whispers, resting her cheek against Catra´s nape, there where she cannot see her face. There, where she cannot hurt her. “No, my love”

Adora hugs her as tight as she possibly can, one arm across her chest, the other firmly pressed over Catra´s eyes, keeping her from opening her eyes or turning around no matter how much she tries. Caressing her soft eyelashes that Adora has kissed thousands of times before and felt with her lips, now soaked in unstoppable tears..

“Don´t send me away,” Catra weeps, holding Adora´s wrists inside her fingers when she realizes Adora will simply not move away.

Adora shakes her head very gently against her neck, letting her own stream of tears take their course. They will never stop now, ever. From now on, Adora will cry for the rest of her life.

“You can´t stay, love”

“I can!” Catra is screaming again, tearing from her beautiful vocal cords until they are shredded and Adora wishes she could turn into liquid and slip inside her skin and bones where she cannot see her but can always be near her heart. “I can. If you won´t let me tear my eyes out then I'll tie a rope around my face. I´ll do it, every single day of my life.”

“No, sweetheart.” Adora laments, kissing the cluster of freckles on Catra´s back, drinking of every single second as they are precious, as they are about to come to an end. “You are healed”

“I'm not healed of anything!”

Catra tries to dig her nails in her eyes out again but Adora covers her with her hand, not even grunting when Catra starches the back of Adora's knuckles instead. In fact, Adora welcomes them, everything, anything she can keep from her wife, she will take it.

“I´m going to hurt you one day.” Adora tells her, explains her, soothing her when Catra´s sobs turn into a wail. “It will be an accident, a slip. We are going to desire to reach for each other and I will turn you into stone.” Adora smiles without an ounce of happiness on it, caressing Catra´s abdomen over the fabric and feeling her breath against her. “You know I'm right”

It has happened, it truly has happened. Adora´s time, their time has come to an end. The Oracle warned her, she told her many years ago what was to happen, what the Fates had also known for even longer.

It´s unfair and she cannot understand it, why, *why* , why now after so long? Why now that Adora is free from him? What kind of punishment do they have to pay just for the desire to be together forever? Why now? Why ever? Why?

But she had the world, Adora had the whole world and the entire skies on the palm of her hands for many years, so little still. She had it all, that's true, in the laughter of her wife and in the smell of her skin. Adora had the sun, the stars, the ellipses, the green springs, she had them. They were hers, they were Catra´s, both of them.

She never doubted their love, from catra´s love, and in the end it protected them. It will not allow them to remain together, but it protected them. Adora might turn into a different kind of stone once Catra is gone, but she loved fiercely and she was loved in return.

“Catra, I understand Orpheus now.” Adora whispers, catching every single tear in her fingertips. “I love you so much, so I will always turn around. I will always look back”

Because to turn around, is to love.

“Don´t do this.” Catra pleads, shaking her head as she undoes herself in tears. “Don´t”

“You need to leave”

“No”

“I´m sorry,” Aora chokes, unable to hold for long the unavoidable pain that Catra´s departure will bring. “I´m so sorry. Catra, if you stay I'm going to kill you. And if you die, Catra if you die I will not survive it.” Adora gasps, trying to catch her breath, trying not to crumble under the pain. “You are my sun, you are my light, Catra. You need to live, I need you alive”

Catra shakes her head, denies, refuses with every fiber of her being. Her hands curl into fists over the ground and the green grass and moss dies immediately after, the very earth feeling the amounts of her pain.

“Let me be stone.” Catra shivers and so does Adora, two halves of the same whole. “Let me be stone to gaze at you forever.” She breaks, completely breaks, watching the war darkness that Adora´s hands bring and feeling herself undone like a river, set adrift without an anchor, “I lied. I lied Adora, I cannot live without you”

Adora cannot help herself but to cry. Cry and cry until she cannot do it any longer and still the tears remain. Cry because it´s not fair, *it´s not fair,* they are married, they love each other, they have each other. What are gods then if they cannot fix this? What are gods then if they allow it to happen?

Why?

“Let me stay.” Catra nuzzles against Adora´s touch, also chasing for every single second, also seeking for eternity in one moment. “Just a little bit longer”

“We can’t.” Adora kisses her head, hoping the touch alone will tell Catra just how much she adores her. “It's over, this is it Kiki. This is the time. This is how your last story ends. It's time to wake up”

Catra crumbles against the ground and Adora catches her, this time, she is the one that keeps her from falling. Adora is safe, the monster is gone, they are here, they are alive. And Catra? Catra can also live now. Adora can give her this last gift to her, a place where she doesn´t dare to go still.

“Adora.” Catra chants, almost not even a word anymore from how softly and yearning she says it. “Adora, I love you. I love you, please no. Please”

“I´m sorry.” Adora might not survive this but Catra will, and that's the only thing Adora thinks she needs. She still has a little bit to learn. “It's you who has to leave this time my love”

They cry in each other's arms, is the only thing they can possibly do right now.

Adora kisses all the way across Catra´s shoulder blades and her neck, not once uncovering her eyes. And Catra kisses deep and profound the skin of Adora´s palms and her wrists, loving her unconditionally even amongst the pits of despair.

“I can take you home.” Catra pleads but Adora just smiles, looking at their joined reflection on the back of the golden shield.

“But you already did.” She soothes her, splitting them apart. “The rest are flowers”



Adora packs for her.

It´s a slow task, long, painful. Murderous.

If they hadn´t love each other this strongly, Adora would not be able to do it at all.

Adora grabs the satchels scattered in their cavern and gently places them in the ground, filling them with clean tunics neatly folded, sandals and blankets. She fills them with soft jewelry and pearls and the veils they wore on their wedding day, all of them carefully taken care of and made anew of the sweet years they lived in here.

She fills the other satchel with food, all of them to the very last bread, fruit and meat. None stays here, Adora doesn´t want it and she doesn´t know how the world is out there, now that the rot has been pulled from the root. As long as Catra can be safe and healthy, she doesn´t care much about anything else.

Adora does it all little by little but never stopping, not even once, not to think or to hesitate or to doubt. If she does so she knows she will break. If she stops to think about what is happening, truly happening even for the tiniest of minutes, Adora will not be able to keep going with it.

And she needs to, she knows she needs to. She loves Catra more than anything else, more than her fear for the unknown, more than her pain for the incoming solitude, more than the suffering from her departure. She loves Catra, likes she loves life itself and Adora has always loved fully, with her entire chest.

She loves her enough to let her go, she doesn´t know how to follow her behind. She doesn´t know how to leave this place too so she stays. This is how their journey goes.

The Fates watch, quiet. Waiting.

Adora steps on the mosaics of the small stairs to the temple and allows herself to hesitate just once, standing still in the entrance of the temple where she can see Catra sitting quietly and unmoving on the edge of the bed.

Her hair is undone, her cheeks wet where the clean cloth that Adora ran through her face and her own tears leave paths like the stone on the ground across her skin.

She is wearing the purple tunic she wore on their wedding day,because she asked Adora to. She begged her under her breath and Adora could not do more but to say yes. Out of all things she cannot give her, like staying or going with her, Adora can give her this.

She slipped the messed up white tunic off her body and cleaned her body too, fresh with water and olive smelling, little by little across every tiny patch of bruised skin and healing scratched. All of them almost completely cured, as a goddess blood can do for someone. As Athena´s blood did for Catra.

Adora is grateful for that, in a way. After all the ways in which the goddess failed her, she could do this for her. Adora doesn´t yet understand why it was made and why it´s still unfair. As it was said, whispered between Fates, both Catra and Adora have a little bit more to learn.

Catra´s face is tilted down, towards her joined hands resting over her lap. She cannot see anything beyond unwavering darkness, her eyes hidden away by the thick fabric Adora had wrapped around her face before daring to move from the cave to the cavern.

The cloth is red, torn from the hem of Adora´s dress, red and beautiful and Adora can see the spots of tears in it, mingling with the golden embroidering and the soft thread. It´s, a lot, like a mirror of their life right now, beautiful, love made, cut short too soon.

Adora takes a shivering breath and tries with all her strength not to think, sinking into her knees in front of Catra. She holds her breath and very gently places her own hemation around her shoulder, blue and golden and beautiful, testimony of a life of love and beauty, wrapping her shivering shoulders and cold skin inside the warm fabric.

She hopes, somehow and a little bit selfish, that it will be able to bring Catra comfort when Adora is not there anymore. She hopes it will keep her warm and shielded. She hopes Catra will remember her through it.

“I love you.” Adora whispers, resting her forehead against Catra´s covered face. “I´m sorry”

She wishes she could tell Catra all she feels inside right now. The lengths of her sadness, of her sorrow, the way is killing her from the inside out, the way is like physically tearing her heart out of her arms.

She wishes she could throw herself to her knees like she is doing right now and tell her about her fear, her terror that one that never left her no matter how much she tried, how much she healed, how high she raised above the ones that had harmed her.

A kind of fear that is consuming her because its presence could mean Catra´s death. Because allowing herself, Adora, to ignore it and follow Catra behind like a spirit out of the underworld might bring Catra doom, so Adora chooses for her sorrow instead.

A kind of fear that chokes, that consumes her, drowns her, that no matter how many years go by, doesn´t seem to let her go, to drop this single thread where Adora is pulled from its existence and Catra and where the first seems to win today.

She wishes she could but she knows Catra already knows too. And she is so quiet right now, quiet like the cavern, quiet like the water, quiet like a moon; silently wrapping her arms around Adora´s neck and holding her close.

Adora carries her in her arms, all the way across the cavern and towards the entrance. She takes her time too, little by little, letting Catra soak on the sounds of a place Adora knows Catra adores. The waterfall, the lake, the breeze on the trees, the chirping birds, soles against the stone and the moss and grass too.

Catra knows Adora is doing it on purpose too because she has known Adora for six years, for even more inside her dreams. She holds Adora tighter by the back of her neck and nuzzles her nose against Adora's jaw, breathing her in fully.

The snakes kiss their way all over Catra´s face, gentle too and just as loving, distracting her as Adora walks through the broken statues in the cave and the burnt ground already scattering itself all over again with green and life.

When they reach the open mouth of the cave Adora hesitates again, just for one moment, staring at the world beyond that she has not seen in a decade and that now seems to receive her with open arms when she finally braves herself to step outside.

The world is… sad.

Sad and unknown, breathing dying breaths yet still refusing to give up.

There is no grass here, no moss. The rivers nearby are dry and the trees are thin and sick, naked from fruits or leaves and barely standing in crackling bark and trunks.

The air is freezing cold and the skies are grey, no longer virulent red or purple now that the celestial war is also over, but still heavy with some kind of sorrow that clusters clouds all over the heavens and hide the sun from sight, no matter how much Adora tries to gaze at it again.

The world is sad and cold but it's not burning anymore, it's no longer red, no longer poisoned, no longer consuming itself from the inside out. A dry world with no flowers and eternal winter, where life might just start again.

For a moment, Adora thinks she will see him there, the remains of him maybe, but she finds none. No blood, no bones, no ripped flesh. And as much as Adora hated him, she feels relief; she feels relief that the gods have at least granted her this, to drag his dead body away from her lands and dispose of it as coal or ash. As nothing, no matter what he has done.

Adora takes Catra to a deep part of the forest, past twisted roots and fallen trees, where the soft earth is kinder and where she knows Catra won´t know her way back.

She doesn´t even know what the entrance of the cavern looks like.

Adora walks and walks until she finds a small meadow, void of life too but gentler, with the earth below her feet soft by the previous and oh so awaited for rain and the patched of ground

tender when Adora rests her soles over them.

She lowers them both carefully towards the ground and places Catra's body over the soft earth, holding her breath where Catra clings into her like a second skin.

It's not a surprise for Adora, but the world changes the moment Catra meets it again. The very second her bare soles touch the earth, green moss and grass starts sprouting everywhere around the meadow, crawling over the dying trees and bringing them to life again.

Pushing tiny blooms, waiting blooms, of a tender blue from the earth and the dew and filling everything almost immediately with its smell, with the lemongrass in the floor and the wisteria blooming above their heads.

Adora watches them grow and spread with a tiny exhale and an even tinier smile, and wonders if this is how the earth felt every time Persephone was released from the claws of the Underworld, from the depths of darkness where unholy creatures are casted.

She wonders if maybe they are not so different after all but then again, even amongst the heartbreak, Adora knows she is holy too because Catra loves her and all Catra loves must be beautiful too.

In this meadow where willows and wisterias live at her touch, Adora places the joy of her heart and the love of her life over the pillows made of daisies and moss, letting go from her yet not completely. Not just now, holding her deep and sweet against her heart.

Just a second, just one more , Adora thinks, cradling Catra's beloved face inside her palms.

“I love you. More than anything” Adora vows, because that is the only thing she can do right now, trust the love of her life into a world that loves her and pray that she will be alright. “Please leave, and please, live all what this life can give you, my love. Live in peace”

Catra´s breath hitches in her throat, her teeth grinding together sharply. She is holding herself strongly to the soft grass beneath her hands, pulling chunks of green earth between her nails. She is not crying anymore but she is trembling violently in Adora´s hands, the skin of her body raised in goosebumps and her red mouth shut so tight her skin turns pale under the pressure.

Adora´s eyebrows knit on her frown, the reality of what is happening starting to weigh down on her. It pushes and pushes and crushes her down, stealing the breath from her lungs and choking her out of her bravery. Breaking Adora in so many little pieces that she doesn´t know, after all, how she is going to survive after this.

“It´s alright.” Adora hums, more for Catra´s sake than for herself, whispering a sweet lullaby for her. “You are ready, my love. You can do this. You will survive this too.”

Adora leans her forehead against Catra´sand breathes her in, as deeply as she can, gathering her smell, her touch and her warmth all inside her heart one last time before letting her hands slip down her dear cheeks and chin, caressing gently the fall of her jaw as they leave her completely.

Catra, though, Catra is not ready, she never will. She catches Adora´s wrists inside her hands and lowers them down over her lap, waving their fingers together as tightly as she does with her tapestries, holding the strands of their life between her fingers.

“No.” Catra snaps, her entire face wrinkling with despair.

“You can´t stay.” Adora can´t help but to sob in front of her, pleading. “Kiki, I love you. I love you. And I know you are angry and you will hate me for this and I will love you forever.” Adora brings Catra´s hand up and kisses her knuckles, the serpents kissing her cheeks and ears too. “Take it all with you”

Adora tries to drop Catra´s hands again but Catra denies it to her, holding Adora´s fingers and wrists with so much strength they might just bruise, pulling her back towards her.

“I said no”

“Catra—”

“Listen to me.” Catra snaps, her breath sweet and quick. This time she is the one who cradles Adora´s face between her hands, tight, pressing her thumbs beneath Adora´s eyes and cupping her cheeks and her jaw. “You have to live”

Adora gasps, the plea and the command slipping inside her bones like a wedding vow all of it ´s own.

“Do you understand me, Adora? You're not allowed to let yourself die. You have to be strong and you have to live. For my sake.” Catra begs, orders, prays to Adora. Her sharp teeth are grinding against each other forcefully and her voice is firm, not wavering not anymore.

This is important, this is everything, a prophecy all of their own.

“You have to choose me. Choose me and live.” Catra´s breath catches on her throat, almost breaking her, barely keeping them intact. “And you have to find your way back to me. I don't care how, I don't care when, just come *back* .”

Adora sobs, resting her cheeks against Catra´s soft hands, remembering every single crevice of them as she loves them more than anything.

“Promise it”

“Kiki”

“Promise it!” Catra exclaims, losing the war against the tears that soak past the thick blindfold and down her cheeks.

Adora gathers every single tear drop off her cheeks and into her fingertips instead and tilts her head with a small sighs, nodding. “I promise”

Catra calls her to her and Adora answers, just one more time, unable to keep themselves apart. They press their lips together and open their mouths against each other, pouring the

sweetness of each other's throat inside their tongues and the strength of the love they have for each other inside the other´s heart.

Catra cries and Adora cries freely too, tears meeting as well and skin and hands, embracing each other over flowers and moss and the lingering promise held between each other like a knot.

Catra presses tiny kisses all over Adora mouth and rests her nose over the divot between her eyes and the bridge of her nose, trusting her freely even if a slip of the eye would mean her death. Catra has never cared about that, has always accepted it no matter what as long as she can stay with Adora. But Adora does care and so Catra has to leave.

“I´ll be waiting for you, in the meadows.” Catra whispers, sobbing when Adora leans back, running the pads of her fingers gently over the red blindfold beneath which she knows Catra ´s eyes lay.

“Close your eyes.”

Catra feels it in the air, in the earth, in the foundations of the trees and the warmth of the sun. She feels it, kneeling in soft grass, the exact moment in which Adora leans back, the exact second she rests her weight on her soles, the exact thread of breath where she steps back and back, not daring to turn around.

Catra tears the blindfold off, sauntering sadly over her lap when she looks with new eyes at the world around her.

“Adora.” A hiccup. A sob. “Adora”

Golden light meets her but Adora is not there anymore.

It's sooner than later that I'm six feet under

It's sooner than later that you'll be alone

So who will you turn to tomorrow? I wonder

For when the bell rings, lover, you're on your own

—*The Ballad of Lucy Baird,* **Rachel Zegler**

Chapter End Notes

In my defense, the Penelope and Orpheus foreshadowing has been there the entire time. You were only too in love to want to turn around.

But to turn around is to love.

Verse XIII

Chapter Notes

Hello :)
Welcome to the second to last chapter of this story ;.; I cannot believe how quick time has gone by and how fast we are approaching the end, but alas, things sooner or later have to end. Or to start :)

I know I left you in a sorrowful note last time and I apologize. But things have to happen this way, believe me and trust me.

Without much more to say, I leave you here with them :) Much love

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Verse **XIII. Ellipses**

Deep in the meadow, under the willow

A bed of grass, a soft green pillow

Lay down your head and close your eyes

And when they open, the sun will rise [...]

Here your dreams are sweet and tomorrow brings them true

Here is the place where I love you

— *Deep in the Meadow*, **The Hunger Games**

There is a woman hidden on the corners of the cave.

The walls are warm, the ceiling no longer dripping with debris and freezing tear drops of water, scattered in rose quartz. The ground is covered in green grass, the statues are broken and fallen and whatever remained from them is cradled in moss. There are flowers under her soles.

The air smells like ripe fruit and past happiness. Like fresh water and lemongrass. Like old stone washed in sunlight.

There is a woman curled up on the floor, knees pressed to the chest, arms around her face. There are wisteria petals crushed under her feet, painting her skin in purples. Her skin is covered by marks, old but then also new. Mark made by love; sun freckles, moles and hidden kisses. Swirls and dots from yellow and maroon inks and rings and bracelets of gold around her wrists.

There is sun under here, sunlight, golden rays that bring warmth with their touch. There are greens, yellows and blues. There weren't, before, but there are now. They are little testimonies, little reminders, of a life lived in here. Of the memory of love, of the strength of it. Of the capability of letting go, of the belief that not looking back will save them, of the realization that looking back is the purest act of love she could ever do.

There is a woman running her hands through her head, tending to them, healing them, braiding them, caressing them again, not bleeding herself into the floor or ripping herself apart until she can't do it anymore. She promised she wouldn't do it, she promised she would love them, for her love loved them too.

The fear remains in her, keeping her from following her behind, forever rooted on her bones. But something else rises inside her chest, inside her soul, maybe even stronger than fear itself.

The walls are warm, the water cradles like songs. There are stones no longer shaped as fake heroes all around her, casting golden shadows like the gods that had once carried her and later had forsaken her; that had avenged her and who could not stop the fate from happening. Shadows that do not matter anymore.

They don't surround her anymore. Their heavy hands cannot trap her, inside this exile that was meant to be a grave for herself and then became a home.

There is a woman sitting on the floor, her eyes no longer blue cradled under the sun painted skin of her cheeks and her palms. She was a demon. She is a princess. She is a wife.

There is a woman resting over soft grass, over green moss, cradled by blue and amber flowers that surround her body like little protectors of her life and her heart. She lays on her side with her arms under her head and over the ground, feeling the soft earth gather below her fingernails and across her palms.

Her dress is purple, slightly shorter in the hem, belonging to the only woman she will ever love. Her hands are long, her skin healed, her soles bare. She wears a knot around her waist and the pin of a wig next to her heart, the belongings of the people she loves living over her body, keeping her alive.

Alive, she is alive. She is heartbroken, she is in pain, an unbelievable kind of pain that almost doesn´t allow her to breath, that almost makes her wish she did not exist. But she is here, laying in grasp, the breath of life exhaled inside her lungs from the mouth of her wife. An unbreakable kind of promise she cannot defy.

She is stuck in time, paralyzed by fear and torn apart by the quiet loneliness of the stone walls, but she is alive.

There is a woman, resting over the stone paths, her head tilted to the sky, to the light pouring from open domes, her body wrapped in red hemations, her back towards the open mouth of her liberation. Her head hangs heavy and still over her shoulder, golden serpents slithering their way over stone and earth.

The sizzle, they sing, tiny lullabies of the half of a soul they miss. They mourn too, they ache, they might die too if they didn´t love her so deeply too. Instead they ring like gold coins and like sweet bells. The woman closes her eyes and opens her mouth, joining them too.

She sings, songs she did not know before, songs she learnt through years and love. Songs about despair, songs about hope, songs that she prays will guide her where she has been lost, where she cannot find herself anymore.

She sings and lays on the floor hearing the echo of her own. She is alive and this body is her own, the hand hovering above her like a sword wanting to rip her head does not exist anymore. She should be free but she is not, not just yet.

She misses something vital, something important; the core, the foundations of her very life and her very soul, she is missing them. She let it go, let *her* go hoping the distance would mean freedom for the one she loves but now she wonders is it´s just punishment, for the both of them.

There is a woman, floating on the surface of the lake, her clothes soaked, her face painted by light, her arms at her sides. She cannot drown, love keeps her afloat.

There is a woman, curled on the sheets of an olive tree that became a marital bed. She wraps herself in beauty and wraps herself in snakes. She breathes from the smell on the pillows and surrounds herself with it.

There is a woman, sitting at the foot of a loom. She pulls the threads of an unfinished tapestry and wonders, if she undoes them all one by one, if she will also be able to undo what she had done.

There is a woman in the ground of a living cavern surrounded by trees, opening her eyes again, looking back at herself through the reflection of the mirror. And there, she doesn´t not gaze at a monster, or a murderer or a bringer of death; she does not gaze at a bad omen, or a sinner, or a cursed soul. Someone destined for solitude instead of sun; someone doomed for quiet instead of laughter.

It´s been eleven years, maybe longer as she doesn´t know how long she has been resting here, sleeping over the dew. But finally, finally, she looks at herself and all she sees is healthy skin, all she sees are pale eyelashes, all she sees are almond eyes, all she sees are lines of laughter and past smiles. She looks and all she sees are purple clothes and fingertips of a lover's hands and the berry kisses pressed on her mouth.

Finally, the woman lying in the grass looks at herself and all she sees is love.

There is a woman in a cavern washed by sunlight, she turns around in her ankles. She looks back.

This time, she is the one who choses.

There is a woman, chasing sunlight. If you look at her eyes, her love might free you from the stone.



For Catra the world is blue. Blue in a way that welcomes her, but she doesn't know it yet.

We are so close to the beginning even though it feels like an end.

Catra doesn´t know the colors.

She learnt them of course, once upon a time and long, long ago. She learnt their names, she learnt about their existence in all things, in the world. But even as a child she could never place a solid image to them, never could associate them with their real meaning.

She learnt colors in a different way, in the way the dye would feel over the strands of wool and cotton. In the way of smells, of sensations, of taste, of words. She learnt them, she never knew them.

Catra doesn´t know the color of the grass between her fingertips. Green, it must be because she knows most grass is green, and because she knows this is grass in the way it feels against her skin. But then again there are so many tones on this so-called grass, so many besides this possible green. Lighter, darker, crisp, soft, dry and damp in dew.

Catra can see them, but she cannot put a name to them. In a way, it reflects the way in which, even with a sight she is the most lost in the world that she has ever been in her entire life.

She can see, *see gods be damned,* so many other things all around. Tall structures circling the place where she has been laid to rest, with surfaces wrinkled yet hard and crowns of flourishing that move with the air. Trees, which ones she doesn´t know. Olive or figs or any at all, she can´t tell. Maybe if she gets close but Catra is stuck here.

The grass, yes, the rocks over the earth. These ones she knows by touch alone, sharp and scratching on the skin of her palms. dark too, with mysterious colours and mysterious critters traveling up and down, tickling on Catra´s skin where they get curiously near to her laid body and then scattered away right after.

The sky, this one she is sure off. It hangs directly over her head, so bright it makes her cry, so vast it makes her want to scream, so unapproachable that Catra wishes she had never met it at all. Bright and filled with colors too, bright colors, bright shapes, every changing as the minutes and the hours go on over her head and she remains where she is. Woven to the very earth, holding herself from the shapes she knows are roots and closing her eyes, hopping when she opens them again all the colors will be gone again.

Herself, Catra can look at herself. She can see her hands, her palms, the length of her nails, the wrinkles and divots on her skin. She can see her freckles and finally understand what they are, how much they can resemble love words in braille and constellations over fabric.

She can see at her own body and, for a moment, all she sees is a stranger. So she closes her eyes again.

Maybe, just maybe, if she lingers long enough in this meadow surrounded by dead earth, she will be found again. Maybe, if she waits here for just a little bit longer, the woman she loves will turn her eyes around, cursed or not, and come back for her, take her back, guide her out of the darkness and towards the light.

So Catra waits. She closes her eyes and she waits, with her breath held and her hands around gentle fabric of a color she doesn´t know but that is the same as the one in the sky, still lemongrass smelling. Still smelling like her wife. Catra waits.

She hears and feels the presence approaching her by the change in the earth but she knows immediately that is not her. The steps are wrong, the weight on them too, the smell, the sound, the breath, it's all wrong.

By all means, it´s inhuman, immortal, detached from the existence of human soul as it kneels somewhere on the flowers that grow behind Catra´s back, keeping her face away from Catra ´s eyes yet placing her fluttering and ethereal hands over her her shoulders, unable to completely touched as she has always done before, even since Catra was a child.

“ C´yra ”

Catra closes her eyes tighter and grinds her teeth, refusing to turn around and meet her, refusing to look at her human form with these eyes. Catra knew her before already, in different ways, kinder ones and she remembers those as one remembers their childhood, with nostalgia.

If Catra gazes as the sight of the last strand she has with her mother, the nostalgia will rot into grudge and Catra doesn´t wants that. She, at least, can choose about that.

“ C´yra .” The Lady of Harvest presses on, her voice catching in the edges. “ **C´yra ”**

“Leave me alone.” Catra snaps, covering her face with the colors and the grass.

The goddess hesitates and at least that brings Catra satisfaction, the capability of throwing them off, the strength of pushing them back. Catra, who for so long lived held to her faith on them like a safe line, has lost all hope in every single one of them but in the heart of her own wife. And even knows, Catra´s heart barely can think or pronounce her name without breaking.

It doesn´t seem fair so Catra is not about to be fair with the gods either.

The green ever colored grass and the meadow shivers into an earthquake all around her, a dangerous warning from ethereal life that dies down the second it lashes against the earth

again. The goddess is displeased, tasting the first strands of anger,but she contains herself as Catra is her granddaughter and her blood.

It´s not like Catra cares.

“You are alive, child.” The goddess barks, still sweetly yet stickier, like molasses stuck to the teeth. “**You are here, you are back here in this world where you belong. Out of darkness. Out of the Underworld. You are here.”**

“Leave me alone.” Catra repeats and this time instead of anger there just comes sorrow. “Leave me. Leave me here to die.”

“You can´t die.” She commands, flustering the earth, the grains and even the long strands of Catra´s hair, so similar to her mother´s and so different still, painted by the testimonies of her life not in shadows but in sunlight cradled beneath stone walls. “**It´s not your time”**

Catra grinds her teeth until she feels her molars chipping under the pressure and closer her eyes so tightly that all she sees are hot sparkles beneath her eyelids, giving her the mercy of a swift moment of blindness before the goddess is speaking into her ear again, her breath heavy with the smells of the harvest and her scene claustrophobic, unused to gentleness after so many years chasing for vengeance.

“C´yra”

“No. No.” Catra denies her all over again, covering her eyes with her mud stained hands and sobbing, angry tears that burn down her cheeks and make tiny sprouts bloom when they fall. “You´ve condemned me to eternal winter. You´ve thrown me to the Asphodels. You´ve killed me, the whole lot of you”

She hears her grandmother gasp and feels the chill in the breeze that follows immediately after but pays no attention to them, drowning inside the pain. A kind of suffering that is unbearable, that breaks, that tears her down, that makes the pain from a wound nothing in comparison to the ache inside a heart Catra is not sure is neither still beating nor still inside her chest.

Here where Catra lays the grass must be green and earth is soft but she is cold, she is cold everywhere. Gone are the sunlight, foreign to the celestial body burning in the sky. Gone are the warm breeze and the gentle breath, gone, all of them.

Gone are the gentle hands covered in scars that Catra memorized in a haze, in a heartbeat, in a push of will, knowing they would be denied to her soon after. Gone is the golden skin scattered in sun freckles and the tiny mole that lives on the soft bone of her wrist.

Gone are the lemongrass smells and the fig taste on a soft mouth. Gone is the sizzling and the singing and the murmuring and the sounds of love. Gone are the softer fabrics and the slithering bodies, and the gaze upon her face that mirrored only adoration and never terror.

Gone is her touch over Catra's body; her beautiful hands caressing her shoulders and the back of her knees; her mouth pressed over Catra's lips and lowering on her skin.

Gone is her voice, her laughter, her heart, so familiar for Catra, so dear. Gone are her sorrows too and her fears and all those things Catra adores from her, all those that make her devoted.

Gone, they are gone, taken away by the hand of the love of her life, caused by a new kind of curse inflicted upon Catra´s eyes.

Gone is the love of Catra's life, the half of her soul, her wife. Avenged maybe but still in that cave where she doesn't dare to step foot off.

She is gone and with her Catra's heart is gone too.

Demeter, the Lady of the Harvest, is back in the world and flowers will bloom again, but Adora is gone and without her Catra has been lost again.

“Leave me alone.” Catra pleads and this time she is listened to, the sky and the sun casted into shadows by the tumultuous shapes that must be the clouds.

She is left on her own, curling over cold grass and the hemation in her hands, sleeping the time away.

The truth is, Catra never once desired to have her sight. She did not wish for it, did not pray, did not plead for it, never once, never in all of her prayers she ever asked for it. Not when she was a child, or younger, not when Io died, not when she found the love of her life. By all means, for a while she found it a small mercy for gods she thought would look after them, being able to exist in a world where she could hold her love inside her arms no matter what.

Being given this, it feels invasive, overwhelming, horrid. Completely and absolutely frightful for her, more fearful than any other kind of heavy silence she has experienced ever in her entire life. Waking up in a world that she doesn´t know anymore and that she doesn´t want to learn on her own.

She feels lost, confused and pained, she feels sad and heartbroken. Completely shredded into pieces. Catra lies here with her head on her hands and her voice clogged inside her throat, crying to herself until she feels her voice cannot go anymore and her limbs numb. Until her heart weighs heavier than her eyes and all the plants around her bloom and die over and over again.

It´s strange, In a way, she thought her grief would be louder.

She thought she would scream, wail,that after the initial shock and the realization felt completely over her she would splinter, break in so many places that the mere brush of them would cut her open like a knife, like a bleeding wound, like a heart ripped off the bones of her ribcage and tossed aside. That it would bring so much suffering that she would howl and yell until the very gods listened to her, until they were unable to not hear her voice, until it would reach the very depths of an unknown cavern and convince her love to come back home.

She is suffering, she is in pain, she is ripping into shreds, but instead of being loud, she is quiet. Her sobs are trembling and low, her tears are endless, her voice shivers like thrown in

the middle of the snow instead of a blooming meadow; her whimpers are barely audible over the sound of the world around her.

Quiet, so, so very quiet. Quiet like a hum, quiet like a gasp, quiet like the earth splintering open to the core and dying all over again. Quiet like a star on the celestial domes exploiting, dying, alone and cold and in silence.

In a way, it scares her even more than being loud. It makes her terrified, the depth of the void that has opened inside her heart, devouring it all with all consuming darkness.

She has eyes, she has a sight, a cure she never asked for, a curse for a soul that loves another soul more than anything. And even with all this light, Catra has never felt more submerged in darkness than it does right now.

Maybe, just maybe, Catra will really die here, like Eurydice bitten by the snake. Die of pain, of unmeasurable longines. Of desire, of wanting, of waiting with all her heart that she is found here before she falls asleep, lily white and poppy red, lying on a bed she made for two and where only one rests.

Catra is pretty sure her skin, her limbs and her very heart have been remade of tears alone when she hears the new sound, soft and pretty, familiar. Not steps, as they never stepped over the ground not even once, not even when Catra knew them for so many years before this. But she knows them, this sound too she knows them.

“You still exist?” Catra speaks to the nothing, pressing the sharp end of her nails against her eyelids without getting to truly break the skin.

Unlike the first one that came to see her, this presence doesn´t sigh or reach for her. Instead they just hover above the grass and between the skies, looking at the life slipping back into the earth by Catra´s touch and her tears.

“Of course I do.” Eros says, their voice curling between a hum and a laugh, as if Catra´s pained voice amused them deeply and yet at the same time filled them with sorrow. “**I live in hearts like yours. Both of you, dream walker.”**

Catra whimpers, closing her eyes again and letting the moss and the fungus take over her. Stain the fabric of her clothes and paint her skin in earth colors and bury her body in loose petals and leaves, quiet through her grief and her mourning.

The god moves, a little bit to every single side, fluttering in ethereal wings that Catra has no desire nor strength to see. She is a daughter of gods and she could gaze at their heavenly bodies with these bare eyes, but these irises and these pupils are also foreign to her, she doesn ´t know them, so Catra closes her eyes.

“You asked her to live.” The god points out, humming a tone that sounds too much like Adora´s lyre.

“I did.” Catra spats, feeling her heart bleeding out and having to look down to see if it isn´t actually dripping into her hands. “Were you spying?”

“I see all the hearts that love, so does my mother. Especially hearts like yours, split in the middle.” The god takes a moment to think but never stops the humming, regarding Catra´s fallen body with hidden eyes. They too are blind, as love sometimes is. “**You asked her to come back”**

“Yes.” Catra gasps, unable to keep the sorrow for herself for a single second longer. “Yes, I did.”

“And she asked you to live this life”

Catra slams her open palm against the bare grass, straightening up until she is resting the weight of her torso over her palms, ripping the grass from the root like the strands of a tapestry, woven and undone over and over again through the long years that are to come.

“I don´t want!” She screams, furious, filled with rage, falling from her like venom and poison and breaking her skin into invisible blisters that make her blister, the wish to rip these very eyes from her face and roam the earth in darkness until she can find her again stronger than anything else she has ever felt in her entire like. “I did not ask for it. I was never frail, I was never broken. Shit happens, disabilities happen. I didn´t ask either of you to take that away from me. It was not my choice!”

Catra gasps, crumbling into a fit of immediate sobs. She rests her face inside the cup of her palm and cries boiling hot and heartbreaking tears against her own skin, still stained by so much hatred that she can barely breathe.

She waits for a second, then for another, absently waiting for the god to be enraged and maybe, just maybe, obliterate her into the ground and end this suffering, so drowned in despair and in confusion and injustice that she forgets for a second what she lives for.

Instead, she hears the god throw their head back and chuckle, actually giggling at her, voice sweet and yet undeniable wise. It makes Catra unbelievably angrier.

“Are you laughing?” Catra spats, making a try to turn around and face the god fully. A hand falls over her this time, resting against the back of her head and palming it softly, It feels both light and heavy, reassuring and commanding, a silence that turns Catra´s brittle bones into ice.

“I find it marveling, you mortals and the meaning of choice.” The god whispers, running hands like feathers and arrows through Catra´s hair, coving the gentle braids Adora had made for her before leaving her here. **“You are right, you were not healed”**

All of Catra´s thoughts come to a halt, her heart lowering down inside her chest until it stops almost completely, by sorrow or by confusion alone, beating still for the life of the woman Catra loves the most and only for that.

“But then—?”

“If you stay here you will die and then what a waste.” Eros cuts her before she can even finish her question, evading the answer maybe or plainly ignoring her, she is not sure. It

tastes bitter, the unknown. It tastes rotten and also sweet, the way the god regards in deep thought the pieces of her heart and the struggle of Catra´s body and almost seems to shake their head. "**What a waste indeed"**

"She put me here!" Catra barks, her anger misplaced, her grief consuming her from the inside out, unable to keep itself contained inside the depth of her grief. She raises her hands and still of bringing them over her cursed eyes she digs them against her soft scalp, pulling from the soft strands until they come undone on her fingers, ripped from root like the grass and the flowers and sauntering sadly on her lap. "I hate her, I hate myself! I hate it all!"

"No, you don´t." The god speaks very, very softly, because after all they are a god of love, born from love itself, and know everything that there is to be about adoration and the grief within.

Catra sobs, ripping from her mouth like an open wound. "I told her I would never leave her no matter what and yet I let her get me out. After all these years, after all I fucking promised her, I let her leave me here. I— I let her come back there alone, on her own, thinking she would kill me otherwise and I— I don´t even know the way back."

Catra chokes around her own tears, gasping for air and for the golden light of the woman she loves and resents and misses more than life. For Adora. It doesn´t seem fair either, that she knows her fully, from the inside out, every sharp crevice and soft corner of her heart and her soul, of her body, of her smell, of her sounds.

Of her skin, Catra cares about nothing from these eyes but the sight of Adora´s hands is seared on her mind, on the back of her eyelids, on the depths of her heart. Every single pale line, every single tender green vein like the grass at her feet, every fall of her fingers and softness of her palms, she remembers them, she resents them, she absolutely loves them.

Catra doesn´t know how she is supposed to live the rest of her life without Adora by her side.

The god hums again, running their hands from the back of Catra´s head to her face, covering her open eyes with incandescent warmth. "Sometimes the greatest act that can be made for love is not sacrificing ourselves but turning around"

By the time Catra starts making out of the shapes of their body they are already away from her all over again, leaving only the shapes of the trees and the meadow mirror on her eyes.

The light has fallen and absently Catra realizes it must be night already, all over again, casting shadows over her and the small spot in the world where life and food has begun to grow again.

"Look up,," the god mutters and Catra has no option but to follow, letting her head, heavy with tears and sorrow, roll backwards towards the sky.

The beauty of Adora´s heavens was not something she had been prepared for.

"These are—"

“Stars”

She knew them, through the fuzzy memories in her head, through the careful descriptions of her mother and of Adam, and most of all, to the studies Adora did on them.

She knew their names, their shapes, the way they would sound in Adora´s voice. The way they twinkle even if she wasn´t quite sure what it meant but that always made Adora excited, laying side by side on their secret garden with the domes open above their heads to let Adora see a glimpse of the world that she would describe to Catra with all the care in the world.

Tiny, to our eyes, yet immense up there in the sky, she would say, painting tiny swirls and pressing soft dots over Catra´s palms.

Bright, almost as bright as the sun as she is the queen of the stars. And twinkling, um, like the sound of the coins in our ankles when we dance.

Infinite. Infinite like the earth's grains, like the trees leaves, like the flower petals. And even when some of them might wither and die, new ones are born again, over and over again. One story ends and another begins.

“You have been given a gift.“

Eros whispers and this time they sound like a sound, like the flutter of butterfly wings brushing against each other, like the voice of his own lover, like the laughter of Catra´s.

“And you have much to do before the time comes, C'yra daughter of dreams.” A pause, a wait, if Catra wants to turn around and meet the face of love she will be granted it. She will see them as they are and have always been since the very first day the god found her as an unlost child in the forest, Catra is now a woman and she is lost for the first time in her life, yet, she doesn´t. **“Wife of Adora”**

Catra covers her face and cries again, for endless and endless hours that feel like cold rain washing over her, nurturing the grounds and soaking her from the inside out. And the entire time love is right there, standing behind her, watching her, sheltering her, waiting for her as her sobs and wails and whimpers subdue and Catra opens her eyes at the fresh drops of rain, hanging heavy from her eyelashes and running crystal clear and not golden down her cheekbones in paths like the ones dug on stone in the earth of her once home.

“Then what should I do?” Catra murmurs and in a way is like asking herself something she already knows.

“Get up your butt and do it,” Love answers, “**Honor her that way”**

It takes Catra a very long time to stand up from her place over the moss and the rain. Minutes,hours, days even.

She lingers, sitting on the ground with her knees against her chest and the hemation around her shoulders, resting her head over her knees as she stares at the meadow blooming alive around her, calling for the bee and the hare all the same.

Her long hair is a mess falling across her face, clustered and knotted with loose leaves, tiny sad blooms and twigs, sticking to the skin of her face by perspiration, drizzle and tears. It falls heavy down the middle of her back and her shoulders, sad loops that curl inside her lap and against the floor like dark roots themselves, holding her down.

But she finally manages to stand up, just a little bit, little by little until she is standing up on her bare feet still painted with the swirls that Adora had done there and that now Catra can fully see, cradling her skin like stems.

“Eros.” Catra whispers, looking at her feet.

“Yes, little princess?”

“It was Athena's blood, wasn't it?” Catra brings her fingers towards her eyes, feeling her soaked eyelashes against the pads of her fingers. It's so strange, the sight of them, they are almost foreign to her. “What did this”

“It was”

Catra closes her eyes, breathing deep through her nose, her heart bleeding completely inside her ribcage. “Did he know? What was he going to cause when he did it?”

“Not in the way you think.” Butterflies are flying all around Catra´s place, resting on her face and drinking from the tears on her cheeks. “**He wished to curse, using her blood.”**

“Didn´t he? Didn´t he curse me in the end? I lost her.” Catra chokes, biting into the venom on her mouth like a poisonous flower under her tongue.

“I believe he misunderstood the meaning of holy blood. And the ways of the Fates.”

Catra clicks her tongue against her teeth, angry, angrier than she has ever been in her entire life. She digs her nails inside her palms and lingers on her bare feet over rain and grass, like the statue of a forgotten goddess in a temple long ago crumbled by time.

“If it had fallen over Adora, would it have given her back her eyes?”

A moment, a hesitation maybe, even coming for a god, thinking what they can say and they cannot. Of what can be confessed, like a small promise done in the form of vows.

“It would have.” The god breathes and then dissolves into the very air, leaving Catra on her own in the middle of a quiet forest. **“It still might.”**

Catra walks barefoot for miles and miles until her soles are bruised and bleeding and she is worn to the bone, and still she keeps walking.

She walks to every side of the dry forest, followed by paths of the green and the colours behind her like one of the comet's trails Adora used to talk about or maybe just what she thinks it might look like. Blooms, roots and grass grow under her steps but she does not pay attention to them, the eyes in her face focused on the dryness in front of her.

There is death, everywhere she goes. Death not in the way of the skull or the corpse but death in the trees, in the ground, in the air. She meets it and knows it because it is not as different from the touch to the eye. It's dry, cracking, heavy; it gets stuck inside Catra´s throat and her nose and clogs her breathing, making her cough and gasp for air. Yet, green follows her everywhere she goes.

She walks until she is met face to face with the tall rock of the mountains, unmovable and hard, so unfamiliar to the one she has come to learn in the last years. Tall mountains rising to the heavens and the sheer sight of them should make Catra gasp with wonder but instead she only sees the closed stone with no caves inside and she walks away.

She doesn´t even notice the snow falling down on the top of the mountains or the winter air, she turns around on her ankles and walks in the other direction, turning her head back several times as if the rock would split open until they too disappear from sight.

I hear you, stepping among rivers and lakes and stone paths made with cautious hands

The sound of past prophecies follows her everywhere she goes, in the breeze, in the soft ground, in the forest, growing stronger and more alive the more she wanders among its dry lands. Like a whisper, following her around with the words of Fate where she meets the void river that fills with the rain pouring over her head and the empty cliffs and meadows that bloom under her touch.

The entire time she searches, she looks. The entire time, she holds Adora´s hemation against her face and her chest and hopes to find the entrance, the path, the way back to a home she once adored, for the one she loves was there with her too.

She doesn´t find it. She doesn´t pray anymore.

Carra doesn't realize she is stepping over crumbled statues until she is directly over them, the shape ends digging in the tender flesh of her soles and sending sparks of pain through her legs.

She stares at her feet, detached from the sight, and blinks at the white and polished stone now fallen and scattered all over the ground.

For a moment, her heart jumps inside her chest, hope making its way sticky and merciless against her soul, eating her up alive and bleeding her out because after all this is own hope works, it's a bleeding work in a battlefield, capable of keeping her alive when she feels like she is being eaten to the very bones.

But when Catra raises her head all that meets her are the open gates and fallen walls of a kingdom, ash showered over the once pristine clearness that Catra thinks might be white. And brightens, blinding and broken but still mighty brightness shimmering to every corner of this war shaken place.

It is, also, not silent. Not quiet, like the forest or the mountain or the river, not at all. There are many sounds inside this place, voices, songs, laughter even among the destruction they live here.

They overwhelm Catra and make her want to turn around but suddenly she has found herself spellcasted, not by the sight but by the smell.

Salt, water, warmth and a little bit of seaweed on the edges. The ocean, nearby, with its seafoam breaking against stone and reef and its natural song calm after many years of war.

Adora's clothes smell a little bit like this, her skin and her palms too. No matter how many years went by, it was always there, below her skin, always a daughter of a seaside kingdom and a princess of the same.

Catra stares at the entrance of the kingdom and hesitates, her feet hovering over the loose stones. She turns her head around one more time, towards the line of tall and beautiful trees behind her, filling the woods with a life they have known nothing about in many, many years. But it´s only that, trees and sky and nothing more, nobody is walking behind Catra, following her back.

Catra steps inside the buzzing kingdom, placing Adora´s hemation around her head and shoulders, covering her from the tiny snowflakes that begin to saunter down the ground.

Her mother´s hemation is wrapped tightly around her waist but even with both of them Catra can feel the cutting edge of the winter cold slipping through the thick fabric, making her shoulders and arms shiver and her cheeks pale, bruised in splotches of warmth and dry lips.

The kingdom is, in all words, completely destroyed. The buildings of what Catra believes must be the DownTown are practically completely gone, rubble and dirt scattered everywhere in so many pieces that for a moment Catra´s new sight confuses the ash with the falling stone, sticking to the skin of the people working without resting to clean the paths and make the lands anew.

The temples are destroyed, every single one of them for all of the old gods. And Catra would like to say she feels satisfaction at the sight, some kind of quiet sense of justice for what they have allowed to happen to her. But all she feels is sadness, crawling to every part of her heart where she finally learns how the murals and columns look like yet they remain broken at her feet, slicing in a thousand pieces and disrespected by the images of a false god that now lay beheaded and death somewhere in the underworld.

There are no trees here, no green, or at least not the one Catra has come to know as green. There are no crops, no animals, no water but the snow, no warmth but the one from the precarious fireplaces and the barely constructed altars. There is another kind of green but it's terrible, poisonous and yet long ago burnt down like the buildings are too. It has been tossed aside from their lives, gone.

The paths are also destroyed and there is the undoubtable hand of past flood and fire lingering on every corner of the city, making it all inhabitable for the months to come. But the people work and, maybe most important than all, the people laugh.

Catra observes the silence as they past heavy rocks from hand to hand or drag long and even heavier wheelbarrows heavy with dirt and debris, their simple clothes stained and their hairs messed up but still they are smiling. They whistle and talk to each other and even sing songs

together, ones that speak of the hope of something new and good to come, now that the worst of it has finally be gone, now that the storm has died, now that they get to return to their homes no matter how broken and defiled and they get to built them all from the ground and up.

A new chance, for a new kind of beginning, one where nor adult, elderly or children have to live in fear. One where they can overcome the pain in their lands and a new life for themselves that gets to honor the previous one.

Catra is so distracted by the sight that she yelps in surprise when tiny bodies crash accidentally against the back of her legs, looking down in time to catch three children laughing breathlessly against each other, obviously in the middle of a race and looking at Catra with gentle eyes filled with joy.

“Oh! Sorry, lady!” One of them chants, gaps between their front teeth and rosy cheeks, white hair and tanned skin, like a tiny bloom looking at Catra´s speechless face with all the grace of a tiny soul that knew war but that survived it, that is alive and here, playing over a graveyard but happy.

“It´s alright,” Catra hears herself whisper, tiny and miserable even for her own ears yet for the children seems to be more than enough because they laugh and start racing each other up and down the broken buildings, dirty tunics and old sandals but alive.

Catra bites into her own mouth hard enough to make herself bleed, forcing herself to keep walking no matter how much her mouth feels with acid.

She learns the sight of things with her fingers, touching it all and waving this new knowledge to the one she had before, when she learnt the world through touch, smell and sound. It´s a new perspective, bolder, wider, it gives a headache and makes her feel infinite sorrow, both by having it and by not knowing how to appreciated it.

It is all so deeply rotten for her that every single sight makes her heart sink and every single new meeting with things she had not known before makes her soul cry and not to sing.

She sees the images passing by like reflections, breathing them in, hearing them, touching them, gathering them all inside her head and trying not to spit them right after. She sees the crumbled stone and the columns of precious metals on the ground.

She sees the broken tapestries and the old symbols of the royal daily that once ruled a prosperous and beautiful kingdom. The intertwined wings casted inside the bright circle, just about to break free but not completely. Shapes Catra had known for many years now, seared on the back of her mind from the hand of a best friend and from the loss of her life.

Catra loses herself a little bit at the sight, stuck in the middle of the road with these eyes focused on the sigil, split in the middle by a sword or an accident, she doesn´t know. She looks at it and it looks at her right back, through the polished reflection like a shield meant for death and not the broken symbol of a dead family.

Returning the sight of these eyes, big and bright and beautiful and foreign to her. Wrong.

“Hey”

Catra jumps out of her feet in surprise, twisting her entire body in one sharp go the second she feels the soft hand resting against the fall of her shoulder.

She hisses loudly, her entire face wrinkling into a single scowl of warning that dies down the second it's born, too worn out to pay attention to it or to truly care about any kind of real danger falling over her in strange lands.

The woman standing behind her, however, is the furthest thing from danger Catra might have considered, or at least in plain sight. She is a few years younger than Catra, not many, and like this place she looks strong yet completely worn out by the war.

Her hair is short, bouncing over her shoulders on purpose after many years of mourning a loved one, light in colors Catra cannot place but that remind her of the tiny flowers of the meadows and the soft shades of the dawn.

She is also a little bit shorter than her but carries with her a kind of aura that is both important and mighty and also profoundly sad, speaking miles of the weight of responsibility placed over her at a very tender age but that she carries with grace.

In a way, she reminds Catra a little bit of Adora, with the soft voice and the shoulders thrown back and the way they very obviously try to hold themselves to the threads of hope whenever they can. The sight of this woman makes Catra´s heart bleed and scream inside her chest, begging to be put out of her misery and making her gasp on accident, her own voice stuck to her throat.

“Oh, sorry i didn't mean to startle you.” The woman says very, very gently, raising her hands off Catra´s body and at the sides of her body, a clear motion to let Catra know that she is harmless. “You looked so lost for a moment there I thought you needed help. I´m sorry.”

Catra closes her mouth with an audible click, looking towards the broken sigil again and then back to the young woman, the tears stuck on her eyelashes turning into tiny snowflakes when they fall across her freckled face.

“I´m fine,” Catra reassures her, cringing when it comes more like a snap than a soothing word.

Still, the woman seems to not take offense into it, nodding softly and still staring at Catra as if for some reason she were to crumble into pieces in front of her. Catra wonders if she might, she wonders if her grief is written as plainly on her face as she feels it on her heart.

“You're freezing.” The young woman murmurs, wrinkling her nose.

Catra is about to fight her back or snap at her again —or maybe just stand there staring at her heartbroken even — but the woman is already moving, walking a few steps towards the entrance of a tall temple that somehow had managed to remain mostly intact to the battles of war.

There are more people there than what Catra had realized before, mostly or completely woman, wrapped in old hemations too and layered skirts of many beautiful colors, handing fabrics and baskets with frail pieces o dry bread to the people walking inside the place, helping each other and their possibly wounded and disabled across the steps with a gentle hand.

Catra follows the woman behind because she doesn´t know what else to do but this. She holds Adora´s hemations closer around her head and over her mouth and nose like a veil, breathing from her smell there and reassuring herself of the privacy that it gives her.

It must be a little dumb, trying to hide herself from strangers that do not know her and couldn't care less about her identity. But then again she does not know what happened in the last six years since she set foot on the mortal world. She doesn´t know what came to be from her town or the people in it, the ones that thought they would manage to kill her and only gave her paradise instead.

She doesn´t know if her aunt or his husband are still alive, or what could be of her if any of them were to see her right now, someone that was deemed cursed by the gods and that now might actually be one.

After all the loss and the pain, the world might not want ever again to take a chance for curses. And they might all learn, to be better and kinder and caring with each other; but there are also human beings and even gods, bound to make the same mistakes over and over again.

If Catra had any hope left, any prayer more to give, it would be to be in the wrong this time. That this time they could all learn and be better. But she doesn´t even know who she is anymore or what she is meant to do now.

“Are you here for the refuge?” The woman asks kindly, ripping Catra off her own head.

Catra blinks at her, deeply confused for a solid second. Her voice is sore and broken in every single note when she speaks again, testimony of her sorrows and the miles wandering without a course. “The refuge?”

“Yes.” The young woman steps down the precarious temple, followed behind by another one, of wheat colored hair and freckles, slightly similar to the kid that had crashed against Catra and with her eyes full of tenderness. “We are placing all newcomers in the temples that survived right now. Just while we figure things out and the winter ends.”

“Here, blankets,” the soft looking woman says, handing Catra a soft bundle that she holds immediately, without even thinking about it.

Catra stares at the soft fabric and then at the two women, who are for some reason looking at Catra with all the patience possible written all over their faces. And for the first time it occurs to Catra how miserable, soiled in earth and covered in snow, she must seem to them. With her face and her body heavy by the sorrow and her breath held.

“Thank you.” Absently, Catra grabs the fragile handle of the satchel that Adora had packed for her and that Catra had been carrying everywhere now, untouched as she hands it to the

women in front of her. “I have food”

“Oh!” The first woman's eyes go huge at the sight of fresh fruits and vegetables inside the bag, the first ones she has laid her eyes upon in over ten years.

Catra pushes it with a little bit more insistence towards her, wrinkling her frown. “Take it”

“Are you sure?”

“Yes”

The woman eyes her curiously for a moment but she finally takes it, holding it against her chest like the most precious treasure, beyond gold or gems. After a decade of surviving only in frail bread and meak water, the sight of the food almost brings her to tears.

“Thank you,” she whispers, and she looks so painfully honest that Catra has to snap her eyes away.

Silence falls between the three of them and it's overwhelming, absurd and horrifying, choking Catra in a way that makes her want to turn around and run away from these people and this place until she cannot see any of its fall and rise anymore.

The tall woman must realize because she takes a precarious step forward, her gentle eyes falling from Catra´s veiled face to her waist, where the precious and carefully woven Heracles knot still hangs around her hips. Pearls and lake crystals dangle from the colorful ends, done by Adora´s hands and placed over Catra´s body every single morning of their lives.

“Are you married?”

Catra has to look down to her own hands, make sure she has not shattered like painted clay.

“I am”

The tall woman gulps, sharing a meaningful look with the other one, a silent conversation done between the both of them before the first one speaks to Catra very cautiously. “Is your spouse—?”

“My wife.” Catra snaps her teeth together, her breath betraying her where it splits her voice apart. “We got separated.” She explains, furious for the way the women look at her with understanding, with sorry, with resignation learnt from years of war. Catra hates them, she doesn´t want nor need their pity. “She´ll come”

“Alright.” The first woman whispers nodding at Catra´s resolution though it is obvious, even for Catra´s new sight, that she is trying to soothe Catra´s heart around the grief.

Catra does not realize how she looks for them, standing barefoot in the middle of this winter. With her colorful clothes and the exquisite embroidered hemation seen only in murals of the royalty. With her long hair bouncing over her ankles and tangled with twigs and leaves and somehow the sight of green plants on her hair is more astonish than her messed up strands.

With the golden jewelry on her forehead, on her ears; hanging heavy and beautiful from her neck and wrists and ankles and beyond the folds of the veils over her head. The way every single fold of fabric and expense of freckled skin makes her look royal yet lost at the eyes of the two women staring at her with wide pupils.

But Catra cannot see or understand any of that in herself.

Catra looks away, locked in a shiver so violent even her teeth tremble with each other inside her mouth, born from the soul of her heart and covering her completely like eternal winter. The woman narrows her eyes sadly at her and looks for her eyes with hers, giving her a tiny smile.

“Do you want to come in? It's getting really cold”

It is. Catra is freezing on the places where Adora's hemation cannot cover her. Her hands are dry and cracking and her feet feel numb with the bruises of walking and the direct touch of the cold ground against her soles. And Catra hates the cold, absolutely dreads it, but she cannot even feel it now, numb to the very core.

Instead, Catra stares at the broken columns and frowns, holding the soft fabric against her chest tighter. “Is this Eternia?”

“Yes”

“The kingdom of the Grayskull family”

Both women stare at her, slightly surprised. “Well, it hasn´t been called that in a long time.” The tall woman explains in a soft voice, nodding her head. “But it was, once”

Catra nods back at her, still refusing to meet both of their eyes as much as she can. She doesn´t want to see anybody in the eye, not right now, maybe not ever.

“Can you show me the way to the palace, please?” Silence meets her, so long that for a moment Catra thinks she has been left alone again. When she turns to look at the women again, she finds that they are both looking at her with strange expressions etched to their faces, wrinkling their factions into something both mournful and uncomfortable. “What is it?”

“Most of the palace burned down during the last battle against the Emperor.” The first woman explains, apologetic. The mention of that man manages to make Catra´s entire skin crawl with hatred but if any of the women notice it, they do not mention it. “If you were looking for someone there—”

“No, I just—” Catra wets her mouth with her tongue, looking at the rubble as she tries to find her own words. “I need to go. For someone”

The tall woman´s eyes gather with tears but the first one remains calm, unfazed beyond eternal comprehension, but at least is not pity, something that Catra appreciates immensely.

She nods, understanding, and hands the bags towards the tall woman, grabbing a blanket for herself and pointing at the destroyed path with her head.

“Very well, please follow me”

Catra gives a tiny nod of recognition at the tall woman and follows the first one, side by side over the ground scattered with tiny rocks and snow. She doesn´t notice the tiny blooms of grass and moss following her behind but the tall woman does, her eyes opening wide as she rushes back inside the temple with her breath caught in her throat.

“What happened to this place?” Catra asks the first woman, desperate to chase away the silence stretching between them as they make their way towards the remains of the palace.

Catra hears her sigh, a very deep exhale that speaks of nothing but long days and even longer nights of endless war. After living so many years inside the cavern alongside Adora, Catra is starting to realize she had forgotten exactly how devastating it would be beyond the stone walls.

“After King Randor and Queen Marlena were assassinated things got so much worse. Prime almost managed to conquer the entirety of Etheria, no city or village managed to escape his hand.” The woman bites into the inside of her cheek, chewing the skin as she pushes word after word out, filled with a venom Catra can understand. “About six years ago, the Rebellion managed to bring the war right here, to the walls he had raised around Etheria. They almost got him but he outsmarted them all and trapped them on the shore. Some were killed by the spear, others poisoned with the very sand, and some others struck down by lightning. The gods hand was talked about.”

“The only reason the rest of the Rebellion managed to escape was because of their leader. She sent her daughter to lead them and stayed back, she sacrificed herself to distract him and saved hundreds in the way.”

The woman stops, taking a shivering breath, her steps flattering a little in the middle.

“I don't know if you knew but she had no royal blood, not like the old queens. The rebellion was mostly formed of simple people, workers and weavers, all of them brave, none of them real warriors. And she— she died to save us all. I know of no one else more deserving of being called a queen than her.”

Catra observes her in silence, taking on the shiver of her voice and the paleness of her cheeks. She speaks of that woman as if she knew her, as if she had been there to witness it. She speaks of it, of her, as if her death weighed her like it crushes Catra's heart too.

She thinks that's the reason this young woman might be able to see the sorrow craved on Catra's face, on her fleeing eyes. Because they share it, in different fonts but they are not as different after all.

“War has not been kind, hasn´t it?” The woman chuckles without a trace of joy, shrugging weakly. “I don´t know a place where it didn´t reach”

Carra cringes, looking away again. She remembers the smell of her home at menagerie, the lingering smell stuck to her nose months after. She remembers the same smoke clinging to the quartz walls of the cavern, covering the moss with ashes.

“No, it hasn´t”

They walk for what must be a good part of an hour but only feels like a couple of minutes. Up and down the rubble of buildings, around the holes on destroyed paths, away from patches of land still smoking with past fire and people talking softly to each other and greeting the first woman, and Catra, with a kindness that the latter had not known in other people for a long time.

They stop near the top of a hill, where the dry earth has been covered by the huge pieces of columns that have long ago cracked and fallen down. Most of the ceilings and roofs are completely destroyed, and the murals on the walls are now nothing but dust.

There are bones here too, old and even older than Catra can even imagine. This is her first time glancing at corpses, at skeletons. At real bones that she had only learned in medical knowledge but never in person, never touched, never so real.

It´s strange, in a way, even more than the burnt pieces of the palace all around her; the way these frail bones once contained lives, souls, threads of life cut short by their own consequences and decisions. After all the wrong, all the suffering and pain that Prime´s warriors had caused in the world, being like this, nothing but dust on the ground and broken splinters, makes them look so insignificant that is almost, almost, funny.

There are, however, a few chambers and towers of the huge palace that have survived the merciless fire, tall and beautiful though covered in dark shadows and in that sense of sorrow that seems to linger on every single corner of this place no matter where Catra looks.

“Here we are.” The woman announces in a whisper, rolling a tiny stone below the worn leather of her sandal. “After Prime murdered the Leader of the Rebellion, Etheria got flooded for many, many years. There was a lot of disease and famine for it and it hit him and his men directly while the Rebellion went underground to recover and become smarter.”

The woman hesitates, wrinkling her nose and rolling her thumbs around each other in a motion that Catra thinks might be grounding for her, among the sea of dark memories she must carry. Still, she hears in silence with her breath held, her heart pounding inside her eardrums

“We knew his men were talking about him growing weak, less favoured by the gods or not being a god at all, the fucking idiots. And then we started hearing another kind of rumours, ones that spoke about unholy feasts with the corpses of his own soldiers, about their meat on his mouth and the sin of it all.”

Catra holds her breath, the woman shivers, both of them standing side by side after living different sides of the same war.

“Nobody knew how true they were until the Rebellion gave the final blow towards the city. By that point his own people hated him so much that if he hadn't set the palace on fire with everyone inside and run away, they would have killed him themselves. I heard they did try to assassinate him, tried to behead him in his sleep and when they failed, stabbed him multiple times before he escaped.” The woman stops, taking a hitching breath, letting through all the hate she truly harbours for him. Catra can understand that, she shares that hate too. “I hope he is lying in some ditch dead by now”

“He is,” Catra snaps before she can help herself, biting into the inside of her mouth when the woman turns to look at her, clearly surprised. Catra clicks her tongue against the back of her teeth, snapping her eyes away with a grunt. “Trust me, he is dead. And he suffered, and he will suffer every day on the underworld from now on”

They stare at each other heavily, in silence, sharing a look that speaks of many things unsaid to the world but that somehow get understood between one another. Catra looks back at the remains of the palace and the woman lets out a deep exhale, following her gaze towards the debris as her tense posture melts into something sad all over again.

“Are you sure about this?”

“Yes”

“Alright,” the woman shuffles on her feet, taking a precarious step back though she still looks as if she diidn´t want to leave Catra there alone. “I— I guess I´ll leave you to it, then”

“Before you go,” Catra snaps suddenly, startling the woman who stops frozen in her tracks. Catra bites nervously into the inside of her mouth, gently grabbing the soft fabric of Adora´s hemation, still wrapped around her shoulders, and showing it to the young woman. “Can you tell me which color is this?”

Surprise written in her face in an understanding. The woman stares at Catra as if she had suddenly grown snakes on her hair and then down at the beautifully embroidered fabric.

“It´s blue.” Her factions soften after a few seconds, some kind of understandment falling over her as she looks back at Catra´s face. “Like your eyes”

“Oh.” Catra gasps, smoothing the hemation back around her shoulders, as she brings a hand towards her face, feeling the tip of her eyelashes against her fingertips. “Like my eyes.” she repeats, unable to hold her wonder.

Blue feels like the water from the lake, Adora had said once. *Easy, breathable but strong too.*

“What is it?” The woman asks, sweetly caring at Catra´s suddenly charged silence.

“I´m just surprised. My mother had different eyes.” Catra explains absently, not truly in the present. She leans down and runs the pads of her fingers over the smooth stone of one of the woman's bracelets, recalling a memory of her childhood that she thought long ago forgotten. “Like this”

“Amber”

“Amber.” Catra rolls the name of the colour on her mouth, tasting right with the memory of Io and her kind eyes before a still too young Catra lost her sight completely, before she learnt how important that blindness would be for her, a part of her. “Yes. I thought they would be like hers, not— different.”

Catra closes the eyes again, breathing deeply through her nose and the fabric that covers it. She doesn´t want to speak anymore of it because if she does she might break into so many pieces that she will not find the strength to gather herself again, scattered on the cold ground like the remains of Adora´s palace that lay at her feet.

She doesn´t realize the pensive expression now etched on the woman's face, in front of her, thinking about Catra´s words and then shrugging softly, placing a possible reason in the confusion.

“Well, maybe your eyes were a gift from someone else that loves you.” She whispers, easy as running water and it makes Catra open the eyes again, staring directly at the pale winter sun hovering above them until she feels them waterdown.

“I haven´t seen blue eyes like yours in a long time, to be honest.” The woman points out, gently, shifting in her feet as if she was suddenly nervous.

Catra tilts her head to the side, her ears low but twitching below the fabric of the hemation. “What do you mean?”

“I´ve only seen eyes like yours in the royal family.” The woman finally spits, vaguely pointing at the destruction around them. “The Prince and Princess, they had eyes like yours. So… strong, so purely blue. Like shades by stars”

Catra´s breath gets stuck in her throat, eager, the sudden need to know more stabbing her from side to side of her heart like a spear across her body.

“Did you know them?” she urges the woman, sinking down again when the latter shakes her head.

“I saw them once, from afar. When my mother took me to the palace to present ourselves to the kings and queen.“ The woman wrinkles her nose, looking back at Catra with gentle mourning. “They were good people”

Catra takes a sharp breath and nods, stepping away in shivering steps. The woman stretches her arms hesitatingly towards her but Catra snaps herself fully away, clenching her jaw until her entire face aches and she doesn´t feel anymore like she is about to cry.

“Are you sure you want to be here?” The woman asks one more time, wrapping herself tighter inside the blanket.

“Yes,” a bit and then, “Thank you”

“You're welcome.” The woman worries her lip between her front teeth, narrowing her eyes at Catra as if she was trying to understand her place in the world and could not understand it. “Can I know your name?”

Finally, Catra looks back at her directly in the eyes, taking in the shadow of them like the violets growing beneath her own soles and the seemingly sparkle living inside them. She looks kind, honest, tired and also wiser beyond her years. In another life, she might have been Catra´s friend.

“C´yra.” Catra takes a shivering breath, the corner of her eyes gathering with tears. “C´yra Latreíana.”

“That's a beautiful name, yours and your wife's.” The woman nods, looking at the beautiful knot around Catra´s waist. “Is good to meet you. I´m Féngo, daughter of Ántzela.” She grins, almost like an inside laugh. “Most people just call me Glimmer, though”

“It's good to meet you too, Glimmer,” Catra whispers, still keeping herself away but softer. Still broken and bleeding, but breathing.

“I´ll leave you to it.” Glimmer starts walking back down the road, the soft snow sauntering gently over her dawn hair and the ground, through which tiny grass has started to grow among the rubble. Glimmer turns her head back to Catra one more time, grinning at her sadly. “There will be a warm bed and food waiting for you at the temple, if you wish to come back. Just, keep it in mind”

Catra walks through the destroyed pieces of the palace, her feet still bare and her shoulders still cold. She walks through broken columns of marble and the galleries where art masterpieces used to lay before the Emperor and the war ended with everything on their pass.

She looks up at different kinds of open domes, where the ceilings have given up against the floor and the sky is as immense and beautiful as it can be. Blue, *blue,* like the hemation in her shoulders and Catra´s eyes and maybe, maybe, Adora´s eyes too.

Finally, she makes it to the main chamber of the original palace, wide, long, empty. Scattered with all bones in the edges and spears dug on the ground that have long ago crumbled too. From here Catra can see the bend shape of a strange form, melted, almost like the way a candle feels against her fingers when put against the fire.

Absently, something tells her it´s some kind of seat and it does not take her long after to understand that it must have been a throne once.

This is the first time Catra sees one and is as unimpressed as she thought it would be. Adora always spoke of the throne of her parents as something mighty and important but for Catra is just this, a pile of rubble that did not handle the flame.

And it reminds her of Adora´s parents, who Adora still loves but Catra cannot help but hate. Given the circumstances, she thinks she is allowed to hate them, just a little bit.

Instead of paying more attention to the broken throne, Catra looks away, the eyes in her face focusing on another kind of shape. Gentler, smooth, somehow intact in both surface and color even after the fire. It rests in the very middle of the chamber, kneeling on a mosaic floor long ago broken everywhere but where his body rests, unbroken and untouched by the hand of men or the pass of the time.

Catra gazes at him with her breath held, walking without realizing it until she is right in front of him, kneeling too on the ground and in between his stretched hands that cradle the empty air where he was once holding someone he loved dearly.

“Hey,” Catra greets him, choking on her breath. “So here you are”

Catra sits right there, hovering her face beneath his and taking, for the very first time, a sight of Adam´s face.

Kind features, that's what she can learn from his marble body. High cheekbones and sharp jaw; the stubble of a beard unsuccessfully grown during the summer that Catra always made fun about. Strong eyebrows and straight nose.

Long hair falling just above his shoulder and the lines of a sweet smile on his mouth. Almond eyes, halfway open, giving a look of love and devotion so honest that it can be seen even through the stone he has been casted into.

He was young, too young, and the realization of just how young he was, of how young Adora truly was that night makes Catra sob, a whimper and tears successfully ripped out of her heart as she looks up at her best friend and her brother in law, laying alone in a palace that has been finally freed to the sunlight.

“Well, weren't you a handsome one?”

Catra chuckles, without joy, without laughter, narrowing the eyes on her face towards the marble ones of Adam, looking at her without seeing at all.

I see you, even though you cannot see yourself. In the reflection of the river, in the marble stone, in impossible eyes. Waiting under the light.

“You were right, Adam.” Catra sobs, crystal tears rolling down her cheeks and falling over the hemation.“I did fall in love with your sister.” She whimpers, holding his wrists. “She was indeed so easy to love”

Catra stares at Adam's stone beautiful face and wonders just how much it might look to his sister. She stares at his face full of kindness and love for the world, for his sister who was inside his arms when he went away, without pain and loving her to his last breath, and lowers her head and cries.

There, in the debris, in the ash, in the snow. Between Adam's hands, under the blue sky, Catra cries.

“I´m sorry,” she gasps, breaking, finally feeling the true amount of suffering that her departure had brought, like a living heart cursed to be torn into two on different sides of the universe and still keep beating. “I´m sorry. I tried, I really tried. I don´t know how to go back”

Catra rests her forehead against the cold marble of Adam's neck and cries over his chest, big, deep, terrible, the heavy tears running down her cheeks and painting tracks over her skin, falling over the smooth stone and feeding the broken floor before where the first stems of olive trees start to grow, tiny and hesitant.

“Please, if you are there, help me.” Catra begs to him, only to him as the gods Catra so much loved have failed her. Pleading because she knows Adam loved Adora and there would not be anybody else she would trust with her anymore. “Help me come back to her.”

Catra curls over the ground where Adam's statue lays and cries there until she can't breathe anymore, until she thinks there are no more tears for her to shed. Until the floor is scattered with moss and stems and her own body is covered by the soft snowflakes falling over her, sticking to her eyelashes and her skin.

She stares at the cold sky over her head and the planes of Adam´s unchanging face hovering above her, narrowing her eyes when the trees growing around the place where they both are start to cover them from the freezing cold and the snow.

The long and beautiful leaves of the twin olive trees stretch their arms towards the sky and then leans towards each other, wrapping their branches like fingers that hold each other across the destroyed mosaics and the places where Adam lays, covering him and Catra, with her head leaned against his shoulder, in the gentle shadow of the leaves and their fruits, thriving even among destruction, thriving even in the merciless cold, as things that belong to their land can never be fully destroyed no matter how greedy the hand,

Catra looks at the beautiful greens of the beautiful trees and then at the olive shape of Adam´s marble eyes, shimmering with the snowflakes melting against his cheek when they touch him. Is a kind sight, in a way and among the suffering, a gentle kind of sight that Catra holds herself onto with all the strength she might have left.

Night has fallen over her by the time Catra gathers enough guts to stand up again, tiny roots and stems snapping off her ankles and wrists when sits down again in front of Adam, learning every single curve and fall of his face inside her memory like she did with the sweet and doomed sight of Adora´s hands.

She rests her cheek in the palm that was once cradling Adora´s face and breathes deep from the smell of the olive tree, watching its pale flowers saunter down and into her lap like snow all of their own. She runs the back of her knuckles across Adam´s face and stands up, tilting on her bruised feet several times before she actually dares to turn around from him, following the path of destroyed stone that leads somewhere away from him.

She hears the coo of the doves flying from the dark skies scattered with Adora´s stars, placing themselves in the nest of the olive trees and staring at Catra walking away with their mother of pearl eyes.

They speak to her, whisper to her, things spoken in a goddess voice that Catra tries to ignore. *A curse, a blessing.* They murmur around the fine fur of her ears, cradling the back of her head and pulling from her long hair. *A child of gods, a wife.*

Catra bats them away and walks through the palace without turning around to look at Aphrodite´s rose following her behind. She is not the love Catra is seeking for on every corner on this destroyed place and she will not turn around for anybody else but for her.

Night is easier for Catra, the closest thing she has to the misted sight she had before yet terribly different. Easier than days but still too bright. Even in the dryness of this world, the moons and the stars are bright all above the city and Catra can follow the corridors easily, without thinking, letting her feet follow their own direction and maybe even the whispers of doves that tell her where to go.

The princess tower is, somehow, miraculously still tall and strong. It might be a mock or maybe a gentle mercy, but even with the raging fire attacking it in the past the marble remains intact, the mosaics unbroken and the gentle wood of the heavy door unscratched.

Like Adam´s statue and tomb on the Hall of the throne, Adora´s chamber remains untouched. Catra wonders if it was some kind of blessing, one last thing the damn gods would do for her after they allowed it all to happen,no matter anymore just how much Catra used to trust in them before.

Catra stands in front of the closed door and stares at the tiny cravings made in there by a young hand before daring to push it open, tender night light flooding the mosaics at her feet when the chamber open completely for this eyes to see.

It´s Adora's, in every single aspect Catra could have ever known and imagined before.

It's Adora's in the blue mosaics on the floor creating the most marvelous shapes, shapes Catra doesn't know but that she thinks maybe they are the waves and the sand and the shape of ships, like the ones Catra used to wish to sail across Eternia once.

It's Adora's in the tall columns of marble and the ceilings where sweet wind chimes hang, creating beautiful sounds when they cradle each other gently. So much like the ones that hang on their bed that almost make Catra bent into herself and scream inside her palms all over again.

It's Adora's in the open windows that lead to the sea, to the dry meadows and the walls that Prime had built and that are now being crumbled to the ground. Where the breeze is warm even on a winter night and tiny grains of sand get stuck to Catra´s eyelashes when she looks outside.

It´s Adora´s in the soft bed propped against the tall pillars on the west wall, with the long blankets of bright colors embroidered in beads and sea crystals. In the pillows soft at the touch of Catra´s fingers even after eleven years have gone by since the last night Adora laid her head over them. In the canopy of soft fabric that shimmers like the stars outside, still lemongrass smelling when she rests her nose against the seams.

It´s Adora´s, in the parchments and ink spilled everywhere in the tables and the floor. In all the paints of many colors that Catra can only compare to the dawn and the flowers making their way up the columns, Maps and plans and paintings of buildings that Catra learnt by memory with the pads of her fingers and that now are on display for her to see in a different way.

It´s, in a way, like stepping inside Adora´s soul. Inside the secret and gentle part of Adora´s heart that had been protected and guarded but that no matter how long it had gone by Adora had never been able to truly bare completely, not in any way that not was in whispers, now placed almost fully inside Catra´s hands for her to guard.

Somehow, war did not manage to reach this place. Even roaring all around her, the fire and the doom that the Emperor had tried to submerge this world into, life had clung with all its strength to the very soil. Catra can see the stems of it, taking root on the cracks between the mosaics, growing tiny and hesitant but strong like paths across Adora´s chamber.

Catra tilts on unsure feet in the middle of Adora´s room, staring at the world around her without saying a world. She holds her breath and looks at the columns all around her and then beyond them, above them, at the beautiful tapestries hung from every single one of them.

One, two, three, many, so many of them, creating images like the stories Catra used to tell every night. Tapestries Catra knows and is learning all over again.

You´re the weaver that makes the tapestries for the princess, Adam had said once. Catra had not understood then but she does now, as she stares at the tapestries her own hands had woven years ago, hanging from Adora´s walls, she understands.

They really have been closer together for longer than she ever thought possible before, either by dreams or by the thread. Their lives have been so deeply laced to each other that when Catra catches sight of herself on the copper mirror on the side, she doesn´t know where Adora ends and she starts.

Like the tapestries around her, they are embroidered together, laced, knotted, woven. Catra is wearing her wedding dress and Adora´s beloved hemetion that covered for many nights alone. There is paint on her palms and soles by Adora´s hands and the Heracles Knot at her waist. Her hair is braided with coins and cuffs and jiggling with bells and there are smudged suns painted in her cheeks.

She has blue eyes, so blue it looks more like the ocean than the sky. Blue eyes with dark eyelashes heavy by the tears and the feeling of being completely lost to the world around her. Blue eyes like the night above her heads painted in violet petals by the moons, and the paint Adora had in her hands the day she lost her.

They give her sight but they are foreign to her, they do not belong to her, not completely.

Catra turns her eyes away and back towards the tapestries, sighing deeply at them, well loved and taken care of yet obviously old where they are covered by thick blankets of dust. Everything in here is covered by the merciless hand of time, not even inside this place that feels all ways holy, it has been able to escape that.

There is another tapestry here, closer to the vanity where sweet things linger. This one is rough and not made by Catra´s hands but is gentle, obviously made with love. Catra recognizes Adora´s handwork on it by the feeling of the seams braided over each other, the way she tenses the threads and she curates the fabrics.

In here, there are four people, almost all of their faces clear for Catra to see among the moonlight and the shadows. A man, a woman and two younger people, circling each other in a homedance that Catra almost recognizes.

She knows the first two are the old queen and king, Marlena and Randor, before everything, before their betrayal to the one they should have remained as loyal as human or god possible. She sees their faces turned in different directions to the younger ones, their eyes closed, and it is funny, in a way, how it seems to reflect a future that was to come.

Catra feels sorry for them but above all things she feels disappointment. Not hatred or rage, just the rawest form of disappointment she can possibly feel. Ugly and sticky like ooze, covering her perception of them like a night without light or Catra without her sun.

“You did not deserve her,” Catra whispers, like a venomous spit, these eyes gathering with tears. “You never did. She is kind and sweet and good, everything you were not. And I wish —” Catra takes a shivering breath, digging her nails inside her palms. “I wish I could hate you, but she loved you both so much, she loves you still. I hope wherever you end you never forget that and what you did to her.”

The younger forms and the kindest ones and Catra recognizes them almost immediately. There is Adam, not a day older than fourteen if the young features of his face and the short strands of his wheat hair that bounce above his shoulders. As on his statue, he is smiling, not at his parents or at the sun above their heads but at the queen of the stars that stands next to him, holding his hand even in the strands.

The fabric has been sliced in the middle of her face, covering her features into shadows. By the sharp blade of a knife or by nails, Catra is not sure, but it hides her face fully from Catra´s sight, even now. She can see the long wheat hair, her hands, the curves of her ankles beneath the color of her dress in the tapestry but her mouth, her nose and her eyes are tucked away from her by an external hand.

It would be so easy, so easy to run her hand over the sliced tapestry and see Adora as she was, a Mycenaean princess, a royal daughter, a prince's sister.

To see the face that the entire world deemed the most beautiful than the most tender of flowers. That made cities, villages and kingdoms whisper about her and her beauty like the myth of a goddess walking among the mortals. That made the worst person in the world seek her out and her kingdom like a rabid animal already trying to destroy the world.

To worship her like someone worships someone else on a pedestal, from far away, from the ground where she lingers in the tapestry.

But you cannot hold someone on an altar and Catra has worshiped Adora in many ways before. She knows what it is to truly devote yourself to someone you love. Tenderly.

It would be easy to see her face like Psyche saw Eros, in the middle of the night with only the moonlight and the old oil lamps to make her company. Easy and awaited, to turn the folded fabric and see her when Adora is not here to allow the sight herself, when she cannot decide, when she cannot say she doesn´t want to be seen like that anymore.

Catra caresses the fabric with her thumb and doesn´t turn it around. She follows the waves of her hair with her fingertips but doesn't push further, doesn't go beyond. Her devotion to Adora remains even in this, in guarding her even from herself where Adora has not chosen for herself.

Even this, right now, Catra here and Adora away, it was her choice. It breaks Catra, rips her apart like flesh, like blood, but she has to honor it for it was Adora's choice. And she loves Adora more than she hates what she has chosen.

Instead, Catra leans her forehead against the fabric in a quiet kiss and looks down, at the items scattered around the vanity in front of her. Round beads of iridescent colours that Catra learns are pearls by touch. Soft metal that she guesses is gold and crystals that must hold a value but that for Adora were like flowers holding the strands of her hair together.

She finds a winged brooch somewhere among a string of pearls and seashells and holds it close to her face, following the soft edges with these eyes and learning the tiny cravings on the metal.

It's well worn, by the tiny scratches over the surface. Well worn, almost daily, and for some reason left here before that night, waiting for its princess to come back.

Catra puts it on her hair, holding the thick curls that bounce against her temples, carrying it with her. She is aware this should count as some kind of stealing but then again she is married to her.

Catra is married to the wonderful woman that once slept and dreamed even awake in this chamber. Nothing can take away that from them, not even distance. So Catra thinks she is allowed to take this one thing with her.

The tapestry in front of her shakes suddenly and before she has time to react a tiny kitten jumps out of the shadows, falling in all soft paws among the pearls and slightly rolling on their belly when they look up and meet Catra's face directly.

“Oh.” Catra gasps, startled and out of breath by the sudden apparition. “Hey”

Her voice is sore, worn out and broken in all places. It makes Catra cry, the way she doesn´t recognize it in herself, the way it is foreign to her.

Catra bites into her mouth and looks away for a second, returning her eyes towards the wood vanity precariously. The baby kitten is still looking at her, their tiny ears perked up and their chubby face between their paws, regarding her in silence.

“Do you live here?” Catra asks gently, stretching her trembling hand towards the shivering kitten.

Their soft coat is of different colors, much like Catra´s hair, but it is also covered by the thick layer of ashes, clinging to the soft fur of their ears and paws and making their soft nose smudged by darkness.

They are coughing too, every once in a while, their tiny chest wheezing with the effort. They must have hidden somewhere during the fires and crawled over the ashes to escape until they found their way here, in the only safe place in these ruins.

“Poor thing, you are shivering.” Catra grabs them gently from their bottom and their tiny legs and lifts them towards her, carrying them over her chest and inside the warmth of Adora´s hemation until they finally stop shivering.

Catra checks them as best as she can, making sure they are not injured beyond their obvious fear and the smoke. She learns that she is a baby girl and that she cannot be more than two months old. And she is alone.

There are no siblings, no mother with her. She is an orphan, she is alone in this quiet chamber where a princess once slept, cradled in tapestries and covered in ashes, with the sand and the waves of the ocean beyond the window only to make her company.

Alone and quiet until she meets the warmth of Catra´s neck where she starts purring almost immediately, soothing herself and somehow also soothing Catra on the way.

Catra starts crying again, quietly. It falls across her cheeks and her wobbling chin and stains the fabric of the hemation, matting the soft fur of the tiny kitten with her tears.

“Look at you, you have two different eyes.” Catra sobs, cleaning her face with the heel of her palm and holding the baby kitten with the other. She looks at the amber and blue eyes of the little one and chuckles, wet with sorrow and void from joy, looking at the ceiling painted in stars with these blue eyes in her face. “They must be mocking me”

Catra sits on the floor below Adora´s bed until dawn starts to break again in the sky. She sees the colors painted in the sky and compares them to all the little trinkets placed around Adora ´s chamber, collected and carefully dotted over by Adora´s young hands.

The little brushes of the clouds that look like her bedsheets, the swirls in the sky that resemble the dry flowers hung from her mirror. The lingering stars that still clung with all their strength to the new day and that are a perfect reflection of the ones painted on Adora´s walls and the columns, a map all of her own where Adora learnt and studied the skies before being casted away from them forever.

She remains there until her legs are both numb and they ache from laying over the cold floor and the baby kitten and nibbling on the sort cartilage of her ears, reassuring, even as a baby, where Catra didn't realize she had begun to cry all over again.

From the window of Adora's chamber Catra can see the destroyed domes of a temple, once big and mighty and now quiet and dark even below the colors of the dawn.

Catra recognizes this temple too, she knows it from Adora's stories. The temples of the gods she used to love, where Adora was a Priestess and a devotee and much later a martyr.

A place where Adora begged for her life, even before the curse, at the foot of the altar where she obtained no answers but a prophecy that is the end did manage to split them in half all over again.

Catra remembers the nights cradling Adora in her arms when she would tell Catra everything about that life, about that time, in drowned out voices and shivering whispers, pouring it out like a poisonous wound from her chest. When she felt alone and forsaken for being she used to trust in, like Catra did.

And even with all of that faith, Catra is here walking in cold paths of abandoned gardens towards the abandoned temple; and Adora is away, in the cavern that had become their home. They have been torn apart, by a salvation that for Catra feels more like the cruelest of curses; by the hand of a man wielding a holy grail.

Catra stands in front of the empty altars of the temple, looking without really seeing anything at all.

She takes on the cold that has settled inside this place, slipping around her very bones. In the old oil lamps that don´t even have a drop of oil to start a fire, the mosaics of gods mightiness that have been covered by both ash and dirt and the destroyed statues of the same that lay scattered in debris all around the floor.

In a way, they remind Catra of the broken statues at the mouth of Adora´s cave, of their cave, where a dozen and more people tried to murder Catra´s love by the sword and the bow. Also stone, also broken, also cold and unfair and easily forsaken.

They are the same, and also in a way Catra thinks is funny that the one man that managed to tear them apart is not on those remains. That he lays rotting somewhere in the forest, now thick with trees and life born from Catra´s very tears, where his bones will turn into dust and he will become dust. Nothing.

Even now, the shadow of his hand is slowly but surely erased from the memory of the world by its people, by the light. A world Catra wants to give to Adora and Adora alone but that she can´t even remember how to navigate, how to return to.

Catra places the tiny kitten gently over the floor, sleepy inside Adora´s hemation, and turns towards the altars. She sees the trinkets left here, long ago defiled from gold or any kind of valuable jewelry Prime´s men could take from themselves. Scattered with the dry and old petals of flowers that Catra cannot recognize, not like this.

She sees herself in the reflection of a broken shield fallen from Athena's statue. Catra can see the fall of her shoulder, slim without Adora´s hemation to wrap them into warmth. Can see the shiver of her hands, thin and with her nails broken in all places after crawling on the earth trying to find her way back.

She can see, *see, t* he soiled fabric of her wedding dress and the Herculean knot around her waist. The laces around her ribs and hips where Adora gently knotted bows over the fabric, like a last vow of love before trying to set her free.

She can see the jewelry with which Adora adorned her too. The beads that feel like pearls around her neck and collarbones, the bracelets of coins that sound like bells and were once laced around Adora´s ankles. The earrings of gold and the fine chains around her forehead like crowns, and absently Catra wonders if Adora dresses her up like this so the world would know she was some kind of royal and would care for her as she knew no other way to protect her outside the walls of her exile.

Absently, Catra resents her for it.

Catra can see the wing pin she took from Adora´s chamber, holding the thick of her long curls, and the way the same bounce and twist over the fabric of her mother´s, of Io´s, hemation wrapped around her waist and of the color pressed berries. There was nothing Adora kept from Catra that could keep her warm in this winter and Catra feels sick at the thought of it, that she gave Catra all of her warmth and kept none in return.

In the mirror of the shield, Catra can see herself. The sunken cheeks, the dark skin paled by grief, the circles around her eyelashes, the dry skin of her mouth. The ellipses reflected on her irises, born from the single strand of a new sun that slips through a crack in the ceiling and falls over her.

She can see these eyes, these eyes that are not hers. Blue and beautiful; kind and overflowing with tears, looking back at her with all the love and all the sorrow in the world.

I see her in you even if you cannot rest your eyes in hers

“I would have stayed in that cavern my whole life.” Catra hears herself say, her voice bleeding with pain. “I would have lived there, loved there, grown old there.”

Catra looks at her reflection and her reflection looks back at her, holding all the grief in the world, mourning in life someone that is not gone but that Catra cannot reach. It's worse, it's so much worse than before because Catra had everything, all of it in the very palm of her hands and she thought she could protect it if she guarded it inside her heart and, still, it was ripped out of her. It´s not fair.

“Why did you do it?” Catra asks, grieves, cries, all over again.

Until the sorrow gives away for something else, that sticky ooze clinging to her soul that finally makes its way around her throat and starts to choke her out, pushing her heart and her voice until all that comes out is a yell and, suddenly, Catra is screaming.

“Why did you do it?! WHY DID YOU DO IT?!”

Catra grabs the fabric and past offerings of the altar and tossed them to the sides. Violent, rageful, out of control. She sees them tumbling to the ground and breaking in dozens of pieces and screams at them. Turns her face towards the shield and screams at her own

reflection, pushing from the heavy metal until that too falls over her ground and cracks in the middle, breaking the sight of these eyes and body into unrecognizable parts.

She screams. She screams and screams and screams. Screams like she has never done it before, until her voice is bleeding and she is gasping for air and still she keeps screaming. Until she is coughing around a mouthful of blood and her eyes are drowned by tears that turn the ground around her iridescent and soft and still she screams again.

She screams as if she had been struck down by arrows, as if the spear had crossed her from the chest to the ground, as if the sword had cut her open in the middle and spilled all of her guts and her heart into the cold snow gathering over old mosaics.

As if the venomous snake had bitten her and poisoned her the wild flower and she was dying a slow death, a merciless one. The kind that drags on and on until Catra is begging for the end to come just so she doesn´t have to keep going for a single second more of this agony where she is half a wife and all the sorrow, roaming a world defiled and murdered without the warmth of another hands around her heart to cover it from the merciless winter.

Catra slams all of the vases and breaks all of the mirrors, refusing to look at herself for a second longer, as she already knows herself and doesn´t need this unwanted sight to know herself. The opens her palms with the sharp edges of the stones and bruises the back of her hands and the soles of her feet with the outburst, with the rage consuming her worse than the fires that almost destroyed Etheria.

“I TRUSTED YOU, I TRUSTED YOU.” Catra hears the screams echoing all around her, the shadow of Echo following her around where she has fallen in love with the sun instead of a narcissus. “I LOVED YOU, I LOVE HER. WHY?! ANSWER ME, WHY?!”

Catra falls heavily on her knees and her palms, resting her forehead against the cold marble as she takes a shivering breath and just cries, loud sobs that turn this dry world into a cold winter where no other color exists but the pale of the snow and the blue in the sky.

She sees the shattered pieces of beautifully painted clay vases. For a moment, Catra drags her heavy soul and her living corpse over the floor and lets herself fall against the steps of the destroyed altars like a fallen goddess all by herself, never like a martyr.

She refuses to see herself yet here she is, her reflection on the surface of the snow that has melted with the touch of the sun twinkling beyond the roof of the temple. She looks back at these eyes and she thinks, for the split of a second, that she can see someone else in there too, too fast for her to remember, too beautiful for her to recognize.

“C’yra” Catra hears a gentle voice coming from the columns of the temples, stepping off the shadows and into the light. ‘You have grown again”

Catra snaps her head to the side, meeting the mesmerizing eyes of the old woman standing patiently to the side. Her hair has gone silver and white, long ago aged out by the pass of time; her tunic is simple and practical, old also by the look of it with the beautiful color washed out long ago, so long it brushes the floor every time she moves; or maybe this woman is just tiny, with her knotted hands and her earlobes heavy with earrings.

There is a kind of kindness with which she carries herself in the spot next to Catra , tender but also firm, her back long ago bent by the weight of the ages and the memories. Standing there between the shadows and the single ray of sun where she studies Catra´s face with a kind of sweetness that makes Catra hold her breath.

The old woman's eyes are liquid and bright like the sun on the sky and for a moment Catra think she might be blind except that the woman is looking at her with so much wisdom written on her face that Catra is sure she is looking at her, truly and beyond ways Catra can possibly begin to understand.

“It´s you, isn´t it?” Catra spats, choking with her own breath when she brings her hands towards these eyes. “The Oracle. You foresee this. You knew they would curse us to this”

The Oracle sighs, heavily, almost as if it made her deeply sad. She looks from Catra to the destroyed pieces of the altars and beyond, to the broken statues. She regards them in charged silence, as if the pain of what happened weighed down on her where the only thing she ever could do was watch it happen.

“A curse, a blessing.” The Oracle whispers, resting over the long cane at her side when she turns to look at her back, “You and Adora, both know sometimes blessings are hidden as pains, and what seem as punishments are hiding miracles”

“What is that supposed to mean?” Catra chuckles, hysteric and beyond reason, listening to it all with her heart roaring inside her eardrums.

“The Fates are testing you, C´yra. Both of you”

I see immeasurable love and with it you´ll carry immeasurable grief

“I don´t want this!” Catra barks, slamming her hands over and over again the mosaics until her entire body is screaming alongside her with the pain. “I don´t want them mingling in my life!”

Catra feels like throwing all the things from the temple again but she cannot find the strength in herself to do it anymore. She lays where she is and covers her face with her snow stained hands, letting the sobs wreck her completely from the inside out.

The soft steps of the woman make a silent sound when she approaches Catra, her bare soles somehow avoiding the sharp ends of the broken things fallen between her and Catra.

The Oracle sits on the cold floor next to Catra, close enough that she can feel the woman's warmth through the wrinkles of the fabric. For a moment Catra thinks the woman will place her hands over her shoulder but she remains patiently away, instead staring at the sun pouring inside with newfound strength.

“Let me tell you a story, storyteller. Dreamwalker.” The Oracle whispers, very gently. “Before the first songs were sung and the first tales were written, there were the heavens and there was silence in the world. Then there was a goddess without a name, a daughter of the

queen of the heavens who loved the world so much that it made the king afraid of what she would become."

Catra takes a shivering breath, tangling his bruised fingers around the matted loops of her hair, pulling from them until she feels the roots protesting under the tension.

"In his fear, he tore her apart, right in the middle. He made of her half of a soul in two bodies and delivered them to the mortal world where he believed they would never meet again." The Oracle chuckles, as if the sadness of the story amused her deeply. "He thought he could control her like this but instead he freed them. He did not turn her into two threads of Fate drifting apart but a single thread split in the middle, tangled forever together no matter how many lives might pass or in which ways they would be pushed away from each other. A kind of love like that requires a lot of loyalty, and a lot of patience. And it can hold a lot of power to be taken lightly."

The Oracle looks at the shadows that the sun creates above their head, smiling secretly at them.

"You see, dear child, like Adora´s ellipses, both of you are nature creatures. You come and go from this earth together and most times than not, you breathe from it together too." The Oracle grabs Catra´s trembling hand and presses it palm down over the ground, watching marveled as tiny sprouts of life begin to grow under her touch. "You are bound to this earth and to each other and no matter how long the thread of your joined life stretches, you will always meet again."

Catra crumbles down. She falls inside the old woman's arms and the latter holds her in kind, soothing her as she luls her from side to side at the feet of the destroyed altars.

"I miss her. I miss her so much. I can't live without her"

"You can, my dear. You have to"

"I don't want to. I love her, I love her, I love her. I love her so much. I can't do this without her. Please, help me find my way to her, please tell them to return her to me. Please"

It´s terribly sad, this, the way in which the very old woman holds a young woman crumbling into pieces. It reminds Catra of her mother, of Io´s warm arms where the nights were too dark and the silence too overwhelming.

The baby kitten comes too, over Catra´s lap, pressing their small body against her chest and purring immediately, like a little gift from the earth herself to remind her that she is not alone in here. Even miles and miles away, Catra can feel Adora´s warmth, wrapped around her very soul as only the most tender of loves knows how to do.

"Why?" Catra mourns, pulling from her own hair and holding the woman's hands tight. "Just tell me why"

The Oracle hums, thinking about it deep and soft. As always, when she speaks it is not with the answer you might want to hear but the one you might just need.

“You love her more than anything.” She whispers and it slices Catra open all over again. “You would die for her and she would die for you. But C´yra, my dear, she needs to choose to live for you too. And for herself.”

Catra shakes her head, grinding her teeth together until she feels her gums bleed and her mouth ache. Even warm she feels empty in all the places that matter, all those she cares about. Her palms, her arms, her womb, her very mouth.

But not her heart, that one remains full, filled by Adora and the years they´ve had together. All those beautiful days and nights filled with light and Adora´s voice right next to her, those cannot be taken away by anything or anyone; man, god or even Adora.

That is Catra and Catra´s alone and she will protect it with her life no matter how much it takes Adora to come back to her.

“C´yra, your love will save her.” The woman whispers, in her voice, in her grandmother´s, in Io´s, in Adam´s, all the people that ever loved her, gathering her shivering body inside her arms and it makes Catra feel like a small child all over again. “But it is her who needs to choose, only her. You cannot do that for her, she has to do it all on her own.”

Catra closes these eyes until all she sees is darkness, true darkness and the sparks of promised light beneath her eyelids. Until all she hears, feels and touches is warmth but a different kind of the one that is actually holding her, one that remains in the exile of a cavern where they were the happiest through war that now is over.

“She must choose to turn around and follow you back. And you have to trust she will, blindly.”

“But why?”

“Because you carry her eyes”

There is a gift, however, for you

The world around her is broken, but it can heal. It´s tainted by the war of one man and the rage of the gods, but the people living in it are like the seeds of their olive trees. Sturdy, strong, nurturing, resilient in the face of fire and kind enough to bloom again under the touch of the sun.

Catra looks at the ground sprouting with her flowers and at the land all around her, covered by snow and the first blooms of winter flowers, the first ones in many years. Even in this harsh cold, beautiful things can grow.

“This is Adora´s kingdom,” she whispers. “This was her home.”

“It was.” The Oracle corrects her softly and in a way Catra thinks it goes beyond what she understands right now. “It was always meant to fall and it was always meant to be brought to a different kind of glory again.”

“And me? What is my role in this play?”

“There is no game anymore, dearie.” The Oracle smiles, cleaning the tears forever painted below Catra´s eyes. “You were always meant to become a queen. A different kind from the one that sits in the throne”

Catra exhales, shivering and deeply terrified, but in a different way than the first step she gave into this land. She holds Adora's hemation in her chest and her eyes inside her heart.

“What do I do?”

“You're her light.” The Oracle looks at the sky now, smiling to the past destruction being cradled with flowers. “Pull them out of darkness”

Catra closes her first around the fabric, biting into her own mouth with sudden anger.

“They do not deserve it”

“Maybe not.” The Oracle smiles at her, in a way that makes Catra's ears lower down her heart to squeeze inside her chest. “Maybe you're closer to understand what a god feels, after all”

Catra holds her breath, feels like screaming again, but the Oracle stops her very gently. It feels like a messenger more than a prophet, right now in this moment between the both of them. An old woman and a young one, both blind and both seeing in different ways. Both god touched.

“You can destroy.” The woman whispers. “You can build again.” She wraps Catra inside the blue fabric. “You can see, learn.” She brushes the loops of long hair behind low ears. “You can wait.” And she smiles and her smile reminds Catra a little bit of her mother. “You can do everything, C´yra”

Catra blinks, slowly, at the woman's blazing eyes and old face, wrinkled by the wheels of time. Painted by the ellipses of the sun. And Catra thinks that these very ellipses are the most beautiful things Catra is able to see now.

Adora was right.

“What's your name?”

“Razz”

“Razz.” Catra lets her eyes fall closed, just one second longer, and then opens them again, drinking off the colors of the world around her. Athena’s healing blood, Adora's gift. “And after? What do I do after?”

Razz kisses her fluttering eyes and smiles, already knowing what is to happen.

“You can give her peace.”

I don’t care how, where, or when

No matter how long it's been, you’re mine

Don’t tell me you’re not the same person

You’re always my husband

And I’ve been waiting, waiting …

… For you

— **Jorge Rivera–Herrans**, *Epic XL: Would you fall in love with me again*

Chapter End Notes

NOTES:
- In ancient greece, some people believe married women wore their spouses name plus the "iana" sufix. Or a more femenine variation of their name. In this case, Catra calls herself "Latreíana" as "Λατρεία (latria) is the word for "adoration". Married woman without children were also called Nymphe
- I didn´t mention it before but Herakles Knots are used as wedding knots and mean protection, love, devotion, commitment and loyalty.

Thank you so very much for all your support, comments and for sticking along through this story. I´ll see you all on May 14th for the end :) Love you, be good

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

Welcome to the last chapter of this love story :,)

I´m not going to lie, I´m very emotional right now, but I hope everyone enjoys the last chapter of this journey. Today we say a final hello to our girls, but never a total goodbye. We might see each other around the white shores of Eternia once again.

For now, I leave you with them. Much love :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Epilogue. Tides

You only have to look at the Medusa

straight on to see her.

And she is not deadly.

She is beautiful.

And she is laughing

— Hélène Cixous

For Adora, the world is green. A different kind of green than the one that broke the world and poisoned the earth, the one that casted her away.

No, that green was unnatural, unwanted and poisonous, slipping into the ground and the temples like spiderwebs. Reaching long claws on the grass and eating away all the other colors. Adora has not thought of that green in a long, long time.

Now the world is green in a way that aches like a promised kiss. Soft, gentle, long awaited. Green that lives in the grass, in the plants, in the moss.

In the vines heavy with colorful flowers that travel over the long marble pillars of the buildings. In the bushes that scatter the ground and the walls of stone of beautiful painted houses, new and beautiful, built with love and taken care of them with the very same devotion.

In the paths on the ground, dug with diligent hands and smoothed with sea stones, salt smelling and gentle after many steps walking over them, making them both new and well worn. New paths, different to the ones Adora remembers from early years but with the same purpose, guiding the people living and breathing inside this place back to their homes.

Now the green lives in the markets, scattered in stalls with cheerful tents and a myriad of trinkets, so many more than Adora ever saw in her entire life. Before there was jewelry and tapestries and clay vases; now there is all of that but also art, song, people sitting together just to sing and play music. Tall murals made with artesian hands and love in their hearts.

Food on every single stall, vegetables and fruits of so many variations and colors that for a second Adora wonders if she is back to the secret garden that she left behind in a hidden cave. Heavy, ripe, sweet and deeply fulfilling. Salted meat and curated skin for a winter that has long passed for this land. Adora can see it all.

And she sees, above all things, the way it is given freely to the people walking by. A basket of pomegranates exchanged by the beautiful woven length of a purple fabric; a golden necklace heavily exchanged by a bag of healthy seed, ready to be planted and nurtured into something equally as beautiful as gems.

A song for a dance; a dress for a ribbon; a vase clay for wine. Over and over again, Adora sees this exchange as she has never seen it before. She sees golden coins too but fewer and fewer until she realizes they have become a matter of habit and not of need.

She observes it from beneath the thick fabric wrapped around her eyes, sheer enough to allow her to see the world around her, but not completely as to be a danger for the beautiful life dancing all around her.

Adora stands in the middle of the paths of Etheria, and observes how life has managed to grow again, to flourish and bloom and be beautiful and kind all over again, without a greedy hand to suffocate it down, without blood and without war. Without her, the world has gone on without Adora and she is glad for it, she is grateful.

It took Adora many, many years to find her way back here. It took her fourteen years to come back to the place she once called home, but now that she is here Adora can´t help but to stand still under the beauty that her land has become.

At the beginning, she remembers white buildings. White, white and tall and pristine, smooth and perfect even after the pass of time, so much they were declared an epitome of royalty and wealth between the people that lived in them. And there were only nobles living in these now bright streets, with expensive jewelry and heavy clothes, dragging with them some kind of sense of fake beauty that in the end only condemned Etheria into nothingness.

Now, the buildings are colorful, like a gentle rainbow, like a cluster of flowers that Persephone has bloomed into the world after a long time of her absence.

And they are not perfect either, not in the way the architects of the past would have deemed. They are not all perfectly symmetrical, perfectly smooth and without mistakes. They are of all sizes and all shapes too, square, circular, shapeless in some places. They have tiny cracks

on the wood doors and the walls are built from sturdy stone but they have been covered by the sweet presence of vines. Bugambilias and wisterias and wild roses, all of them with their beautiful colors showering this land with beauty.

They have tall domes or short ones where the light of the golden sun slips inside as a promise of forever warmth. And the doors are open, all of them, letting their habitats and their neighbours walk inside and out, sharing both food, stories and laughter with each other as if it had always been like this, as if empathy and kindness had always been the norm between the people and never the exception.

What Adora once knew as the royal and white upper city of Etheria, is now the most beautiful sight she has ever seen. Where people of all kinds smile at each other and nobody looks down on the other..

Maybe that's what living through war does, maybe that's what it makes us remember, that at the core of existence we were all supposed to be kind.

The streets that Adora once remembered washed in gold, even in the stones on the floor, are now scattered gently by sea shells and murals. They follow Adora as she walks through these new houses, these new paths. The sound of the gentle waves at the shore accompany her, a sound that has not changed no matter how many years have gone by for Adora and for the world.

But the port changed, and with it, Adora thinks she has never seen the sea as blue as she does now, standing in leather sandals over the soft sand. There are no more warships polluting the waters, but wood boats painted in blues and maroons and greens, meant for fishing and traveling and not for conquer.

The people walking barefoot on the sands and the waters laugh and they share stories of mythical creatures of the sea that are not meant to scare them but to fill them and their children with wonder. Even here, the world seems brighter for Adora, and not for the first time since she stood here she wonders what goddess blessed her birth home, and she quietly thanks her, under her breath.

There are new temples too, this too different to the ones she had known before. In another time it would have been scandalous, sacrilegious even, and it might have started another godly conflict between the Pantheon, and for all of this it seems deeply amusing for Adora too.

Before, the temples were humongous, a whole mile of land for each god that had blessed Etheria and it´s glory. Dripping with gold, turquoise and as much richness as it could be found on every corner of Eternia, from the furthest away to the ones made with the worn out hands of their artisans.

Now, all of them lay gently on the top of the hills around the city, smooth stones where the richness are the nurturing earth and the gold are the fields of wheat and perenne grass all around them. They are big too, and magnificent too, but they are together. And while Adora cannot see the gods they have been raised for, she can see the myriad of people walking on gentle pace up on the hills to present their offerings and their gratitude.

Even after everything, after the pain, the fear and the long years, Adora thinks she can finally understand them, the people. Everyone needs just a little bit of faith where to hold themselves onto, being the gods, the miracles, the skies or the very earth. Each other or the fruits or the laughter.

For Adora, who has known the gods and their games and their faults too better than anyone else in this world, her faith rests in a single woman.

The weather is warm but the breeze is fresh, not too cold, not too humid, and in this golden noon of May, Adora walks among the new life of her people without them knowing what she is or the terror that she could inflict if she is not careful. And she walks in streets filled with laughter where Adora is not being hunted or chased but being walked by just like any other of them.

The soft fabric of her veil tangles a little on her legs when she walks. She smooths the pink fabric tighter around her head and her head, and keeps walking, lowering her head every time someone walks too close from her as to feel their warmth against her.

The serpents are very quiet under the veil, laced in two thick braids from her scalp and all the way down towards the middle of her back, hidden from sight by the veils. They lay almost asleep by the May sun, drowsing off and almost falling off where Adora has to gently nudge them back into place several times.

She is definitely overdressed by this time of the year and the fashion of the city, with the several veils around her head and her mouth, the hemations over her shoulder and waist and her long chiton draped around her body in pale colors.

She sees a few people turning their heads towards her with curiosity and then get distracted when Adora immediately looks away, taking her just as another newcomer arriving in the city for the very first time.

A couple of children rush next to her, laughing at the top of their laughs and ignoring her completely. But their huge smiles and skipping steps don´t go unnoticed for Adora, even when she is looking strictly at her feet and not at them.

She has fallen on her face more times than she can possibly count like this, but even with the thick ropes barely allowing her to see, she doesn´t dare to risk it, not even for the swift spark of joy and of sharp pain that blooms in her chest at the sound.

She wishes, deep inside her chest, that she had been able to show this to Adam, All of this, a world, their home, where their people are able to laugh like this, to share each other's work and joy like this. Something they always talked about and that they never thought they would get to see, not after what happened, but that is here right now in front of her. Real.

Real, like Adora´s presence in this world. Like her steps over the stones and her eyes hidden yet roaming the world this green and beautiful world over and over again in fear that if she looks away she might blink and everything will be dark and lost as all those years where she the war consumed it and Adora never believed she would see it like this ever again.

Real, like the Heracles knot woven in purple and golden thread, fastening around her waist like the gentle hands Adora misses and loves.

Adora walks and walks and walks under the noon light until she finds a quiet stall, already picking up the products of the day and getting ready to go to the daily night festivities and home.

There is a woman behind the stall, around Adora´s age with the dark skin of her cheekbones painted in golden suns and her hair of a sheer blue so similar to the coral and the ocean that it makes Adora take a swift second look. She is wearing the layered skirts Adora grey up with and the open shirt with sea life embroidered in the seams, making her look bright and cheerful around the already beautiful colors around the city.

Something inside Adora goes tender at the sight of these traces of her culture that she remembers better than anything, that she held onto for almost two decades and that make her feel all kinds of soft and all kinds of sorrowful at the sight of them.

Adora doesn´t realize just how long she must have been standing there without moving until the woman turns around and gives a jolt of surprise, startled by Adora´s quiet presence unmoving in front of her stall.

“Oh, my sweet goddess. What in the gods' names?” The woman exclaims, gasping for air.

Adora curls around herself in shame, hiding her face further inside the veils and focusing her sight towards the wood of the stall, whitened by the salt of the sea.

“I apologize,” Adora mutters, barely above a whisper. “I didn´t mean to scare you”

“No, you didn´t.” The woman rushes to say, humming under her breath when she realizes Adora is still refusing her eyes. “Well, just a little bit. Even after so long has gone from that shitshow you remain a little iffy. Bit whatever, is there anything I can help you with? We are almost closed?”

A wisp of delicious smell suddenly hits Adora´s nose, making the snakes stir from their drowsy state and sizzle, very softly and under their breaths. It sounds more like a jiggling but Adora still shushes them down with a swift pull of the veil, her heartbeat skyrocketing inside her chest.

The woman must have heard part of it too but she misunderstands the sound, humming under her breath gently.

“Maybe a plate of warm food? Spinerella down there makes an amazing stew with the fish we bring. I can bring you a plate.”

“No, thank you,” Adora rushes to say, shaking her head very gently. She doesn´t want to attract more attention than needed, she is already taking a horrible risk right now but she has to do it, there is not another way. She doesn´t know where else do to. “I— I´m looking for someone”

The woman in front of her takes a second and sighs, not with annoyance but actually sweetly, moving somewhere beyond the stand. She has slightly worn out hands, creased by the work at the sea yet taken care of too, testimonies of a life that got a little rough in the edges but that now is kind.

“Everybody seems to be looking for someone lately.” The woman comments, grabbing the fabric of her own hemation and wrapping it around her shoulders.

Adora´s frown burrows under the veils, suddenly confused. “What do you mean?”

“Ever since the war ended, you know. Many people lost loved ones.” The woman takes a shiverin breath and so does Adora, both of them shaken for different reasons, both touched by war in different ways. Both standing in the very same green world yet miles apart. “Anyway, who are you looking for?”

“My wife.” Adora tries to, she really tries to, but her voice still splinters in the middle when she speaks the works. It breaks in all places and bleeds her all over the salted wood and the woman's gaze, clear for the world to see the sorrow she carries within.

“Oh, I see.” The woman murmurs, realizing too the amount of grief that this stranger that has arrived to her stall carries over her shoulder. It must be that, what makes her bend down a little, searching for Adora´s eyes beneath the veils and the blindfold.

Adora snaps her head again, almost violently, closing her eyes until her temples ache with the sparks of tension and all she sees are silver flashes of light beneath her closed eyelids. “Please don´t look at me”

“Alright. I´m sorry.” Adora hears the woman move away immediately, her tone dropping from curious to apologetic. “Scars of the war? My husband lost an eye.”

She waits in silence for Adora to answer but all that Adora manages to do is grunt unintelligibly, praying she drops the matter. Fortunately she does because the next time she speaks to Adora is with a new found kind of kindness, still lingering with curiosity but respectful of the way Adora wraps herself away from any sight.

“What does your wife look like?” The woman asks, and the question alone, even as mundane as it should be, makes Adora exhale deeply, her mouth filling with the taste of honey dew and lemongrass.

“She is a bit short.” It stumbles out of her mouth, and Adora just knows that her love would kick her in the sheen if she could hear her which makes Adora only want to cry all over again. She has cried so much and for so long right now, that sometimes she thinks the very rivers are made of her tears. “Brown hair with traces of copper, very, very long. Golden freckles on her cheeks and nose. Dark skin, gentle hands. She has— silver eyes, I think.”

Adora chokes with her words, suddenly unsure. She doesn't know what her eyes look like and it makes her all kind of desperate and all kind of insane because it reminds her exactly why she let her go in the first place. And all the other things remind her why she turned around to look for her.

“Beautiful, she is beautiful. And she is kind and stubborn. She is the most wonderful woman you could ever meet.”

Adora takes a shaking breath, suddenly out of breath. She imagines the look the woman must have been giving her, incredulous, annoyed even maybe, as if everyone and their kind did not think their spouses were the most wonderful thing in the world, Adora is not special. But Adora´s love is, she is special, she is bright and beautiful like this world and Adora doesn´t know how to live a single day more without her.

“She is a magicat,” Adora ends in a sore whisper, curling around herself with grief.

The woman of blue hair drums her fingers over the wood a few times, deep in thought as she turns around.

“Mmm. Sea Hawk!” She calls towards the very back of the stall, near the port where the boats float calmly.

The woman waits impatiently and for a moment Adora is not sure what she supposed to be waiting for until she sees a burst of auburn hair snapping up from the deck of the ship, a big mustache and dark blue clothes the swift things Adora sees from the man that stands up before lowering down her face again, hiding among the shadows of the stall.

“Yes my lovely?!” The man calls back, followed immediately by the sound of a lot of trinkets falling everywhere and the characteristic thud of a body slamming against the wood of the deck, a told tale that the man in his rush to reach his wife again has tripped and fallen flat on his face.

“Ugh, please don´t burn another ship.” The woman mutters with the kind of fond exasperation that reminds Adora so much of her own wife that almost manages to bend her in half and break her. “Have we seen any magicat around here these days?”

“Not as of lately, my bloom!” The man exclaims back, slightly out of breath but back on his feet if the sound of clumsy footsteps near the stall can say anything about it. “Most magicats have gone to the forests of the south, where it is more humid.”

“Well, there you have it,” The woman nods with a small hint of victory but Adora is already shaking her head, her face crumbling beneath the veils even if the two people cannot see her.

“I just came from there,” Adora explains, her voice sore. “She is not there either.”

There is a moment of suspended silence where it's quite obvious that Adora has made the entire thing awkward. And they pity her, Adora feels it all the way to her very bones and she almost screams and the touch of it, finally understanding what her own love meant about unwanted pity.

But in another way, she can understand it, the way in which the woman and her husband must share a look of quiet comprehension that Adora refuses to believe or even think about; the way they knew everything about the war that swept through the world and how still hangs like a shadow of infinite grief no matter how much the world is green now.

“Sorry.” The woman whispers, resting her palm flat and calm over the stall. “How long have you been looking for her?”

“Three years.” Adora gasps and it feels like eternity, it feels like a forever kind of curse different to the one she lives with. It feels and tastes like guilt and sorrow and bitter yearning. Adora hates herself for it.

“That's an awfully long time.” The woman comments under her breath, trying to remain gentle yet that sharp edge of realism slips in her words too. “There were lots of casualties during the war—”

“She is alive.” Adora cuts her short, maybe too sharp and too rude but she cannot avoid it. She digs her nails inside her palms and grinds her teeth together, spitting every word through her clenched jaw. “She is alive, please just– I´ve been traveling to every single corner of Etheria for three years. I don´t know where else to go”

Adora has traveled on foot. Since the moment she set a terrified foot out of the cave to not look back at it ever again; since the moment she walked into the woods filled with green and with life and proceeded to get lost immediately after, she has been traveling.

She didn´t even realize how long it had gone by from the moment she had let her love gone and the time she finally found the bravery to realize she did not want this, did not want to live like this in this cave that had been a home but was now beautiful and empty. That she would risk everything just to be with her again no matter what she would have to do, wrap her eyes in blindfolds forever or pluck out her eyes. After all, Adora knows blindness first hand and she knows the person that carried it with honor and gentleness, Adora is sure she could do the same for her, just to be with her again.

Didn´t even realize that by the time she set foot outside, an entire year had gone by. That it was winter but the world was cradled with beauty and flowers. And from then on, Adora had been looking everywhere for her, no matter how long it took her to arrive, how difficult it was to hide, how afraid she was for someone to realize what she was. Adora would do this, over and over again for the rest of her life until she could come back like she had promised to her.

Across the woods and the forest; up the mountains and the cliffs; across every single meadow and through the seas. On foot, on stolen horse; with the help of people taking her in cart or ship, deeming her wounded by the war and pitying her for looking without an answer to the person she had lost.

Up and down and across Eternia looking for a place nobody knew about and for someone that had somehow disappeared among flowers until she had found her way back here, to the one place she was so terrified to return.

Her past home that she had thought lost and that is instead bursting with life. A past home that had Catra´s hand painted on every colorful corner and patch of flowers. And Adora knows, even if the fisherwoman and her husband does not know her, she knows Catra was here once. Adora can feel her, in the very air.

“Is her name C´yra?”

A fourth voice comes from behind Adora, gentle and curious. The mention of Catra´s name startles Adora so much and pulls from her heart with so much strength that Adora turns around without even thinking about it, dipping her head down immediately after and silently thanking the sheer blindfold and veils without which the tall man behind her would have been lost into marble by accident.

“Yes.” Adora gasps, her heart speeding up inside her throat. *C´yra. Catra, Catra, Catra, that's her name. She is here, she is.* “Is she here?”

“Not anymore, I´m sorry”

The man hums and from this awkward angle Adora can see he has kind hands, working hands filled with callouses and past scars faded in pale pink over his dark skin. He is also tall, as tall as Adora; and there is some kind of gentle aura that surrounds him that Adora can feel, inside her very bones.

She trusts him. For some reason and without explanation, no matter how much her heart is breaking into pieces all over away by Catra´s departure, Adora seems to trust him and his words immediately.

“She was here a while ago, I´d dare to say two years ago.” The man explains, resting his hands at the sides of his lilac and pink chiton.“She helped with the reconstruction”

“The reconstruction?”

“Well she was the one that designed and supervised the library in honor of the royal family.” The man´s words make Adora´s heart slow down in her chest and stop completely, tangling her soul and her breath in her vocal cords, speechless. “She had a lot of plans, she said it had to be right. She was good friends with the new queen but left once the Library was built and the fields were green again. Honestly? Etheria wouldn´t be what it is now without her. Some people even thought she was a goddess”

Something wet falls from Adora´s covered eyes, dampening the fabric in salt smell. Tears, Adora is crying, falling easy and one after the other across her face, losing themselves on the folds of her veils. Around her head, beneath the fabrics too, the serpents start to shiver, crying in their own ways too.

“She said she was doing it out of love.” The man adds, almost in the thread of a voice, his gentle eyes fixed in Adora´s bent and weeping form and Adora alone. He seems to be thinking something deeply, pondering about it until he finally sighs deeply, signalling to Adora. “Come with me, my fathers are the directors of the Library, maybe they can tell you more about where she went.”

Adora gasps, nodding quickly, her entire skin rising in goosebumps with the smallest strand of hope she can possibly receive. “Thank you”

“I´ll take it from here, Mermista.” The man says to the blue haired woman who just shrugs, still eyeing Adora sideways, itching with the feeling that she seems all too familiar to her, who has lived her entire life in Etheria even before the war.

“If you say so.” Mermista mutters before returning to her work, loading the heavy baskets with fish back into her boat.

“Thank you for your help.” Adora says, eyes on the floor, and she hears the woman grunt, probably shrugging as if it wasn´t a big deal at all.

“Whatever. Good luck with your search,” She hesitates a second and then, “I hope you find her, really.”

Adora doesn´t speak anymore but she nods, her eyes full of tears as she follows the man through the stones on the floor.

The travel through the city is quiet but easy. It doesn´t feel oppressive or overwhelming, the presence of this young man next to Adora. He guides her through the newly built streets of Etheria, signaling her low steps or roots in the floor like Adora used to do for Catra back home.

He also shows Adora Etheria. All those old corners she knew and that have been brought back to life; and all the new ones, beautiful and filled with a life so bright it blinds Adora in ways that have nothing to do with her cursed eyes or the fabric wrapped around them to keep her from causing harm.

Even as the sun moves through the sky, all Adora sees is life. In the oil lamps and the candles for the gods and the parchment lamps floating across a clean sky, free from pollution or storm clouds.

After almost fifteen years, Etheria has become something more beautiful than Adora could have ever thought, a beacon of hope after the shadows of war. A place where colors are born and taken care of, where the light is golden and the days are warm. Where even the winter snow is soft and the may noon are filled with the laughter of children and their people walking by.

Adora watches it all in silence, with her eyes covered, following the cheerful steps and voice of this man guiding her through these new stone paths of her once home.

“So,” he asks very gently after a while, waiting as Adora walks down a pair of stone steps with careful feet. “Can I ask what happened?”

Adora knows what he means, and while she prayed he would not ask, he also seems to have met Catra. The Catra with blessed eyes that Adora left miles outside the cavern; the Catra that is her wife and her life, with whom Adora shared six years of a life that feels so empty without her that Adora crawled on her palms and feet across the underworld of the cave and the moss of the earth trying to find her again.

That Catra, that seems to have planted the seed of her beauty on the very foundations of Adora´s home.

“We got separated, after the Emperor's death.” Adora speaks, hesitant at first, telling their story yet not saying a single word of all they truly lived through. “She— the place where we

lived was not safe for her anymore. I thought I was guiding her out to safety, I still think so. That I was protecting her."

Adora narrows her eyes beneath the veils, looking at her hands through sheer fabric. The weight of the red and slightly torn cape wrapped around her shoulders beneath the veils is a steady weight over her body, carrying her through this journey when she thinks she will break completely in the middle. If she pays close attention, she thinks she can still smell Adam´s scent on it.

"It took me a very long time to find my way out of where I was so I could come looking for me," Adora says, biting her tongue with every word.

"I see." The man whispers, his shoulders relaxing. He cares about Catra, and Adora is grateful for that. "I can understand that"

Adora opens her mouth, closes it again, the pink of her lips shivering for the man to see when a sob almost gets ripped out of her with her words. "I did not realize how unbearable life would be without her until I lost her, but— she showed me the beauty of this world." Adora looks all around them, breathing on the essence of the flowers that grow in this newfound garden they have walked into. "Even now without her, I can feel her here. I think this is the only reason why I find strength to keep doing this. Because she asked me to find her again."

Silence falls between them again but it's not uncomfortable or intimidating. Instead is a little bit sad and all kind of mourning, hovering inside Adora´s heart like a hand that never waves and never leaves her breath, not since the day she blindfolded Catra´s beautiful eyes and let her go.

Like Eros to Psyche, like Orpheus to Eurydice, like the winter losing her spring. Like a heaven without the queen of her stars.

"Was she good, when you met her?" Adora asks, seeing as they walk past a bush of red poppies that pass them by. "Was she safe?"

"Yeah, she was." The man shrugs next to Adora, the strong smell of parchment and something bright like some kind of sparkle coming off from him in serene waves. Even in the fear that overcomes her now, she feels at ease at his side, like meeting someone you had been friends with a long time ago. "I always thought she was an extraordinary kind of person because she was kind a stubborn yet she looked like she was carrying the entire weight of the world on her chest"

It brings Adora´s heart to a halt, all the hope that, as this world, Catra had bloomed and become free with her departure dying down inside Adora´s chest like a withering flower.

"Was she— was she not happy?" She dares to ask, already breaking her heart.

"I don´t think so, no." The man answers, honest above the silent apology in his voice. "She was— sad. Like looking at a flower that quiets down after the sun has gone away. She used to sleep on the princess tower and see the paths below until she fell asleep by exhaustion. And she looked like she was waiting."

Adora barely manages to hold back the heartbreaking sob that comes from her mouth. She trips on her feet and tilts dangerously to the side, shaking her head hard when the man shoots his hands immediately towards her, trying to break her fall. She doesn´t stumble on the ground but the overwhelming dizzy feeling remains, clogging her throat and turning her thoughts into white fog.

“She was a weaver,” Adora hears herself say, as if that affirmation alone was the most important of them all. Maybe it is.

“I never saw her weave.” The man confesses, letting his hands fall down again, pulling nervously from the laces of his clothes.

As Adora, he is also wearing a Heracles knot, wrapped around his wrists in lilac colors, twinkling a little when he looks at the sky above them.

“She'd say the sky was her loom, and she would do and undo the threads of the stars for as long as she needed to.” He takes a breath and looks to the side again, not Adora´s face but at her hands and worn out sandals, breathing deep through his nose. “Like Penelope of Ithaca, you know that story?”

“I do”

“I guess—” He blinks and raises his head to meet Adora´s face through the folds of her veils, eyes casted hidden but her mouth and cheeks rose and dampened by the presence of unstoppable tears. “I guess she was waiting for you”

They come to a stop in front of the marble steps of a beautiful building. Adora´s breath gets stolen the very second she rests her eyes in it, not for its side or the magnificence of its columns and walls, but because she *knows* this place.

She saw it inside her head, in her dreams. She breathed life into them on the traces made by pencil on parchments and later over the sand of the lake and the stone walls of the cavern.

She knows every angle, every calculation, every mathematical problem that made the lengths and weights of each beautiful stone that now raises in front of Adora as if the moon had taken a shape in front of her, and her dreams and her ink had jumped out of the still surfaces to make it real.

Adora designed this and later when she was casted away she taught everything about it to the love of her life. Each column carved in specific shapes; each mural with the skies captured on the cracks; each dome open for the galaxies and their starlight to shower inside the polished floors.

Adora can see it all, even if she is still outside, too far away from the reality of it, because she spent many years imagining and now it's right here, in front of her, in the middle of a newborn city. Like traces, like clues, like a quiet gift from a woman that loves Adora above all things.

The world and times is ending and starting over and over again inside Adora´s heart,

“Dads?” The young man calls as he steps inside, past the heavy doors of well loved wood painted in maroon colors.

Adora looks at the carvings made of gold on the handles, the first shade of gold she has found in this beautiful place, forming the shapes of folded wings that remind Adora so much of the crest of her family that the corners of her eyes itch with new coming tears all over again.

The man must have wandered off among the tall columns and slytherin corridors because when Adora turns around, instead of him there is another man, older and with the same kind of hands that the first, his long white chiton covered by the drapes of his red hemation, looking at Adora´s hidden figure with curiosity when she jumps back, startled out of her bones all over again.

“Oh, I´m sorry young lady. Didn´t mean to scare you.” He apologizes immediately, stretching his hand towards her. Adora doesn´t dare to look at his face but she does realise his words are not meant to be condescending but truly apologetic, worried when Adora steps on the he of her own tunic and almost trips with a long black vase placed on the side.

“I´m alright,” Adora rushes to say, refusing his hand even as her ears burn bright red with shame. “I'm not that young anymore”

The man stares at her for a second and then chuckles, his long and dark dreadlocks twinkling with cuffs and bells on the ends. “For us, all of you still seem like kids”

“Dad” The young man is back, rushing through a long corridor and followed behind by a third one.

Unlike the man standing in front of Adora right now, this one has his hair cut very short and there is a moustache on his face curling on the cheekbones, almost making Adora chuckle. She doesn´t see his eyes but she sees he is wearing a shooter chiton than the other one, of the same colors, with his hand coated in some kind of white powder that makes Adora think immediately of a sculptors hands.

Adora looks at them all from the corner of her eyes and curls into herself a little, she cannot help it. She is suddenly inside a closed space surrounded by three strange men and no matter how much Adora healed on those years with Catra, or how long it has been since any men tried to hurt her, the frail weariness still remains inside her chest, coating it all with a cold shiver when the three man look at her.

“Hey,” the young woman calls for Adora´s attention again, very gently, signaling to the two men and then at himself. “It´s alright. These are my fathers, they knew her too. She was good friends with us.” His mouth twitches in the edges with something unspoken and then he adds. “You are safe with us, I promise.”

I promise

It takes Adora an entire minute but little by little she relaxes back again, fixing the translucid length of the veil over her face and the ones covering her entire head before turning to them all once again.

“I understand you are looking for C´yra?” The first man asks, gently, resting his hands one over the other with a kind smile.

Once again, the mention of Catra´s name in somebody else's mouth makes her heart threaten to burst inside her chest, the half of her soul that has remained inside her body fighting its way out, through her mouth or her eyes, whatever if it means being closer to the shadow of its other half.

“Yes,” Adora chokes with her own breath, nodding furiously. “Yes”

“You are her wife then.” The second father adds, full of wonder as he moves just slightly closer. “You got separated, didn´t you? At the end of everything. C´yra said something like that once.”

“We did.” Adora wets her dry mouth with her split tongue, turning her head away for a moment. “Did she— did she say more?”

“She didn´t speak a lot about you, she was always fiercely protective of your privacy.” The first father tells her, shaking his head almost mournfully. “If we are honest, sometimes we thought that she had fallen in love with a goddess, knowing their history with lovers. But she adored you every day and the little thing she did told us where enough to let us know how much she loves you”

“Oh,” Adora shivers around a shuddering breath, suddenly out of words.

The three men look at each other, a silent conversation going between them before they move as one. The first father steps a little bit closer to Adora, signaling her a low step on the mosaic ground filled with pillows, so similar to the fireplace on their cavern that makes Adora hold her breath.

The second father and the son walk in the other direction, bringing clean cups of copper and fresh wine, pouring it directly in front of Adora´s hidden gaze so she is sure it´s clean before handing it to her with a small grin.

“I´m afraid to say it´s true that C´yra is long gone from here.” The first father says, his voice dropping an octave, like a father trying to console a child in the midst of the night. “She took off in the middle of the night after the city was completely restored and the Spring came back fully. She didn't say goodbye or where she was going. She took the clothes she came in and left, just like that”

Adora slips the cup inside the hem of her veils and takes a hesitant sip. But even the sweet and delicious wine tastes rotten for her at this man´s words, her hopes dying down inside her chest and being replaced with something else entirely.

The bitter sense of being so close and yet not arriving soon enough. The horrible truth that as much as Adora wandered the world looking for her, not even that was enough, she was not smart or brave or fast enough to find her in time.

The knowledge that, if she had just stepped out of that cave a day before, she might have found Catra here; if she had just dared to come back to the place she was called home and of which she was so misguide and afraid off, the would have Catra in her arms again, to beg for her forgiveness and never see her face ever again, but able to hold her after all. To tell her she did it, she came back, she turned around.

A tear falls inside the cup of wine, creating ellipses over the superficial tension of the wine.

“I´m sorry,” Adora hears, and she doesn´t know who of the three men says it, but she knows they mean it.

“Did she say anything? Anything at all in the year she was here?” Adora presses on, incapable of giving up in finding Catra, no matter how dark and frail the path seems to her right now.

“She said she would wait for you at home.” The second man chirps up, his entire face suddenly brightening with the memory. “Do you know what she meant?”

Adora exhales, suddenly exasperated with her own wife. Brilliant and beautiful and sometimes so deeply frustrating that it makes Adora entire being ache for her.

“We used to live somewhere else, but she could not possibly refer to that place. She— I don´t really think she knows how to go there.” Adora rests her forehead inside her palm, closing her eyes until they spark with pain. “She was born and grew up in a simple village, one of Etheria´s limits. Menagerie. I´ve been looking for it everywhere but nobody has been able to tell me anything about it, is like— is like it never existed”

A clap echoes inside the entire of the beautiful library, startling both Adora, the young man and the first father. The three of them turn to look at the second father as he sprints out of his seat, his face flushed with excitement as he claps his hands together over and over again, pointing at the nothing with a triumphant smile.

“It existed, oh it existed alright!” He exclaims before proceeding to run down one of the long corridors. His steps are lost inside the shadows of the library, leaving behind Adora and the other two men, who look bewildered where he went.

It doesn´t take long before the man is rushing his way back to the main chamber of the library, carrying on his arms what seem to be a dozen or more of parchments, a huge grin plastered on his face as he drops them all over the low table between all of them.

“Here you go, the records! It was a prolific village for many years. In fact, it was one of the key exporters of wheat, vegetables and meat for Etheria. But a few years after the war started, when it was under the invasion of Prime´s brother, Hordak, it was destroyed. Completely.”

Adora remains where she is but the young man lowers down on the mosaic floor, grabbing the parchments alongside his fathers and extending them one by one to read from them, looking for anything that might help.

“Some people say it never existed to begin with and others say it´s disappearance was divine rage.” The second father keeps saying, reading quickly and without stopping talking once, unaware of the way he might be saving Adora´s entire world. “Gossip voices said that the gods themselves erase it from the world for the people's sins, which I find hard to believe myself, what could offend the gods so much as to destroy an entire village. All I know is that not a single person that remained there after the war started managed to survive. It's A ghost village, a myth”

A cold weight settles inside Adora´s guts, covering in shivers even beneath the weight of her clothes. She knows it had a godlike hand the loss of that village, even if she has no proof, nor was there to see it happen, she knows that's how it went. That goddesses descended with their rage over a land and the people that had forsaken their god blood and avenged Catra´s exile and Io´s death.

Adora does not blame them, she would have done the same. In fact, as the years keep passing her by, she thinks she might understand them a little bit better, just a little. Not enough to beg to them anymore, just enough to ask them to show her the way.

“I can try and find references of where it could be. For you.” The second father reassures Adora, already elbow deep into the parchments. Adora blinks very slowly beneath the veils, fidgeting with her hands over her lap.

“Really?”

“Of course. Our organization system is the best in all of Eternia.” The man stops for a second and then smiles brightly all over again. “Actually, C´yra designed it. She is a very smart girl, if she said she was going home, she might have left a clue of where it was”

“She is very smart,” Adora agrees in the thread of a voice, her eyes aching with tears where she digs her sight fiercely over the moss crawling on the columns and not the men in front of her.

“Trust us.” The first father says gently and Adora finds herself nodding immediately.

“I do,” then she adds with a little gasp because this is the closest she has been to Catra in three years and it makes her all kinds of sad. “Thank you”

“I´ll help.” The young man chirps up, sprinting to his feet to approach his fathers yet still speaking directly to Adora. “Would you like to take a look around meanwhile?”

“Can I?” Adora asks, standing on usure feet in mosaics she knows from memory but had never seen before today.

“Of course!” The young man explains, opening his arms to the side to signal the entirety of the temple to Adora. “Place is yours!”

Adora walks towards the narrow corridors as the three men dive into the myriad of papers on the table. Like this, Adora is free to look at the huge columns of tenderly polished stone and at the sceneries painted on the walls, on the floor, on the very ceiling in places, surrounding

Adora into colours and lights. So beautiful and so real that for a long second Adora doesn´t even know where to go.

“Just be careful and follow the murals. There are many corridors and they can be confusing sometimes.” The young man calls from his spot at the table when she catches Adora still lingering by the mouth of the library. “This used to be the old palace, after all. C´yra preserved a lot of it”

Adora holds back a whimper and a mouthful of tears because yes, this is it. This was her home, once. She doesn´t only know the designs she did in childhood dreams or in the stone walls of the cavern. She knows the way the corridors slither with each other, the cheeky fall on the steps that leads to atriums, the high of the ceiling that extend towards the heavens like praying hands.

It´s not the same as before, it´s quite different. In fact, if Adora didn´t know this place like the back of her hand even after fourteen years, she wouldn´t have been able to tell that once upon a time a royal family and the people that they trusted lived here.

That once, long ago, a child used to play hide and seek around the tall columns. That she grew up knowing all the little corners and secret corridors that only collected dust and that she used to lay and nap or run into when she played a prank on the guards.

That once, a girl with golden hair used to walk through these very mosaics dug in the floor, that she learnt the once that were loose and used to skip over them like their own kind of dance floors. That she walked barefoot or in sandals, leaving trails od white sand like stardust where the fabric of her tunics dragged behind.

That once before, a woman called a princess sat on the inner gardens, and around the hanging plants of heavy floors, tucked around red poppies to read and study and dream. Dream golden images she could not understand just yet. Dream so she could feel the weight of a still unknown love holding her soul in young hands.

That once, this was Adora´s home. The only home she had ever known before her entire world came crashing down. A home that was once warm and then unbearably cold even under the sun, and that now is alive again on this May day, filled with kind greens and reds.

Adora walks around the library until she feels like she cannot keep going anymore, her soles worn out inside the sandals and her chest tired. She looks through vases carefully saved from the destruction of the war and the fires, preserved paintings and mosaics that Adora once memorized with young eyes when the days were long and boring, and rows and rows of long wood shelves filled to the brim with parchments and other pieces of literature.

Adora can read their names, on the sharp lines of the First One´s language placed over the woods. And she can feel their names too, in the carefully carved dots right below the words, the braille clear for anyone that needs or wants to reach for them.

The little traces of Catra´s life and breath inside Adora´s once home makes her want to cry. So she cries.

It takes her a little bit to arrive where she means to, not because she gets lost, but because she is scared and she feels in a way or another it might break her. But she gets there, because she owes it to someone she loves too, and she has missed him for a long time.

Now that she is here, she thinks she owes his brother the kindness of a proper goodbye.

The old throne room, however, is nothing of what Adora remembered.

The tall columns are still here. The ceilings, the mosaic floor. But everything has changed too.

The thrones are gone, that's the most obvious change of them all. And now that Adora thinks about it, walking through Etheria she thinks she did not recognize the new palace at all. It was there, in the middle of it all, the busy buzzing of the city, instead of far away on the meadows. Rising like a shell towards the sun and nothing like Adora new before; royal still but kinder, meant for a gentler queen and king that like to walk among their people instead of keeping themselves unapproachable and far away.

There is light in here too, Adora realizes that too. Before, there was a single open dome that looked at the silver moon during the Harvest. Adora remembers her light washing over her like an apologetic hand the night she changed, right here on this very floor. She remembers feeling it to her very bones, falling across her hidden face and cursed eyes, looking after her like a goddess eye.

Now, the domes are bigger, wider, and they embrace both the moon and the sun. Fully.

They remind Adora of another kind of home.

They remind her of the open domes of the cavern, made of marble instead of raw stone, still crawling with the hand of vines and moss, heavy where it dripps the long lines of wisterias in fully bloom; lime a cascade all of their own, long and long until their almost reach the ground, from the ceilings to the floor.

There, the circle of wisterias and green leaves also mingle with another kind of green, one that Adora knows better than anything else.

The twin olive trees have grown beneath the open domes like columns of their own. Tall, strong, beautiful, Their branches reach for the golden light pouring inside and their green leaves catching the errand wisteria petals sauntering down like feathers.

Their fruits are beautiful, green too and black, a black so deep is almost purple even if it makes no sense at all. They scatter the mosaics, free to roll around and sprout their seeds into other parts of the world as this is their home. They lose themselves a little bit on the moss and soft evergreen grass right below the dome, this circle of green the only patch of garden around the columns of a place that once saw pain.

There, right there, beneath the sun of the dome and the green of the moss, cradled by the twin trees, Adam lies as he was the last time Adora placed her eyes on him. And someone else.

“Adam?” Adora whispers, under her breath, almost not a sound at all, approaching her brother´s side with quiet steps to look at the second statue kneeling in front of him. “Oh, Kiki”

Catra made it herself, Adora knows immediately. She could recognize her crafting hand everywhere.

There must have been blisters in her hand, sprouting like the trees. Blisters and tiny scars where the stone dug its way past the soft skin of her palms. Made for the loom and the song but used to break and polish and carve.

And Adora knows, immediately too, her own face looking back at her from the marble.

A reflection of herself casted in marble lies kneeling on the green floor in front of Adam. Her knees on the ground, her ankles tucked beneath her body. The marble has been worked in a way that the tunic and the veils of the statue almost look like real fabric, smooth and beautiful to the touch, and Adora has to question herself if Apollon themself sauntered down too to help Catra work the stone like this.

But then again, this is Catra, and Catra has always known how to transform the stone into gentleness.

And these? These are Adora´s hands, beautifully crafted, lovingly carved. These are her arms and her shoulder, Adora could compare them bare and side to side and they would be the same. This is her neck, the narrowness of her waist, the wideness of her hips, the point of her ears.

This is her face, carved into stone so a part of her can live with her brother, by the hands of someone that loves her. Cheek, chin, jaw. The straight length of her nose, the curve of her mouth; all those pieces of herself that once seemed so little but that make Adora what she is.

The ones that Catra learnt from memory, not by seeing eyes but by the touch of her hands, embroidering the pieces of Adora´s body into something soft and perennial, something that remains and that is beautiful. Beautiful, the way in which Catra knew her and remembers her is more beautiful than the way people saw her when she was a princess and an ethereal creature. Is the only thing Adora ever needed.

They are all lovingly carved except for her eyes, the only part of Adora that Catra does not know. Those lay hidden beneath the hem of the stone veils, like Adora is wearing now, from the middle of her face and all the way across her head. A silent conversation between the both of them, even miles away, that where Catra knows the truth of Adora´s body, completely, she will always protect it from everyone else.

It is right here, in the way Catra carved a reflection of Adora that is cradled by the forever raised arms of her brother who had been waiting so long for her to return. Right here, tucked between the green of the olive trees that once made a part of their home, and beneath the golden light of the sun.

Here, where Adam´s and Adora´s statue can see the stars at night. Here, where the breathing Adora can see the rays of the sun crossing the leaves, painting shadows over the white stones.

It's not a tomb. It 's a memory.

“Did you look after her again, when I couldn´t?” Adora murmurs, sitting beside Adam's body, his face so much younger than she remembered, “I´m glad. You were always the smarter twin in matters of the heart.”

The chamber remains silent yet is not quiet. Adora can hear it all, she can hear her brother everywhere. In the chirp of the blue birds and the rush of the breeze across the poppies. In the far away murmur of running water and the waves crashing against the sand. In the echo on the columns of white, and her own sobs, tender and sad.

“I love you.” Adora cries against Adam´s marble cheek, leaning her forehead over him as her own statue does between his hands. “I´m sorry. I know it was not my fault but I´m sorry anyway.”

Her crystal tears splash against the stone and fall over her hands and her lap. They dug themselves in the cracks of the ground and there the very earth seems to be able to recognize her because poppy blooms start to sprout.

“I miss you so much. I miss you everyday.” Adora whispers, holding herself to the smooth stone with shivering hands. “I´d like to say I did something good with what you did for me, but I was scared. I was so scared I think I lost so much time.”

Beneath the veils, Adora rests her fingers over her covered eyes but doesn´t push back the tears. She lets them floor, like streaming water, dampening the earth and making it alive too. Holding Adam´s warm stone fingers and then looking at herself, somehow at peace even in the stone.

She thinks she likes that sight, like when she caught her reflection on the copper mirrors in the cavern. The sight of a body that she came to love; the sight of someone that *is* loved. Fiercely.

“But I did fall in love.” Adora smiles, and under this light, she thinks Adam might be smiling too. Beyond the stone. “And I understood, I understood in the end that I was meant for so much more like you said. You were never wrong. That I am meant for a kind life and I'm worthy of being loved in the ways you loved me, in the ways Catra loves me. In many other ways”

She hopes, she really does hope. It's not a prayer but it feels more important than one. She hopes that her tears and her smiles and her words can travel past this stone, mosaic and earth and go all the way beyond the threshold of reality. Skip on the boat and across the rivers of the Underworld and find their way in Adam´s ears on the Elysium.

She hopes he is listening. She hopes he looks at her proudly.

“Thank you for loving her.” This time, when she extends her hand she does so to caress the fall of her own cheekbone on the stone, the one cradled by Adam´s marbled hands and carved with Catra´s love. “Thank you for loving me, thank you for being by my side. For being my brother.”

The stone doesn´t answer her. It didn´t do it the first time she felt the stone in his hands, it doesn´t do it now. But instead of carving holes inside her heart, it soothes her. The knowledge that there is light and tenderness in this place, after so much, after the war, it feels her with a little bit more peace than before,

“I´ll do something very good with this life. My life.” Adora promises, to them, to herself. “And I'll find our families again.”

Adora stares at him, until she is sure she won´t ever forget his face. After all, she might never come back here again. She looks at his eyelashes casted in stone, delicate and soft. Looks at his nose, his cheekbones, his chin, so much like hers that they are mirrors of each other.

Looks at his unmoving hair, his shoulders, his clothes; his smile, the tender and forever kind of smile he had given her since they were children and that remains on his face even now. He truly spent the last moments of her life loving her and being by Adora´s side.

And the old red cape wrapped around her shoulders, walking alongside her for the last three years, feels somehow even warmer than before.

“I love you,” Adora whispers, standing up again, caressing his face with her fingertips before finally letting him depart. In peace. “Farewell, Adam. Until we see each other again.”

Adora remains there for what feels like hours, standing in silence besides their statues. She remains as still as them, as the trees and the sky above their heads. Cradled in soft veils with coin bracelets around her ankles and the golden serpents singing against her ears, very softly, a hum only she and the people she loves can hear.

“They are the royal siblings.” The soft voice of the young man from before says on the sides of the columns. Adora does not turn to greet him, keeping her head low, but she does not slowly, a silent affirmation granted for him to approach. “Adam and Adora, they were twins. They were the first losses of the war.”

He stops next to Adora, looking at the statues too instead of her. He has no idea, he surely doesn't know. The truth about what Adam´s statue holds; the truth that hides beneath Adora´s veils. She wonders if they would judge her and cast her again all over again.

“We raised for them,” The man says, turning Adora´s thoughts to dust. “At the very beginning, when the news of the loss traveled through Eternia. There had been rebellion and anger brewing already against the Emperor and his presence in Etheria, but the princess and prince finally managed to join us all. Not for the queen and king but for them.”

The man sighs, resting his fingertips over the bark of the trees. “We did it for our land, for our children, for ourselves, but it was good having someone to join for. I´m just terribly sad that it was a the cost of them.”

“I thought—” Adora starts, biting her tongue immediately after.

“What?” The man coos her gently, and Adora finally understands why she seems to trust him. He reminds her of her brother.

“Things were said about the princess.” Adora risks, looking at the domes. “Things the Emperor said about her, about a fate worse than death.”

“Don´t let Queen Glimmer hear you,” the man jokes softly but there is an obvious kind of sadness in his voice. “She feels very strongly about this matter. Women being erased and demonized by the men that tried to break them. Men that tried to humiliate their memories. She and everyone else have been working very hard to destroy everything Prime and any other man tried to make of women in our land. It´s the last we could do for their memory.”

Adora grinds her teeth together and holds her breath, digging her sharp nails against the soft skin of her palms.

“If it makes you feel any better, nobody believes anything of what Prime said about Princess Adora.” He whispers, standing just a little bit closer to her. “She was loved, actually loved by her people. Her real people, the ones that saw her grow and that miss her every day. The workers and painters and musicians. The scholars and the women and the children. They come here to leave flowers to her and to Prince Adam. She might be the reason this world might actually learn from its mistakes”

If he hears the tiny sob escaping Adora´s mouth, he does not speak about it.

“Actually, if you step right here at the right moment you will be able to see them”

“See what?”

The man stretches his hand in front of them, guiding Adora's sight up and up until she reaches what she is meant to see. “There”

The half moons painted over marble stone, carved by a hand beyond comprehension that Adora has loved since she could understand the heavens and the sea around her.

“Ellipses”

“Uhu. This whole thing was raised in honor of Princess Adora´s astronomy and architectural plans.” The young man lets his hand fall back down but Adora's gaze is long gone, marveled by the expression of the sun in the palm of her hands. “Her old chamber is now the Astronomy Tower, you can see every single star, moon and planet from there. And there too C’yra sent to build a mechanism princess Adora created, the Antikythera mechanism. Not only to see the stars, the constellations, but to predict the movement of the heavens. It's truly a spectacle. The library, the tower, the stars, it was all done for her.”

You built it, Adora thinks, sobbing. *My beautiful, beautiful love, you built it.*

The fabric of Adora's sheer blindfold is damp with heavy tears, sticking her eyelashes together. She holds the need to scream, to laugh, watching the sky instead as the noon sun

starts to fall and the stars make their beautiful appearance instead.

“Here.” He hands Adora a thin parchment nibbled in neat First Ones handwriting that Adora thinks she can recognize. “It's a report from Prince Adam's travel to Menagerie, giving details of the exportation of tapestries deemed as precious here to the city. Is not much but it's a start”

Adora takes the parchment from his hands and cannot avoid but to laugh, a wet chuckle making it past her mouth where she runs her thumb over the old writing his brother left behind.

Like a gift.

“Menagerie was a river´s village. A very important river actually once called the Oneiros river, in honor of the gods of dreams. It was born on Arthemis´mountains and crossed the entirety of Menagerie´s woods until it met the sea in the end. This sea, actually.” The man nods to himself, hearing the rush of the tide beyond the gardens of the library. “They have always been connected”

Under her veils and away from his sight, Adora grins, the threat of an incredulous chuckle clogging her throat.

“Of course they are.”

She feels the man looking curiously at her but Adora makes no more comment on it, running her fingers to her brother´s writing and detailed maps. He was a good cartographer, once; he knew Catra´s woods too, he knew the way home.

“If you follow the river you should be able to get there sooner or later.” The man follows the trace of the river up and up, humming under his breath. “I´d say a couple days on foot but we can hand you a horse and a cart. I'm sure—

“I'm fine like this.” Adora reassures him, holding the parchment against her chest. “Thank you”

She turns to look at her brother and at herself one more time, washed by the light of the oncoming stars and then turns her body towards the young man, tilting her head towards him without getting to look at his face at all.

“Can I know your name?”

“I´m Bow, from Mycenae. Son of Kontari and Giorgos.” He stands straighter in front of Adora and bows very softly at her, a kind chirp on his voice when he announces his own name. “Arrow Master of Etheria.”

“You are the Queen's husband.” Adora´s eyes go wide as full moons beneath the cloth, catching sight for the first time of the myriad of pale scars around his dark arms and hands. “You are the King”

“Eh.” Bow shrugs, resting importance to a title that once almost broke the world and that now feels like a gentle guide. Like a master or a wise man. “I´m a son of scholars. And I´m a blacksmith, and a gardener. Just that.” This time Adora does chuckle, gaining a tiny grin from Bow´s mouth. “What?”

“I always told Kiki that's exactly what this kingdom needed.” Adora confesses, running her thumb over the fabric of her brother´s hemation. “No golden blood, no royal inheritance. Just someone simple, someone good”

Adora hears Bow hold his breath but she is already saving the parchment inside her tunics and turning around, from the open dome and the pouring light inside, from the twin statues and the olive trees, siblings born from the same olive seed.

It's not leaving behind is walking forwards.

“What was your name again?” Bow asks in the thread of a voice, suddenly softer than Adora has heard him before. She closes her eyes and tilts her head softly towards him,letting the tiny edge of her smile slip through the folds of her veil.

“Thank you, for taking me here.” She answers instead. “I'll keep looking for her”

Adora starts walking down the corridors filled with light, watching every single detail of the beautiful library, a new beacon of hope for her people, passing her by and growing instead of going cold and unapproachable as she once was.

“King Bow?”

“Just, just Bow”

“Bow.” Adora smiles, looking through the open walls and the stone columns at the sea quietly blessing the shore. “Please take care of this city. It´s a beautiful place”

“We will.” He whispers even though she is already far from reach. The moon cradles her like a crown, even here. “Princess”



At night, Adora has a dream.

It´s her first dream in many, many years, when exhaustion has finally managed to reach its hands around her heavy head and her feet are tired and scattered with blisters from where she has walked without stopping for three years.

She is gazing up at the starry night circling above her head and the next thing she knows is blue sky, clear and beautiful. Blue like the oceans, blue like tiny flowers, blue like nothing she has seen before.

And she knows its a dream because the blue is looking back at her, a blue she knows but doesn´t recognize, smiling and, miraculously, also laughing,

Laughter, like a bell, like bracelets made of coins, like the stream of a river. There is blue and there is laughter all around Adora, and she knows it, she knows her. It fills her with joy, the promise of happiness to come, unbroken and young.

Adora dreams with blue and the next time she wakes up, pink dawn meets her. She keeps walking.

The woods of Eternia are treacherous sometimes, long, eternal. They are too filled with green and with colors; they are too filled with the sweet song of the animals that have returned to this earth, being born, growing and living kind lives among the patches of moss and the waterfalls.

In here silence does not exist but quietness does, soft and easy to breath. Adora sits on the edge of the river and deeps her sore feet on its fresh waters, washing away the moss stuck to her soles and the bruises on her ankles from walking and walking and walking day and night until the hours and days begin to mingle together.

She sleeps on the soft moss and stares at the spring stars running their course above her head. She counts them all, one by one from the biggest one to the smallest of them all, following their traces on the haves with her fingertips over the soft earth beneath her.

She does so like following the same paths over marble stone or over the soft fabric of beautifully embroidered hemations and tapestries she knows by heart.

Here, deep in the woods, Adora lets loose of the veils and the ribbons and lets the golden serpents drink; drops them gently inside the waters too and hears them sing for her as they slither across the grass all around her.

They have been her only companions these past three years, them and the stars above her head. In a way, it is like all those years in the cave before Catra arrived, except that now instead of keeping them hidden and choked out by her own hand, they remain loose and free to explore the world around them with their sightless eyes.

Adora rests near the river and stares at herself on its surface, looking back at tired golden eyes and the newfound lines painted in her face. Faint lines on the corner of her golden eyes where many years of past laughter have made their homes on her skin; almost invisible lines on the corner of her mouth born from her own smile given to Catra freely; and the lingering sun moles on her skin that look like copper kisses.

The breeze is brushing against her bare face when she hears it, the faint whisper that might be the wind or a song all of its own, singing its own song inside Adora´s ears.

“ *Adora* ”

Adora´s face snaps up, her eyes aching under the strong light of the May sun hovering right above her head. Everything feels like spinning inside of her, her thoughts, the quietness, the

sky above her head.

“ *Adora* ”

“Catra?”

Adora rises to her feet, tripping with the pale fabric of the tunic and falling hard over her chest and face, blood filling her mouth immediately when she accidentally bites into her mouth.

“ *Adora* ”

“Catra.” Adora calls again, pushing herself on her palms and soles, her heart threatening to rip in pieces inside her chest. “Catra!”

Adora runs across the woods, the whispering following her behind like the shadows casted by the sun.

She runs without seeing where she is going or how long it goes by, her sandals and veils forgotten somewhere in the roots behind her, in the bed of the river, Adam´s red cape draped around her waist and fastened by the Heracles knot over her hips. The serpents curling over her head free and long, wrapping themselves around her ears and neck as she does nothing more but to run. Run.

She doesn´t realize how long she has run, following the river´s tide up and up towards the fogged mountains until she trips and falls all over again, not with the hem of her tunic or the roots on the ground, but with the trail of ethereal feathers left to saunter down on the poppies field the woods are cradled with, nurtured by the sweet waters of the river until all Adora can see is the shade of red washed by golden light.

“What is– what is this?” Adora asks under her breath, gathering the loose and already withering petals inside her palms, her eyelids heavier than ever by the touch of the light.

“**Adora.**” She hears again and this time she recognizes the voice well, not from the mouth of the woman she loves the most but from the goddess to which Adora begged at the feet of the altar and whom she never understood no matter how many years went by.

Adora sits back over the grass, among the poppies, feeling their green stems and velvet petals against her fingertips. The serpents fall across her face, down the middle of her spine and over the moss, curling around themselves and quieting their voices until Adora gathers them all inside her arms and holds them against her chest, caressing them in the way she used to run her fingers across the honey strands of her own hair.

“I don´t want to speak to you,” she says, her voice sore from years of walking and years from crying.

The world all around her moves, changes. Adora holds her breath as the breeze dies down and the very sun seems to still on the sky for a moment, waiting as the goddess saunters behind Adora´s form.

Her bird-like feet make no sound when they touch the ground, the might of her body somehow small where it hovers near the back of Adora´s head without touching her at all. The serpents in Adora´s hands awake from their daze at the feeling of her, turning their blind heads to the owl goddess to quietly hiss at her.

"**I know**," Athena says, like a war horn and a bell.

"I´m not looking for you"

"I know"

The poppy field is in silence now but Adora knows she is there, as well as she knows she is looking at her in the same ways she did before, when Adora was much younger and she asked her guidance and none came.

"Why did you never help me before?" Adora snaps after a second that feels like an eternity, unable to keep back the sudden grudge pouring out of her heart. "Until that night, you remained outside all those years, didn't you? Feeding me and giving me thread. But you never helped, even though you knew exactly where I was"

"**We did. I did."** Athena admits, her wings making a sound like lyres when brushing together. " **You were once one of my favorite acolytes"**

"I was not an acolyte, I was a woman. I was barely more than a child. " Adora barks, letting her eyes fall closed until all she sees is the bright shimmer that Catra used to talk about with a secret smile. Adora knows who she is, now, her own worth, but at the same time she feels impossible empty without her, torn apart. "And yet, nothing was done for me"

"**Even knowing where you had been exiled, I could not intervene, none of us could."** Athena murmurs, extending her ethereal arm beside Adora's face. " **Terrible things happened because I tried to see inside.**"

Adora cannot help but to look down, following the traces of the mortal scar left over her ethereal dark skin. From the thumb to the elbow, like it had been said, bleeding the goddess an ichor that heals.

"You saw?" Adora asks, wrinkling her nose and looking away, feeling the presence of the goddess all around her, the onyx serpents on her body mirroring Adora's golden ones. "You saw me? *Us* ? Our privacy?"

"**I could not."** Athena whispers, turning into a beautiful owl that starts flying in circles around the poppies, her voice echoing everywhere. " **Oneiros forbid it"**

Adora blinks and then narrows her eyes, biting her tongue. "What?"

"**You also know him as Morpheus. They are your lover´s father"**

"I know they are." Adora cuts sharply, grunting as she looks at the clear waters of the river that is guiding her through her own kind of Underworld. "I mean why would they do that?"

“Not all of us are indifferent to mortal affairs. His daughter loves you and she prayed for you, the night it happened. ” The owl disappears in a swirl of feathers only the appear right behind Adora, resting her long claws over Adora's golden eyes. “ **He covered us from seeing you and later his daughter. He too was forbidden from getting involved besides the world dreams where your lover walks. But he could do that, it was fair”**

“And yet, he has not given us the gift of his dreams anymore,” Adora speaks around her hands, digging her nails over the skin of her own palms.

She has not dreamt in such a long time, sleep without dreams, and she knows Catra hasn't done it either. She feels it in her heart.

“**The gift has already been given** ,” Athena coos, in riddles as always. “ **You must go back to it**.”

Adora clicks her tongue against the back of her teeth and looks away incredulous. Fourteen years ago, the presence of the goddess would have made Adora crumble into her knees. Today she is still on her knees but to feel the poppy and the earth, who she vows herself to.

“Our father has lost his bet on you,” Adora quotes, her mind racing where the memories echo inside her head like thunder. “That's what you said that night, three years ago. I want to know what it meant for me. For Catra.”

The space between them goes silent again, the goddess presence still very real and heavy above Adora´s head yet she does not turn her head up to gaze at her nor feels her as overwhelming as she did before, where the shadows of the gods statues were as cold as the statues of heroes now destroyed on an old and lonely cave.

“There was a bet placed on both of you, Prime and you. By Hera and Zeus, one of many quarrels of theirs. ” The way in which the goddess says it is cold, calculated, it makes a shiver run down Adora´s spine but she remains sitting straight, golden eyes carved on the red flowers. “ **Hera chose you as a favorite and Zeus bet for the victory of his son, not over your kingdom but over you. He was sure you would yield in the end and become either the murdered Prime tried to make you be or the obedient wife he wished he had. Hera knew much better, she knew your heart and your loves´s, and who you both were. She knew you were always more than his bastard seed.”**

“But why?” Adora presses on, closing her fists over her thighs. “Why so much hatred against us, against me?”

“Because he is who he is, and he is a man. King or god, he is a man and he is scared of you. Both of you .” The goddess leans to pick up the colorful threads of Adora´s wedding knot, sizzling like a serpent herself when Adora snaps her head towards her, watching her feathered claw rest the threads over the damp ground. “ **Like this river, you two were once a single tide, split in two. And he might say he planned it but in reality it was done to protect you.”**

Adora chuckles, she cannot avoid it, her hollow laughter echoing inside the field of poppies.

“Are you not surprised?” the goddess questions but Adora just shakes her head, looking up to the sky.

“Why would I? I already knew she is half of my soul. It was only logic, as you'd say.” Adora whispers, still smiling slightly hysterically, making the goddess hum. Like an owl's call.

“There is inherent magic born when the two halves are together, like earth blooming and the skies clearing in the middle of war. ” The goddess continues, making Adora hold her breath. “ **You choose love and yourself above my father's grudge and violence. And in the end, it saved you.”**

“Was that another wise plan of yours?” Adora snaps, tired and sick of the goddess speaking about it with so much pride, as it hadn't caused Adora and Catra unbearable amounts of suffering. As if these weren´t their lives to begin with. “Allowing him to curse me. Tearing me and Catra apart. Is this supposed to be mercy? Am I supposed to say thank you?”

She knows it's a mistake the moment she speaks the words but she says them anyway. The frozen bubble they have fallen into shatters and the sky thunders, darkening immediately not with the rage of the pantheon but with the one of the goddess growing and hovering above Adora´s form on the earth.

The goddess grows, mighty and ethereal, stealing the breath from Adora´s lungs and every single sound around them and still Adora refuses to turn around and meet her multiple owl eyes, refuses to cringe away when black ooze falls against the earth and refuses to bow down his her forehead on the rocks for a single second longer.

“**I am a goddess, Adora**.” Athena exclaims, loud like an earthquake.

But Adora snaps her teeth together, long past fear as the stems of the flowers seem to surround her wrists and fingertips, protecting her by other godly blessings even here. Like Persephone´s flowers, like Hestia´s fire burning forever in their cave, like the love of a mother and a sister and a daughter and a lover, godly beyond heavens.

“And I am a woman.” Adora answers back, “I am beauty. I am life. I am earth and I am the sun,” in a gentle whisper instead of a scream, consuming the goddess rage like rain over a forest that has only known green and light for a long time now.

“**Adora** .” And when Athena speaks again she sounds kinder, more human. Adora doesn´t know which one scares her the most. None. **“I´d like to ask for your forgiveness, from all of us.**”

A tear hangs lonely on the pale eyelashes of Adora´s eyes and falls into the ground below. She hadn't noticed she had begun crying, the goddess had. Is all kinds of sad, all kinds of liberating.

“You don't deserve it.” Adora answers and she feels in her bones the way her bones shakel the entirety of the gods pantheon. “But you have it. Not for you, for me.” Adora closes her eyes and holds the wedding lace against her chest like the serpents, against her heart. “I'm free now too, from all of you.”

It should not be possible, but Adora hears the goddess hold her breath, holds her words, maybe even hold her tears,

“**You are**”

“Is there anything I could have done to save my people from war?”

“**No** ,” a breath. “ **Sometimes kingdoms are meant to fall so the earth that held it can breathe again.”**

Adora closes her eyes and nods. Maybe she is right. Maybe Prime was the worst it could happen but the foundations of what Eternia was, were already rotten to begin with, held only by the frail lives of the good people that now can live in it freely.

“I don´t want to see you ever again”

“**I know.”** A flutter. “ **You can ask me any wish and I will grant it to you** ,” Athena murmurs, young, almost as young as Adora was when her world broke down. “ **It's only fair**”

Anything? Anything at all? Her body? Her eyes?

She could, Adora, deep within her chest, she knows she could want to; that she would be allowed to it.. She has found herself again in something new and beautiful, not evil. And yet somewhere inside her chest, still misses herself.

But then again, Adora has always worn her heart around her ankles like bracelets, and she has not always followed the sound of it when she should. She wants to, right now she wants to and her heart is not asking her for golden strands or eyes now.

It's asking for something so much more tender.

“I wanna go home”

The skies above her head clear again and turn blue, blue cradled by the golden light of the sun. She looks at the poppies and then at her hands and all she sees is warm skin, calloused and scarred but hers. Hands she knows, hands her love knows too.

The blue owl like lapis lazulis taking living form fly over the surface of the quiet waters of the river, losing herself among the tall branches of trees surrounded by tiny blue flowers. Nothing flowers. Waiting flowers.

“The river will always guide you home”

Adora walks.

Barefoot, she walks.

Unveiled. Without blindfold, she walks.

The serpents follow her behind, long, golden, free from braids and knots. Dragging over evergreen grass and poppies. She walks.

Her brother´s cape wrapped around her waist, the pale of her tunic stained with moss and the drops of her tears and the rain. She walks.

The days have painted different kinds of suns on her cheeks, copper, golden. Light kissed. She walks.

Hours, days, years, she has been walking for so long. Up and down Eternia, through the valleys and woods and shores. Across sand and grass and rocks. Over and over again until she saw the magnificent beauty of this land, the beauty returned to its roots, the bright sky washing over the world in beautiful colours. So many, Adora thinks her eyes might have changed again just to be able to take a glance at this world, so much richer than gold.

Still, she walks.

She follows the river, the waters, the breeze. She follows the course of a sweet tide that guides her across this whispering woods and, for a moment when Adora glances quickly at it she thinks that maybe, just maybe, she has seen this waters before. That they ran through a different land she remembers, falling in clear lines down a cascade and gathering in blue swirls inside a lake.

Adora walks.

And then, stone.

She lingers at the edge of the meadows and stares down at the brown and gray stone of what was once a crumbled house, overtaken by moss and grass.

It´s a sight to behold, the remains of what was once a village, reduced to stone covered by the woods as they have returned back to life but the rock hasn´t.

Adora sees the pieces of Menagerie at her feet and for a moment she feels like crying. She cries, she does, dripping like snow across her cheekbones. The sight of Adora´s once home being prosperous and beautiful but Catra´s being covered by beauty but destroyed brings a terrible amount of sorrow for Adora´s heart. A kind only rivaled by the loss of who she loves.

Adora takes a hesitant step forward and steps fully into the grass, inside the circle of old homes and temples that now lay broken on the floor. In a way, it reminds Adora a little bit of the cavern, where the marble had also been taken by the moss and the tiny flowers.

Here though, the trees have sprouted across mosaic floors and wrapped themselves around the pieces of the columns leaning to the side. Here the bushes cover the crumbled ceilings and the does and their babies eat from the fruits and flowers of the old altars.

Adora walks through what she thinks was once the market of the Menagerie village and her heart grows heavy with sadness at its fate, the kind that will never be able to wash away

completely but that does not steal her from her sleep.

She knows, after all, what pushed this place into its doom, and she knows deep within her chest that she would have fallen into the same godly rage if she was different than she is now. She too would have broken the world in Catra´s honor.

And yet Catra has nurtured this world for hers. One and the same, different sides of the same coin.

Adora did not break this world, but still Catra fixed it for her

Adora leaves the village behind. She follows the stones, the pieces of marble left by gods like the mirrors of the statues Adora knew for many years, their only companions before she met the sun just as they are the companions of the woods, opening in long fields of wildflowers and grass like their own kind of sea.

She looks a doe in the eye with irises like oak and hesitates for a moment, unsure if she is supposed to keep going or allowed to. She could lay and rest here, in these ruins, but her heart is already screaming at her, singing, so loud she thinks the choirs might be heard by the very heavens above her head.

The doe considers her, from her place among grass so tall it almost covers her out of sight. Her fur is brown colored and the spots on her back and legs are of a pale colour so bright they almost look like silver under the bright light of the kind sun above their heads.

Adora stands feet away from her and waits, just waist, with her breath held, hearing all the sound of the woods all around her until the doe´s ears rise alert again and she turns around, still looking at Adora directly on the eye with her own full moon ones when she starts walking inside the lines of tree, following the stream of the river.

Adora exhales heavily and follows her behind, respectfully away but quickly, rushing on her feet until they ache and her lungs strain inside her ribcage. Mint leaves and berries get crushed under her soles where she leaves the remains of the village behind and follows the doe somewhere else, up in the river, through fig trees heavy with fruits and the frail ellipses reflected on the floor where the sun comes through the thick crowns of the trees.

Adora walks.

Walks, following the silver trail of the doe behind until she loses her from sight. Until she is left alone, wandering in unknown woods and the fresh air of a free world.

The world is beautiful in here, so beautiful and so painfully raw in its beauty that she doesn´t even notice she is alone again until she looks back in front of her and her only companions now are the sun and the trees. And the hum.

A hum, no, a whisper. Maybe even a song.

A lullaby sung from the voice of a bird. Wrong again. A goddess, perhaps even a muse.

A woman. Human, real. Beautiful. So very familiar.

Adora´s breath hitches on her throat and she turns around everywhere but all she can see is golden sunlight. All she can feel is the moss ticking the skin of her feet. All she can feel is the colorful breeze, pushing her forwards, like a lover´s breath, like a spring bless.

Adora takes a step forwards, then another and one more, past tiny pebbles of marble between her toes and the sweet sizzling of serpents below. Across tall trees and tiny ones and the invisible pieces of another house, crumbled too and hidden by the woods too; once burnt by fear and greed and now seed from fields.

Forwards, forwards, forwards without following any other sound than the hum and her own heart, beating like a horse in the shore of the sea, barely avoiding to hold back her tears.

Three years like three months of winter even in the middle of spring, finally coming to a quiet end. Three years too long, three years too much. Three years like three trees in a cavern and the amount of moons it took Adora to find her way back to what she knows.

Three years like three steps, the number it takes Adora to walk inside the meadow of another home, standing directly under sunlight where she almost trips and falls, and right beside the river bed where it comes to a final end, losing itself inside the earth.

Three years, three steps, three seconds of quietness, not silence, waiting.

It's kind, the way it comes to an end, the way it begins again. It's not legendary or mythical or glorious. It's not a battle, not a journey, not a great poem.

It was never about that, it was never meant to be a story about war. It's just a woman in love with another one, finding her way back. It's gentle, like the very first time.

This time too Adora is surrounded by light. This time too, she is the one being found.

“No matter how many years might pass, you always trip on your feet.”

Adora holds her breath, the precarious tears hanging from her pale eyelashes finally rolling down. Like tiny pearls, across her cheeks and into the ground.

Under her feet, the meadow comes to life. The poppies and anemones and tiny waiting flowers bloom and the sun makes their bee soft pollen look like tiny pieces of stardust. Like them, two pieces of the same star.

“I've been waiting for you, Adora.”

Adora breaks into a sob, still looking painfully in front. There is light all around her, she is sure about it. She can feel it, taste it, feel it crawling over her skin like tiny critters.

Yet she feels as if she was at the very edge of the abyss. As if, if she were to look back, just for the tiniest of seconds, the shadows of the underworld would eat away the source of warmth and song that has followed Adora here, that she has finally found after three years too long.

“Turn around, my love”

Adora looks down and cries, closing her eyes so hard white and golden spark flash beneath her closed eyelids.

Oh Orpehus, poor little dreamer, held to his lyre and his love, trying to pull the gentleness from death's hands.

Oh Eurydice, standing behind, proof of loyalty. Walking without a sound and waiting without asking anything else. Hovering her copper feet over the moss of shadows and light.

“Are you a dream?”

“No.” She whispers, and Adora knows she smiles. “Turn around”

“Catra—” Poor Adora, woman and wife, if she turns around the light might consume itself into stone. “I´m afraid what is going to be of you if I do”

Three years, three days following the river, three steps forwards. Adora hears her feet against the soft earth and the chirp of this world she made sing again for her. They are not in the cavern, they are in the meadow where Adora promised to find her again and the sky is clear blue above them.

It´s all beautiful dream.

“Turn around, my love.” Real, a beautiful real dream at last. One Adora is worthy of, one she is terrified to break. “Orpheus. Odysseus. *My* Adora, turn around and come back home.”

But as any poet in love with the sun, Adora cannot do anything else but to follow her voice.

Adora turns around, eyes closed, refusing to look up. Instead she places her hand over her cursed eyes and weeps, loud, heartbreaking, echoing along the hum of the song and the voice of her lover.

Three steps closer, three steps still apart.

And yet Adora can feel her everywhere.

“I did as you asked, Adora. I saw our stars, I drank of their light. I learnt them all by heart”

Adora can feel her in the earth, in the sun, in the rain, drizzling over them like gentle reassurances from the heavens above, who watch over them but finally let them go.

She can feel her in the moss that tickles between her toes and in the blooms that cradle her soles. In the breeze of the meadow and the poppies and the deers.

In the skies, in the very heavens. Like every single day without her, like laying over stone and later over earth, counting the stars in the constellations and desperately wishing Catra would be seeing the same.

In the very sun, golden above their heads, following Adora on her journey back home. No, not following her. Guiding her, like the river.

“You were right, about the ellipses you know? The library studying them carries your name”

Adora chuckles or sobs, maybe both. She nods around pearl tears and still refuses to open her eyes, to tilt her face up even if just a little.

She is so close, she is so far away. If the colorful breeze presses against her back she might trip forwards and fall inside her arms.

“I'm kind of grateful, you know? For these three years. I tried to make your home healthy and happy again. For you, for Adam. For your family,” Catra´s voice hitch in her throat, still like a dream, still like a bloom, too precious to touch. Adora has lived in winter for so long, Catra ´s spring makes her cry. “I think I did a good job.”

Adora opens her mouth and weeps, for the both of them to hear and nobody else. Just for them, inside their palms, between their breaths.

The dream of Catra must see Adora´s heartbreaking tears because she rushes towards her in a breath. Three steps apart, three heartbeats close.

Like this, with her warmth hovering over Adora´s skin, Adora wonders if the sun sauntered down and stood in front of her. If the very constellations took the single form of a beautiful woman and allowed her to have this, for just a second longer.

If she can do this, if Adora can do this as right now. Cover her weeping face with her open palms and cry, never see the light of day again just so she can feel her warmth again. She will do it, she can do it, she will remain like this forever, unseen and unmoving as her own kind of statue, hoping it can be enough to be allowed to embrace *her* again.

She will never look up and will never open her eyes again. She doesn´t need anything else but this, her, right back inside her arms.

Her love, her wife, she wears coin bracelets around her ankles. And she refuses to let Adora wander alone in the dark, even now.

“Adora, I have a gift for you.” Catra whispers with the soft touch of something tiny and cold that Adora realizes are also tears, fallen from Catra´s sweet and unseen eyes against the back of Adora´s hands. “It was given to me and I´d like to give it to you instead”

“No.” Adora mourns, crying at the sound of Catra´s tears. “Why?”

There is quietness for a second and then softness. Softer than velvet petals, softer than snow, softer than moss. Miles away from the cold and unchanging touch of stone. Different, warm, alive.

Loving hands that come up to cradle Adora´s face between the cup of her palms, painting well known constellations with her fingertips against her tearful skin. Loving hands that Adora knows, that she remembers, that she has only seen inside the memory of her dreams. That have been waiting for her for such a long time.

“Because it is mine to give. And I love you.” The living dream of Catra whispers, around tears, around a quiet and trembling smile. “Will you accept it from me?”

“I'm not worthy of it.” Adora blurts, snapping her sharp teeth together yet nuzzling inside Catra´s palms, seeking for her against her very soul. “You´ve healed the world and I have done nothing, Catra. Nothing but wander and take too long”

“Adora,” Catra cuts her short, patient, sweeter than before. Only now Adora realizes she sounds a little bit older, only now Adora realizes she sounds like that too. “Silly, silly princess. Don´t you realize it was all for you?”

Adora gasps, drowning in the cold of her own tears and the warmth of Catra´s skin, like the moon and the sun colliding, like ellipses over the sea, like the green of trees around the golden of the day.

“But—”

“You have to accept it, Adora.” Catra whispers, pleads, her sweet voice breaking in the middle and splintering into pieces against Adora´s heart. “You need to accept my love being given to you. Fully.”

Fully? They are already wives. Fully? They two halves. But she is right, Adora´s sun and gentle sea, she is right.

Even like this, unveiled and with her eyes closed, Adora must give the last step forward, Adora must meet her in the middle. Adora must come back and accept Catra´s arms to catch her inside.

“Yes.” Adora whispers and it also sounds like a choir. “Yes.”

Fabric brushes against the moss, feet standing on their tippy toes to reach her like the branches of olive trees reach for the skies.

Adora feels Catra gentle and real between her hands as the latter reaches for her and kisses her closed eyelids, one and then the other, like tiny stars pressed over lilac dawns, like clouds over pale eyelashes.

Warm, like flowers blooming beneath her eyelids, across Adora´s irises, inside her pupils. Like the sea and the sun cradling her, like petals.

Like Catra's tears, stumbling from her eyelids and falling inside Adora's eyes. Rain, snow, sunlight.

“Open your eyes, Adora.” Catra whispers and oh, she is here, she really is here right next to her. She is real and alive, breathing like a heart against Adora´s eyes.

“But–” Adora sobs, unsure, scared, her tears falling across her face and into Catra´s. “You´ll *die”*

“Trust me, just this once.” Catra coos her, sings to her, lullabies her like a nightingale and a siren and a lover, wrapping Adora in kisses like feathers. She exhales, running her fingers from Adora's eyelids to her temples and back, telling her how much she missed her with her touch alone. “Look at me.”

It happens quietly.

Unlike that night fifteen years ago in a dark palace, in this daylight, when it happens, it's not loud, there are no screams nor pain. The serpents sizzle, sing, choir and then go silent with a kiss against her cheeks, a gentle goodbye. Is quiet, like the breeze, like the river, like love. Quiet and soft.

It happens gently. There is no pain, no excruciating suffering, not undeniable terror. There is no darkness inside a chamber surrounded by marble, no blood on the floor, no scalp ripping open and tearing from Adora all she was or could be.

It´s a gasp, a whisper, a kiss. The fall of water through rock, the tickle of rain across Adora´s spine. A shiver that runs through her body and makes her hold her breath.

It makes her know, deep inside the marrow of her bones and the blooms of her womb that something has changed again, like fire, like air. Like the new trees of new woods; like the blooms inside the marriage bedrest of a cavern. Like this may sun.

It´s a pull from the thread of her life and the held breath of the Fates, looking down at them as Adora gasps and opens her eyes. As she also looks down.

Catra has the moon nestled in her eyes. This is the first thing Adora sees, with these new eyes.

“I'm kind of jealous, you know.” Catra smiles around tears gathering in silver irises. They are two full moons, shimmering under the merciful sunlight that falls over both of them, huge and beautiful as the stars in the heavens. “I just know you have the most beautiful blue eyes”

“What did you—?”

It's the sun, but then again, it's Adora, herself. A strand of golden hair that falls over Adora's eyes, from her forehead to her open mouth and Adora *knows*.

It´s Adora, *Adora,* standing in a green meadow showered by light. Adora and her long sun poured hair hanging over her hips like the serpents once were. Adora, and her bright blue eyes like the sea tides that always come back home no matter what.

It´s Adora, both as she was and as she became. As she is right now. Not fixed or healed but returned, bloomed from sorrow with happiness. Bright.

“ *Oh* ,” Adora runs her fingers over the bodies of the serpents, absently searches for their poisonous burn in her scalp, and all she feels in the softness of strands. “Oh, *Catra* ”

This is the first time Catra turns her blind eyes at Adora's blue eyes, like the sea of her home, smiling.

This is the first time Adora sees her face, surrounded by a halo of light that comes from her own hair and not the skies.

This is the first time she meets her outside her dreams as she was, as she is, as always remained. Princess, sister, wife. Woman.

Untouched, lifted curse. Free.

This is the second time Adora falls in love.

I feel a woman like moss, saddened, burdened. Her pain, I feel her ache, her longing. I feel years passing by, love in every strand of changed hair. I feel an exile that feels like paradise. I feel you love and be loved in return.

I feel you free.

“I´m a waver, you know? Flowers, trees, moss, roots, I bloom them, weave them back to life. But I'm also a healer. It took me a while but I understood it. No matter how angry I was, how desperate to have you back, I understood.” Catra takes a shivering breath, smiling even with her voice. “And I never wanted to be anything else but what I already was. Blindly.”

Catra raises her hand, searching blindly for Adora´s face and finding her immediately, like a second heartbeat; tangling her fingers through the honey strands of Adora´s hair, *her hair.*

“I was given a choice and I took it easily, Adora.” Catra whispers, sweet and sore. “He might have tried to turn us into stone but you're a flower, Adora, and this I can do for you. That's why I'm a child of the gods, that's why it happened like it did. I don´t know if I'll ever trust the gods again but I'm grateful, in a way, that the Lady of Wisdom allowed me to have this so I could give it to you. *Shhh I know—”* Catra reassures Adora´s tears, humming softly. “But above it all, my love, it´s *my* choice. I´ll never regret it and I do it with all my love. I'd do it over and over again for you, Adora.”

Here is the truth of the gods. They were forbidden to intervene in their destinies, and so they fought each other but above it all they watched. They were forbidden so Earth, War, Wisdom, Love and Marriage gazed upon their cave and waited.

They were forbidden so Wisdom stood in front of her bastard brother and allowed him to break her celestial skin until it poured ichor because she knew it would be a blessing she could not handle personally, as the gods had betrayed Adora and they couldn't take back what the hand of a man had done.

It was not the gods´s destiny, so she planned and she hoped until her healing blood was delivered to the only soul in the world capable of reaching Adora in the ways that truly mattered.

It was a woman´s destiny, the other half, born from blooms and river with ichor running in her own veins like the golden freckles on her skin. To take what at the beginning was meant to curse and carry it with her until Adora found her way back and it could be returned to her instead.

This is the truth about their destiny. When the lovers were ripped apart in the heavens, the Fates knew nothing would be able to keep them apart, in each and every life. One will always be meant to save the other, and the other would always be meant to turn around and come back, like the ellipses of the planet around its star.

So the Fates folded their wings and stood by to watch.

“But Kiki—” Adora cries, beyond words, beyond love, beyond tenderness, full of it. “- your eyes—”

But Catra is already shaking her head, running her thumb below Adora´s sapphire irises. She cannot see them anymore but she knows them, like Adora´s voice, like her hands, like their love.

Blood gave Catra the sight to be able to nurture the world, but the love between Adora and Catra has never been stained by blood or war. Instead it's Catra´s golden tears, the ones that return the gentleness of freedom back to her love. It only seems right to be this way, to be done by gentleness.

“I saw our stars and the green of the world and it was enough. Now you can see this world too, all of it because you deserve it. Because it misses you. And I can see you as I´ve always known you.” Catra smiles, letting her moonlight eyes fall closed as she takes Adora´s hand in her and brings it against her face. “I dare to say, I know you better than any sight could ever give me. And that's only mine to keep. It´s a little selfishness of mine.”

Here is the root of her love. The half that never wished to be healed, guiding the one that has learned to love who she became but that still needs it the most, like sunlight.

It´s not a matter of deserving, it´s not a matter of sacrifice not between them.

It´s not a matter of fixing, of repairing, of making it perfect and new. Not a matter of stripping Adora what she had learnt to be, to change her again.

It´s about magic, it´s about the blessing of love. A little about justice, a little about fairness.

About taking that which was defiled and returning it with a kiss and a prayer. No matter how long it might pass, no matter how many steps or nights. It's about finding yourself again in the hands of that who you love. It's about coming back and accepting this life as it is, walk it with your head held high and your heart filled with gold in the cracks.

It´s not about sight, snakes or stone. It´s about them.

The rest are flowers.

“Your hair,” Adora whimpers, feeling the shivering skin of Catra´s hands against her touch.

Adora sobs, the golden of her own hair obscuring her sight when she reaches out and cradles Catra sweet face inside her fingers, brushing past the tears falling below Catra´s blind eyes — Catra´s decision, Catra´s own autonomy — and tangling her fingertips with the short strands of her oak hair.

It´s so short it curls around her soft ears, against the sharp angle of her jaw, over her soft nape like a triangle where Adora rests her trembling fingers. Short, like a mourning, like a spring rain, like a wife missing another one.

Where Adora´s golden hair brushes the floor, Catra´s remains cut short touched by the pass of time and soft against Adora´s hands,

“It was my way of missing my wife.” Catra admits, shrugging gently, tears rolling down. “I've spend an awful long time away from her”

Adora collapses down into her knees, falling hard against the soft moss and grass of the meadow. Catra catches her immediately, like a second breath, wrapping her arms around Adora´s shoulders and the back of her head where pain does not linger anymore, soothing her weeping.

Adora does not know this yet, but Catra is not in pain either. Where her taken sight was before a thing of bad luck and sharp spark of pain, this newfound blindness is not only her choice but also a work of her love, for Adora and for herself, the Catra she knows and who doesn´t want to change who she is.

Catra is not in pain, no, in fact, she can perceive light everywhere, more than before. As if she has been granted the blessing of looking inside the very sun.

For now though Adora, cries. She bends over herself with her knees on the floor and gazes at Catra. Drinks out of her sight in front of her, learns her from the inside out all over again. With these eyes that belong to Adora, blue and beautiful and uncursed.

Catra´s hair is short and her face has more freckles that Adora will have to count and learn all over again. *What a blessing.* She is wearing the purple tunic she used on their wedding day years ago, *as if the same doe that had guided Adora here had also let Catra know she was finally returning home.* And Adora´s hemation is wrapped around her back and shoulders, keeping her warm and embroidered with new constellations, *a map of all the things Catra saw without Adora and that now wants to share with her. Like their entire lives.*

Catra cries too. quiet, accompanying Adora´s loud sobs with her own soft whimpers. She bends over Adora´s body and rests her cheek over her shoulder, against her neck, right next to her cheeks, smearing sun makeup and pearl tears on both of their skins.

Adora feels Catra move around, take the blue fabric of the long hemation and place it over Adora´s arms instead, covering her from sadness and cold but still holding her as they both cry.

And Adora can feel just how strong is Catra shivering on her hands. Violently, her bones shackling on inside the circle of Adora´s arms when desperation and sorrow and the overwhelming sense of relief starts to actually make it past their ribcage and heart, pouring like a flood into the grass below them like the flow of the river mingling with the paths of the mountains around all around them.

Adora slides her hand around Catra´s waist and the curve of her neck and presses her against her chest; wraps her legs around her waist and hips and tangles their limbs painfully close, so strong it's almost harsh, stealing the breath out of Catra´s lungs.

And Adora would feel guilty, sick with worry if it wasn´t because she needs this, her Catra, right now as much as Catra needs her back. Desperately, breathlessly, sickening; sticky like honey under the sun with the feeling of missing each other with so much need that Adora and Catra are both undone under the weight of it.

Adora gasps around a wet sob, her golden hair sticking to her cheekbones and chin with the streams of her tears, burying her weeping face on the short strands of Catra´s short hair, feeling her breathing and real.

It´s easy, sinking into her arms. After almost fifteen years it was easy, returning home.

“I´m sorry,” Adora mumbles, pressing their temples together. “Please, forgive me. Please”

She thinks she hears Catra hum but it sounds more like a heartbroken whimper, whispered right next to her ears where Catra´s lips are shivering too when she speaks.

“Adora, you said then that you understood Oprheus and now I understand Penelope too.” Catra chokes on her own breath, curling on herself as if the amount of her grief for their separation and her love for their reunion again could not fit inside her own body. “I missed you so much, Adora. But I would have waited for you twenty years, sixty, a hundred, all my life. All of it for you”

Adora bursts into tears again, barely held up by the touch of Catra´s hands alone.

Adora leans back a little, just enough to gaze up at Catra´s face, her wife, half of her soul and all of her heart. To gaze up at her, fully, like never before, determined to learn every single old and new crevice of her possible.

She is beautiful, as beautiful as the day Adora let her go thinking it would save her and that in return saved this world. There are strikes of wheat and copper colors in her heart and new lines on her face. Around the corner of her eyes, on the fall of her lips, a little bit on the crease of her eyebrows.

Her skin is darker than Adora remembers and her hands more callous, born from many hours rebuilding Adora´s old home, from working the land she loved, from building the library and all it means with her palms and her mind and her love.

She has grown older, like Adora. And for the single most beautiful reason of loving each other so strongly to always come back and wait for the other, they will get to grow up the rest of their lives in a world that is green and beautiful and free. Together.

“Please let me love you.” Catra pleads suddenly, gasping for air. She also holds Adora painfully tight and her blind eyes move from side to side quickly searching for Adora in front of her, convincing herself that the golden light that surrounds her is real and not another dream. “Please fall in love with me again.”

“I never stopped.” Adora reassures her, pleads right back to her, barely noticing how the green meadow starts to fill with newly blooming flowers, purples and red and pinks so deep they look like the blush in Catra´s cheekbones. “Catra, I looked for you everywhere, in every star.”

Catra sniffles, her entire body finally letting go of the tension, the sorrow and the mourning that she had been holding inside all these years. While she had brought Spring back to this earth, she had guarded all of the Winter right next to her heart, freezing her and aching her slowly, only held by the threads of her hope and knowledge that Adora would, sooner or later, find her way back.

And now that she has, now that she is here in her arms and the world and themselves are as they were all supposed to be to begin with, without the hand of men to stain it ever again, Catra can finally breathe again.

“I love you.” She whispers, and she cannot see it but she knows tiny flowers bloom in Adora ´s honey hair, blue and white and purple. Catra knows the colors now. She raises her trembling hands and presses them softly against the corners and crevices of Adora´s face, knowing them all by heart, better than sight, in the only way that has ever mattered to her. “Please stay.”

“I love you too, so much.” Adora whispers back, hopefully, desperately, cradling Catra´s head inside her palms and bringing her flush against hers, letting their eyelashes and mouths brush together, finally, again. “I'll never part of your side again”

“You promise?”

“I promise”

“That 's good.” Catra smiles, her fangs catching in the plush skin of Adora´s shivering mouth. “Because I love you too much to let you go again”

They kiss as they have kissed infinite times before. And just as Adora´s body stepping back into sunlight, is not big transformation or earthshaking change. It´s just Adora, just Catra, not goddesses or queens or monsters. Two women loving each other over anything else in the world, finally finding solace in their arms woven back together like the tapestries in the library and the stems of the flowers on the moss.

Adora exhales on Catra's mouth and rests her cheek over her dark forehead, watching marveled the way her own golden hair mingles with Catra's oak like one. Like the sun and the earth coming together.

There is a soft crack on the woods behind them and, for a moment, Adora thinks that the silver doe might have come back. But it's not that, it's not that at all.

“You can come in.” Catra whispers next to Adora's eses but not to her, her soft ears twitching at the sides of her head when she catches the sound. “Everything is fine”

Adora holds her breath and without even thinking about it turns around. “What—?”

There is a woman standing on the outskirts of the meadow.

She is a stranger, with auburn hair that curls around the sides of her temples and held high on her head by blue laces and silver crowns. She is also tall, like an Artemis huntress, with the blue fabric of her tunic pooling on her bare feet and her forearms wrapped in leather ropes from the thumb to the elbow, matching the oak of the bow hanging on her back.

She is a stranger, yet she is deeply familiar to Adora, deep within her chest. Like something that comes alive again that Adora didn´t even realize was gone until now, gazing up at the woman who stares at Catra inside Adora´s arms and then turns her leaf green eyes towards her instead.

There is just one second of hesitation on her and then the woman´s entire demeanor relaxes like a drizzle in the meadow. She drops the bow back into the earth and starts walking towards the place where Adora and Catra are tightly bound together, stopping just three steps away before sinking down into her knees too.

And while the rational part of Adora´s brain tells her that she must be familiar to Catra, the other part of her head holds its breath and covers her in shivers, suddenly on edge to the way she is now sure her life is about to change all over again.

“Adora.” The woman whispers, tiny and gentle, real. Also not a goddess, nor a myth; a woman of flesh and bone kneeling besides Adora´s weeping body.

She is a woman and a huntress. A mother, and once, almost a wife but a lover in all the ways that truly matter.

Adora watches her hand, tanned skin from years of living in sacred mountains, raise from the moss and tangle softly around the soft hairs that curl around Adora´s temple and that never truly changed —being by tiny serpents or honey baby strands — feeling them on her fingertips inked by maroon clays.

There is a sparkle of golden that hits Adora´s blue eyes when the sun falls over the woman's shoulder, and when Adora dares to look down she sees the familiar shape of the Greyskull shield, the wings open to the sky inside the tiny circle of the golden pin that fastens her green tunics together.

It´s a symbol, a protection, delivered many years ago in hopes it would mean something to keep loved ones safe. It might have not worked for the kind of world the war submerged it into, but it did as it was hoped for. It protected, it brought a sense of pertinence and it gave the people Adam Grayskull had loved, a way to always carry him in their hearts.

It accompanied Catra. It´s pinned to Adora´s clothes, even now.

“Catra was right.” The woman marvels, running her fingertips beneath Adora´s eyes. “You´re so very much like Adam”

It gave his wife a memory to last.

“Teela?” Adora asks in the thread of a voice, her tears tumbling down her eyelashes and into the moss, growing poppies under the touch.

Teela nods, her green eyes also gathering with tears. “It is me”

“You are—” Adora chokes on her own breath, her heart pounding. “You're looking at me”

Next to Adora´s neck Catra sobs, burying her face right below Adora´s jaw. Teela hears it too because her green eyes fill with compassion, resting her open palm over the curve of Catra´s back, wrecking every once in a while with her cries.

“I am.” Teela reassures Adora, reassures them all.

She presses her other hand over the skin of Adora´s knuckles, letting her feel the softness and warmth of her skin; letting Adora come to the strong realization that Teela is still here, flesh and alive and not stone. It's over.

“Catra has told me a lot about you.” Teela´s eyes unfocus for a second, searching for Adora´s and finding only there the remains of fear, shock and also overwhelming adoration for this new life that is being placed into her hands fully. “You don´t need to be afraid.” Teela adds in a whisper, running her fingertips below Adora´s pale eyelashes. “You are still you”

Adora´s chin wobbles violently and then she is crying all over again. She turns her hands around so she can cradle Teela´s inside hers and nuzzles the side of Catra´s head with her cheeks, dissolving into a wet sob that barely sounds like words.

“All this time, you´ve been here.” Adora marvels, not a question just an affirmation. And she is grateful, even though it took her all these years, Adora is grateful.

“Teela cut my hair.” Catra whispers right back, tangling her fingers across the golden strands of Adora´s hair. “I wasn't alone for that either. Neither of us.”

Another tiny crack comes from the woods, hesitant, almost nervous in the way it echoes inside the meadow scattered with newborn flowers. Adora is too entrailed in Catra´s warmth and in the wonder of this world with eyes gifted to her out of love to turn around but Teela does, nodding almost imperceptibly before she turns to looks at Adora fully all over again.

“There is someone I want you to meet”

It takes a breath, maybe three too, but nothing in the world would have prepared Adora for the sight she was about to be blessed with now.

Teela moves slightly to the side, extending her hand in front of her to reassuringly receive at the newcomer at the same time Catra untangles softly from Adora´s arms, leaning back just enough for Adora to miss her immediately but still have her warmth between her hands.

This time Adora looks at Catra´s precious face instead of around her, her heart threatening to burst from her ribcage and take fly into the sunny heavens. But Catra, wiser and always knowing everything about Adora, just smiles. A tiny grin that Adora knows well, that speaks

of a thousand and one more stories to come this time for longer than five years; for a whole lifetime.

The smile of someone that took the volcanic earth of this world and nurtured back to the green that was always meant to. The smiles of a woman with moonlight blind eyes that saved Adora in all the ways that she could ever be saved. That even now, right now, sightless again and happier than with seeing irises, gives Adora all that she deserves right back into the nest of her arms.

“Ariadne, she is your aunt”

Adora recognizes Catra's handiwork on the thick braids that fall from the girl's golden hair from the high of her head to the ground.

There are tiny daisies woven on each strand, so very much like Adora's, sticking damp with years and sweat to her forehead, yet shining with their own kind of sparkle. And Adora would laugh, laugh and laugh until the world is filled with her laughter because everything is so deeply marvelous and so beautiful and she is grateful even after everything, Catra is the one that braided her niece's hair this morning.

“She is C´yra´s wife. She is your father's sister.” Teela introduces them very gently, like only a mother knows how to do, caressing the small fingers of her daughter and smiling through tears at her. “She has finally found her way home”

There is something very beautiful in looking at such a young soul and seeing only hope and happiness. After years of war and exile, there is something precious in seeing another one, breathing from a world that won't condemn her or forsake her.

“Hi, auntie” the little girl whispers, very shy, and she still has a little tooth gap on her bottom teeth.

This is what Adora sees when she gazes up and looks at her niece, at Ariadne on the face. At her bright blue eyes just slightly mingled with the touch of green, a trait Adora knows in a heartbeat.

“Hey, sweetheart.” Adora whispers, her voice splintering in the middle with the weight of her emotions. “You have your father's eyes”

The young girl looks at her and then her entire young and beautiful face lights up into a precious smile.She is holding a young cat in her arms that purrs loudly at the sight of Adora too, nuzzling to the side of her face. And the baby strands of golden hair in her temples are held up by a pretty golden wing that Adora recognizes as once hers, forgotten in her chamber many years ago yet right here, on her beautiful niece.

She is a princess, a heir to a throne, like Adora was when she was Ariadne´s age. She is beautiful and smart and would be beloved like Adora was. When Adora looks up at her, for the split of a second she also sees herself.

But here is the difference. Her clothes are soft, her face is relaxed. She wears pearls and shells and braids done by the hand of people that truly love her, not that worship her. She wears pink, her nose is bumpy in the middle, like her father, and her front teeth are just slightly crooked, like Adora.

Adora raises her hand, callous for time, softened by love, and cradles her niece´s cheek inside, feeling her warm and alive even though she is looking at her. And she is free, a free girl that will get to grow into a free woman in a world that will love her in all the ways it truly matters. A world made by Catra; a world saved for Adora.

And when Adora looks at her niece she also looks at the person she has become, right now. Someone free.

“You look a lot like me too.” Adora whispers, the corner of her eyes wrinkling where the tears come down again.

Adora loves her, deep and quick, from the very first moment Adora knew of her existence from Catra´s mouth. She knows too, that where Adam rests, he loves her deeply too. And he is smiling at them.

Very gently Ariadne curls inside Adora´s arms and embraces her fully, giggling, laughing, the cat against her chest and the arms of her family around her. She is a new beginning, like Teela, like Catra, like this world. Like Adora.

Catra rests her damp cheek against Adora´s and opens her blind and beautiful eyes, fully herself once again, gazing at the beauty of Adora in ways only she knows. In ways that saved them all.

“You are home now”



For Adora and Catra, the world is golden. And blue, and white, and green. Full of colors and shadows and lights in multiple ways, so full of life that it leaves them breathless every single time.

The wind of the ocean is cold and salty. Imperfect, completely perfect, crashing and caressing against Adora´s face in waves like the ones of the ocean below her. Up and down and then back again, moving the wood of the ship forwards into the horizon.

Sailing is a new part of life that Adora had never experienced, not even living next to the sea for so many years. In that time, she was a princess confined to the chambers of her tower and the gardens of the palace, and in the spare moments she had for herself, she liked to dig her toes on the white sand and imagine what existed beyond the blue line of the horizon.

As with many things lately, she welcomes this new part of her life with open arms. Drinks in the light of this and with it, smiles at her capability to choose and do. Try new things, see the

world. Live. Live with everything life can give her and all the joy this earth gives her in return.

It's tiring work, sailing, especially when they are only by themselves as Teela and Ariadne had chosen to stay home, on the edges of the Oneiros River and visiting the city in peace. But Adora loves it, no matter how exhausted she finds herself every night.

She loves the work, the sweat, the callus in her fingers. The sun painting copper marks over her skin and deepening her blush; brushing her hair into a lighter golden, like the sun at dawn or the sea foam on the ocean.

She loves the pull of the ropes and the heavy fabrics of the sails; the new wood under her sandals, a gift from a different queen and king than her parents; and the movement of the tides below them, taking them where they want to be when they follow the stars at night. Adora loves it, being able to open her eyes to this world and smile.

Still, sailing was Catra´s idea and who is Adora to deny Catra anything? She has been wanting to sail across Eternia for so long and she had waited, for Adora. She had waited so long for Adora to find her way back.

In fact, she never wants to deny her anything at all, not ever again. No matter how many times Catra asks her to, Adora will always turn around for her. And she will always, always, stay.

That´s a promise she plans to keep, like all the other´s she did before, like the ones she does now. To Catra, to Ariadne, to their friends in a city she loves. To Adam, to whom she speaks in dreams and never knows if it's completely real or not, yet Catra´s tony grin always lets her know it is.

To herself.

The sea wind is warm and it ruffles Adora´s hair. Tangles the golden strands into tiny knots, even with the delicate braids Catra does for her diligently every single morning no matter what.

It´s a little routine of theirs, like the ones they used to have on their cavern and that know they can experience fully in a world that welcomes them with open arms. She places pearls and golden cuffs and trinkets like bells around Adora´s head and near her ears and laughs always because it reminds her of years ago, when Adora used to wear coin bracelets for Catra to find her in the dark.

Now there is no need for Catra to search for her, nor for Adora to warn about her presence. Now they do it for the simple reason of habit, of a repetitive motion that brings them both comfort and a little bit of music too. Besides their songs on the lyre and the singing.

Now Adora still wears veils but they are light and sheer, made to keep her golden strands in place when the sea wind plays tricks on her. And Adora would lie if she said that she didn´t sit every morning to stare at herself in the mirrors of their room below the deck, or next to the edge of the boat, a didn´t cry at the realization that it is here, back to her as it never was

supposed to be ripped away. Given back by the gentle hands of the woman Adora loves the most and who loves her just as deeply in return.

Even now, looking at her reflection over the calm waters of the sea, Adora cannot help when she absently runs her fingers across the soft strands, lemongrass and sea salt smelling. She cannot help but pull from them gently, softly, just enough to feel the tug on her scalp and make her sure that this is real, that love truly saved her time and time again.

That Catra was right, she was always right, Adora was still herself, in one way or another. And that she deserves the gentleness and safety of her own body, back.

Still, she feels the soft and cold slide of a body running down the back of her neck and against her shoulder, nuzzling over the sage green of her tunic and tangling accidentally with the pearl laces where the blind eyes of the serpents can´t see where they are bonking.

“Be nice,” Adora whispers to the only three serpents that remained, caressing their tiny heads with her fingertips where they curl around her neck and collarbones like necklaces of turquoise and pearls, breathing alongside her.

Three serpents, one for each year, one for each person Adora loved that are no longer with her. One for Adam, with the little fangs wonk, and one for each of their parents — even if Catra never truly knew how to agree with those two after they realized these three were still here with her, like gifts all on their own —

Three for the trees on the place that saw them meet and fall in love; a place that was once a prison, different to the gilded cage Eternia had been to Adora, and that later had gone from an exile to a paradise.

Three for the Fates watching over them, humming under their breaths as they wave on the golden of their joined thread.

Three for the gods and goddesses that watch silently, to whom Adora nor Catra speak anymore but still leave flowers and wine as silent gratitudes. As silent prayers to never part them again, and reminders that they are now owners of their own destinies, as all women are.

Three for the three times Adora thought she had lost everything and had found all of it in return. And three for the times a day that Adora likes to remind herself just how much she grew, all on her own and through others too.

They are here, still wrapped around her temple and nape like the wings of a dove. And they remind Adora that, even after everything, she is here, in a boat surrounded by clear waters with her golden hair like poured sun. She is here, sailing, learning the stars at night, feeling the sunlight paint new freckles on her cheeks.

She is here, she survived. She cannot be caged or tamed ever again. She found love again and she found herself. Everything else is a gift, everything else are flowers. They make Adora smile every day.

“Adora”

Catra´s sweet voice comes from somewhere behind her and Adora turns around immediately, without thinking, without doubting. .

Catra is standing in bare feet over the deck of the boat, the blue fabric of her tunic tangling around her legs with the sea wind.

Her hair has grown in these past months, brushing the angle of her jaw instead of short over her ears, and it bounces lovely every time she moves. There are flowers tangled on the strands, red poppies like ripe pomegranates, white anemones with their purple centers and blue bless like Adora´s eyes, crowning her in different ways than the queen of a city or a Heaven.

Adora likes to help her wave it into pretty ropes and ribbons too, even if there is not much to braid for now. It makes Catra happy and it fills Adora with joy in the mornings, the way they can tend to each other's hair now, like different kinds of love vows. The way she can see Catra´s hair grow and promise herself in return she will never need to cut it ever again.

It´s marvelous, being granted the gift of seeing Catra grow. Of growing herself next to her. In learning her all over again, all those new things and knowledge they both got from the world in their time apart and that only made them fonder of each other. On seeing the new sun marks on their skins and the glimmer in her blind eyes.

On seeing and seeing this world, out of veils and iron masks. Away from swords and exiles.

There is a mischievous smile engraved in Catra´s berry red mouth and her eyes are open for Adora to see, the silver moonlight still nestled in them, letting her see light and shadows and nothing else.

Adora has asked Catra many times during these months if she was truly sure, if she didn´t regret it, exchanging her well deserved sight for Adora´s liberation from an unjust curse. And as many times Adora has asked, as many times Catra has bonked her in the forehead with her finger, chuckling at Adora´s surprised gasp.

Never once. Catra has said and will say, as many times as Adora needs it. *It doesn't ache anymore. And it´s not wrong, nothing about me is wrong. I am who I am and I´m happy, and I have you back. I don´t need more.*

And because Adora is Adora, she will ask again, in a few days or a couple of weeks, forever wondering what could have been otherwise and forever realizing that Catra found herself in the same ways Adora did. Not by what they could be but what they became together. And that is good. And beautiful. Imperfect and for so completely right.

As good and beautiful as right now, when Catra chuckles under her breath at Adora´s apparent loss of words and starts walking towards her. She keeps her balance expertly, not once stumbling on the surface of the ship no matter how treacherous the tide, letting show through just how badly she always wanted to sail and how deeply she is enjoying it now that they are truly here.

“Kiki.” Adora whispers, sings, taking Catra´s extended hand in hers and guiding her the last three steps until they are pressed together, back in each other's arms no matter how little they have turned apart. “My beautiful, beautiful Catra”

Catra smiles, beautiful and slightly damp in the edges as every time she realizes too that Adora is right here and will never go away. That she will stay, nuzzling her inside warmth and laughter for the rest of their lives.

Adora can feel the edge of her smile when she leans down to kiss her, fully and sweet, bringing the halves of their souls together into a quiet song.

There is a new hemation wrapped around Catra´s shoulders and crossed over her chest, woven by her own hand with sweet patience during many months of waiting, always with Adora next to her to marvel at the blind. creation of it.

As the earth and Adora´s dress, the hemation is green. Green like the meadows, like new blooms, like grass. Green like moss and olive trees and flower stems. A little bit green like the feathers of a peacock, a quiet thank you to one last godly gift.

“She misses you,” Catra whispers against the corner of Adora´s mouth, grinning when Adora chuckles, feeling the way Adora´s cheek goes pink immediately. It´s a little blessing too that even with blind eyes Catra knows exactly how Adora looks at every moment, even if she never quite saw her face.

A blessing indeed.

“Does she?” Adora asks in the thread of a voice, playful, loosening her tender hold around her wife´s waist just so she can look down.

“Of course yes.” The corners of Catra´s eyes wrinkle with her smile, little prophecies of a life full of them to come. “She is all fuzzy again, and she always misses you the most when she wakes up”

“I see,” Adora chirps tenderly, caressing a loving line across Catra´s warm cheek before looking down again, “Let me hold her”

Catra shifts her hold over the green hemation at the same time Adora extends her arms, warm like a sun all of its own, receiving their newborn daughter inside her palms from the hands of the love of her life.

“ *Oh, oh, oh.* Come here sweetheart.” Adora lulls her when the baby starts whimpering with the first notes of a cry. Adora chirps at her like she has learnt from Catra and holds her tiny baby against her warm chest, cooing her softly. “Come here, my baby”

Adora was scared, at the beginning, she would lie if she said otherwise. Scared of not being enough, scared of being too much; scared of not being able to give her all the beauty of this world to the one soul that deserved it above anyone else.

She was scared, that history would repeat itself. That what happened to Catra and to herself was a prophecy of doom meant to happen again. That she would fail and be like her parents, like the gods, disappearing into the thin air and never coming back.

But Adora is here. She is here right now and she was there through it all and by the time she felt her for the first time inside Catra, she knew the world would be different for her. For all of them.

The change is immediate. Catra rests her small head inside the cocoon of Adora´s arms an as d the little baby stirs in her mother's hands, the whimpering stops as fast as it begins, brought up when she feels the loss of Catra´s warmth and calming back down when she sinks in Adora´s instead.

Adora cleans the errand drops of milk still stuck to her baby cheeks and watches her as she sniffles the skin of Adora´s collarbones and recognizes her, nuzzling her tiny cheek over her with a sweet purr.

She is still so small, so much that she still scrunches inside Adora´s palms when she holds her, a memory of her life inside the closed warmth of her mother's womb. She tucks her tiny legs against her belly and rubs her sleepy face inside even tinier hands, yawning right back into a peaceful sleep.

She looks like Catra and thank goodness she does because Adora has never laid eyes on someone sweeter or more beautiful.

She already knew that, in the months Catra carried her, where the days would be as bright as they could possibly be and Adora loved them both, never once parting from them.

She has Catra's dark hair, she has her nose; her skin, her ears barely unfolded as she is barely a few weeks old. She has her freckles and her, still stubbed, tail.

She has Adora's eyes. Blue, blue like the ocean, blue like the skies. Blue like waiting-flowers and blue like a clear day. It will take a few months still to see the true range of the color but Adora already knows this blue. She sees it in herself every day in the mirror. She saw it in her baby, inside her dreams when they were still waiting for her, promises of joy.

Catra carried her, lovingly and sweetly, welcoming this new life inside her body too. Holding her inside her womb and against her heart with her heart full with happiness and her eyes bright like full moons surrounded by stars.

I´ve seen her too, Catra said one night, after dreams, a gift from her father and the Fates. *She looks like us.*

Adora helped her come into this world. Like Catra had done for Ariadne, many years ago, Adora was there.

She was not exiled, not hidden, not gone. She was there, barefoot over moss, long golden hair held up with the warmth of the sunset she was born on. She saw Catra carry her, exquisite,

grow around her too, change too, all those little things that Adora could see with her *own* body and her *own* eyes, forever held golden inside her heart.

She held Catra through it on the long hours that labour lasted, over damp sheets and lilac skies. She never let her wander alone, ever again. And then held her little baby´s damp body inside her hands, towards Catra´s slightly trembling ones and into the immediate tears that followed like the flood of the rivers next to their home.

A little baby whose existence was supposed to be impossible was now here, in this green and golden and blue world. Here in her mother's hands, with her little feet and tiny toes. With her oak and wheat hair in loops and her small fingers closing around Adora´s. With her curled ears and white eyelashes. With her button nose and her sun shaped freckles.

A child who is a daughter of princesses, where her mother´s are the ones that keep her safe, the ones that call the shots. Goddaughter of the queen of heavens who blessed her birth and beloved to the very earth that will see her grow.

She is Catra's daughter, she is Adora's child. Her child, who only knows love and only knows green fields and clear dawns.

Hope in the form of a dream and a dream in the form of a miracle.

“Kassandra.” Adora sings, lowering her face towards her. “We´ve been waiting for you for just a long time. Did you know that, little marigold?

Her little baby stirs inside her arms and then opens her eyes towards Adora. Blue meets blue and the warmth inside Adora´s arms remains, sweet no marble, looking back at her with all the wonder and all the love written in her young face. Even before she understands the world around her, she already loves her mothers and she knows she is loved in return.

Adora smiles, all white teeth and tears on the corner of her gentle eyes, nuzzling her face very gently against her baby´s. Kassandra, like an old princess once destined to tragedy that will know only happiness. She smells like poppies and lemongrass, like honey and earth, and something so much like both Adora and Catra that it brings tears to their eyes every single time.

Adora blinks, her sight swimming with the blur of tears, born from joy and not from sadness, brought up by the happiness of holding her daughter under the daylight and not in darkness. This too is a gift from Catra, the privilege of getting to see this beautiful baby grow into a free world.

Adora caresses her freckled cheek with her pinky and chuckles sweetly when her baby wraps her little fingers around her, keeping her close. It's enough for Adora to lean down again, like being called by the only two beings she wants to worship and devote herself to for the rest of her life.

And this time, she presses a tender kiss on the middle of her baby's forehead, right over the white birthmark in the shape of a star, where she was kissed by Love and Joy and that will bless her forever.

“Sweet, sweet Kassy. You're the love of our lives, did you know that?” Adora whispers, nuzzling their cheeks together. Sun against earth. “You're all our joy”

Catra smiles next to them, catching their shapes surrounded with light in her silver eyes. She wraps her hands softly around Adora´s waist and leans her face against her shoulder, smiling too at their baby daughter who looks back at her mother with eyes like comets. They look at each other, in different ways, in beautiful ways.

This is the third time Adora falls in love.

“I love you.” Adora vows next to Catra´s ears, holding Kassy safely tucked inside her green hemation with one arm and running the other across Catra´s waist. She still carries a little of her pregnancy weight and Adora adores her, deeply. “I love you so much.”

“I love you too,” Catra giggles, rolling her sightless eyes. She too is joyful, she too is full. “Always have”

This is Catra´s decision, all of this. The green of the world, the blue of the water, the blindness of her eyes. Carrying Kassy, that was her decision too, she prayed for it, her final petition.

She granted herself the right to choose and she made a beautiful world with it by being kind and stubborn and brave. For Adora, for Kassy, for herself.

She brought them all home.

“We are here. The three of us, we are here,” Adora marvels, her mouth splitting into a grin next to Catra´s cheek.

“I know, right?” Catra chuckles, her eyes scrunching adorably when she smiles. “ *Wow* ”

“Wow, indeed”

They will get to sail, they will get to explore. They will learn everything left to give by this world and, in time, they will teach it to their daughter too. They are free, they are out of the exile. They are together.

They kept their promises, both of them. And now this world is filled with joy, thanks to them. Princesses, and lost souls and companions. Lovers and wives and soulmates. Mothers.

Orpheus, Eurydice. Odysseus, Penelope. Eros, Psyche. Catra and Adora.

Free women.

From the edge of the ship a white dove wth blue eyes, messenger from a soul in the Elysium, watches them with loving eyes and then flies away.

When Adora looks at her family, all she sees is beauty. No marble or darkness, just sunlight and laughter.

It was worth it, the wait. Adora is worthy of this, the happiness.

Adora holds her breath and kisses Catra sweetly on the mouth, presses their foreheads together, feeling as their baby reaches for both of them, feeling as the three blind serpents nuzzle her little ears. Nothing monstrous touching her, just her mother. And she laughs, right there between both of their arms.

The air is clean, the sea calm. The rest of their lives start right here, with the Medusa holding her daughter and singing to her wife, reaching together the horizon.

“Kiki?”

"Yes?"

Love looks beautiful in Catra. It looks beautiful in Adora too.

“Thank you”

Glimmer, from Brightmoon, Queen of a gentler Etheria, walks inside the cave with precarious steps.

She found this place with much work, hours and hours of searching the little parchments left from the fallen empire, looking and searching for anything that could indicate her where the old princess had been exiled too.

To rescue her maybe, maybe only to find her bones and give her proper rest.

Bow had insisted for many nights that, maybe also, it was not necessary. That maybe she had found peace all on her own, but Glimmer was nothing if not stubborn and she had never accepted defeat. Not during the war and not now.

It was strange, also, the way Bow would sigh and let her be. The way Catra had grinned at her the last time they met, from the hand of a beautiful woman who was her wife. As if they all knew something Glimmer didn't and found peace on it.

Still, Glimmer persevered.

There was little to nothing she could follow. All the paintings of the princess had been destroyed during the empire, all the portraits destroyed, all the writings erased. The beautiful tapestries had been mended with constellations and sun shapes instead of trying to repair the torn threads and nobody else had seen her before the fall.

In fact, sometimes Glimmer thought that if the princess walked in the middle of the town, next to her people and laughing with them, sharing a meal and singing a song, nobody would recognize her as the princess with beauty and bravery that set everyone else's aflame.

But Glimmer is here now and that is all she cares about. She found the only parchment of a long dead soldier describing the way through the woods and the mountains where the hidden cave lays. Where the princess had ceased to exist and the myth of the Medusa had been born in her place.

There are many things here, many stones. Many statues, now unrecognizable and crumbled to the ground.

The floor is covered by moss and grass, reaching blindly up the stone walls, covering every single gray inch with life. There is green here, and red and blue and violet, bringing beauty in a place where it should not be able to exist.

But as many things as this story, they do exist and they are beautiful.

Glimmer crosses the cave with the ceilings of pink quartz and marvels at the sight until she reaches the very end, confused for a long second as she turns around on her ankles wrapped in coin bracelets.

There, in the corner of the stone wall, a frail ray of light. Barely hidden by crawling branches and thick leaves, surrounded by the fallen remains of once beautiful columns and leading to a second place beyond these walls.

Glimmer follows the sunlight without thinking about it twice.

When Queen Glimmer steps inside the light flooded cavern, she holds her breath.

She has heard the stories, of course she has. About the Princess cursed by the false Emperor, destined to live the rest of her life imprisoned in cold stone walls.

But there is nothing cold or ugly or frightening in here. In fact, even with Eternia alive, Glimmer thinks this the most beautiful place she has ever seen in her entire life.

There is light everywhere, washed inside through the open domes on the cavern's ceiling. The golden sunlight pours like the waters of the strong waterfall on the side, dampening the earth and making it alive.

There is moss too here and grass. Overgwon fields of golden wheat and three thick trees in the back that open their branches and their green crowns like arms towards the sky. They invite the birds and all the small animals that have found here a safe nest where to rest, where there is no fear but protection and the lingering feeling that these lands have been blessed by different kinds of goddesses.

The empty temple dug in the stone walls is beautiful and even though it's void it has not been abandoned. It was loved, once, in the canopy and the flower petals scattered over the mosaic. In the olive tree that makes a bed and the wisteria tangled with the green fruits, sauntering flowers down with the air.

There is nobody else here, not anymore, but the traces of them are everywhere, like a lit oil lamp that has lightened the entire ground, like a poppy in bloom, like the ellipses of the sun.

The Medusa was a princess, the Queen will say in the years to come to the kingdom and her children. And her children will tell it to their own grandchildren, and so and so until the end of times, breaking the myth. *She was no monster, no doomed victim. She was beauty, as women are.*

There is a loom in the temple, tall, of wood carefully carved. And in it, a magnificent tapestry. It hangs long and heavy, with the colorful threads braided into gorgeous shapes, made by hands that know this world and everything beautiful in it in deeper ways than only eyes can reach.

The Medusa was a protector. A Gorgonian, shelter of women. She was a symbol of rebirth and the reclaim of healing.

When Glimmer steps close, her sandals over green moss and her pink hair scattered with petals, she catches sight of the shapes in it. And she recognizes it, recognizes *them* , and she finally understands.

Constellations, the sky, the sea, the olive tree. And in the middle of it all, two women, blind eyes and golden serpents, loving each other more than anything.

The Heart of this new earth.

The Medusa, she was a wife. And a lover. And a mother

It is not finished because their story did not end here. Instead, the thread is on the floor, traveling around moss and pebbles and the flow of water, across the lines of trees and the crowns of mountains; below the meadows and the valleys and on the shores of white sand, tangling across the sails.

The Medusa, was a woman.

Breaking free.

The End

They say sufferings are misfortunes

But if I was ask, would I stay as I was before I was taken prisoner or go through it all again

I would say for god's sake let me be a prisoner again [...]

When our lives are knocked off curse, we imagine everything in them is lost

But it is only the start of something new and good.

As long as there is life there is happiness

There is a great deal, a great deal still to come

– War and Peace

Chapter End Notes

Adora is 20 when she gets cursed, 25 when Catra arrives, 26 when they marry, 31 when they are torn apart, 34 when they find each other again and 35 when they have Cassy and set to sail. Took 15 years but she finally got home.

It begins with Adora and begins again with her.

LAST NOTES:

— The only way to break Adora´s curse was always through Catra. At the beginning I was unsure if to follow this conclusion but the more the story progressed the more I realized it was truly the only way possible.

— The gods would´ve never been able to break the curse themselves given it was placed by a mortal man (Prime) and they were forbidden by Zeus to intervene. Even though Athena knew ichor could cure any illness in the world, she couldn´t have given it to Adora herself, instead she placed it near Prime´s reach knowing he would use it to try to harm instead to do good, as proven with the Catra event.

— It was never my intention to "cure" Catra because I´m actually against the idea that happy endings for people with disabilities are only reached by getting cured. The only reason she regained her sight was because the ichor blessed her with the capability of healing. Healing the world Prime broken and then healing what HE did to Adora. As a child of the gods and someone that loved Adora honestly, she was the only capable of giving up the blessing of the ichor to give it to Adora instead.

— Now, for Adora´s disabilities, while I just expressed my opinion on the matter, it was not just for her to live with Prime´s actions on her body, to never be allowed to be with her family or in her world. So I set her free. — She still bears remains of the curse, in the three serpents, and she still carries the work of healing from everything that happened but she can do it now with her family. While I wanted her to be free I also wanted to write about a woman that does not live contained inside her pain but that grows with her own strength and her own work into something beautiful, no matter the past pain.

— Some may not agree, but in this story the figure of Medusa was never meant to be forever a monster that turns you into stone but a woman that protects her own and that learns how to heal.

— For Kassy. The existence of their child was planned from the beginning, even in the prophecy as written above. In that time she was going to be Finn but some friends

jokingly named her Kassandra which I found beautiful given Kassandra of Troy was another woman doomed by the gods and her people. It was fair to give this one a happy life.

— Kassy comes to be as a blessing from Hera, goddess of marriage and birth. Aphrodite, Eros and Demeter have a hand on it too. She is Adora and Catra´s baby born from their soul threads. Consider it a holy birth ehehe

— Props to Mar for the amazing lesson in the Sardinian interpretation of Medusa's story. <3

Thank you everybody for sticking with me through this love story. What was supposed to be only a oneshot became a full tale and I couldn´t be more happy with how it ended. I hope to see you soon on another journey. Until then, be good.

The olive trees will grow again ♡

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!